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Preface

Linear Algebra is often the first place where a student encounters the true power of mathematical abstraction. In an introductory course, one learns to manipulate matrices, solve systems of linear equations, and perhaps calculate eigenvalues. But *Advanced* Linear Algebra is about something deeper: it is the study of structures.

The Philosophy of this Book

The central theme of these notes is the transition from concrete calculation to abstract reasoning. We begin not with numbers, but with axioms. By choosing to define mathematical objects—be they vectors, linear transformations, or inner products—entirely by how they behave rather than what they are, we unlock a universal language.

A theorem proved for an abstract vector space is a theorem proved simultaneously for geometric arrows, for polynomials, for continuous functions, and for quantum states. This “solve once, apply everywhere” philosophy is the heartbeat of modern mathematics.

How to Use These Notes

This book is designed to be a rigorous companion for a second course in linear algebra. Each chapter is structured to build a solid theoretical foundation:

- **Rigorous Definitions:** We start with precise mathematical statements to ensure no ambiguity in our logic.
- **Complete Proofs:** Every major result is accompanied by a full proof. Mathematics is not a spectator sport; I encourage you to attempt the proofs yourself before reading the solutions.
- **Illustrative Examples:** Abstract theory is balanced with concrete examples to build intuition.
- **Exercises:** Practice problems are provided at the end of sections to test your understanding.

Prerequisites

To get the most out of these notes, you should have a solid grasp of:

- **Introductory Linear Algebra:** You should be comfortable with matrix multiplication, determinants, and Gaussian elimination.

- **Calculus:** Familiarity with derivatives and integrals is assumed for some of our more advanced examples.
 - **Mathematical Maturity:** A basic understanding of logic and proof techniques (induction, contradiction, contrapositive) is essential. These are reviewed briefly in Chapter 0.
-

Welcome to the world of abstract linear algebra. I hope you find as much beauty in these structures as I do.

Chapter 0

Preliminaries

Most people meet linear algebra as a way of computing: row reduction, determinants, maybe eigenvalues. This book treats it as a subject you **prove**. Every statement comes with a reason, and those reasons are built from a small set of ideas: sets, functions, equivalence relations, fields, polynomials and matrices. This chapter collects that toolkit in one place.

You have probably seen some of this before. Some of it, such as negating a statement with several quantifiers, or checking that a rule on equivalence classes is well defined, is exactly where careful readers later stumble. So each section spends its time on the delicate points and moves quickly past the rest.

How to use this chapter. Skim the sections you know, but try the *A. Check your understanding* exercises at the end of each one. If you can do them without looking back, move on. If not, that section is worth a slower read.

What you need. Nothing from this book. School algebra is enough, plus some familiarity with numbers such as $\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{Q}$ and $\mathbb{R}$. One convention to note now: in this book the natural numbers $\mathbb{N}$ start at 0.

0.0.1 Roadmap

- **Statements, implications and quantifiers.** How mathematical statements are built, and how to negate them correctly.
- **How proofs are built.** Direct proof, contrapositive, contradiction, cases, uniqueness, counterexamples and induction, and the conventions this book's proofs follow.
- **Sets.** Subsets, operations, indexed families, and the habit of proving two sets equal by double inclusion.
- **Functions.** Injective, surjective and bijective maps; composition; left, right and two-sided inverses.
- **Relations, equivalence classes and quotients.** Sorting a set into classes, and defining functions on classes without ambiguity.
- **Complex numbers.** Arithmetic, conjugates, the modulus, polar form and roots of unity.
- **Fields.** The number systems in which linear algebra works, from $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$ to the finite fields $\mathbb{F}_p$.
- **Polynomials.** Degree, evaluation, and why a polynomial is not the same thing as a function.

- **Matrices.** Addition, the three ways to read a matrix product, transpose, trace and inverses.
- **Groups and permutations.** One structure shared by invertible matrices, the non-zero elements of a field, and rearrangements of a set.

0.0.2 Named moves

These proof techniques appear throughout the book. Each is introduced in this chapter.

- **Contrapositive.** To prove “if P then Q ”, prove “if not Q then not P ”.
- **Assume two.** To prove something is unique, suppose two objects have the property and show they are equal.
- **Double inclusion.** To prove $A = B$, prove $A \subseteq B$ and $B \subseteq A$.
- **Suppose $f(a) = f(b)$.** The standard first line when proving that a function is injective.
- **Check well-definedness.** A rule given through a representative must not depend on which representative is chosen.
- **Induction on n .** Find a smaller instance of the problem inside the larger one.

0.1 Statements, Implications and Quantifiers

Linear algebra is a subject of proofs. Every theorem in this book has the shape “if these hypotheses hold, then this conclusion holds”, and most definitions hide a “for every” or a “there exists”. Before we can prove anything, we need to read such sentences exactly: when they are true, what they claim, and what their opposite says. This section builds that reading skill. It is the grammar that the rest of the book is written in.

0.1.1 Statements and connectives

A **statement** is a sentence that is either true or false, but not both. “7 is prime” is a statement, and it is true. “ $2 + 2 = 5$ ” is a statement, and it is false. “Is 7 prime?” is not a statement, and neither is “ $x > 3$ ” on its own: its truth depends on x , which nobody has chosen yet. Sentences with a free variable are handled by quantifiers later in this section.

We build longer statements from shorter ones with a few fixed words. Everyday language uses these words loosely, so mathematics pins each one down by saying exactly when the combined statement is true.

A connective builds a new statement whose truth depends only on the truth of its parts.

Definition 0.1.1 — Negation, conjunction, disjunction

Let P and Q be statements.

- The **negation** $\neg P$ (“not P ”) is true when P is false, and false when P is true.
- The **conjunction** $P \wedge Q$ (“ P and Q ”) is true when **both** P and Q are true, and false otherwise.
- The **disjunction** $P \vee Q$ (“ P or Q ”) is true when **at least one** of P , Q is true,

and false only when both are false.

A **truth table** lists every combination of truth values of the parts, one per row, and records the value of the compound statement. With T for true and F for false:

P	Q	$\neg P$	$P \wedge Q$	$P \vee Q$
T	T	F	T	T
T	F	F	F	T
F	T	T	F	T
F	F	T	F	F

Two statement forms are **logically equivalent**, written $\equiv$, if they have the same truth value in every row of the truth table. For example, $\neg(\neg P) \equiv P$: negating twice returns the original value in both rows.

A few examples, checked against the definition:

- “7 is prime **and** 7 is even” is false, because its second part is false.
- “7 is prime **or** 7 is even” is true, because its first part is true.
- “ $2 < 3$ **or** $3 < 4$ ” is true. Both parts are true, and that is allowed.

Warning. In mathematics “or” is **inclusive**: $P \vee Q$ is true when both parts are true. The menu phrase “soup or salad”, which forbids having both, is a different connective. So “6 is even or 6 is divisible by 3” is true, even though both halves hold.

0.1.2 Implication

Almost every theorem is an implication: “if P , then Q ”. It is worth being completely precise about when such a sentence counts as true, because the answer surprises many readers in one row of the table.

Think of an implication as a **promise**. A parent says: “If you finish your homework, then you may watch a film.” When has the parent broken the promise? Only when the homework is finished and the film is still refused. If the homework is not finished, the promise says nothing about what happens, so whatever happens, the promise was not broken.

An implication is false only when the hypothesis holds and the conclusion fails.

Definition 0.1.2 — Implication, converse, contrapositive

Let P and Q be statements.

- The **implication** $P \Rightarrow Q$ (“if P then Q ”) is false when P is true and Q is false, and it is true in **every** other case. We call P the **hypothesis** and Q the **conclusion**.
- The **converse** of $P \Rightarrow Q$ is the implication $Q \Rightarrow P$.
- The **contrapositive** of $P \Rightarrow Q$ is the implication $\neg Q \Rightarrow \neg P$.

In words: the first clause says an implication can only fail in one way, by a true hypothesis leading to a false conclusion. The converse swaps the roles of hypothesis and conclusion. The

contrapositive swaps them **and** negates both.

P	Q	$P \Rightarrow Q$
T	T	T
T	F	F
F	T	T
F	F	T

The implication $P \Rightarrow Q$ is read in many ways, and all of them mean the same thing:

- “ P implies Q ”, “ Q whenever P ”, “ Q if P ”;
- “ P only if Q ”;
- “ P is **sufficient** for Q ”, “ Q is **necessary** for P ”.

The phrase “only if” trips people up. “ P only if Q ” says that P cannot happen without Q , which is exactly $P \Rightarrow Q$.

The last two rows of the table, where the hypothesis is false, are called **vacuous** cases. An implication with a false hypothesis is **vacuously true**.

Example. (A vacuously true implication)

Let n be an integer. Is the statement “if n is odd and n is even, then $n = 7$ ” true?

Solution. Yes. No integer is both odd and even, so the hypothesis “ n is odd and n is even” is false for every integer n . By [Definition 0.1.2](#), an implication with a false hypothesis is true, whatever the conclusion says. So the statement is true for every integer n , including $n = 7$ and $n = 0$. It is true, but it tells us nothing.

Why this definition. The two vacuous rows may look like a convention picked for convenience. They are forced once we want implications to work inside “for every” statements. Consider the true fact

for every integer n , if $n > 2$ then $n^2 > 4$.

For this to be true, the implication must be true for **every** integer n . Try $n = -3$: the hypothesis $-3 > 2$ is false, and the conclusion $9 > 4$ is true. Try $n = 1$: the hypothesis $1 > 2$ is false, and the conclusion $1 > 4$ is false. If either row were declared false, this perfectly good theorem would become false. So both vacuous rows must be T. In the same way, a theorem with hypotheses says nothing about objects that fail them, and that is exactly how we want to read it.

Remark. The implication $P \Rightarrow Q$ does **not** claim that P causes Q , or that the two are related at all. “If $2 + 2 = 4$, then 7 is prime” is a true implication, because both parts are true. In practice we only ever prove implications where the hypothesis is used, but the truth value does not depend on that.

The contrapositive is the most useful rewriting of an implication, because it is always interchangeable with the original.

Theorem 0.1.1 — Contrapositive equivalence

For all statements P and Q , the implication $P \Rightarrow Q$ is logically equivalent to its contrapositive $\neg Q \Rightarrow \neg P$.

Proof. Let P and Q be statements. We compute both sides in each of the four rows, using Definition 0.1.1 for the negations and Definition 0.1.2 for the implications.

P	Q	$\neg Q$	$\neg P$	$P \Rightarrow Q$	$\neg Q \Rightarrow \neg P$
T	T	F	F	T	T
T	F	T	F	F	F
F	T	F	T	T	T
F	F	T	T	T	T

In the second row, $\neg Q$ is true and $\neg P$ is false, so $\neg Q \Rightarrow \neg P$ is false. In every other row the hypothesis $\neg Q$ is false or the conclusion $\neg P$ is true, so the contrapositive is true. The last two columns agree in every row. This proves that the two statements are logically equivalent. ■

So to prove “if P then Q ” we may instead prove “if Q fails then P fails”. The next section turns this into a proof technique.

The converse is a different matter. It is a separate statement, and it can be false while the original is true.

Warning. The converse is not the contrapositive. “If $x = 2$, then $x^2 = 4$ ” is true for every real number x . Its converse “if $x^2 = 4$, then $x = 2$ ” is false: $x = -2$ satisfies the hypothesis and fails the conclusion. Proving $P \Rightarrow Q$ never proves $Q \Rightarrow P$.

Later in the book the converse question comes up constantly. In Chapter 2 we will see that if a square matrix A is invertible, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the solution $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. The converse, “if $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the solution $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, then A is invertible”, also turns out to be true for square matrices. But it is a separate theorem, it needs its own proof, and that proof takes real work.

Quick check. Consider “if an integer n is divisible by 6, then n is even”. Write its converse and its contrapositive, and decide which of the three statements are true for every integer n .

Solution. The converse is “if n is even, then n is divisible by 6”. The contrapositive is “if n is not even, then n is not divisible by 6”, that is, “if n is odd, then $6 \nmid n$ ”.

The original is true: if $n = 6k$ then $n = 2(3k)$ is even. The contrapositive is true, by Theorem 0.1.1. The converse is false: $n = 2$ is even but not divisible by 6.

When an implication and its converse are both true, we say the two statements are equivalent.

The **biconditional** $P \Leftrightarrow Q$ (“ P if and only if Q ”, often written “ P iff Q ”) is the statement $(P \Rightarrow Q) \wedge (Q \Rightarrow P)$. It is true exactly when P and Q have the same truth value:

P	Q	$P \Rightarrow Q$	$Q \Rightarrow P$	$P \Leftrightarrow Q$
T	T	T	T	T
T	F	F	T	F
F	T	T	F	F
F	F	T	T	T

The phrase splits in two: “ P if Q ” is $Q \Rightarrow P$, and “ P only if Q ” is $P \Rightarrow Q$. Other phrasings are “ P is necessary and sufficient for Q ” and “ P and Q are equivalent”. Proving an “iff” therefore always means proving two implications.

0.1.3 Quantifiers

The sentence “ $x^2 \geq 0$ ” is not yet a statement, because x is not specified. A sentence $P(x)$ that becomes a statement once a value of x is substituted is called a **predicate** (or open sentence) in the variable x . There are two standard ways to turn a predicate into a statement: claim it for every value, or claim it for at least one.

“For every” makes a claim about each element; “there exists” asks for a single witness.

Definition 0.1.3 — Quantifiers

Let $P(x)$ be a predicate whose variable x ranges over a fixed collection S .

- The **universal** statement $\forall x \in S : P(x)$ (“for every x in S , $P(x)$ ”) is true when $P(x)$ is true for **every** element x of S , and false otherwise.
- The **existential** statement $\exists x \in S : P(x)$ (“there exists x in S such that $P(x)$ ”) is true when $P(x)$ is true for **at least one** element x of S , and false otherwise.

The symbols $\forall$ and $\exists$ are the **universal** and **existential quantifiers**.

In words: a universal statement is a promise about every element, so a single element where P fails makes it false. An existential statement needs one element that works. It does not say which one, and it does not say there is only one.

The collection S is part of the statement. Changing S can change the truth value, so always ask: *ranging over what?*

Example. (Quantified statements)

Decide whether each statement is true.

- $\forall x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 \geq 0$.
- $\exists x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 = -1$.

- (c) $\exists n \in \mathbb{Z} : n^2 = 2$.
 (d) $\forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : n^2 \neq 2$.

Solution.

- (a) True. Every real number x is either ≥ 0 or < 0 , and in both cases $x^2 = x \cdot x \geq 0$.
 (b) False. By (a), $x^2 \geq 0 > -1$ for every real x , so no real x is a witness. Over the complex numbers (introduced later in this chapter), $x = i$ is a witness, so the same predicate becomes true when the range changes from $\mathbb{R}$ to $\mathbb{C}$.
 (c) False. If $|n| \leq 1$ then $n^2 \leq 1 < 2$, and if $|n| \geq 2$ then $n^2 \geq 4 > 2$. So no integer squares to 2.
 (d) True. This is the statement shown in (c), said the other way round: every integer fails to square to 2.

Parts (c) and (d) already show the pattern of the next subsection: “there is no witness” is the same as “everything fails”.

A degenerate case. What if the range contains no elements at all? Take “every integer n with $n^2 < 0$ satisfies $n = 7$ ”. There are no such integers, so there is nothing that could fail, and the statement is true. It is the quantifier version of vacuous truth: it reads $\forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : (n^2 < 0 \Rightarrow n = 7)$, and every instance has a false hypothesis. By contrast, “there exists an integer n with $n^2 < 0$ ” is false, because there is no witness. This case matters later: facts about “every element of an empty list” will be vacuously true, and that is what makes certain edge cases of definitions work.

Remark. We write $\exists! x \in S : P(x)$ for “there exists a **unique** x in S with $P(x)$ ”. It means two things: some x satisfies P , and any two elements satisfying P are equal. The next section shows how each half is proved.

0.1.4 The order of quantifiers

Most definitions in this book use several quantifiers in a row. Their order is part of the meaning.

Example. (Swapping two quantifiers)

Compare the two statements

$$(i) \quad \forall x \in \mathbb{R} \exists y \in \mathbb{R} : y > x, \quad (ii) \quad \exists y \in \mathbb{R} \forall x \in \mathbb{R} : y > x.$$

Decide which is true.

Solution. Statement (i) says: whichever real x you are given, you can find a real y larger than it. This is true. Given x , take $y = x + 1$, and then $y > x$.

Statement (ii) says: there is one real number y that is larger than every real x . This is false. Whatever y is proposed, the choice $x = y + 1$ gives $y > x$ false. So no y is a witness.

The difference is **who chooses first**. In (i), x is chosen first and y may depend on it: $y = x + 1$ changes with x . In (ii), y must be fixed before x is known, so it has to work for all x at once. Reading quantifiers as a game helps: $\forall$ is a move by an opponent, $\exists$ is your reply, and you may only use information already on the table.

Warning. Never swap a $\forall$ and an $\exists$ without a proof. The implication “ $\exists y \forall x \Rightarrow \forall x \exists y$ ” is always valid, since the single y works for each x . The reverse direction fails, as [Example \(Swapping two quantifiers\)](#) shows. Two quantifiers of the **same** kind, such as $\forall x \forall y$, may be swapped freely.

Quick check. Over the positive real numbers, statement (A) is “ $\forall \varepsilon > 0 \exists \delta > 0 : \delta < \varepsilon$ ”. Statement (B) is obtained by swapping the quantifiers: “ $\exists \delta > 0 \forall \varepsilon > 0 : \delta < \varepsilon$ ”. Are (A) and (B) both true?

Solution. No. (A) is true: given $\varepsilon > 0$, take $\delta = \varepsilon/2$, which is positive and smaller than ε . (B) is false: whatever $\delta > 0$ is proposed, the choice $\varepsilon = \delta$ makes $\delta < \varepsilon$ false. In (A) the number δ may depend on ε ; in (B) it may not.

0.1.5 Negation

Much of mathematics consists of showing that something **fails**: a function is not injective, a list is not independent, a claimed theorem is false. To do this we need the negation of the statement written in a usable form. Putting “it is not the case that” in front is correct but useless; we want the negation with the “not” pushed all the way inside, next to a simple condition we can check.

First, the connectives.

Theorem 0.1.2 — De Morgan’s laws for statements

For all statements P and Q :

- (a) $\neg(P \wedge Q) \equiv \neg P \vee \neg Q$;
- (b) $\neg(P \vee Q) \equiv \neg P \wedge \neg Q$;
- (c) $\neg(P \Rightarrow Q) \equiv P \wedge \neg Q$.

Proof. Let P and Q be statements. We compare truth tables, using [Definition 0.1.1](#) and [Definition 0.1.2](#).

P	Q	$\neg(P \wedge Q)$	$\neg P \vee \neg Q$	$\neg(P \vee Q)$	$\neg P \wedge \neg Q$	$\neg(P \Rightarrow Q)$	$P \wedge \neg Q$
T	T	F	F	F	F	F	F
T	F	T	T	F	F	T	T
F	T	T	T	F	F	F	F
F	F	T	T	T	T	F	F

For (a), $P \wedge Q$ is true only in the first row, so its negation is false only there. The statement $\neg P \vee \neg Q$ is false only when $\neg P$ and $\neg Q$ are both false, which is again only the first row. For (b), $\neg(P \vee Q)$ is true only in the last row, where both parts are false, and so is $\neg P \wedge \neg Q$. For (c), $P \Rightarrow Q$ is false only in the second row, so $\neg(P \Rightarrow Q)$ is true only there, and $P \wedge \neg Q$ is also true only there. In each case the two columns agree in all four rows, as claimed. ■

Law (c) deserves a sentence. The negation of an implication is **not** another implication. To refute “if P then Q ”, you must exhibit a situation where P holds **and** Q fails.

Now the quantifiers. A universal statement fails exactly when some element fails it, and an existential statement fails exactly when every element fails it. We record this as the rule we will use every time.

To negate, flip each quantifier and negate what is inside.

Definition 0.1.4 — Negation of quantifiers

Let $P(x)$ be a predicate with x ranging over S . Then

$$\neg(\forall x \in S : P(x)) \equiv \exists x \in S : \neg P(x), \quad \neg(\exists x \in S : P(x)) \equiv \forall x \in S : \neg P(x).$$

For a statement with several quantifiers, apply these rules from the outside in: each $\forall$ becomes $\exists$, each $\exists$ becomes $\forall$, the ranges stay the same, and the innermost condition is negated using [Theorem 0.1.2](#).

In words: “not every x works” means “some x fails”, and “no x works” means “every x fails”. Both rules are just [Definition 0.1.3](#) read carefully. The universal statement is false precisely when it is not the case that every element satisfies P , which is precisely when at least one element satisfies $\neg P$. The **ranges do not change**: the negation of “every real number squared is non-negative” talks about real numbers, not about some other collection.

Example. (Negating simple quantified statements)

Negate each statement, and say which of the statement and its negation is true.

- (a) $\forall x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 \geq 0$.
- (b) $\exists n \in \mathbb{Z} : n$ is even and $n > 10$.
- (c) $\forall x \in \mathbb{R} \exists y \in \mathbb{R} : y > x$.

Solution.

- (a) The negation is $\exists x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 < 0$. The original is true, by [Example \(Quantified statements\)](#), so the negation is false.
- (b) By [Definition 0.1.4](#) and law (a) of [Theorem 0.1.2](#), the negation is $\forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : n$ is odd or $n \leq 10$. The original is true, with witness $n = 12$, so the negation

is false: $n = 12$ is neither odd nor ≤ 10 .

- (c) Flip both quantifiers and negate the inside: $\exists x \in \mathbb{R} \forall y \in \mathbb{R} : y \leq x$. This says that some real number is at least as large as every real number. The original is true by [Example \(Swapping two quantifiers\)](#), so the negation is false.

The next two examples negate definitions that will appear over and over. We use the word **function** informally here, as a rule f that assigns to each a in a collection A one value $f(a)$ in a collection B ; functions are treated properly later in this chapter.

Example. (What “not injective” means)

A function f from A to B is called **injective** if

$$\forall a_1 \in A \forall a_2 \in A : (f(a_1) = f(a_2) \Rightarrow a_1 = a_2).$$

Write down, with no “not” in front, what it means for f to be **not** injective. Then show that $f(x) = x^2$, from $\mathbb{R}$ to $\mathbb{R}$, is not injective.

Solution. By [Definition 0.1.4](#), both $\forall$ become $\exists$, and the inside implication is negated. By law (c) of [Theorem 0.1.2](#), $\neg(f(a_1) = f(a_2) \Rightarrow a_1 = a_2) \equiv f(a_1) = f(a_2) \wedge a_1 \neq a_2$. So f is not injective if and only if

$$\exists a_1 \in A \exists a_2 \in A : f(a_1) = f(a_2) \text{ and } a_1 \neq a_2.$$

In words, two **different** inputs have the same output. For $f(x) = x^2$, take $a_1 = 1$ and $a_2 = -1$. Then $f(1) = 1 = f(-1)$ and $1 \neq -1$, so f is not injective.

Example. (What “not surjective” means)

A function f from A to B is called **surjective** if

$$\forall b \in B \exists a \in A : f(a) = b.$$

Negate this, and show that $f(x) = x^2$, from $\mathbb{R}$ to $\mathbb{R}$, is not surjective.

Solution. Flipping the two quantifiers and negating the equation gives: f is not surjective if and only if

$$\exists b \in B \forall a \in A : f(a) \neq b.$$

In words, **one** value in B is never reached. For $f(x) = x^2$, take $b = -1$. For every real a we have $f(a) = a^2 \geq 0 > -1$ by [Example \(Quantified statements\)](#), so $f(a) \neq -1$. Hence f is not surjective.

The most important negation in the early chapters is that of a statement ending in “all zero”. We meet it here without any vector spaces, using pairs of real numbers added and scaled entry

by entry.

Example. (Negating “only the zero combination”)

Consider the pairs $(1, 2)$, $(2, 4)$, $(0, 1)$, and the statement

$$\forall a, b, c \in \mathbb{R} : \left(a(1, 2) + b(2, 4) + c(0, 1) = (0, 0) \Rightarrow a = 0 \wedge b = 0 \wedge c = 0 \right).$$

Negate it, and decide which of the statement and its negation is true.

Solution. Flip the quantifier, and use law (c) of [Theorem 0.1.2](#) for the implication and law (a) for the conjunction. The negation is

$$\exists a, b, c \in \mathbb{R} : a(1, 2) + b(2, 4) + c(0, 1) = (0, 0) \text{ and } (a \neq 0 \vee b \neq 0 \vee c \neq 0).$$

The last condition says that a, b, c are **not all zero**: at least one of them is non-zero.

The negation is true. Take $a = 2$, $b = -1$, $c = 0$. Then

$$2(1, 2) - (2, 4) + 0(0, 1) = (2 - 2 + 0, 4 - 4 + 0) = (0, 0),$$

and $a = 2 \neq 0$. So the original statement is false.

In Chapter 1 the original statement is what “the list is linearly independent” means, and its negation is “linearly dependent”. The small words in the negation carry the weight.

Warning. **“Not all zero” is not “all non-zero”.** The negation of “ $a = b = c = 0$ ” is “at least one of a, b, c is non-zero”. In [Example \(Negating “only the zero combination”\)](#) the witness is $(2, -1, 0)$, which has a zero entry. In fact **no** witness has all three entries non-zero: comparing entries, $a + 2b = 0$ and $2a + 4b + c = 0$, so $c = -2(a + 2b) = 0$. Negating with “all non-zero” would wrongly conclude that the original statement is true.

Quick check. Negate “every student passed some exam”, with no “not” in front of the whole sentence.

Solution. Write it as “ $\forall$ students $s \exists$ exam $e : s$ passed e ”. Flipping both quantifiers and negating the inside gives “ $\exists$ student $s \forall$ exams $e : s$ did not pass e ”. In words: **some student passed no exam**. The tempting answer “no student passed any exam” is the negation of “some student passed some exam”, a different statement.

Remark. Each form of statement suggests how to prove or refute it. To prove $\forall x \in S : P(x)$, take an arbitrary $x \in S$ and show $P(x)$. To prove $\exists x \in S : P(x)$, produce a witness. To refute a $\forall$, produce one counterexample. To refute an $\exists$, show every candidate fails. The next section develops these moves into proof techniques.

0.1.6 Exercises

0.1.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Decide whether each statement is true: (i) “ $3 < 2$ or 3 is odd”; (ii) “if $3 < 2$, then $3 = 5$ ”; (iii) “if 3 is odd, then $3 < 2$ ”.
- (b) Write the converse and the contrapositive of “if an integer n is divisible by 4, then n is even”. Which of the three statements are true for every integer n ?
- (c) Negate $\forall x \in \mathbb{R} \exists n \in \mathbb{Z} : n > x$, with no $\neg$ in front. Which of the statement and its negation is true?
- (d) True or false: $\neg(P \wedge Q) \equiv \neg P \wedge \neg Q$ for all statements P, Q . Give a reason.

Solution.

- (a) (i) True: the second part is true, and a disjunction needs only one true part. (ii) True: the hypothesis $3 < 2$ is false, so the implication is vacuously true. (iii) False: the hypothesis is true and the conclusion is false, which is the one case where an implication fails.
- (b) The converse is “if n is even, then n is divisible by 4”. The contrapositive is “if n is odd, then n is not divisible by 4”. The original is true: $n = 4k$ gives $n = 2(2k)$. The contrapositive is true by [Theorem 0.1.1](#). The converse is false: $n = 2$ is even and not divisible by 4.
- (c) By [Definition 0.1.4](#), the negation is $\exists x \in \mathbb{R} \forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : n \leq x$. The original is true: given x , some integer exceeds x (for instance the integer part of $|x|$ plus 1). So the negation is false.
- (d) False. Take P true and Q false. Then $P \wedge Q$ is false, so $\neg(P \wedge Q)$ is true, while $\neg P \wedge \neg Q$ is false because $\neg P$ is false. The correct law is $\neg(P \wedge Q) \equiv \neg P \vee \neg Q$, by [Theorem 0.1.2](#).

0.1.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Negating definitions.

Write the negation of each definition as a quantified statement with no $\neg$ in front, and then say it in words.

- (a) A function f from $\mathbb{R}$ to $\mathbb{R}$ is **bounded** if $\exists M \in \mathbb{R} \forall x \in \mathbb{R} : |f(x)| \leq M$.
- (b) A function f from A to B is injective if $\forall a_1, a_2 \in A : (a_1 \neq a_2 \Rightarrow f(a_1) \neq f(a_2))$. Compare your answer with [Example \(What “not injective” means\)](#).
- (c) “Every pair of reals is a combination of $(1, 0)$ and $(1, 1)$ ”: $\forall p, q \in \mathbb{R} \exists a, b \in \mathbb{R} : (p, q) = a(1, 0) + b(1, 1)$, where pairs are added and scaled entry by entry.

Solution.

- (a) By [Definition 0.1.4](#), f is not bounded if and only if $\forall M \in \mathbb{R} \exists x \in \mathbb{R} : |f(x)| > M$. In words: whatever bound M is proposed, some value of f exceeds it in absolute value.

- (b) Flip both quantifiers and negate the implication using law (c) of [Theorem 0.1.2](#): $\exists a_1, a_2 \in A : a_1 \neq a_2 \wedge f(a_1) = f(a_2)$. In words: two different inputs share an output. This is the same condition as in [Example \(What “not injective” means\)](#). That is expected: the given implication is the contrapositive of $f(a_1) = f(a_2) \Rightarrow a_1 = a_2$, so by [Theorem 0.1.1](#) the two definitions agree, and so do their negations.
- (c) Flip all the quantifiers and negate the equation: $\exists p, q \in \mathbb{R} \forall a, b \in \mathbb{R} : (p, q) \neq a(1, 0) + b(1, 1)$. In words: some pair is not a combination of $(1, 0)$ and $(1, 1)$, whatever coefficients are used. (The original is in fact true, since $(p - q)(1, 0) + q(1, 1) = (p, q)$, so this negation is false.)

Exercise B2: Integers versus reals.

For each statement, decide whether it is true when x and y range over $\mathbb{Z}$, and whether it is true when they range over $\mathbb{R}$. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\forall x \exists y : x < y < x + 1$.
 (b) $\forall x (x \neq 0 \Rightarrow \exists y : xy = 1)$.
 (c) $\exists x \forall y : xy = y$.
 (d) $\forall x \exists y : y^2 = x$.

Solution.

- (a) Over $\mathbb{Z}$: false. Take $x = 0$. No integer y satisfies $0 < y < 1$. Over $\mathbb{R}$: true. Given x , take $y = x + \frac{1}{2}$; then $x < y < x + 1$.
- (b) Over $\mathbb{Z}$: false. Take $x = 2$, which is non-zero. If $2y = 1$ for an integer y , then 1 would be even, which is false. Over $\mathbb{R}$: true. Given $x \neq 0$, take $y = 1/x$, which exists because $x \neq 0$, and then $xy = 1$.
- (c) True over both. Take $x = 1$, which lies in $\mathbb{Z}$ and in $\mathbb{R}$. Then $xy = y$ for every y . Here one x works for all y , so the order $\exists x \forall y$ causes no difficulty.
- (d) False over both. Take $x = -1$. For every y , integer or real, $y^2 \geq 0 > -1$ by [Example \(Quantified statements\)](#), so $y^2 \neq -1$.

0.1.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Exporting a hypothesis.

Prove that $P \Rightarrow (Q \Rightarrow R)$ is logically equivalent to $(P \wedge Q) \Rightarrow R$ for all statements P, Q, R . Explain in one sentence why this lets a theorem with two hypotheses be stated either way.

Solution. Let P, Q, R be statements. By [Definition 0.1.2](#), an implication is false exactly when its hypothesis is true and its conclusion is false.

The statement $(P \wedge Q) \Rightarrow R$ is false exactly when $P \wedge Q$ is true and R is false, that is, when P is true, Q is true and R is false.

The statement $P \Rightarrow (Q \Rightarrow R)$ is false exactly when P is true and $Q \Rightarrow R$ is false. By the same definition, $Q \Rightarrow R$ is false exactly when Q is true and R is false. So $P \Rightarrow (Q \Rightarrow R)$ is false exactly when P is true, Q is true and R is false.

Both statements are false in exactly the same row of the eight-row truth table, and true in the other seven. Hence they are logically equivalent.

Consequently “if P , then (if Q , then R)” and “if P and Q , then R ” say the same thing, so a theorem may list its hypotheses one after another or all together.

Exercise C2: When can a converse fail too?.

- (a) Determine whether there exist statements P and Q such that both $P \Rightarrow Q$ and its converse $Q \Rightarrow P$ are false. Justify your answer.
- (b) Give predicates $P(n)$ and $Q(n)$ about integers such that both $\forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : (P(n) \Rightarrow Q(n))$ and $\forall n \in \mathbb{Z} : (Q(n) \Rightarrow P(n))$ are false.
- (c) Explain why (a) and (b) do not contradict each other.

Solution.

- (a) No such statements exist. Suppose $P \Rightarrow Q$ is false. By [Definition 0.1.2](#), P is true and Q is false. Then $Q \Rightarrow P$ has a false hypothesis, so it is true. Hence an implication and its converse can never both be false.
- (b) Let $P(n)$ be “ n is even” and $Q(n)$ be “ n is divisible by 3”. The first universal statement is false: $n = 2$ is even and not divisible by 3. The second is false: $n = 3$ is divisible by 3 and not even.
- (c) In (a), P and Q are single statements, each with one fixed truth value. In (b), each universal statement is refuted by its own counterexample, and the two counterexamples are **different** integers. At $n = 2$ the converse $Q(2) \Rightarrow P(2)$ is vacuously true, and at $n = 3$ the original $P(3) \Rightarrow Q(3)$ is vacuously true, in line with (a). A “for every” statement can fail at one place while its converse fails somewhere else.

0.2 How Proofs Are Built

The previous section taught us to read statements: what an implication claims, what the quantifiers demand, and how to negate. Now we write proofs of them. A proof is a chain of statements, each one justified by a definition, a hypothesis or an earlier result, that ends in the statement we want. This section collects the handful of shapes that almost every proof in this book takes, shows each on a small fact about integers, and ends with the conventions that the book’s proofs follow.

Throughout, a theorem will usually come with two blocks. The **Idea** says how the argument was found, often by working backwards from the goal. The **Proof** then presents the argument forwards, one justified step at a time. Read the Idea first, then check the Proof line by line.

0.2.1 Direct proof

Most statements have the form “for every x , if $P(x)$ then $Q(x)$ ”. The direct way to prove this follows the shape of the statement:

1. **Let** x be arbitrary. By [Definition 0.1.3](#), a universal statement is a claim about each element, so we must not pick a convenient one.
2. **Suppose** $P(x)$. By [Definition 0.1.2](#), the implication can only fail when $P(x)$ is true, so that is the only case we need to handle.
3. **Unwind** $P(x)$ and $Q(x)$ into their definitions. Then push forward from what we have towards what we want, often working backwards from the goal on scrap paper first.

Before we can prove anything about integers, we need definitions to unwind.

Definition 0.2.1 — Even and odd

An integer n is **even** if there **exists** an integer k with $n = 2k$. An integer n is **odd** if there **exists** an integer k with $n = 2k + 1$.

So $0 = 2 \cdot 0$ is even, $-6 = 2 \cdot (-3)$ is even, and $7 = 2 \cdot 3 + 1$ is odd. Each definition is an existential statement: to show a number is even, we must produce the integer k . We use the school fact that **every integer is even or odd, and not both**; an exercise at the end of this section proves a more general fact about remainders.

Proposition 0.2.1 — Sum of even integers

For all integers m and n , if m and n are even, then $m + n$ is even.

Idea. Givens: $m = 2a$ and $n = 2b$ for some integers a, b . Goal: $m + n = 2k$ for some integer k . So we must *find* k . Adding the givens gives $m + n = 2a + 2b = 2(a + b)$, and $k = a + b$ is the witness.

Proof. Let m and n be even integers. By [Definition 0.2.1](#), there exist integers a and b with $m = 2a$ and $n = 2b$. Then

$$m + n = 2a + 2b = 2(a + b).$$

Since $a + b$ is an integer, [Definition 0.2.1](#) shows that $m + n$ is even. This proves the claim. ■

The pattern is worth naming. The hypothesis “ m is even” is an **existence** statement, so using it hands us an integer a to work with. The goal “ $m + n$ is even” is also an existence statement, so proving it means **producing** an integer, here $a + b$. The two letters a and b must be different: m and n are arbitrary, so their halves have nothing to do with each other.

Warning. A **proof of a “for every” statement cannot start with a specific example**. Writing “ $4 + 6 = 10$, which is even” checks one case and proves nothing about all even integers. Equally, writing $m = 2k$ and $n = 2k$ with the **same** k silently assumes $m = n$, so it only proves that $2m$ is even.

0.2.2 Proof by contrapositive

Sometimes the direct route stalls. Consider the statement “if n^2 is even, then n is even”. Going directly, we would suppose $n^2 = 2k$ and try to say something about n . But $n = \pm\sqrt{2k}$ is not visibly of the form $2 \cdot (\text{integer})$, and we are stuck.

By [Theorem 0.1.1](#), “if P then Q ” is equivalent to “if not Q then not P ”. Here the contrapositive is “if n is not even, then n^2 is not even”, that is, “if n is odd, then n^2 is odd”. Now the hypothesis hands us a formula for n , and squaring a formula is easy.

Proposition 0.2.2 — Even squares

For every integer n , if n^2 is even, then n is even.

Idea. The hypothesis n^2 even says little about n , but “ n odd” gives $n = 2k + 1$ explicitly. So prove the contrapositive: from $n = 2k + 1$, expand n^2 and look for the form $2(\dots) + 1$.

Proof. Let n be an integer. By [Theorem 0.1.1](#), it suffices to prove that if n is not even, then n^2 is not even. Suppose n is not even. Since every integer is even or odd, n is odd, so by [Definition 0.2.1](#) there is an integer k with $n = 2k + 1$. Then

$$n^2 = 4k^2 + 4k + 1 = 2(2k^2 + 2k) + 1.$$

Since $2k^2 + 2k$ is an integer, n^2 is odd by [Definition 0.2.1](#). Since no integer is both even and odd, n^2 is not even. This proves the contrapositive, and hence the statement. ■

A contrapositive proof is a direct proof of a different, equivalent implication. Use it when the negated conclusion gives more to work with than the hypothesis does.

0.2.3 Proof by contradiction

To prove a statement S by **contradiction**, suppose that S is false and deduce something impossible: a statement together with its negation. Why does this work? We have shown that the implication $\neg S \Rightarrow (R \wedge \neg R)$ is true, for some statement R . Its conclusion $R \wedge \neg R$ is false in every row, so by [Definition 0.1.2](#) the implication can only be true if its hypothesis $\neg S$ is false. Hence S is true.

Contradiction is the natural tool for statements that say something **cannot** happen, or that there is **no** object of some kind. Such statements give nothing to start from directly, while their negation hands us an object to study.

Statements about fractions and primes need the language of divisibility.

Definition 0.2.2 — Divisibility and primes

Let a and b be integers. We say a **divides** b , written $a \mid b$, if there **exists** an integer k with $b = ak$. An integer p is **prime** if $p \geq 2$ and the only **positive** divisors of p are 1

and p .

For example, $3 \mid 12$ since $12 = 3 \cdot 4$, and $3 \nmid 7$. The first primes are 2, 3, 5, 7, 11. The integer 1 is **not** prime, because the definition requires $p \geq 2$; this convention is what makes factorizations into primes unique. In this language, n is even exactly when $2 \mid n$.

A real number is **rational** if it equals a/b for some integers a and b with $b \neq 0$, and **irrational** otherwise. We use the school fact that every rational number can be written **in lowest terms**: as a/b with $b \geq 1$, where no integer $d \geq 2$ divides both a and b . (We justify this fact at the end of this section.)

Theorem 0.2.3 — Irrationality of $\sqrt{2}$

There is no rational number whose square is 2. That is, $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational.

Idea. “There is no rational x with $x^2 = 2$ ” gives nothing to hold, so suppose there is one, and write it in lowest terms a/b . Clearing denominators gives $a^2 = 2b^2$, an integer equation. Then Proposition 0.2.2 applies twice: first a is even, then (after substituting $a = 2c$) b is even. That contradicts lowest terms.

Proof. Suppose, for a contradiction, that some rational number x satisfies $x^2 = 2$. Write $x = a/b$ in lowest terms, so $b \geq 1$ and no integer $d \geq 2$ divides both a and b . Then $a^2/b^2 = 2$, and multiplying by b^2 , which is non-zero, gives

$$a^2 = 2b^2.$$

Therefore a^2 is even by Definition 0.2.1, and hence a is even by Proposition 0.2.2. Write $a = 2c$ with c an integer. Substituting gives $4c^2 = 2b^2$, so $b^2 = 2c^2$ is even. By Proposition 0.2.2 again, b is even. Thus 2 divides both a and b , which contradicts the choice of a/b in lowest terms. Hence no rational number has square 2. ■

The contradiction came from the lowest-terms condition, which is the hypothesis we chose to impose. That is typical: in a contradiction proof, look for the assumption you have not yet used, because the contradiction usually comes from there.

Remark. If a contradiction proof of “ $P \Rightarrow Q$ ” assumes P and $\neg Q$ and then only ever derives $\neg P$, it is really a contrapositive proof in disguise. Write it as a contrapositive; it is shorter and clearer.

A second classic contradiction proof, that there are infinitely many primes, needs one more tool and appears at the end of this section.

0.2.4 Proof by cases

When a hypothesis splits naturally into possibilities, handle each one separately. If $P_1 \vee P_2$ is true, and both $P_1 \Rightarrow Q$ and $P_2 \Rightarrow Q$ are true, then Q is true: whichever of P_1, P_2 holds, its implication delivers Q . The cases must **cover every possibility**. They are allowed to overlap.

Proposition 0.2.4 — $n^2 + n$ is even

For every integer n , the integer $n^2 + n$ is even.

Idea. Nothing about n is given, but every integer is even or odd, and each case gives a formula for n . Factoring first, $n^2 + n = n(n+1)$, makes each case a one-line computation.

Proof. Let n be an integer. Then $n^2 + n = n(n+1)$. Since every integer is even or odd, there are two cases.

Case 1: n is even. By [Definition 0.2.1](#), $n = 2k$ for some integer k . Then $n(n+1) = 2(k(n+1))$, and $k(n+1)$ is an integer.

Case 2: n is odd. By [Definition 0.2.1](#), $n = 2k+1$ for some integer k . Then $n+1 = 2(k+1)$, so $n(n+1) = 2(n(k+1))$, and $n(k+1)$ is an integer.

In both cases $n^2 + n$ is even by [Definition 0.2.1](#). This shows the claim for every integer n . ■

0.2.5 Proving “if and only if”

By the definition of the biconditional in the previous section, $P \Leftrightarrow Q$ means $(P \Rightarrow Q) \wedge (Q \Rightarrow P)$. So a proof of an “iff” has **two directions**, labeled $(\Rightarrow)$ and $(\Leftarrow)$, and each is proved by any method we like. Often one direction is already known.

Proposition 0.2.5 — Parity of a square

For every integer n , n is even if and only if n^2 is even.

Proof. Let n be an integer.

$(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose n is even, so $n = 2k$ for some integer k by [Definition 0.2.1](#). Then $n^2 = 4k^2 = 2(2k^2)$, and $2k^2$ is an integer, so n^2 is even.

$(\Leftarrow)$ This is [Proposition 0.2.2](#).

Both directions hold, so n is even if and only if n^2 is even. ■

Warning. Reversing the steps is not automatic. A common slip is to “prove the converse” by rewriting the same argument backwards without checking that every step reverses. For instance, from $x = 2$ we get $x^2 = 4$; but from $x^2 = 4$ we only get $x = 2$ **or** $x = -2$. Each direction needs its own justification.

0.2.6 Existence and uniqueness

To prove “there exists x with $P(x)$ ”, the most direct method is to **produce a witness** and check it. For example, “there exists an integer n with $n^2 = n + 2$ ” is proved by $n = 2$: indeed $2^2 = 4 = 2 + 2$.

To prove “there is **at most one** x with $P(x)$ ”, the standard move is: *suppose x and x' both satisfy P , and show $x = x'$* . Notice that we do not assume $x \neq x'$; we simply take two objects with the property and prove they are the same. “There exists a **unique** x ” means both existence and at most one, so it takes both arguments.

Here is an example that we will meet again when we study fields and groups. A **binary operation** $*$ on a collection S is a rule that assigns to each ordered pair a, b of elements of S an element $a * b$ of S . Addition and multiplication of integers are binary operations on $\mathbb{Z}$. An **identity element** for $*$ is an element e of S such that $e * a = a$ and $a * e = a$ for **every** a in S .

Proposition 0.2.6 — Uniqueness of the identity

Let $*$ be a binary operation on S . Then $*$ has at most one identity element.

Idea. Suppose e and e' are both identities. The only thing we know about them is how they behave in a product, so look at the one product that involves both, $e * e'$, and evaluate it in two ways.

Proof. Suppose e and e' are both identity elements for $*$. Since e' is an identity, $e * e' = e$, taking $a = e$ in its defining property. Since e is an identity, $e * e' = e'$, taking $a = e'$ in its defining property. Therefore $e = e * e' = e'$. This shows that any two identity elements are equal. ■

So 0 is **the** identity for addition on $\mathbb{Z}$, and 1 is **the** identity for multiplication. The result says nothing about existence. Subtraction on $\mathbb{Z}$ has no identity at all: $a - e = a$ for every a forces $e = 0$, but then $e - a = -a$, which is not a when $a = 1$. Uniqueness proofs of exactly this shape will recur for zero vectors, negatives, inverse matrices and inverse functions.

0.2.7 Counterexamples

By [Definition 0.1.4](#), the negation of “ $\forall x : P(x)$ ” is “ $\exists x : \neg P(x)$ ”. So to **refute** a universal statement, one witness suffices: a single x where $P(x)$ fails. Such an x is a **counterexample**. Conversely, no number of examples can prove a universal statement over an infinite range.

Example. (Refuting “every prime is odd”)

Decide whether every prime number is odd. Justify your answer.

Solution. False. The statement is $\forall p \text{ prime} : p \text{ is odd}$, so by [Definition 0.1.4](#) one prime that is not odd refutes it. Take $p = 2$. It is prime, since $2 \geq 2$ and a positive divisor of 2 is at most 2, so it is 1 or 2. It is even, since $2 = 2 \cdot 1$, and hence not odd. So 2 is a

counterexample.

Warning. Many examples prove nothing. The number $n^2 + n + 41$ is prime for every integer n from 0 to 39. Yet the statement “ $n^2 + n + 41$ is prime for every $n \geq 0$ ” is false: at $n = 40$ we get $40^2 + 40 + 41 = 1681 = 41^2$, which is not prime.

0.2.8 Mathematical induction

Some statements are really infinitely many statements, one for each natural number: “for every $n \geq 1$, $1 + 2 + \cdots + n = n(n+1)/2$ ”. Checking cases one at a time never finishes. Induction replaces the infinite list of checks by two finite tasks, like knocking over a row of dominoes: push the first one, and make sure each domino knocks over the next.

We take this as a basic property of the integers, not something to prove.

Theorem 0.2.7 — Principle of Mathematical Induction

Let n_0 be an integer, and for each integer $n \geq n_0$ let $P(n)$ be a statement. Suppose

- (i) (**base case**) $P(n_0)$ is true, and
- (ii) (**inductive step**) for **every** integer $n \geq n_0$, if $P(n)$ is true then $P(n+1)$ is true.

Then $P(n)$ is true for every integer $n \geq n_0$.

In the inductive step, the assumption “ $P(n)$ is true” is called the **induction hypothesis**. It is not circular: we do not assume the whole conclusion, only that the statement holds at one arbitrary n , and we prove that it then holds at $n+1$.

Proposition 0.2.8 — Sum of the first n integers

For every integer $n \geq 1$,

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}.$$

Idea. Passing from n to $n+1$ adds exactly one term, $n+1$, to the left side. So the step reduces to the algebra identity $\frac{n(n+1)}{2} + (n+1) = \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2}$, which holds after taking out the factor $n+1$.

Proof. We prove this by induction on n , using Theorem 0.2.7 with $n_0 = 1$. Let $P(n)$ be the statement $1 + 2 + \cdots + n = n(n+1)/2$.

Base case. For $n = 1$ the left side is 1 and the right side is $1 \cdot 2/2 = 1$. So $P(1)$ is true.

Inductive step. Let $n \geq 1$ and suppose $P(n)$ is true. Then

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + n + (n+1) = \frac{n(n+1)}{2} + (n+1) = (n+1)\left(\frac{n}{2} + 1\right) = \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2},$$

where the first equality uses the induction hypothesis $P(n)$. This is $P(n+1)$.

By [Theorem 0.2.7](#), $P(n)$ is true for every integer $n \geq 1$, as claimed. ■

The base case does not have to be 1, and the step does not have to be an equation. In this book the **natural numbers** are $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$: they **include** 0. (Some books start at 1; the next section fixes our convention formally.)

Proposition 0.2.9 — $2^n > n$

For every natural number n , we have $2^n > n$.

Proof. We prove this by induction on n , with $n_0 = 0$. For $n = 0$, $2^0 = 1 > 0$. Now let $n \geq 0$ and suppose $2^n > n$. Then

$$2^{n+1} = 2^n + 2^n > n + 2^n \geq n + 1,$$

where the strict inequality uses the induction hypothesis and the last step uses $2^n \geq 1$. Hence $2^{n+1} > n + 1$. By [Theorem 0.2.7](#), $2^n > n$ for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$. ■

The inductive step must work for **every** $n \geq n_0$, including the smallest ones. The following fake proof fails exactly there.

Warning. The “**all horses are the same color**” fallacy. *Claim:* in every group of $n \geq 1$ horses, all horses have the same color. *“Proof”:* for $n = 1$ there is nothing to show. Suppose the claim holds for groups of n horses, and take a group of $n + 1$ horses $h_1, \dots, h_{n+1}$. The group $h_1, \dots, h_n$ is single-colored by the induction hypothesis, and so is $h_2, \dots, h_{n+1}$. The two groups share a horse, so all $n + 1$ horses have its color. The claim is plainly false, so this “proof” has a gap. Before opening the check below, try to find the exact value of n where the step breaks.

Quick check. Where does the inductive step in the horse argument fail?

Solution. It fails when passing from $n = 1$ to $n + 1 = 2$. The two groups are then $\{h_1\}$ and $\{h_2\}$, which share **no** horse, so nothing links the color of h_1 to that of h_2 . The sentence “the two groups share a horse” is true only when $n \geq 2$. Since the step $P(1) \Rightarrow P(2)$ is not proved, the chain of dominoes breaks at the very first push, and the base case alone gives nothing.

0.2.9 Strong induction and well-ordering

In some arguments, knowing $P(n)$ alone is not enough to reach $P(n + 1)$: we need the statement at some **earlier** value, and we do not know in advance which one. Strong induction allows the hypothesis at all earlier values at once.

Theorem 0.2.10 — Strong induction

Let n_0 be an integer, and for each integer $n \geq n_0$ let $P(n)$ be a statement. Suppose that for **every** integer $n \geq n_0$,

if $P(k)$ is true for all integers k with $n_0 \leq k < n$, then $P(n)$ is true.

Then $P(n)$ is true for every integer $n \geq n_0$.

Idea. Ordinary induction applies to the stronger statement $Q(n)$: “ $P(k)$ holds for all k from n_0 to n ”. The hypothesis is exactly what pushes $Q(n)$ to $Q(n+1)$. At $n = n_0$ the condition “for all k with $n_0 \leq k < n_0$ ” is vacuous, so the hypothesis already contains the base case.

Proof. For each integer $n \geq n_0$, let $Q(n)$ be the statement “ $P(k)$ is true for all integers k with $n_0 \leq k \leq n$ ”. We prove $Q(n)$ for all $n \geq n_0$ by [Theorem 0.2.7](#).

Base case. There is no integer k with $n_0 \leq k < n_0$, so the condition “ $P(k)$ is true for all such k ” is vacuously true. By the hypothesis with $n = n_0$, $P(n_0)$ is true. Hence $Q(n_0)$ is true.

Inductive step. Let $n \geq n_0$ and suppose $Q(n)$ is true, so $P(k)$ holds for all k with $n_0 \leq k < n+1$. By the hypothesis applied to $n+1$, $P(n+1)$ is true. Together with $Q(n)$, this gives $Q(n+1)$.

By [Theorem 0.2.7](#), $Q(n)$ holds for all $n \geq n_0$. In particular $P(n)$ holds for all $n \geq n_0$, since $Q(n)$ includes $k = n$. This proves the theorem. ■

The same property of the natural numbers can be phrased without any statements $P(n)$ at all: there is no endless strictly decreasing sequence of natural numbers, so every search for a smallest example ends.

Theorem 0.2.11 — Well-Ordering Principle

Every non-empty collection of natural numbers has a least element: an element m of the collection with $m \leq s$ for every s in the collection.

We take this as a basic property too. It is equivalent to the Principle of Mathematical Induction, in the sense that each can be proved from the other, but we will not need that. Well-ordering is the natural language for “take a smallest counterexample” arguments, which are contradiction proofs in disguise.

Here is a result that needs strong induction, because the smaller number we reach is not $n-1$.

Proposition 0.2.12 — Existence of a prime factor

Every integer $n \geq 2$ has a prime divisor.

Idea. If n is prime, n itself works. If not, $n = ab$ with $1 < a < n$, and a prime dividing a also divides n . The factor a can be any size below n , so we need the statement for all smaller values, which is strong induction.

Proof. We use [Theorem 0.2.10](#) with $n_0 = 2$. Let $n \geq 2$, and suppose every integer k with $2 \leq k < n$ has a prime divisor.

Case 1: n is prime. Then $n \mid n$, so n is a prime divisor of n .

Case 2: n is not prime. Since $n \geq 2$, [Definition 0.2.2](#) gives a positive divisor a of n with $a \neq 1$ and $a \neq n$. Write $n = ab$ with b an integer. Since a and n are positive, $b \geq 1$, and $b \neq 1$ because $a \neq n$; so $b \geq 2$ and $a = n/b < n$. Thus $2 \leq a < n$, and by the hypothesis a has a prime divisor p , say $a = pc$. Then $n = p(cb)$, so $p \mid n$.

In both cases n has a prime divisor. By [Theorem 0.2.10](#), this holds for every $n \geq 2$. ■

Now the promised contradiction proof.

Theorem 0.2.13 — Infinitely many primes

There are infinitely many prime numbers.

Idea. Suppose the primes form a finite list. Build a number that no prime on the list can divide: multiply them all and add 1. Dividing by any p_i leaves remainder 1. But [Proposition 0.2.12](#) says this number has some prime divisor, and that prime must be on the list.

Proof. Suppose, for a contradiction, that there are only finitely many primes, and list them all as $p_1, p_2, \dots, p_k$. Let

$$N = p_1 p_2 \cdots p_k + 1.$$

The list is non-empty, since 2 is prime, and each $p_i \geq 2$; hence $N \geq 3$. By [Proposition 0.2.12](#), N has a prime divisor p . Since the list contains every prime, $p = p_i$ for some i . Then $p_i \mid N$ and $p_i \mid p_1 p_2 \cdots p_k$, so there are integers s, t with $N = p_i s$ and $p_1 \cdots p_k = p_i t$. Subtracting gives $1 = p_i(s - t)$. Since $s - t$ is an integer and $p_i \geq 2$, this is impossible: $p_i(s - t)$ is 0 when $s = t$, and has absolute value at least 2 otherwise. This contradiction shows that there are infinitely many primes. ■

Remark. Well-ordering also justifies the “lowest terms” fact used in [Theorem 0.2.3](#). Let x be rational. There is at least one way of writing $x = a/b$ with $b \geq 1$: if $x = a/b$ with $b < 0$, then also $x = (-a)/(-b)$ with $-b \geq 1$. Among all such ways, the collection of possible denominators b is a non-empty collection of natural numbers, so by [Theorem 0.2.11](#) it has a least element. Take a representation a/b with that least b . If some $d \geq 2$ divided both, say $a = da'$ and $b = db'$, then $x = a'/b'$ with $1 \leq b' < b$, contradicting minimality. So a/b is in lowest terms.

0.2.10 Writing proofs in this book

The proofs in this book follow a few conventions. Knowing them makes proofs faster to read, and copying them makes your own proofs easier to check.

- **The first sentence does mathematics.** Proofs open with “Let ...”, “Suppose ...”, “Since ...” or “By ...”. The motivation has already been given in the Idea block.
- **Every step names its reason.** Each line cites a hypothesis, a definition, or an earlier result by name, as in “by [Proposition 0.2.2](#)”. When a display hides a reason, a clause such as “where the first equality uses the induction hypothesis” points to it.
- **Structure is marked.** Two directions of an iff are labeled $(\Rightarrow)$ and $(\Leftarrow)$, cases are labeled *Case 1* and *Case 2*, and inductions name their base case and inductive step.
- **No hidden gaps.** Words like “obviously” and “clearly” never stand in for an argument. If a step is short, it is written out; if it is routine and has been done before, the proof says so.
- **The ending restates the result:** “This shows ...”, “This proves ...”, “as claimed”.

How to read a proof here. First read the statement and identify the givens and the goal. Then read the Idea, which says why the argument has the shape it has. Then read the Proof with a pencil. At each line, ask which earlier line or result justifies it; if you cannot answer, that is the line to reread. Finally, ask which hypothesis each step used. If a hypothesis was never used, either it was not needed or you have missed a step.

0.2.11 Exercises

0.2.11.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

For each statement, name the proof technique you would use first (direct, contrapositive, contradiction, cases, induction, or counterexample), and give a one-sentence reason. Then carry out the proof or refutation.

- The sum of two odd integers is even.
- For every integer n , if $3n + 2$ is odd, then n is odd.
- For every integer $n \geq 1$, $3 \mid 4^n - 1$.
- For every integer $n \geq 1$, $n^2 \geq 2n$.
- There is no largest integer.

Solution.

- Direct.* The hypothesis gives formulas to add. Let $m = 2a + 1$ and $n = 2b + 1$ with a, b integers, by [Definition 0.2.1](#). Then $m + n = 2(a + b + 1)$, which is even.
- Contrapositive.* The conclusion’s negation “ n even” gives a formula, while “ $3n + 2$ odd” does not. By [Theorem 0.1.1](#) it suffices to show: if n is even then $3n + 2$ is even. If $n = 2k$, then $3n + 2 = 2(3k + 1)$, which is even, hence not odd.
- Induction.* It is a statement for every $n \geq 1$, and $4^{n+1} - 1$ is built from $4^n - 1$. For $n = 1$, $4 - 1 = 3 = 3 \cdot 1$. If $4^n - 1 = 3k$, then $4^{n+1} - 1 = 4(4^n - 1) + 3 = 3(4k + 1)$.

By [Theorem 0.2.7](#) the claim holds for all $n \geq 1$.

- (d) *Counterexample.* The statement is false, so a single witness refutes it. At $n = 1$, $n^2 = 1 < 2 = 2n$.
- (e) *Contradiction.* It says an object does not exist, so assume it does. Suppose m is a largest integer. Then $m + 1$ is an integer with $m + 1 > m$, contradicting the choice of m . Hence there is no largest integer.

0.2.11.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Contrapositive.

Prove that for every integer n , if n^2 is odd, then n is odd.

Solution. Let n be an integer. By [Theorem 0.1.1](#), it suffices to prove that if n is not odd, then n^2 is not odd. Suppose n is not odd. Since every integer is even or odd, n is even, so $n = 2k$ for some integer k by [Definition 0.2.1](#). Then $n^2 = 4k^2 = 2(2k^2)$, so n^2 is even. Since no integer is both even and odd, n^2 is not odd. This proves the statement.

Exercise B2: Induction.

Prove that for every integer $n \geq 1$, the sum of the first n odd numbers is n^2 :

$$1 + 3 + 5 + \cdots + (2n - 1) = n^2.$$

Solution. We prove this by induction on n , using [Theorem 0.2.7](#) with $n_0 = 1$. Let $P(n)$ be the displayed statement.

Base case. For $n = 1$ the left side is 1 and the right side is $1^2 = 1$, so $P(1)$ is true.

Inductive step. Let $n \geq 1$ and suppose $P(n)$ is true. The $(n + 1)$ -st odd number is $2(n + 1) - 1 = 2n + 1$. Then

$$1 + 3 + \cdots + (2n - 1) + (2n + 1) = n^2 + 2n + 1 = (n + 1)^2,$$

where the first equality uses the induction hypothesis. This is $P(n + 1)$.

By [Theorem 0.2.7](#), $P(n)$ holds for every $n \geq 1$.

Exercise B3: $\sqrt{3}$ is irrational.

You may use the school fact that every integer has exactly one of the forms $3k$, $3k + 1$, $3k + 2$ with k an integer.

- (a) Prove that for every integer n , if $3 \mid n^2$ then $3 \mid n$.
- (b) Hence prove that there is no rational number whose square is 3.

Solution.

- (a) Let n be an integer. By [Theorem 0.1.1](#), it suffices to show that if $3 \nmid n$ then $3 \nmid n^2$. Suppose $3 \nmid n$. Then $n = 3k + 1$ or $n = 3k + 2$ for some integer k .

Case 1: $n = 3k + 1$. Then $n^2 = 9k^2 + 6k + 1 = 3(3k^2 + 2k) + 1$.

Case 2: $n = 3k + 2$. Then $n^2 = 9k^2 + 12k + 4 = 3(3k^2 + 4k + 1) + 1$.

In both cases n^2 has the form $3j + 1$ with j an integer. Since an integer has only one of the three forms, n^2 is not of the form $3j$, so $3 \nmid n^2$. This proves (a).

- (b) Suppose, for a contradiction, that a rational number x satisfies $x^2 = 3$. Write $x = a/b$ in lowest terms, so $b \geq 1$ and no integer $d \geq 2$ divides both a and b . Multiplying $a^2/b^2 = 3$ by $b^2 \neq 0$ gives $a^2 = 3b^2$. Therefore $3 \mid a^2$, and by (a), $3 \mid a$. Write $a = 3c$. Then $9c^2 = 3b^2$, so $b^2 = 3c^2$ and $3 \mid b^2$. By (a) again, $3 \mid b$. Thus 3 divides both a and b , contradicting lowest terms. Hence no rational number has square 3.

0.2.11.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Stamps of 4 and 5.

- (a) Show that each of 12, 13, 14, 15 can be written as $4a + 5b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{N}$.
- (b) Prove by strong induction that every integer $n \geq 12$ can be written as $4a + 5b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{N}$.
- (c) Show that 11 cannot be written in this form, so the bound 12 in (b) cannot be lowered to 11.

Hint: for $n \geq 16$, look at $n - 4$.

Solution.

- (a) $12 = 4 \cdot 3 + 5 \cdot 0$, $13 = 4 \cdot 2 + 5 \cdot 1$, $14 = 4 \cdot 1 + 5 \cdot 2$, and $15 = 4 \cdot 0 + 5 \cdot 3$.
- (b) We use [Theorem 0.2.10](#) with $n_0 = 12$. Let $n \geq 12$, and suppose every integer k with $12 \leq k < n$ can be written as $4a + 5b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{N}$.
Case 1: $12 \leq n \leq 15$. Then n has the required form by (a).
Case 2: $n \geq 16$. Then $k = n - 4$ satisfies $12 \leq k < n$, so by the hypothesis $n - 4 = 4a + 5b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{N}$. Hence $n = 4(a + 1) + 5b$, and $a + 1 \in \mathbb{N}$.
 In both cases n has the required form. By [Theorem 0.2.10](#), every integer $n \geq 12$ does.
- (c) Suppose $11 = 4a + 5b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{N}$. Since $5b \leq 11$, $b \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. If $b = 0$ then $4a = 11$; if $b = 1$ then $4a = 6$; if $b = 2$ then $4a = 1$. None of 11, 6, 1 is a multiple of 4, so no such a exists. Hence 11 is not of the form $4a + 5b$.

Exercise C2: Division with remainder.

Let a and b be integers with $b \geq 1$. Let R be the collection of all **non-negative** integers of the form $a - qb$ with q an integer.

- (a) Show that R is non-empty.
- (b) Let r be the least element of R , which exists by [Theorem 0.2.11](#), and write $r = a - qb$. Prove that $0 \leq r < b$.
- (c) Prove that the pair (q, r) is unique: if $a = qb + r = q'b + r'$ with $0 \leq r < b$ and $0 \leq r' < b$, then $q = q'$ and $r = r'$.

Hint for (a): try $q = -|a|$.

Solution.

- (a) Take $q = -|a|$. Then $a - qb = a + |a|b$. Since $b \geq 1$ and $|a| \geq 0$, we have $|a|b \geq |a|$, so $a + |a|b \geq a + |a| \geq 0$, where the last step uses $|a| \geq -a$. Hence $a + |a|b$ belongs to R , and R is non-empty.
- (b) By (a) and [Theorem 0.2.11](#), R has a least element $r = a - qb$ with $q \in \mathbb{Z}$. Since r belongs to R , $r \geq 0$. Suppose, for a contradiction, that $r \geq b$. Then $r - b = a - (q + 1)b \geq 0$, and $q + 1 \in \mathbb{Z}$, so $r - b$ belongs to R . But $b \geq 1$ gives $r - b < r$, contradicting the choice of r as the least element of R . Hence $0 \leq r < b$.
- (c) Suppose $qb + r = q'b + r'$ with $0 \leq r, r' < b$. Then $r' - r = (q - q')b$, so $b \mid r' - r$. From the bounds, $-b < r' - r < b$. Suppose $q \neq q'$. Then $|q - q'| \geq 1$, so $|r' - r| = |q - q'|b \geq b$, contradicting $-b < r' - r < b$. Hence $q = q'$, and then $r' - r = 0$, so $r = r'$. This proves uniqueness.

Together, (a)–(c) show that for integers a and $b \geq 1$ there are unique integers q, r with $a = qb + r$ and $0 \leq r < b$. With $b = 2$, this is the fact that every integer is even or odd, and not both.

0.3 Sets

Every object in linear algebra is a set with some extra structure. A vector space is a set on which we can add and scale, a subspace is a subset of it, and a linear map sends elements of one set to elements of another. Before the structure arrives, we need the plain language of sets: how to describe them, when two of them are equal, and how to combine them. The most important move in this section is proving that two sets are equal by proving two inclusions, a move we will use for subspaces, spans, kernels and images throughout the book.

0.3.1 Sets, elements and set-builder notation

A **set** is a collection of objects, called its **elements**. We write $x \in A$ for “ x is an element of A ” (also “ x belongs to A ”, “ x lies in A ”), and $x \notin A$ for its negation. A set is determined by its elements and nothing else: it has no order and no repetition. So $\{1, 2\}$, $\{2, 1\}$ and $\{1, 1, 2\}$ all describe the same set, whose elements are 1 and 2. We make this precise below.

Small sets can be listed between braces. Infinite sets we meet constantly have fixed names.

Definition 0.3.1 — Common number sets

We write

- $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, 3, \dots\}$ for the **natural numbers**; in this book $\mathbb{N}$ **includes** 0;
- $\mathbb{Z} = \{\dots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ for the **integers**;
- $\mathbb{Q}$ for the **rational numbers**, the numbers a/b with $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $b \neq 0$;
- $\mathbb{R}$ for the **real numbers**;

- $\mathbb{C}$ for the **complex numbers**, studied later in this chapter.

Books disagree about whether $0 \in \mathbb{N}$. With our convention, the Well-Ordering Principle ([Theorem 0.2.11](#)) applies to collections that contain 0, and “ $n \in \mathbb{N}$ ” means $n \geq 0$. When we need positive integers only, we say “ $n \geq 1$ ”. For real numbers $a \leq b$ we also use **intervals**: $[a, b]$ is the set of real x with $a \leq x \leq b$, (a, b) the set with $a < x < b$, and $[a, b)$, $(a, b]$ are defined in the same way.

Listing elements fails for most sets we care about, such as “the real numbers whose square is less than 4”. Instead we describe a set by a property, and select from a set we already have.

Definition 0.3.2 — Set-builder notation

Let S be a set and let $P(x)$ be a predicate for $x \in S$. The set

$$\{x \in S : P(x)\}$$

is the set whose elements are **exactly** those $x \in S$ for which $P(x)$ is true.

In words: an object y belongs to $\{x \in S : P(x)\}$ if and only if $y \in S$ **and** $P(y)$ is true. Both parts matter. The ambient set S says where we are looking, and the predicate says what we keep. The colon is read “such that”; some books use a vertical bar instead. When it is plain which sets the elements come from, as in the unions and intersections below, we sometimes leave the ambient set out and write $\{x : P(x)\}$.

A second form describes the elements by a formula: $\{2k : k \in \mathbb{Z}\}$ is the set of all numbers of the form $2k$ with k an integer. An object y belongs to it exactly when $y = 2k$ for **some** $k \in \mathbb{Z}$. This form will describe sets such as “all combinations of given vectors” in Chapter 1.

Example. (Reading set-builder notation)

Describe each set more simply.

- $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 < 4\}$.
- $\{x \in \mathbb{Z} : x^2 < 4\}$.
- $\{n \in \mathbb{Z} : n \text{ is even}\}$ and $\{2k : k \in \mathbb{Z}\}$.
- $\{(x, y) : x, y \in \mathbb{R}, x + y = 1\}$, a set of ordered pairs (made precise under Cartesian products below).

Solution.

- A real number satisfies $x^2 < 4$ exactly when $-2 < x < 2$, so the set is the interval $(-2, 2)$.
- The same predicate, selected from $\mathbb{Z}$ instead, keeps only integers: the set is $\{-1, 0, 1\}$. Changing the ambient set changes the set.
- Both are the set $\{\dots, -4, -2, 0, 2, 4, \dots\}$ of even integers. The first selects the integers with a property; the second produces each element by the formula $2k$. By the definition of “even” ([Definition 0.2.1](#)), an integer is even exactly when it equals $2k$ for some $k \in \mathbb{Z}$.
- The pairs of reals whose coordinates add to 1: the line in the plane through $(1, 0)$

and $(0, 1)$.

What if no element of S satisfies the predicate? We still want a set, and it has no elements.

Definition 0.3.3 — Empty set

The **empty set** $\emptyset$ is the set with **no** elements: $x \notin \emptyset$ for every object x .

For example, $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 = -1\} = \emptyset$, since $x^2 \geq 0$ for every real x (Example (Quantified statements)). Also $\{n \in \mathbb{Z} : 0 < n < 1\} = \emptyset$. We will see shortly that there is only **one** empty set, so these two descriptions give the same set.

Statements about all elements of $\emptyset$ are vacuously true: “every element of $\emptyset$ is a prime number” has no element that could fail, just as in the degenerate case discussed after Example (Quantified statements).

Warning. $\emptyset$, $\{\emptyset\}$ and $\{0\}$ are three different sets. The set $\emptyset$ has no elements. The set $\{\emptyset\}$ has exactly one element, namely the empty set. The set $\{0\}$ has exactly one element, namely the number 0. A box containing an empty box is not an empty box. In Chapter 1 this matters: $\{0\}$ will be a subspace, and $\emptyset$ never is.

0.3.2 Subsets

Most sets in this book live inside a bigger set: the even integers inside $\mathbb{Z}$, a line inside the plane, and later a subspace inside a vector space. The first thing to check about a candidate subspace will be that it sits inside the space at all. We need a word for “sits inside”.

A is a subset of B when everything in A is also in B.

Definition 0.3.4 — Subset

Let A and B be sets. We say A is a **subset** of B , and write $A \subseteq B$, if

$$\forall x : (x \in A \Rightarrow x \in B).$$

If $A \subseteq B$ and $A \neq B$, then A is a **proper** subset of B , written $A \subsetneq B$.

In words: $A \subseteq B$ says that **every** element of A is an element of B . It says nothing about elements of B ; B may contain many more. The definition is an implication inside a “for every”, so the proof template of the previous section applies: to show $A \subseteq B$, **let** $x \in A$ and show $x \in B$.

By Definition 0.1.4 and Theorem 0.1.2, the negation reads

$$A \not\subseteq B \iff \exists x : x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B.$$

So to show A is **not** a subset of B , exhibit one element of A outside B .

Example. (Subsets)

Decide whether each inclusion holds.

- (a) $\mathbb{N} \subseteq \mathbb{Z} \subseteq \mathbb{Q} \subseteq \mathbb{R}$.
- (b) $\{1, 2\} \subseteq \{1, 2, 3\}$ and $\{1, 4\} \subseteq \{1, 2, 3\}$.
- (c) $A \subseteq A$ and $\emptyset \subseteq A$, for any set A .
- (d) $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 = 1\} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}$.

Solution.

- (a) All hold. Every natural number is an integer; every integer n equals $n/1$, so it is rational; every rational number is real.
- (b) The first holds: each of 1, 2 is an element of $\{1, 2, 3\}$. The second fails, although it differs from the first in only one element: 1 passes, but $4 \in \{1, 4\}$ and $4 \notin \{1, 2, 3\}$, so 4 is a witness for $\{1, 4\} \not\subseteq \{1, 2, 3\}$.
- (c) Both hold. For $A \subseteq A$: let $x \in A$; then $x \in A$. For $\emptyset \subseteq A$: the implication $x \in \emptyset \Rightarrow x \in A$ has a false hypothesis for every x by [Definition 0.3.3](#), so it is vacuously true ([Definition 0.1.2](#)). The empty set is a subset of every set, including itself.
- (d) Holds. Let $x \in \mathbb{R}$ with $x^2 = 1$. Then $(x - 1)(x + 1) = 0$, so $x = 1$ or $x = -1$, and both are integers.

Warning. $\in$ and $\subseteq$ are different relations. $x \in A$ says the object x is one of the elements of A . $A \subseteq B$ compares two sets, element by element. So $1 \in \{1, 2\}$ is true while $1 \subseteq \{1, 2\}$ makes no sense (1 is not a set here); and $\{1\} \subseteq \{1, 2\}$ is true while $\{1\} \in \{1, 2\}$ is false.

Quick check. Let $X = \{\{1, 2\}, 3\}$. Is $\{1, 2\} \subseteq X$? Is $\{1, 2\} \in X$?

Solution. The set X has exactly two elements: the set $\{1, 2\}$ and the number 3. So $\{1, 2\} \in X$ is **true**. But $\{1, 2\} \subseteq X$ is **false**: $1 \in \{1, 2\}$, and 1 is neither the set $\{1, 2\}$ nor the number 3, so $1 \notin X$.

0.3.3 Equality of sets and double inclusion

We said a set is determined by its elements. Here is the precise version.

Definition 0.3.5 — Set equality

Two sets A and B are **equal**, written $A = B$, if they have exactly the same elements:

$$\forall x : (x \in A \Leftrightarrow x \in B).$$

So $\{1, 2\} = \{2, 1\} = \{1, 1, 2\}$: each object belongs to one of these sets exactly when it is 1 or 2. Order and repetition in a list are features of how we **write** a set, not of the set.

Proving a biconditional for every x at once is awkward. It is much easier to prove two implications separately, and that is exactly what the next result allows.

Theorem 0.3.1 — Double inclusion

Let A and B be sets. Then $A = B$ if and only if $A \subseteq B$ and $B \subseteq A$.

Proof. By Definition 0.3.5, $A = B$ means that for every x , both $x \in A \Rightarrow x \in B$ and $x \in B \Rightarrow x \in A$ hold, since a biconditional is the conjunction of an implication and its converse. A statement of the form “for every x , $P(x)$ and $Q(x)$ ” holds exactly when “for every x , $P(x)$ ” and “for every x , $Q(x)$ ” both hold, by Definition 0.1.3. Hence $A = B$ holds exactly when $\forall x (x \in A \Rightarrow x \in B)$ and $\forall x (x \in B \Rightarrow x \in A)$ both hold. By Definition 0.3.4, these are $A \subseteq B$ and $B \subseteq A$. This proves the theorem. ■

This is the move “**prove set equality by double inclusion**”. The proof is written in two labeled halves, $(\subseteq)$ and $(\supseteq)$, each starting “Let $x \in \dots$ ”. Here is a first consequence.

Remark. There is only one empty set. If E and E' are sets with no elements, then $E \subseteq E'$ and $E' \subseteq E$ hold vacuously, as in Example (Subsets) (c), so $E = E'$ by Theorem 0.3.1. This is why we may say **the** empty set.

Example. (A solution set by double inclusion)

Prove that $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 - 3x + 2 = 0\} = \{1, 2\}$.

Solution. Write $S = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 - 3x + 2 = 0\}$. By Theorem 0.3.1 it suffices to prove $S \subseteq \{1, 2\}$ and $\{1, 2\} \subseteq S$.

$(\subseteq)$ Let $x \in S$. Then x is real and $x^2 - 3x + 2 = 0$. Factoring, $(x - 1)(x - 2) = 0$. A product of two real numbers is zero only if one factor is zero, so $x = 1$ or $x = 2$. Hence $x \in \{1, 2\}$.

$(\supseteq)$ Let $x \in \{1, 2\}$, so $x = 1$ or $x = 2$. Both are real. If $x = 1$, then $1 - 3 + 2 = 0$; if $x = 2$, then $4 - 6 + 2 = 0$. In either case $x \in S$.

This shows $S = \{1, 2\}$.

Solving an equation “at school” usually produces only the $(\subseteq)$ half: “if x is a solution, then x is 1 or 2”. The $(\supseteq)$ half, checking that the candidates really are solutions, is the part that gets forgotten. It matters whenever a step in the solving is not reversible, such as squaring both sides.

0.3.4 Union, intersection and difference

Given two sets, there are three basic ways to form a new one: keep what is in either, keep what is in both, or keep what is in the first but not the second. Each is a set-builder description whose predicate uses a connective from the section on logic.

Definition 0.3.6 — Union

The **union** of sets A and B is

$$A \cup B = \{x : x \in A \text{ or } x \in B\}.$$

Definition 0.3.7 — Intersection

The **intersection** of sets A and B is

$$A \cap B = \{x : x \in A \text{ and } x \in B\}.$$

We call A and B **disjoint** if $A \cap B = \emptyset$.

Definition 0.3.8 — Set difference and complement

The **difference** of sets A and B is

$$A \setminus B = \{x \in A : x \notin B\}.$$

When all sets under discussion are subsets of one fixed set U , the **complement** of $B \subseteq U$ is $B^c = U \setminus B$.

In words: the union keeps an element that lies in **at least one** of the sets (the “or” is inclusive, as always); the intersection keeps an element that lies in **both**; the difference $A \setminus B$ keeps the elements of A that are **not** in B . The complement depends on the choice of U : the complement of $\mathbb{N}$ is the set of negative integers inside $\mathbb{Z}$, but a much bigger set inside $\mathbb{R}$.

Example. (Operations on finite sets)

Let $A = \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ and $B = \{3, 4, 5, 6\}$. Compute $A \cup B$, $A \cap B$, $A \setminus B$ and $B \setminus A$.

Solution. Checking each element against the definitions: $A \cup B = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$; $A \cap B = \{3, 4\}$; $A \setminus B = \{1, 2\}$; and $B \setminus A = \{5, 6\}$. Since $A \setminus B \neq B \setminus A$, the difference is not symmetric in its two arguments, unlike union and intersection.

Example. (Operations on intervals)

Let $A = [0, 2]$ and $B = [1, 3]$. Compute $A \cup B$, $A \cap B$ and $A \setminus B$.

Solution. A real x lies in $A \cup B$ when $0 \leq x \leq 2$ or $1 \leq x \leq 3$, which happens exactly when $0 \leq x \leq 3$; so $A \cup B = [0, 3]$. It lies in $A \cap B$ when both hold, that is, when $1 \leq x \leq 2$; so $A \cap B = [1, 2]$. It lies in $A \setminus B$ when $0 \leq x \leq 2$ and not $1 \leq x \leq 3$. Given $x \leq 2$, “not $1 \leq x \leq 3$ ” means $x < 1$; so $A \setminus B = [0, 1)$. The endpoint 1 is excluded because $1 \in B$.

Unions, intersections and differences interact through laws that mirror those for “or”, “and”

and “not”. The first pair is De Morgan’s laws, the set version of [Theorem 0.1.2](#).

Theorem 0.3.2 — De Morgan’s laws for sets

Let A , B and C be sets. Then

- (a) $A \setminus (B \cup C) = (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$;
- (b) $A \setminus (B \cap C) = (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$.

In particular, if $B, C \subseteq U$, then $(B \cup C)^c = B^c \cap C^c$ and $(B \cap C)^c = B^c \cup C^c$.

Idea. Unwind membership into connectives. “ $x \notin B \cup C$ ” is “not ($x \in B$ or $x \in C$)”, and De Morgan for statements turns that into “ $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$ ”. So each law is its logical counterpart, applied one element at a time. We prove (a) by double inclusion; (b) is an exercise.

Proof. We prove (a) using [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in A \setminus (B \cup C)$. By [Definition 0.3.8](#), $x \in A$ and $x \notin B \cup C$. By [Definition 0.3.6](#), the second says that “ $x \in B$ or $x \in C$ ” is false, so by [Theorem 0.1.2](#), $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$. Since $x \in A$ and $x \notin B$, we have $x \in A \setminus B$; since $x \in A$ and $x \notin C$, we have $x \in A \setminus C$. Hence $x \in (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$ by [Definition 0.3.7](#).

($\supseteq$) Let $x \in (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$. By [Definition 0.3.7](#) and [Definition 0.3.8](#), $x \in A$, $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$. By [Theorem 0.1.2](#), “ $x \in B$ or $x \in C$ ” is false, so $x \notin B \cup C$. Together with $x \in A$, this gives $x \in A \setminus (B \cup C)$.

This proves (a). For the complement form, take $A = U$ and use [Definition 0.3.8](#): $(B \cup C)^c = U \setminus (B \cup C) = (U \setminus B) \cap (U \setminus C) = B^c \cap C^c$, and similarly for (b). ■

The second pair of laws says each of $\cap$ and $\cup$ distributes over the other, like multiplication over addition, except that here **both** directions hold.

Theorem 0.3.3 — Distributive laws for sets

Let A , B and C be sets. Then

- (a) $A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$;
- (b) $A \cup (B \cap C) = (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$.

Idea. Double inclusion again, and in each half the “or” in a union forces a split into cases. For (b) ($\supseteq$), an element of both $A \cup B$ and $A \cup C$ is either in A , and then done, or not in A , and then it must be in B and in C . We prove (b); (a) is an exercise.

Proof. We prove (b) using [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$. By [Definition 0.3.6](#), $x \in A$ or $x \in B \cap C$.

Case 1: $x \in A$. Then $x \in A \cup B$ and $x \in A \cup C$ by [Definition 0.3.6](#).

Case 2: $x \in B \cap C$. Then $x \in B$ and $x \in C$ by Definition 0.3.7, so again $x \in A \cup B$ and $x \in A \cup C$.

In both cases $x \in (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$ by Definition 0.3.7.

($\supseteq$) Let $x \in (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$, so $x \in A \cup B$ and $x \in A \cup C$.

Case 1: $x \in A$. Then $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$.

Case 2: $x \notin A$. Since $x \in A \cup B$ and $x \notin A$, we get $x \in B$. Since $x \in A \cup C$ and $x \notin A$, we get $x \in C$. Hence $x \in B \cap C$, so $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$.

In both cases $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$. This proves (b). ■

Remark. In Chapter 1 we will see that the intersection of two subspaces is always a subspace, while their union usually is not: the two axes in the plane are subspaces, but $(1, 0) + (0, 1) = (1, 1)$ lies on neither. The union is replaced there by a different construction, the sum of subspaces.

0.3.5 Indexed families of sets

Two sets are not always enough. In Chapter 1 we will need “the intersection of **all** subspaces that contain a given set”, and there are usually infinitely many of them. So we need unions and intersections of any number of sets at once.

An indexed family is a list of sets with one set for each label; its union keeps what lies in some member, its intersection what lies in every member.

Definition 0.3.9 — Unions and intersections of indexed families

Let I be a set, and for each $i \in I$ let A_i be a set. The collection $(A_i)_{i \in I}$ is an **indexed family** of sets, with **index set** I . Its **union** is

$$\bigcup_{i \in I} A_i = \{x : \exists i \in I : x \in A_i\},$$

and, if I is **non-empty**, its **intersection** is

$$\bigcap_{i \in I} A_i = \{x : \forall i \in I : x \in A_i\}.$$

In words: x lies in the union when it lies in **at least one** A_i , and in the intersection when it lies in **every** A_i . When $I = \{1, 2\}$, these are $A_1 \cup A_2$ and $A_1 \cap A_2$. When $I = \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$, we also write $\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} A_n$ and $\bigcap_{n=1}^{\infty} A_n$.

Why I must be non-empty for the intersection. If $I = \emptyset$, the condition “ $\forall i \in I : x \in A_i$ ” is vacuously true for **every** object x , so the “intersection” would contain everything, which is not a set we want. (When all sets live inside a fixed U , one sometimes defines the empty intersection to be U .) The empty union causes no such trouble: “ $\exists i \in \emptyset$ ” is always false, so $\bigcup_{i \in \emptyset} A_i = \emptyset$.

Example. (Indexed unions and intersections of intervals)

For each integer $n \geq 1$, let $A_n = [1/n, 1]$ and $B_n = (0, 1/n)$. Show that

$$\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} A_n = (0, 1] \quad \text{and} \quad \bigcap_{n=1}^{\infty} B_n = \emptyset.$$

You may use the fact that for every real $x > 0$ there is an integer $n \geq 1$ with $1/n < x$.

Solution. The union. ($\subseteq$) Let $x \in \bigcup_n A_n$. By [Definition 0.3.9](#), $x \in A_n$ for some $n \geq 1$, so $0 < 1/n \leq x \leq 1$. Hence $x \in (0, 1]$. ($\supseteq$) Let $x \in (0, 1]$. Since $x > 0$, there is an integer $n \geq 1$ with $1/n < x$. Then $1/n \leq x \leq 1$, so $x \in A_n$, and hence x lies in the union. By [Theorem 0.3.1](#), the union is $(0, 1]$.

The intersection. Suppose, for a contradiction, that some x lies in $\bigcap_n B_n$. Then $x \in B_1 = (0, 1)$, so $x > 0$. Choose an integer $n \geq 1$ with $1/n < x$. Then $x \notin (0, 1/n) = B_n$, contradicting $x \in B_n$ for every n . Hence the intersection has no elements, so it equals $\emptyset$.

Each B_n is non-empty (it contains $1/(2n)$), and each is contained in the one before. Yet their intersection is empty. Infinite intersections can shrink to nothing even when no single step does.

De Morgan's laws hold for indexed families with the same proofs: for a non-empty index set I , $A \setminus \bigcup_i B_i = \bigcap_i (A \setminus B_i)$ and $A \setminus \bigcap_i B_i = \bigcup_i (A \setminus B_i)$. The “or” of the finite version becomes “there exists”, and the “and” becomes “for every”, exactly as in [Definition 0.1.4](#).

0.3.6 Cartesian products and n -tuples

A set forgets order: $\{1, 2\} = \{2, 1\}$. But a point in the plane is not like that. The point $(1, 2)$ is different from $(2, 1)$. We need objects that remember order.

An **ordered pair** (a, b) has a first entry a and a second entry b , and two ordered pairs are equal exactly when their entries agree in order:

$$(a, b) = (a', b') \iff a = a' \text{ and } b = b'.$$

Definition 0.3.10 — Cartesian product

Let A and B be sets. The **Cartesian product** of A and B is the set of ordered pairs

$$A \times B = \{(a, b) : a \in A, b \in B\}.$$

More generally, for sets $A_1, \dots, A_n$, the product $A_1 \times \dots \times A_n$ is the set of all ordered lists $(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ with $a_i \in A_i$ for each i .

For example, $\{1, 2\} \times \{x, y\} = \{(1, x), (1, y), (2, x), (2, y)\}$. The order of the factors matters: $(1, x) \in \{1, 2\} \times \{x, y\}$, but $(1, x) \notin \{x, y\} \times \{1, 2\}$, whose pairs have a letter first. A degenerate case: $A \times \emptyset = \emptyset$ for every set A , since no pair can have a second entry from $\emptyset$.

Definition 0.3.11 — n -tuples

Let A be a set and $n \geq 1$ an integer. An **n -tuple** of elements of A is an ordered list $(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ with each $a_i \in A$. The set of all of them is

$$A^n = \underbrace{A \times A \times \cdots \times A}_{n \text{ factors}}.$$

Two n -tuples are equal exactly when $a_i = b_i$ for **every** $i = 1, \dots, n$.

Example. (Sets of tuples)

Describe some elements of $\mathbb{R}^2$, $\mathbb{Z}^3$ and $\{0, 1\}^3$, and count the elements of $\{0, 1\}^3$.

Solution. The set $\mathbb{R}^2$ is the plane: it contains $(0, 0)$, $(1, -2)$ and $(\sqrt{2}, \pi)$. The set $\mathbb{Z}^3$ contains $(1, 0, -4)$ but not $(1, \frac{1}{2}, 0)$, whose second entry is not an integer. The set $\{0, 1\}^3$ consists of the lists of three bits:

$$\{0, 1\}^3 = \{(0, 0, 0), (0, 0, 1), (0, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1), (1, 0, 0), (1, 0, 1), (1, 1, 0), (1, 1, 1)\}.$$

There are two choices for each of the three entries, giving $2 \cdot 2 \cdot 2 = 8$ elements. In the same way, if A has k elements then A^n has k^n elements.

In Chapter 1, $\mathbb{R}^n$ and more generally F^n become the first examples of vector spaces, with n -tuples added and scaled entry by entry.

0.3.7 Power sets

Sets can themselves be elements of sets, as the warning about $\{\emptyset\}$ showed. One such set collects every subset of a given set.

Definition 0.3.12 — Power set

The **power set** of a set S is the set of all subsets of S :

$$\mathcal{P}(S) = \{X : X \subseteq S\}.$$

So $X \in \mathcal{P}(S)$ means exactly $X \subseteq S$. For example,

$$\mathcal{P}(\{1, 2\}) = \{\emptyset, \{1\}, \{2\}, \{1, 2\}\},$$

which has 4 elements. The degenerate case is instructive: $\mathcal{P}(\emptyset) = \{\emptyset\}$ has **one** element, because the empty set has exactly one subset, itself. For a set with n elements the power set has 2^n elements; the last exercise proves this by induction.

0.3.8 Exercises

0.3.8.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

Decide whether each statement is true or false. Give a one-line reason.

- (a) $0 \in \mathbb{N}$.
- (b) $\emptyset \in \emptyset$.
- (c) $\emptyset \subseteq \emptyset$.
- (d) $\{0\} = \emptyset$.
- (e) $\{1, 2\} = \{2, 1, 1\}$ and $(1, 2) = (2, 1)$.
- (f) $\{1\} \in \mathcal{P}(\{1, 2\})$ and $\{1\} \subseteq \mathcal{P}(\{1, 2\})$.

Solution.

- (a) True. By [Definition 0.3.1](#), $\mathbb{N}$ includes 0 in this book.
- (b) False. By [Definition 0.3.3](#), nothing is an element of $\emptyset$, not even $\emptyset$.
- (c) True. The empty set is a subset of every set, vacuously, as in [Example \(Subsets\)](#).
- (d) False. $0 \in \{0\}$ but $0 \notin \emptyset$, so the two sets do not have the same elements ([Definition 0.3.5](#)).
- (e) The first is true: both sets have exactly the elements 1 and 2. The second is false: ordered pairs are equal only when their first entries agree, and $1 \neq 2$.
- (f) The first is true: $\{1\} \subseteq \{1, 2\}$, so $\{1\} \in \mathcal{P}(\{1, 2\})$ by [Definition 0.3.12](#). The second is false: $1 \in \{1\}$, but 1 is a number, not a subset of $\{1, 2\}$, so $1 \notin \mathcal{P}(\{1, 2\})$.

0.3.8.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: The second De Morgan law.

Let A, B, C be sets. Prove that $A \setminus (B \cap C) = (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$, which is part (b) of [Theorem 0.3.2](#).

Solution. We use [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in A \setminus (B \cap C)$. By [Definition 0.3.8](#), $x \in A$ and $x \notin B \cap C$. By [Definition 0.3.7](#), “ $x \in B$ and $x \in C$ ” is false, so by [Theorem 0.1.2](#), $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$. If $x \notin B$, then $x \in A \setminus B$; if $x \notin C$, then $x \in A \setminus C$. In either case $x \in (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$ by [Definition 0.3.6](#).

($\supseteq$) Let $x \in (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$. By [Definition 0.3.6](#), $x \in A \setminus B$ or $x \in A \setminus C$. In the first case $x \in A$ and $x \notin B$; in the second, $x \in A$ and $x \notin C$. In both cases $x \in A$, and “ $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$ ” is true, so by [Theorem 0.1.2](#) “ $x \in B$ and $x \in C$ ” is false, that is, $x \notin B \cap C$. Hence $x \in A \setminus (B \cap C)$.

This proves the equality.

Exercise B2: A distributive law.

Let A, B, C be sets. Prove that $A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$, which is part (a) of [Theorem 0.3.3](#).

Solution. We use [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$. Then $x \in A$ and $x \in B \cup C$, so $x \in B$ or $x \in C$. If $x \in B$, then $x \in A \cap B$; if $x \in C$, then $x \in A \cap C$. In either case $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$.

($\supseteq$) Let $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. If $x \in A \cap B$, then $x \in A$ and $x \in B \subseteq B \cup C$. If $x \in A \cap C$, then $x \in A$ and $x \in C \subseteq B \cup C$. In either case $x \in A$ and $x \in B \cup C$, so $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$.

This proves the equality.

Exercise B3: An indexed intersection.

Prove that

$$\bigcap_{n=1}^{\infty} \left(-\frac{1}{n}, \frac{1}{n}\right) = \{0\}.$$

You may use the fact that for every real $x > 0$ there is an integer $n \geq 1$ with $1/n < x$.

Solution. Write $B_n = (-1/n, 1/n)$ and $B = \bigcap_{n \geq 1} B_n$. We use [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\supseteq$) For every $n \geq 1$, $-1/n < 0 < 1/n$, so $0 \in B_n$. By [Definition 0.3.9](#), $0 \in B$.

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in B$. Suppose, for a contradiction, that $x \neq 0$. Then $|x| > 0$, so there is an integer $n \geq 1$ with $1/n < |x|$. Then $x \geq 1/n$ or $x \leq -1/n$, so $x \notin B_n$. This contradicts $x \in B$, which requires $x \in B_n$ for **every** n . Hence $x = 0$, that is, $x \in \{0\}$.

This shows $B = \{0\}$.

0.3.8.3 C. Going deeper**Exercise C1: When union equals intersection.**

Let A and B be sets. Prove that $A \cup B = A \cap B$ if and only if $A = B$.

Solution. ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $A = B$. Then $A \cup B = A \cup A$ and $A \cap B = A \cap A$. By [Definition 0.3.6](#) and [Definition 0.3.7](#), “ $x \in A$ or $x \in A$ ” and “ $x \in A$ and $x \in A$ ” are both equivalent to $x \in A$, so $A \cup A = A = A \cap A$. Hence $A \cup B = A \cap B$.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $A \cup B = A \cap B$. We show $A = B$ using [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $x \in A$. Then $x \in A \cup B$ by [Definition 0.3.6](#). Since $A \cup B = A \cap B$, we get $x \in A \cap B$, and in particular $x \in B$.

($\supseteq$) Swapping the roles of A and B in the previous paragraph, which is allowed since $A \cup B = B \cup A$ and $A \cap B = B \cap A$, gives $B \subseteq A$.

Hence $A = B$. This proves the equivalence.

Exercise C2: Counting subsets.

For a finite set S , write $|S|$ for its number of elements. The aim is to prove that $|\mathcal{P}(S)| = 2^{|S|}$ for every finite set S .

- (a) Check the claim when $S = \emptyset$.
- (b) Let S have $n+1$ elements, fix $s \in S$, and let $S' = S \setminus \{s\}$. Show that every subset X of S belongs to exactly one of the two collections: the subsets of S with $s \notin X$, and the subsets of S with $s \in X$.
- (c) Show that the subsets of S with $s \notin X$ are exactly the subsets of S' , and that $X \mapsto X \setminus \{s\}$ and $T \mapsto T \cup \{s\}$ pair off the subsets of S containing s with the subsets of S' , each undoing the other.
- (d) Hence prove the claim by induction on $n = |S|$.

Hint: in (c), use double inclusion to check that $(X \setminus \{s\}) \cup \{s\} = X$ when $s \in X$.

Solution.

- (a) The only subset of $\emptyset$ is $\emptyset$ itself, since any $X \subseteq \emptyset$ has no elements and so equals $\emptyset$ by [Theorem 0.3.1](#). So $\mathcal{P}(\emptyset) = \{\emptyset\}$ has $1 = 2^0$ element.
- (b) Let $X \subseteq S$. The statement $s \in X$ is either true or false, and not both. So X lies in exactly one of the two collections.
- (c) *First collection.* If $X \subseteq S$ and $s \notin X$, then every $x \in X$ lies in S and is not s , so $x \in S'$; hence $X \subseteq S'$. Conversely, if $T \subseteq S'$, then $T \subseteq S$ and $s \notin T$, since no element of S' equals s . So the first collection is exactly $\mathcal{P}(S')$.
Second collection. If $X \subseteq S$ with $s \in X$, then $X \setminus \{s\} \subseteq S'$. If $T \subseteq S'$, then $T \cup \{s\} \subseteq S$ contains s . Now we check that the two operations undo each other. For X containing s : an element lies in $(X \setminus \{s\}) \cup \{s\}$ exactly when it is in X and not s , or it is s ; since $s \in X$, this is exactly when it is in X . So $(X \setminus \{s\}) \cup \{s\} = X$. For $T \subseteq S'$: an element lies in $(T \cup \{s\}) \setminus \{s\}$ exactly when it is in T or equal to s , and not equal to s ; since $s \notin T$, this is exactly when it is in T . So $(T \cup \{s\}) \setminus \{s\} = T$. Hence the two operations pair the subsets of S containing s one-to-one with the subsets of S' , and the two collections have the same number of elements.
- (d) Let $P(n)$ be the statement “every set with n elements has exactly 2^n subsets”. We use [Theorem 0.2.7](#) with $n_0 = 0$. The base case $P(0)$ is (a), since the only set with no elements is $\emptyset$. Let $n \geq 0$, suppose $P(n)$, and let S have $n+1$ elements. Fix $s \in S$, which exists since $n+1 \geq 1$, and let $S' = S \setminus \{s\}$, a set with n elements. By (b), the number of subsets of S is the size of the first collection plus the size of the second. By (c) and the induction hypothesis, each of these sizes equals $|\mathcal{P}(S')| = 2^n$. Hence S has $2^n + 2^n = 2^{n+1}$ subsets, which is $P(n+1)$. By [Theorem 0.2.7](#), $P(n)$ holds for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$, as claimed.

0.4 Functions

Sets are the objects of this chapter. The next question is how to move between them, and the tool is a function. Almost everything in linear algebra is a question about a function: a linear map is a function, a matrix will turn out to encode one, and “does $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ have a solution, and

is it unique?” is a question about whether a function is surjective and injective. This section fixes the language of functions, composition and inverses, and proves the handful of facts about them that the rest of the book uses without comment.

0.4.1 What a function is

At school a function is usually a formula, such as $x^2 + 1$. A formula alone is not enough. The same formula x^2 behaves differently depending on which numbers we feed it and where we allow the answers to land, and whether an equation $x^2 = c$ can be solved depends on exactly that information. So a function carries three pieces of data, not one.

A function is a machine with a fixed input set and a fixed target set that turns each input into exactly one output.

Definition 0.4.1 — Function

Let X and Y be sets. A **function** (or **map**) $f: X \rightarrow Y$ is a rule that assigns to **every** element $x \in X$ **exactly one** element $f(x) \in Y$. The set X is the **domain** of f , the set Y is its **codomain**, and $f(x)$ is the **value** of f at x . We also write $x \mapsto f(x)$.

Two functions $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: X' \rightarrow Y'$ are **equal** if $X = X'$, $Y = Y'$, and $f(x) = g(x)$ for every $x \in X$.

In words: the first clause says every input gets an output, so nothing in the domain is left out. The second says the output is unique, so the rule never hesitates between two values. The codomain is where outputs are *allowed* to land; nothing says every element of Y must be hit.

If you want a definition that avoids the vague word “rule”, use the Cartesian product ([Definition 0.3.10](#)): a function $X \rightarrow Y$ is a subset $G \subseteq X \times Y$ such that for every $x \in X$ there is exactly one $y \in Y$ with $(x, y) \in G$. The set G is the **graph** of f , and $f(x)$ is that unique y . Nothing in this book depends on which version you prefer.

Example. (First examples)

Check each of the following against the two clauses of [Definition 0.4.1](#).

- (a) $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $f(x) = 3x - 5$. Every real x gives one real number $3x - 5$.
- (b) $s: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $s(x, y) = x + y$. The domain is a Cartesian product; each pair gives one sum.
- (c) $\ell: \{\text{finite strings of the letters } a, b\} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$, sending a string to its length. The empty string has length 0, which is why it matters that $\mathbb{N}$ contains 0.
- (d) For any set X , the rule $x \mapsto x$ is a function $X \rightarrow X$. It looks too simple to matter, but it will play the role that the number 1 plays for multiplication.
- (e) For any set Y , there is exactly one function $\emptyset \rightarrow Y$, the **empty function**. Both clauses are about elements of the domain, and there are none, so they hold vacuously. It is a degenerate case that makes statements like “for every set X ” true without exceptions.

The failures are just as instructive. The rule “ $x \mapsto$ the real number y with $y^2 = x$ ” is **not** a

function $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. At $x = -1$ there is no such y , so the first clause fails. At $x = 4$ there are two, $y = 2$ and $y = -2$, so the second clause fails. Repairing both problems gives a genuine function $[0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $x \mapsto \sqrt{x}$, where $\sqrt{x}$ means the non-negative root.

The equality clause says the codomain is part of the function. The functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $x \mapsto x^2$ and $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, \infty)$, $x \mapsto x^2$ have the same values but are **different** functions. This is not pedantry: we will see in a moment that one of them is surjective and the other is not.

Quick check. Let $f, g: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be $f(x) = |x|$ and $g(x) = \sqrt{x^2}$. Are f and g equal?

Solution. Yes. They have the same domain and the same codomain, and for every real x we have $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, because $|x|$ is the non-negative number whose square is x^2 . Different formulas can describe the same function; what counts is the values.

0.4.2 Images and preimages

Often we want to push a whole set through a function, or ask which inputs land in a given region. Both operations get a name.

Definition 0.4.2 — Image and preimage

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ be a function, $A \subseteq X$ and $B \subseteq Y$.

- The **image** of A under f is $f(A) := \{f(a) : a \in A\} \subseteq Y$. The set $f(X)$ is called the **image of f** .
- The **preimage** of B under f is $f^{-1}(B) := \{x \in X : f(x) \in B\} \subseteq X$.

In words: $f(A)$ collects the outputs of the inputs in A . The preimage $f^{-1}(B)$ collects every input whose output lies in B . So $y \in f(A)$ means “ $y = f(a)$ for **some** $a \in A$ ”, while $x \in f^{-1}(B)$ means “ $f(x) \in B$ ”, with no existential quantifier at all.

Example. (Images and preimages of the squaring map)

Let $q: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $q(x) = x^2$. Compute $q([-1, 2])$, $q^{-1}([1, 4])$ and $q^{-1}([-5, -1])$.

Solution. As x runs over $[-1, 2]$, the square x^2 takes every value in $[0, 4]$: values in $[0, 1]$ come from $[0, 1]$, values in $[1, 4]$ from $[1, 2]$, and no square is negative or exceeds $2^2 = 4$ on this interval. Hence $q([-1, 2]) = [0, 4]$.

Next, $x^2 \in [1, 4]$ means $1 \leq |x| \leq 2$. Hence $q^{-1}([1, 4]) = [-2, -1] \cup [1, 2]$.

Finally, no real square lies in $[-5, -1]$, so $q^{-1}([-5, -1]) = \emptyset$. A preimage may be empty; that is not an error.

Warning. The symbol $f^{-1}(B)$ is defined for **every** function, invertible or not; it does not mean that an inverse function exists. For the same reason, pushing forward and pulling back need not undo each other. With $q(x) = x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$: for $B = [-1, 4]$ we get

$q^{-1}(B) = [-2, 2]$ and $q(q^{-1}(B)) = [0, 4] \neq B$; for $A = [0, 1]$ we get $q(A) = [0, 1]$ and $q^{-1}(q(A)) = [-1, 1] \neq A$.

What does survive is one inclusion in each direction.

Proposition 0.4.1 — Image and preimage inclusions

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$, $A \subseteq X$ and $B \subseteq Y$. Then

$$f(f^{-1}(B)) \subseteq B \quad \text{and} \quad A \subseteq f^{-1}(f(A)).$$

Proof. Let $y \in f(f^{-1}(B))$. By Definition 0.4.2, $y = f(x)$ for some $x \in f^{-1}(B)$, and $x \in f^{-1}(B)$ means $f(x) \in B$. Hence $y \in B$.

Let $a \in A$. Then $f(a) \in f(A)$ by definition of the image, so $a \in f^{-1}(f(A))$ by definition of the preimage. This proves both inclusions. ■

The warning shows both inclusions can be strict. In [Exercise \(C3: When images and preimages undo each other\)](#) you will find exactly which property of f turns each one into an equality.

0.4.3 Injective, surjective, bijective

Given $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and a target $y \in Y$, the most basic question is how many solutions the equation $f(x) = y$ has. There are two separate issues: whether there is **at least one** solution, and whether there is **at most one**. In linear algebra these become “does $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ have a solution?” and “is the solution unique?”, and they are answered by different tools. So the two halves deserve separate names.

Injective means no two inputs collide; surjective means every target is hit; bijective means both, so every equation $f(x) = y$ has exactly one solution.

Definition 0.4.3 — Injective, surjective, bijective

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ be a function.

- f is **injective** (one-to-one) if **for all** $x_1, x_2 \in X$, $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$ implies $x_1 = x_2$.
- f is **surjective** (onto) if **for every** $y \in Y$ **there exists** $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$.
Equivalently, $f(X) = Y$.
- f is **bijective** if it is both injective and surjective.

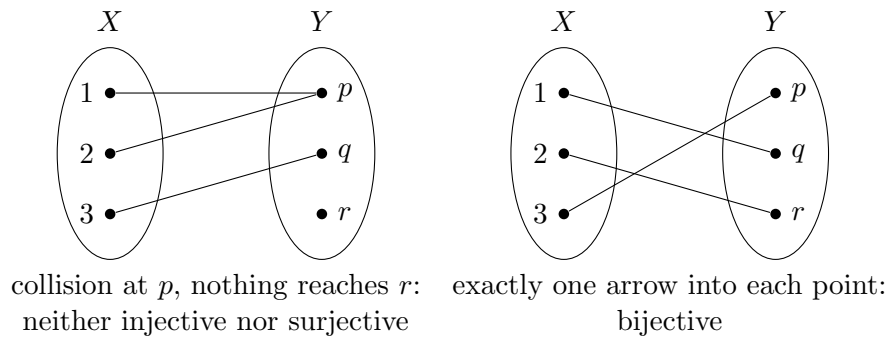
In words: injectivity says that if two inputs give the same output, they were the same input. Equivalently, by the contrapositive ([Theorem 0.1.1](#)), distinct inputs give distinct outputs. Surjectivity says the image of f fills the whole codomain. The quantifiers matter: in surjectivity the x is allowed to depend on y .

Negating these, as in [Example \(What “not injective” means\)](#) and [Example \(What “not surjective” means\)](#), tells us what a counterexample looks like. The map f is **not injective** when there

exist $x_1 \neq x_2$ with $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$: one collision is enough. It is **not surjective** when there exists $y \in Y$ that equals $f(x)$ for no $x \in X$: one missed target is enough.

The standard moves. To prove f injective, write “Suppose $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$ ” and work towards $x_1 = x_2$. To prove f surjective, write “Let $y \in Y$ ” and then produce an x , usually found backwards by solving $f(x) = y$ on scrap paper, and check forwards that $f(x) = y$.

The picture below shows maps between three-element sets, drawn as arrows. A collision is two arrows landing on one point; a missed target is a point with no arrow.



Example. (Deciding injectivity and surjectivity)

Determine which of the following functions are injective, surjective or bijective.

- (a) $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, f(x) = 3x - 5$.
- (b) $g: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}, g(n) = 2n$.
- (c) $s: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, s(x, y) = x + y$.
- (d) $\text{id}_X: X \rightarrow X, x \mapsto x$, for any set X .

Solution.

- (a) Bijective. Suppose $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$. Then $3x_1 - 5 = 3x_2 - 5$, so $3x_1 = 3x_2$, and dividing by $3 \neq 0$ gives $x_1 = x_2$. Hence f is injective. Let $y \in \mathbb{R}$. Solving $3x - 5 = y$ suggests $x = (y + 5)/3$, and indeed $f((y + 5)/3) = (y + 5) - 5 = y$. Hence f is surjective.
- (b) Injective, not surjective. Suppose $2n_1 = 2n_2$; then $n_1 = n_2$. But 1 is not hit: $2n = 1$ has no integer solution, since $2n$ is even. Note that the same formula $x \mapsto 2x$ on $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is surjective; the failure comes from the domain and codomain, not the formula.
- (c) Surjective, not injective. Let $t \in \mathbb{R}$; then $s(t, 0) = t$, so s is surjective. But $s(1, 0) = 1 = s(0, 1)$ while $(1, 0) \neq (0, 1)$, a collision, so s is not injective.
- (d) Bijective. If $\text{id}_X(x_1) = \text{id}_X(x_2)$ then $x_1 = x_2$ directly, and every $x \in X$ is hit by itself. This degenerate case is the model of a bijection and reappears as the identity function below.

The cleanest way to see that domain and codomain are part of the question is to keep the formula $x \mapsto x^2$ fixed and change only the sets. Write $[0, \infty)$ for the non-negative reals.

Function	Injective?	Surjective?
$\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$	no: $(-1)^2 = 1^2$	no: -1 is not a square
$\mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, \infty)$	no: $(-1)^2 = 1^2$	yes: $y = (\sqrt{y})^2$
$[0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$	yes	no: -1 is not a square
$[0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$	yes	yes

For the injective rows: if $x_1, x_2 \geq 0$ and $x_1^2 = x_2^2$, then $(x_1 - x_2)(x_1 + x_2) = 0$. Either $x_1 = x_2$, or $x_1 + x_2 = 0$, which for non-negative numbers forces $x_1 = x_2 = 0$. In both cases $x_1 = x_2$.

Read the table as a set of minimal changes. Shrinking the domain from $\mathbb{R}$ to $[0, \infty)$ removes the collision between -1 and 1 , so the injectivity clause now holds. Shrinking the codomain removes the missed targets, so the surjectivity clause now holds. The formula never changed.

Warning. Do not confuse injectivity with the statement “ $x_1 = x_2 \Rightarrow f(x_1) = f(x_2)$ ”. That implication is true for **every** function; it is the second clause of [Definition 0.4.1](#). Injectivity is its converse, “ $f(x_1) = f(x_2) \Rightarrow x_1 = x_2$ ”, and $x \mapsto x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$ satisfies the first but not the second.

Why these definitions. Surjectivity depends on the codomain, and injectivity on the domain, so neither is a property of a formula alone; this is why [Definition 0.4.1](#) insists on both sets. The names are descriptive: “in-jective” throws the domain *into* the codomain without collisions, and “sur-jective” (French *sur*, onto) lands *onto* all of it. In Chapter 3 we will meet a fast test for linear maps: a linear map is injective exactly when the only input sent to $\mathbf{0}$ is $\mathbf{0}$. That test is special to linear maps and fails for general functions, which is one reason the general definitions come first.

0.4.4 Composition

If the outputs of one function can be fed into another, we can run them in sequence. This is the operation that matrix multiplication will describe in Chapter 3.

Definition 0.4.4 — Composition

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: Y \rightarrow Z$ be functions. The **composition** $g \circ f: X \rightarrow Z$ is defined by

$$(g \circ f)(x) := g(f(x)) \quad \text{for every } x \in X.$$

Read $g \circ f$ as “ g after f ”: the function written on the **right** acts **first**. The definition needs the codomain of f to equal the domain of g , so that $g(f(x))$ makes sense.

Example. (Order matters)

- (a) Let $f, g: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be $f(x) = x + 3$ and $g(x) = 2x$. Compute $g \circ f$ and $f \circ g$.
- (b) Let $q: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, \infty)$, $q(x) = x^2$, and $r: [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $r(y) = \sqrt{y}$. Compute $r \circ q$ and $q \circ r$.

Solution.

- (a) $(g \circ f)(x) = g(x + 3) = 2x + 6$, while $(f \circ g)(x) = f(2x) = 2x + 3$. At $x = 0$ these are $6 \neq 3$, so $g \circ f \neq f \circ g$. Composition is not commutative, even when both orders make sense.
- (b) $r \circ q: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is $x \mapsto \sqrt{x^2} = |x|$. In the other order, $q \circ r: [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ is $y \mapsto (\sqrt{y})^2 = y$. So $q \circ r$ does nothing, while $r \circ q$ forgets the sign of x . The two orders do not even have the same domain. We will return to this pair when we discuss one-sided inverses.

Although the order matters, the grouping does not. This is what lets us write $h \circ g \circ f$ without brackets.

Theorem 0.4.2 — Associativity of composition

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$, $g: Y \rightarrow Z$ and $h: Z \rightarrow W$ be functions. Then $(h \circ g) \circ f = h \circ (g \circ f)$.

Proof. Both sides are functions $X \rightarrow W$. Let $x \in X$. By [Definition 0.4.4](#) applied twice on each side,

$$((h \circ g) \circ f)(x) = (h \circ g)(f(x)) = h(g(f(x))) = h((g \circ f)(x)) = (h \circ (g \circ f))(x).$$

Since the values agree at every x , the two functions are equal by [Definition 0.4.1](#). ■

Next, the properties of the previous subsection pass through composition.

Theorem 0.4.3 — Composition preserves injectivity and surjectivity

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: Y \rightarrow Z$ be functions.

- (a) If f and g are injective, then $g \circ f$ is injective.
- (b) If f and g are surjective, then $g \circ f$ is surjective.
- (c) If f and g are bijective, then $g \circ f$ is bijective.

Idea. For (a), start from a collision of $g \circ f$ and peel off one function at a time, outermost first: injectivity of g removes g , then injectivity of f removes f . For (b), run backwards: reach z from some y using g , then reach that y from some x using f .

Proof.

- (a) Suppose $(g \circ f)(x_1) = (g \circ f)(x_2)$, that is, $g(f(x_1)) = g(f(x_2))$. Since g is injective, $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$. Since f is injective, $x_1 = x_2$. Hence $g \circ f$ is injective.
- (b) Let $z \in Z$. Since g is surjective, there is $y \in Y$ with $g(y) = z$. Since f is surjective, there is $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$. Then $(g \circ f)(x) = g(y) = z$. Hence $g \circ f$ is surjective.
- (c) If f and g are bijective, then $g \circ f$ is injective by (a) and surjective by (b), so it is bijective.

The converse of (a) is false, but half of it survives, and that half is surprisingly useful. Suppose $g \circ f$ is injective. A collision of f would be a collision of $g \circ f$, so f must be injective; but g is only used on the image $f(X)$, so g may still collide outside it. The surjective case is dual.

Theorem 0.4.4 — Partial converse for compositions

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: Y \rightarrow Z$ be functions.

- (a) If $g \circ f$ is injective, then f is injective.
- (b) If $g \circ f$ is surjective, then g is surjective.

Proof.

- (a) Suppose $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$. Applying g to both sides gives $(g \circ f)(x_1) = (g \circ f)(x_2)$. Since $g \circ f$ is injective, $x_1 = x_2$. Hence f is injective.
- (b) Let $z \in Z$. Since $g \circ f$ is surjective, there is $x \in X$ with $g(f(x)) = z$. Put $y = f(x) \in Y$; then $g(y) = z$. Hence g is surjective.

Remark. The other halves really fail. Take $X = Z = \{1\}$, $Y = \{1, 2\}$, $f(1) = 1$ and $g(1) = g(2) = 1$. Then $g \circ f = \text{id}_{\{1\}}$ is bijective, yet g is not injective ($g(1) = g(2)$) and f is not surjective (nothing maps to 2).

0.4.5 Identity and one-sided inverses

The function that does nothing deserves a name, because “undoing f ” means “composing with f gives the function that does nothing”.

Definition 0.4.5 — Identity function

For a set X , the **identity function** on X is $\text{id}_X: X \rightarrow X$, $\text{id}_X(x) = x$.

For every $f: X \rightarrow Y$ we have $f \circ \text{id}_X = f$ and $\text{id}_Y \circ f = f$, since both sides send x to $f(x)$. Notice the subscripts: on the right of f the identity lives on the domain, on the left on the codomain.

Now look again at [Example \(Order matters\)](#) (b). There $q \circ r = \text{id}_{[0, \infty)}$, but $r \circ q = |\cdot| \neq \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}}$. So r undoes q from one side only. This one-sided behavior is common enough to need a word.

Definition 0.4.6 — Left and right inverses

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$. A function $g: Y \rightarrow X$ is a **left inverse** of f if $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$, and a **right inverse** of f if $f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$.

“Left” and “right” refer to where g is written in the composition. A left inverse recovers the input from the output: $g(f(x)) = x$. A right inverse picks, for each target y , an input that reaches it: $f(g(y)) = y$. In [Example \(Order matters\)](#) (b), r is a right inverse of q , and q is a left inverse of r . But r is **not** a left inverse of q , because $r(q(-1)) = 1 \neq -1$.

The descriptions “recovers the input” and “reaches every target” should remind you of injective and surjective. They are exactly that.

Theorem 0.4.5 — Left inverses and injectivity

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ with X **non-empty**. Then f has a left inverse if and only if f is injective.

Idea. $(\Rightarrow)$ is [Theorem 0.4.4](#) with $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$, which is injective. For $(\Leftarrow)$ we must define $g(y)$ for every $y \in Y$. If y is in the image, injectivity gives a **unique** x with $f(x) = y$, and $g(y)$ must be that x . If y is not in the image, the condition $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$ says nothing about $g(y)$, so we send y anywhere in X . That is where non-emptiness is used.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$. The identity id_X is injective, so f is injective by [Theorem 0.4.4](#) (a).

$(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose f is injective. Since $X \neq \emptyset$, we may fix some $x_0 \in X$. Define $g: Y \rightarrow X$ as follows. If $y \in f(X)$, there is some $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$, and this x is unique because f is injective; set $g(y) = x$. If $y \notin f(X)$, set $g(y) = x_0$. Every y receives exactly one value, so g is a function. For $x \in X$, the element $y = f(x)$ lies in $f(X)$, and the unique input sent to it is x , so $g(f(x)) = x$. Hence $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$, as claimed. ■

The hypothesis $X \neq \emptyset$ is not decoration. The empty function $\emptyset \rightarrow \{1\}$ is injective (there are no two inputs to collide), but there is no function $\{1\} \rightarrow \emptyset$ at all, since 1 would have nowhere to go.

Theorem 0.4.6 — Right inverses and surjectivity

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$. Then f has a right inverse if and only if f is surjective.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$. The identity id_Y is surjective, so f is surjective by [Theorem 0.4.4](#) (b).

$(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose f is surjective. For each $y \in Y$ the set $f^{-1}(\{y\})$ is non-empty, so we may choose one element of it and call it $g(y)$. This defines $g: Y \rightarrow X$ with $f(g(y)) = y$ for every $y \in Y$, that is, $f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$. ■

When Y is infinite, the step “choose one element from each of infinitely many non-empty sets at once” is an axiom of set theory, the **axiom of choice**; we use it freely and never mention it again in this chapter.

Unlike an inverse in the usual sense, one-sided inverses are rarely unique. For $q: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, \infty)$, $x \mapsto x^2$, both $y \mapsto \sqrt{y}$ and $y \mapsto -\sqrt{y}$ are right inverses: each picks one of the two square roots.

Quick check. Give a function $f: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ that has a left inverse but no right inverse.

Solution. Take $f(n) = n + 1$. It is injective, since $n_1 + 1 = n_2 + 1$ gives $n_1 = n_2$, so by [Theorem 0.4.5](#) it has a left inverse; explicitly, $g(m) = m - 1$ for $m \geq 1$ and $g(0) = 0$ satisfies $g(f(n)) = n$. It is not surjective, since $n + 1 = 0$ has no solution in $\mathbb{N}$. So by [Theorem 0.4.6](#) it has no right inverse.

0.4.6 Inverses

When a function has an inverse on both sides, the two one-sided inverses turn out to coincide, and we get the notion of inverse we know from e^x and $\ln x$.

Definition 0.4.7 — Inverse function

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$. A function $g: Y \rightarrow X$ is an **inverse** of f if

$$g \circ f = \text{id}_X \quad \text{and} \quad f \circ g = \text{id}_Y.$$

If f has an inverse, f is **invertible**.

Both conditions are needed: [Example \(Order matters\)](#) (b) shows a pair with one but not the other. The next theorem says which functions are invertible and that “the” inverse is justified.

Theorem 0.4.7 — Bijective if and only if invertible

A function $f: X \rightarrow Y$ is invertible if and only if it is bijective. Moreover, an inverse of f , when it exists, is **unique**; we denote it $f^{-1}: Y \rightarrow X$.

Idea. For $(\Leftarrow)$ one could combine the two one-sided theorems, but that route needs $X \neq \emptyset$ and a choice. A bijection makes both unnecessary: every y has **exactly one** preimage, so $f^{-1}(y)$ is forced. For uniqueness, the standard move is to assume two inverses g and h , and sandwich: $g = g \circ (f \circ h) = (g \circ f) \circ h = h$.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose g is an inverse of f . Since $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$ is injective, f is injective by [Theorem 0.4.4](#) (a). Since $f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$ is surjective, f is surjective by [Theorem 0.4.4](#) (b). Hence f is bijective.

$(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose f is bijective, and let $y \in Y$. Since f is surjective, some $x \in X$ has $f(x) = y$, and since f is injective, this x is unique. Define $g(y)$ to be this x . Then $f(g(y)) = y$ for every $y \in Y$, so $f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$. For $x \in X$, the unique input sent to $f(x)$ is x itself, so $g(f(x)) = x$, and $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$. Hence g is an inverse of f .

(Uniqueness) Suppose g and h are both inverses of f . Then

$$g = g \circ \text{id}_Y = g \circ (f \circ h) = (g \circ f) \circ h = \text{id}_X \circ h = h,$$

where the third equality is [Theorem 0.4.2](#). This proves the theorem. ■

The uniqueness computation used only $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$ and $f \circ h = \text{id}_Y$. So it proves more: **if f has a left inverse g and a right inverse h , then $g = h$** , and this common function is the inverse. The same sandwich will prove that a matrix has at most one inverse.

Warning. The notation f^{-1} now has two meanings. The preimage $f^{-1}(B)$ of a **set** $B \subseteq Y$ exists for every f . The inverse function f^{-1} , applied to an **element** $y \in Y$, exists only for bijective f . Writing $q^{-1}(4)$ for $q(x) = x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$ is meaningless, while $q^{-1}(\{4\}) = \{-2, 2\}$ is fine. When f is bijective the two agree: $f^{-1}(\{y\}) = \{f^{-1}(y)\}$.

Example. (Finding inverses)

For each function, decide whether it is invertible, and if so find its inverse.

- (a) $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, f(x) = 5 - 2x$.
- (b) $t: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2, t(x, y) = (y, x)$.
- (c) $g: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, g(x) = x^2$.
- (d) $h: [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty), h(x) = x^2$.

Solution.

- (a) Solving $5 - 2x = y$ gives $x = (5 - y)/2$. Put $k(y) = (5 - y)/2$. Check: $k(f(x)) = (5 - (5 - 2x))/2 = x$ and $f(k(y)) = 5 - (5 - y) = y$. So k is an inverse of f , and $f^{-1}(y) = (5 - y)/2$.
- (b) $t(t(x, y)) = t(y, x) = (x, y)$, so $t \circ t = \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}^2}$. Hence t is its own inverse: $t^{-1} = t$.
- (c) Not invertible. $g(-1) = g(1)$, so g is not injective, hence not bijective, and [Theorem 0.4.7](#) says it has no inverse.
- (d) Invertible. By the table in the previous subsection h is bijective, and the inverse is $h^{-1}(y) = \sqrt{y}$: indeed $\sqrt{x^2} = x$ for $x \geq 0$ and $(\sqrt{y})^2 = y$ for $y \geq 0$.

To undo two steps, undo the last one first. When you dress, the shirt goes on before the jacket; to undress, the jacket comes off first.

Theorem 0.4.8 — Inverse of a composition

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: Y \rightarrow Z$ be bijective. Then $g \circ f$ is bijective and

$$(g \circ f)^{-1} = f^{-1} \circ g^{-1}.$$

Proof. Using [Theorem 0.4.2](#) to regroup,

$$(f^{-1} \circ g^{-1}) \circ (g \circ f) = f^{-1} \circ (g^{-1} \circ g) \circ f = f^{-1} \circ \text{id}_Y \circ f = f^{-1} \circ f = \text{id}_X,$$

and in the same way $(g \circ f) \circ (f^{-1} \circ g^{-1}) = g \circ (f \circ f^{-1}) \circ g^{-1} = g \circ \text{id}_Y \circ g^{-1} = g \circ g^{-1} = \text{id}_Z$. Hence $f^{-1} \circ g^{-1}$ is an inverse of $g \circ f$. By [Theorem 0.4.7](#), $g \circ f$ is bijective and its unique inverse is $f^{-1} \circ g^{-1}$, as claimed. ■

The same reversal will appear for matrices as $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$, and for the same reason.

0.4.7 Maps between finite sets

For functions between two finite sets **of the same size**, one of the two conditions comes for free. This is the pigeonhole principle, and it is the ancestor of a move used constantly from Chapter 3 on: instead of checking both injectivity and surjectivity, count, and check only one.

We write $|X|$ for the number of elements of a finite set X . We use two counting facts about lists without proof: a list of n entries with a repeated entry contains at most $n - 1$ distinct elements, and a subset of a finite set Y with $|Y|$ elements is all of Y .

Theorem 0.4.9 — Injective iff surjective for finite sets of equal size

Let X and Y be finite sets with $|X| = |Y|$, and let $f: X \rightarrow Y$. Then f is injective if and only if f is surjective. In that case f is bijective.

Idea. List the elements of X as $x_1, \dots, x_n$; the image $f(X)$ is then listed by $f(x_1), \dots, f(x_n)$. Injective means this list has no repeats, so it has n distinct entries and must fill Y . Surjective means the list fills Y , which has n elements, so there is no room for a repeat.

Proof. Let $n = |X| = |Y|$, and write $X = \{x_1, \dots, x_n\}$ with the x_i distinct. By Definition 0.4.2, $f(X)$ consists of the entries of the list $f(x_1), \dots, f(x_n)$.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose f is injective. Since the x_i are distinct, the entries $f(x_1), \dots, f(x_n)$ are distinct. Hence $f(X)$ is a subset of Y with $n = |Y|$ elements, so $f(X) = Y$, and f is surjective.

($\Leftarrow$) We prove the contrapositive (Theorem 0.1.1). Suppose f is not injective. Then $f(x_i) = f(x_j)$ for some $i \neq j$, so the list $f(x_1), \dots, f(x_n)$ has a repeated entry and $f(X)$ has at most $n - 1$ elements. Hence $f(X) \neq Y$, and f is not surjective.

So if f is injective or surjective, the two directions show that it is both, that is, bijective. ■

For a finite set X , this applies to every $f: X \rightarrow X$: such a map is injective if and only if it is surjective. In Chapter 3 the same shape of statement returns for linear maps $V \rightarrow V$ on a finite-dimensional space, with dimension playing the role of the number of elements.

Warning. The theorem needs finiteness. The map $g: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$, $g(n) = 2n$, is injective but misses every odd number, so it is not surjective, even though domain and codomain are the same set. Infinite sets have room for an injection into a proper part of themselves.

0.4.8 Exercises

0.4.8.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) State what it means for $f: X \rightarrow Y$ to be injective, and what it means to be surjective.
- (b) True or false: the functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $x \mapsto x^3$ and $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $x \mapsto x \cdot x \cdot x$ are equal. Give a reason.
- (c) True or false: if $g \circ f$ is injective, then g is injective. Give a reason.
- (d) Write down the first line of a proof that a function f is injective, and the first line of a proof that it is surjective.
- (e) True or false: the preimage $f^{-1}(B)$ is defined only when f is bijective.
- (f) True or false: every injective function $\{1, 2, 3\} \rightarrow \{1, 2, 3\}$ is bijective. Name the result you use.

Solution.

- (a) f is injective if for all $x_1, x_2 \in X$, $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$ implies $x_1 = x_2$. It is surjective if for every $y \in Y$ there exists $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$.
- (b) True. They have the same domain and codomain, and $x^3 = x \cdot x \cdot x$ for every real x . Equality of functions is about values, not formulas.
- (c) False. In the remark after [Theorem 0.4.4](#), $g \circ f = \text{id}_{\{1\}}$ is injective but $g(1) = g(2)$. Only f is forced to be injective.
- (d) Injective: “Suppose $x_1, x_2 \in X$ satisfy $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$.” Surjective: “Let $y \in Y$.”
- (e) False. $f^{-1}(B) = \{x \in X : f(x) \in B\}$ makes sense for every function; see [Definition 0.4.2](#) and the warning after it.
- (f) True, by [Theorem 0.4.9](#): domain and codomain are finite with the same number of elements, so an injective map is surjective, hence bijective.

0.4.8.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Injective or surjective?.

Determine whether each function is injective, and whether it is surjective. Justify your answers.

- (a) $f: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$, $f(n) = 3n + 1$.
- (b) $g: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$, $g(x, y) = (x + y, x - y)$.
- (c) $h: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$, $h(n) = \lfloor n/2 \rfloor$, the largest integer not exceeding $n/2$.
- (d) $p: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$, $p(t) = (t, t^2)$.

Solution.

- (a) Injective, not surjective. Suppose $3n_1 + 1 = 3n_2 + 1$. Then $3n_1 = 3n_2$, so $n_1 = n_2$. But 0 is not hit: $3n + 1 = 0$ would give $n = -1/3 \notin \mathbb{Z}$.
- (b) Bijective. Suppose $g(x_1, y_1) = g(x_2, y_2)$. Then $x_1 + y_1 = x_2 + y_2$ and $x_1 - y_1 = x_2 - y_2$. Adding the two equations gives $2x_1 = 2x_2$, and subtracting gives $2y_1 = 2y_2$, so $(x_1, y_1) = (x_2, y_2)$. Hence g is injective. Let $(u, v) \in \mathbb{R}^2$. Then

$$g\left(\frac{u+v}{2}, \frac{u-v}{2}\right) = \left(\frac{u+v}{2} + \frac{u-v}{2}, \frac{u+v}{2} - \frac{u-v}{2}\right) = (u, v).$$

Hence g is surjective.

- (c) Surjective, not injective. Let $m \in \mathbb{N}$. Then $h(2m) = \lfloor m \rfloor = m$, so h is surjective. But $h(0) = 0 = h(1)$, a collision, so h is not injective.
- (d) Injective, not surjective. Suppose $(t_1, t_1^2) = (t_2, t_2^2)$. Comparing first coordinates gives $t_1 = t_2$. But $(0, 1)$ is not hit: $p(t) = (0, 1)$ forces $t = 0$ and then $t^2 = 0 \neq 1$.

Exercise B2: Inverses.

- (a) Show that $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $f(x) = 7 - 4x$, is invertible and find f^{-1} .
- (b) Let $D = \mathbb{R} \setminus \{1\}$ and define $k: D \rightarrow D$ by $k(x) = \frac{x+1}{x-1}$. Show that k really takes values in D , and that $k \circ k = \text{id}_D$. Hence deduce that k is bijective and find k^{-1} .
- (c) With g as in B1(b), find g^{-1} . Hence find the inverse of $g \circ g$ without computing $g \circ g$ first.

Solution.

- (a) Put $e(y) = (7 - y)/4$. Then $e(f(x)) = (7 - (7 - 4x))/4 = x$ and $f(e(y)) = 7 - (7 - y) = y$. So e is an inverse of f , and by [Theorem 0.4.7](#) f is invertible with $f^{-1}(y) = (7 - y)/4$.
- (b) For $x \in D$ the denominator $x - 1$ is non-zero, so $k(x)$ is a real number. If $k(x) = 1$, then $x + 1 = x - 1$, that is, $1 = -1$, which is false. Hence $k(x) \in D$. Next, for $x \in D$,

$$k(k(x)) = \frac{\frac{x+1}{x-1} + 1}{\frac{x+1}{x-1} - 1} = \frac{(x+1) + (x-1)}{(x+1) - (x-1)} = \frac{2x}{2} = x,$$

where the second equality multiplies numerator and denominator by $x - 1 \neq 0$. So $k \circ k = \text{id}_D$. This says k is an inverse of itself, so k is invertible, hence bijective by [Theorem 0.4.7](#), and $k^{-1} = k$.

- (c) The solution of B1(b) shows that $e(u, v) = (\frac{u+v}{2}, \frac{u-v}{2})$ satisfies $g \circ e = \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}^2}$. Also $e(g(x, y)) = e(x + y, x - y) = (\frac{2x}{2}, \frac{2y}{2}) = (x, y)$, so $e \circ g = \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}^2}$. Hence $g^{-1} = e$. By [Theorem 0.4.8](#),

$$(g \circ g)^{-1} = g^{-1} \circ g^{-1}, \quad g^{-1}(g^{-1}(u, v)) = g^{-1}\left(\frac{u+v}{2}, \frac{u-v}{2}\right) = \left(\frac{u}{2}, \frac{v}{2}\right).$$

(As a check, $g(g(x, y)) = g(x + y, x - y) = (2x, 2y)$, which $(u, v) \mapsto (u/2, v/2)$ indeed undoes.)

Exercise B3: Images of unions and intersections.

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $A_1, A_2 \subseteq X$.

- (a) Prove that $f(A_1 \cup A_2) = f(A_1) \cup f(A_2)$.
- (b) Prove that $f(A_1 \cap A_2) \subseteq f(A_1) \cap f(A_2)$.
- (c) Using $q(x) = x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$, give an example where the inclusion in (b) is strict.

Solution.

- (a) We use double inclusion ([Theorem 0.3.1](#)).
- ($\subseteq$) Let $y \in f(A_1 \cup A_2)$. Then $y = f(a)$ for some $a \in A_1 \cup A_2$. If $a \in A_1$, then $y \in f(A_1)$; if $a \in A_2$, then $y \in f(A_2)$. In either case $y \in f(A_1) \cup f(A_2)$.
- ($\supseteq$) Let $y \in f(A_1) \cup f(A_2)$. If $y \in f(A_1)$, then $y = f(a)$ for some $a \in A_1 \subseteq A_1 \cup A_2$, so $y \in f(A_1 \cup A_2)$. The case $y \in f(A_2)$ is the same with the roles of A_1 and A_2 swapped. This proves the equality.
- (b) Let $y \in f(A_1 \cap A_2)$. Then $y = f(a)$ for some $a \in A_1 \cap A_2$. Since $a \in A_1$, $y \in f(A_1)$, and since $a \in A_2$, $y \in f(A_2)$. Hence $y \in f(A_1) \cap f(A_2)$.
- (c) Take $A_1 = \{-1\}$ and $A_2 = \{1\}$. Then $A_1 \cap A_2 = \emptyset$, so $q(A_1 \cap A_2) = \emptyset$, while $q(A_1) \cap q(A_2) = \{1\} \cap \{1\} = \{1\}$. The inclusion is strict. The collision $q(-1) = q(1)$ is what goes wrong; for an injective f , equality holds in (b).

0.4.8.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Left inverses are not unique.

- (a) Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ be injective but **not** surjective, with X having at least two elements. Prove that f has at least two different left inverses.
- (b) Find two different left inverses of $f: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$, $f(n) = n + 1$.
- (c) Explain why a bijective function has exactly one left inverse.

Hint for (a): look at the proof of [Theorem 0.4.5](#) and ask where it made a free choice.

Solution.

- (a) Since f is not surjective, there is $y_0 \in Y \setminus f(X)$. Since X has at least two elements, there are $x_0 \neq x_1$ in X . As in the proof of [Theorem 0.4.5](#), for $y \in f(X)$ let $\bar{y}$ be the unique $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$. Define $g_0, g_1: Y \rightarrow X$ by $g_i(y) = \bar{y}$ for $y \in f(X)$, and $g_i(y) = x_i$ for $y \notin f(X)$. The proof of [Theorem 0.4.5](#) shows that each g_i is a left inverse of f , since $g_i(f(x)) = x$ uses only the values on $f(X)$. But $g_0(y_0) = x_0 \neq x_1 = g_1(y_0)$, so $g_0 \neq g_1$.
- (b) The only element missed by f is 0. Define $g_0(m) = m - 1$ for $m \geq 1$ and $g_0(0) = 0$; define $g_1(m) = m - 1$ for $m \geq 1$ and $g_1(0) = 5$. Both satisfy $g_i(n + 1) = n$ for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$, and $g_0(0) \neq g_1(0)$.
- (c) Let f be bijective, and let g be any left inverse. By [Theorem 0.4.7](#), f has an inverse f^{-1} , which in particular is a right inverse. By the observation following that theorem, a left inverse and a right inverse of the same function are equal, so $g = f^{-1}$. Hence every left inverse equals f^{-1} . Conversely, f^{-1} is itself a left inverse, since $f^{-1} \circ f = \text{id}_X$. So f has exactly one left inverse.

Exercise C2: Self-maps of finite and infinite sets.

- (a) Let X be a finite set and $f: X \rightarrow X$ injective. Prove that f is bijective.
- (b) Show that (a) fails for $X = \mathbb{N}$: give an injective $f: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ that is not bijective.
- (c) Give a surjective $h: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ that is not bijective.
- (d) Let X be finite and $f, g: X \rightarrow X$ with $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$. Prove that $f \circ g = \text{id}_X$ as well.

Hint for (d): first show that f is bijective.

Solution.

- (a) The domain and codomain are the same finite set, so $|X| = |X|$. By [Theorem 0.4.9](#), the injective map f is bijective.
- (b) $f(n) = n + 1$ is injective, since $n_1 + 1 = n_2 + 1$ gives $n_1 = n_2$, but 0 is not of the form $n + 1$ with $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Hence f is not surjective, so not bijective.
- (c) Take $h(n) = \lfloor n/2 \rfloor$. By B1(c) it is surjective but not injective.
- (d) Since $g \circ f = \text{id}_X$ is injective, f is injective by [Theorem 0.4.4](#) (a). By (a), f is bijective, so it has an inverse f^{-1} by [Theorem 0.4.7](#). Then

$$g = g \circ \text{id}_X = g \circ (f \circ f^{-1}) = (g \circ f) \circ f^{-1} = \text{id}_X \circ f^{-1} = f^{-1},$$

using [Theorem 0.4.2](#). Hence $f \circ g = f \circ f^{-1} = \text{id}_X$, as claimed. (For $X = \mathbb{N}$ this fails: with $f(n) = n + 1$ and g_0 from C1(b), $g_0 \circ f = \text{id}_{\mathbb{N}}$ but $f(g_0(0)) = 1 \neq 0$. The matrix version of (d), “ $AB = I$ implies $BA = I$ for square matrices”, is proved in Chapter 2.)

Exercise C3: When images and preimages undo each other.

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$.

- (a) Prove that $f(f^{-1}(B)) = B$ for **every** $B \subseteq Y$ if and only if f is surjective.
- (b) Prove that $f^{-1}(f(A)) = A$ for **every** $A \subseteq X$ if and only if f is injective.

Hint: for each direction you need only one well-chosen set; try a one-element set.

Solution.

- (a) $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose the equality holds for every B , and let $y \in Y$. Taking $B = \{y\}$ gives $f(f^{-1}(\{y\})) = \{y\}$, so $y \in f(f^{-1}(\{y\}))$. Hence $y = f(x)$ for some x , and f is surjective.
- $(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose f is surjective, and let $B \subseteq Y$. The inclusion $f(f^{-1}(B)) \subseteq B$ is [Proposition 0.4.1](#). For the reverse, let $y \in B$. Since f is surjective, $y = f(x)$ for some $x \in X$. Then $f(x) \in B$, so $x \in f^{-1}(B)$, and hence $y = f(x) \in f(f^{-1}(B))$. By [Theorem 0.3.1](#), $f(f^{-1}(B)) = B$.
- (b) $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose the equality holds for every A , and suppose $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$. Taking $A = \{x_1\}$ gives $f^{-1}(\{f(x_1)\}) = \{x_1\}$. Since $f(x_2) = f(x_1)$, we have $x_2 \in f^{-1}(\{f(x_1)\}) = \{x_1\}$, so $x_2 = x_1$. Hence f is injective.
- $(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose f is injective, and let $A \subseteq X$. The inclusion $A \subseteq f^{-1}(f(A))$ is [Proposition 0.4.1](#). For the reverse, let $x \in f^{-1}(f(A))$. Then $f(x) \in f(A)$, so $f(x) = f(a)$ for some $a \in A$. Since f is injective, $x = a \in A$. By [Theorem 0.3.1](#), $f^{-1}(f(A)) = A$.

0.5 Relations, Equivalence Classes and Quotients

Mathematics constantly declares different-looking things to be “the same”: $\frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2}{4}$ are the same number, 14:00 and 2 p.m. are the same time, and in Chapter 3 two vectors will count as the same when their difference lies in a fixed subspace. This section makes “the same, for present purposes” precise. The notion is an equivalence relation. Gluing equivalent things together produces a new set, the quotient, and the one real danger of working with quotients is defining a function on them that secretly depends on a choice. We will learn to check for that.

0.5.1 Relations

Before we can say what a good notion of sameness is, we need a word for any way of comparing two elements of a set, good or bad. Examples are $\leq$ on numbers, “divides” on integers, and “has the same birthday as” on people. What such a comparison really amounts to is the list of pairs that are related, and a list of pairs is a subset of the Cartesian product (Definition 0.3.10).

Definition 0.5.1 — Relation

A **relation** on a set X is a subset $R \subseteq X \times X$. When $(x, y) \in R$ we say x **is related to** y and write $x R y$, or $x \sim y$ when the relation is fixed.

Example. (Relations)

- (a) On $\mathbb{Z}$: $a \leq b$. The pairs $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 2)$ belong to the relation, $(2, 1)$ does not.
- (b) On $\mathbb{Z}$: $a \mid b$ (“ a divides b ”), meaning $b = ka$ for some $k \in \mathbb{Z}$. So $3 \mid 12$ and $3 \mid 0$, but $3 \nmid 5$.
- (c) On $\mathbb{R}$: $x \sim y$ if $x^2 + y^2 = 1$. As a subset of $\mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R} = \mathbb{R}^2$ this relation is the unit circle, so a relation can literally be a picture.
- (d) On any set X : the **empty relation** $R = \emptyset$, in which nothing is related to anything, and the **full relation** $R = X \times X$, in which everything is related to everything. These two extremes are useful test cases for every property below.

Every subset of $X \times X$ is a relation, so the definition has no non-examples. The interesting question is which properties a given relation has.

0.5.2 Equivalence relations

What must any reasonable notion of “ x is the same as y ” satisfy? Think of “has the same birthday as”. Everyone has the same birthday as themselves. If you share a birthday with me, I share one with you. If x shares a birthday with y , and y with z , then x shares one with z . Those three features are exactly what we ask for.

An equivalence relation is a way of declaring elements “the same” that behaves like equality:

everything is the same as itself, sameness goes both ways, and it can be chained.

Definition 0.5.2 — Equivalence relation

A relation $\sim$ on a set X is an **equivalence relation** if it satisfies the following three conditions.

- (E1) **Reflexive:** $x \sim x$ for every $x \in X$.
- (E2) **Symmetric:** for all $x, y \in X$, if $x \sim y$ then $y \sim x$.
- (E3) **Transitive:** for all $x, y, z \in X$, if $x \sim y$ and $y \sim z$ then $x \sim z$.

In words: (E1) asks every single element to be related to itself, with no exceptions. (E2) says the relation cannot be one-way. (E3) says a chain of two links can be shortened to one link, and so, by applying it repeatedly, can any finite chain. When $x \sim y$ we say x and y are **equivalent**.

The standard move for checking an equivalence relation is to write three short paragraphs, one per condition, each starting from its hypothesis (“Let $x \in X$.”, “Suppose $x \sim y$.”, “Suppose $x \sim y$ and $y \sim z$.”).

Example. (Equivalence relations)

Show that each of the following is an equivalence relation.

- (a) Equality on any set X : $x \sim y$ if $x = y$.
- (b) **Congruence modulo n** on $\mathbb{Z}$, for a fixed integer $n \geq 1$: $a \equiv b \pmod{n}$ if $n \mid a - b$.
- (c) “Same length” on the set S of finite strings of the letters a, b : $u \sim v$ if u and v have the same number of letters.
- (d) “Same value”: for a function $f: X \rightarrow Y$, put $x \sim_f x'$ if $f(x) = f(x')$.
- (e) Fractions: on $P = \mathbb{Z} \times (\mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\})$, put $(a, b) \sim (c, d)$ if $ad = bc$.

Solution.

- (a) Every x equals itself; $x = y$ gives $y = x$; $x = y$ and $y = z$ give $x = z$. Equality is the degenerate case: it is the equivalence relation that identifies nothing new, and the model the other examples imitate.
- (b) *Reflexive.* Let $a \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then $a - a = 0 = 0 \cdot n$, so $n \mid a - a$. *Symmetric.* Suppose $a - b = kn$ with $k \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then $b - a = (-k)n$, so $n \mid b - a$. *Transitive.* Suppose $a - b = kn$ and $b - c = \ell n$ with $k, \ell \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then $a - c = (a - b) + (b - c) = (k + \ell)n$, so $n \mid a - c$. For $n = 2$ this is “same parity”: $a \equiv b \pmod{2}$ says a and b are both even or both odd.
- (c) This is the special case of (d) in which $f: S \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ sends a string to its length, so it follows from (d), whose proof does not use (c).
- (d) *Reflexive:* $f(x) = f(x)$. *Symmetric:* $f(x) = f(x')$ gives $f(x') = f(x)$. *Transitive:* $f(x) = f(x')$ and $f(x') = f(x'')$ give $f(x) = f(x'')$. Each condition is inherited from the same property of equality in Y . Many equivalence relations are of this form: “same distance from the origin” on $\mathbb{R}^2$ is $\sim_f$ for $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$.
- (e) *Reflexive:* $ab = ba$, so $(a, b) \sim (a, b)$. *Symmetric:* $ad = bc$ gives $cb = da$, which says $(c, d) \sim (a, b)$. *Transitive:* suppose $ad = bc$ and $cf = de$. Multiplying the first

equation by f and the second by b gives $adf = bcf = bde$. Hence $d(af - be) = 0$. Since $d \neq 0$, we get $af = be$, that is, $(a, b) \sim (e, f)$. Transitivity is exactly where second entries must be non-zero: with $d = 0$ allowed, $(1, 1) \sim (0, 0) \sim (2, 1)$ but $(1, 1) \not\sim (2, 1)$.

Minimal changes to these examples show that each condition can fail on its own.

Example. (Relations that are not equivalence relations)

Decide which of (E1)–(E3) each relation satisfies.

- (a) $\leq$ on $\mathbb{Z}$.
- (b) On $\mathbb{R}$: $x \sim y$ if $|x - y| \leq 1$.
- (c) On $\mathbb{R}$: $x \sim y$ if $xy > 0$.

Solution.

- (a) Change “=” to “ $\leq$ ”. Reflexivity survives ($a \leq a$) and so does transitivity ($a \leq b \leq c$ gives $a \leq c$). **Symmetry fails:** $1 \leq 2$ but $2 \not\leq 1$.
- (b) Change “ $|x - y| = 0$ ” (which is equality) to “ $|x - y| \leq 1$ ”. Reflexivity survives, since $|x - x| = 0$, and so does symmetry, since $|y - x| = |x - y|$. **Transitivity fails:** $0 \sim 1$ and $1 \sim 2$, but $|0 - 2| = 2 > 1$. “Close to” cannot be chained; many small steps make a big one.
- (c) Symmetry holds, since $yx = xy$. Transitivity holds: if $xy > 0$ and $yz > 0$, then $xy^2z > 0$, and since $y^2 > 0$ this gives $xz > 0$. **Reflexivity fails, at exactly one point:** $0 \cdot 0 = 0$, so $0 \not\sim 0$. On $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$ the same rule is an equivalence relation (“same sign”).

Warning. A tempting argument claims that (E1) follows from (E2) and (E3): “if $x \sim y$, then $y \sim x$ by symmetry, so $x \sim x$ by transitivity.” The gap is the word “if”. The argument needs some y with $x \sim y$, and there may be none. In [Example \(Relations that are not equivalence relations\)](#) (c), the element 0 is related to nothing, which is exactly why it escapes. Reflexivity must always be checked on its own.

Quick check. On $\mathbb{Z}$, define $a \sim b$ if $ab \geq 0$. Is $\sim$ an equivalence relation?

Solution. No. It is reflexive ($a^2 \geq 0$) and symmetric, but not transitive: $1 \sim 0$ and $0 \sim -1$ since both products are 0, yet $1 \cdot (-1) = -1 < 0$, so $1 \not\sim -1$. Compare [Example \(Relations that are not equivalence relations\)](#) (c): moving from $>$ to $\geq$ repairs reflexivity at 0 but lets 0 link the positives to the negatives.

Why these three conditions. They are precisely what the next subsection needs. Reflexivity will guarantee that every element lies in its own class, so no class is empty and nothing is lost. Symmetry and transitivity together will guarantee that two classes are either identical or disjoint. Drop any one of them and the picture of X cut cleanly into pieces falls apart, as the non-examples above show.

Remark. Two equivalence relations on matrices are central later: *row equivalence*, which records that one matrix can be reached from another by row operations, and *similarity*, which records that two square matrices describe the same linear map in different

coordinates. Both are introduced once matrices are available, later in this chapter, and studied in Chapters 2 and 3.

0.5.3 Equivalence classes and partitions

Once we have decided which elements count as the same, it is natural to collect everything that is the same as a given element into one set.

Definition 0.5.3 — Equivalence class

Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on X , and let $x \in X$. The **equivalence class** of x is

$$[x] := \{y \in X : y \sim x\}.$$

Any element of $[x]$ is called a **representative** of the class.

The word “representative” is chosen carefully. A class is one set, but it usually has many names: $[x] = [y]$ is possible with $x \neq y$.

Example. (Equivalence classes)

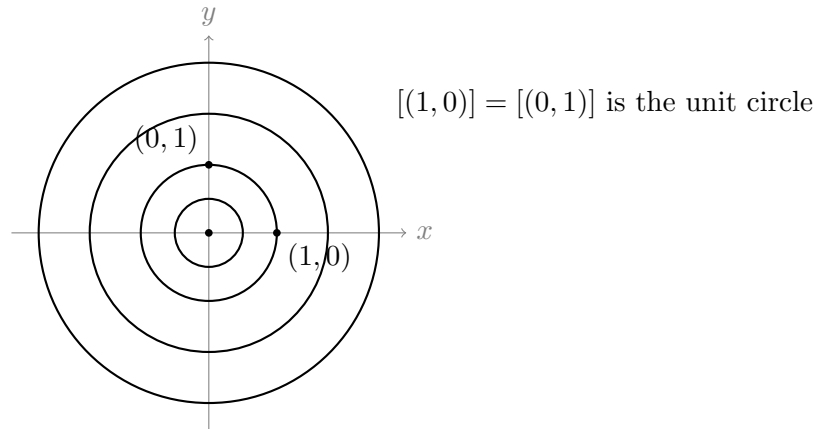
- (a) For equality on X , $[x] = \{x\}$. Every class has one element.
- (b) For congruence modulo 3 on $\mathbb{Z}$:

$$[0] = \{\dots, -6, -3, 0, 3, 6, \dots\}, \quad [1] = \{\dots, -5, -2, 1, 4, 7, \dots\}, \quad [2] = \{\dots, -4, -1, 2, 5, 8, \dots\}.$$

Here $[0] = [3] = [-3]$ and $[2] = [-1]$: one class, many names.

- (c) For “same length” on strings of a, b , the class of ab is $\{aa, ab, ba, bb\}$, and the class of the empty string contains only the empty string.
- (d) For the full relation $X \times X$ on a non-empty set X , there is a single class, $[x] = X$.
- (e) For “same distance from the origin” on $\mathbb{R}^2$, the class of (x, y) is the circle of radius $\sqrt{x^2 + y^2}$ centered at the origin. The class of the origin is the one-point set $\{(0, 0)\}$.

In example (e), the classes look like this. Each circle is one class; the origin on its own is another.



The picture suggests two facts: every point lies on exactly one circle, and two different circles never meet. Both hold for every equivalence relation, and the proof is where the three conditions do their work.

Lemma 0.5.1 — Classes are equal or disjoint

Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on X , and let $a, b \in X$.

- (a) $[a] = [b]$ if and only if $a \sim b$.
- (b) Either $[a] = [b]$ or $[a] \cap [b] = \emptyset$.

Proof.

- (a) $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $[a] = [b]$. By reflexivity $a \sim a$, so $a \in [a] = [b]$, which means $a \sim b$.
 $(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose $a \sim b$. Let $x \in [a]$, so $x \sim a$. Since $a \sim b$, transitivity gives $x \sim b$, so $x \in [b]$. Hence $[a] \subseteq [b]$. By symmetry $b \sim a$, and swapping the roles of a and b in the argument gives $[b] \subseteq [a]$. By [Theorem 0.3.1](#), $[a] = [b]$.
- (b) Suppose $[a] \cap [b] \neq \emptyset$, and let $c \in [a] \cap [b]$. Then $c \sim a$ and $c \sim b$. By symmetry $a \sim c$, and by transitivity $a \sim b$. By (a), $[a] = [b]$.

■

Part (a) is the working form of the lemma: to show two classes are equal, show one representative is equivalent to the other. The picture of non-overlapping pieces that cover everything has its own name.

Definition 0.5.4 — Partition

A **partition** of a set X is a collection $\mathcal{P}$ of subsets of X , called **blocks**, such that:

- (P1) every block is **non-empty**;
- (P2) **distinct** blocks are disjoint: if $B, B' \in \mathcal{P}$ and $B \neq B'$, then $B \cap B' = \emptyset$;
- (P3) the blocks cover X : every $x \in X$ lies in some block.

By (P2) and (P3), every element of X lies in **exactly one** block. For example, $\{\{1, 3\}, \{2\}\}$ is a partition of $\{1, 2, 3\}$, while $\{\{1, 2\}, \{2, 3\}\}$ is not, because the distinct blocks share 2 and (P2)

fails.

Quick check. Is $\{\{1, 2, 3\}, \emptyset\}$ a partition of $\{1, 2, 3\}$? Is $\{\{1\}, \{2\}\}$?

Solution. Neither. The first contains the empty block, so (P1) fails, even though (P2) and (P3) hold. The second does not cover 3, so (P3) fails.

The main theorem says that equivalence relations and partitions are two descriptions of the same thing: “which elements are the same” and “how X is cut into pieces”.

Theorem 0.5.2 — Equivalence relations and partitions

Let X be a set.

- (a) If $\sim$ is an equivalence relation on X , then the set of its equivalence classes is a partition of X .
- (b) If $\mathcal{P}$ is a partition of X , then the relation “ $x \sim_{\mathcal{P}} y$ if x and y lie in the same block” is an equivalence relation on X , and its equivalence classes are exactly the blocks of $\mathcal{P}$.
- (c) The two constructions undo each other: starting from $\sim$, the relation defined in (b) by the partition in (a) is $\sim$ again.

Idea. Part (a) is the lemma plus reflexivity: (P1) and (P3) come from $x \in [x]$, and (P2) is Lemma 0.5.1 (b). Part (b) runs the other way, and each block condition pays for one equivalence condition: covering gives reflexivity, and disjointness gives transitivity, because a middle element y can lie in only one block. Part (c) is Lemma 0.5.1 (a) read as a sentence about blocks.

Proof.

- (a) Let $\mathcal{P} = \{[x] : x \in X\}$. For every $x \in X$, reflexivity gives $x \in [x]$. Hence every class is non-empty, which is (P1), and every element lies in some class, which is (P3). If $[a] \neq [b]$, then $[a] \cap [b] = \emptyset$ by Lemma 0.5.1 (b), which is (P2). Hence $\mathcal{P}$ is a partition of X .
- (b) *Reflexive.* Let $x \in X$. By (P3), x lies in some block, so $x \sim_{\mathcal{P}} x$. *Symmetric.* “ x and y lie in a common block” does not depend on the order of x and y . *Transitive.* Suppose $x, y \in B$ and $y, z \in B'$ for blocks B, B' . Then $y \in B \cap B'$, so $B = B'$ by (P2). Hence $x, z \in B$, and $x \sim_{\mathcal{P}} z$.
Now let $B \in \mathcal{P}$ and $x \in B$; we show $[x] = B$, where the class is taken for $\sim_{\mathcal{P}}$. ($\subseteq$) If $y \in [x]$, then y and x lie in a common block B' ; since $x \in B \cap B'$, (P2) gives $B' = B$, so $y \in B$. ($\supseteq$) If $y \in B$, then y and x both lie in B , so $y \sim_{\mathcal{P}} x$ and $y \in [x]$. Hence $[x] = B$ by Theorem 0.3.1. Every class $[x]$ is therefore the block containing x , which exists by (P3); and every block B is a class, namely $[x]$ for any $x \in B$, which exists by (P1). So the classes are exactly the blocks.
- (c) Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation, and let $\approx$ be the relation built by (b) from the classes of $\sim$. If $x \sim y$, then $x, y \in [y]$, so $x \approx y$. Conversely, if $x \approx y$, then $x, y \in [z]$ for some z ; thus $x \sim z$ and $y \sim z$, and symmetry and transitivity give $x \sim y$. Hence $\approx$ and $\sim$ are the same relation. This proves the theorem. ■

So whenever you meet an equivalence relation, you may think of it as a way of cutting the set into non-overlapping pieces, and vice versa. Exercise C2 uses this to count equivalence relations by counting partitions instead.

0.5.4 Quotient sets

Now we take the decisive step: treat each piece as a single new element. The time of day is the classic case. Hours counted from some starting moment are integers, but a clock only records the class of the hour modulo 12.

Definition 0.5.5 — Quotient set

Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on X . The **quotient set** of X by $\sim$ is the set of all equivalence classes,

$$X/\sim := \{[x] : x \in X\}.$$

The function $\pi: X \rightarrow X/\sim$, $\pi(x) = [x]$, is the **quotient map**.

The elements of $X/\sim$ are sets, but once the quotient is formed we stop looking inside them and treat each class as a single point. The quotient map is surjective, since every class is $[x] = \pi(x)$ for some x . By Lemma 0.5.1 (a), $\pi(x) = \pi(y)$ exactly when $x \sim y$: the quotient map makes equivalent elements literally equal.

Example. (Quotient sets)

- (a) For an integer $n \geq 1$, the quotient of $\mathbb{Z}$ by congruence modulo n is written $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$. Show that it has exactly n elements, namely $[0], [1], \dots, [n-1]$.
- (b) Describe the quotient of the set S of strings in a, b by “same length”, and of $\mathbb{R}^2$ by “same distance from the origin”.

Solution.

- (a) Let $a \in \mathbb{Z}$. By division with remainder (Exercise C2: Division with remainder), $a = qn + r$ with $q, r \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $0 \leq r < n$. Then $a - r = qn$, so $a \equiv r \pmod{n}$, and $[a] = [r]$ by Lemma 0.5.1 (a). Hence every class is one of $[0], \dots, [n-1]$. These are distinct: if $0 \leq r < s < n$, then $0 < s - r < n$, so $s - r$ is not a multiple of n , hence $r \not\equiv s$ and $[r] \neq [s]$ by Lemma 0.5.1 (a). So $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} = \{[0], [1], \dots, [n-1]\}$ has exactly n elements.
- (b) Two strings are identified exactly when they have the same length, so there is one class for each length $k \in \mathbb{N}$: the set of all 2^k strings of length k . Similarly, $\mathbb{R}^2$ modulo “same distance” has one class for each radius $r \in [0, \infty)$: the circle of radius r , or the origin when $r = 0$. In both cases the quotient is “the same as” the set of values $\mathbb{N}$ or $[0, \infty)$, and the next subsection makes that precise.

0.5.5 Functions on a quotient

We want to compute with classes. On a clock, “three hours after 11 o’clock” is 2 o’clock, which is really addition on $\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}$. The natural way to define such an operation is through representatives: to add two classes, pick an element of each, add them, and take the class of the result. The danger is that a class has many representatives, and different choices might give different answers. When they do, the “definition” does not define a function at all.

Here is that failure in its simplest form.

Example. (The numerator is not well defined)

Let $P = \mathbb{Z} \times (\mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\})$ with $(a, b) \sim (c, d)$ if $ad = bc$, as in [Example \(Equivalence relations\)](#) (e). Its classes are the rational numbers: the class of (a, b) is the fraction a/b , with all its other names. Is “ $[(a, b)] \mapsto a$ ” a function $P/\sim \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$?

Solution. No. Since $1 \cdot 4 = 2 \cdot 2$, we have $(1, 2) \sim (2, 4)$, so $[(1, 2)] = [(2, 4)]$ by [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a). The rule assigns to this one class the value 1 through one name and 2 through the other. So it does not assign **exactly one** value to each element of the domain, and [Definition 0.4.1](#) fails. “The numerator of $\frac{1}{2}$ ” is a statement about how a fraction is written, not about the number.

By contrast, “ $[(a, b)] \mapsto 1$ if $a = 0$, and 0 otherwise” is fine. If $(a, b) \sim (c, d)$ and $a = 0$, then $bc = ad = 0$, so $c = 0$ because $b \neq 0$. By symmetry, $c = 0$ forces $a = 0$. So equivalent pairs always get the same value.

The contrast in that example is the whole story, and the following theorem turns it into a test. A function f on X passes to the quotient exactly when it cannot tell equivalent elements apart.

Theorem 0.5.3 — Functions on a quotient

Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on X , let $\pi: X \rightarrow X/\sim$ be the quotient map, and let $f: X \rightarrow Y$ be a function.

- (a) If $f(a) = f(b)$ **whenever** $a \sim b$, then there is **exactly one** function $\bar{f}: X/\sim \rightarrow Y$ with $\bar{f}([x]) = f(x)$ for every $x \in X$, that is, $\bar{f} \circ \pi = f$.
- (b) Conversely, if some function $\bar{f}: X/\sim \rightarrow Y$ satisfies $\bar{f} \circ \pi = f$, then $f(a) = f(b)$ whenever $a \sim b$.

Idea. The formula $\bar{f}([x]) = f(x)$ leaves no freedom: if $\bar{f}$ exists, this is its value. The only question is whether the formula makes sense, since the class $C = [x]$ may also be called $[x']$. So look at **all** the values f takes on C at once, the image $f(C)$. A function needs exactly one value; $f(C)$ is non-empty because C is, and has at most one element because all elements of C are equivalent.

Proof.

- (a) Let $C \in X/\sim$. By [Definition 0.5.5](#), $C = [x]$ for some $x \in X$, so C is non-empty, and hence the image $f(C)$ is non-empty. If $x', x'' \in C$, then $[x'] = C = [x'']$ by [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a) applied to $x' \sim x$ and $x'' \sim x$; hence $x' \sim x''$ by the same lemma,

and $f(x') = f(x'')$ by hypothesis. Therefore $f(C)$ has exactly one element, and we define $\bar{f}(C)$ to be that element. This assigns exactly one value to each class, so $\bar{f}$ is a function. For $x \in X$, we have $x \in [x]$ by reflexivity, so $\bar{f}([x]) \in f([x]) = \{f(x)\}$, that is, $\bar{f}([x]) = f(x)$.

For uniqueness, suppose $g: X/\sim \rightarrow Y$ also satisfies $g([x]) = f(x)$ for every x . Every class is $[x]$ for some x , and there $g([x]) = f(x) = \bar{f}([x])$. Hence $g = \bar{f}$.

- (b) Suppose $\bar{f} \circ \pi = f$ and $a \sim b$. By [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a), $[a] = [b]$. Hence $f(a) = \bar{f}([a]) = \bar{f}([b]) = f(b)$, as claimed. ■

In practice we rarely name f and $\bar{f}$ separately. We write down a rule “ $[x] \mapsto (\text{expression in } x)$ ” and check that equivalent representatives give the same value. That check is what people mean when they say a function is **well defined**. For example, “same value” in [Example \(Equivalence relations\)](#) (d) satisfies the hypothesis by its very definition, so every $f: X \rightarrow Y$ induces a function $X/\sim_f \rightarrow Y$. This $\bar{f}$ is injective: $\bar{f}([x]) = \bar{f}([x'])$ means $f(x) = f(x')$, which is $x \sim_f x'$, so $[x] = [x']$. This makes precise the remark that $\mathbb{R}^2$ modulo “same distance” is “the same as” $[0, \infty)$: the induced map $[(x, y)] \mapsto \sqrt{x^2 + y^2}$ is a bijection onto $[0, \infty)$.

The most important application in this chapter is arithmetic modulo n . The operation takes two classes, so we check both representatives at once.

Example. (Addition modulo n is well defined)

Fix an integer $n \geq 1$. Show that the rule $[a] + [b] := [a + b]$ defines a function $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$. Then compute $[3] + [2]$ in $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$.

Solution. We must show that the value $[a + b]$ depends only on the classes $[a]$ and $[b]$, not on the representatives a and b . Suppose $[a] = [a']$ and $[b] = [b']$. By [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a), $a \equiv a' \pmod{n}$ and $b \equiv b' \pmod{n}$, so $a - a' = kn$ and $b - b' = \ell n$ for some $k, \ell \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then

$$(a + b) - (a' + b') = (a - a') + (b - b') = (k + \ell)n,$$

so $a + b \equiv a' + b' \pmod{n}$, and $[a + b] = [a' + b']$ by the same lemma. Hence every choice of representatives gives the same class, and the rule defines a function.

In $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, $[3] + [2] = [5] = [1]$, since $5 - 1 = 4$. Choosing other names gives the same answer, as it must: $[7] + [-2] = [5] = [1]$.

This is the same principle as [Theorem 0.5.3](#), applied to a function of two variables. The same check ([Exercise \(B3: Multiplication modulo \$n\$ \)](#)) shows multiplication $[a][b] := [ab]$ is well defined. With these operations, $\mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z}$ for a prime p will become our first finite field later in this chapter, and the identical pattern, now with “ $\mathbf{v} \sim \mathbf{w}$ if $\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w} \in U$ ”, will build quotient vector spaces in Chapter 3.

Warning. A rule written in terms of a representative is not automatically a function on classes. Define it, then check it. For example, “ $[a] \mapsto a$ ” from $\mathbb{Z}/5\mathbb{Z}$ to $\mathbb{Z}$ is not a function, because $[0] = [5]$ would be sent to both 0 and 5. The check is not a formality: forgetting it is the most common error in any argument that uses quotients.

Quick check. Which of these rules defines a function? (i) $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$, $[a]_6 \mapsto [a]_3$.
(ii) $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, $[a]_6 \mapsto [a]_4$. Here the subscript records the modulus.

Solution.

- (i) Yes. If $[a]_6 = [a']_6$, then $a - a' = 6k = 3(2k)$, so $[a]_3 = [a']_3$.
- (ii) No. $[0]_6 = [6]_6$, but $[0]_4 \neq [6]_4 = [2]_4$, since $6 - 0 = 6$ is not a multiple of 4.
The first works because $3 \mid 6$; the second fails because $4 \nmid 6$.

0.5.6 Exercises

0.5.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) State the three conditions for a relation $\sim$ on X to be an equivalence relation.
- (b) True or false: a symmetric and transitive relation is automatically reflexive. Give a reason.
- (c) True or false: if two equivalence classes $[a]$ and $[b]$ have an element in common, then $a \sim b$.
- (d) You want to define a function on $X/\sim$ by a formula in a representative x . What must you check?
- (e) How many elements does $\mathbb{Z}/5\mathbb{Z}$ have? Is $[12] = [-3]$ in $\mathbb{Z}/5\mathbb{Z}$?

Solution.

- (a) Reflexive: $x \sim x$ for every $x \in X$. Symmetric: $x \sim y$ implies $y \sim x$. Transitive: $x \sim y$ and $y \sim z$ imply $x \sim z$.
- (b) False. On $\mathbb{R}$, $x \sim y$ if $xy > 0$ is symmetric and transitive, but $0 \not\sim 0$; see [Example \(Relations that are not equivalence relations\)](#) (c) and the warning after it.
- (c) True. By [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (b) the classes are equal, and by part (a) of the same lemma $a \sim b$.
- (d) That equivalent representatives give the same value: if $x \sim x'$, the formula gives the same result for x and x' . By [Theorem 0.5.3](#) this is exactly what is needed.
- (e) Five, by [Example \(Quotient sets\)](#) (a). Yes: $12 - (-3) = 15 = 3 \cdot 5$, so $12 \equiv -3 \pmod{5}$, and both classes equal $[2]$.

0.5.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Which are equivalence relations?.

Determine which of the following are equivalence relations. For those that are, describe the equivalence classes. For those that are not, name a condition that fails with a specific witness.

- (a) On $\mathbb{Z}$: $a \sim b$ if $a + b$ is even.

- (b) On $\mathbb{Z}$: $a \sim b$ if $a - b$ is odd.
- (c) On $\mathbb{R}$: $x \sim y$ if $x - y \in \mathbb{Z}$.
- (d) On $\{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$: $m \sim n$ if m and n have a common divisor greater than 1.
- (e) On the set of all subsets of $\{1, 2, 3\}$: $A \sim B$ if A and B have the same number of elements.

Solution.

- (a) Equivalence relation. *Reflexive*: $a + a = 2a$ is even. *Symmetric*: $b + a = a + b$. *Transitive*: if $a + b$ and $b + c$ are even, then $a + c = (a + b) + (b + c) - 2b$ is a sum of even integers, hence even. There are two classes: the even integers and the odd integers. (In fact $a + b$ is even exactly when $a - b = (a + b) - 2b$ is even, so this is congruence modulo 2.)
- (b) Not an equivalence relation. Reflexivity fails: $0 - 0 = 0$ is even, so $0 \not\sim 0$. (Transitivity also fails: $0 \sim 1$ and $1 \sim 2$, but $0 - 2$ is even.)
- (c) Equivalence relation. *Reflexive*: $x - x = 0 \in \mathbb{Z}$. *Symmetric*: if $x - y = k \in \mathbb{Z}$, then $y - x = -k \in \mathbb{Z}$. *Transitive*: if $x - y = k$ and $y - z = \ell$ with $k, \ell \in \mathbb{Z}$, then $x - z = k + \ell \in \mathbb{Z}$. The class of x is $\{x + k : k \in \mathbb{Z}\}$, the points at integer distance from x in either direction. Each class contains exactly one number in $[0, 1)$, namely $x - \lfloor x \rfloor$.
- (d) Not an equivalence relation. Reflexivity fails at 1: the only positive divisor of 1 is 1. Transitivity also fails: $2 \sim 6$ (common divisor 2) and $6 \sim 3$ (common divisor 3), but 2 and 3 have no common divisor greater than 1.
- (e) Equivalence relation, since it is “same value” (Example (Equivalence relations) (d)) for the function $A \mapsto |A|$. There are four classes: $\{\emptyset\}$; $\{\{1\}, \{2\}, \{3\}\}$; $\{\{1, 2\}, \{1, 3\}, \{2, 3\}\}$; $\{\{1, 2, 3\}\}$.

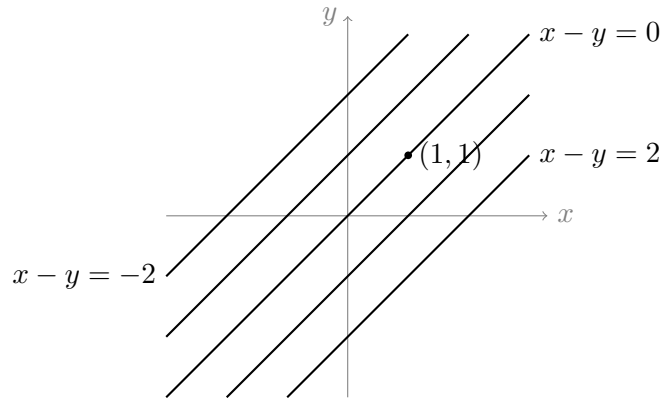
Exercise B2: Parallel lines as classes.

On $\mathbb{R}^2$, define $(x, y) \sim (x', y')$ if $x - y = x' - y'$.

- (a) Prove that $\sim$ is an equivalence relation.
- (b) Describe the class of (x_0, y_0) geometrically, and draw several classes.
- (c) Show that $[(x, y)] \mapsto x - y$ is a well-defined function $\mathbb{R}^2/\sim \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, and that it is a bijection.

Solution.

- (a) This is “same value” for $f: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $f(x, y) = x - y$, so it is an equivalence relation by Example (Equivalence relations) (d). Directly: $x - y = x - y$; equality of the numbers $x - y$ and $x' - y'$ is symmetric and transitive.
- (b) Put $c = x_0 - y_0$. Then $[(x_0, y_0)] = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x - y = c\} = \{(x, y) : y = x - c\}$, the line of slope 1 through (x_0, y_0) , which meets the y -axis at $(0, -c)$. The classes are all the lines parallel to $y = x$: each point of the plane lies on exactly one of them, as Theorem 0.5.2 predicts.



- (c) Let $f(x, y) = x - y$. If $(x, y) \sim (x', y')$, then $f(x, y) = f(x', y')$ by the definition of $\sim$. By [Theorem 0.5.3](#) (a), there is a function $\bar{f}: \mathbb{R}^2/\sim \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with $\bar{f}([(x, y)]) = x - y$.

Injective. Suppose $\bar{f}([(x, y)]) = \bar{f}([(x', y')])$. Then $x - y = x' - y'$, so $(x, y) \sim (x', y')$, and $[(x, y)] = [(x', y')]$ by [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a).

Surjective. Let $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $\bar{f}([(c, 0)]) = c - 0 = c$.

Hence $\bar{f}$ is a bijection: the set of parallel lines is labeled, one to one, by the real number c .

Exercise B3: Multiplication modulo n .

Fix an integer $n \geq 1$.

- Prove that $[a][b] := [ab]$ is a well-defined operation on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$.
- Write out the multiplication table of $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, using the representatives 0, 1, 2, 3.
- Hence find a class $[a] \neq [0]$ in $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ with $[a][a] = [0]$.

Solution.

- (a) Suppose $[a] = [a']$ and $[b] = [b']$. By [Lemma 0.5.1](#) (a), $a - a' = kn$ and $b - b' = \ell n$ for some $k, \ell \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then

$$ab - a'b' = ab - a'b + a'b - a'b' = (a - a')b + a'(b - b') = (kb + a'\ell)n,$$

so $ab \equiv a'b' \pmod{n}$ and $[ab] = [a'b']$ by the same lemma. Hence the value does not depend on the representatives, and the operation is well defined.

- (b) Reducing each product modulo 4:

$\cdot$	[0]	[1]	[2]	[3]
[0]	[0]	[0]	[0]	[0]
[1]	[0]	[1]	[2]	[3]
[2]	[0]	[2]	[0]	[2]
[3]	[0]	[3]	[2]	[1]

For instance $[2][3] = [6] = [2]$ and $[3][3] = [9] = [1]$.

- (c) From the table, $[2][2] = [4] = [0]$, while $[2] \neq [0]$ since $4 \nmid 2$. So a product of non-zero classes can be zero in $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, something that never happens with ordinary numbers.

0.5.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Squares and powers modulo n .

- (a) Let $n \geq 1$. Prove that $[x] \mapsto [x^2]$ is a well-defined function $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$.
 (b) On $\mathbb{N}$, let $\equiv_3$ be congruence modulo 3. Show that the rule $[x] \mapsto [2^x]_3$ does **not** define a function from $\mathbb{N}/\equiv_3$ to $\mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$.
 (c) On $\mathbb{N}$, let $\equiv_2$ be congruence modulo 2. Prove that $[x] \mapsto [2^x]_3$ **does** define a function from $\mathbb{N}/\equiv_2$ to $\mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$.

Hint for (c): compute 2^2 modulo 3.

Solution.

- (a) Suppose $[x] = [x']$. By [Exercise \(B3: Multiplication modulo \$n\$ \)](#) (a) with $a = b = x$ and $a' = b' = x'$, we get $[x][x] = [x'][x']$, that is, $[x^2] = [x'^2]$. Hence the value depends only on the class, and the function is well defined.
 (b) In $\mathbb{N}$, $0 \equiv 3 \pmod{3}$, so $[0] = [3]$. The rule sends this class to $[2^0]_3 = [1]_3$ through the representative 0, and to $[2^3]_3 = [8]_3 = [2]_3$ through the representative 3. Since $8 - 1 = 7$ is not a multiple of 3, $[1]_3 \neq [2]_3$. So one class receives two different values, and the rule is not a function.
 (c) By [Theorem 0.5.3](#) (a), it suffices to show that $x \equiv x' \pmod{2}$ implies $2^x \equiv 2^{x'} \pmod{3}$. By symmetry of both relations we may assume $x \leq x'$, so $x' = x + 2k$ with $k \in \mathbb{N}$. First, $4^k \equiv 1 \pmod{3}$ for every $k \in \mathbb{N}$, by induction on k ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)): $4^0 = 1$, and if $4^k - 1 = 3m$, then $4^{k+1} - 1 = 4(4^k - 1) + 3 = 3(4m + 1)$. Hence

$$2^{x'} - 2^x = 2^x(4^k - 1)$$

is a multiple of 3, so $[2^{x'}]_3 = [2^x]_3$, as claimed. The difference between (b) and (c) is that the powers of 2 modulo 3 repeat with period 2, and 3 is not a multiple of 2.

Exercise C2: Counting equivalence relations.

- (a) List all partitions of $\{1, 2, 3\}$.
 (b) Hence deduce that there are exactly 5 equivalence relations on $\{1, 2, 3\}$.
 (c) Write the equivalence relation corresponding to the partition $\{\{1, 3\}, \{2\}\}$ as a subset of $\{1, 2, 3\} \times \{1, 2, 3\}$.

Solution.

- (a) Sort by the number of blocks. One block: $\{\{1, 2, 3\}\}$. Two blocks: one block is a single element and the other the remaining pair, giving $\{\{1\}, \{2, 3\}\}$, $\{\{2\}, \{1, 3\}\}$, $\{\{3\}, \{1, 2\}\}$. Three blocks: $\{\{1\}, \{2\}, \{3\}\}$. Four or more non-empty disjoint blocks are impossible in a three-element set. That is 5 partitions.

- (b) By [Theorem 0.5.2](#) (a), every equivalence relation gives a partition, its set of classes. By [Theorem 0.5.2](#) (c), the relation can be recovered from that partition, so distinct equivalence relations give distinct partitions. By [Theorem 0.5.2](#) (b), every partition arises this way. Hence equivalence relations on $\{1, 2, 3\}$ correspond one to one with partitions, and there are exactly 5 of them.
- (c) Two elements are related exactly when they lie in a common block:

$$\{(1, 1), (2, 2), (3, 3), (1, 3), (3, 1)\}.$$

Exercise C3: Intersections and unions of equivalence relations.

Let R_1 and R_2 be equivalence relations on a set X , viewed as subsets of $X \times X$.

- (a) Prove that $R_1 \cap R_2$ is an equivalence relation on X .
- (b) Show by an example that $R_1 \cup R_2$ need not be an equivalence relation. Which condition fails?
- (c) For congruence modulo 2 and modulo 3 on $\mathbb{Z}$, identify $R_1 \cap R_2$ as a familiar relation.

Hint for (b): try congruence modulo 2 and modulo 3 on $\mathbb{Z}$.

Solution.

- (a) *Reflexive.* Let $x \in X$. Then $(x, x) \in R_1$ and $(x, x) \in R_2$, since both are reflexive, so $(x, x) \in R_1 \cap R_2$. *Symmetric.* Suppose $(x, y) \in R_1 \cap R_2$. Since R_1 and R_2 are symmetric, $(y, x) \in R_1$ and $(y, x) \in R_2$, so $(y, x) \in R_1 \cap R_2$. *Transitive.* Suppose $(x, y), (y, z) \in R_1 \cap R_2$. Both pairs lie in R_1 , which is transitive, so $(x, z) \in R_1$; likewise $(x, z) \in R_2$. Hence $(x, z) \in R_1 \cap R_2$.
- (b) Let R_1 be congruence modulo 2 and R_2 congruence modulo 3 on $\mathbb{Z}$. The union is still reflexive and symmetric, since each of R_1, R_2 is. But transitivity fails: $(0, 2) \in R_1$ since $2 \mid 2$, and $(2, 5) \in R_2$ since $3 \mid 3$, yet $(0, 5)$ lies in neither, because 5 is not a multiple of 2 or of 3.
- (c) $(a, b) \in R_1 \cap R_2$ means $2 \mid a - b$ and $3 \mid a - b$. This holds exactly when $6 \mid a - b$. Indeed, if $a - b = 2k$ and $a - b = 3m$ with $k, m \in \mathbb{Z}$, then $a - b = 3(a - b) - 2(a - b) = 3 \cdot 2k - 2 \cdot 3m = 6(k - m)$. Conversely, if $a - b = 6j$, then $a - b = 2(3j) = 3(2j)$. So $R_1 \cap R_2$ is congruence modulo 6. The same phenomenon, where intersections behave well and unions do not, will reappear for subspaces in Chapter 1.

0.6 Complex Numbers

The equation $x^2 + 1 = 0$ has no real solution, because the square of a real number is never negative. For most of school mathematics this gap is harmless. In linear algebra it is not: later in the book we meet real matrices, such as a rotation of the plane, whose most useful data cannot be found among the real numbers. This section builds the complex numbers, the number system that closes the gap, and collects the facts about them that the rest of the book uses.

0.6.1 The complex numbers as pairs of reals

The quick way to introduce complex numbers is to say “invent a symbol i with $i^2 = -1$ and compute as usual”. That raises a fair worry. How do we know that such a symbol does not lead to a contradiction, the way “invent a number z with $0 \cdot z = 1$ ” does? The answer is to build the new numbers out of objects we already trust: pairs of real numbers.

Here is the recurring expression that suggests the definition. If we pretend $i^2 = -1$ and expand, we get

$$(a + bi)(c + di) = ac + adi + bci + bd i^2 = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i.$$

So a “number $a + bi$ ” is really the pair (a, b) , and the product should be the pair $(ac - bd, ad + bc)$. We take this formula as the definition, so nothing is pretended.

A complex number is a pair of real numbers, multiplied as if $i^2 = -1$.

Definition 0.6.1 — Complex Numbers

The set of **complex numbers** is $\mathbb{C} := \mathbb{R}^2 = \{(a, b) : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\}$, with addition and multiplication defined **for every** $(a, b), (c, d) \in \mathbb{C}$ by

$$(a, b) + (c, d) := (a + c, b + d), \quad (a, b)(c, d) := (ac - bd, ad + bc).$$

We write a for $(a, 0)$ and i for $(0, 1)$, so that $(a, b) = a + bi$. For $z = a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, the **real part** of z is $\operatorname{Re} z := a$ and the **imaginary part** of z is $\operatorname{Im} z := b$.

In words: addition is coordinate by coordinate, as for points of the plane. Multiplication is the formula found by expanding. The last sentence is a naming convention: the real number a is identified with the point $(a, 0)$ on the horizontal axis, and i is the point one unit up. Note that the imaginary part b is a **real** number; it is not bi .

Two things need checking before this convention is safe.

- **The notation $a + bi$ is honest.** By the definitions, $a + bi = (a, 0) + (b, 0)(0, 1) = (a, 0) + (0, b) = (a, b)$. Two complex numbers are equal exactly when they are equal as pairs, so $a + bi = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$ means $a = c$ **and** $b = d$. This is how we “compare real and imaginary parts”.
- **Identifying a with $(a, 0)$ does not change real arithmetic.** We have $(a, 0) + (c, 0) = (a + c, 0)$ and $(a, 0)(c, 0) = (ac - 0, 0 + 0) = (ac, 0)$. So adding or multiplying two real numbers inside $\mathbb{C}$ gives the same answer as in $\mathbb{R}$.

With these in place, the equation that motivated everything is now a computation: $i^2 = (0, 1)(0, 1) = (0 \cdot 0 - 1 \cdot 1, 0 \cdot 1 + 1 \cdot 0) = (-1, 0) = -1$.

Example. (First Computations in $\mathbb{C}$)

Compute $(2 + 3i)(1 - i)$, the powers $i^0, i^1, \dots, i^7$, and the product $(a + bi)(a - bi)$ for real a, b .

Solution. By the multiplication rule with $a = 2, b = 3, c = 1, d = -1$,

$$(2 + 3i)(1 - i) = (2 \cdot 1 - 3 \cdot (-1)) + (2 \cdot (-1) + 3 \cdot 1)i = 5 + i.$$

For the powers, $i^0 = 1$, $i^1 = i$, $i^2 = -1$, $i^3 = i^2 \cdot i = -i$ and $i^4 = (-i)i = -i^2 = 1$. From then on the pattern repeats with period 4: $i^5 = i$, $i^6 = -1$, $i^7 = -i$.

Finally, $(a + bi)(a - bi) = (a^2 - b(-b)) + (a(-b) + ba)i = a^2 + b^2$. This product is a real number, and it is **non-negative**. We will meet it again as $|z|^2$.

The degenerate case deserves a look too. A real number $a = a + 0i$ is a complex number whose imaginary part is zero, and the number $0 = 0 + 0i$ is the only complex number with both parts zero. Every computation with real numbers is also a computation in $\mathbb{C}$, by the second check above.

A non-example by minimal change. Change one sign in the multiplication rule: define $(a, b) * (c, d) := (ac + bd, ad + bc)$, which is what expanding gives if we pretend $j^2 = +1$ instead. Addition is unchanged, and this product is still commutative and has $(1, 0)$ as a unit. But

$$(1, 1) * (1, -1) = (1 - 1, -1 + 1) = (0, 0),$$

so two non-zero elements multiply to zero. Division also breaks down: $(1, 1) * (c, d) = (c + d, c + d)$ can never equal the unit $(1, 0)$, because that would need $c + d = 1$ and $c + d = 0$ at once. So the non-zero element $(1, 1)$ has no inverse. The single sign in $ac - bd$ is what makes the complex numbers a number system in which we can divide, as we are about to see.

Quick check. Using the definition, compute i^{10} and $(1 + i)^2$. Is $\text{Im}(3 - 4i)$ equal to $-4i$?

Solution. Since the powers of i repeat with period 4 and $10 = 8 + 2$, we get $i^{10} = i^2 = -1$. Next, $(1 + i)^2 = (1 - 1) + (1 + 1)i = 2i$. No: the imaginary part is the real number -4 , not $-4i$.

The usual rules of arithmetic hold. Before computing freely, we should confirm that rearranging, regrouping and expanding brackets are legal in $\mathbb{C}$. The definition does not promise this; it has to be checked.

Proposition 0.6.1 — Arithmetic Laws in $\mathbb{C}$

For all $z, w, u \in \mathbb{C}$:

- (a) $z + w = w + z$ and $zw = wz$;
- (b) $(z + w) + u = z + (w + u)$ and $(zw)u = z(wu)$;
- (c) $z(w + u) = zw + zu$;
- (d) $z + 0 = z$, $z \cdot 1 = z$, and $z + (-z) = 0$, where $-(a + bi) := (-a) + (-b)i$.

Idea. Every law reduces to the corresponding law for real numbers once both sides are written as pairs. Addition is coordinate by coordinate, so its laws are immediate. For multiplication the only real work is associativity: expand both sides and see that they produce the same four terms in each coordinate.

Proof. Let $z = a + bi$, $w = c + di$ and $u = e + fi$ with $a, b, c, d, e, f \in \mathbb{R}$. Since addition acts coordinate by coordinate, the laws for addition in (a), (b) and (d) follow from the same laws in $\mathbb{R}$, applied to each coordinate.

- (a) By definition $zw = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i$ and $wz = (ca - db) + (cb + da)i$. These are equal because real multiplication and addition are commutative.

(b) Expanding with the definition twice gives

$$(zw)u = ((ac - bd)e - (ad + bc)f) + ((ac - bd)f + (ad + bc)e)i$$

and

$$z(wu) = (a(ce - df) - b(cf + de)) + (a(cf + de) + b(ce - df))i.$$

Multiplying out, both real parts equal $ace - adf - bcf - bde$ and both imaginary parts equal $acf + ade + bce - bdf$. Hence $(zw)u = z(wu)$.

(c) We have $w + u = (c + e) + (d + f)i$, so

$$z(w+u) = (a(c+e) - b(d+f)) + (a(d+f) + b(c+e))i = ((ac - bd) + (ae - bf)) + ((ad + bc) + (af + be))i,$$

which is $zw + zu$ by the definitions of the product and the sum.

(d) With $1 = 1 + 0i$, we get $z \cdot 1 = (a \cdot 1 - b \cdot 0) + (a \cdot 0 + b \cdot 1)i = a + bi = z$. Also $z + (-z) = (a - a) + (b - b)i = 0$. This proves the proposition. ■

From now on we compute in $\mathbb{C}$ exactly as in $\mathbb{R}$: expand brackets, collect terms, and replace i^2 by -1 . The proposition is what makes that habit legitimate.

0.6.2 Conjugate and modulus

Division is still missing. To divide by $3 + 4i$ we want some number to multiply by that lands in the real numbers, where division is familiar. The computation $(a + bi)(a - bi) = a^2 + b^2$ in [Example \(First Computations in \$\mathbb{C}\$ \)](#) shows exactly which number does the job. Both ingredients get names.

Conjugating reflects a point in the real axis; the modulus is its distance from the origin.

Definition 0.6.2 — Conjugate and Modulus

Let $z = a + bi \in \mathbb{C}$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. The **complex conjugate** of z is $\bar{z} := a - bi$. The **modulus** (or absolute value) of z is the real number $|z| := \sqrt{a^2 + b^2} \geq 0$, the non-negative square root.

In words: the conjugate keeps the real part and flips the sign of the imaginary part. The modulus is the length of the segment from 0 to the point (a, b) , by Pythagoras. For a real number $a = a + 0i$, we get $\bar{a} = a$ and $|a| = \sqrt{a^2}$, the usual absolute value, so the notation does not clash with its real meaning. For example, $\overline{3 + 4i} = 3 - 4i$, $|3 + 4i| = 5$, $\bar{i} = -i$ and $|i| = 1$.

The following rules are used constantly, in this section and much later for complex inner products.

Theorem 0.6.2 — Properties of Conjugation and Modulus

For all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$:

(a) $\overline{z + w} = \bar{z} + \bar{w}$ and $\bar{\bar{z}} = z$;

- (b) $\overline{zw} = \overline{z}\overline{w}$;
- (c) $z\overline{z} = |z|^2$ and $z + \overline{z} = 2\operatorname{Re} z$;
- (d) $|zw| = |z||w|$ and $|\overline{z}| = |z|$.

Idea. Parts (a)–(c) are direct computations with real and imaginary parts. For (d), expanding $|zw|$ directly is legitimate but messy. It is cleaner to square: by (c) a squared modulus is a product with a conjugate, and (b) lets the conjugate split across the product.

Proof. Let $z = a + bi$ and $w = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$.

- (a) We have $\overline{z + w} = (a + c) - (b + d)i = (a - bi) + (c - di) = \overline{z} + \overline{w}$, and $\overline{\overline{z}} = \overline{a - bi} = a + bi = z$.
- (b) Since $zw = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i$, we get $\overline{zw} = (ac - bd) - (ad + bc)i$. On the other hand,

$$\overline{z}\overline{w} = (a - bi)(c - di) = (ac - (-b)(-d)) + (a(-d) + (-b)c)i = (ac - bd) - (ad + bc)i.$$
- (c) By the computation in [Example \(First Computations in \$\mathbb{C}\$ \)](#), $z\overline{z} = a^2 + b^2 = |z|^2$. Also $z + \overline{z} = 2a = 2\operatorname{Re} z$.
- (d) By (c), then (b), then [Proposition 0.6.1](#) to reorder the four factors,

$$|zw|^2 = (zw)\overline{zw} = zw\overline{z}\overline{w} = (z\overline{z})(w\overline{w}) = |z|^2|w|^2.$$

Both $|zw|$ and $|z||w|$ are non-negative real numbers with the same square, so they are equal. Finally $|\overline{z}| = \sqrt{a^2 + (-b)^2} = |z|$. This proves the theorem. ■

The first payoff is division. If $z \neq 0$, then $|z|^2 = a^2 + b^2$ is a **strictly** positive real number, so we may divide by it.

Proposition 0.6.3 — Inverse of a Complex Number

Let $z \in \mathbb{C}$ with $z \neq 0$. Then $w := \frac{1}{|z|^2} \overline{z}$ satisfies $zw = 1$. We write z^{-1} or $\frac{1}{z}$ for this w .

Proof. Write $z = a + bi$. Since $z \neq 0$, at least one of a, b is non-zero, so $|z|^2 = a^2 + b^2 > 0$. By [Proposition 0.6.1](#) and [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (c),

$$zw = \frac{1}{|z|^2} (z\overline{z}) = \frac{1}{|z|^2} |z|^2 = 1,$$

as claimed. ■

In practice, “multiply top and bottom by the conjugate”. For instance

$$\frac{1}{3 + 4i} = \frac{3 - 4i}{(3 + 4i)(3 - 4i)} = \frac{3 - 4i}{25}, \quad \frac{5 + i}{1 - i} = \frac{(5 + i)(1 + i)}{(1 - i)(1 + i)} = \frac{4 + 6i}{2} = 2 + 3i,$$

which agrees with $(2 + 3i)(1 - i) = 5 + i$ from [Example \(First Computations in \$\mathbb{C}\$ \)](#). Only one inverse exists; this is a special case of a general fact about fields proved in the next section.

The triangle inequality. The modulus measures distance: $|z - w|$ is the distance between the points z and w of the plane. The side of a triangle is never longer than the other two sides together, and this is the algebraic form of that fact.

Theorem 0.6.4 — Triangle Inequality

For all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$,

$$|z + w| \leq |z| + |w|.$$

Idea. Moduli are square roots, which are awkward to add. Both sides are non-negative, so it suffices to compare their squares. Expand $|z + w|^2$ using $|u|^2 = u\bar{u}$: the cross terms combine into $2\operatorname{Re}(z\bar{w})$. A real part is never bigger than the modulus, and that single estimate finishes the proof.

Proof. First, for any $u = x + yi$ with $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$, we have $\operatorname{Re} u = x \leq |x| = \sqrt{x^2} \leq \sqrt{x^2 + y^2} = |u|$, since the square root is increasing.

Now let $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$. By [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (c), (a) and [Proposition 0.6.1](#),

$$|z + w|^2 = (z + w)(\bar{z} + \bar{w}) = z\bar{z} + z\bar{w} + w\bar{z} + w\bar{w} = |z|^2 + (z\bar{w} + \overline{z\bar{w}}) + |w|^2,$$

where we used $w\bar{z} = \overline{z\bar{w}}$, which follows from [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (b) and (a). By [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (c) the bracket equals $2\operatorname{Re}(z\bar{w})$. Therefore, using $\operatorname{Re} u \leq |u|$ and then [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d),

$$|z + w|^2 \leq |z|^2 + 2|z\bar{w}| + |w|^2 = |z|^2 + 2|z||w| + |w|^2 = (|z| + |w|)^2.$$

Both $|z + w|$ and $|z| + |w|$ are non-negative, so taking square roots preserves the inequality. This proves the triangle inequality. ■

The route “square, expand, bound the cross term” is worth remembering: it is exactly the route we will take for norms in inner product spaces. The inequality is often strict. For $z = 1$ and $w = -1$, the left side is 0 and the right side is 2.

0.6.3 Two things that do not carry over from the reals

Complex numbers obey the rules of arithmetic, but not every habit from the real line survives.

The first loss is order. On $\mathbb{R}$ we use two facts about positivity: for every x , exactly one of $x > 0$, $x = 0$, $-x > 0$ holds, and sums and products of positive numbers are positive. Suppose some relation $>$ on $\mathbb{C}$ had both properties. Since $i \neq 0$, either $i > 0$ or $-i > 0$, and in both cases the product rule gives $i^2 = (-i)^2 = -1 > 0$. The same argument applied to $1 \neq 0$ gives $1 = 1^2 = (-1)^2 > 0$. Then both 1 and -1 are positive, so their sum 0 is positive, which contradicts “exactly one”.

Warning. There is no ordering on $\mathbb{C}$ compatible with addition and multiplication, so an inequality such as $z < w$ between complex numbers means nothing. Inequalities in this book compare **real** numbers: moduli $|z|$, real parts, or quantities known to be real. Writing $i > 0$ leads, as shown above, to $0 > 0$.

The second loss is the square-root rule $\sqrt{x}\sqrt{y} = \sqrt{xy}$, which on $\mathbb{R}$ is only claimed for $x, y \geq 0$.

Warning. Every non-zero complex number has **two** square roots, and no choice of “the” square root makes $\sqrt{z}\sqrt{w} = \sqrt{zw}$ true for all z, w . With $\sqrt{-1} = i$: $\sqrt{-1} \cdot \sqrt{-1} = i^2 = -1$, but $\sqrt{(-1)(-1)} = \sqrt{1} = 1$. Avoid the symbol $\sqrt{z}$ for non-real z ; say “a square root of z ” and solve $w^2 = z$ instead.

Solving $w^2 = z$ is a finite computation, done by comparing real and imaginary parts.

Example. (Square Roots of $5 - 12i$)

Find all $w \in \mathbb{C}$ with $w^2 = 5 - 12i$.

Solution. Write $w = x + yi$ with $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $w^2 = (x^2 - y^2) + 2xyi$, so comparing real and imaginary parts, $w^2 = 5 - 12i$ holds exactly when

$$x^2 - y^2 = 5 \quad \text{and} \quad xy = -6.$$

Taking moduli in $w^2 = 5 - 12i$ and using [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d) gives $|w|^2 = |5 - 12i| = \sqrt{25 + 144} = 13$, that is $x^2 + y^2 = 13$. Adding and subtracting this and the first equation gives $x^2 = 9$ and $y^2 = 4$, so $x = \pm 3$ and $y = \pm 2$. The condition $xy = -6 < 0$ says x and y have opposite signs. Hence $w = 3 - 2i$ or $w = -3 + 2i$. Both work: $(3 - 2i)^2 = 9 - 12i + 4i^2 = 5 - 12i$, and $(-3 + 2i)^2 = (3 - 2i)^2$.

0.6.4 Polar form: multiplication rotates and scales

Addition in $\mathbb{C}$ is the familiar addition of arrows in the plane. Multiplication has a geometric meaning too, and it only becomes visible when we describe a point by its distance from 0 and its angle, instead of by its coordinates.

Let $z \neq 0$ and put $r = |z| > 0$. The number z/r has modulus 1 by [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d), so it lies on the unit circle. From trigonometry, every point (x, y) with $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ is $(\cos \theta, \sin \theta)$ for some real θ . We abbreviate

$$e^{i\theta} := \cos \theta + i \sin \theta \quad (\theta \in \mathbb{R}),$$

and then every non-zero complex number can be written as

$$z = re^{i\theta}, \quad r = |z| > 0, \quad \theta \in \mathbb{R}.$$

This is the **polar form** of z , and θ is **an** argument of z . The word “an” matters: θ and $\theta + 2\pi k$ give the same point for every integer k . Conversely, if $re^{i\theta} = se^{i\varphi}$ with $r, s > 0$, then taking moduli gives $r = s$ (as $|e^{i\theta}| = \sqrt{\cos^2 \theta + \sin^2 \theta} = 1$). Comparing real and imaginary parts then gives $\cos \theta = \cos \varphi$ and $\sin \theta = \sin \varphi$, which from trigonometry means $\theta - \varphi$ is an integer multiple of 2π .

For now $e^{i\theta}$ is only a name for $\cos \theta + i \sin \theta$. The next result is the reason the name is a good one: these numbers multiply the way exponentials do.

Theorem 0.6.5 — Multiplication in Polar Form

For all $\theta, \varphi \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$e^{i\theta} e^{i\varphi} = e^{i(\theta+\varphi)}.$$

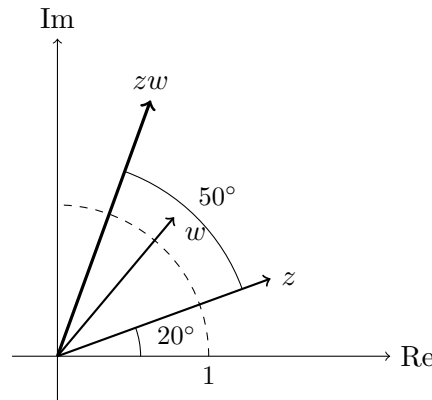
Consequently, if $z = re^{i\theta}$ and $w = se^{i\varphi}$ with $r, s > 0$, then $zw = rs e^{i(\theta+\varphi)}$.

Proof. By the multiplication rule,

$$e^{i\theta} e^{i\varphi} = (\cos \theta \cos \varphi - \sin \theta \sin \varphi) + (\cos \theta \sin \varphi + \sin \theta \cos \varphi)i = \cos(\theta + \varphi) + i \sin(\theta + \varphi),$$

where the last equality uses the addition formulas for cosine and sine. This is $e^{i(\theta+\varphi)}$. For the second statement, $zw = (rs)(e^{i\theta} e^{i\varphi})$ by [Proposition 0.6.1](#), and the first statement finishes the proof. ■

In words: **to multiply two complex numbers, multiply their moduli and add their arguments**. Multiplying by a fixed $w = se^{i\varphi}$ is therefore a rotation of the plane about 0 by the angle φ , combined with a stretch by the factor s . The picture shows z , w and zw for $|z| = 1.5$, $|w| = 1.2$ and arguments 20° and 50° .



The arrow for zw has length $1.5 \times 1.2 = 1.8$ and makes the angle $20^\circ + 50^\circ = 70^\circ$ with the positive real axis: it is the arrow for z , turned by w 's angle and stretched by w 's length. The small arc marks the argument of z , the large arc marks the extra turn by the argument of w , and the dashed arc is the unit circle, where the numbers $e^{i\theta}$ live.

Two special cases are worth isolating. Multiplying by $i = e^{i\pi/2}$ is a quarter turn counterclockwise, which explains $i^2 = -1$: two quarter turns send 1 to -1 . And $e^{i\theta} e^{-i\theta} = e^0 = 1$, so $(e^{i\theta})^{-1} = e^{-i\theta} = \overline{e^{i\theta}}$.

Repeating [Theorem 0.6.5](#) gives powers.

Theorem 0.6.6 — De Moivre's Formula

For every $\theta \in \mathbb{R}$ and every $n \in \mathbb{N}$,

$$(e^{i\theta})^n = e^{in\theta}, \quad \text{that is,} \quad (\cos \theta + i \sin \theta)^n = \cos n\theta + i \sin n\theta.$$

Consequently $(re^{i\theta})^n = r^n e^{in\theta}$ for every real $r > 0$.

Proof. We use induction on n ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)). For $n = 0$, both sides equal 1, since $e^{i \cdot 0} = \cos 0 + i \sin 0 = 1$. Suppose $(e^{i\theta})^n = e^{in\theta}$ for some $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Then $(e^{i\theta})^{n+1} = (e^{i\theta})^n e^{i\theta} = e^{in\theta} e^{i\theta} = e^{i(n+1)\theta}$ by the induction hypothesis and [Theorem 0.6.5](#). The consequence follows by the same induction, since $(re^{i\theta})^{n+1} = (r^n e^{in\theta})(re^{i\theta}) = r^{n+1} e^{i(n+1)\theta}$ by [Theorem 0.6.5](#). ■

Powers that are painful to expand become one line in polar form.

Example. (A Power via Polar Form)

Compute $(\sqrt{3} + i)^6$.

Solution. The modulus is $|\sqrt{3} + i| = \sqrt{3 + 1} = 2$, and $\sqrt{3} + i = 2\left(\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} + \frac{1}{2}i\right) = 2\left(\cos \frac{\pi}{6} + i \sin \frac{\pi}{6}\right) = 2e^{i\pi/6}$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#),

$$(\sqrt{3} + i)^6 = 2^6 e^{i \cdot 6\pi/6} = 64(\cos \pi + i \sin \pi) = -64.$$

Expanding $(\sqrt{3} + i)^6$ with the binomial theorem gives the same answer after seven terms and some cancellation.

Quick check. Use polar form to compute $(1 + i)^8$.

Solution. We have $|1 + i| = \sqrt{2}$ and $1 + i = \sqrt{2}\left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} + \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}i\right) = \sqrt{2}e^{i\pi/4}$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#), $(1 + i)^8 = (\sqrt{2})^8 e^{i \cdot 8\pi/4} = 16e^{2\pi i} = 16$. As a cross-check, $(1 + i)^2 = 2i$, so $(1 + i)^8 = (2i)^4 = 16i^4 = 16$.

0.6.5 Roots of unity

Polar form also turns the equation $z^n = c$ into a question about angles. The most important case is $c = 1$.

Example. (Roots of Unity)

Let $n \geq 1$ be an integer. Find all $z \in \mathbb{C}$ with $z^n = 1$, and draw them for $n = 6$.

Solution. Since $0^n = 0 \neq 1$, every solution is non-zero, so we may write $z = re^{i\theta}$ with $r > 0$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#), $z^n = r^n e^{in\theta}$, and $1 = 1 \cdot e^{i0}$. By uniqueness of the polar form up to multiples of 2π , $z^n = 1$ holds exactly when $r^n = 1$ and $n\theta = 2\pi k$ for some integer

k . Since $r > 0$ is real, $r^n = 1$ forces $r = 1$. Hence the solutions are

$$e^{2\pi i k/n}, \quad k \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

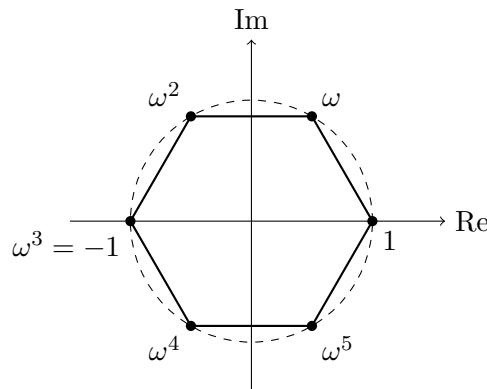
Put $\omega := e^{2\pi i/n}$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#), $e^{2\pi i k/n} = \omega^k$ for $k \geq 0$. Two integers k, l give the same number exactly when $2\pi(k-l)/n$ is a multiple of 2π , that is, when n divides $k-l$. So there are exactly n distinct solutions,

$$1, \omega, \omega^2, \dots, \omega^{n-1},$$

the **n -th roots of unity**. They sit on the unit circle at equally spaced angles. For $n \geq 3$ they are the corners of a regular polygon with n corners, one of them at 1; for $n = 2$ they are ± 1 .

For $n = 6$, the angles are multiples of 60° , and the roots are

$$1, \quad \frac{1}{2} + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i, \quad -\frac{1}{2} + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i, \quad -1, \quad -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i, \quad \frac{1}{2} - \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}i.$$



The six roots sum to 0: since $\omega^3 = e^{i\pi} = -1$, we have $\omega^{k+3} = -\omega^k$, so the roots cancel in the opposite pairs $\{1, \omega^3\}$, $\{\omega, \omega^4\}$, $\{\omega^2, \omega^5\}$. In the picture, the hexagon is symmetric about its center 0. The sum of the n -th roots of unity is 0 for every $n \geq 2$; see [Exercise \(C2: Roots of Unity Sum to Zero\)](#).

0.6.6 The Fundamental Theorem of Algebra

We built $\mathbb{C}$ so that one polynomial equation, $z^2 + 1 = 0$, has a solution. It turns out that nothing more ever needs to be added: every polynomial equation already has a solution in $\mathbb{C}$. Here a **complex polynomial of degree n** means an expression $a_n z^n + \dots + a_1 z + a_0$ with $a_0, \dots, a_n \in \mathbb{C}$ and $a_n \neq 0$; polynomials are studied properly in a later section of this chapter.

Theorem 0.6.7 — Fundamental Theorem of Algebra

Let $n \geq 1$ and let $a_0, a_1, \dots, a_n \in \mathbb{C}$ with $a_n \neq 0$. Then there exists $z \in \mathbb{C}$ with

$$a_n z^n + a_{n-1} z^{n-1} + \dots + a_1 z + a_0 = 0.$$

We do not prove this theorem here. Its proof needs tools we have not built, and it is proved in

Chapter 5. Nothing in Chapters 0–4 depends on it.

Remark. Combined with division of polynomials (also in Chapter 5), the theorem gives the form in which it is usually applied: every complex polynomial of degree $n \geq 1$ **splits into linear factors**, $a_n z^n + \cdots + a_0 = a_n(z - z_1)(z - z_2) \cdots (z - z_n)$ for some $z_1, \dots, z_n \in \mathbb{C}$, not necessarily distinct. For linear algebra this is the fact that every complex square matrix has an eigenvalue, the starting point of the theory of canonical forms.

One companion fact needs no heavy machinery. If the coefficients $a_0, \dots, a_n$ are **real** and $p(z) = a_n z^n + \cdots + a_0$ has $p(z_0) = 0$, then applying [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (a) and (b) term by term, and $\overline{a_k} = a_k$, gives $p(\overline{z_0}) = \overline{p(z_0)} = \overline{0} = 0$. So the non-real roots of a real polynomial come in conjugate pairs. For example, $z^2 - 2z + 5$ has the roots $1 + 2i$ and $1 - 2i$: indeed $(1 + 2i)^2 - 2(1 + 2i) + 5 = (-3 + 4i) - (2 + 4i) + 5 = 0$.

0.6.7 Exercises

0.6.7.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define the complex conjugate $\bar{z}$ and the modulus $|z|$ of $z = a + bi$, where $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$.
- State the triangle inequality for complex numbers.
- True or false: $|z + w| = |z| + |w|$ for all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: $z\bar{z}$ is a non-negative real number for every $z \in \mathbb{C}$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: if $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$ and $z^2 = w^2$, then $z = w$. Justify your answer.
- State the Fundamental Theorem of Algebra.

Solution.

- See [Definition 0.6.2](#): $\bar{z} = a - bi$ and $|z| = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2} \geq 0$.
- See [Theorem 0.6.4](#): $|z + w| \leq |z| + |w|$ for all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$.
- False. For $z = 1$ and $w = -1$, $|z + w| = 0$ but $|z| + |w| = 2$.
- True. By [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (c), $z\bar{z} = |z|^2 = a^2 + b^2$, which is real and non-negative.
- False. For $z = 1$ and $w = -1$, $z^2 = w^2 = 1$ but $z \neq w$. (What is true is that $z^2 = w^2$ implies $z = w$ or $z = -w$.)
- See [Theorem 0.6.7](#): every complex polynomial $a_n z^n + \cdots + a_0$ with $n \geq 1$ and $a_n \neq 0$ has a root in $\mathbb{C}$.

0.6.7.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Arithmetic.

Write each of the following in the form $a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, or as a real number where indicated.

- (a) $(3 - 2i)(4 + i)$.
 (b) $\frac{1 + 2i}{2 - i}$.
 (c) $|(3 + 4i)(5 - 12i)|$, without expanding the product.
 (d) $\operatorname{Re} \frac{1}{1 + i}$ and $\operatorname{Im} \frac{1}{1 + i}$.

Solution.

- (a) Expanding and using $i^2 = -1$: $(3 - 2i)(4 + i) = 12 + 3i - 8i - 2i^2 = 14 - 5i$.
 (b) Multiplying top and bottom by $\overline{2 - i} = 2 + i$ ([Proposition 0.6.3](#)),

$$\frac{1 + 2i}{2 - i} = \frac{(1 + 2i)(2 + i)}{(2 - i)(2 + i)} = \frac{2 + i + 4i + 2i^2}{4 + 1} = \frac{5i}{5} = i.$$

- (c) By [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d), $|(3 + 4i)(5 - 12i)| = |3 + 4i| |5 - 12i| = \sqrt{25} \cdot \sqrt{169} = 5 \cdot 13 = 65$.
 (d) By [Proposition 0.6.3](#), $\frac{1}{1 + i} = \frac{1 - i}{|1 + i|^2} = \frac{1 - i}{2} = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{2}i$. Hence the real part is $\frac{1}{2}$ and the imaginary part is $-\frac{1}{2}$.

Exercise B2: A Square Root.

- (a) Find all $w \in \mathbb{C}$ with $w^2 = -3 + 4i$.
 (b) Hence solve $z^2 + 2z + 4 - 4i = 0$.

Hint: for (b), complete the square.

Solution.

- (a) Write $w = x + yi$ with $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$. Comparing real and imaginary parts in $(x^2 - y^2) + 2xyi = -3 + 4i$ gives $x^2 - y^2 = -3$ and $xy = 2$. Taking moduli, by [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d), $x^2 + y^2 = |w|^2 = |-3 + 4i| = 5$. Adding and subtracting, $x^2 = 1$ and $y^2 = 4$. Since $xy = 2 > 0$, x and y have the same sign. Therefore $w = 1 + 2i$ or $w = -1 - 2i$. Check: $(1 + 2i)^2 = 1 + 4i - 4 = -3 + 4i$, and $(-1 - 2i)^2 = (1 + 2i)^2$.
 (b) Completing the square, $z^2 + 2z + 4 - 4i = (z + 1)^2 - 1 + 4 - 4i = (z + 1)^2 - (-3 + 4i)$. So the equation holds exactly when $(z + 1)^2 = -3 + 4i$. By (a), this means $z + 1 = 1 + 2i$ or $z + 1 = -1 - 2i$. Hence the solutions are $z = 2i$ and $z = -2 - 2i$.

Exercise B3.

Let $z \in \mathbb{C}$ with $z \neq 0$. Prove that $\frac{1}{z} = \bar{z}$ if and only if $|z| = 1$.

Solution. By [Proposition 0.6.3](#), $\frac{1}{z} = \frac{1}{|z|^2} \bar{z}$.

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $|z| = 1$. Then $\frac{1}{z} = \frac{1}{1} \bar{z} = \bar{z}$.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $\frac{1}{z} = \bar{z}$. Then $\frac{1}{|z|^2} \bar{z} = \bar{z}$. Since $z \neq 0$, also $\bar{z} \neq 0$, so multiplying both sides by $(\bar{z})^{-1}$ gives $\frac{1}{|z|^2} = 1$, that is, $|z|^2 = 1$. As $|z| \geq 0$, this forces $|z| = 1$. This proves the equivalence.

Exercise B4: Polar Form.

- (a) Compute $(1 - \sqrt{3}i)^6$.
- (b) Find all $z \in \mathbb{C}$ with $z^3 = -8i$, in the form $a + bi$.

Solution.

- (a) We have $|1 - \sqrt{3}i| = \sqrt{1+3} = 2$ and $1 - \sqrt{3}i = 2(\cos(-\frac{\pi}{3}) + i\sin(-\frac{\pi}{3})) = 2e^{-i\pi/3}$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#), $(1 - \sqrt{3}i)^6 = 64e^{-2\pi i} = 64(\cos 2\pi - i\sin 2\pi) = 64$.
- (b) Since $0^3 \neq -8i$, write $z = re^{i\theta}$ with $r > 0$. Also $-8i = 8e^{-i\pi/2}$. By [Theorem 0.6.6](#), $z^3 = r^3e^{3i\theta}$. By uniqueness of polar form up to multiples of 2π , $z^3 = -8i$ holds exactly when $r^3 = 8$ and $3\theta = -\frac{\pi}{2} + 2\pi k$ for some integer k . Therefore $r = 2$ and $\theta = -\frac{\pi}{6} + \frac{2\pi k}{3}$. The values $k = 0, 1, 2$ give $\theta = -\frac{\pi}{6}, \frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{7\pi}{6}$, and every other k differs from one of these by a multiple of 3, which changes θ by a multiple of 2π . Hence the solutions are

$$2e^{-i\pi/6} = \sqrt{3} - i, \quad 2e^{i\pi/2} = 2i, \quad 2e^{7i\pi/6} = -\sqrt{3} - i.$$

Check: $(2i)^3 = 8i^3 = -8i$.

0.6.7.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Reverse Triangle Inequality.

Prove that $||z| - |w|| \leq |z - w|$ for all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$.

Hint: write $z = (z - w) + w$.

Solution. Let $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$. Since $z = (z - w) + w$, the triangle inequality ([Theorem 0.6.4](#)) gives $|z| \leq |z - w| + |w|$, so $|z| - |w| \leq |z - w|$. Swapping the roles of z and w gives $|w| - |z| \leq |w - z|$. Moreover $|w - z| = |(-1)(z - w)| = |-1||z - w| = |z - w|$ by [Theorem 0.6.2](#) (d). The real number $||z| - |w||$ equals one of $|z| - |w|$ and $|w| - |z|$, and both are at most $|z - w|$. This proves the inequality.

Exercise C2: Roots of Unity Sum to Zero.

Let $n \geq 2$ and $\omega = e^{2\pi i/n}$.

- (a) Prove that $1 + \omega + \omega^2 + \cdots + \omega^{n-1} = 0$.
- (b) Deduce that $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \cos \frac{2\pi k}{n} = 0$ and $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \sin \frac{2\pi k}{n} = 0$.

Hint: compare S with ωS , where S is the sum in (a).

Solution.

- (a) Let $S = 1 + \omega + \cdots + \omega^{n-1}$. By Theorem 0.6.6, $\omega^n = e^{2\pi i} = 1$. Therefore

$$\omega S = \omega + \omega^2 + \cdots + \omega^{n-1} + \omega^n = \omega + \omega^2 + \cdots + \omega^{n-1} + 1 = S,$$

so $(\omega - 1)S = 0$. Since $n \geq 2$, we have $0 < 2\pi/n \leq \pi$, so $\operatorname{Re} \omega = \cos(2\pi/n) < 1$ and $\omega \neq 1$. Hence $\omega - 1 \neq 0$, and multiplying $(\omega - 1)S = 0$ by $(\omega - 1)^{-1}$ (Proposition 0.6.3) gives $S = 0$.

- (b) By Theorem 0.6.6, $\omega^k = \cos \frac{2\pi k}{n} + i \sin \frac{2\pi k}{n}$ for each k . Since addition in $\mathbb{C}$ is coordinate by coordinate, the real part of S is $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \cos \frac{2\pi k}{n}$ and the imaginary part is $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \sin \frac{2\pi k}{n}$. By (a), $S = 0$, so both sums are 0.

Exercise C3: Symmetries of $\mathbb{C}$ Fixing $\mathbb{R}$.

Let $\sigma: \mathbb{C} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ be a function with $\sigma(z + w) = \sigma(z) + \sigma(w)$ and $\sigma(zw) = \sigma(z)\sigma(w)$ for all $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$, and $\sigma(a) = a$ for every $a \in \mathbb{R}$.

- (a) Prove that $\sigma(i)^2 = -1$.
- (b) Prove that the only complex numbers u with $u^2 = -1$ are i and $-i$.
- (c) Deduce that either $\sigma(z) = z$ for every $z \in \mathbb{C}$, or $\sigma(z) = \bar{z}$ for every $z \in \mathbb{C}$.
- (d) Show that $z \mapsto \bar{z}$ does satisfy all three conditions on σ .

Hint: for (b), write $u = x + yi$ and compare real and imaginary parts.

Solution.

- (a) Since σ respects products and fixes the real number -1 , we get $\sigma(i)^2 = \sigma(i \cdot i) = \sigma(-1) = -1$.
- (b) Let $u = x + yi$ with $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$ and $u^2 = -1$. Comparing real and imaginary parts in $(x^2 - y^2) + 2xyi = -1$ gives $x^2 - y^2 = -1$ and $xy = 0$. If $y = 0$, then $x^2 = -1$, which is impossible for real x . Hence $x = 0$, so $y^2 = 1$ and $y = \pm 1$. Therefore $u = i$ or $u = -i$, and both satisfy $u^2 = -1$.
- (c) By (a) and (b), $\sigma(i) = i$ or $\sigma(i) = -i$. Let $z = a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. Since σ respects sums and products and fixes a and b ,

$$\sigma(z) = \sigma(a) + \sigma(b)\sigma(i) = a + b\sigma(i).$$

If $\sigma(i) = i$, this gives $\sigma(z) = z$ for every z . If $\sigma(i) = -i$, it gives $\sigma(z) = a - bi = \bar{z}$ for every z .

- (d) By Theorem 0.6.2 (a) and (b), conjugation respects sums and products. For $a \in \mathbb{R}$, $\bar{a} = a + 0i = a - 0i = a$. So conjugation satisfies all three conditions.

0.7 Fields

Linear algebra is about equations like $2x + 3y = 7$, and so far we have met several number systems in which such equations make sense: $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$, and the arithmetic of remainders $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$. Which of them can serve as the numbers of linear algebra? This section answers by isolating the rules that solving linear equations actually uses. A number system obeying those rules is called a field, and fields are the scalars of every later chapter.

0.7.1 What solving linear equations needs

Here is a small system, solved the way you learned at school:

$$\begin{aligned} 2x + 3y &= 7, \\ x - y &= 1. \end{aligned}$$

Subtracting twice the second equation from the first gives $5y = 5$. Dividing by 5 gives $y = 1$, and then $x = 1 + y = 2$. Check: $2 \cdot 2 + 3 \cdot 1 = 7$ and $2 - 1 = 1$.

Look at what we used. We added and subtracted equations, multiplied an equation by a number, and divided by a **non-zero** number. Silently we also rearranged terms, regrouped them and expanded brackets. Every step of Gaussian elimination is of this kind, and every one of them works in $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$.

Now try the integers. The equation $2x = 1$ involves only integers, yet it has no integer solution, because the step “divide by 2” leaves $\mathbb{Z}$. Elimination stalls as soon as a pivot has no inverse. So what separates $\mathbb{Z}$ from $\mathbb{Q}$ is division, and division is exactly what we must demand.

A field is a number system where you can add, subtract, multiply, and divide by anything non-zero, with the usual rules.

0.7.2 The definition

Definition 0.7.1 — Field

A **field** is a set F together with two functions, **addition** $+: F \times F \rightarrow F$, $(a, b) \mapsto a + b$, and **multiplication** $\cdot: F \times F \rightarrow F$, $(a, b) \mapsto a \cdot b = ab$, satisfying the following axioms.

- (F1) $a + b = b + a$ **for all** $a, b \in F$.
- (F2) $(a + b) + c = a + (b + c)$ **for all** $a, b, c \in F$.
- (F3) There exists an element $0 \in F$ such that $a + 0 = a$ **for every** $a \in F$.
- (F4) **For every** $a \in F$ there exists an element $-a \in F$ such that $a + (-a) = 0$.
- (F5) $(ab)c = a(bc)$ **for all** $a, b, c \in F$.
- (F6) $ab = ba$ **for all** $a, b \in F$.
- (F7) There exists an element $1 \in F$ with $1 \neq 0$ such that $a \cdot 1 = a$ **for every** $a \in F$.
- (F8) **For every non-zero** $a \in F$ there exists an element $a^{-1} \in F$ such that $aa^{-1} = 1$.
- (F9) $a(b + c) = ab + ac$ **for all** $a, b, c \in F$.

Read the axioms in groups.

- **(F1)–(F4)** are about addition alone. It is commutative and associative, it has a neutral element 0, and every element has a negative. Subtraction is then defined by $a - b := a + (-b)$.
- **(F5)–(F8)** say the same things about multiplication, with one change: only **non-zero** elements are required to have inverses. Division is defined by $a/b := ab^{-1}$ for $b \neq 0$. We never divide by 0, and the axioms never ask us to.
- **(F7)** also insists that $1 \neq 0$: the two neutral elements are different.
- **(F9)** is the one rule linking the two operations. It is what lets us expand brackets.

Note the order of quantifiers in (F3): **one** element 0 works **for every** a . This is stronger than “for every a there is some element z_a with $a + z_a = a$ ”. In (F4) the order is reversed, as it must be: the negative $-a$ depends on a .

We often say “ F is a field” when the operations are clear, and write $(F, +, \cdot)$ when they need to be named. Since addition and multiplication are functions into F , sums and products of elements of F stay in F ; when we build a field inside a bigger number system, this “closure” is the first thing to check.

0.7.3 First consequences of the axioms

The notation in the definition hides a question. We wrote “0”, “ $-a$ ” and “ a^{-1} ” as if each were a single well-defined element. The axioms only say that such elements **exist**. If a field could contain two different elements behaving like 0, the symbol 0 would be ambiguous, and so would $a - b$ and a/b . The next theorem removes this worry and proves the familiar rules of algebra from the nine axioms.

Theorem 0.7.1 — Basic Properties of Fields

Let F be a field and let $a, b, c \in F$.

- The element 0 in (F3) is unique, and the element 1 in (F7) is unique.
- (Cancellation) If $a + b = a + c$, then $b = c$. If $ab = ac$ and $a \neq 0$, then $b = c$.
- The negative $-a$ in (F4) is unique, and for $a \neq 0$ the inverse a^{-1} in (F8) is unique.
- $0 \cdot a = 0$.
- $(-1)a = -a$.
- If $ab = 0$, then $a = 0$ or $b = 0$.

Idea. Each part is a short chain of axioms, and the chain is found backwards from the goal. For uniqueness we use the standard move: suppose two elements both have the property, and show they are equal. For (d) there is no axiom about $0 \cdot a$ at all, so we must create a situation where one applies. The trick is to rewrite 0 in a fancy way as $0 + 0$, expand with (F9), and cancel. For (f), the hypothesis $a \neq 0$ is there to be spent on (F8).

We prove the uniqueness of 0, additive cancellation, the uniqueness of negatives, (d) and (f). The remaining statements are [Exercise \(B1: The Remaining Basic Properties\)](#).

Proof.

- (a) Suppose 0 and $0'$ both satisfy (F3). Applying (F3) for $0'$ to the element 0, and (F3) for 0 to the element $0'$, and using (F1),

$$0 = 0 + 0' = 0' + 0 = 0'.$$

So the zero element is unique.

- (b) Suppose $a + b = a + c$. Adding $-a$ on the left of both sides and using (F2),

$$((-a) + a) + b = ((-a) + a) + c.$$

By (F1) and (F4), $(-a) + a = a + (-a) = 0$. Hence $0 + b = 0 + c$, and by (F1) and (F3) this says $b = c$.

- (c) Suppose b and c both satisfy (F4) for a , that is, $a + b = 0$ and $a + c = 0$. Then $a + b = a + c$, so $b = c$ by additive cancellation in (b).
 (d) By (F3), $0 + 0 = 0$. Therefore, by (F9),

$$a \cdot 0 = a(0 + 0) = a \cdot 0 + a \cdot 0.$$

By (F3), also $a \cdot 0 = a \cdot 0 + 0$. Comparing, $a \cdot 0 + 0 = a \cdot 0 + a \cdot 0$, and additive cancellation (b) gives $0 = a \cdot 0$. Finally $0 \cdot a = a \cdot 0$ by (F6), so $0 \cdot a = 0$.

- (e) Suppose $ab = 0$. If $a = 0$ there is nothing to prove, so suppose $a \neq 0$. By (F8), a^{-1} exists. Then, by (F7), (F8), (F6) and (F5),

$$b = b \cdot 1 = b(aa^{-1}) = (ba)a^{-1} = (ab)a^{-1} = 0 \cdot a^{-1} = 0,$$

where the last equality is (d). This shows that $a = 0$ or $b = 0$. ■

Two small consequences are used without comment from now on: $0 + a = a$ and $1 \cdot a = a$, by (F1), (F3), (F6) and (F7). More importantly, every identity of school algebra that is proved from these rules, such as $(a + b)^2 = a^2 + 2ab + b^2$ or $(-a)(-b) = ab$, now holds in every field. Part (f) is the property we will use most: a product of non-zero elements is non-zero.

0.7.4 Examples

We check the standard examples first, then an exotic one, then a degenerate case.

Example. (The Fields $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$)

Explain why $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$, with their usual addition and multiplication, are fields.

Solution. For $\mathbb{R}$, the axioms (F1)–(F9) are the rules of arithmetic for real numbers that we take as familiar, and $1 \neq 0$.

For $\mathbb{Q}$, the sum, product and negative of fractions are fractions, and so is the inverse $\frac{q}{p}$ of a non-zero fraction $\frac{p}{q}$. So the operations of $\mathbb{R}$ restrict to functions $\mathbb{Q} \times \mathbb{Q} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$, and $0, 1, -a, a^{-1}$ lie in $\mathbb{Q}$ whenever a does. The identities in (F1), (F2), (F5), (F6) and (F9)

hold for all real numbers, so in particular for rational ones. Hence $\mathbb{Q}$ is a field.

For $\mathbb{C}$, the axioms (F1)–(F6) and (F9), together with the existence of $1 = 1 + 0i$, are [Proposition 0.6.1](#). We have $1 = (1, 0) \neq (0, 0) = 0$. Finally (F8) is [Proposition 0.6.3](#): a non-zero z has the inverse $\bar{z}/|z|^2$. Hence $\mathbb{C}$ is a field.

The next example is a field strictly between $\mathbb{Q}$ and $\mathbb{R}$. It shows that the inverse axiom (F8) can take real work to check.

Example. ($\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ Is a Field)

Let $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) := \{a + b\sqrt{2} : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}$, with the addition and multiplication of $\mathbb{R}$. Show that $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a field, and find the inverse of $1 + 2\sqrt{2}$.

Solution. Let $x = a + b\sqrt{2}$ and $y = c + d\sqrt{2}$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{Q}$.

Closure. We have $x + y = (a + c) + (b + d)\sqrt{2}$ and $xy = (ac + 2bd) + (ad + bc)\sqrt{2}$, using $\sqrt{2} \cdot \sqrt{2} = 2$. The coefficients are rational, so $x + y, xy \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.

Axioms that are identities. (F1), (F2), (F5), (F6) and (F9) hold for all real numbers, hence for the elements of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.

Neutral elements and negatives. $0 = 0 + 0\sqrt{2}$ and $1 = 1 + 0\sqrt{2}$ lie in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, and $1 \neq 0$. The negative $-x = (-a) + (-b)\sqrt{2}$ lies in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.

Inverses. Suppose $x \neq 0$. We first claim $a - b\sqrt{2} \neq 0$. If $b \neq 0$ and $a - b\sqrt{2} = 0$, then $\sqrt{2} = a/b$ would be rational, contradicting [Theorem 0.2.3](#). If $b = 0$, then $a = x \neq 0$, so $a - b\sqrt{2} = a \neq 0$. Therefore $a - b\sqrt{2} \neq 0$, and by [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f) in $\mathbb{R}$,

$$N := (a + b\sqrt{2})(a - b\sqrt{2}) = a^2 - 2b^2 \neq 0.$$

Since N is a non-zero rational number, the element

$$x' := \frac{a}{N} + \frac{-b}{N}\sqrt{2} \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$$

satisfies $xx' = \frac{1}{N}(a + b\sqrt{2})(a - b\sqrt{2}) = 1$. So (F8) holds, and $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a field.

For $x = 1 + 2\sqrt{2}$ we get $N = 1 - 8 = -7$, so $x^{-1} = -\frac{1}{7} + \frac{2}{7}\sqrt{2} = \frac{-1+2\sqrt{2}}{7}$. Check: $(1 + 2\sqrt{2})(-1 + 2\sqrt{2}) = -1 + 2\sqrt{2} - 2\sqrt{2} + 8 = 7$.

The method is “rationalize the denominator”, the same move as multiplying by the conjugate in $\mathbb{C}$. The irrationality of $\sqrt{2}$ is exactly what guarantees the new denominator is not zero.

Quick check. Is $\{a + b\sqrt{3} : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\}$, with the operations of $\mathbb{R}$, a field?

Solution. Yes, by the same argument as [Example \(\$\mathbb{Q}\(\sqrt{2}\)\$ Is a Field\)](#). Products stay in the set because $\sqrt{3} \cdot \sqrt{3} = 3$ is rational. For inverses, the number $a^2 - 3b^2$ is non-zero whenever $a + b\sqrt{3} \neq 0$, because $\sqrt{3}$ is irrational ([Exercise \(B3: \$\sqrt{3}\$ is irrational\)](#)). The inverse is $\frac{a-b\sqrt{3}}{a^2-3b^2}$.

The degenerate case. Let $F = \{0\}$ with $0 + 0 = 0$ and $0 \cdot 0 = 0$. Every axiom except one holds: (F1), (F2), (F5), (F6) and (F9) are identities between elements that all equal 0, (F3) and

(F4) hold with $-0 = 0$, and (F8) holds vacuously because there is no non-zero element. The only failure is (F7): the one element that could serve as 1 is 0, and the axiom demands $1 \neq 0$. So $\{0\}$ is not a field, and every field has at least the two elements 0 and 1. This one-element system is the reason the clause $1 \neq 0$ is there.

0.7.5 Finite fields

Every field so far is infinite. The arithmetic of remainders gives finite ones, and they are genuinely useful: computer science and coding theory do linear algebra over them all the time.

Recall from [Definition 0.5.2](#) and [Definition 0.5.5](#) that for an integer $n \geq 1$, congruence modulo n is an equivalence relation on $\mathbb{Z}$. We write $[a]$ for the class of a and $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ for the quotient set. By division with remainder ([Exercise \(C2: Division with remainder\)](#)), $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} = \{[0], [1], \dots, [n-1]\}$, and these n classes are distinct. Also $[a] = [b]$ exactly when n divides $a - b$.

Example. (Arithmetic on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$)

Let $n \geq 1$. Define $[a] + [b] := [a + b]$ and $[a][b] := [ab]$. Show that these operations are well defined, that they satisfy every field axiom except possibly (F8) and the clause $1 \neq 0$, and that $1 \neq 0$ holds exactly when $n \geq 2$. Write out the tables for $n = 2$.

Solution. Well-definedness. The formulas use representatives, so we must check that the answer does not depend on which representatives we pick. For addition this is [Example \(Addition modulo \$n\$ is well defined\)](#). For multiplication, suppose $[a] = [a']$ and $[b] = [b']$, so n divides $a - a'$ and $b - b'$. Then

$$ab - a'b' = a(b - b') + (a - a')b'$$

is divisible by n , so $[ab] = [a'b']$.

Axioms. Every identity in (F1), (F2), (F5), (F6), (F9) transfers from $\mathbb{Z}$, because both sides can be computed on representatives. For instance, for (F9),

$$[a]([b] + [c]) = [a][b + c] = [a(b + c)] = [ab + ac] = [ab] + [ac] = [a][b] + [a][c].$$

The same one-line computation works for the other four. The class $[0]$ satisfies (F3) since $[a] + [0] = [a]$, the class $[-a]$ is a negative of $[a]$ as in (F4), and $[1]$ satisfies $[a][1] = [a]$.

The clause $1 \neq 0$. We have $[1] = [0]$ exactly when n divides 1, that is, when $n = 1$. So $[1] \neq [0]$ exactly when $n \geq 2$.

Tables for $n = 2$. Writing 0, 1 for $[0], [1]$, the set $\mathbb{F}_2 := \mathbb{Z}/2\mathbb{Z} = \{0, 1\}$ has the tables

+	0	1
0	0	1
1	1	0

·	0	1
0	0	0
1	0	1

The only surprise is $1 + 1 = 0$, since 2 is even. Here (F8) holds as well, since the only non-zero element is 1 and $1 \cdot 1 = 1$. Hence $\mathbb{F}_2$ is a field.

So for $n \geq 2$, whether $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is a field comes down to one question: does every non-zero class have an inverse? To find an inverse of $[a]$ we need an integer x with $[ax] = [1]$, that is, $ax + ny = 1$

for some integer y . The following lemma produces such x and y .

Lemma 0.7.2 — Bézout's Lemma for Integers

Let $a, n \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $n \geq 1$, and suppose that the only positive integer dividing both a and n is 1. Then there exist $x, y \in \mathbb{Z}$ with

$$ax + ny = 1.$$

Idea. Consider all positive integers of the form $ax + ny$. There is a smallest one, d , by well-ordering. The plan: ① show d divides a and n ; ② conclude $d = 1$ from the hypothesis. For ①, divide a by d : the remainder is again of the form $ax + ny$ and is smaller than d , so minimality forces it to be 0.

Proof. Let $S = \{ax + ny : x, y \in \mathbb{Z}\} \cap \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$. Since $n = a \cdot 0 + n \cdot 1 \geq 1$, we have $n \in S$, so S is a non-empty subset of $\mathbb{N}$. By the well-ordering principle (Theorem 0.2.11), S has a smallest element $d = ax_0 + ny_0$.

By division with remainder (Exercise (C2: Division with remainder)), $a = qd + r$ for some integers q, r with $0 \leq r < d$. Then

$$r = a - q(ax_0 + ny_0) = a(1 - qx_0) + n(-qy_0)$$

has the form $ax + ny$. If $r \geq 1$, then $r \in S$ and $r < d$, contradicting the minimality of d . Hence $r = 0$, and d divides a . The same argument with n in place of a shows that d divides n .

Therefore d is a positive integer dividing both a and n . By hypothesis $d = 1$, so $ax_0 + ny_0 = 1$, as claimed. ■

Now we can decide exactly when $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is a field.

Theorem 0.7.3 — $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ Is a Field Exactly for Prime n

Let $n \geq 2$ be an integer. Then $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is a field if and only if n is prime.

Idea. By Example (Arithmetic on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$), only (F8) is in question. If n is prime, a non-zero class $[a]$ has a not divisible by n , so a and n share no factor, and Bézout hands us the inverse. If $n = rs$ factors, then $[r][s] = [n] = [0]$ with both factors non-zero, which no field allows.

Proof. By Example (Arithmetic on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$), $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ satisfies all field axioms except possibly (F8), including $[1] \neq [0]$ since $n \geq 2$.

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $n = p$ is prime, and let $[a] \neq [0]$. Then p does not divide a . A positive integer dividing p is 1 or p , and p does not divide a , so the only positive common divisor of a and p is 1. By Lemma 0.7.2 there are $x, y \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $ax + py = 1$. Since $ax - 1 = -py$ is divisible by p ,

$$[a][x] = [ax] = [1].$$

So $[x]$ is an inverse of $[a]$, and (F8) holds. Hence $\mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z}$ is a field.

($\Rightarrow$) We prove the contrapositive. Suppose $n \geq 2$ is not prime. Then $n = rs$ for some integers r, s with $1 < r < n$ and $1 < s < n$. Since $0 < r < n$, n does not divide r , so $[r] \neq [0]$; likewise $[s] \neq [0]$. But $[r][s] = [rs] = [n] = [0]$. By [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f), this cannot happen in a field. Hence $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is not a field. This proves the theorem. ■

For a prime p we write $\mathbb{F}_p := \mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z}$, and usually drop the brackets, writing its elements as $0, 1, \dots, p-1$ and computing “mod p ”. So $\mathbb{F}_2, \mathbb{F}_3, \mathbb{F}_5, \mathbb{F}_7, \dots$ are fields, while $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$ and $\mathbb{Z}/9\mathbb{Z}$ are not.

Quick check. Find the inverse of 3 in $\mathbb{F}_7$.

Solution. We need x with $3x$ leaving remainder 1 on division by 7. Trying $x = 1, 2, \dots$: $3 \cdot 5 = 15 = 2 \cdot 7 + 1$. So $3^{-1} = 5$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$. (By [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (c) this is the only inverse.)

Because $\mathbb{F}_p$ is a field, the elimination from the start of the section runs unchanged in it. Only the arithmetic is new.

Example. (Elimination over $\mathbb{F}_5$)

Solve the system $2x + y = 3$, $3x + 2y = 4$ over $\mathbb{F}_5$.

Solution. In $\mathbb{F}_5$ the inverses are $1^{-1} = 1$, $2^{-1} = 3$, $3^{-1} = 2$, $4^{-1} = 4$, since $2 \cdot 3 = 6 = 5 + 1$ and $4 \cdot 4 = 16 = 15 + 1$. Multiply the first equation by $2^{-1} = 3$: since $3 \cdot 2 = 1$, $3 \cdot 1 = 3$ and $3 \cdot 3 = 9 = 4$, it becomes $x + 3y = 4$. Subtract 3 times this from the second equation: the x -terms cancel, and we get

$$(2 - 9)y = 4 - 12, \quad \text{that is,} \quad 3y = 2,$$

since $-7 = -10 + 3$ and $-8 = -10 + 2$. Multiply by $3^{-1} = 2$: $y = 4$. Then $x = 4 - 3y = 4 - 12 = -8 = 2$. Check: $2 \cdot 2 + 4 = 8 = 3$ and $3 \cdot 2 + 2 \cdot 4 = 14 = 4$ in $\mathbb{F}_5$. Hence $(x, y) = (2, 4)$ is the unique solution.

0.7.6 Non-examples

Each of these fails some part of the slogan, and it pays to name the exact clause that fails.

- $\mathbb{Z}$. Everything but (F8) holds: $\mathbb{Z}$ is closed under $+$ and $\cdot$, contains 0, 1 and negatives, and inherits the identities from $\mathbb{R}$. But $2 \neq 0$ has no inverse in $\mathbb{Z}$, since $2m$ is even and never equals 1. Changing $\mathbb{Z}$ to $\mathbb{Q}$ is the minimal change that repairs it.
- $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$. This is $\mathbb{F}_5$ with the modulus changed from 5 to 6. All axioms but (F8) still hold ([Example \(Arithmetic on \$\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}\$ and the Field \$\mathbb{F}_2\$ \)](#)), but $[2][3] = [0]$ with $[2], [3] \neq [0]$. By [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f), $[2]$ cannot have an inverse; indeed $[2][x]$ is always one of $[0], [2], [4]$.
- 2×2 **real matrices**, with the matrix operations you know from school (they are treated properly later in this chapter). The identity matrix plays the role of 1. Two axioms fail.

(F6) fails:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

(F8) fails too: $E = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ is not the zero matrix, but every product EX has second row zero, so EX is never the identity.

Warning. “[a] $\neq$ [0]” does not mean [a] can be divided by in $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$. In $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$ the equation $[2]x = [1]$ has no solution, and $[2]x = [4]$ has two, $x = [2]$ and $x = [5]$. Before dividing modulo n , check that n is prime, or at least that a and n share no factor.

0.7.7 Why these axioms

Each clause is there because something we rely on breaks without it.

- **Without (F8)**, elimination stalls, as $2x = 1$ over $\mathbb{Z}$ showed. Worse, the theorems of the next chapters fail: over $\mathbb{Z}$, the analogues of vector spaces (called modules) need not have bases, and “a set of n independent vectors in an n -dimensional space spans it” becomes false. This book always works over a field.
- **Without (F6)**, scalars would not commute with each other. The matrices above show such systems exist, and there are even systems with division but without commutativity. Linear algebra constantly swaps scalars, as in $a(b\mathbf{v}) = b(a\mathbf{v})$ for a vector $\mathbf{v}$ (Chapter 1), so we keep commutativity.
- **Without $1 \neq 0$** , the one-element system $\{0\}$ would count, and every statement of the form “a field has a non-zero element” would fail. Keeping it costs nothing.
- **The name** “field” is historical and carries no extra meaning.

Remark. Many identities we are used to are consequences of the axioms and hold in **every** field, including $\mathbb{F}_2$. But properties that involve **order** or **size**, such as “squares are non-negative” or “ $1 + 1 + \cdots + 1 \neq 0$ ”, are not among the axioms. The first already fails in $\mathbb{C}$, where $i^2 = -1$, as the warning on ordering in the previous section explains. The second fails in $\mathbb{F}_p$, which is the subject of the last part of this section.

0.7.8 The characteristic of a field

In $\mathbb{Q}$ we can add 1 to itself as often as we like without reaching 0. In $\mathbb{F}_2$ two copies already give 0, and in $\mathbb{F}_p$ it takes p copies. This number is the most basic invariant of a field, and it decides whether familiar arguments such as “ $2x = 0$ implies $x = 0$ ” are valid.

First some notation. For $a \in F$ and $m \in \mathbb{N}$, define the **integer multiple** $m \cdot a$ by $0 \cdot a := 0$ and $(m+1) \cdot a := m \cdot a + a$. So $m \cdot a = a + a + \cdots + a$ with m terms. This agrees with the field product when $m = 0$, by [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (d).

Lemma 0.7.4 — Integer Multiples

Let F be a field, $a \in F$ and $m, k \in \mathbb{N}$. Then

$$(m \cdot 1) + (k \cdot 1) = (m + k) \cdot 1, \quad (m \cdot 1)(k \cdot 1) = (mk) \cdot 1, \quad (m \cdot 1)a = m \cdot a.$$

Proof. All three follow by induction on one variable ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)). For the first, induct on k : the case $k = 0$ is $m \cdot 1 + 0 = m \cdot 1$ by (F3), and if it holds for k , then by (F2) and the definition,

$$m \cdot 1 + (k + 1) \cdot 1 = (m \cdot 1 + k \cdot 1) + 1 = (m + k) \cdot 1 + 1 = (m + k + 1) \cdot 1.$$

For the third, induct on m : the case $m = 0$ is $0 \cdot a = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (d), and if it holds for m , then by (F6), (F9) and (F7),

$$((m + 1) \cdot 1)a = (m \cdot 1 + 1)a = (m \cdot 1)a + 1 \cdot a = m \cdot a + a = (m + 1) \cdot a.$$

The second is the third with $a = k \cdot 1$, combined with $m \cdot (k \cdot 1) = (mk) \cdot 1$, which follows from the first by induction on m . ■

Definition 0.7.2 — Characteristic

Let F be a field. If there is a **positive** integer n with $n \cdot 1 = 0$, the **characteristic** of F is the **smallest** such n . If there is no such n , the characteristic of F is 0.

In words: count how many copies of 1 must be added to reach 0. If it never happens, the convention is to say “characteristic 0”, not “characteristic ∞ ”: in that case the only integer $m \geq 0$ with $m \cdot 1 = 0$ is $m = 0$.

- $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$ have characteristic 0, because $n \cdot 1 = n \neq 0$ for every positive integer n .
- $\mathbb{F}_p$ has characteristic p : $n \cdot [1] = [n]$, which is $[0]$ exactly when p divides n , and the smallest positive such n is p .
- $\mathbb{F}_2$ is the smallest case: characteristic 2, because $1 + 1 = 0$.

Can a field have characteristic 6? In $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$, six copies of $[1]$ give $[0]$, but $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$ is not a field. This is no accident.

Theorem 0.7.5 — The Characteristic Is 0 or Prime

The characteristic of a field is either 0 or a prime number.

Idea. Suppose the characteristic n factors as rs with smaller factors. Then the elements $r \cdot 1$ and $s \cdot 1$ are non-zero, by minimality of n , but their product is $n \cdot 1 = 0$. A field has no such pairs. This is the same argument as in [Theorem 0.7.3](#), run inside an arbitrary field.

Proof. Let F be a field of characteristic $n \neq 0$. Since the integer multiple $1 \cdot 1 = 0 + 1 = 1$ is non-zero by (F7), we have $n \neq 1$, so $n \geq 2$. Suppose, for a contradiction, that n is not

prime. Then $n = rs$ with integers $1 < r < n$ and $1 < s < n$. By [Lemma 0.7.4](#),

$$(r \cdot 1)(s \cdot 1) = (rs) \cdot 1 = n \cdot 1 = 0.$$

By [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f), $r \cdot 1 = 0$ or $s \cdot 1 = 0$. Either way we have a positive integer smaller than n whose multiple of 1 is 0, contradicting the minimality of n . Hence n is prime. ■

So the characteristic is 0, 2, 3, 5, 7, and so on. Together with [Exercise \(C2: Finite Fields Have Prime Characteristic\)](#), this says a finite field always has prime characteristic.

Warning. In a field of characteristic 2, such as $\mathbb{F}_2$, we have $1 + 1 = 0$, so $-1 = 1$ and $x = -x$ for **every** x . The familiar argument “ $x = -x$, so $2x = 0$, so $x = 0$ ” divides by $2 = 1 + 1$, which is 0 there. For example, in $\mathbb{F}_2$ the element 1 satisfies $1 = -1$ but is not 0. This is why later results, notably on symmetric bilinear forms in Chapter 13, carry the hypothesis “characteristic $\neq 2$ ”.

With fields in hand, the stage for linear algebra is set: in Chapter 1, a vector space is defined **over a field** F , and every result proved there holds at once for $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$, $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and $\mathbb{F}_p$.

0.7.9 Exercises

0.7.9.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define what it means for a set F with two operations to be a field.
- (b) True or false: in every field, $a^2 = 0$ implies $a = 0$. Justify your answer.
- (c) True or false: $\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z}$ is a field. Justify your answer.
- (d) True or false: in every field, $1 + 1 \neq 0$. Justify your answer.
- (e) What are the characteristics of $\mathbb{C}$ and of $\mathbb{F}_7$?
- (f) The set $\mathbb{N}$ with the usual addition and multiplication is not a field. Name two axioms that fail, each with a witness.

Solution.

- (a) See [Definition 0.7.1](#): two operations satisfying (F1)–(F9), including $1 \neq 0$.
- (b) True. If $a \cdot a = 0$, then $a = 0$ or $a = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f).
- (c) False. Since $8 = 2 \cdot 4$ is not prime, $\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z}$ is not a field by [Theorem 0.7.3](#); concretely $[2][4] = [0]$ with $[2], [4] \neq [0]$.
- (d) False. In $\mathbb{F}_2$, $1 + 1 = 0$.
- (e) $\mathbb{C}$ has characteristic 0, and $\mathbb{F}_7$ has characteristic 7 (see the examples after [Definition 0.7.2](#)).
- (f) (F4) fails: $1 \in \mathbb{N}$, but no $b \in \mathbb{N}$ has $1 + b = 0$. (F8) fails: $2 \neq 0$, but no $b \in \mathbb{N}$ has $2b = 1$.

0.7.9.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: The Remaining Basic Properties.

Let F be a field and $a, b, c \in F$. Using only the axioms and the parts of [Theorem 0.7.1](#) proved in the text, prove:

- (a) the element 1 in (F7) is unique;
- (b) if $ab = ac$ and $a \neq 0$, then $b = c$;
- (c) for $a \neq 0$, the inverse a^{-1} is unique;
- (d) $(-1)a = -a$.

Hint: for (d), show that $a + (-1)a = 0$.

Solution.

- (a) Suppose 1 and $1'$ both satisfy (F7). Then, by (F7) for $1'$, (F6), and (F7) for 1, $1 = 1 \cdot 1' = 1' \cdot 1 = 1'$.
- (b) Suppose $ab = ac$ and $a \neq 0$. By (F8), a^{-1} exists, and multiplying both sides by it gives $(ab)a^{-1} = (ac)a^{-1}$. By (F6) and (F5), $(ab)a^{-1} = (ba)a^{-1} = b(aa^{-1}) = b \cdot 1 = b$, using (F8) and (F7) at the end. In the same way $(ac)a^{-1} = c$. Hence $b = c$.
- (c) Suppose b and c both satisfy (F8) for $a \neq 0$: $ab = 1 = ac$. By (b), $b = c$.
- (d) By (F7) and (F6), $a = 1 \cdot a$. Therefore, using (F6) and (F9),

$$a + (-1)a = 1 \cdot a + (-1)a = a \cdot 1 + a(-1) = a(1 + (-1)) = a \cdot 0 = 0,$$

where the last two equalities use (F4) and [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (d). So $(-1)a$ satisfies (F4) for a . By uniqueness of negatives ([Theorem 0.7.1](#) (c)), $(-1)a = -a$.

Exercise B2: Solving Equations in $\mathbb{F}_7$.

- (a) Solve $3x + 5 = 2$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$.
- (b) Solve the system $x + 2y = 3$, $3x + y = 1$ over $\mathbb{F}_7$.

Solution.

- (a) Adding -5 to both sides gives $3x = 2 - 5 = -3 = 4$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$. Since $3 \cdot 5 = 15 = 1$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$, we have $3^{-1} = 5$. Multiplying by 5, $x = 20 = 6$. Check: $3 \cdot 6 + 5 = 23 = 2$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$. Hence $x = 6$.
- (b) Subtract 3 times the first equation from the second: $(1 - 6)y = 1 - 9$, that is, $-5y = -8$, or $2y = 6$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$. Since $2 \cdot 4 = 8 = 1$, $2^{-1} = 4$, so $y = 24 = 3$. Then $x = 3 - 2y = 3 - 6 = -3 = 4$. Check: $4 + 2 \cdot 3 = 10 = 3$ and $3 \cdot 4 + 3 = 15 = 1$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$. Hence $(x, y) = (4, 3)$.

Exercise B3: Which Are Fields?

Determine which of the following are fields, with the stated operations. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\mathbb{Z}/9\mathbb{Z}$, with the operations of [Example \(Arithmetic on \$\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}\$ and the Field \$\mathbb{F}_2\$ \)](#).
- (b) $\mathbb{Q}(i) := \{a + bi : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\}$, with the operations of $\mathbb{C}$.
- (c) $\{a + bi : a, b \in \mathbb{Z}\}$, with the operations of $\mathbb{C}$.
- (d) $\mathbb{F}_5$.

Solution.

- (a) Not a field. Since $9 = 3 \cdot 3$ is not prime, [Theorem 0.7.3](#) applies; concretely $[3][3] = [0]$ with $[3] \neq [0]$, which is impossible in a field by [Theorem 0.7.1 \(f\)](#).
- (b) A field. Let $x = a + bi$ and $y = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{Q}$. Then $x + y = (a + c) + (b + d)i$, $xy = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i$ and $-x = -a - bi$ have rational parts, and $0, 1 \in \mathbb{Q}(i)$ with $1 \neq 0$. The identities (F1), (F2), (F5), (F6), (F9) hold because they hold in $\mathbb{C}$ ([Example \(The Fields \$\mathbb{Q}\$, \$\mathbb{R}\$ and \$\mathbb{C}\$ \)](#)). If $x \neq 0$, then $a^2 + b^2$ is a non-zero rational number, and by [Proposition 0.6.3](#) $x^{-1} = \frac{a}{a^2 + b^2} - \frac{b}{a^2 + b^2}i$, which lies in $\mathbb{Q}(i)$. So (F8) holds.
- (c) Not a field: (F8) fails for 2. Suppose $u = a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ satisfied $2u = 1$. This is also an equation in the field $\mathbb{C}$, where $\frac{1}{2}$ is an inverse of 2; by uniqueness of inverses in $\mathbb{C}$ ([Theorem 0.7.1 \(c\)](#)), $u = \frac{1}{2}$. But $\frac{1}{2}$ has real part $\frac{1}{2} \notin \mathbb{Z}$, a contradiction.
- (d) A field, by [Theorem 0.7.3](#), since 5 is prime.

0.7.9.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: A Field with Four Elements.

Let $F = \{a + b\alpha : a, b \in \mathbb{F}_2\}$, a set of four formal symbols $0, 1, \alpha, \beta$, where $\beta := 1 + \alpha$. Define

$$(a + b\alpha) + (c + d\alpha) := (a + c) + (b + d)\alpha, \quad (a + b\alpha)(c + d\alpha) := (ac + bd) + (ad + bc + bd)\alpha,$$

with all coefficient arithmetic in $\mathbb{F}_2$. (The product is what expanding gives if we replace α^2 by $\alpha + 1$.)

- (a) Write out the addition and multiplication tables of F .
- (b) Prove that F is a field.
- (c) Explain why there is no bijection $\varphi: F \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ with $\varphi(x + y) = \varphi(x) + \varphi(y)$ and $\varphi(xy) = \varphi(x)\varphi(y)$ for all $x, y \in F$. So this four-element field is not “ $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ in disguise”.

Hint: for (c), look for a non-zero element of $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ whose square is zero.

Solution.

- (a) Using the formulas, with $1 + 1 = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$: $\begin{array}{c|ccc} & 0 & 1 & \alpha & \beta \\ \hline 0 & 0 & 1 & \alpha & \beta \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & \beta & \alpha \\ \alpha & \alpha & \beta & 0 & 1 \\ \beta & \beta & \alpha & 1 & 0 \end{array}$

• $\alpha^2 = \alpha + 1$

$\alpha^3 = \alpha(\alpha + 1) = \alpha^2 + \alpha = (\alpha + 1) + \alpha = 1$

$\cdot$	0	1	α	β
0	0	0	0	0
1	0	1	α	β
α	0	α	β	1
β	0	β	1	α

] For instance, $\alpha \cdot \alpha = (0 + 1\alpha)(0 + 1\alpha) = (0 + 1) + (0 + 0 + 1)\alpha = 1 + \alpha = \beta$, and $\alpha\beta = (0 + 1\alpha)(1 + 1\alpha) = (0 + 1) + (0 + 1 + 1)\alpha = 1$.

- (b) Let $x = a + b\alpha$, $y = c + d\alpha$, $z = e + f\alpha$ with $a, \dots, f \in \mathbb{F}_2$. Since $\mathbb{F}_2$ is a field (Example (Arithmetic on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$)), we may compute with the coefficients using the rules of algebra.

Addition. It acts coordinate by coordinate, so (F1) and (F2) follow from the same laws in $\mathbb{F}_2$, the element $0 = 0 + 0\alpha$ satisfies (F3), and $-x = x$ satisfies (F4) because $a + a = 0$ and $b + b = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$.

(F6). The formula for xy is unchanged when (a, b) and (c, d) are swapped: $ac + bd = ca + db$ and $ad + bc + bd = cb + da + db$.

(F7). With $1 = 1 + 0\alpha$, $x \cdot 1 = (a + 0) + (0 + b + 0)\alpha = x$, and $1 \neq 0$ since the coefficients differ.

(F9). Since $y + z = (c + e) + (d + f)\alpha$,

$$x(y + z) = (a(c + e) + b(d + f)) + (a(d + f) + b(c + e) + b(d + f))\alpha,$$

and expanding the coefficients shows this is $((ac + bd) + (ae + bf)) + ((ad + bc + bd) + (af + be + bf))\alpha = xy + xz$.

(F5). Write $xy = g + h\alpha$ with $g = ac + bd$, $h = ad + bc + bd$. Then $(xy)z = (ge + hf) + (gf + he + hf)\alpha$. Expanding,

$$ge + hf = ace + adf + bcf + bde + bdf, \quad gf + he + hf = acf + ade + adf + bce + bcf + bde,$$

where in the second we used $bdf + bdf = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$. Similarly $yz = k + l\alpha$ with $k = ce + df$, $l = cf + de + df$, and $x(yz) = (ak + bl) + (al + bk + bl)\alpha$. Expanding gives $ak + bl = ace + adf + bcf + bde + bdf$ and $al + bk + bl = acf + ade + adf + bce + bcf + bde$, again using $bdf + bdf = 0$. Hence $(xy)z = x(yz)$.

(F8). From the table, $1 \cdot 1 = 1$, $\alpha\beta = 1$ and $\beta\alpha = 1$, so every non-zero element has an inverse.

This proves that F is a field.

- (c) Suppose such a bijection φ existed. First, $\varphi(0) = \varphi(0 + 0) = \varphi(0) + \varphi(0)$, so additive cancellation in $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ (adding $-\varphi(0)$, which only uses (F1)–(F4), valid there by Example (Arithmetic on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$)) gives $\varphi(0) = [0]$. Since φ is surjective, there is $x \in F$ with $\varphi(x) = [2]$. As $[2] \neq [0] = \varphi(0)$, we have $x \neq 0$. But

$$\varphi(x \cdot x) = \varphi(x)\varphi(x) = [2][2] = [4] = [0] = \varphi(0),$$

so $x \cdot x = 0$ because φ is injective. This contradicts Theorem 0.7.1 (f) in the field F (from (b)). Hence no such φ exists.

Exercise C2: Finite Fields Have Prime Characteristic.

- (a) Let F be a finite field. Prove that the characteristic of F is a prime p .
 (b) Let F be a field of characteristic $p > 0$. Prove that $p \cdot a = 0$ for every $a \in F$.

Hint: for (a), the elements $1 \cdot 1, 2 \cdot 1, 3 \cdot 1, \dots$ cannot all be different.

Solution.

- (a) The elements $m \cdot 1$ for $m = 1, 2, 3, \dots$ all lie in the finite set F , so they cannot all be distinct. Hence there are positive integers $k < m$ with $m \cdot 1 = k \cdot 1$. By Lemma 0.7.4, $m \cdot 1 = k \cdot 1 + (m - k) \cdot 1$, so $k \cdot 1 + (m - k) \cdot 1 = k \cdot 1 + 0$, and additive cancellation (Theorem 0.7.1 (b)) gives $(m - k) \cdot 1 = 0$ with $m - k \geq 1$. Therefore the characteristic of F is not 0. By Theorem 0.7.5, it is a prime p .
- (b) Let $a \in F$. By Lemma 0.7.4 and the definition of characteristic, $p \cdot a = (p \cdot 1) a = 0 \cdot a = 0$, where the last step is Theorem 0.7.1 (d).

Exercise C3: The Frobenius Identity.

Let p be a prime.

- (a) Let $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ with p dividing ab . Prove that p divides a or p divides b .
- (b) Deduce that p divides the binomial coefficient $\binom{p}{k}$ for $0 < k < p$.
- (c) Let F be a field of characteristic p . Prove that $(x + y)^p = x^p + y^p$ for all $x, y \in F$.

You may use the binomial theorem $(x + y)^n = \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} \cdot (x^k y^{n-k})$ in any field, with integer multiples as in Lemma 0.7.4; its inductive proof uses only the field axioms.

Hint: for (a), use Lemma 0.7.2. For (b), use $p! = \binom{p}{k} k! (p - k)!$.

Solution.

- (a) Suppose p does not divide a . A positive integer dividing p is 1 or p , so the only positive common divisor of a and p is 1. By Lemma 0.7.2 there are $x, y \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $ax + py = 1$. Multiplying by b , $b = (ab)x + p(by)$. Both terms on the right are divisible by p , the first because p divides ab . Hence p divides b .
- (b) First, by (a) and induction on the number of factors, if p divides a product of integers then it divides one of the factors. The integers $1, 2, \dots, p - 1$ are not divisible by p , so p divides neither $k!$ nor $(p - k)!$ for $0 < k < p$, and hence, by (a) once more, not their product. Now p divides $p! = \binom{p}{k} \cdot (k! (p - k)!)$. By (a), p divides $\binom{p}{k}$.
- (c) Let $x, y \in F$. By the binomial theorem,

$$(x + y)^p = x^p + y^p + \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} \binom{p}{k} \cdot (x^k y^{p-k}),$$

since $\binom{p}{0} = \binom{p}{p} = 1$. Fix $0 < k < p$. By (b), $\binom{p}{k} = pm$ for some $m \in \mathbb{N}$. By Lemma 0.7.4,

$$\binom{p}{k} \cdot (x^k y^{p-k}) = ((pm) \cdot 1)(x^k y^{p-k}) = (p \cdot 1)(m \cdot 1)(x^k y^{p-k}) = 0,$$

because $p \cdot 1 = 0$ in characteristic p and 0 times anything is 0 (Theorem 0.7.1 (d)). So every middle term vanishes, and $(x + y)^p = x^p + y^p$, as claimed.

0.8 Polynomials

We now have fields: number systems in which we can add, subtract, multiply and divide by anything non-zero. The next objects built on top of a field are polynomials. They will be everywhere in this book: as examples of vectors in Chapter 1, as the characteristic and minimal polynomials of a matrix later on, and as the reason some fields behave differently from others. This section says precisely what a polynomial is, introduces its degree, and explains why a polynomial is **not** the same thing as the function it defines.

0.8.1 What a polynomial is

At school, a polynomial is “an expression like $3x^2 - x + 2$ ”. That is a good picture, but it leaves one question open: what is x ? One tempting answer is that x is a number to be plugged in, so a polynomial is really a function. This answer breaks down as soon as we leave the familiar number systems.

Work over the field $\mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$ of [Example \(Arithmetic on \$\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}\$ and the Field \$\mathbb{F}_2\$ \)](#), where $1 + 1 = 0$. The expressions $x^2 + x$ and 0 look different. But if we plug in the two elements of $\mathbb{F}_2$, we get $0^2 + 0 = 0$ and $1^2 + 1 = 1 + 1 = 0$. As functions on $\mathbb{F}_2$, the two are the same. If a polynomial *were* its function, then $x^2 + x$ would be the zero polynomial, and it would have no sensible degree. We want $x^2 + x$ to be a genuine polynomial of degree 2, so we must define polynomials by their coefficients alone.

A polynomial is its list of coefficients, and nothing else.

Definition 0.8.1 — Polynomial

Let F be a field. A **polynomial over F** in the indeterminate x is a sequence $(a_0, a_1, a_2, \dots)$ of elements of F , indexed by $\mathbb{N}$, such that **only finitely many** a_k are non-zero. That is, there is some $N \in \mathbb{N}$ with $a_k = 0$ **for every** $k > N$.

The element a_k is the **coefficient of x^k** . We write the polynomial as

$$p = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + \cdots + a_Nx^N = \sum_{k=0}^N a_kx^k.$$

Two polynomials $p = \sum a_kx^k$ and $q = \sum b_kx^k$ are **equal** if and only if $a_k = b_k$ **for every** $k \in \mathbb{N}$.

In words: a polynomial is an infinite list of coefficients that is eventually all zero. The expression $\sum_{k=0}^N a_kx^k$ is only a way of displaying the list: x^k marks the position k , and we stop writing once the remaining coefficients are all zero. Two polynomials are equal exactly when they agree position by position. A sequence indexed by $\mathbb{N}$ is a function $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow F$, so this is just equality of functions in the sense of [Definition 0.4.1](#).

There is one thing to check about the notation. The number N in the display is not unique: if $a_k = 0$ for every $k > N$, the same is true for every $k > N + 1$. Writing $\sum_{k=0}^N a_kx^k$ or $\sum_{k=0}^{N+1} a_kx^k$ only adds a term $0 \cdot x^{N+1}$, which we agree to drop. So the display names the same sequence whichever admissible N we use. We also drop terms with zero coefficient in the middle, write x

for $1 \cdot x^1$, and write a_0 for a_0x^0 .

Example. (Polynomials over various fields)

Read off the coefficient sequence of each polynomial, and check it against [Definition 0.8.1](#).

$$3x^2 - x + 2 \in \mathbb{R}[x], \quad x^5 + \pi x^3 - \sqrt{2} \in \mathbb{R}[x], \quad (1+i)x - i \in \mathbb{C}[x], \quad x^2 + x \in \mathbb{F}_2[x], \quad 7, \quad 0.$$

(The symbol $F[x]$ for the set of all polynomials over F is defined formally in [Definition 0.8.2](#) below.)

Solution. The first is the sequence $(2, -1, 3, 0, 0, \dots)$ of real numbers. It has finitely many non-zero terms, so it is a polynomial over $\mathbb{R}$.

The second is $(-\sqrt{2}, 0, 0, \pi, 0, 1, 0, \dots)$. Its coefficients are real but irrational; the definition only asks that they lie in the field.

The third is $(-i, 1+i, 0, \dots)$, a polynomial over $\mathbb{C}$.

The fourth is $(0, 1, 1, 0, \dots)$ with entries in $\mathbb{F}_2$. It is **not** the zero sequence, so it is not the zero polynomial, even though it vanishes at both points of $\mathbb{F}_2$.

The constant 7 is the sequence $(7, 0, 0, \dots)$. It is a polynomial over $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ it would be $(1, 0, 0, \dots)$, because $7 = 1$ there.

The last, $0 = (0, 0, 0, \dots)$, is the **zero polynomial**. It is the degenerate case: every coefficient is zero, and the finiteness condition holds with $N = 0$. It matters because it is the one polynomial whose degree needs a special convention, as we will see.

Now the non-example, by a minimal change. Take the polynomial $1 + x + x^2$, whose sequence is $(1, 1, 1, 0, 0, \dots)$, and change every later 0 to 1. The result $(1, 1, 1, 1, \dots)$, informally “ $1 + x + x^2 + x^3 + \dots$ ”, is still a sequence of elements of $\mathbb{R}$. What fails is the clause **only finitely many** coefficients are non-zero, so this is **not** a polynomial. (It is a *formal power series*, which we will not need.) Expressions such as $x^{-1} + 1$ and $\sqrt{x}$ are not polynomials either: they are not of the form $\sum a_k x^k$ with $k \in \mathbb{N}$ at all.

Why insist on finitely many non-zero coefficients? Because we want to plug elements of the field into polynomials, which means forming the sum $\sum a_k c^k$, and in a field only finite sums make sense. Finiteness is also what gives every non-zero polynomial a highest power, its degree.

0.8.2 Adding and multiplying polynomials

The coefficient picture tells us how to add and multiply. Adding $3x^2 - x + 2$ and $x + 5$ at school means collecting like powers, so we add coefficients position by position. Multiplying means expanding every product $a_i x^i \cdot b_j x^j = a_i b_j x^{i+j}$ and collecting like powers, so the coefficient of x^k collects all pairs (i, j) with $i + j = k$.

Definition 0.8.2 — The polynomial ring $F[x]$

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Let F be a field. The set of **all** polynomials over F is denoted $F[x]$. For $p = \sum a_k x^k$ and $q = \sum b_k x^k$ in $F[x]$, define the **sum** $p + q$ and the **product** pq by their coefficients:

$$p + q = \sum_k (a_k + b_k) x^k, \quad pq = \sum_k \left(\sum_{i=0}^k a_i b_{k-i} \right) x^k.$$

We must check that $p + q$ and pq are again polynomials, that is, that their coefficient sequences are eventually zero. Suppose $a_i = 0$ for every $i > m$ and $b_j = 0$ for every $j > n$. If $k > \max(m, n)$, then $a_k + b_k = 0 + 0 = 0$. If $k > m + n$, then in each product $a_i b_{k-i}$ either $i > m$ or $k - i > n$, because otherwise $k = i + (k - i) \leq m + n$. So every term is 0, and the coefficient of x^k in pq is 0. Hence both are polynomials, and addition and multiplication are well defined on $F[x]$.

With this multiplication, $x \cdot x$ has coefficient sequence $(0, 0, 1, 0, \dots)$, and by induction on k the k -th power of the polynomial x is the sequence with a 1 in position k and 0 elsewhere. So the notation x^k in [Definition 0.8.1](#) agrees with the actual power, and $\sum a_k x^k$ is an honest sum of products.

Example. (A product, coefficient by coefficient)

In $\mathbb{R}[x]$, compute $(3x^2 - x + 2)(x + 1)$ from the definition.

Solution. Here $(a_0, a_1, a_2) = (2, -1, 3)$ and $(b_0, b_1) = (1, 1)$, with all other coefficients 0. The coefficient of x^k in the product is $\sum_{i=0}^k a_i b_{k-i}$:

$$\begin{aligned} k = 0 : a_0 b_0 &= 2, \\ k = 1 : a_0 b_1 + a_1 b_0 &= 2 - 1 = 1, \\ k = 2 : a_0 b_2 + a_1 b_1 + a_2 b_0 &= 0 - 1 + 3 = 2, \\ k = 3 : a_0 b_3 + a_1 b_2 + a_2 b_1 + a_3 b_0 &= 0 + 0 + 3 + 0 = 3, \end{aligned}$$

and every coefficient with $k \geq 4$ is 0 by the argument above (here $m + n = 3$). Hence $(3x^2 - x + 2)(x + 1) = 3x^3 + 2x^2 + x + 2$, which is what expanding by hand gives.

The operations obey the rules we expect. We record them once, so that later sections can use them freely.

Theorem 0.8.1 — Arithmetic in $F[x]$

]

Let F be a field and $p, q, r \in F[x]$. Then:

1. $p + q = q + p$ and $(p + q) + r = p + (q + r)$;
2. $p + 0 = p$, and $p + (-p) = 0$, where $-p = \sum (-a_k) x^k$;
3. $pq = qp$ and $(pq)r = p(qr)$;
4. $1 \cdot p = p$, where 1 is the constant polynomial $(1, 0, 0, \dots)$;
5. $p(q + r) = pq + pr$.

Idea. Two polynomials are equal when their coefficients agree, so each identity reduces to an identity between coefficients, which the field axioms supply. For products it helps to write the coefficient of x^k in pq symmetrically, as a sum over all pairs (i, j) of natural

numbers with $i + j = k$.

Proof. Let $p = \sum a_k x^k$, $q = \sum b_k x^k$ and $r = \sum c_k x^k$. By [Definition 0.8.1](#), it suffices to compare the coefficient of x^k on both sides, for each $k \in \mathbb{N}$.

Parts 1, 2 and 4 hold because in each position they are the corresponding field axioms of [Definition 0.7.1](#): for example, the coefficient of x^k in $p + q$ is $a_k + b_k = b_k + a_k$, the coefficient in $q + p$. For 4, the coefficient of x^k in $1 \cdot p$ is $\sum_{i+j=k} e_i a_j$ with $e_0 = 1$ and $e_i = 0$ for $i \geq 1$, which equals a_k .

For 3, the coefficient of x^k in pq is $\sum_{i+j=k} a_i b_j$. Since multiplication in F is commutative, this equals $\sum_{i+j=k} b_j a_i$, the coefficient in qp . Next, the coefficient of x^k in $(pq)r$ is

$$\sum_{s+l=k} \left(\sum_{i+j=s} a_i b_j \right) c_l = \sum_{i+j+l=k} a_i b_j c_l,$$

where the equality uses distributivity and associativity in F . The same computation for $p(qr)$ gives $\sum_{i+s=k} a_i \left(\sum_{j+l=s} b_j c_l \right) = \sum_{i+j+l=k} a_i b_j c_l$. Therefore $(pq)r = p(qr)$.

For 5, the coefficient of x^k in $p(q + r)$ is $\sum_{i+j=k} a_i (b_j + c_j) = \sum_{i+j=k} a_i b_j + \sum_{i+j=k} a_i c_j$ by distributivity in F , which is the coefficient in $pq + pr$. This proves the theorem. ■

A set with an addition and a multiplication satisfying these rules is called a **commutative ring**; this is where the name “polynomial ring” comes from. We will not need the word again in this chapter. What matters is that we may now calculate with polynomials exactly as at school.

Quick check. Over $\mathbb{R}$, are $(x + 1)^2$ and $x^2 + 2x + 1$ equal as polynomials? Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, are $(x + 1)^2$ and $x^2 + 1$ equal as polynomials?

Solution. Both answers are yes, but for a reason that depends on the field. Expanding gives $(x + 1)^2 = x^2 + 2x + 1$, with coefficient sequence $(1, 2, 1, 0, \dots)$. Over $\mathbb{R}$ this is exactly the sequence of $x^2 + 2x + 1$. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ we have $2 = 1 + 1 = 0$, so the sequence is $(1, 0, 1, 0, \dots)$, which is the sequence of $x^2 + 1$.

0.8.3 Degree

The most useful single number attached to a polynomial is the highest power of x that actually occurs. Every non-zero polynomial has one: it has at least one non-zero coefficient and only finitely many, so there is a largest position holding a non-zero coefficient. The zero polynomial has no such position, and we must decide what to do with it.

Definition 0.8.3 — Degree

Let $p = \sum a_k x^k \in F[x]$.

- If $p \neq 0$, the **degree** of p , written $\deg p$, is the **largest** $n \in \mathbb{N}$ with $a_n \neq 0$. The coefficient a_n is the **leading coefficient** of p , and p is **monic** if its leading coefficient is 1.

- The zero polynomial has degree $\deg 0 = -\infty$.

We use the conventions $-\infty < n$ and $-\infty + n = n + (-\infty) = -\infty$ for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$, and $-\infty + (-\infty) = -\infty$.

Examples, simplest first. A non-zero constant c has degree 0; its leading coefficient is c . The polynomial $x + 5 \in \mathbb{R}[x]$ is monic of degree 1. The polynomial $3x^3 + 2x^2 + x + 2$ from [Example \(A product, coefficient by coefficient\)](#) has degree 3 and leading coefficient 3. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, $x^2 + x$ has degree 2, even though it vanishes at every point of $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Why $-\infty$, and not 0 or -1 ? Look at the formula we expect: the degree of a product is the sum of the degrees. With $\deg 0 = 0$ it fails at once, since $0 \cdot x = 0$ would give $0 = \deg 0 = \deg 0 + \deg x = 1$. With $\deg 0 = -1$ it fails too: $-1 = \deg(0 \cdot x) \neq \deg 0 + \deg x = 0$. The formula needs $\deg 0 + n = \deg 0$ for every n , and $-\infty$ is exactly the symbol with that property. The convention keeps a formula true, and that is its only job.

It turns out that the degree of a sum is controlled by the larger degree, and the degree of a product is the sum of the degrees:

Theorem 0.8.2 — Degree of a sum

Let F be a field and $p, q \in F[x]$. Then

$$\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q),$$

with **equality** whenever $\deg p \neq \deg q$.

Proof. Let $p = \sum a_k x^k$, $q = \sum b_k x^k$ and $M = \max(\deg p, \deg q)$. If $M = -\infty$, then $p = q = 0$, so $p + q = 0$ and both sides are $-\infty$. Suppose $M \in \mathbb{N}$. For every $k > M$ we have $k > \deg p$ and $k > \deg q$, so $a_k = b_k = 0$ by [Definition 0.8.3](#). Hence the coefficient $a_k + b_k$ of x^k in $p + q$ is 0 for every $k > M$, and therefore $\deg(p + q) \leq M$.

Now suppose $\deg p \neq \deg q$; by symmetry we may assume $\deg p > \deg q$, so $M = \deg p \in \mathbb{N}$. Then $a_M \neq 0$ and $b_M = 0$, because $M > \deg q$. The coefficient of x^M in $p + q$ is $a_M + 0 = a_M \neq 0$, so $\deg(p + q) \geq M$. Together with the first part, $\deg(p + q) = M$. This proves the theorem. ■

The inequality can be strict: over any field, $\deg(x + (-x)) = \deg 0 = -\infty < 1$. The leading terms cancel. That is the only way the degree of a sum can drop.

Theorem 0.8.3 — Degree of a product

Let F be a field and $p, q \in F[x]$. Then

$$\deg(pq) = \deg p + \deg q.$$

If p and q are non-zero, the leading coefficient of pq is the product of their leading coefficients.

Idea. Expanding $(a_mx^m + \text{lower terms})(b_nx^n + \text{lower terms})$, the only way to reach x^{m+n} is $a_mx^m \cdot b_nx^n$, and nothing reaches beyond. So the top coefficient is a_mb_n . The one real question is whether a_mb_n could be 0. In a field it cannot, and this is exactly where the field axioms enter.

Proof. If $p = 0$ or $q = 0$, then $pq = 0$ by the definition of the product, so both sides equal $-\infty$ by the conventions in Definition 0.8.3. Suppose now $p = \sum a_kx^k$ and $q = \sum b_kx^k$ are non-zero, with $m = \deg p$ and $n = \deg q$. Then $a_m \neq 0$, $b_n \neq 0$, $a_i = 0$ for $i > m$ and $b_j = 0$ for $j > n$.

We showed after Definition 0.8.2 that the coefficient of x^k in pq is 0 for every $k > m+n$. For $k = m+n$, the coefficient is $\sum_{i+j=m+n} a_ib_j$. A term with $i > m$ has $a_i = 0$, and a term with $i < m$ has $j = m+n-i > n$, so $b_j = 0$. Hence only $i = m$, $j = n$ survives, and the coefficient is a_mb_n .

Since $a_m \neq 0$ and $b_n \neq 0$, Theorem 0.7.1 gives $a_mb_n \neq 0$, because a product of non-zero elements of a field is non-zero. Therefore $\deg(pq) = m+n$ and the leading coefficient of pq is a_mb_n , as claimed. ■

Warning. The field axioms are doing real work here. The same definitions make sense with coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$, which is **not** a field. There $(2x+1)(3x^2+x) = 6x^3+5x^2+x = 5x^2+x$, because $2 \cdot 3 = 6 = 0$. The factors have degrees 1 and 2, but the product has degree 2, not 3.

The first consequence is that polynomials over a field behave like integers: a product can only be zero if a factor is, and non-zero factors can be canceled.

Corollary 0.8.4 — No zero divisors in $F[x]$

]

Let F be a field and $p, q, r \in F[x]$.

1. If $pq = 0$, then $p = 0$ or $q = 0$.
2. If $pq = pr$ and $p \neq 0$, then $q = r$.

Proof. For 1, we prove the contrapositive. Suppose $p \neq 0$ and $q \neq 0$. Then $\deg p, \deg q \in \mathbb{N}$, so by Theorem 0.8.3, $\deg(pq) = \deg p + \deg q \in \mathbb{N}$. In particular $\deg(pq) \neq -\infty$, so $pq \neq 0$.

For 2, suppose $pq = pr$ and $p \neq 0$. By Theorem 0.8.1, $p(q-r) = pq - pr = 0$. By part 1 and $p \neq 0$, we get $q-r = 0$, that is, $q = r$. This proves the corollary. ■

Quick check. Let $p, q \in \mathbb{R}[x]$ with $\deg p = 3$ and $\deg q = 2$. What are $\deg(pq)$, $\deg(p+q)$ and $\deg(p^2)$? Can you say what $\deg(p-x^3)$ is?

Solution. By [Theorem 0.8.3](#), $\deg(pq) = 5$ and $\deg(p^2) = 6$. Since the degrees differ, [Theorem 0.8.2](#) gives $\deg(p+q) = 3$. The degree of $p-x^3$ is not determined: if the leading coefficient of p is 1, the x^3 terms cancel and the degree is at most 2 (it could even be $-\infty$ if $p = x^3$); otherwise it is 3.

0.8.4 Polynomials of bounded degree

In linear algebra we constantly need “all polynomials up to a given size”. For instance, the quadratics $ax^2 + bx + c$ are described by three numbers, much like points of $\mathbb{R}^3$. So we give such collections names.

Definition 0.8.4 — Polynomials of degree at most n

Let F be a field and $n \in \mathbb{N}$. The set of polynomials over F of degree **at most** n is

$$F[x]_{\leq n} = \{p \in F[x] : \deg p \leq n\} = \{a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_nx^n : a_0, \dots, a_n \in F\}.$$

The two descriptions agree: $\deg p \leq n$ says exactly that every coefficient beyond position n is zero, and the coefficients $a_0, \dots, a_n$ are then free, any of them allowed to be zero. In particular the zero polynomial lies in $F[x]_{\leq n}$, since $-\infty \leq n$.

Example. (Inside $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$)

Which of $3x^2 - 2x + 1$, $5x + 7$, -4 , 0 and $x^3 - x^3 + x$ lie in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$? Which lie in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 0}$?

Solution. All five lie in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$. Their degrees are 2, 1, 0, $-\infty$, and 1 (the last is the polynomial x , since $x^3 - x^3 = 0$ as polynomials). Only -4 and 0 lie in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 0}$, which is the set of constant polynomials, 0 included.

Sometimes we need the degree to be exactly n , for instance when we speak of “a quadratic” and mean that the x^2 term is really there.

Definition 0.8.5 — Polynomials of degree exactly n

Let F be a field and $n \in \mathbb{N}$. The set of polynomials over F of degree **exactly** n is

$$F[x]_{=n} = \{p \in F[x] : \deg p = n\} = \{a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_nx^n : a_0, \dots, a_n \in F, a_n \neq 0\}.$$

Example. (Comparing the two notations)

For each of $x^2 + 1$, $3x - 2$ and 0 , decide whether it lies in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ and whether it lies in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{=2}$.

Solution. The polynomial $x^2 + 1$ has degree 2, so it lies in both. The polynomial $3x - 2$ has degree $1 \leq 2$, so it lies in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ but **not** in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{=2}$. The zero polynomial has

degree $-\infty \leq 2$, so it lies in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$, but $-\infty \neq 2$, so it is **not** in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{=2}$. In general $F[x]_{\leq n} = F[x]_{=n} \cup F[x]_{\leq n-1}$ for $n \geq 1$, and the union is disjoint.

The two sets differ in one small clause, $a_n \neq 0$, and that clause changes their behavior completely.

Warning. $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is closed under addition, but $F[x]_{=n}$ is **not**. For example $x^2 + x$ and $-x^2 + 1$ both lie in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{=2}$, but their sum $x + 1$ has degree 1. The leading terms cancel. Also $F[x]_{=n}$ does not contain 0. In Chapter 1 this is why $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is a subspace and $F[x]_{=n}$ is not.

The positive half is [Theorem 0.8.2](#) at work: if $\deg p \leq n$ and $\deg q \leq n$, then $\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q) \leq n$. Multiplying by a constant $c \in F$ also cannot raise the degree, by [Theorem 0.8.3](#).

0.8.5 Evaluation and roots

A polynomial is not a function, but every polynomial *defines* a function: plug an element of the field in for x .

Definition 0.8.6 — Evaluation and roots

Let F be a field, $p = \sum_{k=0}^N a_k x^k \in F[x]$ and $c \in F$. The **value** of p at c is the element

$$p(c) = \sum_{k=0}^N a_k c^k = a_0 + a_1 c + \cdots + a_N c^N \in F,$$

where $c^0 = 1$. An element $c \in F$ is a **root** of p if $p(c) = 0$. The function $F \rightarrow F$, $c \mapsto p(c)$, is the **polynomial function** of p .

The value does not depend on the choice of N : enlarging N adds terms $0 \cdot c^k = 0$ (by [Theorem 0.7.1](#)), which do not change the sum. So $p(c)$ is well defined.

For example, $p = x^2 - 3x + 2 \in \mathbb{R}[x]$ has $p(0) = 2$ and $p(1) = 1 - 3 + 2 = 0$, so 1 is a root. Over $\mathbb{F}_3 = \{0, 1, 2\}$, the polynomial $x^3 + 2$ has $1^3 + 2 = 3 = 0$, so 1 is a root; the other two values are $0 + 2 = 2$ and $8 + 2 = 10 = 1$, so 1 is its only root in $\mathbb{F}_3$.

Evaluation turns the operations of $F[x]$ into the operations of F :

Theorem 0.8.5 — Evaluation respects sums and products

Let F be a field, $p, q \in F[x]$ and $c \in F$. Then

$$(p + q)(c) = p(c) + q(c), \quad (pq)(c) = p(c)q(c),$$

and the constant polynomial a has value a at c .

Proof. Let $p = \sum_{i=0}^m a_i x^i$ and $q = \sum_{j=0}^n b_j x^j$, where we choose m and n large enough that all non-zero coefficients are included. The statement about constants is immediate from [Definition 0.8.6](#). For sums, taking $N = \max(m, n)$ and padding with zero coefficients,

$(p + q)(c) = \sum_{k=0}^N (a_k + b_k)c^k = \sum_{k=0}^N a_k c^k + \sum_{k=0}^N b_k c^k$ by distributivity in F .

For products, all non-zero coefficients of pq occur at positions $k \leq m + n$, so

$$(pq)(c) = \sum_{k=0}^{m+n} \left(\sum_{i+j=k} a_i b_j \right) c^k = \sum_{i=0}^m \sum_{j=0}^n a_i b_j c^i c^j = \sum_{i=0}^m \sum_{j=0}^n (a_i c^i)(b_j c^j) = \left(\sum_{i=0}^m a_i c^i \right) \left(\sum_{j=0}^n b_j c^j \right),$$

where the first equality is [Definition 0.8.2](#), the second uses distributivity and $c^{i+j} = c^i c^j$ and regroups the pairs (i, j) , the third uses **commutativity** of multiplication in F to move c^i past b_j , and the last is distributivity again. This shows $(pq)(c) = p(c)q(c)$. ■

Note which step used commutativity. In the next section we will plug a square matrix A into a polynomial. Products of matrices do not commute in general, but the proof only moves **scalars** past powers of A , and multiplies powers of the same A ; both are still allowed for matrices, so the same identity will hold there.

As a first use, a root of a factor is a root of the product: if $q(c) = 0$, then $(pq)(c) = p(c) \cdot 0 = 0$. Conversely, if $(pq)(c) = 0$ then $p(c)q(c) = 0$, so $p(c) = 0$ or $q(c) = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#). This is how one solves $x^2 - 3x + 2 = (x - 1)(x - 2) = 0$ at school.

Now we can return to the question from the start of the section.

Example. (Different polynomials, same function)

Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, compare the polynomials $x^2 + x$ and 0, and the polynomials x^2 and x , both as polynomials and as functions $\mathbb{F}_2 \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2$.

Solution. As polynomials, $x^2 + x$ has coefficient sequence $(0, 1, 1, 0, \dots)$ and 0 has $(0, 0, 0, \dots)$. They differ in position 1, so $x^2 + x \neq 0$ by [Definition 0.8.1](#). Its degree is 2.

As functions, $\mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$ has two elements, and

$$0^2 + 0 = 0, \quad 1^2 + 1 = 1 + 1 = 0.$$

So the polynomial function of $x^2 + x$ is the zero function, the same as that of 0. Both elements of $\mathbb{F}_2$ are roots of a polynomial of degree 2 that is not the zero polynomial.

Similarly $x^2 \neq x$ as polynomials, but $0^2 = 0$ and $1^2 = 1$, so they define the same function. Indeed, by [Theorem 0.8.5](#), two polynomials define the same function exactly when their difference is a polynomial whose function is zero, and $x^2 - x = x^2 + x$ in $\mathbb{F}_2[x]$.

Warning. A polynomial is not a function. Two different polynomials can define the same polynomial function, as $x^2 + x$ and 0 do over $\mathbb{F}_2$. So “ $p(c) = 0$ for every $c \in F$ ” does **not** imply $p = 0$ in general, and we may never read off coefficients or a degree from the values alone. This happens over every finite field: if $F = \{c_1, \dots, c_q\}$, then $(x - c_1)(x - c_2) \cdots (x - c_q)$ has degree q by [Theorem 0.8.3](#), yet vanishes at every c_i by [Theorem 0.8.5](#). Over $\mathbb{F}_p$, [Exercise \(C2: A non-zero polynomial vanishing everywhere\)](#) below gives the shorter example $x^p - x$.

Over an infinite field such as $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$, the problem disappears: a polynomial whose function is zero is the zero polynomial, so polynomials and polynomial functions can be identified. We prove this in Chapter 2 (in the section on applications of linear systems), once we can count roots. Until then, whenever we say two polynomials are equal we mean their coefficients agree.

0.8.6 Looking ahead

Two tools will be built on this section later.

Remark. Division with remainder. Over a field, if $f, g \in F[x]$ and $g \neq 0$, there are unique $q, r \in F[x]$ with $f = qg + r$ and $\deg r < \deg g$. This is long division of polynomials, and the convention $\deg 0 = -\infty$ makes “ $\deg r < \deg g$ ” cover the case $r = 0$. We state it here only for orientation; it is proved in Chapter 5 and is not used before then.

Remark. Polynomials in a matrix. In the next section, once matrices and their products are available, we substitute a square matrix A for x , replacing the constant term a_0 by $a_0 I$. This is how the characteristic and minimal polynomials of later chapters act on matrices.

0.8.7 Exercises

0.8.7.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define the degree of a polynomial over a field F , including the zero polynomial. State the formula for $\deg(pq)$.
- Is $1 + x + x^2 + x^3 + \cdots$, with every coefficient equal to 1, a polynomial over $\mathbb{R}$? Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “for all $p, q \in F[x]$, $\deg(p+q) = \max(\deg p, \deg q)$.” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if $p \in \mathbb{F}_2[x]$ and $p(c) = 0$ for every $c \in \mathbb{F}_2$, then $p = 0$.” Justify your answer.
- Explain why $F[x]_{=2}$ is **not** closed under addition, while $F[x]_{\leq 2}$ is.

Solution.

- For $p = \sum a_k x^k \neq 0$, $\deg p$ is the largest n with $a_n \neq 0$; and $\deg 0 = -\infty$. For all $p, q \in F[x]$, $\deg(pq) = \deg p + \deg q$ ([Theorem 0.8.3](#)).
- No. Its coefficient sequence $(1, 1, 1, \dots)$ has infinitely many non-zero terms, so it fails the clause “only finitely many a_k are non-zero” of [Definition 0.8.1](#).
- False. Take $p = x$ and $q = -x$. Then $p + q = 0$ has degree $-\infty$, while $\max(\deg p, \deg q) = 1$. Only the inequality $\leq$ holds in general ([Theorem 0.8.2](#)).
- False. By [Example \(Different polynomials, same function\)](#), $p = x^2 + x$ satisfies $p(0) = p(1) = 0$, but $p \neq 0$.
- The sum of x^2 and $-x^2 + 1$, both of degree exactly 2, is 1, of degree 0. For $F[x]_{\leq 2}$: if $\deg p \leq 2$ and $\deg q \leq 2$, then $\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q) \leq 2$ by

Theorem 0.8.2.

0.8.7.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Sums, products and degrees.

- (a) In $\mathbb{R}[x]$, let $p = 2x^3 - x + 4$ and $q = -2x^3 + x^2 + 3$. Compute $p + q$ and pq , and give their degrees. Which inequality or formula from this section does each degree illustrate?
- (b) In $\mathbb{F}_3[x]$, compute $(x + 2)(x^2 + x + 1)$. Hence find all roots in $\mathbb{F}_3$ of the product.

Solution.

- (a) Adding coefficients gives $p + q = x^2 - x + 7$, of degree 2. Here $\deg p = \deg q = 3$ and the x^3 terms cancel, so the inequality of Theorem 0.8.2 is strict. Expanding,

$$pq = -4x^6 + 2x^5 + 2x^4 - 3x^3 + 4x^2 - 3x + 12,$$

of degree $6 = 3 + 3$, as Theorem 0.8.3 predicts; its leading coefficient is $2 \cdot (-2) = -4$.

- (b) Expanding, $(x + 2)(x^2 + x + 1) = x^3 + 3x^2 + 3x + 2$. In $\mathbb{F}_3$ we have $3 = 0$, so the product is $x^3 + 2$. By Theorem 0.8.5 and Theorem 0.7.1, c is a root of the product if and only if $c + 2 = 0$ or $c^2 + c + 1 = 0$. The first gives $c = 1$. For the second, the values at $0, 1, 2$ are $1, 3 = 0$ and $7 = 1$. Hence the only root in $\mathbb{F}_3$ is $c = 1$, which occurs in both factors.

Exercise B2: Degree of a composition.

For $p = \sum_{k=0}^m a_k x^k$ and q in $F[x]$, define the **composition** $p \circ q = \sum_{k=0}^m a_k q^k \in F[x]$, where $q^0 = 1$.

- (a) Prove that if p and q are non-constant, then $\deg(p \circ q) = \deg p \cdot \deg q$.
- (b) Give an example showing the formula fails when q is constant.

Hint: first find $\deg(q^k)$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $m = \deg p \geq 1$ and $d = \deg q \geq 1$, so $a_m \neq 0$. By Theorem 0.8.3 and induction on k (Theorem 0.2.7), $\deg(q^k) = kd$ for every $k \in \mathbb{N}$: the case $k = 0$ is $\deg 1 = 0$, and $\deg(q^{k+1}) = \deg(q^k) + \deg q = kd + d$. Hence, again by Theorem 0.8.3, $\deg(a_m q^m) = 0 + md = md$, and for $k < m$, $\deg(a_k q^k) \leq kd < md$ (it is kd or $-\infty$). Let $s = \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} a_k q^k$. Applying Theorem 0.8.2 $m - 1$ times gives $\deg s \leq \max_{k < m} \deg(a_k q^k) < md$. Since $\deg s \neq \deg(a_m q^m)$, the equality case of Theorem 0.8.2 gives $\deg(p \circ q) = \deg(s + a_m q^m) = md$. This proves $\deg(p \circ q) = \deg p \cdot \deg q$.
- (b) Take $p = x - 1$ and $q = 1$. Then $p \circ q = 1 - 1 = 0$ has degree $-\infty$, while $\deg p \cdot \deg q = 1 \cdot 0 = 0$.

Exercise B3: All small polynomials over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

List all polynomials in $\mathbb{F}_2[x]_{\leq 2}$. For each, give its degree and its polynomial function (the values at 0 and 1). Hence determine which of them define the zero function, and explain why every function $\mathbb{F}_2 \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2$ is the polynomial function of exactly two of them.

Solution. A polynomial $a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2$ with $a_i \in \mathbb{F}_2$ has value a_0 at 0 and $a_0 + a_1 + a_2$ at 1. With $2^3 = 8$ choices of coefficients:

polynomial	degree	value at 0	value at 1
0	$-\infty$	0	0
1	0	1	1
x	1	0	1
$x + 1$	1	1	0
x^2	2	0	1
$x^2 + 1$	2	1	0
$x^2 + x$	2	0	0
$x^2 + x + 1$	2	1	1

The zero function requires $a_0 = 0$ and $a_0 + a_1 + a_2 = 0$, that is, $a_0 = 0$ and $a_1 = a_2$. Hence exactly 0 and $x^2 + x$ define the zero function.

A function $f: \mathbb{F}_2 \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2$ is determined by the pair $(f(0), f(1))$. Given such a pair (u, v) , the polynomial $a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2$ defines f exactly when $a_0 = u$ and $a_1 + a_2 = v - u$. The first fixes a_0 , and for each of the two choices of a_2 the second fixes $a_1 = v - u - a_2$. Therefore exactly two of the eight polynomials define f , and the table confirms this.

0.8.7.3 C. Going deeper**Exercise C1: Roots of a quadratic.**

Let F be a field.

- Let $p = ax^2 + bx + c \in F[x]$ and $r \in F$ with $p(r) = 0$. Prove that $p = (x - r)(ax + (b + ar))$.
- Deduce that a non-zero polynomial in $F[x]_{\leq 2}$ has at most 2 roots in F .
- The same definitions make sense with coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z}$. Show that $x^2 - 1$ has four roots there, and name the step of (b) that breaks.

Hint for (b): use (a) together with [Theorem 0.8.5](#).

Solution.

- Since $p(r) = 0$, we have $ar^2 + br + c = 0$, so $c = -ar^2 - br$. Expanding with [Theorem 0.8.1](#),

$$(x - r)(ax + (b + ar)) = ax^2 + (b + ar)x - arx - r(b + ar) = ax^2 + bx - (br + ar^2) = ax^2 + bx + c = p.$$

- Let $p \neq 0$ with $\deg p \leq 2$. *Case 1.* $\deg p = 0$. Then $p = c \neq 0$ is constant and $p(r) = c \neq 0$ for every r , so p has no roots. *Case 2.* $\deg p = 1$, say $p = bx + c$

with $b \neq 0$. Then $p(r) = 0$ if and only if $r = -b^{-1}c$, so p has exactly one root. *Case 3.* $\deg p = 2$, say $p = ax^2 + bx + c$ with $a \neq 0$. If p has no root we are done. Otherwise let r be a root. By (a), $p = (x - r)q$ with $q = ax + (b + ar)$, of degree 1 since $a \neq 0$. Let s be any root of p . By [Theorem 0.8.5](#), $0 = p(s) = (s - r)q(s)$, so $s = r$ or $q(s) = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#). By Case 2, q has exactly one root. Hence every root of p is r or the root of q , and p has at most 2 roots. This proves the claim.

- (c) In $\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z}$, $1^2 = 1$, $3^2 = 9 = 1$, $5^2 = 25 = 1$ and $7^2 = 49 = 1$, so 1, 3, 5, 7 are four roots of $x^2 - 1$. The argument in (b) breaks at “ $(s - r)q(s) = 0$ implies $s - r = 0$ or $q(s) = 0$ ”: for $r = 1$, $s = 3$ we get $(3 - 1)(3 + 1) = 2 \cdot 4 = 0$ with both factors non-zero. That step needs the field property that a product of non-zero elements is non-zero.

Exercise C2: A non-zero polynomial vanishing everywhere.

Let p be a prime and $F = \mathbb{F}_p$.

- (a) Fix $a \in F \setminus \{0\}$. Prove that the map $F \setminus \{0\} \rightarrow F \setminus \{0\}$, $b \mapsto ab$, is a bijection.
- (b) Deduce that $a^{p-1} = 1$ for every $a \in F \setminus \{0\}$.
- (c) Hence show that the polynomial $x^p - x \in \mathbb{F}_p[x]$ is not the zero polynomial but that its polynomial function is the zero function.

Hint for (b): multiply together all the elements of $F \setminus \{0\}$ in two ways.

Solution.

- (a) The map lands in $F \setminus \{0\}$, since a product of non-zero elements of a field is non-zero ([Theorem 0.7.1](#)). It is injective: if $ab = ab'$, multiplying by a^{-1} gives $b = b'$. The set $F \setminus \{0\}$ is finite with $p - 1$ elements, so an injective map from it to itself is surjective by [Theorem 0.4.9](#), hence bijective.
- (b) Let P be the product of all $p - 1$ elements of $F \setminus \{0\}$; it is non-zero by [Theorem 0.7.1](#). Since $b \mapsto ab$ is a bijection by (a), the elements ab , as b runs over $F \setminus \{0\}$, are the same elements in a different order. Multiplication in F is commutative and associative, so the product does not depend on the order, and

$$P = \prod_{b \neq 0} (ab) = a^{p-1} \prod_{b \neq 0} b = a^{p-1} P.$$

Multiplying by P^{-1} gives $a^{p-1} = 1$.

- (c) The coefficient of x^p in $x^p - x$ is $1 \neq 0$, so the polynomial is non-zero, of degree p . For its function: $0^p - 0 = 0$, and for $a \neq 0$, (b) gives $a^p - a = a \cdot a^{p-1} - a = a - a = 0$. Hence every element of $\mathbb{F}_p$ is a root, and the polynomial function of $x^p - x$ is the zero function. For $p = 2$ this is $x^2 - x = x^2 + x$, the polynomial of [Example \(Different polynomials, same function\)](#).

Exercise C3: Which polynomials have inverses?.

- (a) Let F be a field and $p, q \in F[x]$ with $pq = 1$. Prove that p and q are non-zero constants.

(b) Show that (a) fails with coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$ by computing $(2x + 1)^2$ there.

Solution.

- (a) Since $pq = 1 \neq 0$, neither p nor q is the zero polynomial, so $\deg p, \deg q \in \mathbb{N}$. By [Theorem 0.8.3](#), $\deg p + \deg q = \deg 1 = 0$. Two natural numbers with sum 0 are both 0, so $\deg p = \deg q = 0$. Therefore p and q are non-zero constants.
- (b) In $\mathbb{Z}/4\mathbb{Z}$, $(2x + 1)^2 = 4x^2 + 4x + 1 = 1$, because $4 = 0$. So $2x + 1$ has degree 1 and is its own inverse. The proof of (a) breaks at [Theorem 0.8.3](#), which fails here because the leading coefficient $2 \cdot 2 = 4 = 0$.

0.9 Matrices

You have probably met matrices as tables of numbers that are multiplied by a strange rule. This section rebuilds them over an arbitrary field F and answers the questions a computational course leaves open. Why is the product defined the way it is? Which rules of school algebra survive, and which fail? What does it mean to divide by a matrix? Everything later in the book, from Gaussian elimination in Chapter 2 to the matrix of a linear map in Chapter 3, rests on the answers.

Throughout, F is a field ([Definition 0.7.1](#)). Nothing here uses more about F than the field axioms, so every statement holds over $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$ and $\mathbb{F}_p$ alike.

0.9.1 Matrices and their entries

Definition 0.9.1 — Matrix

Let F be a field and $m, n \geq 1$ integers. An $m \times n$ **matrix over** F is a rectangular array

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} & \cdots & a_{1n} \\ a_{21} & a_{22} & \cdots & a_{2n} \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ a_{m1} & a_{m2} & \cdots & a_{mn} \end{pmatrix}$$

with m rows and n columns, whose **entries** a_{ij} lie in F . Formally, it is a function $\{1, \dots, m\} \times \{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow F$, $(i, j) \mapsto a_{ij}$. The set of all such matrices is $M_{m \times n}(F)$, and we write $M_n(F) = M_{n \times n}(F)$ for the **square** matrices.

The entry a_{ij} sits in row i and column j : **row first, column second**. We write $A = (a_{ij})$, and $(A)_{ij}$ for the (i, j) -entry when the matrix has no letter of its own. Two matrices are **equal** when they have the **same size** and the same entry in every position; this is equality of functions ([Definition 0.4.1](#)).

Two sizes deserve their own names. A matrix in $M_{n \times 1}(F)$ is a **column vector**, and we write

$$F^n = M_{n \times 1}(F), \quad \mathbf{x} = \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

In running text we write $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$ and still mean a column. Columns are printed in bold. A matrix in $M_{1 \times n}(F)$ is a **row vector**. For $j = 1, \dots, n$, the column $\mathbf{e}_j \in F^n$ has 1 in position j and 0 elsewhere.

We will often cut a matrix into its columns. If $\mathbf{a}_j = (a_{1j}, \dots, a_{mj}) \in F^m$ is the j -th column of A , we write

$$A = (\mathbf{a}_1 \quad \mathbf{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \mathbf{a}_n).$$

The i -th row of A is the row vector $(a_{i1} \quad \cdots \quad a_{in}) \in M_{1 \times n}(F)$.

Example. (Matrices over different fields)

Identify the size, the field and a few entries of each matrix:

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 4 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} i & 1+i \\ 0 & 2-i \end{pmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad D = (5).$$

Here C is meant over $\mathbb{F}_2$. Also write out the 2×2 real matrix E with $e_{ij} = i + 2j$.

Solution. $A \in M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$, with $a_{12} = -2$ and $a_{23} = 4$; its second column is $\mathbf{a}_2 = (-2, 1)$. $B \in M_2(\mathbb{C})$, with $b_{12} = 1+i$ and $b_{21} = 0$. $C \in M_3(\mathbb{F}_2)$; every entry is 0 or 1. $D \in M_1(\mathbb{R})$ is the degenerate case, a 1×1 matrix. It behaves exactly like the number 5, and 1×1 matrices are how numbers will appear inside matrix formulas. Finally $e_{11} = 3$, $e_{12} = 5$, $e_{21} = 4$, $e_{22} = 6$, so $E = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 5 \\ 4 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$. Swapping the roles of i and j would give a different matrix, which is why the order “row, column” matters.

0.9.2 Special matrices

A few shapes of matrix occur so often that they have names. The **main diagonal** of a square matrix $A \in M_n(F)$ consists of the entries $a_{11}, a_{22}, \dots, a_{nn}$.

Definition 0.9.2 — Zero matrix

The **zero matrix** $0 = 0_{m \times n} \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is the matrix all of whose entries are 0.

Definition 0.9.3 — Identity matrix

The **identity matrix** $I_n \in M_n(F)$ has entries

$$(I_n)_{ij} = \delta_{ij} = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } i = j, \\ 0 & \text{if } i \neq j. \end{cases}$$

That is, 1 on the main diagonal and 0 elsewhere. We write I when the size is clear. The symbol δ_{ij} is the **Kronecker delta**.

The columns of I_n are exactly $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n$.

Definition 0.9.4 — Diagonal matrix

A square matrix $A \in M_n(F)$ is **diagonal** if $a_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i \neq j$. We write $\text{diag}(d_1, \dots, d_n)$ for the diagonal matrix with diagonal entries $d_1, \dots, d_n$.

Definition 0.9.5 — Upper triangular matrix

A square matrix $A \in M_n(F)$ is **upper triangular** if $a_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i > j$, that is, every entry **strictly below** the main diagonal is zero. It is **lower triangular** if $a_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i < j$.

Example. (Zero and identity matrices)

Write out $0_{2 \times 3}$, I_2 and I_3 . Which of them are diagonal?

Solution.

$$0_{2 \times 3} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad I_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad I_3 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

$I_2 = \text{diag}(1, 1)$ and $I_3 = \text{diag}(1, 1, 1)$ are diagonal. The matrix $0_{2 \times 3}$ is **not** diagonal, because the definition only applies to square matrices; the square zero matrix $0_{n \times n} = \text{diag}(0, \dots, 0)$ is diagonal.

Example. (Diagonal and triangular)

Classify each matrix as diagonal, upper triangular, lower triangular, or none of these:

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Q = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 4 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & 6 \end{pmatrix}, \quad R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 4 & 5 \\ 0 & 7 & 6 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Solution. $P = \text{diag}(3, -1, 0)$ is diagonal. A zero on the diagonal is allowed: the definition only constrains off-diagonal entries. P is also both upper and lower triangular, and in general a matrix is diagonal exactly when it is both. Q is upper triangular but not lower triangular, since $q_{12} = 2 \neq 0$. R differs from Q in one entry, $r_{32} = 7$. All other entries below the diagonal are still zero, but the clause “ $a_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i > j$ ” fails at $(i, j) = (3, 2)$, so R is not upper triangular. It is not lower triangular either.

0.9.3 Addition and scalar multiplication

Matrices of the same size are added, and multiplied by scalars, one entry at a time.

Definition 0.9.6 — Matrix addition

Let $A = (a_{ij})$ and $B = (b_{ij})$ be in $M_{m \times n}(F)$, of the **same size**. Their **sum** is $A + B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ with $(A + B)_{ij} = a_{ij} + b_{ij}$.

Definition 0.9.7 — Scalar multiplication

Let $A = (a_{ij}) \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $c \in F$. The **scalar multiple** $cA \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ has entries $(cA)_{ij} = c a_{ij}$.

Definition 0.9.8 — Additive inverse

The **additive inverse** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is $-A = (-1)A$, with entries $-a_{ij}$. We write $A - B = A + (-B)$.

Matrices of different sizes are never added: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$ is not defined.

Example. (Adding and scaling)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 2 & -1 \\ 0 & -5 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ in $M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$. Compute $A + B$, $3A$ and $A - 2B$.

Solution. Entry by entry,

$$A+B = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 0 & -1 \\ 3 & -4 & 5 \end{pmatrix}, \quad 3A = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & -6 & 0 \\ 9 & 3 & 12 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A-2B = \begin{pmatrix} 1-4 & -2-4 & 0+2 \\ 3-0 & 1+10 & 4-2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -3 & -6 & 2 \\ 3 & 11 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Because both operations work entry by entry, they inherit the rules of F :

Theorem 0.9.1 — Properties of addition and scalar multiplication

Let $A, B, C \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $c, d \in F$. Then:

1. $A + B = B + A$;
2. $(A + B) + C = A + (B + C)$;
3. $A + 0 = A$;
4. $A + (-A) = 0$;
5. $c(A + B) = cA + cB$ and $(c + d)A = cA + dA$;
6. $(cd)A = c(dA)$ and $1A = A$.

Proof. Two matrices of the same size are equal when their entries agree, so it suffices to compare (i, j) -entries. For 1, $(A + B)_{ij} = a_{ij} + b_{ij} = b_{ij} + a_{ij} = (B + A)_{ij}$, where the middle equality is commutativity of addition in F . For 5, $(c(A + B))_{ij} = c(a_{ij} + b_{ij}) = ca_{ij} + cb_{ij} = (cA + cB)_{ij}$ by distributivity in F . Each remaining identity reduces in the same way to the corresponding field axiom of Definition 0.7.1 in each entry. This proves the theorem. ■

These eight rules will reappear in Chapter 1 as the axioms of a vector space: $M_{m \times n}(F)$ is one of our standard examples.

0.9.4 Matrix multiplication

Addition was entrywise. The obvious guess for multiplication is also entrywise, but that product is almost useless. The product that matters is the one that records **substitution**, and it looks very different.

Suppose new variables y_1, y_2 are given in terms of x_1, x_2 , and z_1, z_2 in terms of y_1, y_2 :

$$\begin{aligned} y_1 &= 2x_1 + x_2 & z_1 &= y_1 + 2y_2 \\ y_2 &= x_1 + 4x_2 & z_2 &= 3y_1 - y_2 \end{aligned}$$

Record each substitution by its table of coefficients: $B = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ for $\mathbf{y}$ in terms of $\mathbf{x}$, and $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$ for $\mathbf{z}$ in terms of $\mathbf{y}$. Substituting,

$$\begin{aligned} z_1 &= (2x_1 + x_2) + 2(x_1 + 4x_2) = (1 \cdot 2 + 2 \cdot 1)x_1 + (1 \cdot 1 + 2 \cdot 4)x_2 = 4x_1 + 9x_2, \\ z_2 &= 3(2x_1 + x_2) - (x_1 + 4x_2) = (3 \cdot 2 + (-1) \cdot 1)x_1 + (3 \cdot 1 + (-1) \cdot 4)x_2 = 5x_1 - x_2. \end{aligned}$$

So $\mathbf{z}$ in terms of $\mathbf{x}$ has coefficient table $\begin{pmatrix} 4 & 9 \\ 5 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$. Look at how each entry arose: the coefficient of x_k in z_i is $a_{i1}b_{1k} + a_{i2}b_{2k}$, row i of A against column k of B . The entrywise product $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 2 \\ 3 & -4 \end{pmatrix}$ has nothing to do with the substitution. This forces the definition.

To multiply matrices, run each row of the first against each column of the second: the product of two matrices is the table of the combined substitution.

Definition 0.9.9 — Matrix multiplication

Let $A = (a_{ij}) \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B = (b_{jk}) \in M_{n \times p}(F)$, so that **the number of columns of A equals the number of rows of B** . Their **product** is the matrix $AB \in M_{m \times p}(F)$ with entries

$$(AB)_{ik} = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij}b_{jk} = a_{i1}b_{1k} + a_{i2}b_{2k} + \cdots + a_{in}b_{nk}$$

for $1 \leq i \leq m$ and $1 \leq k \leq p$. If the sizes do not match, AB is **not defined**.

In words: to get the (i, k) -entry of AB , walk along row i of A and down column k of B at the same time, multiply the entries you meet in pairs, and add. The size condition says that the row and the column have the same length n , so the pairing makes sense. The product has as many rows as A and as many columns as B :

$$\begin{matrix} A & B & = & AB \\ m \times n & n \times p & & m \times p \end{matrix}$$

In particular, for $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and a column $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$, the product $A\mathbf{x} \in F^m$ is defined, with i -th entry $a_{i1}x_1 + \cdots + a_{in}x_n$. A system of m linear equations in n unknowns is therefore a single equation $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$.

Example. (A product of square matrices)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$. Compute AB and BA .

Solution. Row i of A against column k of B :

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} 2 \cdot 1 + (-1)(-2) & 2 \cdot 4 + (-1) \cdot 1 \\ 0 \cdot 1 + 3 \cdot (-2) & 0 \cdot 4 + 3 \cdot 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & 7 \\ -6 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad BA = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \cdot 2 + 4 \cdot 0 & 1 \cdot (-1) + 4 \cdot 3 \\ -2 \cdot 2 + 1 \cdot 0 & (-2)(-1) + 1 \cdot 3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 11 \\ -4 & 5 \end{pmatrix}$$

Both products are defined, and they are different.

Example. (Products of rectangular matrices)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 \\ -1 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$. Determine the sizes of AB and BA and compute them. Then compute $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 3 \\ 4 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 3 \\ 4 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$.

Solution. AB is $(2 \times 3)(3 \times 2)$, so it is 2×2 ; BA is $(3 \times 2)(2 \times 3)$, so it is 3×3 . Computing row against column,

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} 3 + 0 + 2 & 1 + 0 + 0 \\ -3 + 6 + 1 & -1 + 3 + 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 5 & 1 \\ 4 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad BA = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 3 & 7 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \\ 1 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

For instance $(BA)_{13} = 3 \cdot 2 + 1 \cdot 1 = 7$. The last two products show the extreme cases: a row times a column is 1×1 , namely $(1 \cdot 3 + 2 \cdot 4) = (11)$, while a column times a row is 2×2 , namely $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 6 \\ 4 & 8 \end{pmatrix}$.

Here is a non-example by minimal change. Take the same six entries as B , but arrange them in two rows: $C = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$. The entries are still real numbers and A is unchanged. But A has 3 columns and C has 2 rows, so forming AC would pair a row of length 3 with a column of length 2. The clause “the number of columns of A equals the number of rows of B ” fails, and AC is **not defined**.

Why this definition, and not the entrywise one? Because it is the only rule under which “the

table of a combined substitution is the product of the tables". In Chapter 3 the same fact becomes: the matrix of a composition of linear maps is the product of their matrices. Every property of matrix multiplication, good or bad, comes from this.

0.9.5 Three views of a product

The entry formula is how one computes a product by hand, but it hides the structure. Two other descriptions, by columns and by rows, are what we will actually think with. It turns out that multiplying by A on the left acts on each column of B separately, and multiplying by B on the right acts on each row of A separately:

Theorem 0.9.2 — Three views of a product

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B \in M_{n \times p}(F)$, and write $B = (\mathbf{b}_1 \ \cdots \ \mathbf{b}_p)$ with columns $\mathbf{b}_k \in F^n$. Then:

1. **(Entries)** $(AB)_{ik} = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij}b_{jk}$ for all i, k ;
2. **(Columns)** the k -th column of AB is $A\mathbf{b}_k$, that is,

$$AB = (A\mathbf{b}_1 \ A\mathbf{b}_2 \ \cdots \ A\mathbf{b}_p);$$

3. **(Rows)** the i -th row of AB is (row i of A) B .

Proof. Part 1 is [Definition 0.9.9](#). For part 2, fix k . The column $\mathbf{b}_k$ has entries $b_{1k}, \dots, b_{nk}$, so by [Definition 0.9.9](#) the i -th entry of $A\mathbf{b}_k \in F^m$ is $\sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij}b_{jk}$. By part 1 this is $(AB)_{ik}$, the i -th entry of the k -th column of AB . Hence the k -th column of AB is $A\mathbf{b}_k$.

For part 3, fix i , and let $\mathbf{r} = (a_{i1} \ \cdots \ a_{in})$ be row i of A . Then $\mathbf{r}B$ is a $1 \times p$ matrix whose k -th entry is $\sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij}b_{jk} = (AB)_{ik}$, again by [Definition 0.9.9](#). This is the k -th entry of row i of AB . This proves the theorem. ■

The column view reduces every matrix product to products $A\mathbf{x}$ of a matrix with a single column. So it pays to understand $A\mathbf{x}$ well, and here is the fact to understand:

Theorem 0.9.3 — $A\mathbf{x}$ is a combination of the columns of A

Let $A = (\mathbf{a}_1 \ \cdots \ \mathbf{a}_n) \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ with columns $\mathbf{a}_j \in F^m$, and let $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in F^n$. Then

$$A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + x_2\mathbf{a}_2 + \cdots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n.$$

In particular $A\mathbf{e}_j = \mathbf{a}_j$ for each j . Similarly, if $\mathbf{r}_1, \dots, \mathbf{r}_m$ are the rows of A and $\mathbf{y} = (y_1 \ \cdots \ y_m)$ is a row vector, then $\mathbf{y}A = y_1\mathbf{r}_1 + \cdots + y_m\mathbf{r}_m$.

Proof. Both sides are in F^m , so we compare i -th entries. By [Definition 0.9.9](#), the i -th entry of $A\mathbf{x}$ is $\sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij}x_j$. On the right, the i -th entry of $x_j\mathbf{a}_j$ is x_ja_{ij} by [Definition 0.9.7](#), so by [Definition 0.9.6](#) the i -th entry of $\sum_j x_j\mathbf{a}_j$ is $\sum_{j=1}^n x_ja_{ij}$. These agree because multiplication in F is commutative. Taking $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_j$, whose only non-zero entry is $x_j = 1$,

gives $A\mathbf{e}_j = \mathbf{a}_j$. The statement for rows follows in the same way, comparing the k -th entries $\sum_i y_i a_{ik}$. This proves the theorem. ■

Read the formula as a sentence: **the entries of $\mathbf{x}$ are the weights, and the columns of A are what gets weighted**. So $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a solution exactly when $\mathbf{b}$ can be built from the columns of A . This single observation drives much of Chapters 2 and 3. Combined with [Theorem 0.9.2](#), it also says that **every column of AB is a combination of the columns of A** , with weights taken from the corresponding column of B , and **every row of AB is a combination of the rows of B** .

Example. (One product, three ways)

Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & -1 \\ 0 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R}), \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R}), \quad \mathbf{x} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Compute $A\mathbf{x}$ as a combination of the columns of A . Then compute AB by columns, check one row by the row view, and check one entry by the entry formula.

Solution. The columns of A are $\mathbf{a}_1 = (1, 3, 0)$ and $\mathbf{a}_2 = (2, -1, 4)$. By [Theorem 0.9.3](#),

$$A\mathbf{x} = 2\mathbf{a}_1 - \mathbf{a}_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 6 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} - \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ -1 \\ 4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 7 \\ -4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Columns. The first column of B is $\mathbf{b}_1 = (2, -1) = \mathbf{x}$, so the first column of AB is $A\mathbf{b}_1 = (0, 7, -4)$, just computed. The second column is $\mathbf{b}_2 = (1, 1)$, so $A\mathbf{b}_2 = \mathbf{a}_1 + \mathbf{a}_2 = (3, 2, 4)$. Hence

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 3 \\ 7 & 2 \\ -4 & 4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Rows. Row 2 of A is $(3 \ -1)$, and by [Theorem 0.9.3](#) (rows version) $(3 \ -1)B = 3(2 \ 1) - (-1 \ 1) = (7 \ 2)$, which is row 2 of AB .

Entries. $(AB)_{32} = a_{31}b_{12} + a_{32}b_{22} = 0 \cdot 1 + 4 \cdot 1 = 4$, as in the answer.

The column view needed nothing beyond scaling and adding columns of A . When the columns of B are simple, it is usually the fastest route.

Quick check. Without multiplying out, what is the second column of $\begin{pmatrix} 5 & -1 & 7 \\ 2 & 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \\ 4 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$?

Solution. The second column of the right factor is $\mathbf{e}_3 = (0, 0, 1)$. By [Theorem 0.9.2](#) and [Theorem 0.9.3](#), the second column of the product is $A\mathbf{e}_3$, the third column of the left factor: $(7, 3)$.

0.9.6 The rules of multiplication

Matrix multiplication keeps the most important rules of arithmetic: associativity, both distributive laws, and an identity.

Theorem 0.9.4 — Properties of matrix multiplication

Let $c \in F$, and let $A, A' \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, $B, B' \in M_{n \times p}(F)$ and $C \in M_{p \times q}(F)$. Then:

1. **(Associativity)** $(AB)C = A(BC)$;
2. **(Distributivity)** $A(B + B') = AB + AB'$ and $(A + A')B = AB + A'B$;
3. **(Identity)** $I_m A = A = A I_n$;
4. **(Scalars)** $c(AB) = (cA)B = A(cB)$;
5. **(Zero)** $0_{\ell \times m} A = 0_{\ell \times n}$ and $A 0_{n \times r} = 0_{m \times r}$ for all $\ell, r \geq 1$.

Idea. Each identity is checked entry by entry. The only one with content is associativity. Both sides have (i, l) -entry equal to the double sum $\sum_j \sum_k a_{ij} b_{jk} c_{kl}$, added up in two different orders, so the proof is “expand, swap the order of the finite sums, and fold back up”. In the substitution picture it is no surprise: substituting in two stages gives the same result whichever pair of stages we combine first.

Proof. For 1, both sides lie in $M_{m \times q}(F)$. Fix i and l . By Definition 0.9.9 applied twice,

$$((AB)C)_{il} = \sum_{k=1}^p (AB)_{ik} c_{kl} = \sum_{k=1}^p \left(\sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} b_{jk} \right) c_{kl} = \sum_{k=1}^p \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} b_{jk} c_{kl},$$

where the last step uses distributivity in F . The same computation gives

$$(A(BC))_{il} = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} (BC)_{jl} = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} \left(\sum_{k=1}^p b_{jk} c_{kl} \right) = \sum_{j=1}^n \sum_{k=1}^p a_{ij} b_{jk} c_{kl}.$$

The two double sums add the same np terms in different orders, so they are equal, by commutativity and associativity of addition in F . Hence $(AB)C = A(BC)$.

For 2, $(A(B + B'))_{ik} = \sum_j a_{ij} (b_{jk} + b'_{jk}) = \sum_j a_{ij} b_{jk} + \sum_j a_{ij} b'_{jk} = (AB + AB')_{ik}$ by distributivity in F ; the other law is the same with the roles of the factors swapped.

For 3, $(I_m A)_{ik} = \sum_{j=1}^m \delta_{ij} a_{jk} = a_{ik}$, because by Definition 0.9.3 only the term $j = i$ survives. Likewise $(A I_n)_{ik} = \sum_j a_{ij} \delta_{jk} = a_{ik}$.

For 4, $(c(AB))_{ik} = c \sum_j a_{ij} b_{jk} = \sum_j (ca_{ij}) b_{jk} = ((cA)B)_{ik}$, and moving c next to b_{jk} instead, using commutativity in F , gives $(A(cB))_{ik}$. For 5, every term $0 \cdot a_{jk}$ or $a_{ij} \cdot 0$ is 0 by Theorem 0.7.1. This proves the theorem. ■

Associativity means we may write ABC without brackets, and more generally a product of any number of matrices, as long as consecutive sizes match.

Just as important is what is **missing** from the list. There is no commutative law, and no cancellation law. Each of the following failures will cost you a wrong proof if you forget it.

Warning. $AB \neq BA$ in general. Take $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Then $AB = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ but $BA = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Before swapping two factors in a proof, you must know that they commute. (And if A is 2×3 and B is 3×2 , then AB and BA do not even have the same size.)

Warning. **A product can be zero with both factors non-zero.** In $M_2(\mathbb{R})$,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

So $M_n(F)$ is not a field for $n \geq 2$, and “ $AB = 0$ implies $A = 0$ or $B = 0$ ” is false.

Warning. **Cancellation fails: $AC = BC$ does not imply $A = B$.** With

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 9 \end{pmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

we get $AC = BC = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 3 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ although $A \neq B$. By the column view, both columns of C are $\mathbf{e}_1$, so AC and BC only see the first columns of A and B , which agree. Canceling C is legal only when C is invertible, as we will see below.

Quick check. Find a non-zero $A \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ with $A^2 = AA = 0$.

Solution. Take $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. By the column view, $A\mathbf{e}_1 = \mathbf{0}$ and $A\mathbf{e}_2 = \mathbf{e}_1$, so the columns of A^2 are $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ and $A\mathbf{e}_1 = \mathbf{0}$. Hence $A^2 = 0$ although $A \neq 0$. This small matrix is the source of a remarkable number of counterexamples in this book; it will reappear often.

0.9.7 The transpose

Rows and columns play symmetric roles in a matrix, and the transpose exchanges them.

Definition 0.9.10 — Transpose

Let $A = (a_{ij}) \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. The **transpose** of A is the matrix $A^\top \in M_{n \times m}(F)$ with entries

$$(A^\top)_{ij} = a_{ji}.$$

In words: row i of A becomes column i of $A^\top$, and the size flips from $m \times n$ to $n \times m$. A square matrix is reflected in its main diagonal.

Definition 0.9.11 — Symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices

A square matrix $A \in M_n(F)$ is **symmetric** if $A^\top = A$, that is, $a_{ij} = a_{ji}$ for all i, j . It

is **skew-symmetric** if $A^\top = -A$, that is, $a_{ij} = -a_{ji}$ for all i, j .

Example. (Transposes, symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices)

Compute the transpose of $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$. Decide whether

$$S = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 4 & 5 \\ 3 & 5 & 6 \end{pmatrix}, \quad K = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2 & -1 \\ -2 & 0 & 3 \\ 1 & -3 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad S' = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 4 & 5 \\ 3 & 6 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$$

over $\mathbb{R}$ are symmetric or skew-symmetric.

Solution. The rows of A become columns: $A^\top = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ -2 & 1 \\ 0 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$.

S is symmetric: $s_{12} = s_{21} = 2$, $s_{13} = s_{31} = 3$, $s_{23} = s_{32} = 5$. K is skew-symmetric: $k_{12} = 2 = -k_{21}$, $k_{13} = -1 = -k_{31}$, $k_{23} = 3 = -k_{32}$, and each diagonal entry satisfies $k_{ii} = -k_{ii}$, so it is 0. The matrix S' differs from S only in the entry $(3, 2)$. Every other symmetric pair still matches, but $s'_{23} = 5 \neq 6 = s'_{32}$, so S' is **not** symmetric. A 1×1 matrix is always symmetric, and the identity I_n and every diagonal matrix are symmetric.

Over $\mathbb{R}$, a skew-symmetric matrix has zero diagonal, since $a_{ii} = -a_{ii}$ forces $2a_{ii} = 0$. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, where $-1 = 1$, “skew-symmetric” and “symmetric” mean the same thing, and I_2 is skew-symmetric. The characteristic of the field (Definition 0.7.2) matters.

The transpose is compatible with the operations, except that it **reverses** products:

Theorem 0.9.5 — Properties of the transpose

Let $c \in F$. For matrices of sizes for which each expression is defined:

1. $(A^\top)^\top = A$;
2. $(A + B)^\top = A^\top + B^\top$;
3. $(cA)^\top = cA^\top$;
4. $(AB)^\top = B^\top A^\top$ for $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B \in M_{n \times p}(F)$.

Idea. The order reverses for a size reason before any computation: $(AB)^\top$ is $p \times m$, and $B^\top A^\top$ is $(p \times n)(n \times m) = p \times m$, while $A^\top B^\top$ is $(n \times m)(p \times n)$, usually not even defined. Then compare entries.

Proof. For 1, $((A^\top)^\top)_{ij} = (A^\top)_{ji} = a_{ij}$ by Definition 0.9.10. For 2 and 3, $((A + B)^\top)_{ij} = a_{ji} + b_{ji} = (A^\top + B^\top)_{ij}$ and $((cA)^\top)_{ij} = ca_{ji} = (cA^\top)_{ij}$.

For 4, both sides lie in $M_{p \times m}(F)$. Fix $1 \leq i \leq p$ and $1 \leq k \leq m$. By Definition 0.9.10

and Definition 0.9.9,

$$((AB)^\top)_{ik} = (AB)_{ki} = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{kj}b_{ji}, \quad (B^\top A^\top)_{ik} = \sum_{j=1}^n (B^\top)_{ij}(A^\top)_{jk} = \sum_{j=1}^n b_{ji}a_{kj}.$$

The two sums agree term by term because multiplication in F is commutative. Hence $(AB)^\top = B^\top A^\top$. This proves the theorem. ■

For example, for every $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, the square matrix $A^\top A$ is symmetric: by parts 4 and 1, $(A^\top A)^\top = A^\top (A^\top)^\top = A^\top A$. Matrices of this form are central to least squares and the singular value decomposition much later on.

0.9.8 The trace

The trace is the simplest number attached to a square matrix, and it has one surprising property.

Definition 0.9.12 — Trace

The **trace** of a square matrix $A = (a_{ij}) \in M_n(F)$ is the sum of its diagonal entries:

$$\operatorname{tr} A = \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ii} = a_{11} + a_{22} + \cdots + a_{nn} \in F.$$

Example. (Computing traces)

Compute $\operatorname{tr} A$ for $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 7 & -1 \\ 0 & -3 & 5 \\ 4 & 1 & 6 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R})$, and $\operatorname{tr} I_n$ over $\mathbb{R}$ and over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Solution. $\operatorname{tr} A = 2 + (-3) + 6 = 5$; the off-diagonal entries play no role. $\operatorname{tr} I_n = 1 + \cdots + 1 = n \cdot 1$. Over $\mathbb{R}$ this is n . Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ it is 0 when n is even and 1 when n is odd. The trace is **not** defined for a non-square matrix.

Theorem 0.9.6 — Properties of the trace

Let $A, B \in M_n(F)$ and $c \in F$. Then:

1. $\operatorname{tr}(A + B) = \operatorname{tr} A + \operatorname{tr} B$ and $\operatorname{tr}(cA) = c \operatorname{tr} A$;
2. $\operatorname{tr}(A^\top) = \operatorname{tr} A$;
3. $\operatorname{tr}(AB) = \operatorname{tr}(BA)$. More generally, this holds for all $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B \in M_{n \times m}(F)$, where AB is $m \times m$ and BA is $n \times n$.

Idea. Part 3 is surprising because $AB \neq BA$ in general. But the trace only sees the diagonal, and $\operatorname{tr}(AB) = \sum_i \sum_j a_{ij}b_{ji}$ is a sum over all pairs (i, j) of the product of a_{ij}

with the “mirror” entry b_{ji} . That description does not care which matrix is written first.

Proof. Parts 1 and 2 follow from the definitions: the diagonal entries of $A + B$, cA and A^T are $a_{ii} + b_{ii}$, ca_{ii} and a_{ii} .

For 3, let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B \in M_{n \times m}(F)$. By [Definition 0.9.12](#) and [Definition 0.9.9](#),

$$\operatorname{tr}(AB) = \sum_{i=1}^m (AB)_{ii} = \sum_{i=1}^m \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} b_{ji} = \sum_{j=1}^n \sum_{i=1}^m b_{ji} a_{ij} = \sum_{j=1}^n (BA)_{jj} = \operatorname{tr}(BA),$$

where the middle equality swaps the order of the finite double sum and uses commutativity of multiplication in F . This proves the theorem. ■

A first payoff: for all $A, B \in M_n(F)$, the matrix $AB - BA$ has trace $\operatorname{tr}(AB) - \operatorname{tr}(BA) = 0$. So over $\mathbb{R}$ it can never equal I_n , whose trace is n ([Exercise \(C1: \$AB - BA = I\$ is impossible, or is it?\)](#)). The trace will also turn out to be one of the quantities that does not change when we change coordinates.

It is tempting to conclude that the trace of a product ignores the order of **all** the factors. It does not.

Warning. $\operatorname{tr}(ABC) \neq \operatorname{tr}(BAC)$ **in general**. Take $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $C = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Then $ABC = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has trace 1, but $BA = 0$, so $BAC = 0$ has trace 0. What **is** true is that a **cyclic** rotation preserves the trace: $\operatorname{tr}(ABC) = \operatorname{tr}((AB)C) = \operatorname{tr}(C(AB)) = \operatorname{tr}(CAB)$ by part 3.

0.9.9 Inverse matrices

In a field we solve $ax = b$ by multiplying by a^{-1} , and this works exactly when $a \neq 0$. We would like to solve a system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ the same way, by “dividing by A ”. What should that mean, and for which A is it possible?

The naive answer, “every non-zero matrix”, fails. Let $N = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \neq 0$. For **any** $B \in M_2(F)$, the first column of BN is B times the first column of N , that is $B\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, by [Theorem 0.9.2](#). The first column of I_2 is $\mathbf{e}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$, so $BN \neq I_2$: no matrix undoes N from the left. Dividing needs a genuine two-sided inverse, and not every non-zero matrix has one.

An invertible matrix is a square matrix whose effect can be undone by multiplying, on either side.

Definition 0.9.13 — Invertible matrix

A **square** matrix $A \in M_n(F)$ is **invertible** if there exists $B \in M_n(F)$ such that

$$AB = I_n \quad \text{and} \quad BA = I_n.$$

Such a B is called **an inverse** of A . A square matrix that is not invertible is called **singular**.

In words: A is invertible when some matrix B of the same size cancels it **from the right** ($AB = I_n$) **and** from the left ($BA = I_n$). The definition asks for one B doing both jobs, and it only speaks about square matrices.

Is “an inverse” really “the inverse”? Yes: an inverse, if it exists, is unique. This is part 1 of the next theorem, and it lets us write A^{-1} . The remaining parts are what inverses are for.

Theorem 0.9.7 — Properties of inverses

Let $A, B \in M_n(F)$.

1. **(Uniqueness)** If B and B' are both inverses of A , then $B = B'$. We write A^{-1} for **the** inverse of an invertible A .
2. If A is invertible, then so is A^{-1} , and $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$.
3. If A and B are invertible, then so is AB , and $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$.
4. If A is invertible, then so is A^T , and $(A^T)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^T$.
5. If A is invertible and $c \in F$ is **non-zero**, then cA is invertible, and $(cA)^{-1} = c^{-1}A^{-1}$.
6. **(Cancellation)** If A is invertible, then $AX = AY$ implies $X = Y$ for all $X, Y \in M_{n \times p}(F)$, and $XA = YA$ implies $X = Y$ for all $X, Y \in M_{p \times n}(F)$.
7. **(Solving)** If A is invertible, then for every $\mathbf{b} \in F^n$ the equation $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has **exactly one** solution $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$, namely $\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{b}$.

Idea. Uniqueness is the standard trick for “prove unique by assuming two”: sandwich B' between B and A , and use associativity to collapse the product both ways. For the other parts the candidate inverse is written in the statement, so we only multiply it out on **both** sides, as the definition demands. The order in part 3 is the “socks and shoes” rule: to undo “first B , then A ”, undo A first.

Proof. For 1, suppose $AB = BA = I_n$ and $AB' = B'A = I_n$. By Theorem 0.9.4 (identity and associativity),

$$B = BI_n = B(AB') = (BA)B' = I_n B' = B'.$$

For 2, the equations $AA^{-1} = I_n$ and $A^{-1}A = I_n$ say precisely that A is an inverse of A^{-1} . By part 1 it is the inverse.

For 3, by associativity,

$$(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = A(BB^{-1})A^{-1} = AI_n A^{-1} = AA^{-1} = I_n,$$

and similarly $(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = B^{-1}(A^{-1}A)B = B^{-1}B = I_n$. Hence $B^{-1}A^{-1}$ is an inverse of AB , and by part 1 it is $(AB)^{-1}$.

For 4, by Theorem 0.9.5, $A^T(A^{-1})^T = (A^{-1}A)^T = I_n^T = I_n$ and $(A^{-1})^T A^T = (AA^{-1})^T = I_n^T = I_n$, where $I_n^T = I_n$ since I_n is symmetric. Hence $(A^{-1})^T$ is the inverse of A^T .

For 5, since $c \neq 0$, the inverse c^{-1} exists in F . By Theorem 0.9.4 (scalars), $(cA)(c^{-1}A^{-1}) = (cc^{-1})(AA^{-1}) = I_n$, and similarly in the other order.

For 6, suppose $AX = AY$. Multiplying on the left by A^{-1} and using associativity, $X = I_n X = (A^{-1}A)X = A^{-1}(AX) = A^{-1}(AY) = (A^{-1}A)Y = Y$. The statement for $XA = YA$ follows by multiplying on the right by A^{-1} .

For 7, $\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{b}$ is a solution, since $A(A^{-1}\mathbf{b}) = (AA^{-1})\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{b}$. If $\mathbf{x}$ is any solution, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b} = A(A^{-1}\mathbf{b})$, and part 6 (with $p = 1$) gives $\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{b}$. This proves the theorem. ■

Part 6 is the repair of the failed cancellation law from the warnings above: **you may cancel an invertible matrix**, on the side where it stands, and nothing else.

Example. (Some invertible matrices)

Show that each of the following is invertible and find its inverse: I_n ; a diagonal matrix $D = \text{diag}(d_1, \dots, d_n)$ with **all** $d_i \neq 0$; $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 5 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$; and $U = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{F}_2)$.

Solution. $I_n I_n = I_n$, so I_n is its own inverse. This is the degenerate case: I_n plays the role that 1 plays among numbers.

For D , let $E = \text{diag}(d_1^{-1}, \dots, d_n^{-1})$, which exists since every $d_i \neq 0$. Then $(DE)_{ik} = \sum_j d_{ij} e_{jk}$, and only $j = i = k$ can contribute, so $DE = \text{diag}(d_1 d_1^{-1}, \dots, d_n d_n^{-1}) = I_n$; likewise $ED = I_n$. Hence $D^{-1} = E$. For $n = 1$ this says the 1×1 matrix (a) is invertible when $a \neq 0$, with inverse (a^{-1}) , exactly as in the field.

For A , let $B = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & -1 \\ -5 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} 6-5 & -2+2 \\ 15-15 & -5+6 \end{pmatrix} = I_2, \quad BA = \begin{pmatrix} 6-5 & 3-3 \\ -10+10 & -5+6 \end{pmatrix} = I_2,$$

so $A^{-1} = B$. (Where B came from is explained by [Theorem 0.9.8](#) below.)

For U over $\mathbb{F}_2$, $U^2 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1+1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, since $1+1=0$. So U is its own inverse.

Over $\mathbb{R}$ the same array would have inverse $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$: the answer depends on the field.

Now a non-example by minimal change. The matrix $\text{diag}(1, 2)$ is invertible, with inverse $\text{diag}(1, \frac{1}{2})$. Change the entry 2 to 0: $A = \text{diag}(1, 0)$ is still diagonal and still non-zero. But for any $B \in M_2(F)$, the second column of BA is B times the second column of A , which is $B\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, while the second column of I_2 is $\mathbf{e}_2$. So $BA \neq I_2$ for every B : the clause “**there exists** B with ... $BA = I_n$ ” fails, and $\text{diag}(1, 0)$ is singular. The same argument shows that any square matrix with a zero column is singular, and in particular so is every zero matrix $0_{n \times n}$.

Why does the definition insist on a **square** matrix and on **both** equations? For non-square matrices one-sided inverses can exist without the other side: with $C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{1 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$ and $D = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$, we get $CD = (1) = I_1$ but $DC = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \neq I_2$. Demanding both equations makes the inverse unique (part 1) and makes both cancellation laws (part 6) hold.

Warning. For square matrices, $AB = I_n$ already implies $BA = I_n$. This is true, but it is not obvious, and we do not know it yet. Nothing in this chapter proves it: the entries of AB and BA are different sums. It is proved in Chapter 2, using row reduction. Until then, to show that B is the inverse of A , check **both** $AB = I_n$ and $BA = I_n$. (The non-square example above shows that some argument is needed.)

For 2×2 matrices, invertibility is decided by one number.

Theorem 0.9.8 — Inverse of a 2×2 matrix

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(F)$. Then A is invertible **if and only if** $ad - bc \neq 0$. In that case,

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{ad - bc} \begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}.$$

Idea. Where does the formula come from? Try to kill the off-diagonal entries of A by multiplying with a matrix built from its own entries. Swapping a and d and negating b and c gives $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix} = (ad - bc)I_2$. If $ad - bc \neq 0$, divide by it. If $ad - bc = 0$, the same computation shows that A sends a non-zero column to $\mathbf{0}$, and an invertible matrix cannot do that, since its inverse would have to send $\mathbf{0}$ back to a non-zero column.

Proof. Write $\Delta = ad - bc$ and $\tilde{A} = \begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}$. By Definition 0.9.9 and commutativity of multiplication in F ,

$$A\tilde{A} = \begin{pmatrix} ad - bc & -ab + ba \\ cd - dc & -cb + da \end{pmatrix} = \Delta I_2, \quad \tilde{A}A = \begin{pmatrix} da - bc & db - bd \\ -ca + ac & -cb + ad \end{pmatrix} = \Delta I_2.$$

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\Delta \neq 0$, so Δ^{-1} exists in F . By Theorem 0.9.4 (scalars), $A(\Delta^{-1}\tilde{A}) = \Delta^{-1}(A\tilde{A}) = \Delta^{-1}\Delta I_2 = I_2$, and likewise $(\Delta^{-1}\tilde{A})A = I_2$. Hence A is invertible with $A^{-1} = \Delta^{-1}\tilde{A}$, which is the stated formula.

($\Rightarrow$) We prove the contrapositive. Suppose $\Delta = 0$. We first find $\mathbf{x} \in F^2$ with $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$ and $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.

Case 1. $A = 0$. Take $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_1$.

Case 2. $c \neq 0$ or $d \neq 0$. Take $\mathbf{x} = (d, -c) \neq \mathbf{0}$. Then $A\mathbf{x} = (ad - bc, cd - dc) = (\Delta, 0) = \mathbf{0}$.

Case 3. $c = d = 0$ but $a \neq 0$ or $b \neq 0$. Take $\mathbf{x} = (b, -a) \neq \mathbf{0}$. Then $A\mathbf{x} = (ab - ba, cb - da) = (0, 0) = \mathbf{0}$, since $c = d = 0$.

These cases cover every A . Now suppose, for a contradiction, that A is invertible. Then by Theorem 0.9.4,

$$\mathbf{x} = I_2\mathbf{x} = (A^{-1}A)\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}(A\mathbf{x}) = A^{-1}\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0},$$

contradicting $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Hence A is not invertible. This proves the theorem. ■

The number $ad - bc$ will return in Chapter 6 as the determinant of A . Here it arose from a single multiplication, and the proof used nothing beyond the field axioms, so the theorem holds over every field. For instance, $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 5 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ has $ad - bc = 6 - 5 = 1$, which explains the inverse found in [Example \(Some invertible matrices\)](#); and $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ has $ad - bc = 0$, so it is singular, with $A(2, -1) = \mathbf{0}$.

0.9.10 Powers and polynomials of a matrix

A square matrix can be multiplied by itself, so we can form powers, and then plug the matrix into a polynomial ([Definition 0.8.1](#)). This is how polynomials act on matrices throughout the book.

Definition 0.9.14 — Powers and polynomials of a matrix

Let $A \in M_n(F)$. The **powers** of A are defined recursively by

$$A^0 = I_n, \quad A^{k+1} = A^k A \quad (k \in \mathbb{N}).$$

For a polynomial $p = a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_Nx^N \in F[x]$, the matrix $p(A)$ is

$$p(A) = a_0I_n + a_1A + a_2A^2 + \cdots + a_NA^N \in M_n(F).$$

Two points in this definition deserve attention. The **constant term** a_0 becomes a_0I_n , because a_0 alone is a number and cannot be added to matrices; this matches $x^0 = 1$ with $A^0 = I_n$. And $p(A)$ is well defined, because enlarging N only adds terms $0 \cdot A^k = 0$, exactly as for evaluation at a number ([Definition 0.8.6](#)).

The next theorem says that plugging in a matrix respects sums and products, just as plugging in a number does ([Theorem 0.8.5](#)).

Theorem 0.9.9 — Polynomials in one matrix

Let $A \in M_n(F)$ and $p, q \in F[x]$. Then:

1. $A^j A^k = A^{j+k}$ for all $j, k \in \mathbb{N}$;
2. $(p + q)(A) = p(A) + q(A)$ and $(pq)(A) = p(A)q(A)$;
3. $p(A)q(A) = q(A)p(A)$.

Idea. In the proof of [Theorem 0.8.5](#), the only delicate step moved c^i past a coefficient b_j . Here the coefficients are scalars, and scalars can be moved freely through matrix products. The other step, $c^i c^j = c^{i+j}$, becomes part 1, which is associativity plus induction. Part 3 is then free, because $pq = qp$ in $F[x]$.

Proof. For 1, fix j and use induction on k ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)). For $k = 0$, $A^j A^0 = A^j I_n = A^j$. If $A^j A^k = A^{j+k}$, then by [Definition 0.9.14](#) and associativity ([Theorem 0.9.4](#)),

$$A^j A^{k+1} = A^j (A^k A) = (A^j A^k) A = A^{j+k} A = A^{j+k+1}.$$

For 2, let $p = \sum_{i=0}^m a_i x^i$ and $q = \sum_{j=0}^l b_j x^j$. The statement for sums follows from [Theorem 0.9.1](#), since $(a_i + b_i)A^i = a_i A^i + b_i A^i$. For products, by [Definition 0.8.2](#) the coefficient of x^k in pq is $\sum_{i+j=k} a_i b_j$, so

$$(pq)(A) = \sum_k \left(\sum_{i+j=k} a_i b_j \right) A^k = \sum_{i=0}^m \sum_{j=0}^l (a_i b_j) A^i A^j = \left(\sum_{i=0}^m a_i A^i \right) \left(\sum_{j=0}^l b_j A^j \right) = p(A) q(A),$$

where the second equality uses part 1 and [Theorem 0.9.1](#), and the third uses distributivity and the scalar rule $(a_i A^i)(b_j A^j) = (a_i b_j) A^i A^j$ from [Theorem 0.9.4](#).

For 3, $pq = qp$ in $F[x]$ by [Theorem 0.8.1](#). Hence by part 2, $p(A)q(A) = (pq)(A) = (qp)(A) = q(A)p(A)$. This proves the theorem. ■

Example. (Plugging a matrix into a polynomial)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ and $p = x^2 - 4x + 3$. Compute $p(A)$ directly, and again using the factorization $p = (x - 1)(x - 3)$.

Solution. First $A^2 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 8 \\ 0 & 9 \end{pmatrix}$. Hence

$$p(A) = A^2 - 4A + 3I_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 8 \\ 0 & 9 \end{pmatrix} - \begin{pmatrix} 4 & 8 \\ 0 & 12 \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 0 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The constant term contributed $3I_2$, not “3”. By [Theorem 0.9.9](#), $p(A) = (A - I_2)(A - 3I_2)$, and indeed

$$(A - I_2)(A - 3I_2) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} -2 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Note that neither factor is zero; this is the second warning of the multiplication part in action. That the diagonal entries 1, 3 of A are the roots of p is no accident, as we will see with eigenvalues.

[Theorem 0.9.9](#) is about polynomials in **one** matrix. Identities with **two** different matrices are another matter.

Warning. School identities fail for matrices that do not commute. Expanding with distributivity, $(A + B)^2 = A^2 + AB + BA + B^2$, and this equals $A^2 + 2AB + B^2$ only when $AB = BA$. With $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$: $(A + B)^2 = I_2$, but $A^2 + 2AB + B^2 = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Before using a polynomial identity valid for numbers, check that all the matrices involved commute; polynomials in a single A always do.

0.9.11 Two equivalence relations on matrices

We close with two relations on matrices that the rest of the book studies in depth. Both are equivalence relations ([Definition 0.5.2](#)), and the proofs are short exercises in using [Theorem 0.9.7](#).

Example. (Similarity)

For $A, B \in M_n(F)$, say A is **similar** to B , written $A \sim B$, if there is an **invertible** $P \in M_n(F)$ with $B = P^{-1}AP$. Prove that similarity is an equivalence relation on $M_n(F)$. Then check that $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ is similar to $\text{diag}(1, 3)$ using $P = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, and show that $\text{diag}(1, 2)$ is **not** similar to I_2 over $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution. We check the three conditions of [Definition 0.5.2](#).

Reflexive. Let $A \in M_n(F)$. The identity I_n is invertible with $I_n^{-1} = I_n$ ([Example \(Some invertible matrices\)](#)), and $I_n^{-1}AI_n = A$. Hence $A \sim A$.

Symmetric. Suppose $A \sim B$, so $B = P^{-1}AP$ with P invertible. Multiplying on the left by P and on the right by P^{-1} , and using associativity, $PBP^{-1} = (PP^{-1})A(PP^{-1}) = A$. By [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 2), $Q = P^{-1}$ is invertible with $Q^{-1} = P$, so $A = Q^{-1}BQ$. Hence $B \sim A$.

Transitive. Suppose $A \sim B$ and $B \sim C$, so $B = P^{-1}AP$ and $C = Q^{-1}BQ$ with P, Q invertible. Then

$$C = Q^{-1}(P^{-1}AP)Q = (Q^{-1}P^{-1})A(PQ) = (PQ)^{-1}A(PQ),$$

where the last step is [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3), which also says PQ is invertible. Hence $A \sim C$. This shows that similarity is an equivalence relation.

For the numerical part, $P^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ by [Theorem 0.9.8](#) (here $ad - bc = 1$), and

$$P^{-1}AP = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Finally, if $P^{-1}I_2P = \text{diag}(1, 2)$ for some invertible P , then $\text{diag}(1, 2) = P^{-1}P = I_2$, which is false. (Alternatively: similar matrices have equal traces by [Theorem 0.9.6](#), and $\text{tr } \text{diag}(1, 2) = 3 \neq 2 = \text{tr } I_2$.) Hence $\text{diag}(1, 2) \not\sim I_2$.

In Chapter 3 we will see that similar matrices describe the same linear map in two different coordinate systems. That is why a quantity like the trace, which similar matrices share, is really a property of the map and not of the matrix. Deciding when two matrices are similar is one of the main problems of this book.

Example. (Row equivalence)

For $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, say A is **row equivalent** to B if there is an **invertible** $E \in M_m(F)$ with $B = EA$. Prove that row equivalence is an equivalence relation on $M_{m \times n}(F)$. Then, with $E = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, compute EA for $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 5 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and describe

what E did to the rows of A .

Solution. Reflexive. $A = I_m A$ and I_m is invertible, so A is row equivalent to itself.

Symmetric. Suppose $B = EA$ with E invertible. Multiplying on the left by E^{-1} , $E^{-1}B = (E^{-1}E)A = A$, and E^{-1} is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 2). So B is row equivalent to A .

Transitive. Suppose $B = EA$ and $C = E'B$ with E, E' invertible. Then $C = E'(EA) = (E'E)A$ by associativity, and $E'E$ is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3). So A is row equivalent to C . This shows that row equivalence is an equivalence relation.

For the computation, E is invertible, with inverse $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ (check both products, or use [Theorem 0.9.8](#) with $ad - bc = 1$). By the row view of [Theorem 0.9.2](#) and [Theorem 0.9.3](#), row 1 of EA is $1 \cdot (\text{row 1 of } A)$ and row 2 is $-2 \cdot (\text{row 1}) + 1 \cdot (\text{row 2})$:

$$EA = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2-2 & 5-4 & 0-2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

So E subtracted twice row 1 from row 2, which is the first step of Gaussian elimination on A .

In Chapter 2 we will see that every elementary row operation is multiplication on the left by an invertible matrix, and that row equivalence is exactly “reachable by a sequence of row operations”. This is why Gaussian elimination never changes the solutions of a linear system.

0.9.12 Exercises

0.9.12.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Let $A \in M_{2 \times 3}(F)$ and $B \in M_{3 \times 4}(F)$. Which of AB , BA , $A^T A$ and $B^T A^T$ are defined? Give the size of each one that is.
- Define what it means for $A \in M_n(F)$ to be invertible.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if $A, B \in M_n(F)$ and $AB = 0$, then $A = 0$ or $B = 0$.” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “ $(A + B)(A - B) = A^2 - B^2$ for all $A, B \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$.” Justify your answer.
- Let $A \in M_3(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \mathbf{a}_2, \mathbf{a}_3$. Express $A(2, 0, -1)$ and the second column of A^2 in terms of the columns of A and A itself.

Solution.

- AB is $(2 \times 3)(3 \times 4)$, defined, of size 2×4 . BA would pair rows of length 4 with columns of length 2, so it is not defined. $A^T A$ is $(3 \times 2)(2 \times 3)$, defined, of size 3×3 . $B^T A^T$ is $(4 \times 3)(3 \times 2)$, defined, of size 4×2 ; it equals $(AB)^T$ by [Theorem 0.9.5](#).
- A is invertible if there exists $B \in M_n(F)$ with $AB = I_n$ and $BA = I_n$.

- (c) False. $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = 0$ with both factors non-zero.
- (d) False. Expanding gives $(A+B)(A-B) = A^2 - AB + BA - B^2$, which differs from $A^2 - B^2$ unless $AB = BA$. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, we have $A^2 = B^2 = 0$, but $(A+B)(A-B) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \neq 0$.
- (e) By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $A(2, 0, -1) = 2\mathbf{a}_1 - \mathbf{a}_3$. By [Theorem 0.9.2](#), the second column of $A^2 = AA$ is $A\mathbf{a}_2$.

0.9.12.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Products and sizes.

Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 4 \end{pmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$$

over $\mathbb{R}$.

- Compute AB and BA .
- Determine which of AC and CA is defined, and compute it.
- Compute $A\mathbf{x}$ for $\mathbf{x} = (2, 0, -1)$ as a combination of the columns of A .

Solution.

- (a) AB is 2×2 and BA is 3×3 . Row against column,

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} 2 - 1 + 0 & 1 + 0 + 8 \\ 0 + 3 + 0 & 0 + 0 + 4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 9 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix}, \quad BA = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & 5 \\ 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 0 & 12 & 4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

For instance $(BA)_{12} = 2 \cdot (-1) + 1 \cdot 3 = 1$ and $(BA)_{32} = 0 \cdot (-1) + 4 \cdot 3 = 12$.

- (b) AC would be $(2 \times 3)(2 \times 2)$, and $3 \neq 2$, so it is not defined. CA is $(2 \times 2)(2 \times 3)$, of size 2×3 :

$$CA = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 + 6 & 2 + 2 \\ 3 & -3 + 12 & 6 + 4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 5 & 4 \\ 3 & 9 & 10 \end{pmatrix}.$$

- (c) By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $A\mathbf{x} = 2\mathbf{a}_1 + 0\mathbf{a}_2 - \mathbf{a}_3 = 2(1, 0) - (2, 1) = (0, -1)$.

Exercise B2: Traces of products.

- With A and B as in [Exercise \(B1: Products and sizes\)](#), verify that $\text{tr}(AB) = \text{tr}(BA)$, although AB and BA have different sizes.
- Let $A = \text{diag}(1, 2)$, $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $C = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Show that $\text{tr}(ABC) \neq \text{tr}(BAC)$, and verify that $\text{tr}(ABC) = \text{tr}(CAB)$.

Solution.

- (a) From [Exercise \(B1: Products and sizes\)](#), $\text{tr}(AB) = 1 + 4 = 5$ and $\text{tr}(BA) = 2 + (-1) + 4 = 5$, as [Theorem 0.9.6](#) predicts.
- (b) By the column view, BC has columns $B\mathbf{e}_2 = \mathbf{e}_1$ and $B\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, so $BC = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, and $ABC = A(BC) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, with trace 1. Next, $BA = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, so $BAC = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, with trace 2. Hence $\text{tr}(ABC) = 1 \neq 2 = \text{tr}(BAC)$. Finally $AB = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $CAB = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, with trace $1 = \text{tr}(ABC)$, as the cyclic rule predicts.

Exercise B3: Inverses of 2×2 matrices.

- (a) Find the inverse of $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$, and check both products.
- (b) Show that $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 6 \\ 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ is not invertible by finding a non-zero $\mathbf{x}$ with $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.
- (c) Find the inverse of $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{F}_5)$.
- (d) For which $t \in \mathbb{R}$ is $\begin{pmatrix} t & 2 \\ 2 & t \end{pmatrix}$ invertible?

Solution.

- (a) Here $ad - bc = 9 - 8 = 1 \neq 0$, so by [Theorem 0.9.8](#) the inverse is $B = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & -4 \\ -2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$.
Check: $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix} B = \begin{pmatrix} 9 - 8 & -12 + 12 \\ 6 - 6 & -8 + 9 \end{pmatrix} = I_2$ and $B \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 9 - 8 & 12 - 12 \\ -6 + 6 & -8 + 9 \end{pmatrix} = I_2$.
- (b) Here $ad - bc = 6 - 6 = 0$. Following the proof of [Theorem 0.9.8](#), take $\mathbf{x} = (d, -c) = (3, -1) \neq \mathbf{0}$. Then $A\mathbf{x} = (6 - 6, 3 - 3) = \mathbf{0}$. If A were invertible, then $\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}(A\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{0}$, a contradiction. Hence A is not invertible.
- (c) In $\mathbb{F}_5$, $ad - bc = 4 - 6 = -2 = 3 \neq 0$, and $3^{-1} = 2$ since $3 \cdot 2 = 6 = 1$. By [Theorem 0.9.8](#) the inverse is $2 \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -2 \\ -3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 8 & -4 \\ -6 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 4 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$. Check:
 $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 4 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 11 & 5 \\ 25 & 11 \end{pmatrix} = I_2$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 4 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 6 & 10 \\ 10 & 16 \end{pmatrix} = I_2$ in $\mathbb{F}_5$.
- (d) By [Theorem 0.9.8](#), it is invertible if and only if $t^2 - 4 \neq 0$, that is, $t \neq 2$ and $t \neq -2$.

Exercise B4: Transposes of products.

- (a) Prove that $(A_1 A_2 \cdots A_k)^\top = A_k^\top \cdots A_2^\top A_1^\top$ for all $k \geq 1$ and matrices $A_1, \dots, A_k$ whose sizes allow the product.
- (b) Let $A \in M_n(F)$. Prove that $A + A^\top$ is symmetric and $A - A^\top$ is skew-symmetric.

Solution.

- (a) We use induction on k ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)). For $k = 1$ there is nothing to prove. Suppose the formula holds for products of k matrices, and let $A_1, \dots, A_{k+1}$ be given. By associativity, $A_1 \cdots A_{k+1} = (A_1 \cdots A_k)A_{k+1}$. By [Theorem 0.9.5](#) (part 4) and then the induction hypothesis,

$$(A_1 \cdots A_{k+1})^\top = A_{k+1}^\top (A_1 \cdots A_k)^\top = A_{k+1}^\top A_k^\top \cdots A_1^\top.$$

This proves the formula for all $k \geq 1$.

- (b) By [Theorem 0.9.5](#) (parts 1–3), $(A + A^\top)^\top = A^\top + (A^\top)^\top = A^\top + A = A + A^\top$, so $A + A^\top$ is symmetric. Similarly $(A - A^\top)^\top = A^\top - A = -(A - A^\top)$, so $A - A^\top$ is skew-symmetric.

0.9.12.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: $AB - BA = I$ is impossible, or is it?.

- (a) Prove that there are no $A, B \in M_n(\mathbb{R})$, for any $n \geq 1$, with $AB - BA = I_n$.
- (b) Show that the argument of (a) breaks down in $M_2(\mathbb{F}_2)$, and that $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $B = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ satisfy $AB - BA = I_2$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Hint: consider the trace of both sides.

Solution.

- (a) Suppose, for a contradiction, that $AB - BA = I_n$. Taking traces and using [Theorem 0.9.6](#) (parts 1 and 3),

$$n = \text{tr } I_n = \text{tr}(AB - BA) = \text{tr}(AB) - \text{tr}(BA) = 0.$$

This contradicts $n \geq 1$. Hence no such A, B exist.

- (b) Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ the same computation gives $\text{tr } I_2 = 1 + 1 = 0$, so taking traces yields $0 = 0$ and no contradiction. For the given matrices, the column view gives $AB = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $BA = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, so $AB - BA = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = I_2$, because $-1 = 1$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Exercise C2: Triangular matrices with non-zero diagonal.

Let F be a field.

- (a) Let $U = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix}$ with $a, d \neq 0$. Show that U is invertible and that U^{-1} is upper triangular.

- (b) Let $U = \begin{pmatrix} a & b & c \\ 0 & d & e \\ 0 & 0 & f \end{pmatrix}$ with $a, d, f \neq 0$. Show that

$$V = \begin{pmatrix} a^{-1} & -b(ad)^{-1} & (be - cd)(adf)^{-1} \\ 0 & d^{-1} & -e(df)^{-1} \\ 0 & 0 & f^{-1} \end{pmatrix}$$

is the inverse of U .

- (c) Explain how the entries of V can be found, column by column, by solving $U\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{e}_k$.

The general case, for all n , follows from the methods of Chapter 2.

Solution.

- (a) Here $ad - b \cdot 0 = ad \neq 0$, since a product of non-zero elements of a field is non-zero (Theorem 0.7.1). By Theorem 0.9.8, U is invertible with $U^{-1} = (ad)^{-1} \begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ 0 & a \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a^{-1} & -b(ad)^{-1} \\ 0 & d^{-1} \end{pmatrix}$, which is upper triangular.
- (b) The inverses a^{-1}, d^{-1}, f^{-1} exist, and $ad, df, adf \neq 0$ by Theorem 0.7.1, so V is defined. We check $UV = I_3$ entry by entry. The diagonal entries are $a \cdot a^{-1} = 1$, $d \cdot d^{-1} = 1$, $f \cdot f^{-1} = 1$. Below the diagonal both matrices are zero, so $(UV)_{21} = (UV)_{31} = (UV)_{32} = 0$. Above the diagonal,

$$(UV)_{12} = a \cdot (-b(ad)^{-1}) + bd^{-1} = -bd^{-1} + bd^{-1} = 0,$$

$$(UV)_{23} = d \cdot (-e(df)^{-1}) + ef^{-1} = -ef^{-1} + ef^{-1} = 0,$$

$$(UV)_{13} = a(be - cd)(adf)^{-1} + b(-e(df)^{-1}) + cf^{-1} = (be - cd)(df)^{-1} - be(df)^{-1} + cd(df)^{-1} = 0.$$

Hence $UV = I_3$. For VU , again the diagonal entries are 1 and the entries below the diagonal are 0, and

$$(VU)_{12} = a^{-1}b - b(ad)^{-1}d = a^{-1}b - a^{-1}b = 0,$$

$$(VU)_{23} = d^{-1}e - e(df)^{-1}f = 0,$$

$$(VU)_{13} = a^{-1}c - b(ad)^{-1}e + (be - cd)(adf)^{-1}f = a^{-1}c - be(ad)^{-1} + be(ad)^{-1} - cd(ad)^{-1} = 0,$$

using $cd(ad)^{-1} = ca^{-1}$. Hence $VU = I_3$, and $V = U^{-1}$. Both products had to be checked, since we may not yet use that one implies the other.

- (c) By Theorem 0.9.2, $UV = I_3$ says exactly that the columns $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3$ of V satisfy $U\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{e}_k$. Because U is upper triangular, each system can be solved from the bottom row up. For example, $U\mathbf{v}_3 = \mathbf{e}_3$ reads $fx_3 = 1$, $dx_2 + ex_3 = 0$, $ax_1 + bx_2 + cx_3 = 0$, giving $x_3 = f^{-1}$, then $x_2 = -e(df)^{-1}$, then $x_1 = (be - cd)(adf)^{-1}$, which is the third column of V . (This only finds a candidate satisfying $UV = I_3$; the check $VU = I_3$ in (b) is still needed.)

Exercise C3: Matrices that commute.

Let $N = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$.

- (a) Find all $X \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ with $XN = NX$.
 (b) Deduce that the only matrices $X \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ with $XY = YX$ **for every** $Y \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ are the scalar multiples cI_2 , $c \in \mathbb{R}$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $X = \begin{pmatrix} p & q \\ r & s \end{pmatrix}$. By the column view, $XN = (X\mathbf{0} \quad X\mathbf{e}_1) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & p \\ 0 & r \end{pmatrix}$, and by the row view, NX has rows (row 2 of X) and $\mathbf{0}$: $NX = \begin{pmatrix} r & s \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Comparing entries, $XN = NX$ if and only if $r = 0$ and $p = s$, that is, $X = \begin{pmatrix} p & q \\ 0 & p \end{pmatrix} = pI_2 + qN$ with $p, q \in \mathbb{R}$ arbitrary.
- (b) Every cI_2 commutes with every Y , by [Theorem 0.9.4](#): $(cI_2)Y = cY = Y(cI_2)$. Conversely, suppose $XY = YX$ for every Y . Taking $Y = N$, part (a) gives $X = \begin{pmatrix} p & q \\ 0 & p \end{pmatrix}$. Taking $Y = N^\top = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, we compute $XN^\top = \begin{pmatrix} q & 0 \\ p & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $N^\top X = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ p & q \end{pmatrix}$. Equality forces $q = 0$. Hence $X = pI_2$, as claimed.

0.10 Groups and Permutations

Several structures in this chapter have quietly behaved alike. The invertible $n \times n$ matrices, the non-zero elements of a field, and the bijections of a set can each be combined, have an element that does nothing, and can be undone. This short section gives that common structure a name, proves its basic rules once, and introduces the permutations that the determinant in Chapter 6 is built from. We keep it brief: groups are a language for us here, not a subject.

0.10.1 Groups

Look at four situations side by side. In $\text{GL}_n(F)$, the set of invertible matrices in $M_n(F)$, we multiply matrices, I_n does nothing, and each A is undone by A^{-1} ([Theorem 0.9.7](#)). In a field F , we multiply non-zero elements, 1 does nothing, and each a is undone by a^{-1} . The four rotations of a square about its center (by $0^\circ, 90^\circ, 180^\circ, 270^\circ$) can be performed one after another, the rotation by 0° does nothing, and each rotation is undone by rotating back. The bijections $X \rightarrow X$ of a set are composed, id_X does nothing, and each is undone by its inverse function ([Theorem 0.4.7](#)). The objects differ completely, but the rules we use are the same three. So we give the pattern a name.

A group is a set with one way of combining elements, in which combining is associative, some element does nothing, and every element can be undone.

Definition 0.10.1 — Group

A **group** is a set G together with a **binary operation** $G \times G \rightarrow G$, $(a, b) \mapsto ab$, such that:

- (G1) (**Associativity**) $(ab)c = a(bc)$ for all $a, b, c \in G$;
 (G2) (**Identity**) there is an element $e \in G$ with $ea = ae = a$ for every $a \in G$;
 (G3) (**Inverses**) for every $a \in G$ there is $b \in G$ with $ab = ba = e$, where e is the element of (G2).

The group is **abelian** if moreover $ab = ba$ for all $a, b \in G$.

In words: the operation is a function on pairs, so the combination of two elements of G lies in G again; this “closure” is built into the phrase “binary operation $G \times G \rightarrow G$ ”. (G1) lets us drop brackets. (G2) asks for an element that changes nothing, from **both** sides. (G3) asks that each element can be undone, again from both sides, back to that same e . When the operation is addition we write $a + b$, 0 and $-a$ instead of ab , e and a^{-1} ; this notation is only used for abelian groups.

Example. (Groups)

Check that each of the following is a group, and decide which are abelian: $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$; $(F, +)$ and $(F \setminus \{0\}, \cdot)$ for a field F ; $\text{GL}_n(F)$ under matrix multiplication; the set S_n of bijections $\{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\}$ under composition; and a one-element set $\{e\}$ with $ee = e$.

Solution. $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$: the sum of integers is an integer, addition is associative, 0 is an identity, and $-a$ undoes a . It is abelian. $(F, +)$ is a group for the same reasons, by the field axioms (Definition 0.7.1); it is abelian.

$(F \setminus \{0\}, \cdot)$: the product of two non-zero elements is non-zero by Theorem 0.7.1, so the operation lands in $F \setminus \{0\}$. Associativity and the identity $1 \neq 0$ come from the field axioms, and each $a \neq 0$ has an inverse a^{-1} , which is non-zero since $aa^{-1} = 1 \neq 0$. It is abelian.

$\text{GL}_n(F)$: by Theorem 0.9.7 (part 3), a product of invertible matrices is invertible, so the operation lands in $\text{GL}_n(F)$. Associativity holds by Theorem 0.9.4, I_n is invertible and is an identity, and $A^{-1} \in \text{GL}_n(F)$ undoes A by part 2. For $n \geq 2$ it is **not** abelian: for $n = 2$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, while the product in the other order is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$. (Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ read 2 as 0; the two products still differ.) For $n \geq 3$, put these blocks in the top-left corner and 1's further down the diagonal. $\text{GL}_1(F)$ is just $F \setminus \{0\}$, and is abelian.

S_n : a composition of bijections is a bijection (Theorem 0.4.3), composition is associative (Theorem 0.4.2), id is an identity, and each bijection has an inverse function (Theorem 0.4.7), which is again a bijection. We will see below that S_n is not abelian for $n \geq 3$.

$\{e\}$: all three axioms reduce to $ee = e$. This **trivial group** is the degenerate case; it reappears as the smallest subgroup of every group.

Now non-examples, each a minimal change of an example. Replace addition on $\mathbb{Z}$ by multiplication. The operation still lands in $\mathbb{Z}$, it is associative, and 1 is an identity. But (G3) fails: there is no integer b with $2b = 1$. So $(\mathbb{Z}, \cdot)$ is **not** a group. Similarly, replace $\text{GL}_n(F)$ by all of $M_n(F)$ under multiplication: (G1) and (G2) still hold with I_n , but the zero matrix has no inverse, so (G3) fails. Keep $\mathbb{N}$ under $+$: the identity 0 is there, but 1 has no inverse in $\mathbb{N}$.

Warning. **The operation must land in the set.** $\text{GL}_n(F)$ under matrix **addition** is not a group: I_n and $-I_n$ are invertible, but $I_n + (-I_n) = 0$ is not, so addition is not even a binary operation on $\text{GL}_n(F)$. Before checking (G1)–(G3), check that combining two elements of the set gives an element of the set.

The rules we proved separately for fields and for matrices follow from the axioms alone. It is worth proving them once:

Theorem 0.10.1 — Basic properties of groups

Let G be a group and $a, b, c \in G$.

1. The identity element of G is unique.
2. The inverse of a is unique. We denote it by a^{-1} .
3. $(a^{-1})^{-1} = a$ and $(ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1}$.
4. **(Cancellation)** If $ab = ac$, then $b = c$. If $ba = ca$, then $b = c$.

Proof. For 1, suppose e and e' both satisfy (G2). Then $e = ee'$, using that e' is an identity, and $ee' = e'$, using that e is one. Hence $e = e'$.

For 2, suppose b and b' both satisfy $ab = ba = e$ and $ab' = b'a = e$. By (G2) and (G1),

$$b = be = b(ab') = (ba)b' = eb' = b'.$$

For 3, the equations $aa^{-1} = a^{-1}a = e$ say that a is an inverse of a^{-1} , so $(a^{-1})^{-1} = a$ by part 2. Next, by (G1),

$$(ab)(b^{-1}a^{-1}) = a(bb^{-1})a^{-1} = aea^{-1} = aa^{-1} = e,$$

and similarly $(b^{-1}a^{-1})(ab) = b^{-1}(a^{-1}a)b = e$. By part 2, $(ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1}$.

For 4, suppose $ab = ac$. Multiplying on the left by a^{-1} and using (G1), $b = (a^{-1}a)b = a^{-1}(ab) = a^{-1}(ac) = (a^{-1}a)c = c$. The second statement follows by multiplying on the right by a^{-1} . This proves the theorem. ■

These are the arguments of Theorem 0.9.7 with matrices erased. That is the point of the definition: a proof that uses only (G1)–(G3) holds in every group at once.

0.10.2 Subgroups

After a structure comes the substructure. The even integers sit inside $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$ and form a group on their own, with the same operation.

Definition 0.10.2 — Subgroup

Let G be a group. A subset $H \subseteq G$ is a **subgroup** of G if $e \in H$, and $ab \in H$ and $a^{-1} \in H$ for all $a, b \in H$.

Then the operation of G restricts to a binary operation on H , and H is a group with it: (G1) holds in H because it holds in G , and (G2), (G3) hold because e and the inverses lie in H . In practice one checks a single condition:

Theorem 0.10.2 — Subgroup test

Let G be a group and $H \subseteq G$. Then H is a subgroup of G if and only if $H \neq \emptyset$ and $ab^{-1} \in H$ for all $a, b \in H$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) If H is a subgroup, then $e \in H$, so $H \neq \emptyset$. For $a, b \in H$ we have $b^{-1} \in H$, and then $ab^{-1} \in H$.

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $H \neq \emptyset$ and $ab^{-1} \in H$ for all $a, b \in H$. Pick $h \in H$. Taking $a = b = h$ gives $e = hh^{-1} \in H$. For $b \in H$, taking $a = e$ gives $b^{-1} = eb^{-1} \in H$. For $a, b \in H$, we now know $b^{-1} \in H$, so $ab = a(b^{-1})^{-1} \in H$ by Theorem 0.10.1. Hence H is a subgroup. This proves the theorem. ■

For example, $2\mathbb{Z} = \{2k : k \in \mathbb{Z}\}$ is a subgroup of $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$. In additive notation the test reads “ $a - b \in H$ ”, and $2k - 2l = 2(k - l) \in 2\mathbb{Z}$, while $0 \in 2\mathbb{Z}$. By contrast $\mathbb{N} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}$ is non-empty and closed under $+$, but $0 - 1 = -1 \notin \mathbb{N}$: the test fails, because $\mathbb{N}$ lacks inverses. The set of odd integers fails more badly, since it does not contain 0. In $\text{GL}_n(F)$, the invertible diagonal matrices form a subgroup: I_n is one, and by Example (Some invertible matrices) the inverse of $\text{diag}(d_1, \dots, d_n)$ is $\text{diag}(d_1^{-1}, \dots, d_n^{-1})$, so DE^{-1} is again diagonal with non-zero diagonal entries. Every group G has the subgroups $\{e\}$ and G .

0.10.3 Homomorphisms

After objects come the maps between them that respect the structure.

Definition 0.10.3 — Group homomorphism

Let G and H be groups. A function $\varphi: G \rightarrow H$ is a **homomorphism** if $\varphi(ab) = \varphi(a)\varphi(b)$ for all $a, b \in G$. A **bijective** homomorphism is an **isomorphism**. The **kernel** of φ is $\ker \varphi = \{g \in G : \varphi(g) = e_H\}$, where e_H is the identity of H .

The product ab on the left is taken in G , and $\varphi(a)\varphi(b)$ on the right in H . For example, $F \setminus \{0\} \rightarrow \text{GL}_2(F)$, $a \mapsto \text{diag}(a, 1)$, is a homomorphism, since $\text{diag}(ab, 1) = \text{diag}(a, 1) \text{diag}(b, 1)$; its kernel is $\{1\}$. The map $\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$, $a \mapsto [a]$, is a homomorphism of additive groups, because $[a + b] = [a] + [b]$ is exactly how addition on $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ was defined (Example (Addition modulo n is well defined)); its kernel is $n\mathbb{Z}$. On the other hand, $x \mapsto x + 1$ from $(\mathbb{R}, +)$ to itself is not a homomorphism: writing $\varphi(x) = x + 1$, we get $\varphi(0 + 0) = 1$ but $\varphi(0) + \varphi(0) = 2$.

Theorem 0.10.3 — Basic properties of homomorphisms

Let $\varphi: G \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism of groups. Then $\varphi(e_G) = e_H$, $\varphi(a^{-1}) = \varphi(a)^{-1}$ for every $a \in G$, and $\ker \varphi$ is a subgroup of G .

Proof. Since $\varphi(e_G)\varphi(e_G) = \varphi(e_G e_G) = \varphi(e_G) = \varphi(e_G)e_H$, cancellation (Theorem 0.10.1) gives $\varphi(e_G) = e_H$. Next, $\varphi(a)\varphi(a^{-1}) = \varphi(aa^{-1}) = \varphi(e_G) = e_H$, and similarly $\varphi(a^{-1})\varphi(a) = e_H$, so $\varphi(a^{-1}) = \varphi(a)^{-1}$ by uniqueness of inverses. Finally, $e_G \in \ker \varphi$, and for $a, b \in \ker \varphi$,

$$\varphi(ab^{-1}) = \varphi(a)\varphi(b)^{-1} = e_H e_H^{-1} = e_H,$$

so $ab^{-1} \in \ker \varphi$. By Theorem 0.10.2, $\ker \varphi$ is a subgroup. This proves the theorem. ■

Two homomorphisms will matter later: the determinant $\text{GL}_n(F) \rightarrow F \setminus \{0\}$ and the sign $S_n \rightarrow \{1, -1\}$, both in Chapter 6. Linear maps in Chapter 3 are, among other things, homomorphisms of additive groups, and their kernels will be one of our main tools.

0.10.4 Permutations

A **permutation** of $\{1, \dots, n\}$ is a bijection $\{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\}$, and S_n is the group of all of them, the **symmetric group**. It has $n!$ elements: there are n choices for $\sigma(1)$, then $n-1$ for $\sigma(2)$, and so on.

A permutation σ can be written in **two-line notation**, with $\sigma(i)$ below i . A more compact notation lists what happens along a loop. For **distinct** $i_1, \dots, i_k \in \{1, \dots, n\}$, the **cycle** $(i_1 i_2 \cdots i_k)$ is the permutation sending

$$i_1 \mapsto i_2 \mapsto \cdots \mapsto i_k \mapsto i_1$$

and fixing every other element. A cycle of length 2 is a **transposition**: $(i j)$ swaps i and j . The same cycle can be written starting at any of its entries: $(1 2 3) = (2 3 1) = (3 1 2)$, but $(1 3 2)$ is different.

The product $\sigma\tau$ in S_n means the composition $\sigma \circ \tau$: **first apply τ , then σ** . So products of cycles are read **from right to left**.

Example. (Computing with cycles)

In S_3 , compute $(1 3)(1 2)$ and $(1 2)(1 3)$. In S_5 , write $\sigma = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 & 5 \\ 3 & 5 & 1 & 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ (two-line notation) as a product of cycles.

Solution. For $(1 3)(1 2)$, follow each element through $(1 2)$ first, then $(1 3)$: $1 \mapsto 2 \mapsto 2$, $2 \mapsto 1 \mapsto 3$, $3 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 1$. So $(1 3)(1 2) = (1 2 3)$. For $(1 2)(1 3)$: $1 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 3$, $3 \mapsto 1 \mapsto 2$, $2 \mapsto 2 \mapsto 1$. So $(1 2)(1 3) = (1 3 2)$. The two products differ, so S_3 is not abelian; the same two transpositions show that S_n is not abelian for every $n \geq 3$.

For σ , start at 1 and follow: $1 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 1$, a loop $(1 3)$. The smallest element not yet used

is 2: $2 \mapsto 5 \mapsto 4 \mapsto 2$, a loop $(2\ 5\ 4)$. Every element is now used, so $\sigma = (1\ 3)(2\ 5\ 4)$. These two cycles move disjoint sets of elements, so they can be applied in either order.

Warning. Mind the order. $\sigma\tau$ applies τ first, exactly as for functions, and as for matrices: $(AB)\mathbf{x} = A(B\mathbf{x})$ applies B first. Reading a product of cycles from left to right gives the wrong answer, as the two different products $(1\ 3)(1\ 2) \neq (1\ 2)(1\ 3)$ above show.

Quick check. Compute $(1\ 2\ 3)(1\ 2)$ in S_3 .

Solution. Apply $(1\ 2)$ first: $1 \mapsto 2 \mapsto 3$, $2 \mapsto 1 \mapsto 2$, $3 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 1$. So 1 and 3 are swapped and 2 is fixed: $(1\ 2\ 3)(1\ 2) = (1\ 3)$.

The example showed $(1\ 2\ 3) = (1\ 3)(1\ 2)$: a 3-cycle is a product of transpositions. Every permutation is, and the proof is a model induction on n .

Theorem 0.10.4 — Transpositions generate S_n

Let $n \geq 2$. Every permutation in S_n is a product of transpositions.

Idea. Induction on n : what is the smaller object inside a permutation of $n+1$ elements? If σ fixes $n+1$, it is really a permutation of $\{1, \dots, n\}$. If not, one transposition repairs that: swap $\sigma(n+1)$ back to $n+1$. The result fixes $n+1$, so the induction hypothesis applies, and we undo the swap.

Proof. We use induction on $n \geq 2$ (Theorem 0.2.7). For $n = 2$, $S_2 = \{\text{id}, (1\ 2)\}$, and $\text{id} = (1\ 2)(1\ 2)$.

Suppose every permutation in S_n is a product of transpositions, and let $\sigma \in S_{n+1}$.

Case 1. $\sigma(n+1) = n+1$. Since σ is injective, $\sigma(i) \neq n+1$ for $i \leq n$, so σ restricts to a function $\sigma': \{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\}$. It is injective because σ is, and hence bijective by Theorem 0.4.9. By the induction hypothesis, $\sigma' = \tau_1 \cdots \tau_r$ with transpositions $\tau_j \in S_n$. Regard each τ_j as a transposition in S_{n+1} fixing $n+1$. Then $\tau_1 \cdots \tau_r$ agrees with $\sigma' = \sigma$ on $\{1, \dots, n\}$ and fixes $n+1$, as σ does. Hence $\sigma = \tau_1 \cdots \tau_r$.

Case 2. $\sigma(n+1) = k \neq n+1$. Let $\tau = (k\ n+1)$. Then $(\tau\sigma)(n+1) = \tau(k) = n+1$, so by Case 1, $\tau\sigma = \tau_1 \cdots \tau_r$ for some transpositions τ_j . Since $\tau\tau = \text{id}$, multiplying on the left by τ gives $\sigma = \tau\tau_1 \cdots \tau_r$, a product of transpositions.

This completes the induction, and proves the theorem. ■

The product is not unique: $(1\ 2\ 3) = (1\ 3)(1\ 2) = (1\ 2)(2\ 3)$, and one can always insert $(1\ 2)(1\ 2) = \text{id}$. What turns out to be unique is whether the number of transpositions is even or odd. That fact defines the **sign** of a permutation, which we do not define here; it is the subject of Chapter 6, where it builds the determinant.

0.10.5 Exercises

0.10.5.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) State the three axioms of a group.
- (b) Is $\mathbb{Z}$ with the operation $(a, b) \mapsto a - b$ a group? Justify your answer.
- (c) Determine whether the following statement is true: “in every group, $(ab)^{-1} = a^{-1}b^{-1}$.” Justify your answer.
- (d) Compute $(1\ 3)(1\ 2\ 3)$ in S_3 .
- (e) Explain why $\{A \in M_2(\mathbb{R}) : A \text{ is not invertible}\}$ is **not** a subgroup of $GL_2(\mathbb{R})$.

Solution.

- (a) (G1) $(ab)c = a(bc)$ for all a, b, c ; (G2) there is e with $ea = ae = a$ for all a ; (G3) for every a there is b with $ab = ba = e$. The operation must be a binary operation $G \times G \rightarrow G$.
- (b) No. Associativity fails: $(1 - 1) - 1 = -1$, but $1 - (1 - 1) = 1$.
- (c) False. By [Theorem 0.10.1](#), $(ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1}$, and this can differ from $a^{-1}b^{-1}$. In S_3 take $a = (1\ 2)$ and $b = (1\ 3)$, which are their own inverses. By [Example \(Computing with cycles\)](#), $ab = (1\ 3\ 2)$, whose inverse is $(1\ 2\ 3)$, while $a^{-1}b^{-1} = ab = (1\ 3\ 2)$. The statement is true in abelian groups.
- (d) Apply $(1\ 2\ 3)$ first: $1 \mapsto 2 \mapsto 2$, $2 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 1$, $3 \mapsto 1 \mapsto 3$. Hence $(1\ 3)(1\ 2\ 3) = (1\ 2)$.
- (e) It is not even a subset of $GL_2(\mathbb{R})$, since its elements are not invertible; for instance it does not contain the identity I_2 .

0.10.5.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: The table of S_3 .

List the six elements of S_3 in cycle notation and write out the table whose entry in row x and column y is xy . Hence find all elements $x \in S_3$ with $x^2 = \text{id}$, and all x that commute with every element of S_3 .

Solution. The elements are $\text{id}, (1\ 2), (1\ 3), (2\ 3), (1\ 2\ 3), (1\ 3\ 2)$. Computing each product right to left, as in [Example \(Computing with cycles\)](#), the entry in row x , column y is xy :

xy	id	$(1\ 2)$	$(1\ 3)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	$(1\ 3\ 2)$
id	id	$(1\ 2)$	$(1\ 3)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	$(1\ 3\ 2)$
$(1\ 2)$	$(1\ 2)$	id	$(1\ 3\ 2)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 3)$
$(1\ 3)$	$(1\ 3)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	id	$(1\ 3\ 2)$	$(1\ 2)$	$(2\ 3)$
$(2\ 3)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 3\ 2)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	id	$(1\ 3)$	$(1\ 2)$
$(1\ 2\ 3)$	$(1\ 2\ 3)$	$(1\ 3)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 2)$	$(1\ 3\ 2)$	id
$(1\ 3\ 2)$	$(1\ 3\ 2)$	$(2\ 3)$	$(1\ 2)$	$(1\ 3)$	id	$(1\ 2\ 3)$

For example, the entry in row $(1\ 2)$, column $(2\ 3)$ is $(1\ 2)(2\ 3)$: $1 \mapsto 1 \mapsto 2$, $2 \mapsto 3 \mapsto 3$, $3 \mapsto 2 \mapsto 1$, which is $(1\ 2\ 3)$.

Reading the diagonal, $x^2 = \text{id}$ exactly for $x = \text{id}, (1\ 2), (1\ 3), (2\ 3)$. An element x commutes with every element exactly when row x equals column x . This holds for id . It fails for every other element: $(1\ 2)(1\ 3) = (1\ 3\ 2) \neq (1\ 2\ 3) = (1\ 3)(1\ 2)$ handles $(1\ 2)$ and $(1\ 3)$; $(2\ 3)(1\ 2) = (1\ 3\ 2) \neq (1\ 2\ 3) = (1\ 2)(2\ 3)$ handles $(2\ 3)$; and $(1\ 2\ 3)(1\ 2) = (1\ 3) \neq (2\ 3) = (1\ 2)(1\ 2\ 3)$ handles $(1\ 2\ 3)$ and, since $(1\ 3\ 2)(1\ 2) = (2\ 3) \neq (1\ 3) = (1\ 2)(1\ 3\ 2)$, also $(1\ 3\ 2)$. Hence only id commutes with everything.

Exercise B2: Invertible upper triangular matrices.

Let F be a field and $T = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix} : a, b, d \in F, a \neq 0, d \neq 0 \right\}$.

- (a) Prove that T is a subgroup of $\text{GL}_2(F)$.
- (b) For which fields F is T abelian? Justify your answer.

Solution.

- (a) Let $X = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix} \in T$. Since $a, d \neq 0$, $ad - b \cdot 0 = ad \neq 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#), so X is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.8](#). Hence $T \subseteq \text{GL}_2(F)$, and $T \neq \emptyset$ since $I_2 \in T$. Now let $Y = \begin{pmatrix} a' & b' \\ 0 & d' \end{pmatrix} \in T$. By [Theorem 0.9.8](#), $Y^{-1} = (a'd')^{-1} \begin{pmatrix} d' & -b' \\ 0 & a' \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a'^{-1} & -b'(a'd')^{-1} \\ 0 & d'^{-1} \end{pmatrix}$. Therefore

$$XY^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} aa'^{-1} & -ab'(a'd')^{-1} + bd'^{-1} \\ 0 & dd'^{-1} \end{pmatrix},$$

whose $(2, 1)$ -entry is 0 and whose diagonal entries aa'^{-1} , dd'^{-1} are non-zero by [Theorem 0.7.1](#). So $XY^{-1} \in T$, and T is a subgroup by [Theorem 0.10.2](#).

- (b) It depends on the field. *Case 1:* F has an element c with $c \neq 0$ and $c \neq 1$ (for example $c = 2$ in $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{F}_3$). Let $X = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $Y = \text{diag}(1, c)$, both in T . Then $XY = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & c \\ 0 & c \end{pmatrix}$ and $YX = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & c \end{pmatrix}$, which differ in the $(1, 2)$ -entry since $c \neq 1$. So T is **not** abelian. *Case 2:* $F = \{0, 1\}$, that is, $F = \mathbb{F}_2$. Then $a = d = 1$ is forced, so $T = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & b \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} : b \in \mathbb{F}_2 \right\}$, and $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & b \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & b' \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & b+b' \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ is symmetric in b, b' . So T is abelian over $\mathbb{F}_2$, and over every other field it is not.

Exercise B3: The exponential is an isomorphism.

Let $\mathbb{R}_{>0} = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x > 0\}$. Show that $(\mathbb{R}_{>0}, \cdot)$ is a group, and that $\exp: (\mathbb{R}, +) \rightarrow (\mathbb{R}_{>0}, \cdot)$, $x \mapsto e^x$, is an isomorphism. What is its kernel? You may use the familiar facts $e^{x+y} = e^x e^y$, $e^x > 0$, and that $\ln: \mathbb{R}_{>0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfies $\ln(e^x) = x$ and $e^{\ln y} = y$.

Solution. A product of positive reals is positive, so multiplication is a binary operation on $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$. It is associative, $1 \in \mathbb{R}_{>0}$ is an identity, and for $y > 0$ the inverse $1/y$ is positive. Hence $(\mathbb{R}_{>0}, \cdot)$ is a group.

Since $e^x > 0$, $\exp$ maps $\mathbb{R}$ into $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$, and $e^{x+y} = e^x e^y$ says exactly that it is a homomorphism from $(\mathbb{R}, +)$ to $(\mathbb{R}_{>0}, \cdot)$. The function $\ln$ satisfies $\ln \circ \exp = \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}}$ and $\exp \circ \ln = \text{id}_{\mathbb{R}_{>0}}$, so $\exp$ is bijective by [Theorem 0.4.7](#). Hence $\exp$ is an isomorphism. Its kernel is $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : e^x = 1\} = \{0\}$, since $\exp$ is injective and $e^0 = 1$.

0.10.5.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Every element its own inverse.

- (a) Let G be a group in which $g^2 = gg = e$ for every $g \in G$. Prove that G is abelian.
- (b) Show that $(M_2(\mathbb{F}_2), +)$ is an example of such a group, written additively.

Solution.

- (a) Let $a, b \in G$. The hypothesis $gg = e$ says that every g is its own inverse, by uniqueness of inverses ([Theorem 0.10.1](#)). Applying this to ab , a and b , and using [Theorem 0.10.1](#),

$$ab = (ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1} = ba.$$

Hence G is abelian.

- (b) $(M_2(\mathbb{F}_2), +)$ is a group by [Theorem 0.9.1](#): addition is associative, 0 is an identity, and $-A$ is an inverse. In additive notation, “ $g^2 = e$ ” reads $A + A = 0$, and indeed $(A + A)_{ij} = a_{ij} + a_{ij} = (1 + 1)a_{ij} = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$. (This group is abelian anyway, consistent with (a).)

Exercise C2: The order of a product of disjoint cycles.

The **order** of $\sigma \in S_n$ is the smallest integer $m \geq 1$ with $\sigma^m = \text{id}$, where σ^m is the product of m copies of σ . Two cycles are **disjoint** if no element appears in both.

- (a) Let $\sigma = (i_1 \cdots i_k)$ be a k -cycle. Prove that $\sigma^m = \text{id}$ if and only if k divides m . Deduce that σ has order k .
- (b) Prove that disjoint cycles σ and τ commute, and deduce $(\sigma\tau)^m = \sigma^m\tau^m$ for all $m \geq 1$.
- (c) Let σ be a k -cycle and τ an l -cycle, disjoint. Prove that $\sigma\tau$ has order $\text{lcm}(k, l)$.
- (d) Find the order of $(1\ 2)(3\ 4\ 5) \in S_5$.

Hint for (c): σ^m moves only elements that appear in σ .

Solution.

- (a) Index the entries of the cycle modulo k , so $\sigma(i_j) = i_{j+1}$ with $i_{k+1} = i_1$. By induction on m , $\sigma^m(i_j) = i_{j+m}$, indices taken modulo k , and σ^m fixes every element not in the cycle. Hence $\sigma^m = \text{id}$ if and only if $i_{j+m} = i_j$ for all j . Since $i_1, \dots, i_k$ are distinct, this holds if and only if $j + m \equiv j \pmod{k}$, that is, $k \mid m$. The smallest $m \geq 1$ with $k \mid m$ is k , so σ has order k .

- (b) Let A and B be the disjoint sets of elements appearing in σ and τ . Note that σ maps A to A and fixes everything outside A , and τ does the same with B . Let $i \in \{1, \dots, n\}$. If $i \in A$, then $i \notin B$ and $\sigma(i) \in A$, so $\sigma(i) \notin B$; hence $\sigma\tau(i) = \sigma(i) = \tau\sigma(i)$. The case $i \in B$ is the same with the roles swapped. If $i \notin A \cup B$, both sides give i . Hence $\sigma\tau = \tau\sigma$. Then $(\sigma\tau)^m = \sigma^m\tau^m$ follows by induction on m : $(\sigma\tau)^{m+1} = \sigma^m\tau^m\sigma\tau = \sigma^m\sigma\tau^m\tau = \sigma^{m+1}\tau^{m+1}$, moving σ past τ one factor at a time, which is allowed because they commute.
- (c) By (b), $(\sigma\tau)^m = \sigma^m\tau^m$. We claim this is id if and only if $\sigma^m = \text{id}$ and $\tau^m = \text{id}$. One direction is clear. Conversely, suppose $\sigma^m\tau^m = \text{id}$, and let $i \in A$. Then $i \notin B$, so $\tau^m(i) = i$ by the hint, and $\sigma^m(i) = \sigma^m\tau^m(i) = i$. Since σ^m also fixes every $i \notin A$, $\sigma^m = \text{id}$, and then $\tau^m = \sigma^m\tau^m = \text{id}$ as well. By (a), $(\sigma\tau)^m = \text{id}$ if and only if $k \mid m$ and $l \mid m$. The smallest such $m \geq 1$ is $\text{lcm}(k, l)$, which is therefore the order of $\sigma\tau$.
- (d) $(1\ 2)$ and $(3\ 4\ 5)$ are disjoint cycles of lengths 2 and 3, so by (c) the order is $\text{lcm}(2, 3) = 6$.

Chapter 1

Vector Spaces

Arrows in the plane can be added and stretched. So can solutions of a homogeneous system of equations, polynomials, matrices, and real-valued functions. In each case the same handful of rules governs the arithmetic, and none of the arguments we care about uses anything beyond those rules. This chapter names the structure, a **vector space**, so that every theorem proved once holds for all of these examples at the same time.

The second half of the chapter answers a question that sounds innocent: how big is a vector space? The spaces $\mathbb{R}^3$, $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ and the symmetric 2×2 matrices are all infinite sets, yet each is “three-dimensional” in a precise sense. Making that sense precise, and proving that it does not depend on any choices, takes the Exchange Theorem, the most important proof in the chapter. Everything later in the book measures with the dimension defined here.

What you need. From Chapter 0: fields ([Definition 0.7.1](#)) and their basic arithmetic ([Theorem 0.7.1](#)), sets and double inclusion ([Theorem 0.3.1](#)), functions, and induction ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)). Polynomials ([Definition 0.8.1](#)) and matrices ([Definition 0.9.1](#)) supply many of the examples.

1.0.1 Roadmap

- **Vector spaces.** The eight axioms, a gallery of examples and non-examples, and the first consequences of the axioms.
- **Subspaces.** A subset that is a vector space in its own right, recognized by three checks.
- **Linear combinations and span.** Everything that can be built from a list of vectors, and the smallest subspace containing them.
- **Linear independence.** When a list contains no redundant vector, and the Linear Dependence Lemma that finds the redundant one when it does.
- **Bases and coordinates.** Lists that span without waste; every vector gets unique coordinates, and every finite spanning list can be trimmed to a basis.
- **The Exchange Theorem and dimension.** Independent lists are never longer than spanning lists, so all bases have the same length; extending bases and counting instead of checking.
- **Sums and direct sums.** Combining subspaces, the dimension formula, and splitting a space into independent pieces.
- **Infinite-dimensional spaces.** Every vector space has a basis (via Zorn’s lemma), and which finite-dimensional facts fail without finiteness.
- **Changing the field.** The same set viewed over a smaller or larger field: restriction of

scalars, the tower law, and complexification.

1.0.2 Named moves

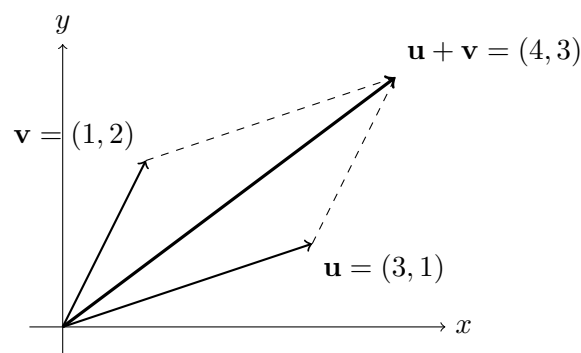
- **The three-check subspace test.** Zero vector, closed under addition, closed under scaling, each check ending with its own sentence.
- **“Let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$.”** The first line of every independence proof; the goal is then to show every a_i is zero.
- **Exchange one vector at a time.** Swap a vector of an independent list into a spanning list without losing the span.
- **Count instead of check.** In a space of dimension n , an independent list of length n is automatically a basis, and so is a spanning list of length n .
- **Basis of the smallest space, then extend.** For any dimension formula, start from a basis of the smallest subspace in sight, extend it, and count.

1.1 Vector Spaces

Chapter 0 met several kinds of objects that can be added and scaled: pairs of real numbers, polynomials, matrices. Each time we checked the same handful of rules by hand. This section collects those rules into one definition, the vector space, and proves the first consequences once, so that they hold in every example at the same time.

1.1.1 One set of rules in three places

Start with the plane $\mathbb{R}^2$. A pair $\mathbf{u} = (3, 1)$ can be pictured as an arrow from the origin to the point $(3, 1)$. Two arrows are added tip to tail, which is the same as taking the diagonal of the parallelogram they span, and an arrow is scaled by stretching it.



The picture shows one rule at once: going along $\mathbf{u}$ and then $\mathbf{v}$ ends at the same corner as going along $\mathbf{v}$ and then $\mathbf{u}$, so $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u}$. Other rules are just as familiar. Scaling a sum is the same as adding the scaled arrows, $2(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = 2\mathbf{u} + 2\mathbf{v}$. Adding the zero arrow changes nothing, and every arrow is undone by its reverse.

Now look at polynomials of degree at most 2. We add them coefficient by coefficient,

$$(1 + 2x - x^2) + (3 - x + 4x^2) = 4 + x + 3x^2,$$

and scale them the same way, $2(1 + 2x - x^2) = 2 + 4x - 2x^2$. There is no picture of arrows here, yet the rules are identical: order does not matter in a sum, the zero polynomial changes nothing, and $-1 - 2x + x^2$ undoes $1 + 2x - x^2$.

The same happens for 2×2 real matrices. [Theorem 0.9.1](#) lists the rules for adding matrices and multiplying them by numbers, and they are again the same rules.

Arrows, polynomials and matrices are very different objects, but many arguments about them only use these rules. If we prove a statement from the rules alone, it holds for arrows, polynomials and matrices at once, and for every other system obeying the rules. So we list the rules once and give the systems that obey them a name.

A vector space is a set whose elements can be added and scaled by numbers from a field, with the usual rules of arithmetic.

1.1.2 The definition

Definition 1.1.1 — Vector Space

Let F be a field. A **vector space over F** is a set V together with two functions

$$+ : V \times V \rightarrow V, (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) \mapsto \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}, \quad \cdot : F \times V \rightarrow V, (a, \mathbf{v}) \mapsto a\mathbf{v},$$

called **addition** and **scalar multiplication**, such that the following axioms hold.

- (VS1) $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u}$ for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (VS2) $(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u} + (\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w})$ for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in V$.
- (VS3) There exists an element $\mathbf{0} \in V$ such that $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{v}$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (VS4) For every $\mathbf{v} \in V$ there exists an element $\mathbf{v}' \in V$ such that $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{0}$.
- (VS5) $a(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = a\mathbf{u} + a\mathbf{v}$ for all $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (VS6) $(a + b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{v}$ for all $a, b \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (VS7) $a(b\mathbf{v}) = (ab)\mathbf{v}$ for all $a, b \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (VS8) $1\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v}$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in V$, where 1 is the identity element of F .

Read the definition clause by clause.

- **The two functions.** Addition takes two elements of V and returns an element of V . Scalar multiplication takes a number from F and an element of V and returns an element of V . So “the sum stays in the set” and “a multiple stays in the set” are not extra axioms: they are built into the word “function into V ”. When we test a candidate, this closure is the first thing to check.
- **(VS1)–(VS4)** concern addition alone. It is commutative and associative, there is a vector $\mathbf{0}$ that changes nothing, and every vector can be undone. These are the axioms (F1)–(F4) of [Definition 0.7.1](#), now for vectors.
- **(VS5) and (VS6)** are the two distributive laws. In (VS6) the symbol $+$ appears twice with two meanings: on the left it adds scalars in F , on the right it adds vectors in V .
- **(VS7)** says scaling by b and then by a is scaling by the product ab , computed in F .
- **(VS8)** says the scalar 1 acts as it should. It looks too obvious to state, but we will see below that it cannot be dropped.

Note the order of quantifiers in (VS3): **one** vector $\mathbf{0}$ works for **every** $\mathbf{v}$. In (VS4) the vector $\mathbf{v}'$ is allowed to depend on $\mathbf{v}$.

Definition 1.1.2 — Vectors and Scalars

Let V be a vector space over F . The elements of V are called **vectors**, and the elements of F are called **scalars**. The element $\mathbf{0}$ in (VS3) is a **zero vector** of V , and an element $\mathbf{v}'$ as in (VS4) is an **additive inverse** of $\mathbf{v}$.

A vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ is also called a **real vector space**, and one over $\mathbb{C}$ a **complex vector space**. When the operations are clear from context, we say “ V is a vector space over F ” instead of naming the triple $(V, +, \cdot)$. The field is part of the data, and we will see shortly that changing it changes the space.

We wrote “**a** zero vector” and “**an** additive inverse” on purpose. The axioms only say these exist. That there is only one of each is a theorem, proved later in this section.

Warning. Two different zeros. The scalar $0 \in F$ and the zero vector $\mathbf{0} \in V$ are different objects. In $M_2(\mathbb{R})$, the scalar is the number 0 and the zero vector is the zero matrix; in $\mathbb{R}^3$, the zero vector is $(0, 0, 0)$. This book writes the zero vector in bold. An equation such as $0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ has a scalar on the left and a vector on the right, and mixing them up produces statements that make no sense, such as “ $\mathbf{v} = 0$ ” for a matrix $\mathbf{v}$.

1.1.3 Examples

We start with the families we will use throughout the book. For each, the work is to say what the operations are and why the axioms hold. We check some axioms in full and point out the pattern for the rest.

Example. (The Standard Vector Spaces)

Let F be a field. Explain why each of the following is a vector space over F .

- (a) F^n , with entrywise addition and scalar multiplication.
- (b) $M_{m \times n}(F)$, with the matrix operations of Definition 0.9.6 and Definition 0.9.7.
- (c) $F[x]$, with the addition of Definition 0.8.2 and $c \sum a_k x^k := \sum (ca_k) x^k$.
- (d) For a set X , the set F^X of **all** functions $X \rightarrow F$, with the **pointwise** operations

$$(f + g)(t) := f(t) + g(t), \quad (af)(t) := af(t) \quad \text{for all } t \in X.$$

- (e) The set $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ of all sequences $(s_0, s_1, s_2, \dots)$ of elements of F , with termwise operations.

Solution.

- (b) The sum and scalar multiple of $m \times n$ matrices are $m \times n$ matrices, so both operations are functions into $M_{m \times n}(F)$. The eight axioms are exactly the rules of Theorem 0.9.1, with the zero matrix as $\mathbf{0}$ and $-A$ as an additive inverse of A .
- (c) Chapter 0 defines $F^n = M_{n \times 1}(F)$, the column vectors, and the entrywise opera-

tions are the matrix operations. So (a) is the case of (b) with n rows and 1 column. The zero vector is $(0, \dots, 0)$.

- (d) The formulas define functions $f + g$ and af from X to F , so the operations land in F^X . Two functions $X \rightarrow F$ are equal when they take the same value at every $t \in X$ (Definition 0.4.1), so each axiom is checked one point at a time. For (VS3), let $\mathbf{0}$ be the zero function, $\mathbf{0}(t) = 0$ for all t . Then $(f + \mathbf{0})(t) = f(t) + 0 = f(t)$ for every t , by (F3), so $f + \mathbf{0} = f$. For (VS4), let $f'(t) := -f(t)$. Then $(f + f')(t) = f(t) + (-f(t)) = 0 = \mathbf{0}(t)$ by (F4), so $f + f' = \mathbf{0}$. For (VS6), let $a, b \in F$. For every $t \in X$,

$$((a + b)f)(t) = (a + b)f(t) = af(t) + bf(t) = (af)(t) + (bf)(t) = (af + bf)(t),$$

where the second equality is (F9) together with (F6) in F . Hence $(a + b)f = af + bf$. The other five axioms reduce in the same way to a field axiom at each point: (VS1) to (F1), (VS2) to (F2), (VS5) to (F9), (VS7) to (F5), and (VS8) to (F7) with (F6).

- (e) A sequence $(s_0, s_1, \dots)$ is a function $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow F$, $k \mapsto s_k$, and the termwise operations are the pointwise ones. So (e) is (d) with $X = \mathbb{N}$.
- (f) Let $p = \sum a_k x^k \in F[x]$ and $c \in F$. Only finitely many a_k are non-zero, and $a_k = 0$ forces $ca_k = 0$, so cp is again a polynomial. The sum of polynomials is a polynomial by Definition 0.8.2. By Theorem 0.8.1 (parts 1 and 2), addition satisfies (VS1)–(VS4), with the zero polynomial as $\mathbf{0}$ and $-p$ as an additive inverse. Since polynomials are equal when their coefficients agree (Definition 0.8.1), (VS5)–(VS8) are checked coefficient by coefficient. For instance, the coefficient of x^k in $(c + d)p$ is $(c + d)a_k = ca_k + da_k$, which is the coefficient of x^k in $cp + dp$. The others reduce in the same way: (VS5) to (F9), (VS7) to (F5), and (VS8) to (F7) with (F6).

The pattern is worth naming. Whenever the operations are defined **entry by entry**, **point by point** or **coefficient by coefficient**, each axiom for vectors is a field axiom applied in each slot. In fact (a), (b) and (e) are all instances of (d): a column in F^n is a function $\{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow F$, and a matrix in $M_{m \times n}(F)$ is a function on the set of positions $\{1, \dots, m\} \times \{1, \dots, n\}$.

A **subset** of a known space often works just as well, provided the operations do not lead out of it.

The set $F[x]_{\leq n}$ of Definition 0.8.4 is a vector space over F , with the operations of $F[x]$. Closure is the only real issue. If $\deg p \leq n$ and $\deg q \leq n$, then $\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q) \leq n$ by Theorem 0.8.2. If $a_k = 0$ for all $k > n$, then $ca_k = 0$ for all $k > n$, so $\deg(cp) \leq n$. The zero polynomial has degree $-\infty \leq n$, and $-p$ has the same coefficients as p up to sign, so it stays in $F[x]_{\leq n}$. The six axioms (VS1), (VS2), (VS5)–(VS8) are equations that hold for **all** polynomials, so in particular for those of degree at most n .

The next example applies the same pattern to a set of real numbers, with a smaller field of scalars.

Example. $(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ over $\mathbb{Q}$)

Let $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) = \{a + b\sqrt{2} : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\}$, with the addition of $\mathbb{R}$ and with scalar multiplication $c(a + b\sqrt{2}) := ca + cb\sqrt{2}$ for $c \in \mathbb{Q}$. Show that $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Solution. Let $\mathbf{u} = a + b\sqrt{2}$ and $\mathbf{v} = a' + b'\sqrt{2}$ with $a, b, a', b' \in \mathbb{Q}$, and let $c \in \mathbb{Q}$.

Closure. We have $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = (a + a') + (b + b')\sqrt{2}$ and $c\mathbf{u} = ca + cb\sqrt{2}$. Sums and

products of rationals are rational, so both lie in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$. Hence addition is a function $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) \times \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, and scalar multiplication is a function $\mathbb{Q} \times \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.

Zero and additive inverses. The number $0 = 0 + 0\sqrt{2}$ lies in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and satisfies $\mathbf{u} + 0 = \mathbf{u}$, so (VS3) holds. The number $-\mathbf{u} = (-a) + (-b)\sqrt{2}$ lies in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and satisfies $\mathbf{u} + (-\mathbf{u}) = 0$, so (VS4) holds.

The identities. Scalar multiplication by $c \in \mathbb{Q}$ is the multiplication of real numbers, since $c(a + b\sqrt{2}) = ca + cb\sqrt{2}$ in $\mathbb{R}$. So each of (VS1), (VS2) and (VS5)–(VS8) is an identity between real numbers, and it holds by the field axioms of $\mathbb{R}$: (VS1) is (F1), (VS2) is (F2), (VS5) is (F9), (VS6) is (F9) with (F6), (VS7) is (F5), and (VS8) is (F7) with (F6). Hence $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$.

We saw in [Example \(\$\mathbb{Q}\(\sqrt{2}\)\$ Is a Field\)](#) that $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is even a field. As a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$, we simply ignore how to multiply two of its elements together and keep only multiplication by rationals.

The same set can carry more than one field of scalars. The next example makes this concrete.

Example. (The Same Set over Different Fields)

Explain why $\mathbb{C}$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$ and also over $\mathbb{R}$, and why $\mathbb{R}$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ and also over $\mathbb{Q}$. In each case the addition is the usual one and the scalar multiplication is the usual product.

Solution. $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{C}$ is F^1 for $F = \mathbb{C}$, covered by [Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (a). For $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$, a real number r is the complex number $r + 0i$, and rz is their complex product, which lies in $\mathbb{C}$. Each axiom is an identity among complex numbers in which some of the numbers happen to be real, so it holds by [Proposition 0.6.1](#): (VS5) and (VS6) by distributivity together with commutativity, (VS7) by associativity of multiplication, and (VS8) since $1 \cdot z = z$. The argument for $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ is the same, with the field axioms of $\mathbb{R}$ in place of the laws of $\mathbb{C}$.

As sets, $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{C}$ and $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$ are the same. As vector spaces they differ, because the scalars available differ. In $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{C}$, the vector i is a scalar multiple of the vector 1 . In $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$ it is not, since $r \cdot 1 = i$ has no real solution r . Later in this chapter this difference becomes a difference in dimension. That is why we always say **over which field**.

The degenerate case. The set $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ with one element, with $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ and $a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $a \in F$, is a vector space over any field. Every axiom is an equation between elements that all equal $\mathbf{0}$, and $\mathbf{0}$ serves as the zero vector and as its own additive inverse. It is called the **zero space**. It matters because it turns up constantly as an answer: the only solution of a system, or the smallest vector space inside every other one. Unlike a field, which must contain $1 \neq 0$ ([Definition 0.7.1](#)), a vector space is allowed to have a single element, since no axiom asks for a vector different from $\mathbf{0}$.

A final example looks strange, but it satisfies every axiom.

Example. (Positive Reals with Exotic Operations)

Let $V = \mathbb{R}_{>0} = \{t \in \mathbb{R} : t > 0\}$. For $u, v \in V$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$, define

$$u \boxplus v := uv, \quad c \boxminus v := v^c.$$

Show that these operations are functions into V , find the zero vector and the additive inverse of v , and check (VS6) and (VS8).

Solution. Closure. For $u, v > 0$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$, the product uv is positive and the power v^c is positive. So $\boxplus: V \times V \rightarrow V$ and $\boxminus: \mathbb{R} \times V \rightarrow V$.

(VS3). We need $z \in V$ with $v \boxplus z = v$, that is, $vz = v$, for every $v > 0$. The number $z = 1$ works, since $v \cdot 1 = v$. So the zero vector of V is the real number 1.

(VS4). For $v \in V$, we need $v' \in V$ with $v \boxplus v' = 1$, that is, $vv' = 1$. The number $v' = 1/v$ is positive and works. So the additive inverse of v is $1/v$.

(VS6). For $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ and $v \in V$, by the laws of exponents,

$$(a + b) \boxminus v = v^{a+b} = v^a v^b = (a \boxminus v) \boxplus (b \boxminus v).$$

(VS8). $1 \boxminus v = v^1 = v$.

The remaining axioms (VS1), (VS2), (VS5) and (VS7) are [Exercise \(B3: Finishing the Positive Reals\)](#). So V is a real vector space.

This example earns its place for one reason. The words “zero vector” and “addition” describe **roles** fixed by the axioms, not the familiar number 0 or the familiar $+$. Here the vector playing the role of **0** is the number 1, and “adding” means multiplying.

Quick check. Explain why each of the following, with the usual operations, is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$.

- (a) The set S of twice-differentiable functions $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with $f'' + f = 0$.
- (b) The set of symmetric matrices $A \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$, that is, those with $A^\top = A$.

Solution. Both are subsets of known spaces, so we use the pattern after [Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#): check closure, the zero vector and additive inverses; the other six axioms are identities inherited from the big space.

- (a) $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$. If $f, g \in S$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$, then by the sum and constant multiple rules of calculus, $f + g$ and cf are twice differentiable, with $(f + g)'' + (f + g) = (f'' + f) + (g'' + g) = 0$ and $(cf)'' + cf = c(f'' + f) = 0$. So both lie in S . The zero function **0** satisfies $\mathbf{0}'' + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, so $\mathbf{0} \in S$. If $f \in S$, its additive inverse in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is $t \mapsto -f(t)$, and $-f(t) = (-1)f(t)$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (e); so it is the function $(-1)f$, which lies in S by closure under scaling. The identities hold in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ ([Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (d)), hence in S . For instance $\sin$ and $\cos$ lie in S .
- (b) By [Theorem 0.9.5](#), $(A + B)^\top = A^\top + B^\top = A + B$ and $(cA)^\top = cA^\top = cA$ when $A^\top = A$ and $B^\top = B$. The zero matrix is symmetric, and the additive inverse $-A$, which Chapter 0 defines as $(-1)A$, is symmetric by closure under scaling. The identities hold in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$, hence for symmetric matrices.

1.1.4 Non-examples

Each non-example below is a small change to an example. We say what still works and name the exact clause that fails.

- **Change scalar multiplication on $\mathbb{R}^2$ to $c(x, y) := (cx, 0)$** , keeping the usual addition. Addition is untouched, so (VS1)–(VS4) hold. (VS5) holds: $c((x, y) + (x', y')) = (c(x + x'), 0) = (cx, 0) + (cx', 0)$. In the same way (VS6) and (VS7) hold. But $1(0, 1) = (0, 0) \neq (0, 1)$, so **(VS8) fails**.
- **Change the line $x + 2y = 0$ to $x + 2y = 3$** . Let $L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x + 2y = 3\}$ with the operations of $\mathbb{R}^2$. The points $(3, 0)$ and $(1, 1)$ lie on L , but their sum $(4, 1)$ has $4 + 2 \cdot 1 = 6 \neq 3$. So addition is **not a function** $L \times L \rightarrow L$, and L is not a vector space with these operations.
- **Change “degree at most 2” to “degree exactly 2”**. In $\mathbb{R}[x]_{=2}$ (Definition 0.8.5), $x^2 + 2x$ and $-x^2 + 3$ have degree 2, but their sum $2x + 3$ has degree 1. Again addition leaves the set. There is no zero vector either: the zero polynomial has degree $-\infty$, not 2.
- **Change the entries from real to integer**, keeping $\mathbb{R}$ as the field. For $\mathbb{Z}^2 \subseteq \mathbb{R}^2$, addition is fine, but $\frac{1}{2}(1, 0) = (\frac{1}{2}, 0) \notin \mathbb{Z}^2$. So scalar multiplication is **not a function** $\mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{Z}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^2$.

1.1.5 Why these axioms

Each axiom is there for a reason, and a few conventions deserve a comment.

- **(VS8) cannot be dropped**. The first non-example satisfies all other axioms. Without (VS8), the “scalar multiplication” $c\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ for all c and $\mathbf{v}$ would also be allowed, and scaling would carry no information at all.
- **(VS1) is in fact redundant**. Commutativity of addition follows from the other seven axioms, by expanding $(1 + 1)(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v})$ in two ways (Exercise (C1: Commutativity Comes for Free)). It is kept because the proof is fiddly and nobody wants to repeat it.
- **Closure is not optional**. Two of the non-examples fail only because an operation leads out of the set. That is why the definition asks for **functions into V** .
- **The scalars form a field**. We use division by non-zero scalars in the zero product law at the end of the next subsection. The warning after it shows what goes wrong without division.
- **The name**. “Vector” originally meant an arrow in physics. The word is kept for elements of any vector space, even when they are polynomials or functions.

1.1.6 First consequences of the axioms

The definition says a zero vector and additive inverses **exist**, not that they are unique. Before writing $\mathbf{0}$ and $-\mathbf{v}$ as if each named one thing, we prove uniqueness. We also prove that familiar rules such as $0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ follow from the axioms. None of this is obvious from the axioms: in Example (Positive Reals with Exotic Operations), $0 \boxplus v = v^0 = 1$, which happens to be the zero vector there, and it takes a proof to see that this is no coincidence.

Throughout, we use one fact about functions without further comment: if two inputs are equal, the outputs are equal. So from $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$ we may conclude $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ and $a\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{w}$.

The first tool lets us cancel a vector from both sides of an equation.

Theorem 1.1.1 — Left Cancellation Law

Let V be a vector space over F and let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in V$. If $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$, then $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$.

Proof. Suppose $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$. By (VS4) there is $\mathbf{u}' \in V$ with $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}' = \mathbf{0}$. Adding $\mathbf{u}'$ on the left of both sides gives $\mathbf{u}' + (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{u}' + (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w})$, and by (VS2),

$$(\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u}) + \mathbf{v} = (\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u}) + \mathbf{w}.$$

By (VS1) and the choice of $\mathbf{u}'$, $\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}' = \mathbf{0}$. Hence $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{w}$. By (VS1) this is $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{0}$, and by (VS3), $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$. ■

Theorem 1.1.2 — Right Cancellation Law

Let V be a vector space over F and let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in V$. If $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u}$, then $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$.

Proof. By (VS1), the hypothesis says $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$. By [Theorem 1.1.1](#), $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$. ■

Uniqueness uses the standard move from Chapter 0: suppose there are two, and show they are equal.

Theorem 1.1.3 — Zero Vector Is Unique

Let V be a vector space over F . There is exactly one element $\mathbf{0} \in V$ satisfying (VS3).

Proof. Existence is (VS3). Suppose $\mathbf{0}$ and $\mathbf{0}'$ both satisfy (VS3). Applying (VS3) for $\mathbf{0}'$ to the vector $\mathbf{0}$, then (VS1), then (VS3) for $\mathbf{0}$ to the vector $\mathbf{0}'$,

$$\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0}' = \mathbf{0}' + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}'.$$

This shows the zero vector is unique. ■

Theorem 1.1.4 — Additive Inverse Is Unique

Let V be a vector space over F and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. There is exactly one $\mathbf{v}' \in V$ with $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{0}$.

Proof. Existence is (VS4). Suppose $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{0}$ and $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}'' = \mathbf{0}$. Then $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}''$, and [Theorem 1.1.1](#) gives $\mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{v}''$. ■

Since the inverse is unique, it deserves a name.

Definition 1.1.3 — Notation for the Additive Inverse

Let V be a vector space over F and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. The unique additive inverse of $\mathbf{v}$ is denoted $-\mathbf{v}$. For $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$ we write $\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v} := \mathbf{u} + (-\mathbf{v})$.

For example, $\mathbf{v} + (-\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{0}$ and $(-\mathbf{v}) + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by (VS1), so $\mathbf{v}$ is the additive inverse of $-\mathbf{v}$. By Theorem 1.1.4, $-(-\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{v}$.

Remark. Axioms (VS1)–(VS4) say that V with addition is an abelian group (Definition 0.10.1). So the four results above are also special cases of Theorem 0.10.1. We proved them directly to practice citing the axioms.

Now to scalars. No axiom mentions $0\mathbf{v}$, so we must create a situation in which one applies. The move is to write the scalar 0 in a fancy way, as $0 + 0$, expand with a distributive law, and cancel. We will call it **expand zero and cancel**.

Theorem 1.1.5 — Zero Scalar Gives the Zero Vector

Let V be a vector space over F . Then $0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Since $0 + 0 = 0$ in F by (F3), (VS6) gives

$$0\mathbf{v} + 0\mathbf{v} = (0 + 0)\mathbf{v} = 0\mathbf{v} = 0\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0},$$

where the last equality is (VS3). By Theorem 1.1.1, $0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. ■

The same move, with the zero vector in place of the zero scalar, handles $a\mathbf{0}$.

Theorem 1.1.6 — Scalar Multiple of the Zero Vector

Let V be a vector space over F . Then $a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $a \in F$.

Proof. Let $a \in F$. Since $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ by (VS3), (VS5) gives

$$a\mathbf{0} + a\mathbf{0} = a(\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0}) = a\mathbf{0} = a\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0},$$

where the last equality is (VS3). By Theorem 1.1.1, $a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$. ■

To identify a vector as $-\mathbf{v}$, it is enough to show it adds with $\mathbf{v}$ to $\mathbf{0}$, by Theorem 1.1.4. This gives the next two results.

Theorem 1.1.7 — Negation as Scalar Multiplication

Let V be a vector space over F . Then $(-1)\mathbf{v} = -\mathbf{v}$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. By (VS8), (VS6), (F4) and [Theorem 1.1.5](#),

$$\mathbf{v} + (-1)\mathbf{v} = 1\mathbf{v} + (-1)\mathbf{v} = (1 + (-1))\mathbf{v} = 0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}.$$

So $(-1)\mathbf{v}$ is an additive inverse of $\mathbf{v}$, and by [Theorem 1.1.4](#) it equals $-\mathbf{v}$. ■

Theorem 1.1.8 — Negative Scalars

Let V be a vector space over F . Then $(-a)\mathbf{v} = -(a\mathbf{v})$ for every $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Proof. Let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. By (VS6), (F4) and [Theorem 1.1.5](#),

$$a\mathbf{v} + (-a)\mathbf{v} = (a + (-a))\mathbf{v} = 0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}.$$

So $(-a)\mathbf{v}$ is an additive inverse of $a\mathbf{v}$, and by [Theorem 1.1.4](#) it equals $-(a\mathbf{v})$. ■

The companion rules $a(-\mathbf{v}) = -(a\mathbf{v})$ and $a(\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}) = a\mathbf{u} - a\mathbf{v}$ are [Exercise \(B2: More Rules for Signs\)](#). From now on, we compute with $+$, $-$ and scalars as in school algebra, citing these results when a step is not a single axiom.

The last result is the one we will use most. In a field, a product of non-zero numbers is non-zero ([Theorem 0.7.1](#) (f)). The same holds for a scalar times a vector.

Theorem 1.1.9 — Zero Product Law

Let V be a vector space over F , let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Then $a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if $a = 0$ or $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$.

Idea. The direction $(\Leftarrow)$ is the two zero results above, [Theorem 1.1.5](#) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#). For $(\Rightarrow)$, the only way to get rid of a is to multiply by a^{-1} , and that is exactly where the hypothesis $a \neq 0$ and the field axiom (F8) are spent.

Proof. $(\Leftarrow)$ If $a = 0$, then $a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.5](#). If $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, then $a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.6](#).

$(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. If $a = 0$ there is nothing to prove, so suppose $a \neq 0$. By (F8), a has an inverse $a^{-1} \in F$. Then

$$\mathbf{v} = 1\mathbf{v} = (a^{-1}a)\mathbf{v} = a^{-1}(a\mathbf{v}) = a^{-1}\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0},$$

by (VS8), (F8) with (F6), (VS7), the hypothesis, and [Theorem 1.1.6](#). This shows $a = 0$ or $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$.



Warning. The zero product law needs division by scalars. Suppose we allowed integer “scalars” and let $V = \mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$ with its own addition, where $n \cdot v$ is v for odd n and 0 for even n (for $n \geq 0$ this is $v + \cdots + v$ with n terms). Every rule of the shape (VS1)–(VS8) still holds. But $2 \cdot 1 = 1 + 1 = 0$, although $2 \neq 0$ in $\mathbb{Z}$ and $1 \neq 0$ in V . The proof above breaks exactly where it multiplies by a^{-1} : the integer 2 has no inverse in $\mathbb{Z}$. This is one reason vector spaces are defined **over a field**.

As a first use, here is a fact about sizes. Let $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$ be a vector in a space over $\mathbb{R}$. If $a\mathbf{v} = b\mathbf{v}$, then $(a - b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by (VS6) and Theorem 1.1.8, so $a = b$ by Theorem 1.1.9. So the multiples $a\mathbf{v}$, $a \in \mathbb{R}$, are all different, and a real vector space other than $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ has infinitely many elements (Exercise (C2: How Big Is a Vector Space?) treats a general field). This is our first glimpse of the question at the heart of this chapter: all these spaces are infinite sets, so how should we measure their size? The next section starts on the answer by looking at the vector spaces that sit inside a given one.

1.1.7 Exercises

1.1.7.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- State the eight axioms of a vector space over a field F , and say which of them involve scalars.
- Identify the zero vector in each of: $M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$; $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$; $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$; the space $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$ of Example (Positive Reals with Exotic Operations).
- True or false: a vector space can have exactly two elements. Justify your answer.
- True or false: in every vector space, $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ implies $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: if $a\mathbf{v} = b\mathbf{v}$ and $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$, then $a = b$. Justify your answer.

Solution.

- See Definition 1.1.1. The axioms (VS5)–(VS8) involve scalars; (VS1)–(VS4) involve only addition.
- The zero matrix of size 2×3 ; the zero polynomial; the zero function $t \mapsto 0$; the number 1 (Example (Positive Reals with Exotic Operations)).
- True. Let $F = \mathbb{F}_2$. By Example (The Standard Vector Spaces) (a), $\mathbb{F}_2^1 = \mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{F}_2$, and it has exactly two elements.
- False. In the vector space $\mathbb{F}_2$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$ from (c), the vector $1 \neq 0$ satisfies $1 + 1 = 0$. (Over $\mathbb{R}$ the statement is true: $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v} = (1 + 1)\mathbf{v} = 2\mathbf{v}$ by (VS8) and (VS6), and $2 \neq 0$, so $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by Theorem 1.1.9.)
- True. By (VS6) and Theorem 1.1.8, $(a - b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} + (-b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Since $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$, Theorem 1.1.9 gives $a - b = 0$, so $a = b$.

1.1.7.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Which Are Vector Spaces?.

Determine which of the following are vector spaces. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\mathbb{R}^2$ over $\mathbb{R}$, with the usual scalar multiplication but with addition $(x, y) + (x', y') := (x + x', 0)$.
- (b) The set of upper triangular matrices in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$, over $\mathbb{R}$, with the matrix operations.
- (c) $\{p \in \mathbb{R}[x] : p(1) = 0\}$, over $\mathbb{R}$, with the operations of $\mathbb{R}[x]$.
- (d) $\{p \in \mathbb{R}[x] : p(1) = 1\}$, over $\mathbb{R}$, with the operations of $\mathbb{R}[x]$.
- (e) $\mathbb{R}^2$ over $\mathbb{C}$, with $c(x, y) := (cx, cy)$ and the usual addition.

Solution.

- (a) Not a vector space: (VS3) fails. Suppose $\mathbf{0} = (z_1, z_2)$ satisfied (VS3). Then $(0, 1) + (z_1, z_2) = (z_1, 0)$ would equal $(0, 1)$, which is impossible since the second entries differ.
- (b) A vector space. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} a' & b' \\ 0 & d' \end{pmatrix}$ be upper triangular and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $A + B = \begin{pmatrix} a + a' & b + b' \\ 0 & d + d' \end{pmatrix}$ and $cA = \begin{pmatrix} ca & cb \\ 0 & cd \end{pmatrix}$ are upper triangular, so the operations land in the set. The zero matrix is upper triangular, and so is $-A = (-1)A$. The identities (VS1), (VS2), (VS5)–(VS8) hold for all matrices in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ by [Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (b), hence for upper triangular ones.
- (c) A vector space. Let $U = \{p \in \mathbb{R}[x] : p(1) = 0\}$, $p, q \in U$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. By [Theorem 0.8.5](#), $(p + q)(1) = p(1) + q(1) = 0$. Also cp is the product of the constant polynomial c with p , since by the product formula of [Definition 0.8.2](#) that product has coefficients ca_k . So $(cp)(1) = cp(1) = 0$. Hence $p + q, cp \in U$. The zero polynomial has value 0 at 1, and $-p = (-1)p \in U$ by closure under scaling. The identities hold in $\mathbb{R}[x]$ by [Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (c), hence in U .
- (d) Not a vector space: addition leaves the set. The constant polynomial 1 lies in the set, but $(1 + 1)(1) = 2 \neq 1$, so $1 + 1$ does not.
- (e) Not a vector space: scalar multiplication leaves the set. We have $i \in \mathbb{C}$ and $(1, 0) \in \mathbb{R}^2$, but $i(1, 0) = (i, 0) \notin \mathbb{R}^2$. So the rule is not a function $\mathbb{C} \times \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$.

Exercise B2: More Rules for Signs.

Let V be a vector space over F , let $a, b \in F$ and $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$. Prove that:

- (a) $a(-\mathbf{v}) = -(a\mathbf{v})$;
- (b) $(-a)(-\mathbf{v}) = a\mathbf{v}$;
- (c) $a(\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}) = a\mathbf{u} - a\mathbf{v}$ and $(a - b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v}$.

Hint: to show a vector equals $-(a\mathbf{v})$, use [Theorem 1.1.4](#).

Solution.

- (a) By (VS5), (VS4) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#),

$$a\mathbf{v} + a(-\mathbf{v}) = a(\mathbf{v} + (-\mathbf{v})) = a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}.$$

So $a(-\mathbf{v})$ is an additive inverse of $a\mathbf{v}$. By [Theorem 1.1.4](#), $a(-\mathbf{v}) = -(a\mathbf{v})$.

- (b) By (a) applied with the scalar $-a$, then [Theorem 1.1.8](#), then the remark after [Definition 1.1.3](#),

$$(-a)(-\mathbf{v}) = -((-a)\mathbf{v}) = -(-(a\mathbf{v})) = a\mathbf{v}.$$

- (c) By [Definition 1.1.3](#), (VS5) and (a),

$$a(\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}) = a(\mathbf{u} + (-\mathbf{v})) = a\mathbf{u} + a(-\mathbf{v}) = a\mathbf{u} + (-(a\mathbf{v})) = a\mathbf{u} - a\mathbf{v}.$$

Similarly, since $a - b = a + (-b)$ in F , (VS6) and [Theorem 1.1.8](#) give $(a - b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} + (-b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} + (-(b\mathbf{v})) = a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v}$.

Exercise B3: Finishing the Positive Reals.

Let $V = \mathbb{R}_{>0}$ with the operations $\boxplus$ and $\boxminus$ of [Example \(Positive Reals with Exotic Operations\)](#).

- (a) Verify (VS1), (VS2), (VS5) and (VS7). Hence V is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$.
- (b) Compute the vector $(2 \boxminus 3) \boxplus ((-1) \boxminus 6)$.
- (c) Find the vector $-(2 \boxminus 3)$, and check your answer against [Theorem 1.1.8](#).

Solution.

- (a) Let $u, v, w \in V$ and $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. By the laws of real multiplication and of exponents for positive bases:
 - (VS1): $u \boxplus v = uv = vu = v \boxplus u$.
 - (VS2): $(u \boxplus v) \boxplus w = (uv)w = u(vw) = u \boxplus (v \boxplus w)$.
 - (VS5): $a \boxminus (u \boxplus v) = (uv)^a = u^a v^a = (a \boxminus u) \boxplus (a \boxminus v)$.
 - (VS7): $a \boxminus (b \boxminus v) = (v^b)^a = v^{ab} = (ab) \boxminus v$.

Together with closure, (VS3), (VS4), (VS6) and (VS8) from [Example \(Positive Reals with Exotic Operations\)](#), all eight axioms hold. Hence V is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$.

- (b) $2 \boxminus 3 = 3^2 = 9$ and $(-1) \boxminus 6 = 6^{-1} = \frac{1}{6}$. So the vector is $9 \boxplus \frac{1}{6} = 9 \cdot \frac{1}{6} = \frac{3}{2}$.
- (c) By [Example \(Positive Reals with Exotic Operations\)](#), the additive inverse of a vector v is $1/v$. Since $2 \boxminus 3 = 9$, we get $-(2 \boxminus 3) = \frac{1}{9}$. By [Theorem 1.1.8](#), this should equal $(-2) \boxminus 3 = 3^{-2} = \frac{1}{9}$, and it does.

1.1.7.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Commutativity Comes for Free.

Let V be a set with operations $+: V \times V \rightarrow V$ and $\cdot: F \times V \rightarrow V$ satisfying (VS2)–(VS8), but **not necessarily** (VS1). Fix $\mathbf{0}$ as in (VS3).

- (a) Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$ and $\mathbf{v}'$ as in (VS4). Put $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{v}$. Show that $\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{w}$, and deduce that $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$.
- (b) Show that $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v}$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in V$.
- (c) Deduce that both cancellation laws hold: $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ implies $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$, and $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u}$ implies $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$.
- (d) By expanding $(1+1)(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v})$ in two ways, prove that $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u}$ for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$.

Hint: in (a), add an additive inverse of $\mathbf{w}$ on the right. The proof of Theorem 1.1.1 used (VS1), so it cannot be quoted in (c).

Solution. Throughout we use only (VS2)–(VS8), and we drop brackets in sums whenever (VS2) allows it.

- (a) Since $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}' = \mathbf{0}$ and $\mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{v}'$ by (VS3),

$$\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{v}' + (\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}') + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}.$$

By (VS4) choose $\mathbf{w}'$ with $\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w}' = \mathbf{0}$. Adding $\mathbf{w}'$ on the right of $\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{w}$ gives $\mathbf{w} + (\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w}') = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{w}'$, that is, $\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$. By (VS3), $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$. So $\mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ as well.

- (b) Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$ and $\mathbf{v}'$ as in (VS4). By (a), (VS2) and (VS3),

$$\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = (\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}') + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + (\mathbf{v}' + \mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{v}.$$

- (c) Suppose $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$, and let $\mathbf{u}'$ be as in (VS4). Adding $\mathbf{u}'$ on the left and using (VS2), $(\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u}) + \mathbf{v} = (\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u}) + \mathbf{w}$. By (a), $\mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0}$, so $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{w}$, and (b) gives $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$. Now suppose $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u}$. Adding $\mathbf{u}'$ on the right and using (VS2), $\mathbf{v} + (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}') = \mathbf{w} + (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}')$, so $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{0}$, and (VS3) gives $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$.
- (d) Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$. On the one hand, by (VS6) and (VS8),

$$(1+1)(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = 1(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + 1(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}.$$

On the other hand, by (VS5), then (VS6) and (VS8),

$$(1+1)(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) = (1+1)\mathbf{u} + (1+1)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}.$$

Hence $\mathbf{u} + (\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u}) + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + \mathbf{v}$, grouping by (VS2). Canceling $\mathbf{u}$ on the left and then $\mathbf{v}$ on the right, by (c), gives $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}$. This proves (VS1).

Exercise C2: How Big Is a Vector Space?.

- (a) Let F be an infinite field and $V \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$ a vector space over F . Prove that V is an infinite set.
- (b) Let p be a prime and $n \geq 1$. How many elements does the vector space $\mathbb{F}_p^n$ over $\mathbb{F}_p$ have? Explain why this does not contradict (a).

Hint: for (a), fix $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$ and consider the function $F \rightarrow V$, $a \mapsto a\mathbf{v}$.

Solution.

- (a) Since $V \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$ and $\mathbf{0} \in V$, there is $\mathbf{v} \in V$ with $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Consider $\varphi: F \rightarrow V$, $\varphi(a) = a\mathbf{v}$. Suppose $\varphi(a) = \varphi(b)$, so $a\mathbf{v} = b\mathbf{v}$. By [Exercise \(B2: More Rules for Signs\)](#) (c), $(a - b)\mathbf{v} = a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Since $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$, [Theorem 1.1.9](#) gives $a - b = 0$, so $a = b$. Therefore φ is injective. An injective function from an infinite set has an infinite image, so V , which contains the image of φ , is infinite.
- (b) An element of $\mathbb{F}_p^n$ is a list $(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ with each x_i chosen freely from the p elements of $\mathbb{F}_p$. So $\mathbb{F}_p^n$ has p^n elements. There is no contradiction, because (a) assumes the field is infinite and $\mathbb{F}_p$ is finite. The proof of (a) still shows that $a \mapsto a\mathbf{v}$ is injective, so a non-zero space over $\mathbb{F}_p$ has at least p elements.

Exercise C3: Shrinking the Field.

Let F be a field and let $K \subseteq F$ be a subset with $0, 1 \in K$ that is closed under addition, multiplication, negatives, and inverses of non-zero elements. (So K is itself a field with the operations of F ; for example $\mathbb{Q} \subseteq \mathbb{R} \subseteq \mathbb{C}$.)

- (a) Let V be a vector space over F . Prove that V , with the same addition and with scalar multiplication restricted to $K \times V$, is a vector space over K .
- (b) Deduce that $\mathbb{C}^n$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ and over $\mathbb{Q}$.
- (c) Explain why $\mathbb{R}$, with its usual addition and multiplication, is **not** a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$.

Solution.

- (a) The addition is unchanged, so it is a function $V \times V \rightarrow V$ satisfying (VS1)–(VS4). Scalar multiplication $F \times V \rightarrow V$ restricts to a function $K \times V \rightarrow V$, since $K \subseteq F$. The axioms (VS5)–(VS7) are statements about **all** scalars in F , so they hold in particular for all scalars in K ; the operations $a + b$ and ab appearing in them are the same in K as in F . For (VS8), the identity of K is the identity 1 of F , and $1\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v}$ holds in V over F . Hence V is a vector space over K .
- (b) $\mathbb{C}^n$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$ by [Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (a). The subsets $\mathbb{R} \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ and $\mathbb{Q} \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ contain 0 and 1 and are closed under the four operations, so (a) applies to both.
- (c) The only candidate for scalar multiplication is $(c, t) \mapsto ct$, the product in $\mathbb{C}$. But it does not land in $\mathbb{R}$: $i \in \mathbb{C}$ and $1 \in \mathbb{R}$, while $i \cdot 1 = i \notin \mathbb{R}$. So there is no function $\mathbb{C} \times \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ given by this rule, and $\mathbb{R}$ is not a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$ with these operations.

1.2 Subspaces

After defining a structure, the next step is to look at the smaller copies of it that sit inside. In the previous section we showed three times, for $F[x]_{\leq n}$, $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and the solutions of $f'' + f = 0$, that a subset of a known vector space is itself a vector space, and each time the same few checks did the work. This section turns that pattern into a theorem, the subspace test, and makes its three checks a routine we will use for the rest of the book.

1.2.1 Spaces inside spaces

Consider the set

$$P = \{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x + y - z = 0\},$$

a plane through the origin in $\mathbb{R}^3$. It contains $(1, 0, 1)$ and $(0, 1, 1)$, and also their sum $(1, 1, 2)$, since $1 + 1 - 2 = 0$. Stretching a vector of P keeps it in the plane. So P , with the addition and scalar multiplication of $\mathbb{R}^3$, looks like a vector space in its own right.

To prove it we could check all eight axioms again. That is wasteful, and the previous section already showed why. The axioms (VS1), (VS2) and (VS5)–(VS8) are equations that hold for **all** vectors of $\mathbb{R}^3$, so they hold in particular for the vectors of P . What can go wrong is different: a sum or a multiple might leave P , and the zero vector or an additive inverse might not lie in P . The question of this section is which of these checks are really needed.

A subspace is a subset that is a vector space in its own right, using the same addition and scalar multiplication.

Definition 1.2.1 — Subspace

Let V be a vector space over F . A subset $U \subseteq V$ is a **subspace** of V if

- $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$ and $a\mathbf{u} \in U$ **for all** $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$ and $a \in F$, so that the operations of V restrict to functions $U \times U \rightarrow U$ and $F \times U \rightarrow U$; and
- U , with these restricted operations, is a vector space **over** F .

In words: the first clause says that adding or scaling vectors of U never leads out of U , so that U has an addition and a scalar multiplication at all. These are **the same** operations as in V , only applied to fewer vectors. The second clause says that with these operations, all eight axioms hold in U . In particular U must contain **a** zero vector of its own, and every vector of U must have an additive inverse **in** U . The field does not change: a subspace of a space over F is again a space over F .

There is a question hidden in “a zero vector of its own”. Could U have a zero vector different from the zero vector of V ? The proof of the subspace test below shows that it cannot.

The two extreme cases come first.

Example. (Trivial Subspaces)

Let V be a vector space over F . Show that V and $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ are subspaces of V , and that the empty set $\emptyset$ is not.

Solution. For V itself, the restricted operations are the operations of V , and V is a vector space by assumption.

For $\{\mathbf{0}\}$, the only sum is $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ by (VS3), and $a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $a \in F$ by [Theorem 1.1.6](#). So both operations stay in $\{\mathbf{0}\}$, and $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ with them is the zero space, a vector space as noted in the previous section.

For $\emptyset$, axiom (VS3) demands that some element $\mathbf{0}$ exists in the set. The empty set has no elements, so (VS3) fails and $\emptyset$ is not a subspace.

The subspace $\{0\}$ is the **zero subspace**. A subspace other than V is called **proper**. The zero subspace is small, but it is the answer to many questions later: the solutions of a system with only the trivial solution, or the intersection of two lines through the origin that are not equal.

1.2.2 The subspace test

The following theorem says that three checks suffice. Two of them are the closure conditions of the definition, and the third replaces all of the axioms.

Theorem 1.2.1 — Subspace Test

Let V be a vector space over F and let $U \subseteq V$. Then U is a subspace of V if and only if the following three conditions hold.

- (1) $0 \in U$, where 0 is the zero vector of V .
- (2) U is **closed under addition**: $u + w \in U$ for all $u, w \in U$.
- (3) U is **closed under scalar multiplication**: $au \in U$ for all $a \in F$ and $u \in U$.

Idea. Sort the eight axioms into two kinds. Six of them, (VS1), (VS2) and (VS5)–(VS8), say “an equation holds **for all** vectors”; they are true in V , so they are automatically true for the fewer vectors in U . The other two, (VS3) and (VS4), say “**there exists** a vector”, and a witness must be found **inside** U . Condition (1) supplies the zero. For inverses, the results of the previous section give $-u = (-1)u$, so closure under scaling supplies them for free. For $(\Rightarrow)$, the only non-obvious point is that the zero vector of U is the zero vector of V ; cancellation in V settles it.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose U is a subspace of V . Conditions (2) and (3) are the first clause of Definition 1.2.1. By (VS3) in U , there is $z \in U$ with $u + z = u$ for every $u \in U$; in particular $z + z = z$. By (VS3) in V , also $z + 0 = z$. Hence $z + z = z + 0$, and Theorem 1.1.1 in V gives $z = 0$. Therefore $0 \in U$, which is (1).

$(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose (1), (2) and (3) hold. By (2) and (3), addition and scalar multiplication of V restrict to functions $U \times U \rightarrow U$ and $F \times U \rightarrow U$. We check the axioms for U with these operations.

- (VS1), (VS2), (VS5), (VS6), (VS7) and (VS8) state that certain equations hold for all vectors and scalars. They hold for all vectors of V , since V is a vector space, so in particular for all vectors of U .
- (VS3): by (1), $0 \in U$, and $u + 0 = u$ for every $u \in U$ by (VS3) in V .
- (VS4): let $u \in U$. By (3), $(-1)u \in U$. By Theorem 1.1.7, $(-1)u = -u$, so $u + (-1)u = 0$. Thus u has an additive inverse in U .

Hence U is a vector space over F with the operations of V , that is, a subspace of V . ■

From now on we never check eight axioms for a subset of a known vector space. We check three things, always in the same order and with the same wording. This is the first named move of the chapter.

The three-check move. To show that a subset U of a vector space V is a subspace:

- make sure U is a subset of V (what are its elements, and do they lie in V ?);
- **(1) Zero vector.** Show $\mathbf{0} \in U$ by checking that $\mathbf{0}$ satisfies the condition defining U . End with “Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in U$.”
- **(2) Closed under addition.** Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$. Write down what membership in U means for each, then regroup $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ so that those conditions appear. End with “This shows that U is closed under addition.”
- **(3) Closed under scalar multiplication.** Let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u} \in U$, and do the same for $a\mathbf{u}$. End with “This shows that U is closed under scalar multiplication.”
- Conclude: “Hence U is a subspace of V by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).”

To show that U is **not** a subspace, one failure suffices. Check (1) first, since it is the cheapest, and if it holds, look for a concrete pair of vectors or a concrete scalar that leads out of U .

Remark. Condition (1) may be replaced by “ U is non-empty”. Indeed, if U contains some $\mathbf{u}$, then (3) gives $0\mathbf{u} \in U$, and $0\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.5](#). We still prefer (1): the zero vector is the easiest element to test, and when it is missing we have a refutation in one line.

Warning. **The empty set is never a subspace.** It is tempting to check only (2) and (3). But $\emptyset$ satisfies both, vacuously: there are no vectors in it to add or scale. It fails only (1). So whichever version of the test you use, do not skip the first condition, and remember that “ $\mathbf{0} \in U$ ” and “ U is non-empty” are interchangeable only in the presence of (3).

1.2.3 Examples: the three-check move

Every example below follows the move exactly. The first is the model.

Example. (A Line through the Origin)

Show that $U = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x + 2y = 0\}$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$.

Solution. By definition, U is a subset of $\mathbb{R}^2$.

(1) Zero vector. The zero vector $(0, 0)$ satisfies $0 + 2 \cdot 0 = 0$. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in U$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $\mathbf{u} = (x_1, y_1)$ and $\mathbf{w} = (x_2, y_2)$ be in U , so that $x_1 + 2y_1 = 0$ and $x_2 + 2y_2 = 0$. Then $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} = (x_1 + x_2, y_1 + y_2)$, and

$$(x_1 + x_2) + 2(y_1 + y_2) = (x_1 + 2y_1) + (x_2 + 2y_2) = 0 + 0 = 0.$$

Therefore $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$. This shows that U is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbf{u} = (x, y) \in U$, so that $x + 2y = 0$. Then $a\mathbf{u} = (ax, ay)$, and

$$ax + 2(ay) = a(x + 2y) = a \cdot 0 = 0.$$

Therefore $a\mathbf{u} \in U$. This shows that U is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence U is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$ by the subspace test (Theorem 1.2.1).

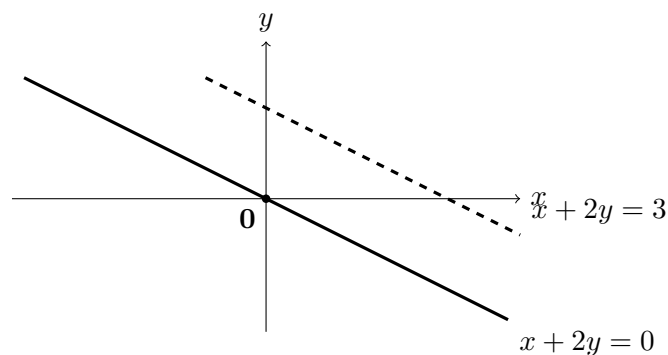
Change the right-hand side from 0 to 3, and everything breaks.

Example. (A Line Missing the Origin)

Show that $L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x + 2y = 3\}$ is **not** a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$.

Solution. Condition (1) fails: the zero vector has $0 + 2 \cdot 0 = 0 \neq 3$, so $\mathbf{0} \notin L$. By the subspace test (Theorem 1.2.1), L is not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$.

The other two conditions fail as well, as we saw in the previous section: $(3, 0) + (1, 1) = (4, 1) \notin L$, and $2(3, 0) = (6, 0) \notin L$. One failure is enough, though, and (1) is the cheapest to find.



The solid line U passes through the origin; the dashed line L is parallel to it and misses the origin. The line L is a translate of a subspace, a kind of set we will study in Chapter 3, but it is not a subspace.

The line U is the set of solutions of one homogeneous equation. The same three checks work for any number of homogeneous equations, written as one matrix equation.

Example. (Solutions of a Homogeneous System)

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. Show that $N = \{\mathbf{x} \in F^n : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}\}$ is a subspace of F^n .

Solution. By definition, N is a subset of F^n . Recall that $F^n = M_{n \times 1}(F)$, so $A\mathbf{x} \in F^m$ is a matrix product, and we may use Theorem 0.9.4.

(1) Zero vector. By the zero rule of Theorem 0.9.4, $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, where the first $\mathbf{0}$ is the zero column in F^n and the second is the zero column in F^m . Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in N$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in N$, so that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ and $A\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$. By distributivity (Theorem 0.9.4),

$$A(\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y}) = A\mathbf{x} + A\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}.$$

Therefore $\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y} \in N$. This shows that N is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{x} \in N$. By the scalar rule

of [Theorem 0.9.4](#) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#) in F^m ,

$$A(a\mathbf{x}) = a(A\mathbf{x}) = a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}.$$

Therefore $a\mathbf{x} \in N$. This shows that N is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence N is a subspace of F^n by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

With $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ and $F = \mathbb{R}$, this is [Example \(A Line through the Origin\)](#) again, and with $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$ it is the plane P from the start of the section. The word **homogeneous** (right-hand side $\mathbf{0}$) is essential: [Example \(A Line Missing the Origin\)](#) is a system with right-hand side 3. This subspace will be called the null space of A in Chapter 2.

Next, polynomials. The pair “degree at most n ” and “degree exactly n ” is another minimal change. The previous section checked the first of them by hand; here it is as a three-check move.

Example. (Polynomials of Bounded Degree)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Show that $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is a subspace of $F[x]$.

Solution. By [Definition 0.8.4](#), $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is a subset of $F[x]$.

(1) Zero vector. The zero polynomial has degree $-\infty \leq n$ ([Definition 0.8.3](#)). Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in F[x]_{\leq n}$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $p, q \in F[x]_{\leq n}$, so that $\deg p \leq n$ and $\deg q \leq n$. By [Theorem 0.8.2](#), $\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q) \leq n$. Therefore $p + q \in F[x]_{\leq n}$. This shows that $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $c \in F$ and $p = a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_nx^n \in F[x]_{\leq n}$. Then $cp = ca_0 + ca_1x + \cdots + ca_nx^n$, whose coefficients of x^k for $k > n$ are all 0. So $\deg(cp) \leq n$, and therefore $cp \in F[x]_{\leq n}$. This shows that $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is a subspace of $F[x]$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

Example. (Polynomials of Exact Degree)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Show that $F[x]_{=n}$ is **not** a subspace of $F[x]$.

Solution. Condition (1) fails: the zero polynomial has degree $-\infty \neq n$, so $\mathbf{0} \notin F[x]_{=n}$. By the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)), $F[x]_{=n}$ is not a subspace of $F[x]$.

Even if we added the zero polynomial by hand, condition (2) would still fail for $n \geq 1$: the polynomials $x^n + 1$ and $-x^n$ have degree exactly n , but their sum is the constant 1, of degree 0. The leading terms cancel, and nothing in “degree exactly n ” prevents it.

The same move works in function spaces. Here the facts we need come from calculus.

Example. (Differentiable Functions)

Let D be the set of differentiable functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Show that D is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$.

Solution. Every element of D is a function $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, so $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$.

(1) Zero vector. The zero vector of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is the zero function ([Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#)), which is constant and hence differentiable. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in D$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $f, g \in D$. By the sum rule of calculus, $f + g$ is differentiable, with $(f + g)' = f' + g'$. Therefore $f + g \in D$. This shows that D is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ and $f \in D$. By the constant multiple rule, af is differentiable, with $(af)' = af'$. Therefore $af \in D$. This shows that D is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence D is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

The same three checks show that the continuous functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ form a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$, and that D is a subspace of it. A subspace of a subspace is a subspace, since the operations are the same throughout.

Finally, two families of matrices. Each uses one rule from Chapter 0 for all three checks.

Example. (Symmetric Matrices)

Show that the set $S = \{A \in M_n(F) : A^T = A\}$ of symmetric matrices ([Definition 0.9.11](#)) is a subspace of $M_n(F)$.

Solution. By definition, S is a subset of $M_n(F)$.

(1) Zero vector. Every entry of the zero matrix is 0, so $(0)_{ji} = 0 = (0)_{ij}$ for all i, j , and the zero matrix is symmetric. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in S$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $A, B \in S$, so that $A^T = A$ and $B^T = B$. By [Theorem 0.9.5](#),

$$(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T = A + B.$$

Therefore $A + B \in S$. This shows that S is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $c \in F$ and $A \in S$. By [Theorem 0.9.5](#), $(cA)^T = cA^T = cA$. Therefore $cA \in S$. This shows that S is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence S is a subspace of $M_n(F)$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

Example. (Trace-Free Matrices)

Show that the set $T = \{A \in M_n(F) : \text{tr } A = 0\}$ of trace-free matrices is a subspace of $M_n(F)$.

Solution. By definition, T is a subset of $M_n(F)$.

(1) Zero vector. The zero matrix has trace $0 + \cdots + 0 = 0$. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in T$.

(2) Closed under addition. Let $A, B \in T$, so that $\operatorname{tr} A = \operatorname{tr} B = 0$. By [Theorem 0.9.6](#), $\operatorname{tr}(A + B) = \operatorname{tr} A + \operatorname{tr} B = 0 + 0 = 0$. Therefore $A + B \in T$. This shows that T is closed under addition.

(3) Closed under scalar multiplication. Let $c \in F$ and $A \in T$. By [Theorem 0.9.6](#), $\operatorname{tr}(cA) = c \operatorname{tr} A = c \cdot 0 = 0$. Therefore $cA \in T$. This shows that T is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence T is a subspace of $M_n(F)$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

The pattern in the last two examples, and in [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#), is the same: the condition defining the set is “some rule that respects sums and scalar multiples sends the element to zero”. Chapter 3 gives such rules a name, linear maps, and this pattern becomes a single theorem about their kernels.

1.2.4 Non-examples

Here are two more subsets of $\mathbb{R}^2$ that fail, each in a different way.

- **The unit circle** $\{(x, y) : x^2 + y^2 = 1\}$ fails (1), since $0^2 + 0^2 \neq 1$. It fails (2) and (3) as well: $(1, 0) + (0, 1) = (1, 1)$ and $2(1, 0) = (2, 0)$ are not on the circle.
- **The set** $Q = \{(x, y) : xy \geq 0\}$, the first and third quadrants together with both axes. Here (1) holds, since $0 \cdot 0 = 0 \geq 0$. Condition (3) holds too: if $xy \geq 0$ and $a \in \mathbb{R}$, then $(ax)(ay) = a^2xy \geq 0$. But (2) fails: $(1, 0)$ and $(0, -1)$ lie in Q , while their sum $(1, -1)$ has $1 \cdot (-1) = -1 < 0$. So Q is not a subspace.

The set Q shows that (3) does not imply (2). The next check shows that (2) does not imply (3).

Quick check. Find a subset of $\mathbb{R}^2$ that contains $\mathbf{0}$ and is closed under addition, but is not a subspace. Which condition of the subspace test fails?

Solution. Take the closed first quadrant $U = \{(x, y) : x \geq 0 \text{ and } y \geq 0\}$. It contains $(0, 0)$, and if $x_1, y_1, x_2, y_2 \geq 0$, then $x_1 + x_2 \geq 0$ and $y_1 + y_2 \geq 0$, so it is closed under addition. Condition (3) fails: $(1, 0) \in U$ but $(-1)(1, 0) = (-1, 0) \notin U$. Another answer is $\mathbb{Z}^2$: it contains $\mathbf{0}$ and is closed under addition, but $\frac{1}{2}(1, 0) \notin \mathbb{Z}^2$.

1.2.5 Why this definition

The definition insists on **the same** operations. This is not a formality. The positive reals $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$ form a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ ([Example \(Positive Reals with Exotic Operations\)](#)), and $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$ is a subset of the vector space $\mathbb{R}$. But $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$ is **not** a subspace of $\mathbb{R}$: with the operations of $\mathbb{R}$, it does not contain the zero vector 0 , and $(-1) \cdot 1 = -1$ leaves it. Its vector space structure uses different operations, multiplication and powers, and those do not count.

The definition also keeps the field. For example, $\mathbb{R}^2$ is a subset of $\mathbb{C}^2$, and it is closed under addition and under multiplication by **real** scalars. But it is not a subspace of $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{C}$, because $i(1, 0) = (i, 0) \notin \mathbb{R}^2$. Condition (3) quantifies over **every** scalar of the field.

Finally, why “(1) $\mathbf{0} \in U$ ” rather than “ U is non-empty”? The two are equivalent given (3), as

the remark after the test explains. We choose the version that is quicker to check and quicker to refute.

1.2.6 Intersections of subspaces

Given several subspaces, can we build new ones? The first way is to take the vectors they have in common. Recall from [Definition 0.3.9](#) that the intersection of a **non-empty** family of sets $(U_i)_{i \in I}$ consists of the elements lying in every U_i .

Theorem 1.2.2 — Intersection of Subspaces

Let V be a vector space over F , and let $(U_i)_{i \in I}$ be a family of subspaces of V with I non-empty. Then $\bigcap_{i \in I} U_i$ is a subspace of V .

Proof. Let $U = \bigcap_{i \in I} U_i$. Each U_i is a subset of V , so $U \subseteq V$. We use the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)) for U , and for each U_i its direction ($\Rightarrow$).

- (1) For every $i \in I$, $\mathbf{0} \in U_i$, since U_i is a subspace. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in U$.
- (2) Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$. Then $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U_i$ for every $i \in I$. Since each U_i is closed under addition, $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U_i$ for every $i \in I$. Therefore $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$. This shows that U is closed under addition.
- (3) Let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u} \in U$. Then $\mathbf{u} \in U_i$ for every $i \in I$, and since each U_i is closed under scalar multiplication, $a\mathbf{u} \in U_i$ for every $i \in I$. Therefore $a\mathbf{u} \in U$. This shows that U is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence U is a subspace of V by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)). ■

The index set may be infinite, and this matters. In the next section we will build the smallest subspace containing a given set of vectors, and one way to describe it is as the intersection of **all** subspaces containing that set.

For two subspaces, the theorem gives familiar pictures: two different planes through the origin in $\mathbb{R}^3$ meet in a line through the origin. It also explains [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#) from a new angle. The solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is the intersection of the solution sets of its m individual equations, each of which is a subspace of F^n . An algebraic example: in $M_2(F)$, the matrices that are both symmetric and trace-free ([Example \(Symmetric Matrices\)](#), [Example \(Trace-Free Matrices\)](#)) are those of the form $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & -a \end{pmatrix}$, and they form a subspace.

1.2.7 Unions of subspaces

Intersections behave well. Unions do not, and the reason is visible in the simplest picture.

Example. (The Union of the Two Axes)

In $\mathbb{R}^2$, let $U = \{(x, 0) : x \in \mathbb{R}\}$ be the x -axis and $W = \{(0, y) : y \in \mathbb{R}\}$ the y -axis. Show

that U and W are subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^2$, but $U \cup W$ is not.

Solution. The x -axis is the solution set of the homogeneous equation $y = 0$, that is, of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ with $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. By [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#), U is a subspace. In the same way W is the solution set of $x = 0$, so it is a subspace.

For the union, condition (2) fails. We have $(1, 0) \in U \subseteq U \cup W$ and $(0, 1) \in W \subseteq U \cup W$, but

$$(1, 0) + (0, 1) = (1, 1),$$

which is on neither axis, since both of its entries are non-zero. So $(1, 1) \notin U \cup W$, and $U \cup W$ is not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$.

The union passes (1) and (3): it contains $\mathbf{0}$, and scaling a vector on an axis keeps it on that axis. Only addition breaks it, by mixing a vector from each axis. That observation is the whole proof of the general fact.

Proposition 1.2.3 — Union of Two Subspaces

Let V be a vector space over F , and let U and W be subspaces of V . Then $U \cup W$ is a subspace of V if and only if $U \subseteq W$ or $W \subseteq U$.

Idea. The direction $(\Leftarrow)$ is immediate, because the union is then just the bigger of the two. For $(\Rightarrow)$, a statement of the form “one of two inclusions holds” invites contradiction. If neither inclusion holds, there is a vector $\mathbf{u}$ of U outside W and a vector $\mathbf{w}$ of W outside U , exactly like $(1, 0)$ and $(0, 1)$ for the axes. Look at $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$. It must lie in U or in W . If it lies in U , subtracting $\mathbf{u}$ keeps us in U and leaves $\mathbf{w}$, which is not in U .

Proof. $(\Leftarrow)$ If $U \subseteq W$, then $U \cup W = W$, which is a subspace. If $W \subseteq U$, then $U \cup W = U$, which is a subspace.

$(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $U \cup W$ is a subspace of V , and suppose, for a contradiction, that $U \not\subseteq W$ and $W \not\subseteq U$. Then there exist $\mathbf{u} \in U$ with $\mathbf{u} \notin W$, and $\mathbf{w} \in W$ with $\mathbf{w} \notin U$. Both lie in $U \cup W$, so $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U \cup W$ by condition (2) of the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

Case 1: $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$. Since U is a subspace and $\mathbf{u} \in U$, condition (3) gives $(-1)\mathbf{u} \in U$, and $(-1)\mathbf{u} = -\mathbf{u}$ by [Theorem 1.1.7](#). By condition (2) for U , $(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}) + (-\mathbf{u}) \in U$. By (VS1), (VS2), (VS4) and (VS3),

$$(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}) + (-\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{w} + (\mathbf{u} + (-\mathbf{u})) = \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{w}.$$

So $\mathbf{w} \in U$, contradicting the choice of $\mathbf{w}$.

Case 2: $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in W$. Swapping the roles of U and W , and of $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{w}$, in Case 1 gives $\mathbf{u} \in W$, contradicting the choice of $\mathbf{u}$.

Both cases lead to a contradiction. Hence $U \subseteq W$ or $W \subseteq U$. ■

Warning. Do not combine subspaces by taking their union. Apart from the case where one subspace already contains the other, the union of two subspaces is never a

subspace, by [Proposition 1.2.3](#). The two axes in $\mathbb{R}^2$ are the standard failing case: their union misses $(1, 1)$, and in fact misses every vector with two non-zero entries.

The right way to combine two subspaces U and W is to take all sums $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ with $\mathbf{u} \in U$ and $\mathbf{w} \in W$. For the two axes this gives all of $\mathbb{R}^2$. This construction, the sum of subspaces, is the subject of a later section of this chapter; [Exercise \(C2: The Sum of Two Subspaces\)](#) gives a preview.

We now have a supply of vector spaces for free: every subspace of a known space is one, and every theorem of the previous section applies to it. In the next section we ask a sharper question. Given a few vectors, what is the smallest subspace that contains them? Its answer, the span, is the first step toward measuring the size of a vector space.

1.2.8 Exercises

1.2.8.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define what it means for a subset U of a vector space V over F to be a subspace.
- State the subspace test.
- True or false: $\emptyset$ is a subspace of every vector space. Justify your answer.
- True or false: if U is a subspace of V and W is a subspace of U , then W is a subspace of V . Justify your answer.
- True or false: the union of two subspaces is never a subspace. Justify your answer.
- Which condition of the subspace test would you check first to show that $\{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x + y + z = 1\}$ is not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^3$? Carry out the check.

Solution.

- See [Definition 1.2.1](#): U is closed under the addition and scalar multiplication of V , and with these operations it is a vector space over F .
- See [Theorem 1.2.1](#): $U \subseteq V$ is a subspace if and only if $\mathbf{0} \in U$, U is closed under addition, and U is closed under scalar multiplication.
- False. The empty set does not contain $\mathbf{0}$, so condition (1) fails ([Example \(Trivial Subspaces\)](#)).
- True. Since W is a subspace of U , it contains the zero vector of U , which is $\mathbf{0}$ (the proof of [Theorem 1.2.1](#) shows the zero vector of a subspace is the zero vector of the big space). The operations of U are those of V , so closure of W under the operations of U is closure under the operations of V . By the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)), W is a subspace of V .
- False. If $U \subseteq W$, then $U \cup W = W$ is a subspace ([Proposition 1.2.3](#)). For example, $\{\mathbf{0}\} \cup V = V$.
- Condition (1). The zero vector has $0 + 0 + 0 = 0 \neq 1$, so it is not in the set, and the set is not a subspace.

1.2.8.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Which Are Subspaces?.

Determine which of the following are subspaces of the given vector space over $\mathbb{R}$. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x - 2y + z = 0\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
- (b) $\{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x = y^2\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
- (c) $\{A \in M_2(\mathbb{R}) : A \text{ is invertible}\}$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$.
- (d) $\{A \in M_2(\mathbb{R}) : a_{12} = 2a_{21}\}$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$.
- (e) $\{p \in \mathbb{R}[x] : p(2) = 0 \text{ and } p'(2) = 0\}$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]$, where p' is the derivative of p .
- (f) The even functions $\{f \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}} : f(-t) = f(t) \text{ for all } t \in \mathbb{R}\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$.
- (g) $\{f \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}} : f(0) = 1\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$.
- (h) The continuous functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$.

Solution.

- (a) A subspace. It is $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^3 : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}\}$ with $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, a subspace by [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#).
- (b) Not a subspace: (3) fails. The vector $(1, 1, 0)$ lies in the set, since $1 = 1^2$. But $2(1, 1, 0) = (2, 2, 0)$ does not, since $2 \neq 2^2$.
- (c) Not a subspace: (1) fails. The zero matrix is not invertible, because $0 \cdot B = 0 \neq I_2$ for every $B \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$.
- (d) A subspace. Call the set U .
 - (1) The zero matrix has $a_{12} = 0 = 2 \cdot 0 = 2a_{21}$. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in U$.
 - (2) Let $A, B \in U$, so $a_{12} = 2a_{21}$ and $b_{12} = 2b_{21}$. The $(1, 2)$ -entry of $A + B$ is $a_{12} + b_{12} = 2a_{21} + 2b_{21} = 2(a_{21} + b_{21})$, which is twice its $(2, 1)$ -entry. Therefore $A + B \in U$. This shows that U is closed under addition.
 - (3) Let $c \in \mathbb{R}$ and $A \in U$. The $(1, 2)$ -entry of cA is $ca_{12} = c(2a_{21}) = 2(ca_{21})$, twice its $(2, 1)$ -entry. Therefore $cA \in U$. This shows that U is closed under scalar multiplication.
 Hence U is a subspace of $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).
- (e) A subspace. Call the set U . We use [Theorem 0.8.5](#) for values, and the sum and constant multiple rules for derivatives.
 - (1) The zero polynomial has value 0 at 2, and its derivative is the zero polynomial, also with value 0 at 2. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in U$.
 - (2) Let $p, q \in U$. Then $(p+q)(2) = p(2) + q(2) = 0$ and $(p+q)'(2) = p'(2) + q'(2) = 0$. Therefore $p+q \in U$. This shows that U is closed under addition.
 - (3) Let $c \in \mathbb{R}$ and $p \in U$. Then $(cp)(2) = cp(2) = 0$ and $(cp)'(2) = cp'(2) = 0$. Therefore $cp \in U$. This shows that U is closed under scalar multiplication.
 Hence U is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}[x]$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).
- (f) A subspace. Call the set E .
 - (1) The zero function satisfies $\mathbf{0}(-t) = 0 = \mathbf{0}(t)$ for all t . Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in E$.
 - (2) Let $f, g \in E$. For every $t \in \mathbb{R}$, $(f+g)(-t) = f(-t) + g(-t) = f(t) + g(t) = (f+g)(t)$. Therefore $f+g \in E$. This shows that E is closed under addition.
 - (3) Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ and $f \in E$. For every $t \in \mathbb{R}$, $(af)(-t) = af(-t) = af(t) = (af)(t)$. Therefore $af \in E$. This shows that E is closed under scalar multiplication.
 Hence E is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

- (g) Not a subspace: (1) fails. The zero function has value $0 \neq 1$ at 0.
- (h) A subspace. **(1)** The zero function is constant, hence continuous. **(2)** A sum of continuous functions is continuous. **(3)** A constant multiple of a continuous function is continuous. Hence the continuous functions form a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

Exercise B2: Matrices Commuting with a Given Matrix.

Fix $B \in M_n(F)$, and let $C(B) = \{A \in M_n(F) : AB = BA\}$.

- (a) Prove that $C(B)$ is a subspace of $M_n(F)$.
- (b) Let $n = 2$, $F = \mathbb{R}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$. Find all $A \in C(B)$. Hence describe $C(B)$ in words.

Solution.

- (a) By definition, $C(B) \subseteq M_n(F)$. We use [Theorem 0.9.4](#) throughout.
- (1)** By the zero rule, $0B = 0 = B0$. Therefore $\mathbf{0} \in C(B)$.
- (2)** Let $A_1, A_2 \in C(B)$, so $A_1B = BA_1$ and $A_2B = BA_2$. By distributivity,

$$(A_1 + A_2)B = A_1B + A_2B = BA_1 + BA_2 = B(A_1 + A_2).$$

Therefore $A_1 + A_2 \in C(B)$. This shows that $C(B)$ is closed under addition.

(3) Let $c \in F$ and $A \in C(B)$. By the scalar rule, $(cA)B = c(AB) = c(BA) = B(cA)$. Therefore $cA \in C(B)$. This shows that $C(B)$ is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence $C(B)$ is a subspace of $M_n(F)$ by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

- (b) Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} a & 2b \\ c & 2d \end{pmatrix}, \quad BA = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 2c & 2d \end{pmatrix}.$$

So $AB = BA$ if and only if $2b = b$ and $c = 2c$, that is, $b = 0$ and $c = 0$. Hence $C(B)$ is the set of diagonal matrices $\begin{pmatrix} a & 0 \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix}$ with $a, d \in \mathbb{R}$.

Exercise B3: Intersection and Union of Two Planes.

In $\mathbb{R}^3$, let $U = \{(x, y, z) : x + y + z = 0\}$ and $W = \{(x, y, z) : x - y = 0\}$.

- (a) Explain why U and W are subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^3$, and find $U \cap W$.
- (b) Find $\mathbf{u} \in U$ with $\mathbf{u} \notin W$ and $\mathbf{w} \in W$ with $\mathbf{w} \notin U$. Hence show directly that $U \cup W$ is not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution.

- (a) U and W are the solution sets of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ for $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, so they are subspaces by [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#). A vector

(x, y, z) lies in $U \cap W$ exactly when $x + y + z = 0$ and $x = y$. Substituting $y = x$ gives $z = -2x$. Hence

$$U \cap W = \{(t, t, -2t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\},$$

a line through the origin, which is a subspace by [Theorem 1.2.2](#).

- (b) Take $\mathbf{u} = (1, -1, 0)$, which lies in U since $1 - 1 + 0 = 0$, but not in W since $1 - (-1) = 2 \neq 0$. Take $\mathbf{w} = (1, 1, 0)$, which lies in W , but not in U since $1 + 1 + 0 = 2 \neq 0$. Both lie in $U \cup W$. Their sum is $(2, 0, 0)$, which is not in U (as $2 + 0 + 0 \neq 0$) and not in W (as $2 - 0 \neq 0$). Hence $U \cup W$ is not closed under addition, and it is not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

1.2.8.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Covering a Space by Subspaces.

- (a) Let V be a vector space over any field F . Prove that V is not the union of two proper subspaces.
- (b) Show that $\mathbb{F}_2^2$ is the union of three proper subspaces.

Hint: for (a), use [Proposition 1.2.3](#).

Solution.

- (a) Suppose, for a contradiction, that $V = U \cup W$ with U and W proper subspaces of V . Then $U \cup W = V$ is a subspace of V , so by [Proposition 1.2.3](#), $U \subseteq W$ or $W \subseteq U$. In the first case $V = U \cup W = W$, and in the second $V = U$. Either way one of the subspaces equals V , contradicting that both are proper. Hence V is not the union of two proper subspaces.
- (b) The space $\mathbb{F}_2^2$ has the four elements $(0, 0), (1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1)$. Let $\mathbf{v}$ be one of the three non-zero elements, and let $U_{\mathbf{v}} = \{\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{v}\}$. We check that $U_{\mathbf{v}}$ is a subspace with the three-check move.

(1) $\mathbf{0} \in U_{\mathbf{v}}$ by construction.

(2) The possible sums are $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{v}$, and $\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v} = (1 + 1)\mathbf{v} = 0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, using (VS8), (VS6), $1 + 1 = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$, and [Theorem 1.1.5](#). All lie in $U_{\mathbf{v}}$, so $U_{\mathbf{v}}$ is closed under addition.

(3) The only scalars are 0 and 1. For $\mathbf{u} \in U_{\mathbf{v}}$, $0\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.5](#) and $1\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u}$ by (VS8), both in $U_{\mathbf{v}}$. So $U_{\mathbf{v}}$ is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence each $U_{\mathbf{v}}$ is a subspace. Each has two elements, so it is proper. Every element of $\mathbb{F}_2^2$ is $\mathbf{0}$ or one of the three non-zero vectors, so

$$\mathbb{F}_2^2 = U_{(1,0)} \cup U_{(0,1)} \cup U_{(1,1)}.$$

So three proper subspaces can cover a vector space, although (a) shows two never can.

Exercise C2: The Sum of Two Subspaces.

Let U and W be subspaces of a vector space V over F , and let

$$U + W = \{\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} : \mathbf{u} \in U, \mathbf{w} \in W\}.$$

- (a) Prove that $U + W$ is a subspace of V containing both U and W .
- (b) Prove that if X is a subspace of V with $U \cup W \subseteq X$, then $U + W \subseteq X$.
- (c) For the two axes U and W of [Example \(The Union of the Two Axes\)](#), show that $U + W = \mathbb{R}^2$.

Solution.

- (a) Every $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ is a vector of V , so $U + W \subseteq V$.
 (1) Since $\mathbf{0} \in U$ and $\mathbf{0} \in W$, and $\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ by (VS3), we get $\mathbf{0} \in U + W$.
 (2) Let $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{w}_1$ and $\mathbf{u}_2 + \mathbf{w}_2$ be in $U + W$, with $\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2 \in U$ and $\mathbf{w}_1, \mathbf{w}_2 \in W$. By (VS1) and (VS2),

$$(\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{w}_1) + (\mathbf{u}_2 + \mathbf{w}_2) = (\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2) + (\mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2).$$

Since U and W are closed under addition, $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 \in U$ and $\mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2 \in W$. Therefore the sum lies in $U + W$. This shows that $U + W$ is closed under addition.

(3) Let $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U + W$. By (VS5), $a(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}) = a\mathbf{u} + a\mathbf{w}$, with $a\mathbf{u} \in U$ and $a\mathbf{w} \in W$ by closure. Therefore $a(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}) \in U + W$. This shows that $U + W$ is closed under scalar multiplication.

Hence $U + W$ is a subspace of V . For $\mathbf{u} \in U$, we have $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{0}$ with $\mathbf{0} \in W$, so $\mathbf{u} \in U + W$; thus $U \subseteq U + W$. Swapping the roles of U and W gives $W \subseteq U + W$, using (VS1).

- (b) Let $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U + W$ with $\mathbf{u} \in U$ and $\mathbf{w} \in W$. Then $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U \cup W \subseteq X$. Since X is a subspace, it is closed under addition, so $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in X$. Hence $U + W \subseteq X$.
- (c) By (a), $U + W \subseteq \mathbb{R}^2$. Conversely, let $(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2$. Then $(x, y) = (x, 0) + (0, y)$ with $(x, 0) \in U$ and $(0, y) \in W$, so $(x, y) \in U + W$. Hence $U + W = \mathbb{R}^2$, whereas $U \cup W$ is only the two axes.

Exercise C3: A One-Line Test, and a Test over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Let V be a vector space over F and $U \subseteq V$.

- (a) Prove that U is a subspace of V if and only if $U \neq \emptyset$ and $a\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$ for all $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$.
- (b) Suppose $F = \mathbb{F}_2$. Prove that U is a subspace of V if and only if $\mathbf{0} \in U$ and U is closed under addition.
- (c) Show by an example that the statement in (b) is false over $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution.

- (a) ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose U is a subspace. By the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)), $\mathbf{0} \in U$, so $U \neq \emptyset$. For $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$, condition (3) gives $a\mathbf{u} \in U$, and then condition (2) gives $a\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$.
- ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $U \neq \emptyset$ and $a\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$ for all $a \in F$, $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$. Pick $\mathbf{u}_0 \in U$.

Taking $a = -1$ and $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u}_0$, and using [Theorem 1.1.7](#) and (VS4),

$$(-1)\mathbf{u}_0 + \mathbf{u}_0 = -\mathbf{u}_0 + \mathbf{u}_0 = \mathbf{0} \in U,$$

where $-\mathbf{u}_0 + \mathbf{u}_0 = \mathbf{u}_0 + (-\mathbf{u}_0)$ by (VS1). This is condition (1). For $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in U$, taking $a = 1$ and using (VS8) gives $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} = 1\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} \in U$, which is (2). For $a \in F$ and $\mathbf{u} \in U$, taking $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0} \in U$ and using (VS3) gives $a\mathbf{u} = a\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{0} \in U$, which is (3). By the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)), U is a subspace.

- (b) ($\Rightarrow$) This is part of the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)). ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\mathbf{0} \in U$ and U is closed under addition. The only scalars in $\mathbb{F}_2$ are 0 and 1. For $\mathbf{u} \in U$, $0\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0} \in U$ by [Theorem 1.1.5](#), and $1\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u} \in U$ by (VS8). So U is closed under scalar multiplication, and by the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)) U is a subspace.
- (c) Take $V = \mathbb{R}^2$ and $U = \mathbb{Z}^2$. Then $\mathbf{0} \in U$, and the sum of two integer vectors is an integer vector. But $\frac{1}{2}(1, 0) = (\frac{1}{2}, 0) \notin U$, so U is not a subspace. Over $\mathbb{R}$ there are many more scalars to test than 0 and 1.

1.3 Linear Combinations and Span

We now have vector spaces and, inside them, subspaces. So far every subspace has been handed to us by a condition, such as “ $x + 2y = 0$ ” or “ $A^T = A$ ”. This section goes the other way. We start from a few vectors, build everything that can be built from them, and show that the result is always a subspace: the smallest one containing the vectors we started with. Along the way we meet the first way of measuring a space, by asking whether finitely many vectors are enough to build all of it.

1.3.1 Linear combinations

Take two vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$, say $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 0, 1)$ and $\mathbf{v}_2 = (0, 1, 1)$. Which vectors can we build from them, using only the two operations a vector space gives us? Scaling gives $a\mathbf{v}_1$ and $b\mathbf{v}_2$, and adding gives

$$a\mathbf{v}_1 + b\mathbf{v}_2 = (a, b, a + b).$$

Adding or scaling again produces nothing new: for instance $2(a\mathbf{v}_1 + b\mathbf{v}_2) + (c\mathbf{v}_1 + d\mathbf{v}_2) = (2a + c)\mathbf{v}_1 + (2b + d)\mathbf{v}_2$ has the same shape. So the vectors we can reach are exactly those of the form $(a, b, a + b)$: the plane $z = x + y$ through the origin. The expression $a\mathbf{v}_1 + b\mathbf{v}_2$ will appear in almost every argument from now on, so it deserves a name.

The vectors we combine come as a **list** $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$: a finite sequence of vectors, in order, in which repeats are allowed. A list of length $k = 0$ is the **empty list** $()$. Why lists rather than sets becomes important in the next section; for now it costs nothing.

Definition 1.3.1 — Linear Combination

Let V be a vector space over F , and let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ be a list of vectors in V , where $k \geq 0$. A **linear combination** of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is a vector of the form

$$a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + a_2\mathbf{v}_2 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k, \quad \text{where } a_1, \dots, a_k \in F.$$

The scalars a_i are the **coefficients** of the combination. A linear combination of the empty list is, by convention, the **empty sum** $\mathbf{0}$.

In words: scale each vector of the list by a scalar from F , then add up the results. Two small points hide in the notation. First, a sum of k vectors needs no brackets, because addition in V is associative (VS2); so the expression names a single vector. Second, the coefficients must lie in the field F we are working over. Changing the field can change what counts as a combination, as [Exercise \(C2: The Span Depends on the Field\)](#) shows.

The empty sum convention is the additive twin of $0! = 1$ and $x^0 = 1$, where a product with no factors is the neutral element 1 for multiplication: a sum with no terms is the neutral element $\mathbf{0}$ for addition. It will make several statements true without exceptions.

Example. (Linear Combinations in Four Families)

Show that each vector is a linear combination of the given list.

- (a) $(3, -2, 1) \in \mathbb{R}^3$, of the list $((1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1))$.
- (b) $x^2 - 1 \in \mathbb{R}[x]$, of the list $((x+1)^2, x+1)$.
- (c) The function $\sin^2$ in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$, of the list $(1, \cos 2x)$, where 1 is the constant function.
- (d) The zero vector of any vector space V , of any list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ in V .

Solution.

- (a) We need $a(1, 0, 1) + b(0, 1, 1) = (a, b, a+b)$ to equal $(3, -2, 1)$. The first two entries force $a = 3$ and $b = -2$, and then the third entry is $a + b = 1$, as required. Hence $(3, -2, 1) = 3(1, 0, 1) - 2(0, 1, 1)$.
- (b) Expanding, $(x+1)^2 - 2(x+1) = x^2 + 2x + 1 - 2x - 2 = x^2 - 1$. So the coefficients are 1 and -2 .
- (c) The double-angle formula $\cos 2x = 1 - 2\sin^2 x$ holds for every real x . Hence $\sin^2 x = \frac{1}{2} \cdot 1 + (-\frac{1}{2})\cos 2x$ for every x , which is an equality of functions by [Definition 0.4.1](#). The coefficients $\frac{1}{2}$ and $-\frac{1}{2}$ are real, as they must be.
- (d) Take every coefficient to be 0. By [Theorem 1.1.5](#), $0\mathbf{v}_i = \mathbf{0}$ for each i , so $0\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + 0\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. For the empty list, $\mathbf{0}$ is the empty sum. This degenerate case matters: it says the zero vector can always be built, from anything, even from nothing.

Notice that the question in (a) was a small system of equations in the unknown coefficients. That is typical: deciding whether a vector is a combination of a list means deciding whether a system of linear equations has a solution. Here we solve such systems by hand; Chapter 2 gives a systematic method.

1.3.2 The span

The span of some vectors is everything you can build from them by scaling and adding.

We have two kinds of input to cover. Usually we start from a list, as above. But sometimes the natural input is a set, possibly infinite, such as all the powers $1, x, x^2, \dots$ in $F[x]$. A linear combination only ever uses finitely many vectors, so for a set we allow every finite list drawn from it.

Definition 1.3.2 — Span

Let V be a vector space over F .

- The **span** of a list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ of vectors in V is the set of **all** its linear combinations:

$$\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = \{a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k : a_1, \dots, a_k \in F\}.$$

- The **span** of a subset $S \subseteq V$, possibly infinite, is the set of all vectors that are linear combinations of **some finite** list of vectors in S :

$$\text{span}(S) = \{a_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{s}_k : k \geq 0, \mathbf{s}_1, \dots, \mathbf{s}_k \in S, a_1, \dots, a_k \in F\}.$$

In particular $\text{span}() = \text{span}(\emptyset) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. When the field matters we write span_F .

In words: for a list, the span collects every choice of coefficients. For a set, we may first pick any finite number of vectors from S (the same vector more than once is allowed), and then any coefficients. The value $k = 0$ is allowed, and it contributes the empty sum $\mathbf{0}$. So $\mathbf{0} \in \text{span}(S)$ for **every** S , including $S = \emptyset$.

One thing to check. A list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ now has two spans: the span of the list, and the span of the set $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k\}$ of its entries. They agree. A combination of the list is a combination of a finite list from the set, so the first is contained in the second. Conversely, take a combination $b_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + b_m\mathbf{w}_m$ where each $\mathbf{w}_r$ is one of the $\mathbf{v}_i$; for each r , choose one index $i(r)$ with $\mathbf{w}_r = \mathbf{v}_{i(r)}$. Group the terms with the same index together, using (VS1), (VS2) and $b\mathbf{v} + b'\mathbf{v} = (b + b')\mathbf{v}$ (VS6). The result is $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k$, where a_i is the sum of the b_r with $i(r) = i$ (and $a_i = 0$ if there are none, by [Theorem 1.1.5](#)). So the second is contained in the first. In particular the span of a list does not change if we reorder the list or repeat an entry.

Why $\text{span}(\emptyset) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$? The definition forces it through the empty sum, but it is also the only sensible choice. We will prove that the span of S is the smallest subspace containing S . The smallest subspace containing nothing in particular is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$, since every subspace contains $\mathbf{0}$. Any other convention would make that theorem false for $S = \emptyset$, and the empty list will turn out to be a basis of the zero space.

Example. (Computing Spans)

Describe each span.

- $\text{span}((1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$. Is $(1, 2, 3)$ in it? Is $(1, 2, 4)$?
- $\text{span}(\mathbf{v})$ for a single vector $\mathbf{v}$ in a vector space V .
- $\text{span}(1, x^2)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]$.
- $\text{span}(\{1, x, x^2, x^3, \dots\})$ in $F[x]$.

Solution.

- As computed at the start of the section, the combinations are $a(1, 0, 1) + b(0, 1, 1) = (a, b, a + b)$. So the span is $\{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : z = x + y\}$, a plane through the origin. For membership, a vector (x, y, z) is in the span exactly when the entries fit: the first two entries force $a = x$ and $b = y$, and then we need $z = x + y$. Since $3 = 1 + 2$, the vector $(1, 2, 3) = 1(1, 0, 1) + 2(0, 1, 1)$ is in the span. Since $4 \neq 1 + 2$, the vector

$(1, 2, 4)$ is not.

- (b) $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}) = \{a\mathbf{v} : a \in F\}$. If $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$ and $V = \mathbb{R}^2$ or $\mathbb{R}^3$, this is the line through the origin in the direction of $\mathbf{v}$. If $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, then $a\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ for every a ([Theorem 1.1.6](#)), so $\text{span}(\mathbf{0}) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. This degenerate case shows that a span can be as small as the zero space even when the list is not empty.
- (c) The combinations are $a + bx^2$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$: the polynomials of degree at most 2 with no x term. For example $x^2 + x$ is **not** in the span, because its coefficient of x is $1 \neq 0$ and polynomials are equal only when all coefficients agree ([Definition 0.8.1](#)).
- (d) Every polynomial $a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_Nx^N$ is a combination of the finite list $(1, x, \dots, x^N)$ of vectors in the set. Conversely every combination of finitely many powers of x is a polynomial. So the span is all of $F[x]$. No single polynomial here is a combination of *infinitely* many powers: each one uses only the powers up to its degree.

Quick check. Is $\text{span}((1, 2))$ a subset of $\text{span}((2, 4))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$? Are they equal?

Solution. Yes to both. Since $(2, 4) = 2(1, 2)$, every $a(2, 4) = (2a)(1, 2)$ lies in $\text{span}((1, 2))$. Since $(1, 2) = \frac{1}{2}(2, 4)$, every $a(1, 2) = \frac{a}{2}(2, 4)$ lies in $\text{span}((2, 4))$. Both spans are the line $y = 2x$. Different lists can have the same span.

1.3.3 The span is the smallest subspace

The plane in [Example \(Computing Spans\)](#) (a) was a subspace. That was no accident. Adding two combinations gives a combination, and so does scaling one. And any subspace that contains the vectors must contain all their combinations, because a subspace is closed under exactly the operations that build them. So the span is both a subspace and the smallest one available:

Theorem 1.3.1 — Span Is the Smallest Subspace

Let V be a vector space over F and let $S \subseteq V$. Then:

- (1) $\text{span}(S)$ is a subspace of V ;
- (2) $S \subseteq \text{span}(S)$;
- (3) if U is a subspace of V with $S \subseteq U$, then $\text{span}(S) \subseteq U$.

The same holds for the span of a list, which equals the span of the set of its entries.

Idea. Part (1) is the three-check subspace test. Part (2) is the combination **1s**. Part (3) is “a subspace is closed under the operations that build combinations”; since a combination has k terms for an arbitrary k , we add one term at a time, by induction on k .

Proof.

- (1) We apply [Theorem 1.2.1](#).
 - *Zero.* The empty list is a finite list of vectors in S , and its only combination is $\mathbf{0}$. Hence $\mathbf{0} \in \text{span}(S)$.
 - *Addition.* Let $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in \text{span}(S)$. Then $\mathbf{x} = a_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{s}_k$ and $\mathbf{y} = b_1\mathbf{t}_1 + \cdots + b_l\mathbf{t}_l$.

$\cdots + b_m \mathbf{t}_m$ for some $\mathbf{s}_i, \mathbf{t}_j \in S$ and scalars $a_i, b_j \in F$. Therefore

$$\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y} = a_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k \mathbf{s}_k + b_1 \mathbf{t}_1 + \cdots + b_m \mathbf{t}_m,$$

which is a combination of the list $(\mathbf{s}_1, \dots, \mathbf{s}_k, \mathbf{t}_1, \dots, \mathbf{t}_m)$ of vectors in S . (If some $\mathbf{t}_j$ equals some $\mathbf{s}_i$, the list has a repeat, which lists allow.) Hence $\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y} \in \text{span}(S)$. This shows $\text{span}(S)$ is closed under addition.

- *Scaling.* Let $\mathbf{x} = a_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k \mathbf{s}_k \in \text{span}(S)$ and $c \in F$. By (VS5), applied $k - 1$ times, and by (VS7) for each term,

$$c\mathbf{x} = (ca_1)\mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + (ca_k)\mathbf{s}_k,$$

which is a combination of the same list. Hence $c\mathbf{x} \in \text{span}(S)$. This shows $\text{span}(S)$ is closed under scalar multiplication.

Therefore $\text{span}(S)$ is a subspace of V .

- (2) Let $\mathbf{s} \in S$. By (VS8), $\mathbf{s} = 1\mathbf{s}$, which is a combination of the list $(\mathbf{s})$. Hence $\mathbf{s} \in \text{span}(S)$.
- (3) Let U be a subspace with $S \subseteq U$. By [Theorem 1.2.1](#), U contains $\mathbf{0}$ and is closed under addition and scalar multiplication. We prove by induction on $k \geq 0$ ([Theorem 0.2.7](#)) that every combination $a_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k \mathbf{s}_k$ with $\mathbf{s}_i \in S$ lies in U . For $k = 0$ the combination is $\mathbf{0} \in U$. Suppose the claim holds for k , and consider $a_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_{k+1} \mathbf{s}_{k+1}$. By the induction hypothesis $\mathbf{x} = a_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k \mathbf{s}_k \in U$. Since $\mathbf{s}_{k+1} \in S \subseteq U$ and U is closed under scaling, $a_{k+1} \mathbf{s}_{k+1} \in U$. Since U is closed under addition, $\mathbf{x} + a_{k+1} \mathbf{s}_{k+1} \in U$. This completes the induction, and shows $\text{span}(S) \subseteq U$.

■

In one phrase: $\text{span}(S)$ is a subspace containing S , and it sits inside every other one. So “the smallest subspace containing S ” makes sense, and it is $\text{span}(S)$. This gives a second, top-down description of the span, which does not mention combinations at all.

Corollary 1.3.2 — Span as an Intersection

Let V be a vector space and $S \subseteq V$. Let $\mathcal{U}$ be the set of all subspaces U of V with $S \subseteq U$. Then

$$\text{span}(S) = \bigcap_{U \in \mathcal{U}} U.$$

Proof. The index set $\mathcal{U}$ is non-empty, because V is a subspace of itself containing S ; so the intersection is defined ([Definition 0.3.9](#)).

($\subseteq$) By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (3), $\text{span}(S) \subseteq U$ for every $U \in \mathcal{U}$. Hence $\text{span}(S)$ is contained in the intersection.

($\supseteq$) By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (1) and (2), $\text{span}(S)$ is itself a member of $\mathcal{U}$. An intersection is contained in each of its members, so the intersection is contained in $\text{span}(S)$.

By [Theorem 0.3.1](#), the two sets are equal.

■

By [Theorem 1.2.2](#), an intersection of subspaces is a subspace, so the right-hand side is a subspace for a reason that never mentions combinations. The two descriptions complement each other. The bottom-up one (combinations) tells us what the elements look like. The top-down one (intersection) is convenient for proving that the span lies inside something.

Warning. The span of S is **not** S , and it is a subspace **even when** S is **not**. For example $S = \{(1, 0), (0, 1)\}$ is a two-element set, and not a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^2$ (it does not contain $(0, 0)$). Its span is the whole plane $\mathbb{R}^2$, since $(x, y) = x(1, 0) + y(0, 1)$. By [Theorem 1.3.1](#), $\text{span}(S) = S$ holds exactly when S is already a subspace. Also keep the two uses of the word apart: “the span of S ” is a noun, a subspace; “ S spans V ” is a verb, defined next.

1.3.4 Spanning lists and finite-dimensional spaces

The most important case is when the span is everything. Then the list is a complete toolkit for the space: every vector can be built from it.

Definition 1.3.3 — Spanning List, Spanning Set

Let V be a vector space over F . A list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ in V **spans** V , or is a **spanning list** of V , if $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = V$. A subset $S \subseteq V$ **spans** V , or is a **spanning set** of V , if $\text{span}(S) = V$.

Since every span is contained in V , to show that a list spans V we must show one thing: **every** $\mathbf{v} \in V$ can be written as $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k$ for **some** scalars. The scalars may depend on $\mathbf{v}$, and they need not be unique.

Example. (Spanning Lists)

Show that each list spans the given space.

- (a) $(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n)$ in F^n , where $\mathbf{e}_i$ has 1 in position i and 0 elsewhere.
- (b) $(1, x, x^2)$ in $F[x]_{\leq 2}$.
- (c) $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$.
- (d) $(E_{11}, E_{12}, E_{21}, E_{22})$ in $M_2(F)$, where E_{ij} has 1 in entry (i, j) and 0 elsewhere.
- (e) The empty list, in the zero space $\{\mathbf{0}\}$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $(x_1, \dots, x_n) \in F^n$. Adding entry by entry, $x_1\mathbf{e}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{e}_n = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$. So every vector is a combination, with its own entries as coefficients.
- (b) Every $p \in F[x]_{\leq 2}$ has the form $a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2$ ([Definition 0.8.4](#)), which is the combination $a_0 \cdot 1 + a_1 \cdot x + a_2 \cdot x^2$.
- (c) Let $(p, q) \in \mathbb{R}^2$. We look for a, b with $a(1, 1) + b(1, -1) = (p, q)$, that is,

$$a + b = p, \quad a - b = q.$$

Adding the equations gives $2a = p + q$, and subtracting gives $2b = p - q$. So

- $a = \frac{p+q}{2}$ and $b = \frac{p-q}{2}$. Check: $\frac{p+q}{2} + \frac{p-q}{2} = p$ and $\frac{p+q}{2} - \frac{p-q}{2} = q$. Hence $(p, q) = \frac{p+q}{2}(1, 1) + \frac{p-q}{2}(1, -1)$, and the list spans $\mathbb{R}^2$. For instance $(3, 5) = 4(1, 1) - (1, -1)$.
- (d) For any matrix, $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} = aE_{11} + bE_{12} + cE_{21} + dE_{22}$, by adding entry by entry.
- (e) $\text{span}() = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ by [Definition 1.3.2](#). So the empty list spans the zero space. (So does the list $(\mathbf{0})$.)

The solution of (3) divided by 2, which is fine in $\mathbb{R}$. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, where $2 = 0$, the same list fails: there $1 = -1$, so both vectors equal $(1, 1)$, and their span is $\{(0, 0), (1, 1)\} \neq \mathbb{F}_2^2$. Whether a list spans depends on the field.

Now the non-example, by a minimal change of (3). Replace the list by $((1, 2), (2, 4))$. It still has two vectors, and neither is zero. But every combination is

$$a(1, 2) + b(2, 4) = (a + 2b)(1, 2),$$

a vector whose second entry is twice its first. So $(0, 1)$ is **not** reached, and the list does **not** span $\mathbb{R}^2$. The clause that fails is “**every** $\mathbf{v} \in V$ is a combination”. The two vectors point along the same line, so their span is only the line $y = 2x$.

Some spaces are spanned by a short list; others need infinitely many vectors. That distinction is the first coarse measurement of size in this book.

Definition 1.3.4 — Finite-Dimensional

A vector space V over F is **finite-dimensional** if **some** finite list of vectors in V spans V . Otherwise V is **infinite-dimensional**.

By [Example \(Spanning Lists\)](#), F^n , $F[x]_{\leq 2}$, $M_2(F)$ and $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ are finite-dimensional. The same argument as in (2) and (4) shows that $F[x]_{\leq n}$ and $M_{m \times n}(F)$ are finite-dimensional too. The word “dimension” is used before we have defined a number called dimension; that number, and the fact that it is well defined, are the subject of section 6 of this chapter.

For the whole polynomial space no finite list is enough. The reason is degree: finitely many polynomials have a largest degree, and combining them never climbs above it.

Theorem 1.3.3 — $F[x]$ Is Infinite-Dimensional

For every field F , the vector space $F[x]$ is infinite-dimensional.

Proof. Let $(p_1, \dots, p_k)$ be any finite list in $F[x]$. We show it does not span $F[x]$. Each $\deg p_i$ is either a natural number or $-\infty$, and there are finitely many, so we can choose $N \in \mathbb{N}$ with $\deg p_i \leq N$ for every i .

Let $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$. The coefficients of $a_i p_i$ are a_i times those of p_i ([Example \(The Standard Vector Spaces\)](#) (c)). Every coefficient of x^m with $m > N$ in p_i is 0, by [Definition 0.8.3](#), and $a_i \cdot 0 = 0$ by (F6) and [Theorem 0.7.1](#) (d); hence $\deg(a_i p_i) \leq N$. By [Theorem 0.8.2](#), $\deg(p + q) \leq \max(\deg p, \deg q)$, so a sum of two polynomials of degree at most N has degree at most N . Applying this $k - 1$ times, $\deg(a_1 p_1 + \dots + a_k p_k) \leq N$. (For $k = 0$ the combination is 0, of degree $-\infty \leq N$.)

Hence every element of $\text{span}(p_1, \dots, p_k)$ has degree at most N . But $x^{N+1} \in F[x]$ has

degree $N + 1 > N$, so $x^{N+1} \notin \text{span}(p_1, \dots, p_k)$. Since the list was arbitrary, no finite list spans $F[x]$. This shows $F[x]$ is infinite-dimensional. ■

(In the proof we wrote polynomials in plain italic, p , as in Chapter 0; they are vectors of $F[x]$ all the same.) The proof is the move “find a quantity that combinations cannot increase”. The space $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ of all functions is infinite-dimensional too, and so are the sequence spaces; we return to such spaces in section 8 of this chapter.

Remark. For an arbitrary subset $S \subseteq V$, finite or infinite, “ S spans V ” means that **every** vector of V is a combination of **some finite** list of vectors in S . Different vectors may use different finite lists, as in [Example \(Computing Spans\)](#) (d). We never form infinite sums: a vector space only lets us add two vectors at a time, so only finite sums have a meaning. The same “every finite list” reading will be used for independence of an arbitrary set in the next section.

1.3.5 Working with spans

Three facts make spans easy to manipulate. Each follows from [Theorem 1.3.1](#) without writing a single combination.

Proposition 1.3.4 — Basic Properties of Span

Let V be a vector space and $S, T \subseteq V$.

- (1) If $T \subseteq \text{span}(S)$, then $\text{span}(T) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$.
- (2) (Monotonicity) If $T \subseteq S$, then $\text{span}(T) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$.
- (3) $\text{span}(\text{span}(S)) = \text{span}(S)$.

Proof.

- (1) By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (1), $\text{span}(S)$ is a subspace, and by hypothesis it contains T . By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (3) applied to T , $\text{span}(T) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$.
- (2) By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (2), $T \subseteq S \subseteq \text{span}(S)$. Now apply (1).
- (3) Taking $T = \text{span}(S)$ in (1) gives $\text{span}(\text{span}(S)) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$. The reverse inclusion is [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (2) applied to the set $\text{span}(S)$. ■

Part (1) is the workhorse. To show $\text{span}(T) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$, it is enough to check that each vector of T is a combination of vectors of S ; we do not have to handle every combination of T .

The next fact is the one later sections lean on most. If a vector can already be built from S , then adding it to S builds nothing new.

Theorem 1.3.5 — Absorbing a Vector into a Span

Let V be a vector space, $S \subseteq V$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. If $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(S)$, then

$$\text{span}(S \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}) = \text{span}(S).$$

In particular, for a list: if $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, then $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k, \mathbf{v}) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, and the same holds with $\mathbf{v}$ inserted at any position of the list.

Proof. ($\supseteq$) Since $S \subseteq S \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$, monotonicity (Proposition 1.3.4 (2)) gives $\text{span}(S) \subseteq \text{span}(S \cup \{\mathbf{v}\})$.

($\subseteq$) By Theorem 1.3.1 (2), $S \subseteq \text{span}(S)$, and $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(S)$ by hypothesis. Hence $S \cup \{\mathbf{v}\} \subseteq \text{span}(S)$, and Proposition 1.3.4 (1) gives $\text{span}(S \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$.

For the list version, the span of a list equals the span of the set of its entries, whatever the order. The entries of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k, \mathbf{v})$ form the set $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k\} \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$, so the first part applies. ■

Concretely, the proof substitutes. If $\mathbf{v} = c_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + c_k\mathbf{v}_k$, then any combination $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k + b\mathbf{v}$ equals $(a_1 + bc_1)\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + (a_k + bc_k)\mathbf{v}_k$, which no longer uses $\mathbf{v}$. Read backwards, the lemma says that a vector lying in the span of the others can be **deleted** from a list without shrinking its span. The next section turns this into the idea of a redundant vector, and section 6 of this chapter uses it at every step of the Exchange Theorem.

Example. (Two Lists with the Same Span)

Show that $\text{span}(1+x, 1-x) = \text{span}(1, x)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]$.

Solution. ($\subseteq$) Both $1+x = 1 \cdot 1 + 1 \cdot x$ and $1-x = 1 \cdot 1 + (-1) \cdot x$ lie in $\text{span}(1, x)$. By Proposition 1.3.4 (1), $\text{span}(1+x, 1-x) \subseteq \text{span}(1, x)$.

($\supseteq$) Conversely,

$$1 = \frac{1}{2}(1+x) + \frac{1}{2}(1-x), \quad x = \frac{1}{2}(1+x) - \frac{1}{2}(1-x),$$

so both 1 and x lie in $\text{span}(1+x, 1-x)$. By Proposition 1.3.4 (1) again, $\text{span}(1, x) \subseteq \text{span}(1+x, 1-x)$.

Hence the spans are equal; both are $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 1}$. Notice that we only checked four vectors, not all combinations. We also used $\frac{1}{2}$, so the argument needs $2 \neq 0$ in the field.

Quick check. Is $x^2 + 1 \in \text{span}(x^2 + x, x + 1)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]$?

Solution. No. Suppose $a(x^2 + x) + b(x + 1) = x^2 + 1$. The left side is $ax^2 + (a+b)x + b$. Comparing coefficients (Definition 0.8.1): $a = 1$ from x^2 , $b = 1$ from the constant term, and $a + b = 0$ from x . But then $a + b = 2 \neq 0$, a contradiction. So no such a, b exist.

1.3.6 Exercises

1.3.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define the span of a subset S of a vector space V . What is $\text{span}(\emptyset)$, and why?
- (b) Determine whether the following statement is true: “for a subset $S \subseteq V$, $\text{span}(S) = S$ if and only if S is a subspace of V .” Justify your answer.
- (c) Determine whether the following statement is true: “if $\text{span}(S) = \text{span}(T)$, then $S = T$.” Justify your answer.
- (d) Is the zero vector in the span of every list? Is it in the span of the empty list?
- (e) State what it means for V to be finite-dimensional, and name the quantity used to show that $F[x]$ is not.

Solution.

- (a) $\text{span}(S)$ is the set of all linear combinations $a_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{s}_k$ with $k \geq 0$, $\mathbf{s}_i \in S$ and $a_i \in F$. $\text{span}(\emptyset) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$: the only combination with no vectors is the empty sum $\mathbf{0}$. This is also the smallest subspace containing $\emptyset$, as [Theorem 1.3.1](#) requires.
- (b) True. If $\text{span}(S) = S$, then S is a subspace by [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (1). Conversely, if S is a subspace, then $\text{span}(S) \subseteq S$ by [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (3) with $U = S$, and $S \subseteq \text{span}(S)$ by (2).
- (c) False. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, take $S = \{(1, 0), (0, 1)\}$ and $T = \{(1, 1), (1, -1)\}$. Both span $\mathbb{R}^2$ ([Example \(Spanning Lists\)](#)), but $S \neq T$.
- (d) Yes to both: take all coefficients 0, or, for the empty list, the empty sum. See [Example \(Linear Combinations in Four Families\)](#) (d).
- (e) V is finite-dimensional if some finite list of vectors in V spans V . For $F[x]$ the quantity is the degree: combinations of a finite list have degree at most the largest degree in the list ([Theorem 1.3.3](#)).

1.3.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Membership in a Span.

Determine whether each vector lies in the given span. If it does, write it as a linear combination. Justify your answer.

- (a) $(2, -1, 5)$ and $(3, 4, 1)$, in $\text{span}((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1)) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^3$.
- (b) $2x^2 - 3x + 1$ and $x^2 + x + 1$, in $\text{span}(x^2 - x, x - 1) \subseteq \mathbb{R}[x]$.

Solution.

- (a) A combination is $a(1, 1, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) = (a, a + b, b)$. For $(2, -1, 5)$, the first and third entries force $a = 2$ and $b = 5$; then the middle entry would be $7 \neq -1$. Hence $(2, -1, 5)$ is **not** in the span. For $(3, 4, 1)$, we get $a = 3$, $b = 1$, and the middle entry is 4, as required. Hence $(3, 4, 1) = 3(1, 1, 0) + (0, 1, 1)$ is in the span.
- (b) A combination is $a(x^2 - x) + b(x - 1) = ax^2 + (b - a)x - b$. Compare coefficients

([Definition 0.8.1](#)). For $2x^2 - 3x + 1$: $a = 2$, $-b = 1$ so $b = -1$, and then $b - a = -3$, as required. Hence $2x^2 - 3x + 1 = 2(x^2 - x) - (x - 1)$ is in the span. For $x^2 + x + 1$: $a = 1$, $b = -1$, and then $b - a = -2 \neq 1$. Hence $x^2 + x + 1$ is **not** in the span. (Every element p of this span has $p(1) = a - a + b - b = 0$, and indeed $x^2 + x + 1$ has value 3 at 1.)

Exercise B2: Two Lists with the Same Span.

Prove that $\text{span}((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1)) = \text{span}((1, 2, 1), (1, 0, -1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution. Write $\mathbf{u} = (1, 1, 0)$, $\mathbf{w} = (0, 1, 1)$.

($\subseteq$) We have $\mathbf{u} = \frac{1}{2}(1, 2, 1) + \frac{1}{2}(1, 0, -1)$ and $\mathbf{w} = \frac{1}{2}(1, 2, 1) - \frac{1}{2}(1, 0, -1)$: indeed $\frac{1}{2}(2, 2, 0) = (1, 1, 0)$ and $\frac{1}{2}(0, 2, 2) = (0, 1, 1)$. So $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w} \in \text{span}((1, 2, 1), (1, 0, -1))$, and [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (1) gives the inclusion.

($\supseteq$) We have $(1, 2, 1) = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ and $(1, 0, -1) = \mathbf{u} - \mathbf{w}$. So both lie in $\text{span}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w})$, and [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (1) gives the reverse inclusion.

Hence the two spans are equal.

Exercise B3: Spans in $\mathbb{R}^3$, Geometrically.

Describe each span as the origin, a line through the origin, a plane through the origin (give an equation), or all of $\mathbb{R}^3$. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\text{span}((1, 2, 3))$.
- (b) $\text{span}((1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0), (1, 1, 0))$.
- (c) $\text{span}((1, -1, 0), (0, 1, -1))$.
- (d) $\text{span}((0, 0, 0))$.

Solution.

- (a) The span is $\{(t, 2t, 3t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}$: the line through the origin and $(1, 2, 3)$.
- (b) Since $(1, 1, 0) = (1, 0, 0) + (0, 1, 0)$, [Theorem 1.3.5](#) gives $\text{span}((1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0), (1, 1, 0)) = \text{span}((1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0)) = \{(a, b, 0) : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\}$: the plane $z = 0$.
- (c) A combination is $a(1, -1, 0) + b(0, 1, -1) = (a, b - a, -b)$, whose entries sum to 0. Conversely, if $x + y + z = 0$, take $a = x$ and $b = -z$; then $b - a = -z - x = y$, so $(x, y, z) = x(1, -1, 0) - z(0, 1, -1)$. Hence the span is the plane $x + y + z = 0$.
- (d) $\text{span}((0, 0, 0)) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, by [Example \(Computing Spans\)](#) (b): the origin alone.

1.3.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Spans of Intersections and Unions.

Let S, T be subsets of a vector space V .

- (a) Prove that $\text{span}(S \cap T) \subseteq \text{span}(S) \cap \text{span}(T)$.

- (b) Give an example in $\mathbb{R}^2$ where the inclusion in (a) is strict.
- (c) Prove that $\text{span}(S \cup T) = \{\mathbf{s} + \mathbf{t} : \mathbf{s} \in \text{span}(S), \mathbf{t} \in \text{span}(T)\}$.

Hint for (c): in a combination of vectors of $S \cup T$, sort the terms into two groups.

Solution.

- (a) Since $S \cap T \subseteq S$, monotonicity (Proposition 1.3.4 (2)) gives $\text{span}(S \cap T) \subseteq \text{span}(S)$. By symmetry, $\text{span}(S \cap T) \subseteq \text{span}(T)$. Hence $\text{span}(S \cap T) \subseteq \text{span}(S) \cap \text{span}(T)$.
- (b) Take $S = \{(1, 0), (0, 1)\}$ and $T = \{(1, 1)\}$. Then $S \cap T = \emptyset$, so $\text{span}(S \cap T) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. But $\text{span}(S) = \mathbb{R}^2$ (Example (Spanning Lists)), so $\text{span}(S) \cap \text{span}(T) = \text{span}(T)$, the line $y = x$, which contains $(1, 1) \neq \mathbf{0}$. The inclusion is strict.
- (c) Write $W = \{\mathbf{s} + \mathbf{t} : \mathbf{s} \in \text{span}(S), \mathbf{t} \in \text{span}(T)\}$.
 - ($\subseteq$) Let $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(S \cup T)$, say $\mathbf{v} = a_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + a_k \mathbf{u}_k$ with each $\mathbf{u}_i \in S \cup T$. Let $\mathbf{s}$ be the sum of the terms $a_i \mathbf{u}_i$ with $\mathbf{u}_i \in S$, and $\mathbf{t}$ the sum of the remaining terms, whose vectors lie in T . Since addition is commutative and associative, $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{s} + \mathbf{t}$. Now $\mathbf{s} \in \text{span}(S)$ and $\mathbf{t} \in \text{span}(T)$; if a group is empty, its sum is $\mathbf{0}$, which lies in every span. Hence $\mathbf{v} \in W$.
 - ($\supseteq$) Let $\mathbf{s} \in \text{span}(S)$ and $\mathbf{t} \in \text{span}(T)$. By monotonicity, both lie in $\text{span}(S \cup T)$, which is closed under addition by Theorem 1.3.1 (1). Hence $\mathbf{s} + \mathbf{t} \in \text{span}(S \cup T)$. By Theorem 0.3.1, $\text{span}(S \cup T) = W$. (So W is the set $\text{span}(S) + \text{span}(T)$ of Exercise (C2: The Sum of Two Subspaces), the **sum** of the two subspaces, studied in section 7 of this chapter.)

Exercise C2: The Span Depends on the Field.

The set $\mathbb{C}^2$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$. With the same addition, and scalar multiplication restricted to real scalars, it is also a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$, by Exercise (C3: Shrinking the Field): every axiom holds for all complex scalars, so in particular for real ones.

- (a) Show that $((1, 0), (0, 1))$ spans $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{C}$.
- (b) Explain why $((1, 0), (0, 1))$ does **not** span $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{R}$.
- (c) Find a finite list that spans $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{R}$. Hence $\mathbb{C}^2$ is finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{R}$ as well.

Solution.

- (a) For $(z, w) \in \mathbb{C}^2$, $(z, w) = z(1, 0) + w(0, 1)$ with $z, w \in \mathbb{C}$.
- (b) Over $\mathbb{R}$ the coefficients must be real, and $a(1, 0) + b(0, 1) = (a, b)$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ has real entries. So $(i, 0)$ is not in $\text{span}_{\mathbb{R}}((1, 0), (0, 1))$.
- (c) Take $((1, 0), (i, 0), (0, 1), (0, i))$. Write $z = a + bi$ and $w = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$ (Definition 0.6.1). Then

$$(z, w) = a(1, 0) + b(i, 0) + c(0, 1) + d(0, i),$$

a combination with real coefficients. So this list spans $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{R}$, and $\mathbb{C}^2$ is finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{R}$ by Definition 1.3.4.

1.4 Linear Independence

A spanning list tells us that every vector of a space can be built. It says nothing about waste. The list $((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1))$ spans $\mathbb{R}^2$, but its third vector adds nothing that the first two did not already reach. To measure a space by the length of a list, we need lists with no such waste. This section makes “no vector is wasted” precise, proves the lemma that finds a wasted vector whenever there is one, and shows that lists without waste give every vector in their span a unique description.

1.4.1 Redundant vectors

The previous section gave a way to shorten a list: if a vector lies in the span of the others, we may delete it without changing the span (Theorem 1.3.5). Call such a vector **redundant**. We want a test for “this list has no redundant vector”.

A first guess is that a vector is wasted when it repeats the direction of another one, so the test would be “no vector is a scalar multiple of another”. This guess fails. In $\mathbb{R}^3$, take

$$\mathbf{u} = (1, 0, 1), \quad \mathbf{v} = (0, 1, 1), \quad \mathbf{w} = (1, 1, 2).$$

No one of them is a multiple of another: a multiple of $\mathbf{u}$ has second entry 0, a multiple of $\mathbf{v}$ has first entry 0, a multiple $(c, c, 2c)$ of $\mathbf{w}$ has equal first and second entries, and in each case neither of the other two vectors has that shape. Yet $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}$. All three lie in the plane $z = x + y$, and by Theorem 1.3.5, $\text{span}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w}) = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$. The vector $\mathbf{w}$ is redundant even though it is not parallel to anything.

A second guess is correct but clumsy: “no vector is a linear combination of the others”. For a list of length k this is k separate conditions, one for each vector. Here is a way to fold them into one. Move everything in $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}$ to one side:

$$1\mathbf{u} + 1\mathbf{v} + (-1)\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}.$$

This is a way to build $\mathbf{0}$ from the list with coefficients that are **not all zero**. Conversely, suppose $a\mathbf{u} + b\mathbf{v} + c\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$ with, say, $c \neq 0$. Then $\mathbf{w} = -\frac{a}{c}\mathbf{u} - \frac{b}{c}\mathbf{v}$, so $\mathbf{w}$ is redundant. The same works whichever coefficient is non-zero. So a redundant vector exists exactly when $\mathbf{0}$ can be built in a non-trivial way. Building $\mathbf{0}$ trivially, with every coefficient 0, is always possible, so the condition we want is that this is the only way.

A list is independent when the only way to build the zero vector from it is the trivial way.

1.4.2 Definition and examples

Definition 1.4.1 — Linear Independence

Let V be a vector space over F and let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ be a list of vectors in V , where $k \geq 0$. The list is **linearly independent** (over F) if, for all $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$,

$$a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + a_2\mathbf{v}_2 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0} \implies a_1 = a_2 = \dots = a_k = 0.$$

The list is **linearly dependent** if it is not linearly independent: that is, if there exist $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$, **not all zero**, with $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. Such an equation is a **linear**

relation among the vectors. The empty list is linearly independent.

In words: the hypothesis is an arbitrary linear combination that happens to equal $\mathbf{0}$. The conclusion says that **every** coefficient in it is 0. Dependence is the negation, obtained by the rules of Definition 0.1.4: “for all a , (combination = $\mathbf{0} \Rightarrow$ all $a_i = 0$)” becomes “there exist a with combination = $\mathbf{0}$ and **not** all $a_i = 0$ ”. This is exactly the negation worked out in Example (Negating “only the zero combination”). The empty list is independent because the condition is vacuous: there are no coefficients, so “all of them are 0” holds automatically.

The definition also dictates how every independence proof starts. It is a “for all” statement about coefficients, so we take arbitrary coefficients and assume the hypothesis:

Let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. Then ... hence all $a_i = 0$.

Between “Let” and “hence”, the work is to turn one vector equation into scalar equations. How we do that depends on what $\mathbf{0}$ means in the space: in F^n we compare entries, in $F[x]$ we compare coefficients, in a function space we evaluate at points, and in $M_{m \times n}(F)$ we compare entries.

Example. (Independent Lists in Four Families)

Show that each list is linearly independent.

- (a) $(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n)$ in F^n .
- (b) $(1, x, x^2)$ in $F[x]$.
- (c) $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$.
- (d) $(\sin, \cos)$ in the space $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ of all functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $a_1\mathbf{e}_1 + \cdots + a_n\mathbf{e}_n = \mathbf{0}$. The left side is the vector $(a_1, \dots, a_n)$, and $\mathbf{0} = (0, \dots, 0)$. Comparing entries, $a_1 = \cdots = a_n = 0$. Hence the list is independent.
- (b) Let $a + bx + cx^2 = 0$, where 0 is the **zero polynomial**, the polynomial with every coefficient 0. Two polynomials are equal exactly when all their coefficients agree (Definition 0.8.1). Comparing the coefficients of $1, x, x^2$ gives $a = b = c = 0$. Hence the list is independent.
- (c) Let $a(1, 1) + b(1, -1) = (0, 0)$. Comparing entries, $a + b = 0$ and $a - b = 0$. Adding the two equations gives $2a = 0$, so $a = 0$ since $2 \neq 0$ in $\mathbb{R}$; then $b = -a = 0$. Hence the list is independent.
- (d) Let $a \sin + b \cos = 0$, where 0 is the **zero function**. Equality of functions means equality at every point (Definition 0.4.1), so $a \sin t + b \cos t = 0$ for **every** $t \in \mathbb{R}$. We may choose convenient points. At $t = 0$: $a \cdot 0 + b \cdot 1 = 0$, so $b = 0$. At $t = \pi/2$: $a \cdot 1 + b \cdot 0 = 0$, so $a = 0$. Hence the list is independent.

In (d) we did not need the equation at every point, only at two well-chosen ones. That is the general move for functions: **choose good points**, where most terms vanish. Note the logic. Evaluating at a point can only prove independence; if the equations at our chosen points had allowed non-zero solutions, we would have learned nothing, and would have to try other points or another method.

The degenerate cases are worth settling once, because they come up inside every later argument.

Example. (Degenerate Lists)

Let V be a vector space over F . Decide whether each list is independent.

- (a) A list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ with some $\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$.
- (b) A list $(\mathbf{v})$ of length one.
- (c) A list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ with a repeat: $\mathbf{v}_i = \mathbf{v}_j$ for some $i \neq j$.

Solution.

- (a) Dependent. Take $a_j = 1$ and every other coefficient 0. By [Theorem 1.1.5](#) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#), every term is $\mathbf{0}$, so the combination is $\mathbf{0}$, and the coefficient $a_j = 1$ is not zero.
- (b) Independent if and only if $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$. If $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, use (a). If $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$, let $a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$; by [Theorem 1.1.9](#), $a = 0$ or $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, and the second is false, so $a = 0$.
- (c) Dependent. Take $a_i = 1$, $a_j = -1$, and every other coefficient 0. The combination is $\mathbf{v}_i + (-1)\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{v}_i - \mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.7](#), since $\mathbf{v}_i = \mathbf{v}_j$, and $a_i = 1 \neq 0$.

Now the non-example, by a minimal change. Add one vector to the independent list $((1, 0), (0, 1))$ of [Example \(Independent Lists in Four Families\)](#) (a), to get $((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1))$. Each vector is still non-zero, and any two of the three still form an independent list. But

$$1(1, 0) + 1(0, 1) + (-1)(1, 1) = (0, 0)$$

with coefficients not all zero, so the clause “ $\implies a_1 = \dots = a_k = 0$ ” fails, and the list is **dependent**. The polynomial version behaves the same way: $(1, x)$ is independent, but $(1, x, 1 + x)$ is dependent, because $1 \cdot 1 + 1 \cdot x + (-1)(1 + x) = 0$.

Quick check. Is the list $((1, 2, 0), (0, 1, 1), (1, 0, -2))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ linearly independent?

Solution. No. Let $a(1, 2, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) + c(1, 0, -2) = \mathbf{0}$. Comparing entries: $a + c = 0$, $2a + b = 0$, $b - 2c = 0$. The first two give $c = -a$ and $b = -2a$, and then the third reads $-2a + 2a = 0$, which holds for every a . Taking $a = 1$ gives the relation $(1, 2, 0) - 2(0, 1, 1) - (1, 0, -2) = \mathbf{0}$, with coefficients not all zero.

Two more kinds of question come up constantly: lists that depend on a parameter, and lists of matrices. The method does not change.

Example. (A Parameter and a List of Matrices)

- (a) For which $k \in \mathbb{R}$ is the list $((1, 1, 0), (1, 0, 1), (0, 1, k))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ linearly independent?
- (b) Is the list $\left(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \right)$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ linearly independent?

Solution.

- (a) Let $a(1, 1, 0) + b(1, 0, 1) + c(0, 1, k) = \mathbf{0}$. Comparing entries gives $a + b = 0$, $a + c = 0$ and $b + kc = 0$. The first two give $b = -a$ and $c = -a$; substituting into the third, $-a - ka = -(1 + k)a = 0$. If $k \neq -1$, then $1 + k \neq 0$, so $a = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#), and then $b = c = 0$. The

list is independent.

If $k = -1$, the equations hold for every a ; taking $a = 1$ gives $(1, 1, 0) - (1, 0, 1) - (0, 1, -1) = \mathbf{0}$ with coefficients not all zero. The list is dependent.

So the list is independent exactly when $k \neq -1$. Notice the shape of the argument: the parameter ends up as a factor multiplying one unknown, and the only question is when that factor can be zero.

- (b) Let $a \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + b \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} + c \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. The left side is $\begin{pmatrix} a & b+c \\ b & a \end{pmatrix}$. Two matrices are equal when their entries agree (Definition 0.9.1), so $a = 0$, $b + c = 0$ and $b = 0$; hence $c = 0$ too. The list is independent.

For matrices, “compare entries” turns one matrix equation into four scalar equations, one per entry.

1.4.3 Why lists, and why this definition

Remark. Why lists, not sets. In a set, repeats disappear: $\{\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{v}\} = \{\mathbf{v}\}$. If independence were defined for sets, the “list” $(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{v})$, which has the obvious relation $\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, would silently become the independent set $\{\mathbf{v}\}$ when $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$. The repeat can also be hidden: $x + 1$ and $1 + x$ look different on the page but are the same vector. A list keeps both entries and so records the dependence. The second reason is order. Coordinates with respect to a basis (next section) are read off in order, so $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ and $(\mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_1)$ must be different objects. The Linear Dependence Lemma below also refers to “the vectors before $\mathbf{v}_j$ ”, which needs an order. Reordering a list does not change whether it is independent, since a relation can be rearranged term by term.

For an arbitrary subset $S \subseteq V$, finite or infinite, we say S is **linearly independent** if **every** finite list of **distinct** vectors of S is linearly independent. The word “distinct” is essential: without it, the list $(\mathbf{s}, \mathbf{s})$ would make every non-empty set dependent. For a finite set $S = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k\}$ with the $\mathbf{v}_i$ distinct, this agrees with independence of the list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$: every list of distinct vectors of S is a reordered sub-list, and a sub-list of an independent list is independent (Exercise (B3: Sub-Lists)). Together with “ S spans V ” from the previous section, this is the language section 8 of this chapter uses for spaces with no finite spanning list.

Why “all $a_i = 0$ ”, and why is the empty list independent? Suppose we only asked that **some** a_i be 0. The list $((1, 0), (0, 1), (0, 2))$ has the redundant vector $(0, 2) = 2(0, 1)$. But in any relation $a(1, 0) + b(0, 1) + c(0, 2) = \mathbf{0}$, comparing first entries forces $a = 0$, so every relation has a zero coefficient, and the list would pass the weaker test. Only “all $a_i = 0$ ” rules out every non-trivial relation. The empty list is independent because it wastes nothing, and this convention makes the empty list a basis of the zero space in the next section, just as $\text{span}() = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ makes it a spanning list.

Warning. “Not all zero” is not “all non-zero”. A dependence relation needs **one** non-zero coefficient, not every coefficient non-zero. The list $((1, 0), (0, 1), (0, 2))$ is dependent, by $0(1, 0) + 2(0, 1) - (0, 2) = \mathbf{0}$. But no relation has all three coefficients non-zero: comparing first entries in $a(1, 0) + b(0, 1) + c(0, 2) = \mathbf{0}$ forces $a = 0$. Hunting for a relation with no zero coefficient would wrongly conclude that the list is independent.

Warning. Pairwise independence is not independence. Checking pairs is not enough. In the list $((1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1), (1, 1, 2))$ from the start of the section, every two of the three vectors form an independent list, but the three together are dependent, since

$(1, 0, 1) + (0, 1, 1) - (1, 1, 2) = \mathbf{0}$. For three or more vectors, independence is a condition on all of them at once.

1.4.4 The Linear Dependence Lemma

The definition says that a dependent list has a relation. It does not say which vector is redundant, and the discussion at the start of the section only found a redundant vector where the coefficient was non-zero. The next lemma makes a definite choice, and chooses it so that the redundant vector depends only on vectors **before** it in the list. This one-directional form is what later proofs need, because they build lists from left to right.

Theorem 1.4.1 — Linear Dependence Lemma

Let V be a vector space over F , and let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ be a linearly dependent list in V . Then:

- (1) there is an index $j \in \{1, \dots, k\}$ with $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$. For $j = 1$ this means $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{0}$, so if $\mathbf{v}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$, then $j \geq 2$;
- (2) for any such j , removing $\mathbf{v}_j$ does not change the span:

$$\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1}, \mathbf{v}_{j+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k).$$

Idea. Take a relation with coefficients not all zero. We want to solve for one vector in terms of the vectors before it, so we need a vector whose coefficient is non-zero and which comes **after** every other vector with a non-zero coefficient. That is the **largest** index j with $a_j \neq 0$. Everything after it has coefficient zero and drops out, and we divide by a_j . Part (2) is then [Theorem 1.3.5](#) read backwards.

Proof.

- (1) Since the list is dependent, there are $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$, not all zero, with $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. The set $\{i : a_i \neq 0\}$ is non-empty and finite, so it has a largest element; call it j . Then $a_j \neq 0$, and $a_i = 0$ for every $i > j$. By [Theorem 1.1.5](#) the terms with $i > j$ are $\mathbf{0}$, so

$$a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_{j-1}\mathbf{v}_{j-1} + a_j\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}.$$

Adding the negative of $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_{j-1}\mathbf{v}_{j-1}$ to both sides gives $a_j\mathbf{v}_j = -(a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_{j-1}\mathbf{v}_{j-1})$. Since $a_j \neq 0$ and F is a field, a_j has an inverse $a_j^{-1} \in F$ ([Definition 0.7.1](#)). Multiplying both sides by a_j^{-1} , and using $a_j^{-1}(a_j\mathbf{v}_j) = (a_j^{-1}a_j)\mathbf{v}_j = 1\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{v}_j$ on the left, and $-\mathbf{x} = (-1)\mathbf{x}$ ([Theorem 1.1.7](#)) with the distributive laws on the right, we get

$$\mathbf{v}_j = (-a_j^{-1}a_1)\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + (-a_j^{-1}a_{j-1})\mathbf{v}_{j-1}.$$

Hence $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$. When $j = 1$ the right side is the empty sum, so $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{0}$; therefore if $\mathbf{v}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$, then $j \geq 2$.

- (2) Let j be any index with $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$, and let $L = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1}, \mathbf{v}_{j+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$. Each of $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1}$ is an entry of L , so by monotonicity ([Proposition 1.3.4](#) (2))

$\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1}) \subseteq \text{span}(L)$, and hence $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(L)$. By [Theorem 1.3.5](#), inserting $\mathbf{v}_j$ back into L at position j does not change the span. That is, $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = \text{span}(L)$, as claimed. ■

The index j need not be unique, and the lemma does **not** say that every vector depends on earlier ones. A small example shows both.

Example. (The Lemma on a Concrete List)

In $\mathbb{R}^2$, let $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 1)$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = (1, -1)$, $\mathbf{v}_3 = (2, 0)$, $\mathbf{v}_4 = (0, 1)$. Find two different linear relations, and the index j that the proof of [Theorem 1.4.1](#) extracts from each. Which indices j satisfy $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$?

Solution. First relation: $\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2 - \mathbf{v}_3 = (1 + 1 - 2, 1 - 1 - 0) = (0, 0)$. The largest index with a non-zero coefficient is $j = 3$, and solving gives $\mathbf{v}_3 = \mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$.

Second relation: $\mathbf{v}_1 - \mathbf{v}_2 - 2\mathbf{v}_4 = (1 - 1 - 0, 1 + 1 - 2) = (0, 0)$. Here the largest index is $j = 4$, and $\mathbf{v}_4 = \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{v}_1 - \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{v}_2 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$.

So $j = 3$ and $j = 4$ both qualify, and by part (2) of the lemma either $\mathbf{v}_3$ or $\mathbf{v}_4$ can be removed without changing the span. On the other hand, $j = 2$ does not qualify: $\mathbf{v}_2 = (1, -1)$ is not a multiple of $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 1)$, because a multiple (c, c) has equal entries. And $j = 1$ does not occur since $\mathbf{v}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$. Removing $\mathbf{v}_3$ and then (by the lemma applied to $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_4)$, which is still dependent by the second relation) $\mathbf{v}_4$ leaves $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$, whose span is $\mathbb{R}^2$ by [Example \(Spanning Lists\)](#).

The lemma only locates vectors that depend on **earlier** ones. Here $\mathbf{v}_1$ and $\mathbf{v}_2$ could also be removed without changing the span, since $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{v}_3 - \mathbf{v}_2$ and $\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{v}_3 - \mathbf{v}_1$, but the lemma never points at them.

Read the other way round, part (1) is a test for independence that works left to right.

Remark. Independence, one vector at a time. A list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is linearly independent **if and only if** no $\mathbf{v}_j$ lies in $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$. The “if” direction is the contrapositive of part (1). For “only if”, suppose $\mathbf{v}_j = c_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + c_{j-1}\mathbf{v}_{j-1}$. Then $c_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + c_{j-1}\mathbf{v}_{j-1} + (-1)\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$, with zero coefficients on $\mathbf{v}_{j+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k$, is a relation whose coefficient -1 is non-zero. So the list is dependent. In words: a list is independent exactly when each vector reaches something new beyond the vectors before it. For instance $(1, x, x^2)$ passes: $1 \neq 0$, x is not a constant, and x^2 has degree too high to be in $\text{span}(1, x)$.

Combining the two parts of the lemma gives a clean statement about spans alone: a list is dependent exactly when it contains a vector that can be thrown away for free.

Theorem 1.4.2 — Span Preservation

Let V be a vector space and $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ a list in V with $k \geq 1$. Then the list is linearly

dependent **if and only if** there is an index j such that

$$\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1}, \mathbf{v}_{j+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k).$$

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) By [Theorem 1.4.1](#) (1) there is an index j with $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{j-1})$, and by part (2) removing that $\mathbf{v}_j$ does not change the span.

($\Leftarrow$) Let L be the list with $\mathbf{v}_j$ removed, and suppose $\text{span}(L) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$. By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) (2), $\mathbf{v}_j \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k) = \text{span}(L)$. So $\mathbf{v}_j = \sum_{i \neq j} c_i \mathbf{v}_i$ for some scalars c_i , and therefore $\sum_{i \neq j} c_i \mathbf{v}_i + (-1)\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$. The coefficient of $\mathbf{v}_j$ is $-1 \neq 0$, so the list is dependent. ■

So a spanning list that is dependent can always be shortened and still span. Repeating this until the list becomes independent is the idea behind the next section's proof that every finite spanning list contains a basis.

1.4.5 Unique representations

Independence was introduced to rule out waste. Its most useful consequence is about uniqueness. If a vector could be built from a list in two different ways, subtracting the two recipes would give a non-trivial way to build $\mathbf{0}$. So for an independent list, every vector in the span has exactly one recipe.

Theorem 1.4.3 — Independence and Uniqueness of Coefficients

Let V be a vector space over F and $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ a list in V . The following are equivalent:

- (a) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is linearly independent;
- (b) every $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ has **exactly one** representation as a linear combination: if $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = b_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + b_k\mathbf{v}_k$, then $a_i = b_i$ for every i .

Proof. (a $\Rightarrow$ b) Suppose the list is independent, and let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = b_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + b_k\mathbf{v}_k$. Subtracting the right side from both sides and using $a\mathbf{v} - b\mathbf{v} = (a - b)\mathbf{v}$ ([Theorem 1.1.8](#) and [Definition 1.1.1](#)) gives

$$(a_1 - b_1)\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + (a_k - b_k)\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}.$$

By independence, $a_i - b_i = 0$ for every i , that is, $a_i = b_i$.

(b $\Rightarrow$ a) Suppose (b) holds, and let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. By [Theorem 1.1.5](#), also $0\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + 0\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. These are two representations of $\mathbf{0} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, so by (b), $a_i = 0$ for every i . Hence the list is independent. ■

Every vector of a span has **at least** one representation, by definition of the span; independence is what makes it **at most** one. For a dependent list uniqueness fails: with the list

$((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1)),$

$$(1, 1) = 1(1, 0) + 1(0, 1) + 0(1, 1) = 0(1, 0) + 0(0, 1) + 1(1, 1).$$

In the next section, a list that is independent **and** spans is called a basis. By this theorem every vector then has a unique list of coefficients, its coordinates.

1.4.6 Polynomials of distinct degrees

For polynomials there is a test that needs no equations at all. The list $(x^2 + x, x - 3, 5)$ is independent, and the reason is visible: the degrees are 2, 1 and 0, and combining lower-degree polynomials can never produce a higher degree.

Theorem 1.4.4 — Polynomials of Distinct Degrees Are Independent

Let F be a field and let $p_1, \dots, p_k \in F[x]$ be **non-zero** polynomials whose degrees are **pairwise distinct**. Then the list $(p_1, \dots, p_k)$ is linearly independent.

Idea. Put the polynomials in order of increasing degree. If the list were dependent, the Linear Dependence Lemma would give a polynomial lying in the span of the ones before it. Those all have smaller degree, so their span consists of polynomials of smaller degree, and cannot contain it.

Proof. A linear relation among the p_i can be rearranged term by term, so reordering the list does not affect independence. Hence we may assume $\deg p_1 < \deg p_2 < \dots < \deg p_k$.

Suppose, for a contradiction, that the list is dependent. Since $p_1 \neq 0$, [Theorem 1.4.1](#) gives an index $j \geq 2$ with $p_j \in \text{span}(p_1, \dots, p_{j-1})$. Let $n = \deg p_{j-1}$, a natural number since $p_{j-1} \neq 0$. For every $i \leq j-1$ we have $\deg p_i \leq n$, so $p_1, \dots, p_{j-1}$ lie in $F[x]_{\leq n}$, which is a subspace of $F[x]$ by [Example \(Polynomials of Bounded Degree\)](#). By [Theorem 1.3.1 \(3\)](#), $\text{span}(p_1, \dots, p_{j-1}) \subseteq F[x]_{\leq n}$. Hence $\deg p_j \leq n = \deg p_{j-1}$, contradicting $\deg p_{j-1} < \deg p_j$. Therefore the list is linearly independent. ■

Both hypotheses matter. The zero polynomial must be excluded, because a list containing 0 is dependent ([Example \(Degenerate Lists\)](#)). And the converse fails: distinct degrees are sufficient, not necessary. The list $(x, x + 1)$ has equal degrees but is independent, since $ax + b(x + 1) = (a + b)x + b = 0$ forces $b = 0$ and then $a = 0$.

1.4.7 Independence depends on the field

The same set can be a vector space over two fields, and the answer to “independent?” can change with the field, because the field decides which coefficients are allowed.

Warning. Always ask: independent over which field? In $\mathbb{C}^2$, let $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, i)$ and $\mathbf{v}_2 = (i, -1)$. Over $\mathbb{C}$ the list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$ is **dependent**: $i\mathbf{v}_1 = (i, i^2) = (i, -1) = \mathbf{v}_2$, so $i\mathbf{v}_1 + (-1)\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{0}$ with coefficient $i \neq 0$. Over $\mathbb{R}$ (the same addition, but only real

scalars, as in [Exercise \(C2: The Span Depends on the Field\)](#) the list is **independent**: if $a\mathbf{v}_1 + b\mathbf{v}_2 = (a + bi, ai - b) = (0, 0)$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, then the first entry $a + bi = 0$ forces $a = b = 0$, since a complex number is zero only when its real and imaginary parts are. The relation over $\mathbb{C}$ used the coefficient i , which is not available over $\mathbb{R}$.

A second example of the same phenomenon: $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ is independent in $\mathbb{R}^2$ ([Example \(Independent Lists in Four Families\)](#) (c)), but in $\mathbb{F}_2^2$, where $-1 = 1$, it is the list $((1, 1), (1, 1))$ with a repeat, hence dependent. The proof over $\mathbb{R}$ divided by 2, which is 0 in $\mathbb{F}_2$.

1.4.8 Exercises

1.4.8.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define what it means for a list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ in a vector space over F to be linearly independent, and what it means for it to be linearly dependent.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “a list of vectors is linearly dependent if and only if one of its vectors is a scalar multiple of another.” Justify your answer.
- Is the empty list linearly independent? Is the list $(\mathbf{0})$?
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$ is linearly dependent, then $\mathbf{v}_3 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$.” Justify your answer.
- To prove that a list of functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is independent, what does “ $= 0$ ” mean, and what is a standard way to extract scalar equations?

Solution.

- It is independent if for all $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$, $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$ implies $a_1 = \dots = a_k = 0$. It is dependent if there are $a_1, \dots, a_k \in F$, not all zero, with $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$.
- False. The list $((1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1), (1, 1, 2))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ is dependent, since the third vector is the sum of the first two, but no vector is a multiple of another. (The “if” direction is true: $\mathbf{v}_i = c\mathbf{v}_j$ with $i \neq j$ gives the relation $\mathbf{v}_i - c\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$ with coefficient $1 \neq 0$.)
- The empty list is independent: there are no coefficients, so the condition holds vacuously. The list $(\mathbf{0})$ is dependent: $1 \cdot \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$ with coefficient $1 \neq 0$ ([Example \(Degenerate Lists\)](#)).
- False. Take $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 0)$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = (2, 0)$, $\mathbf{v}_3 = (0, 1)$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$. The list is dependent, since $2\mathbf{v}_1 - \mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{0}$. But every combination of $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2$ has second entry 0, so $\mathbf{v}_3 \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$. [Theorem 1.4.1](#) only promises **some** j ; here $j = 2$.
- It means the zero function: the combination takes the value 0 at **every** point. Evaluating at well-chosen points turns it into scalar equations for the coefficients.

1.4.8.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Independent or Not?

Determine which of the following lists are linearly independent. Justify your answer.

- (a) $((1, 0, 2), (0, 1, 1), (1, 1, 3))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
- (b) $((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1), (1, 0, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
- (c) $(x^2 + 1, x^2 - 1, x)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]$.
- (d) $\left(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}\right)$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$.
- (e) (f, g) in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$, where $f(t) = e^t$ and $g(t) = e^{2t}$.

Solution.

- (a) Dependent. Since $(1, 0, 2) + (0, 1, 1) = (1, 1, 3)$, we have $(1, 0, 2) + (0, 1, 1) - (1, 1, 3) = \mathbf{0}$, with coefficients not all zero.
- (b) Independent. Let $a(1, 1, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) + c(1, 0, 1) = \mathbf{0}$. Comparing entries: $a + c = 0$, $a + b = 0$, $b + c = 0$. The first two give $c = -a$ and $b = -a$; then the third gives $-2a = 0$, so $a = 0$, and hence $b = c = 0$.
- (c) Independent. Let $a(x^2 + 1) + b(x^2 - 1) + cx = 0$. The left side is $(a+b)x^2 + cx + (a-b)$. Comparing coefficients (Definition 0.8.1): $a + b = 0$, $c = 0$, $a - b = 0$. Adding the first and third gives $2a = 0$, so $a = 0$, and then $b = 0$.
- (d) Dependent. The first two matrices add up to the third, so $1 \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + 1 \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} + (-1) \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ is the zero matrix.
- (e) Independent. Let $af + bg = 0$, the zero function. Then $ae^t + be^{2t} = 0$ for every $t \in \mathbb{R}$. At $t = 0$: $a + b = 0$. At $t = \ln 2$: $2a + 4b = 0$, so $a + 2b = 0$. Subtracting the first equation gives $b = 0$, and then $a = 0$.

Exercise B2: A Parameter.

For which $t \in \mathbb{R}$ is the list $((1, t), (t, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$ linearly independent? Justify your answer.

Solution. Let $a(1, t) + b(t, 1) = (0, 0)$, that is, $a + tb = 0$ and $ta + b = 0$. The first equation gives $a = -tb$. Substituting into the second, $-t^2b + b = (1 - t^2)b = 0$.

If $t \neq \pm 1$, then $1 - t^2 \neq 0$, so $b = 0$ by Theorem 0.7.1, and then $a = -tb = 0$. The list is independent.

If $t = 1$, the list is $((1, 1), (1, 1))$, which has a repeat and is dependent. If $t = -1$, the list is $((1, -1), (-1, 1))$, and $1 \cdot (1, -1) + 1 \cdot (-1, 1) = (0, 0)$, so it is dependent.

Hence the list is linearly independent exactly when $t \neq 1$ and $t \neq -1$.

Exercise B3: Sub-Lists.

A **sub-list** of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is a list $(\mathbf{v}_{i_1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{i_m})$ with $1 \leq i_1 < i_2 < \dots < i_m \leq k$.

- (a) Prove that every sub-list of a linearly independent list is linearly independent.

- (b) Deduce that if some sub-list of a list is linearly dependent, then the whole list is linearly dependent.

Solution.

- (a) Let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ be independent, and let $b_1\mathbf{v}_{i_1} + \dots + b_m\mathbf{v}_{i_m} = \mathbf{0}$. Define $a_i = b_r$ if $i = i_r$ for some r (the indices i_r are distinct, so this is well defined), and $a_i = 0$ otherwise. By [Theorem 1.1.5](#) the extra terms are $\mathbf{0}$, so $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = b_1\mathbf{v}_{i_1} + \dots + b_m\mathbf{v}_{i_m} = \mathbf{0}$. By independence, every $a_i = 0$; in particular every $b_r = a_{i_r} = 0$. Hence the sub-list is independent.
- (b) This is the contrapositive of (a): if the whole list were independent, every sub-list would be independent by (a).

1.4.8.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Sums of Pairs, and the Field $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Let V be a vector space over F and $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w})$ a linearly independent list in V .

- (a) Suppose $F = \mathbb{R}$. Prove that $(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u})$ is linearly independent.
- (b) Suppose $F = \mathbb{F}_2$. Prove that $(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u})$ is linearly dependent, and give an example of an independent list $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w})$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$, so that the statement is not vacuous.
- (c) Which property of $\mathbb{R}$ did (a) use that $\mathbb{F}_2$ lacks? Deduce that (a) holds over every field in which $1 + 1 \neq 0$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $a(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + b(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) + c(\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$. Expanding and regrouping with the axioms of [Definition 1.1.1](#) gives $(a + c)\mathbf{u} + (a + b)\mathbf{v} + (b + c)\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$. By independence of $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w})$, $a + c = 0$, $a + b = 0$ and $b + c = 0$. The first two give $c = -a$ and $b = -a$, and then the third gives $-2a = 0$. Since $2 \neq 0$ in $\mathbb{R}$, $a = 0$, and hence $b = c = 0$. This proves independence.
- (b) Over $\mathbb{F}_2$,

$$1(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + 1(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) + 1(\mathbf{w} + \mathbf{u}) = (1+1)\mathbf{u} + (1+1)\mathbf{v} + (1+1)\mathbf{w} = 0\mathbf{u} + 0\mathbf{v} + 0\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0},$$

using $1 + 1 = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$ and [Theorem 1.1.5](#). The coefficients are $1 \neq 0$, so the list is dependent. For an example, $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_3)$ in $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ is independent by the argument of [Example \(Independent Lists in Four Families\)](#) (a), which works over any field.

- (c) Part (a) divided by $2 = 1 + 1$, that is, used $2 \neq 0$, to pass from $-2a = 0$ to $a = 0$. In $\mathbb{F}_2$, $2 = 0$. In any field with $1 + 1 \neq 0$, the element 2 has an inverse, and the proof of (a) goes through word for word.

Exercise C2: Adding a Vector outside the Span.

Let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ be a linearly independent list in V , and let $\mathbf{v} \in V$ with $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$. Prove that $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k, \mathbf{v})$ is linearly independent. Give an example showing that the hypothesis $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ cannot be dropped.

Solution. Let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k + a\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Suppose $a \neq 0$. Then, as in the proof of [Theorem 1.4.1](#), $\mathbf{v} = (-a^{-1}a_1)\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + (-a^{-1}a_k)\mathbf{v}_k \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, contradicting the hypothesis. Hence $a = 0$, and the relation becomes $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. By independence of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, $a_1 = \cdots = a_k = 0$. So all coefficients are zero, and the longer list is independent.

For the example, take $(\mathbf{e}_1)$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$ and $\mathbf{v} = 2\mathbf{e}_1 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$. The list $(\mathbf{e}_1)$ is independent, but $(\mathbf{e}_1, 2\mathbf{e}_1)$ is dependent, by $2\mathbf{e}_1 - 2\mathbf{e}_1 = \mathbf{0}$.

Exercise C3: $1, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Regard $\mathbb{R}$ as a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$. Prove that the list $(1, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3})$ is linearly independent over $\mathbb{Q}$. Is it linearly independent over $\mathbb{R}$?

Hint: you may use without proof that $\sqrt{3}$ and $\sqrt{6}$ are irrational (the proof of [Theorem 0.2.3](#) adapts). Isolate one square root and square.

Solution. Let $a + b\sqrt{2} + c\sqrt{3} = 0$ with $a, b, c \in \mathbb{Q}$. Then $a + b\sqrt{2} = -c\sqrt{3}$, and squaring both sides gives $a^2 + 2b^2 + 2ab\sqrt{2} = 3c^2$.

If $ab \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{2} = \frac{3c^2 - a^2 - 2b^2}{2ab} \in \mathbb{Q}$, contradicting [Theorem 0.2.3](#). Hence $ab = 0$, so $a = 0$ or $b = 0$.

Case 1: $b = 0$. Then $a + c\sqrt{3} = 0$. If $c \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{3} = -a/c \in \mathbb{Q}$, a contradiction. So $c = 0$, and then $a = 0$.

Case 2: $a = 0$. Then $b\sqrt{2} + c\sqrt{3} = 0$. Multiplying by $\sqrt{2}$ gives $2b + c\sqrt{6} = 0$. If $c \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{6} = -2b/c \in \mathbb{Q}$, a contradiction. So $c = 0$, then $b\sqrt{2} = 0$, and $b = 0$ since $\sqrt{2} \neq 0$.

In both cases $a = b = c = 0$, so the list is linearly independent over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Over $\mathbb{R}$ it is dependent: $\sqrt{2} \cdot 1 + (-1) \cdot \sqrt{2} + 0 \cdot \sqrt{3} = 0$, and the coefficient $\sqrt{2}$ is a non-zero real number. Over $\mathbb{R}$ any two non-zero real numbers form a dependent list.

1.5 Bases and Coordinates

Spanning lists and independent lists each solve half of a problem. A spanning list reaches every vector of the space, but it may reach some vectors in more than one way. An independent list never wastes a vector, but it may not reach everything. This section puts the two halves together. The result, a basis, turns an abstract vector space into columns of numbers, and we prove that every space spanned by a finite list has one.

1.5.1 What makes coordinates work

Start with the plane. Every vector of $\mathbb{R}^2$ can be written as

$$(x, y) = x\mathbf{e}_1 + y\mathbf{e}_2,$$

and the pair (x, y) is its address. Two separate facts make this addressing system work. First, **every** vector has an address: the list $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ spans $\mathbb{R}^2$. Second, every vector has **only one** address: if $x\mathbf{e}_1 + y\mathbf{e}_2 = x'\mathbf{e}_1 + y'\mathbf{e}_2$, then $(x, y) = (x', y')$, so $x = x'$ and $y = y'$.

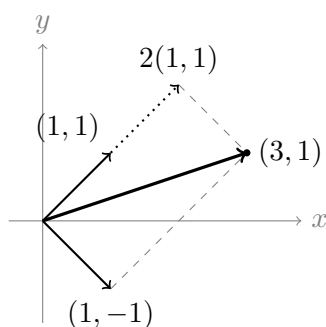
Nothing about this is special to $\mathbf{e}_1$ and $\mathbf{e}_2$. Take instead the list $((1, 1), (1, -1))$. To find an address for (x, y) we solve

$$a(1, 1) + b(1, -1) = (x, y), \quad \text{that is,} \quad a + b = x, \quad a - b = y.$$

Adding and subtracting the two equations gives $2a = x + y$ and $2b = x - y$. So there is a solution, and it is the only one:

$$a = \frac{x + y}{2}, \quad b = \frac{x - y}{2}.$$

For example $(3, 1) = 2(1, 1) + 1(1, -1)$, and no other pair of scalars works. The grid is slanted, but every point still has exactly one address.



Look at which property did which job. **Existence** of an address is spanning. **Uniqueness** of the address is independence: by [Theorem 1.4.3](#), a list is independent exactly when every vector in its span has only one expression as a combination of it. A coordinate system is a list that does both jobs at once.

A basis is a list with enough vectors to build everything and no vector to spare.

1.5.2 Bases

Definition 1.5.1 — Basis

Let V be a vector space over F . A **basis** of V is a **list** $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ of vectors in V such that

- (B1) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is **linearly independent**, and
- (B2) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ **spans** V , that is, $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n) = V$.

We usually name a basis with a calligraphic letter, $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$, and call n its **length**. The plural of basis is **bases**.

In words: (B1) says that the only combination of the $\mathbf{v}_i$ equal to $\mathbf{0}$ is the one with **all** coefficients zero, so no vector in the list is wasted. (B2) says that **every** vector of V is some combination of the $\mathbf{v}_i$, so nothing is out of reach. The basis is a list, so its entries come in a definite order, and a basis is always a basis **of** a particular space: $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$, but not of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

We start with the bases that come with the running examples.

Example. (Standard Bases)

Show that each of the following lists is a basis. They are called the **standard bases**.

- (a) $(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n)$ in F^n , where $\mathbf{e}_i$ has 1 in position i and 0 elsewhere.
- (b) $(1, x, x^2, \dots, x^n)$ in $F[x]_{\leq n}$.
- (c) $(E_{11}, E_{12}, \dots, E_{1n}, E_{21}, \dots, E_{mn})$ in $M_{m \times n}(F)$, where the **matrix unit** E_{ij} has 1 in entry (i, j) and 0 elsewhere, listed row by row.

Solution.

- (a) (B2): every $(x_1, \dots, x_n) \in F^n$ equals $x_1\mathbf{e}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{e}_n$. (B1): let $a_1\mathbf{e}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{e}_n = \mathbf{0}$. The left side is the column $(a_1, \dots, a_n)$, so comparing entries gives $a_1 = \dots = a_n = 0$.
- (b) (B2): by [Definition 0.8.4](#), every element of $F[x]_{\leq n}$ has the form $a_0 + a_1x + \dots + a_nx^n$, which is a combination of $1, x, \dots, x^n$. (B1): let $a_0 \cdot 1 + a_1x + \dots + a_nx^n = 0$. Here 0 is the zero polynomial, all of whose coefficients are 0. Two polynomials are equal exactly when their coefficients agree ([Definition 0.8.1](#)), so $a_0 = a_1 = \dots = a_n = 0$.
- (c) (B2): a matrix $A = (a_{ij})$ equals $\sum_{i,j} a_{ij}E_{ij}$, since both sides have a_{ij} in entry (i, j) . (B1): if $\sum_{i,j} c_{ij}E_{ij}$ is the zero matrix, then its (i, j) entry c_{ij} is 0 for every i, j .

The next examples show that a space has other bases, that the field matters, and what happens in the smallest space.

Example. (Three More Bases)

Show that each list is a basis.

- (a) $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$.
- (b) $(1, i)$ in $\mathbb{C}$, regarded as a vector space **over** $\mathbb{R}$.
- (c) The empty list $()$ in the zero space $\{\mathbf{0}\}$.

Solution.

- (a) We showed above that for every $(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ the equation $a(1, 1) + b(1, -1) = (x, y)$ has a solution, so (B2) holds. Taking $(x, y) = (0, 0)$, the only solution is $a = \frac{0+0}{2} = 0$ and $b = 0$, so (B1) holds.
- (b) The scalars are now real. (B2): every complex number is $a + bi = a \cdot 1 + b \cdot i$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ ([Definition 0.6.1](#)). (B1): let $a \cdot 1 + b \cdot i = 0$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. A complex number is 0 exactly when its real and imaginary parts are 0, so $a = b = 0$.
- (c) The empty list is linearly independent: there are no coefficients, so the condition “all coefficients are zero” holds vacuously. Its span is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ by the convention for the empty span. So both (B1) and (B2) hold.

The degenerate case (c) matters more than it looks. Without it, the zero space would be the one space with no basis, and every theorem below would need an exception for it.

Non-examples by minimal change. Add one vector to the standard basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$, making $((1,0), (0,1), (1,1))$. Spanning (B2) still holds, since the first two vectors already span. But (B1) fails:

$$1 \cdot (1,0) + 1 \cdot (0,1) + (-1) \cdot (1,1) = (0,0),$$

with coefficients **not all zero**. The effect is exactly the loss of unique addresses: $(3,1) = 3(1,0) + 1(0,1) + 0(1,1) = 2(1,0) + 0(0,1) + 1(1,1)$.

Now remove a vector instead. In $\mathbb{R}^3$, the list $((1,0,0), (0,1,0))$ is still independent, since $a(1,0,0) + b(0,1,0) = (a,b,0) = \mathbf{0}$ forces $a = b = 0$. But (B2) fails: every combination $(a,b,0)$ has third entry 0, so $(0,0,1)$ is out of reach.

Quick check. Is $((1,2), (2,1), (0,0))$ a basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$? If not, which of (B1) and (B2) fails?

Solution. No. (B2) holds: $(1,2)$ and $(2,1)$ already span $\mathbb{R}^2$, because solving $a(1,2) + b(2,1) = (x,y)$ gives $a = \frac{2y-x}{3}$ and $b = \frac{2x-y}{3}$. But (B1) fails, because the list contains the zero vector: $0(1,2) + 0(2,1) + 1(0,0) = (0,0)$ with a non-zero coefficient.

Why this definition. Drop (B1), and addresses stop being unique, as the list $((1,0), (0,1), (1,1))$ showed. Drop (B2), and some vectors have no address at all. Keeping both is exactly what an addressing system needs. The name comes from the everyday word: the basis is what everything else is built on.

Remark. Why a list and not a set? Two reasons. Coordinates, defined below, are a column of numbers, and a column needs to know which scalar comes first. And a set would hide repeats: the list $((1,0), (1,0), (0,1))$ is dependent, since $1(1,0) - 1(1,0) = \mathbf{0}$, but as a set $\{(1,0), (1,0), (0,1)\} = \{(1,0), (0,1)\}$ it would look like the standard basis.

Warning. Say **a** basis, not **the** basis. A space usually has many bases; a non-zero space over an infinite field such as $\mathbb{R}$ has infinitely many. For instance $((1,0), (c,1))$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$ for **every** real number c , since $(x,y) = (x-cy)(1,0) + y(c,1)$, and this is the only solution. The standard basis is a convenient choice, not a canonical one.

1.5.3 Unique representation and coordinates

We found the definition by asking for addresses that exist and are unique. The first result confirms that this is exactly what a basis delivers, and nothing more.

Theorem 1.5.1 — Unique Representation

Let V be a vector space over F , and let $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a list in V . Then $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis of V if and only if every $\mathbf{v} \in V$ can be written as

$$\mathbf{v} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n \quad (a_1, \dots, a_n \in F)$$

in **exactly one** way.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Since $\mathcal{B}$ spans V , there are scalars with $\mathbf{v} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n$. Suppose also $\mathbf{v} = b_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + b_n\mathbf{v}_n$. Subtracting the two expressions and regrouping

with the vector space axioms,

$$(a_1 - b_1)\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + (a_n - b_n)\mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}.$$

Since $\mathcal{B}$ is linearly independent, $a_i - b_i = 0$ for every i . Hence the two expressions are the same.

($\Leftarrow$) Every $\mathbf{v} \in V$ is a combination of $\mathcal{B}$, so $\mathcal{B}$ spans V . For independence, let $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{0}$. We also have $\mathbf{0} = 0\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + 0\mathbf{v}_n$. By uniqueness of the expression for the vector $\mathbf{0}$, all $a_i = 0$. Hence $\mathcal{B}$ is linearly independent, and $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis. ■

This is [Theorem 1.4.3](#) in the special case where the span is the whole space. The theorem also gives a second way to check that a list is a basis: solve for the coefficients of a general vector, and see that there is always exactly one solution. We did exactly that for $((1, 1), (1, -1))$.

Whenever something exists and is unique, it deserves a name.

Definition 1.5.2 — Coordinates

Let $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a basis of a vector space V over F , and let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. The unique scalars $a_1, \dots, a_n$ with $\mathbf{v} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n$ are the **coordinates** of $\mathbf{v}$ with respect to $\mathcal{B}$. The column

$$[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} := \begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ \vdots \\ a_n \end{pmatrix} \in F^n$$

is the **coordinate vector** of $\mathbf{v}$ with respect to $\mathcal{B}$.

In the standard basis of F^n , the coordinate vector of $(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ is the column $(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ itself. That is why we rarely notice coordinates in F^n . In other bases and other spaces they carry real information.

Example. (Coordinates of a Polynomial)

Show that $\mathcal{B} = (1, 1+x, 1+x+x^2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$, and find $[p]_{\mathcal{B}}$ for $p = 3 - x + 2x^2$.

Solution. We use [Theorem 1.5.1](#). Let $q = q_0 + q_1x + q_2x^2 \in \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ be arbitrary. For scalars a, b, c ,

$$a \cdot 1 + b(1+x) + c(1+x+x^2) = (a+b+c) + (b+c)x + cx^2.$$

Two polynomials are equal exactly when their coefficients agree, so this equals q if and only if

$$c = q_2, \quad b+c = q_1, \quad a+b+c = q_0.$$

Solving from the top, $c = q_2$, then $b = q_1 - q_2$, then $a = q_0 - q_1$. So every q has exactly one expression, and $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$.

For $p = 3 - x + 2x^2$ we have $q_0 = 3$, $q_1 = -1$, $q_2 = 2$. Hence $c = 2$, $b = -1 - 2 = -3$,

and $a = 3 - (-1) = 4$:

$$[p]_{\mathcal{B}} = \begin{pmatrix} 4 \\ -3 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Check: $4 - 3(1 + x) + 2(1 + x + x^2) = (4 - 3 + 2) + (-3 + 2)x + 2x^2 = 3 - x + 2x^2$. In the standard basis $(1, x, x^2)$, the same polynomial has coordinate vector $(3, -1, 2)$.

Warning. Coordinates depend on the basis **and on its order**. Take $\mathbf{v} = (3, 1) \in \mathbb{R}^2$. With respect to the standard basis $\mathcal{E} = (\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$, $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{E}} = (3, 1)$. With respect to $\mathcal{B} = ((1, 1), (1, -1))$, $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (2, 1)$. With respect to $\mathcal{B}' = ((1, -1), (1, 1))$, the same two vectors in the other order, $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}'} = (1, 2)$. A column of numbers means nothing until you say which ordered basis it refers to.

The point of coordinates is that they turn computations in V into computations with columns. That works because they respect the two operations.

Theorem 1.5.2 — Coordinates Respect the Operations

Let $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a basis of a vector space V over F . Then for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$ and $c \in F$,

$$[\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = [\mathbf{u}]_{\mathcal{B}} + [\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}, \quad [c\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = c[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}.$$

Moreover, every column $(a_1, \dots, a_n) \in F^n$ is the coordinate vector of exactly one vector of V , namely $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n$.

Proof. Let $[\mathbf{u}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (a_1, \dots, a_n)$ and $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (b_1, \dots, b_n)$. By the vector space axioms,

$$\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} = \sum_{i=1}^n a_i \mathbf{v}_i + \sum_{i=1}^n b_i \mathbf{v}_i = \sum_{i=1}^n (a_i + b_i) \mathbf{v}_i, \quad c\mathbf{v} = c \sum_{i=1}^n b_i \mathbf{v}_i = \sum_{i=1}^n (cb_i) \mathbf{v}_i.$$

By Theorem 1.5.1 these are the only expressions of $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}$ and $c\mathbf{v}$ in $\mathcal{B}$, so their coefficients are the coordinates: $[\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (a_i + b_i)_i$ and $[c\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (cb_i)_i$, as claimed.

For the last statement, let $(a_1, \dots, a_n) \in F^n$ and $\mathbf{w} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n$. By Definition 1.5.2, $[\mathbf{w}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (a_1, \dots, a_n)$. If also $[\mathbf{w}']_{\mathcal{B}} = (a_1, \dots, a_n)$, then by definition $\mathbf{w}' = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{w}$. ■

So a basis of length n sets up a one-to-one correspondence $\mathbf{v} \mapsto [\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ between V and F^n that respects addition and scaling. Any question about sums and multiples in V can be answered in F^n instead. In Chapter 3 we will call such a correspondence an **isomorphism**.

1.5.4 Every finite spanning list contains a basis

Where do bases come from? A finite-dimensional space is, by Definition 1.3.4, a space spanned by some finite list. That list reaches everything but may contain waste, so the natural plan is to throw the waste away.

Care is needed about **what** to throw away. In $((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1))$ each vector is a combination of the other two. Any single one can go, but not two of them. So redundancy is not a property of one vector alone: it depends on which other vectors stay. The fix is to decide one vector at a time, reading from left to right, and to compare each vector only with the vectors already kept.

First, a small lemma that tells us when a kept list stays independent.

Lemma 1.5.3 — Appending a Vector to an Independent List

Let $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ be a linearly independent list in a vector space V , and let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Then $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, \mathbf{v})$ is linearly independent **if and only if** $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$.

Proof. $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$, say $\mathbf{v} = c_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + c_k\mathbf{u}_k$. Then $c_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + c_k\mathbf{u}_k + (-1)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, with the coefficient $-1 \neq 0$. So the longer list is dependent. This proves $(\Rightarrow)$ by contraposition.

$(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$, and let $a_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{u}_k + b\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. If $b \neq 0$, then b^{-1} exists and

$$\mathbf{v} = -b^{-1}a_1\mathbf{u}_1 - \dots - b^{-1}a_k\mathbf{u}_k \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k),$$

a contradiction. Hence $b = 0$. Then $a_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + a_k\mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$, and the independence of $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ gives $a_1 = \dots = a_k = 0$. So all coefficients are zero, and the longer list is independent. ■

The direction $(\Leftarrow)$ is [Exercise \(C2: Adding a Vector outside the Span\)](#). When $k = 0$, the lemma says that the one-vector list $(\mathbf{v})$ is independent exactly when $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}() = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, that is, when $\mathbf{v} \neq \mathbf{0}$, in agreement with [Example \(Degenerate Lists\)](#).

Now the procedure. Given a list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m)$ in V , **sifting** it means the following.

Start with the empty list $S_0 = ()$. For $r = 1, 2, \dots, m$ in turn:

- if $\mathbf{v}_r \notin \text{span}(S_{r-1})$, **keep** it: $S_r = (S_{r-1}, \mathbf{v}_r)$;
- if $\mathbf{v}_r \in \text{span}(S_{r-1})$, **discard** it: $S_r = S_{r-1}$.

The final list S_m is the **sifted list** of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m)$.

Here $(S_{r-1}, \mathbf{v}_r)$ means the list S_{r-1} with $\mathbf{v}_r$ appended at the end. Each S_r is a **sub-list** of $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m)$: it is obtained by deleting some entries and keeping the rest in their original order.

Theorem 1.5.4 — Sifting Theorem

Let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m)$ be a list in a vector space V , and let S_m be its sifted list. Then S_m is linearly independent and

$$\text{span}(S_m) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m).$$

In particular, every finite list that spans V contains a sub-list that is a basis of V .

Idea. Sifting protects two things at every step. A vector is kept only when it lies outside the span of what was kept before, so by [Lemma 1.5.3](#) the kept list stays independent. A vector is discarded only when it is already in that span, so by [Theorem 1.3.5](#) discarding it loses nothing. We turn “at every step” into an induction on r , the number of vectors read so far, with the invariant: S_r is independent and has the same span as $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r$.

Proof. We prove by induction on $r \in \{0, 1, \dots, m\}$ the statement

$$P(r): \text{ the list } S_r \text{ is linearly independent and } \text{span}(S_r) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r).$$

Base case. S_0 is the empty list, which is linearly independent, and both sides of the span equation are the span of the empty list. So $P(0)$ holds.

Inductive step. Let $1 \leq r \leq m$ and suppose $P(r-1)$ holds. Put $W = \text{span}(S_{r-1})$, so that $W = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{r-1})$ by $P(r-1)$.

Case 1: $\mathbf{v}_r \in W$. Then $S_r = S_{r-1}$, which is independent. Since $\mathbf{v}_r \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{r-1})$, [Theorem 1.3.5](#) gives $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r) = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{r-1}) = W = \text{span}(S_r)$.

Case 2: $\mathbf{v}_r \notin W$. Then $S_r = (S_{r-1}, \mathbf{v}_r)$. Since S_{r-1} is independent and $\mathbf{v}_r \notin \text{span}(S_{r-1})$, [Lemma 1.5.3](#) shows that S_r is independent. For the spans, recall from [Theorem 1.3.1](#) that the span of a list is a subspace, and is contained in every subspace containing the entries of the list. Every entry of S_r is one of $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r$, so $\text{span}(S_r) \subseteq \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r)$. Conversely, $\text{span}(S_r)$ is a subspace containing the entries of S_{r-1} , so it contains W , and with it $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_{r-1}$; it also contains $\mathbf{v}_r$. Hence $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r) \subseteq \text{span}(S_r)$.

In both cases $P(r)$ holds. By induction $P(m)$ holds, which is the first statement.

Finally, suppose $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m)$ spans V . Then S_m is a sub-list of it that is independent and satisfies $\text{span}(S_m) = V$. So S_m is a basis of V . ■

Alternatively, one can delete instead of keep. As long as the list is dependent, the Linear Dependence Lemma ([Theorem 1.4.1](#)) locates an entry lying in the span of the entries before it, and deleting that entry does not change the span. Each deletion shortens the list, so the process stops after at most m steps. Sifting performs the same idea in a single left-to-right pass.

The decision “is $\mathbf{v}_r$ in the span of the kept vectors?” is a small system of equations. For now we solve these systems by hand; Chapter 2 gives a systematic method.

Example. (Sifting a List in $\mathbb{R}^3$)

Sift the list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_6)$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$, where

$$\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 1, 1), \quad \mathbf{v}_2 = (2, 2, 2), \quad \mathbf{v}_3 = (1, 0, 0), \quad \mathbf{v}_4 = (3, 2, 2), \quad \mathbf{v}_5 = (1, 1, 0), \quad \mathbf{v}_6 = (0, 0, 1).$$

Hence find a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$ inside the list.

Solution. We go through the list once, comparing each vector with the vectors kept so far.

- $\mathbf{v}_1$: the kept list is empty, with span $\{\mathbf{0}\}$. Since $\mathbf{v}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$, **keep** $\mathbf{v}_1$.
- $\mathbf{v}_2$: $\mathbf{v}_2 = 2\mathbf{v}_1 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1)$. **Discard**.
- $\mathbf{v}_3$: if $(1, 0, 0) = a(1, 1, 1) = (a, a, a)$, the first entry gives $a = 1$ and the second gives $a = 0$, a contradiction. So $\mathbf{v}_3 \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1)$. **Keep**.
- $\mathbf{v}_4$: $2\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_3 = (2, 2, 2) + (1, 0, 0) = (3, 2, 2) = \mathbf{v}_4$, so $\mathbf{v}_4 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_3)$. **Discard**.
- $\mathbf{v}_5$: suppose $(1, 1, 0) = a(1, 1, 1) + b(1, 0, 0) = (a + b, a, a)$. The second entry gives $a = 1$ and the third gives $a = 0$, a contradiction. So $\mathbf{v}_5 \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_3)$. **Keep**.
- $\mathbf{v}_6$: $\mathbf{v}_1 - \mathbf{v}_5 = (1, 1, 1) - (1, 1, 0) = (0, 0, 1) = \mathbf{v}_6$, so $\mathbf{v}_6 \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_3, \mathbf{v}_5)$. **Discard**.

The sifted list is $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_3, \mathbf{v}_5) = ((1, 1, 1), (1, 0, 0), (1, 1, 0))$. By [Theorem 1.5.4](#) it is independent and has the same span as the original list. That span is all of $\mathbb{R}^3$, since it contains $\mathbf{e}_1 = \mathbf{v}_3$, $\mathbf{e}_2 = \mathbf{v}_5 - \mathbf{v}_3$ and $\mathbf{e}_3 = \mathbf{v}_6$, and hence every combination of them. So $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_3, \mathbf{v}_5)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Sifting has no memory of the future, so its output depends on the order of the input.

Example. (The Order Matters)

Sift $((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1))$ and $((1, 1), (1, 0), (0, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$.

Solution. For the first list: $(1, 0) \neq \mathbf{0}$, so keep it. Every multiple of $(1, 0)$ has second entry 0, so $(0, 1) \notin \text{span}((1, 0))$; keep it. Then $(1, 1) = (1, 0) + (0, 1)$; discard it. The result is $((1, 0), (0, 1))$.

For the second list: $(1, 1) \neq \mathbf{0}$, so keep it. If $(1, 0) = a(1, 1) = (a, a)$, then $a = 1$ and $a = 0$, which is impossible; keep $(1, 0)$. Then $(0, 1) = (1, 1) - (1, 0)$; discard it. The result is $((1, 1), (1, 0))$.

Both results are bases of $\mathbb{R}^2$ (the lists span $\mathbb{R}^2$ because they contain $\mathbf{e}_1$ and $\mathbf{e}_2$), but they are different bases. A zero vector, by contrast, is discarded wherever it stands, because $\mathbf{0}$ lies in every span.

Quick check. Sift the list $(x, 2x, 1 + x, 1)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 1}$. Which vectors are kept?

Solution. Keep x , since $x \neq 0$. Discard $2x = 2 \cdot x$. Keep $1 + x$: every multiple ax has constant term 0, but $1 + x$ has constant term 1. Discard $1 = (1 + x) - x$. The sifted list is $(x, 1 + x)$.

The theorem answers the question we started with.

Corollary 1.5.5 — Existence of Bases

Every finite-dimensional vector space has a basis.

Proof. Let V be finite-dimensional. By [Definition 1.3.4](#), V is spanned by some finite list. By [Theorem 1.5.4](#), that list contains a sub-list that is a basis of V . ■

For $V = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ the proof still works: $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ is spanned by the empty list, and sifting it returns the

empty list, which is the basis found in [Example \(Three More Bases\)](#).

We now know that bases exist, and we can find one inside any finite spanning list. But a space has many bases. The next section proves the fact that makes them measurable: all bases of the same space have the same length.

1.5.5 Exercises

1.5.5.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define what it means for a list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ to be a basis of a vector space V over F .
- (b) True or false: every list that spans $\mathbb{R}^2$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$. Justify your answer.
- (c) True or false: $((1, 0), (0, 1))$ and $((0, 1), (1, 0))$ are the same basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$. Justify your answer.
- (d) What is a basis of the zero space $\{\mathbf{0}\}$?
- (e) When sifting a list, under what condition is the vector $\mathbf{v}_r$ discarded?
- (f) True or false: if $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis of V and $[\mathbf{u}]_{\mathcal{B}} = [\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$, then $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{v}$. Justify your answer.

Solution.

- (a) See [Definition 1.5.1](#): the list is linearly independent and spans V .
- (b) False. $((1, 0), (0, 1), (1, 1))$ spans $\mathbb{R}^2$, but it is dependent, since $(1, 0) + (0, 1) - (1, 1) = \mathbf{0}$.
- (c) False. A basis is a list, and the two lists have their entries in different orders. The difference is visible in coordinates: $(3, 1)$ has coordinate vector $(3, 1)$ in the first basis and $(1, 3)$ in the second.
- (d) The empty list $()$, by [Example \(Three More Bases\)](#) (c).
- (e) When $\mathbf{v}_r$ lies in the span of the vectors kept before it, that is, $\mathbf{v}_r \in \text{span}(S_{r-1})$.
- (f) True. If both coordinate vectors equal $(a_1, \dots, a_n)$, then $\mathbf{u} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{v}$ by [Definition 1.5.2](#), where $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$.

1.5.5.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: A Basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$ and Coordinates.

Let $\mathcal{B} = ((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1), (1, 0, 1))$. Show that $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$. Hence find $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ for $\mathbf{v} = (2, 3, 5)$.

Solution. Let $(p, q, r) \in \mathbb{R}^3$. For scalars a, b, c ,

$$a(1, 1, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) + c(1, 0, 1) = (a + c, a + b, b + c),$$

so this equals (p, q, r) if and only if $a + c = p$, $a + b = q$ and $b + c = r$. Adding the three

equations gives $2(a + b + c) = p + q + r$, so $a + b + c = \frac{p+q+r}{2}$. Subtracting each equation from this one,

$$b = \frac{-p + q + r}{2}, \quad c = \frac{p - q + r}{2}, \quad a = \frac{p + q - r}{2}.$$

Conversely, these values satisfy the three equations: for instance $a + c = \frac{2p}{2} = p$, and the other two are checked the same way. So every vector of $\mathbb{R}^3$ has exactly one expression in $\mathcal{B}$, and $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis by [Theorem 1.5.1](#).

For $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$: $a = \frac{2+3-5}{2} = 0$, $b = \frac{-2+3+5}{2} = 3$, $c = \frac{2-3+5}{2} = 2$. Check: $0(1, 1, 0) + 3(0, 1, 1) + 2(1, 0, 1) = (2, 3, 5)$. Hence $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (0, 3, 2)$.

Exercise B2: Sifting Polynomials.

Sift the list $(1 + x, 2 + 2x, x^2, 1 + x + x^2, x, 1)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$, justifying each decision. Hence find a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ contained in the list.

Solution. We read the list from left to right, comparing coefficients.

- $1 + x \neq 0$: **keep**.
- $2 + 2x = 2(1 + x)$: **discard**.
- x^2 : every multiple $a(1 + x)$ has x^2 -coefficient 0, while x^2 has x^2 -coefficient 1. So $x^2 \notin \text{span}(1 + x)$: **keep**.
- $1 + x + x^2 = (1 + x) + x^2$: **discard**.
- x : suppose $x = a(1 + x) + bx^2 = a + ax + bx^2$. The constant terms give $a = 0$ and the x -coefficients give $a = 1$, a contradiction. So $x \notin \text{span}(1 + x, x^2)$: **keep**.
- $1 = (1 + x) - x$: **discard**.

The sifted list is $(1 + x, x^2, x)$. The original list contains $1, x$ and x^2 , so its span contains every combination of them, which is all of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ by [Example \(Standard Bases\)](#). Hence the list spans $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$, and by [Theorem 1.5.4](#) the sifted list $(1 + x, x^2, x)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$.

Exercise B3: Symmetric Matrices.

Let $U = \{A \in M_2(\mathbb{R}) : A^T = A\}$. Show that $(E_{11}, E_{12} + E_{21}, E_{22})$ is a basis of U , and find the coordinate vector of $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ -1 & 5 \end{pmatrix}$ with respect to it.

Solution. Each of the three matrices is symmetric, so the list lies in U .

Spanning. Let $A \in U$. Writing $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}$, the condition $A^T = A$ says $c = b$. Hence

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & d \end{pmatrix} = aE_{11} + b(E_{12} + E_{21}) + dE_{22}.$$

Independence. Let $aE_{11} + b(E_{12} + E_{21}) + dE_{22} = 0$. The left side is $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & d \end{pmatrix}$, so comparing entries with the zero matrix gives $a = b = d = 0$.

Hence the list is a basis of U . Reading off $a = 2$, $b = -1$, $d = 5$, the coordinate vector is $(2, -1, 5)$.

1.5.5.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Polynomials Vanishing at 1.

Let F be a field, $n \geq 1$, and $U = \{p \in F[x]_{\leq n} : p(1) = 0\}$.

- (a) Prove that $(x - 1, x^2 - 1, \dots, x^n - 1)$ is a basis of U .
- (b) For $n = 3$, find the coordinate vector of $x^3 - 2x + 1$ with respect to this basis.

Hint: for $p = a_0 + a_1x + \dots + a_nx^n$, what does $p(1) = 0$ say about a_0 ?

Solution.

- (a) For $p = a_0 + a_1x + \dots + a_nx^n$, evaluation gives $p(1) = a_0 + a_1 + \dots + a_n$, since every power of 1 is 1. In particular each $x^k - 1$ lies in U , because $1 - 1 = 0$.
Spanning. Let $p \in U$. Then $a_0 = -(a_1 + \dots + a_n)$, so

$$p = a_1x + \dots + a_nx^n - (a_1 + \dots + a_n) = a_1(x - 1) + a_2(x^2 - 1) + \dots + a_n(x^n - 1).$$

Independence. Let $c_1(x - 1) + \dots + c_n(x^n - 1) = 0$. For $1 \leq k \leq n$, the coefficient of x^k on the left is c_k , since x^k appears in no other term. The zero polynomial has all coefficients 0, so $c_k = 0$ for every k .

Hence the list is a basis of U .

- (b) For $p = x^3 - 2x + 1$ we have $p(1) = 0$, and $(a_1, a_2, a_3) = (-2, 0, 1)$. By the formula in (a), $p = -2(x - 1) + 0(x^2 - 1) + 1(x^3 - 1)$. Check: $-2x + 2 + x^3 - 1 = x^3 - 2x + 1$. The coordinate vector is $(-2, 0, 1)$.

Exercise C2: The Same List over a Different Field.

- (a) Explain why $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ is **not** a basis of $\mathbb{F}_2^2$.
- (b) Let F be any field. Prove that $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ is a basis of F^2 if and only if $1 + 1 \neq 0$ in F .

Solution.

- (a) In $\mathbb{F}_2$ we have $-1 = 1$, so the list is $((1, 1), (1, 1))$. It is dependent: $1 \cdot (1, 1) + 1 \cdot (1, 1) = (1 + 1, 1 + 1) = (0, 0)$ with non-zero coefficients. (It also fails to span: every combination is (c, c) , so $(1, 0)$ is out of reach.)

- (b) Write $2 = 1 + 1 \in F$.

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $2 \neq 0$, so 2^{-1} exists. Let $(x, y) \in F^2$. The equation $a(1, 1) + b(1, -1) = (x, y)$ says $a + b = x$ and $a - b = y$. If it holds, adding and subtracting gives $2a = x + y$ and $2b = x - y$, so $a = 2^{-1}(x + y)$ and $b = 2^{-1}(x - y)$. Conversely these values satisfy $a + b = 2^{-1} \cdot 2x = x$ and $a - b = 2^{-1} \cdot 2y = y$. So every vector has exactly one expression, and the list is a basis by [Theorem 1.5.1](#).

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $2 = 0$. Then $1 = -1$, and the argument of (a) applies word for word:

$1 \cdot (1, 1) + 1 \cdot (1, -1) = (2, 0) = (0, 0)$, so the list is dependent and is not a basis. This proves $(\Rightarrow)$ by contraposition.

Exercise C3: Rescaling a Basis.

Let $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a basis of V over F , and let $c_1, \dots, c_n \in F$ be **non-zero**.

- (a) Prove that $\mathcal{B}' = (c_1\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, c_n\mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V .
- (b) Express $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}'}$ in terms of $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$.
- (c) Explain why the conclusion of (a) can fail if some $c_i = 0$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$ and $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = (a_1, \dots, a_n)$. Since each $c_i \neq 0$, c_i^{-1} exists, and

$$\mathbf{v} = \sum_{i=1}^n a_i \mathbf{v}_i = \sum_{i=1}^n (a_i c_i^{-1})(c_i \mathbf{v}_i).$$

So $\mathbf{v}$ has an expression in $\mathcal{B}'$. Suppose $\mathbf{v} = \sum_i b_i (c_i \mathbf{v}_i) = \sum_i (b_i c_i) \mathbf{v}_i$. By uniqueness of the expression in $\mathcal{B}$ (Theorem 1.5.1), $b_i c_i = a_i$ for each i , so $b_i = a_i c_i^{-1}$. Hence the expression in $\mathcal{B}'$ is unique, and $\mathcal{B}'$ is a basis by Theorem 1.5.1.

- (b) By (a), $[\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}'} = (a_1 c_1^{-1}, \dots, a_n c_n^{-1})$: divide the i -th coordinate by c_i .
- (c) If $c_1 = 0$, then $\mathcal{B}'$ contains $0\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{0}$, and $1 \cdot \mathbf{0} + 0 \cdot c_2 \mathbf{v}_2 + \dots + 0 \cdot c_n \mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{0}$ is a combination with a non-zero coefficient. So $\mathcal{B}'$ is dependent and is not a basis.

1.6 The Exchange Theorem and Dimension

Every finite-dimensional space has a basis, and usually a great many of them. This section proves that they all have the same length, so that the length is a property of the space and not of the basis we happened to pick. That number is the dimension. The key step is the Steinitz Exchange Theorem, the most important proof of the chapter. With it we build the everyday tools of dimension counting: size bounds, “count instead of check”, extension of independent lists to bases, and dimensions of subspaces.

1.6.1 How big is a vector space?

We would like to say that a plane is smaller than space, and that $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ and $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$ are, in some sense, the same size. The naive measure is the number of elements. It fails at once: $\mathbb{R}^2$, $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ and $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$ are all infinite sets, and counting elements cannot tell them apart.

A better measure counts **how many vectors it takes to build everything, without waste**, which is the length of a basis. The standard bases give

$$\mathbb{R}^2 : 2, \quad M_2(\mathbb{R}) : 4 \ (E_{11}, E_{12}, E_{21}, E_{22}), \quad \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} : 4 \ (1, x, x^2, x^3).$$

This matches intuition: a matrix $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}$ and a polynomial $a + bx + cx^2 + dx^3$ are both described

by four free numbers.

But there is a gap. A space has many bases. We counted the standard basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$; the basis $((1, 1), (1, -1))$ also has length 2, but what guarantees that no basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$ has length 3? If some space had bases of two different lengths, “the length of a basis” would be meaningless. So before we can define anything, we need the following.

Goal. Any two bases of a finite-dimensional vector space have the same length.

A basis is independent **and** spanning, and the goal follows from a single inequality about the two properties separately: *an independent list is never longer than a spanning list*. Granting this, take two bases $\mathcal{B}$ and $\mathcal{C}$. Since $\mathcal{B}$ is independent and $\mathcal{C}$ spans, $\mathcal{B}$ is not longer than $\mathcal{C}$. Swapping the roles, $\mathcal{C}$ is not longer than $\mathcal{B}$. So they have the same length. Everything rests on the inequality.

1.6.2 The Steinitz Exchange Theorem

Why should an independent list be no longer than a spanning list? In $\mathbb{R}^2$ the spanning list $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ has length 2, and three vectors in the plane always satisfy a linear relation, but “the plane is two-dimensional” is what we are trying to define, so we cannot use it. The idea is instead to feed the independent vectors into the spanning list one at a time, pushing out one spanning vector each time, while keeping the list spanning. If the independent vectors outnumbered the spanning ones, we would run out of vectors to push out.

Theorem 1.6.1 — Steinitz Exchange Theorem

Let V be a vector space over F . Suppose that $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m)$ is a **linearly independent** list in V and that $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ is a list that **spans** V . Then

- (a) $m \leq n$, and
- (b) after renumbering $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n$ suitably, the list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V .

In words: an independent list is at most as long as a spanning list, and the independent vectors can **replace** m of the spanning vectors without losing the spanning property. “Renumbering” means listing the $\mathbf{w}$ ’s in a different order; which $\mathbf{w}$ ’s get replaced depends on the $\mathbf{u}$ ’s.

Idea. Picture a row of n slots holding $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n$; the row spans V . We push $\mathbf{u}_1$ into the row and push one $\mathbf{w}$ out, then $\mathbf{u}_2$, and so on, keeping the row spanning after every exchange. Here is the picture for $m = 3$, $n = 4$, with the $\mathbf{w}$ ’s numbered in the order they leave.

after 0	$\mathbf{w}_1$	$\mathbf{w}_2$	$\mathbf{w}_3$	$\mathbf{w}_4$	spans V
after 1	$\mathbf{u}_1$	$\mathbf{w}_2$	$\mathbf{w}_3$	$\mathbf{w}_4$	$\mathbf{u}_1$ in, $\mathbf{w}_1$ out
after 2	$\mathbf{u}_1$	$\mathbf{u}_2$	$\mathbf{w}_3$	$\mathbf{w}_4$	$\mathbf{u}_2$ in, $\mathbf{w}_2$ out
after 3	$\mathbf{u}_1$	$\mathbf{u}_2$	$\mathbf{u}_3$	$\mathbf{w}_4$	$\mathbf{u}_3$ in, $\mathbf{w}_3$ out
every row spans V					

Which $\mathbf{w}$ may leave? Write the incoming $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ as a combination of the current row. Any $\mathbf{w}$ with a **non-zero** coefficient can be solved for, so it lies in the span of the other entries together with $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$, and removing it costs nothing. Such a $\mathbf{w}$ must exist: otherwise $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ would be a combination of $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k$ alone, which independence forbids. In particular, while $\mathbf{u}$'s remain to be inserted, a $\mathbf{w}$ remains to be removed, and that is why $m \leq n$.

Step roadmap. Induction on the number k of exchanges, with the invariant

$P(k)$: $k \leq n$, and after renumbering the $\mathbf{w}$'s, the list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, \mathbf{w}_{k+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V .

Step 1 is the base case $k = 0$. **Step 2** writes $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ in the current list. **Step 3** is the Claim that some remaining $\mathbf{w}$ has a non-zero coefficient. **Step 4** exchanges that $\mathbf{w}$ for $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ and checks the span.

Proof. We prove $P(k)$ for $k = 0, 1, \dots, m$ by induction on k . The case $k = m$ is the theorem.

Step 1 (base case). For $k = 0$ the list in $P(0)$ is $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$, which spans V by hypothesis, and $0 \leq n$. So $P(0)$ holds.

Step 2. Let $0 \leq k < m$ and suppose $P(k)$ holds. Renumber the $\mathbf{w}$'s as $P(k)$ allows, so that

$$L_k = (\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, \mathbf{w}_{k+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$$

spans V . Since $k < m$, the vector $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ exists, and $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} \in V = \text{span}(L_k)$. Hence there are scalars $a_1, \dots, a_k, b_{k+1}, \dots, b_n \in F$ with

$$\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = a_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + a_k \mathbf{u}_k + b_{k+1} \mathbf{w}_{k+1} + \dots + b_n \mathbf{w}_n. \quad (*)$$

(If $k = n$, the list L_k contains no $\mathbf{w}$'s and the second group of terms is empty.)

Step 3.

Claim. We have $k + 1 \leq n$, and $b_j \neq 0$ for some j with $k + 1 \leq j \leq n$.

Proof. Suppose not. Then either $k = n$, so that there are no b 's at all, or $k < n$ and $b_{k+1} = \cdots = b_n = 0$. In both cases $(*)$ reads $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = a_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{u}_k$. Therefore

$$a_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{u}_k + (-1)\mathbf{u}_{k+1} + 0\mathbf{u}_{k+2} + \cdots + 0\mathbf{u}_m = \mathbf{0}$$

is a linear relation among $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m$ in which the coefficient of $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}$ is $-1 \neq 0$. This contradicts the linear independence of $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m)$. Hence there is at least one $\mathbf{w}$ in L_k , so $k+1 \leq n$, and some b_j with $j \geq k+1$ is non-zero. ■

Step 4. Renumber $\mathbf{w}_{k+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n$ among themselves so that $b_{k+1} \neq 0$. This only changes the order of entries of L_k , so L_k still spans V (the span of a list does not depend on the order of its entries), and $(*)$ still holds with the coefficients renumbered in the same way. Put

$$L_{k+1} = (\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{k+1}, \mathbf{w}_{k+2}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n).$$

Since $b_{k+1} \neq 0$, the scalar b_{k+1}^{-1} exists, and solving $(*)$ for $\mathbf{w}_{k+1}$ gives

$$\mathbf{w}_{k+1} = b_{k+1}^{-1}(\mathbf{u}_{k+1} - a_1\mathbf{u}_1 - \cdots - a_k\mathbf{u}_k - b_{k+2}\mathbf{w}_{k+2} - \cdots - b_n\mathbf{w}_n).$$

The right side is a combination of the entries of L_{k+1} , so $\mathbf{w}_{k+1} \in \text{span}(L_{k+1})$. By [Theorem 1.3.5](#), inserting $\mathbf{w}_{k+1}$ into L_{k+1} does not change the span:

$$\text{span}(L_{k+1}) = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{k+1}, \mathbf{w}_{k+1}, \mathbf{w}_{k+2}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n).$$

The list on the right contains every entry of L_k , so its span is a subspace containing all entries of L_k , and hence contains $\text{span}(L_k) = V$ by [Theorem 1.3.1](#). Therefore $\text{span}(L_{k+1}) = V$. Together with $k+1 \leq n$ from the Claim, this is $P(k+1)$.

By induction, $P(m)$ holds: $m \leq n$, and after renumbering the $\mathbf{w}$'s, $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V . This proves the theorem. ■

Part (a) is the inequality our goal needed. Part (b), the exchange itself, is a bonus that we will spend later in this section, to extend independent lists to bases.

Warning. The $\mathbf{w}$ that leaves must have a **non-zero** coefficient; an arbitrary $\mathbf{w}$ will not do. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, take the spanning list $(\mathbf{w}_1, \mathbf{w}_2) = ((1, 0), (0, 1))$ and the independent vector $\mathbf{u}_1 = (1, 0) = 1\mathbf{w}_1 + 0\mathbf{w}_2$. Exchanging $\mathbf{u}_1$ for $\mathbf{w}_1$ gives $((1, 0), (0, 1))$, which spans. Exchanging $\mathbf{u}_1$ for $\mathbf{w}_2$, whose coefficient is 0, gives $((1, 0), (1, 0))$, which does not reach $(0, 1)$.

The theorem already settles questions that would otherwise need a computation.

Quick check. Can the four polynomials $1 + x$, $x + x^2$, $x^2 + 1$, $1 + x + x^2$ be linearly independent in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$?

Solution. No. The list $(1, x, x^2)$ spans $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ and has length 3, so by [Theorem 1.6.1](#) every independent list there has length at most $3 < 4$. Indeed $(1+x) + (x+x^2) + (x^2+1) - 2(1+x+x^2) = 0$.

1.6.3 Dimension

The goal of the section is now one line away.

Theorem 1.6.2 — Basis Theorem

Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space. Then V has a basis, and any two bases of V have the same length.

Proof. By [Corollary 1.5.5](#), V has a basis. Let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ and $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_m)$ be bases of V . The first is linearly independent and the second spans V , so $n \leq m$ by [Theorem 1.6.1](#). Swapping the roles of the two bases gives $m \leq n$. Hence $m = n$. ■

We started from a question: how big is a vector space? The Basis Theorem says that one number, the length of a basis, answers it without depending on any choice. So we give that number a name.

The dimension of a space is the number of vectors in any basis: how many independent directions the space has.

Definition 1.6.1 — Dimension

Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space over F . The **dimension** of V over F , written $\dim_F V$ or simply $\dim V$, is the length of **any** basis of V .

In words: pick a basis of V , any basis at all, and count its vectors. The dimension is defined only for finite-dimensional spaces ([Definition 1.3.4](#)); a space spanned by no finite list is infinite-dimensional, and we do not assign it a number here. The subscript F records the field of scalars, which, as we will see, matters.

Well-definedness. Two things could go wrong with “the length of any basis”: there might be no basis to count, or different bases might give different counts. The first is ruled out by [Corollary 1.5.5](#) and the second by [Theorem 1.6.2](#). That is exactly what the word **any** in the definition needs.

Example. (Dimensions of the Running Examples)

Find the dimension of each space.

- (a) F^n , $M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $F[x]_{\leq n}$.
- (b) The zero space $\{\mathbf{0}\}$.

- (c) $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{C}$, and $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$.
- (d) $U = \{A \in M_2(\mathbb{R}) : A^T = A\}$, the symmetric 2×2 real matrices.
- (e) $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) = \{a + b\sqrt{2} : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ (Example ($\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ over $\mathbb{Q}$)).

Solution. In each case we exhibit one basis and count it.

- (a) The standard bases of Example (Standard Bases) have lengths n , mn and $n + 1$. So $\dim F^n = n$, $\dim M_{m \times n}(F) = mn$, and $\dim F[x]_{\leq n} = n + 1$.
- (b) The empty list is a basis of $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ (Example (Three More Bases)), so $\dim\{\mathbf{0}\} = 0$.
- (c) Over $\mathbb{C}$, the list (1) is a basis of $\mathbb{C}$: every z equals $z \cdot 1$, and $z \cdot 1 = 0$ forces $z = 0$. So $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} \mathbb{C} = 1$. Over $\mathbb{R}$, the list $(1, i)$ is a basis (Example (Three More Bases)), so $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C} = 2$.
- (d) A symmetric matrix has the form $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & d \end{pmatrix} = aE_{11} + b(E_{12} + E_{21}) + dE_{22}$, and this combination is the zero matrix only when $a = b = d = 0$. So $(E_{11}, E_{12} + E_{21}, E_{22})$ is a basis of U , as in Exercise (B3: Symmetric Matrices), and $\dim U = 3$.
- (e) Every element is $a \cdot 1 + b\sqrt{2}$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$, so $(1, \sqrt{2})$ spans. Let $a + b\sqrt{2} = 0$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$. If $b \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{2} = -a/b \in \mathbb{Q}$, contradicting Theorem 0.2.3. So $b = 0$, and then $a = 0$. Hence $(1, \sqrt{2})$ is a basis, and $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) = 2$.

The zero space in (b) is the degenerate case: it has dimension 0 because its basis is empty, not because it has no elements. It has one element, $\mathbf{0}$.

Non-example by minimal change. Remove the degree bound from $F[x]_{\leq n}$. The space $F[x]$ is not spanned by any finite list (Theorem 1.3.3), so it has no finite basis and no dimension in the sense of Definition 1.6.1. The hypothesis “finite-dimensional” in the Basis Theorem is exactly what fails.

Why this definition. Why a basis, and not some other list? Spanning lists can be made as long as we like by repeating vectors, and independent lists can be made as short as we like by deleting vectors, so neither length alone is an invariant. A basis sits exactly where the two meet: it is the longest possible independent list and the shortest possible spanning list, as we prove next. And why not count elements? Over $\mathbb{R}$ every non-zero space is infinite, so the count says nothing. Over a finite field the count does carry information, but it is determined by the dimension; see Exercise (C3: Counting Elements over a Finite Field).

Warning. The dimension of $F[x]_{\leq n}$ is $n + 1$, **not** n . The basis $(1, x, \dots, x^n)$ has one vector for each exponent $0, 1, \dots, n$, and the constant 1 is easy to forget. For instance $\dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2} = 3$.

Warning. Dimension depends on the field. The set $\mathbb{C}$ has dimension 1 over $\mathbb{C}$ but dimension 2 over $\mathbb{R}$, because over $\mathbb{R}$ the scalar i is no longer available and i must be counted as a separate basis vector. When more than one field is in sight, write $\dim_F$.

Quick check. What are $\dim M_{2 \times 3}(F)$ and $\dim F[x]_{\leq 5}$? Which of them equals $\dim F^6$?

Solution. $\dim M_{2 \times 3}(F) = 2 \cdot 3 = 6$ and $\dim F[x]_{\leq 5} = 5 + 1 = 6$. Both equal $\dim F^6 = 6$.

1.6.4 Size bounds

The first payoff turns the Exchange Theorem into statements about the number $\dim V$.

Theorem 1.6.3 — Size Bounds

Let V be a vector space over F with $\dim V = n$.

- (a) Every linearly independent list in V has length at most n . Hence every list in V of length **greater than** n is linearly dependent.
- (b) Every list that spans V has length at least n . Hence no list of length **less than** n spans V .

Proof. Let $\mathcal{B}$ be a basis of V ; it has length n .

- (a) Let $\mathcal{L}$ be an independent list of length ℓ . Since $\mathcal{B}$ spans V , Theorem 1.6.1 gives $\ell \leq n$. The second sentence is the contrapositive.
- (b) Let $\mathcal{L}$ be a list of length ℓ that spans V . Since $\mathcal{B}$ is independent, Theorem 1.6.1 gives $n \leq \ell$. The second sentence is the contrapositive.

■

So in a space of dimension n ,

$$\text{length of an independent list} \leq n \leq \text{length of a spanning list}.$$

This settles many questions with no computation. The four vectors $(1, 2, 3), (4, 5, 6), (7, 8, 9), (1, 0, 0)$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ are dependent, because $4 > 3$. Three matrices never span $M_2(F)$, because $3 < 4$.

1.6.5 Count instead of check

To show a list is a basis we normally check two things, independence and spanning. When the length of the list equals the dimension, one check is enough. This is one of the most used facts in the book.

Theorem 1.6.4 — Count Instead of Check

Let V be a vector space with $\dim V = n$, and let $\mathcal{L} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a list in V of length exactly n .

- (a) If $\mathcal{L}$ is linearly independent, then $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis of V .
- (b) If $\mathcal{L}$ spans V , then $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis of V .

Idea. For (a), the exchange part of Theorem 1.6.1 does the work: we can push all n vectors of $\mathcal{L}$ into a basis of length n , and then no old vectors are left, so $\mathcal{L}$ alone spans. For (b), sift $\mathcal{L}$: the result is a basis, so it has length n , so nothing was discarded.

Proof.

- (a) Let $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ be a basis of V ; in particular it spans V . Since $\mathcal{L}$ is independent of length n , [Theorem 1.6.1](#) (b) with $m = n$ says that, after renumbering the $\mathbf{w}$'s, the list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{w}_{n+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V . This list contains no $\mathbf{w}$'s: it is $\mathcal{L}$. So $\mathcal{L}$ is independent and spans V , and it is a basis.
- (b) By [Theorem 1.5.4](#), $\mathcal{L}$ contains a sub-list that is a basis of V . By [Theorem 1.6.2](#), that sub-list has length $\dim V = n$. The only sub-list of length n of a list of length n is the list itself. Hence $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis.

■

The theorem lets us choose the easier check, and independence is almost always easier: it is a single equation equal to $\mathbf{0}$, while spanning asks us to solve for an arbitrary vector.

Example. (A Basis by Counting)

Show that $(1, 1 + x, (1 + x)^2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$.

Solution. By [Example \(Dimensions of the Running Examples\)](#), $\dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2} = 3$, and the list has length 3. So by [Theorem 1.6.4](#) (a) it suffices to check independence. Let

$$a \cdot 1 + b(1 + x) + c(1 + x)^2 = 0.$$

Expanding, the left side is $(a + b + c) + (b + 2c)x + cx^2$. Comparing coefficients with the zero polynomial: $c = 0$; then $b + 2c = 0$ gives $b = 0$; then $a + b + c = 0$ gives $a = 0$. Hence the list is independent, with $3 = \dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ elements, and therefore it is a basis.

We never had to show that every polynomial of degree at most 2 is a combination of $1, 1 + x, (1 + x)^2$. The dimension count did it for us.

1.6.6 Extending to a basis

Sifting finds a basis **inside** a spanning list. The opposite direction starts from an independent list and grows it into a basis. This is the tool behind every dimension formula later in the book: start from a basis of the smallest space, then extend.

Theorem 1.6.5 — Basis Extension Theorem

Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space with $\dim V = n$, and let $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m)$ be a linearly independent list in V . Then $m \leq n$, and there are vectors $\mathbf{v}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n \in V$ such that

$$(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{v}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$$

is a basis of V . Moreover, the $\mathbf{v}$'s can be chosen from any given basis of V .

Proof. Let $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ be a basis of V . It spans V , so by [Theorem 1.6.1](#), $m \leq n$, and after renumbering the $\mathbf{w}$'s the list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V . This list has

length $m + (n - m) = n = \dim V$, so it is a basis by [Theorem 1.6.4](#) (b). Take $\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{w}_j$ for $m < j \leq n$. ■

Alternatively, sift the list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$. It spans V , and sifting keeps every $\mathbf{u}_k$: the sub-list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ is independent ([Exercise \(B3: Sub-Lists\)](#)), so $\mathbf{u}_k \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{k-1})$ by [Lemma 1.5.3](#). Sifting has the advantage of telling us **which** $\mathbf{w}$'s to add.

Example. (Extending an Independent List)

Extend the list $((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1))$ to a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution. The list is independent: $a(1, 1, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) = (a, a+b, b) = \mathbf{0}$ forces $a = b = 0$. By [Theorem 1.6.5](#), one vector from the standard basis will do, so we try $\mathbf{e}_1$. Let

$$a(1, 1, 0) + b(0, 1, 1) + c(1, 0, 0) = (a + c, a + b, b) = (0, 0, 0).$$

Then $b = 0$, so $a = 0$ from the second entry, so $c = 0$ from the first. Hence $((1, 1, 0), (0, 1, 1), (1, 0, 0))$ is independent, with $3 = \dim \mathbb{R}^3$ elements, and therefore a basis by [Theorem 1.6.4](#) (a).

The extension is far from unique. The same computation with $\mathbf{e}_2$ gives $(a, a + b + c, b) = \mathbf{0}$, and with $\mathbf{e}_3$ gives $(a, a + b, b + c) = \mathbf{0}$; both force $a = b = c = 0$. So any one of $\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_3$ completes this list to a basis.

1.6.7 Largest independent lists and smallest spanning lists

We claimed that a basis is where independence and spanning meet. Here is the precise statement. It does not need finite dimension, and it is the form of “basis” that generalizes to infinite-dimensional spaces later in this chapter.

Call an independent list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ in V **maximal independent** if for **every** $\mathbf{v} \in V$ the longer list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{v})$ is dependent. Call a spanning list **minimal spanning** if deleting **any one** of its entries gives a list that does not span V .

Theorem 1.6.6 — Maximal Independent and Minimal Spanning Lists

Let V be a vector space and $\mathcal{L} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ a list in V .

- (a) $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis of V if and only if $\mathcal{L}$ is maximal independent.
- (b) $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis of V if and only if $\mathcal{L}$ is minimal spanning.

Proof.

- (a) $(\Rightarrow)$ Let $\mathcal{L}$ be a basis and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Then $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(\mathcal{L}) = V$, so $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{v})$ is dependent by [Lemma 1.5.3](#). Hence $\mathcal{L}$ is maximal independent.

- ($\Leftarrow$) Let $\mathcal{L}$ be maximal independent and $\mathbf{v} \in V$. The list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{v})$ is dependent while $\mathcal{L}$ is independent, so $\mathbf{v} \in \text{span}(\mathcal{L})$ by [Lemma 1.5.3](#). Hence $\mathcal{L}$ spans V , and $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis.
- (b) ($\Rightarrow$) Let $\mathcal{L}$ be a basis, and suppose that deleting $\mathbf{v}_j$ gives a list that still spans V . Then $\mathbf{v}_j = \sum_{i \neq j} c_i \mathbf{v}_i$ for some scalars, so $\sum_{i \neq j} c_i \mathbf{v}_i + (-1)\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}$, a linear relation with the coefficient $-1 \neq 0$. This contradicts independence. Hence $\mathcal{L}$ is minimal spanning.
- ($\Leftarrow$) Let $\mathcal{L}$ be minimal spanning. By [Theorem 1.5.4](#), some sub-list S of $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis of V . Suppose $S \neq \mathcal{L}$. Then S omits some entry $\mathbf{v}_j$, so every entry of S is an entry of the list $\mathcal{L}'$ obtained by deleting $\mathbf{v}_j$. By [Theorem 1.3.1](#), $\text{span}(\mathcal{L}')$ contains $\text{span}(S) = V$, so $\mathcal{L}'$ spans V , contradicting minimality. Hence $S = \mathcal{L}$, and $\mathcal{L}$ is a basis. ■

“Maximal” means “cannot be enlarged”, which is different from “longest possible”. In a finite-dimensional space the two agree: by [Theorem 1.6.3](#) a longest independent list has length $\dim V$, and by [Theorem 1.6.4](#) every independent list of that length is a basis.

1.6.8 Dimensions of subspaces

A subspace should be no bigger than the space containing it. Proving this needs care, because of a tempting circular argument.

Theorem 1.6.7 — Dimension of a Subspace

Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space and U a subspace of V . Then U is finite-dimensional, and $\dim U \leq \dim V$.

Idea. The tempting proof is: “take a basis of U ; it is independent in V , so its length is at most $\dim V$ ”. But we do not yet know that U **has** a basis. [Corollary 1.5.5](#) needs a finite spanning list of U , and that is exactly what we are trying to prove. So we build from below instead. Independent lists inside U are independent in V , so their lengths are bounded by $\dim V$. Take one of the largest possible length. If it did not span U , we could append a vector of U outside its span and get a longer one.

Proof. Let $n = \dim V$. Independence of a list depends only on its vectors and the operations of V , which U shares, so every independent list in U is an independent list in V , and has length at most n by [Theorem 1.6.3](#). The empty list is independent in U . Hence the set of lengths of independent lists in U is a non-empty set of integers in $\{0, 1, \dots, n\}$, and it has a largest element $k \leq n$. Choose an independent list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ in U of this length.

We claim $\text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k) = U$. Since U is a subspace containing every $\mathbf{u}_i$, [Theorem 1.3.1](#) gives $\text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k) \subseteq U$. Conversely, let $\mathbf{u} \in U$, and suppose $\mathbf{u} \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$. By [Lemma 1.5.3](#), $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, \mathbf{u})$ is an independent list in U of length $k + 1$, contradicting the maximality of k . Hence $\mathbf{u} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$.

Therefore $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ spans U , so U is finite-dimensional ([Definition 1.3.4](#)), and the list is a basis of U . Hence $\dim U = k \leq n = \dim V$.

When the dimensions are equal, there is no room left. ■

Theorem 1.6.8 — Equal Dimension Forces Equality

Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space and U a subspace of V . If $\dim U = \dim V$, then $U = V$.

Proof. Let $n = \dim U = \dim V$; U is finite-dimensional by Theorem 1.6.7. Let $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n)$ be a basis of U (Corollary 1.5.5). It is an independent list in V of length $n = \dim V$, so it is a basis of V by Theorem 1.6.4 (a). Hence $V = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n) \subseteq U$, where the inclusion is Theorem 1.3.1 (3) applied to the subspace U . Since also $U \subseteq V$, we get $U = V$. ■

This is the dimension version of “count instead of check”: to prove two subspaces are equal, prove **one** inclusion and compare dimensions. It is usually much less work than proving both inclusions.

Quick check. Let U be a subspace of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ that contains 1 , $1+x$ and $(1+x)^2$. Must $U = \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$?

Solution. Yes. By Example (A Basis by Counting), $(1, 1+x, (1+x)^2)$ is independent, and it lies in U , so $\dim U \geq 3$ by Theorem 1.6.3 applied in U (which is finite-dimensional by Theorem 1.6.7). Also $\dim U \leq \dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2} = 3$. So $\dim U = 3$, and Theorem 1.6.8 gives $U = \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$.

Warning. Both hypotheses of Theorem 1.6.8 matter. Containment is needed: the xy -plane and the xz -plane in $\mathbb{R}^3$ both have dimension 2, but neither contains the other, and they are different. Without finite dimension it fails too. In $F[x]$, the subspace U of polynomials with constant coefficient 0 has the basis-like list $x, x^2, x^3, \dots$, which matches $1, x, x^2, \dots$ one for one; yet $1 \notin U$. Later in this chapter we make this precise for infinite-dimensional spaces.

1.6.9 Exercises

1.6.9.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) State the Steinitz Exchange Theorem.
- (b) True or false: $\dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} = 3$. Justify your answer.
- (c) True or false: in a vector space of dimension 3, every spanning list of length 3 is a basis. Justify your answer.
- (d) True or false: $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ contains a linearly independent list of length 5. Justify your answer.

- (e) True or false: if U and W are subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^4$ with $\dim U = \dim W = 2$, then $U = W$. Justify your answer.
- (f) What are $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} \mathbb{C}^2$ and $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}^2$?

Solution.

- (a) See [Theorem 1.6.1](#): if $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m)$ is independent and $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V , then $m \leq n$, and after renumbering the $\mathbf{w}$'s, $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_{m+1}, \dots, \mathbf{w}_n)$ spans V .
- (b) False. The basis $(1, x, x^2, x^3)$ has length 4, so $\dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} = 4$.
- (c) True, by [Theorem 1.6.4](#) (b).
- (d) False. $\dim M_2(\mathbb{R}) = 4$, and by [Theorem 1.6.3](#) (a) every list of length $5 > 4$ is dependent.
- (e) False. The subspaces $\text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ and $\text{span}(\mathbf{e}_3, \mathbf{e}_4)$ both have dimension 2, but $\mathbf{e}_1$ lies in the first and not in the second. [Theorem 1.6.8](#) needs one subspace to be contained in the other.
- (f) $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} \mathbb{C}^2 = 2$, with basis $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$. Over $\mathbb{R}$, the list $(\mathbf{e}_1, i\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, i\mathbf{e}_2)$ is a basis: every $(a + bi, c + di)$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$ equals $a\mathbf{e}_1 + b(i\mathbf{e}_1) + c\mathbf{e}_2 + d(i\mathbf{e}_2)$, and this is $\mathbf{0}$ only if $a + bi = 0$ and $c + di = 0$, that is, $a = b = c = d = 0$. So $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}^2 = 4$.

1.6.9.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Dimension and a Basis of a Subspace.

Find a basis and the dimension of each subspace.

- (a) $U_1 = \{(x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4) \in \mathbb{R}^4 : x_1 + x_2 = 0 \text{ and } x_3 - x_4 = 0\}$.
- (b) $U_2 = \{A \in M_3(\mathbb{R}) : \text{tr } A = 0\}$.
- (c) $U_3 = \{p \in \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} : p(1) = p(-1) = 0\}$.

Solution.

- (a) A vector lies in U_1 exactly when $x_2 = -x_1$ and $x_3 = x_4$, that is, when it equals

$$(x_1, -x_1, x_4, x_4) = x_1(1, -1, 0, 0) + x_4(0, 0, 1, 1).$$

So $((1, -1, 0, 0), (0, 0, 1, 1))$ spans U_1 . It is independent: $a(1, -1, 0, 0) + b(0, 0, 1, 1) = (a, -a, b, b) = \mathbf{0}$ forces $a = b = 0$. Hence it is a basis, and $\dim U_1 = 2$.

- (b) Write $A = (a_{ij})$. The condition $a_{11} + a_{22} + a_{33} = 0$ says $a_{33} = -a_{11} - a_{22}$, so

$$A = \sum_{i \neq j} a_{ij} E_{ij} + a_{11}(E_{11} - E_{33}) + a_{22}(E_{22} - E_{33}).$$

All eight matrices on the right have trace 0, so the list of the six E_{ij} with $i \neq j$, followed by $E_{11} - E_{33}$ and $E_{22} - E_{33}$, spans U_2 . For independence, let $\sum_{i \neq j} c_{ij} E_{ij} + d_1(E_{11} - E_{33}) + d_2(E_{22} - E_{33}) = 0$. The entry (i, j) with $i \neq j$ of the left side is c_{ij} , the entry $(1, 1)$ is d_1 , and the entry $(2, 2)$ is d_2 ; all must be 0. Hence the list is a basis, and $\dim U_2 = 8$.

- (c) Let $p = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + a_3x^3$. Then $p(1) = a_0 + a_1 + a_2 + a_3$ and $p(-1) = a_0 - a_1 + a_2 - a_3$. Adding and subtracting, $p \in U_3$ exactly when $a_0 + a_2 = 0$ and

$a_1 + a_3 = 0$. Hence $p \in U_3$ exactly when

$$p = -a_2 - a_3x + a_2x^2 + a_3x^3 = a_2(x^2 - 1) + a_3(x^3 - x).$$

So $(x^2 - 1, x^3 - x)$ spans U_3 . It is independent: $a(x^2 - 1) + b(x^3 - x) = 0$ has x^3 -coefficient b and x^2 -coefficient a , so $a = b = 0$. Hence it is a basis, and $\dim U_3 = 2$.

Exercise B2: Extending to a Basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$.

Show that $((1, 1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 1, 0))$ is linearly independent, and extend it to a basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$ using vectors from the standard basis.

Solution. Let $\mathbf{u}_1 = (1, 1, 0, 0)$ and $\mathbf{u}_2 = (0, 1, 1, 0)$. If $a\mathbf{u}_1 + b\mathbf{u}_2 = (a, a + b, b, 0) = \mathbf{0}$, then $a = b = 0$, so the list is independent. By [Theorem 1.6.5](#), two standard basis vectors complete it; we sift $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_3, \mathbf{e}_4)$ to find which.

- $\mathbf{u}_1 \neq \mathbf{0}$: keep. $\mathbf{u}_2 \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1)$, since a multiple $(a, a, 0, 0)$ of $\mathbf{u}_1$ has third entry 0: keep.
- $\mathbf{e}_1$: if $(a, a + b, b, 0) = (1, 0, 0, 0)$, then $a = 1$ and $b = 0$, but then $a + b = 1 \neq 0$. So $\mathbf{e}_1 \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2)$: keep.
- $\mathbf{e}_2 = \mathbf{u}_1 - \mathbf{e}_1$: discard.
- $\mathbf{e}_3 = -\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 + \mathbf{e}_1$, since $-(1, 1, 0, 0) + (0, 1, 1, 0) + (1, 0, 0, 0) = (0, 0, 1, 0)$: discard.
- $\mathbf{e}_4$: every combination of $\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{e}_1$ has fourth entry 0: keep.

The sifted list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_4)$ is independent by [Theorem 1.5.4](#). It has $4 = \dim \mathbb{R}^4$ entries, so it is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$ by [Theorem 1.6.4 \(a\)](#).

Exercise B3: Count Instead of Check.

Show that $(1, x - 1, (x - 1)^2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$. Hence find the coordinate vector of x^2 with respect to this basis.

Solution. Let $a + b(x - 1) + c(x - 1)^2 = 0$. Expanding, $(a - b + c) + (b - 2c)x + cx^2 = 0$. Comparing coefficients, $c = 0$, then $b = 2c = 0$, then $a = b - c = 0$. So the list is independent, with $3 = \dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ elements, and it is a basis by [Theorem 1.6.4 \(a\)](#).

Writing $x = (x - 1) + 1$,

$$x^2 = ((x - 1) + 1)^2 = 1 + 2(x - 1) + (x - 1)^2.$$

Hence the coordinate vector of x^2 is $(1, 2, 1)$.

1.6.9.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Symmetric and Skew-Symmetric Matrices.

Let $n \geq 1$. For a field F , let U_+ and U_- be the subspaces of symmetric and of skew-symmetric matrices in $M_n(F)$ ([Definition 0.9.11](#)): $U_+ = \{A : A^T = A\}$ and $U_- = \{A : A^T = -A\}$.

- (a) For $F = \mathbb{R}$, prove that $\dim U_+ = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$.
 (b) For $F = \mathbb{R}$, prove that $\dim U_- = \frac{n(n-1)}{2}$.
 (c) For $F = \mathbb{F}_2$, show that $U_- = U_+$, and find its dimension. Which step of (b) fails?

Solution.

- (a) Consider the list $\mathcal{S}$ consisting of E_{ii} for $1 \leq i \leq n$ and $E_{ij} + E_{ji}$ for $1 \leq i < j \leq n$. Each is symmetric. If $A = (a_{ij})$ is symmetric, then $a_{ji} = a_{ij}$, so

$$A = \sum_i a_{ii} E_{ii} + \sum_{i < j} a_{ij} (E_{ij} + E_{ji}),$$

because both sides have a_{ij} in entry (i, j) and $a_{ij} = a_{ji}$ in entry (j, i) . So $\mathcal{S}$ spans U_+ . If $\sum_i c_{ii} E_{ii} + \sum_{i < j} c_{ij} (E_{ij} + E_{ji}) = 0$, then for $i \leq j$ the entry (i, j) of the left side is c_{ij} , so every coefficient is 0. Hence $\mathcal{S}$ is a basis, of length $n + \frac{n(n-1)}{2} = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$.

- (b) If $A^T = -A$, then comparing diagonal entries gives $a_{ii} = -a_{ii}$, so $2a_{ii} = 0$, and $a_{ii} = 0$ because $2 \neq 0$ in $\mathbb{R}$. Off the diagonal, $a_{ji} = -a_{ij}$. Hence

$$A = \sum_{i < j} a_{ij} (E_{ij} - E_{ji}).$$

Each $E_{ij} - E_{ji}$ is skew-symmetric, so these matrices span U_- , and as in (a) the entry (i, j) with $i < j$ of a combination is its coefficient, so they are independent. There are $\frac{n(n-1)}{2}$ pairs $i < j$, so $\dim U_- = \frac{n(n-1)}{2}$.

- (c) In $\mathbb{F}_2$, $-1 = 1$, so $-A = A$ for every matrix A , and the conditions $A^T = -A$ and $A^T = A$ coincide. Hence $U_- = U_+$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$, which has dimension $\frac{n(n+1)}{2}$ by the argument of (a), which works over any field. The step of (b) that fails is “ $2a_{ii} = 0$ implies $a_{ii} = 0$ ”, which divides by $2 = 0$. For example, $I_n \in U_-$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$, although its diagonal entries are not 0.

Exercise C2: A complex space viewed over the reals.

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$ with $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} V = n$. Restricting the scalars to real numbers makes V a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$. Prove that $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} V = 2n$.

Hint: start from a basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ over $\mathbb{C}$, and consider the vectors $i\mathbf{v}_k$.

Solution. Let $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ be a basis of V over $\mathbb{C}$. We show that $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, i\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, i\mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V over $\mathbb{R}$.

Spanning. Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Then $\mathbf{v} = \sum_k z_k \mathbf{v}_k$ with $z_k \in \mathbb{C}$. Write $z_k = a_k + b_k i$ with $a_k, b_k \in \mathbb{R}$. By the distributive and associative axioms of scalar multiplication, $z_k \mathbf{v}_k = a_k \mathbf{v}_k + (b_k i) \mathbf{v}_k = a_k \mathbf{v}_k + b_k (i \mathbf{v}_k)$. Hence $\mathbf{v} = \sum_k (a_k \mathbf{v}_k + b_k (i \mathbf{v}_k))$, a real combination of $\mathcal{B}$.

Independence. Let $\sum_k (a_k \mathbf{v}_k + b_k (i \mathbf{v}_k)) = \mathbf{0}$ with $a_k, b_k \in \mathbb{R}$. Reading the same axioms backwards, $\sum_k (a_k + b_k i) \mathbf{v}_k = \mathbf{0}$. Since $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is independent over $\mathbb{C}$, every $a_k + b_k i = 0$, so $a_k = b_k = 0$.

Hence $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis over $\mathbb{R}$ of length $2n$, and $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} V = 2n$.

Exercise C3: Counting Elements over a Finite Field.

Let p be a prime.

- (a) Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{F}_p$ with $\dim V = k$. Prove that V has exactly p^k elements.
- (b) Deduce that no vector space over $\mathbb{F}_2$ has exactly 6 elements.
- (c) Let K be a finite field that contains $\mathbb{F}_p$, with the same addition and multiplication. Explain why K is a finite-dimensional vector space over $\mathbb{F}_p$, and deduce that K has p^k elements for some integer $k \geq 1$.

Hint: for (a), use coordinates.

Solution.

- (a) Let $\mathcal{B}$ be a basis of V , of length k . By [Theorem 1.5.2](#), $\mathbf{v} \mapsto [\mathbf{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ is a bijection from V to $\mathbb{F}_p^k$: every column is the coordinate vector of exactly one vector. So V has as many elements as $\mathbb{F}_p^k$. A column in $\mathbb{F}_p^k$ is a choice of k entries, each from the p elements of $\mathbb{F}_p$, so there are p^k columns. Hence V has p^k elements.
- (b) A vector space over $\mathbb{F}_2$ with finitely many elements is spanned by the finite list of all its elements, so it is finite-dimensional, of some dimension k . By (a) it has 2^k elements. Since 6 is not a power of 2, no such space has 6 elements.
- (c) Define scalar multiplication $\mathbb{F}_p \times K \rightarrow K$ by the multiplication of K . The vector space axioms are then instances of the field axioms of K : addition in K is commutative and associative with zero and negatives, multiplication is associative, $1 \cdot a = a$, and multiplication distributes over addition. So K is a vector space over $\mathbb{F}_p$. It is spanned by the finite list of all its elements, so it is finite-dimensional; let $k = \dim_{\mathbb{F}_p} K$. By (a), K has p^k elements. Since K contains $0 \neq 1$, it is not the zero space, so $k \geq 1$.

1.7 Sums and Direct Sums

We can now measure a single subspace: take a basis and count. This section asks how two or more subspaces combine. The intersection of two subspaces is again a subspace, but the union usually is not, so we need a better way to join them. The answer is the sum $U + W$. We then prove the dimension formula for sums and single out the best case, the direct sum, in which every vector splits into pieces in exactly one way.

1.7.1 The sum of subspaces

Recall from [Theorem 1.2.2](#) that $U \cap W$ is a subspace whenever U and W are. It is the largest subspace inside both. The natural companion would be the smallest subspace containing both, and the first guess is the union $U \cup W$.

That guess fails. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, let U be the x -axis and W the y -axis. Then $(1, 0) \in U$ and $(0, 1) \in W$, but their sum $(1, 1)$ lies on neither axis, so $U \cup W$ is not closed under addition ([Example \(The](#)

Union of the Two Axes)). In fact Proposition 1.2.3 shows that $U \cup W$ is a subspace only in the dull case $U \subseteq W$ or $W \subseteq U$.

The failure tells us what is missing. Any subspace containing U and W must contain $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ for every $\mathbf{u} \in U$ and $\mathbf{w} \in W$, because subspaces are closed under addition. So we put all these sums in from the start.

The sum of two subspaces is everything you can reach by adding one vector from each.

Definition 1.7.1 — Sum of Subspaces

Let V be a vector space over F , and let U and W be subspaces of V . The **sum** of U and W is the subset

$$U + W := \{\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} : \mathbf{u} \in U \text{ and } \mathbf{w} \in W\}.$$

More generally, for subspaces $U_1, \dots, U_k$ of V (with $k \geq 1$), their **sum** is

$$U_1 + \dots + U_k := \{\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k : \mathbf{u}_i \in U_i \text{ for each } i = 1, \dots, k\}.$$

In words: a vector $\mathbf{v}$ lies in $U + W$ when **there exist** some $\mathbf{u} \in U$ and some $\mathbf{w} \in W$ with $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$. The definition asks for one such pair. It does not say the pair is unique, and in general it is not. For k subspaces we pick **one** vector from **each** U_i and add them. We also write $\sum_{i=1}^k U_i$, and for $k = 1$ the sum is just U_1 .

Here are some first examples.

- **The two axes.** In $\mathbb{R}^2$, with U the x -axis and W the y -axis, every (a, b) equals $(a, 0) + (0, b)$, so $U + W = \mathbb{R}^2$. The union is two lines; the sum is the whole plane.
- **Two planes in $\mathbb{R}^3$.** Let $P_{xy} = \{(x, y, 0)\}$ and $P_{yz} = \{(0, y, z)\}$. Every $(a, b, c) = (a, b, 0) + (0, 0, c)$ is a sum of a vector in P_{xy} and one in P_{yz} , so $P_{xy} + P_{yz} = \mathbb{R}^3$.
- **Polynomials.** In $F[x]_{\leq 2}$, let U be the constant polynomials and $W = \{bx + cx^2 : b, c \in F\}$. Then $a + bx + cx^2 = a + (bx + cx^2)$, so $U + W = F[x]_{\leq 2}$.
- **Matrices.** In $M_2(F)$, the upper triangular matrices plus the lower triangular matrices give everything:

$$\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ c & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

- **Degenerate cases.** For any subspace U , we have $U + \{\mathbf{0}\} = U$ and $U + U = U$. In both, “ $\supseteq$ ” holds because $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{0}$, and “ $\subseteq$ ” holds because U is closed under addition. So adding a subspace to itself produces nothing new: a sum is not a count.

Non-example by minimal change. The definition makes sense for any two subsets $S, T \subseteq V$, but the result need not be a subspace. Take $S = \{(1, 0)\}$ and $T = \{(0, 1)\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Then $S + T = \{(1, 1)\}$, which does not contain $\mathbf{0}$. What changed is that S and T are not subspaces: the hypothesis “subspace” is exactly what makes the next theorem work.

Warning. The sum $U + W$ is **not** the union $U \cup W$. A vector of $U + W$ need not lie in U or in W : $(1, 1)$ lies in the sum of the two axes but on neither axis. Conversely, $U + W$ is usually far bigger than $U \cup W$.

The sum does what we built it to do.

Theorem 1.7.1 — Sum of Subspaces Theorem

Let $U_1, \dots, U_k$ be subspaces of a vector space V . Then $U_1 + \dots + U_k$ is a subspace of V that contains each U_i . Moreover, if X is any subspace of V containing every U_i , then $U_1 + \dots + U_k \subseteq X$. In other words, $U_1 + \dots + U_k$ is the **smallest** subspace of V containing $U_1, \dots, U_k$.

Proof. Write $S = U_1 + \dots + U_k$. We apply the Subspace Test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)).

- (1) Each U_i contains $\mathbf{0}$, so $\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} + \dots + \mathbf{0} \in S$.
- (2) Let $\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k$ and $\mathbf{u}'_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}'_k$ be in S , with $\mathbf{u}_i, \mathbf{u}'_i \in U_i$. Regrouping with (VS1) and (VS2),

$$(\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k) + (\mathbf{u}'_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}'_k) = (\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}'_1) + \dots + (\mathbf{u}_k + \mathbf{u}'_k),$$

and $\mathbf{u}_i + \mathbf{u}'_i \in U_i$ because U_i is closed under addition. Hence S is closed under addition.

- (3) Let $c \in F$. By the distributive axiom, $c(\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k) = c\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + c\mathbf{u}_k$, and $c\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$ because U_i is closed under scaling. Hence S is closed under scalar multiplication.

Therefore S is a subspace. It contains U_j : for $\mathbf{u} \in U_j$, take $\mathbf{u}_j = \mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{0} \in U_i$ for $i \neq j$. Finally, let X be a subspace containing every U_i . An element $\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k$ of S is a sum of vectors $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i \subseteq X$, so it lies in X since X is closed under addition. This shows $S \subseteq X$. ■

So the sum plays the role that the union could not. It is the subspace analogue of span, and the two notions fit together exactly. Recall from [Theorem 1.3.1](#) that $\text{span}(S)$ is the smallest subspace containing S .

Proposition 1.7.2 — Sum of Spans

Let $L_1, \dots, L_k$ be finite lists of vectors in V , and let L be the list obtained by writing $L_1, \dots, L_k$ one after another. Then

$$\text{span}(L_1) + \dots + \text{span}(L_k) = \text{span}(L).$$

Proof. ($\subseteq$) The subspace $\text{span}(L)$ contains every vector of each L_i , so by [Theorem 1.3.1](#) it contains each $\text{span}(L_i)$. By [Theorem 1.7.1](#) it therefore contains $\text{span}(L_1) + \dots + \text{span}(L_k)$.

($\supseteq$) The sum $\text{span}(L_1) + \dots + \text{span}(L_k)$ is a subspace by [Theorem 1.7.1](#), and it contains each $\text{span}(L_i)$, hence every vector of L . By [Theorem 1.3.1](#) it contains $\text{span}(L)$. ■

In practice this means: **to find a spanning list of a sum, concatenate spanning lists of the summands.** That list may be dependent, and the dimension formula below tells us by how much.

Quick check. In $\mathbb{R}^3$, what is $\text{span}((1, 0, 0)) + \text{span}((0, 1, 0))$? Is it equal to $\text{span}((1, 0, 0)) \cup \text{span}((0, 1, 0))$?

Solution. By [Proposition 1.7.2](#) the sum is $\text{span}((1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0)) = \{(a, b, 0) : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\}$, the xy -plane. It is not the union: $(1, 1, 0)$ lies in the plane but on neither axis.

1.7.2 The dimension formula

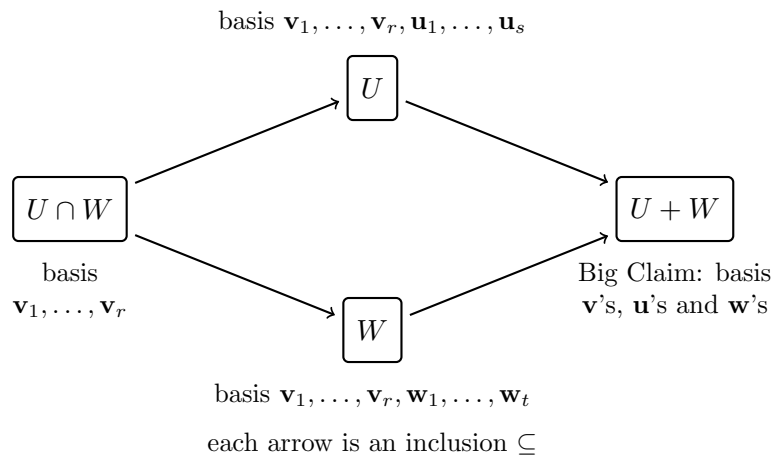
If U and W are finite-dimensional, how big is $U + W$? Concatenating a basis of U and a basis of W gives a spanning list of $U + W$ of length $\dim U + \dim W$ ([Proposition 1.7.2](#)). That count is too large when U and W overlap. For the two planes P_{xy} and P_{yz} in $\mathbb{R}^3$, it would give $2 + 2 = 4$, but $P_{xy} + P_{yz} = \mathbb{R}^3$ has dimension 3. The overlap is the y -axis, of dimension 1, and it has been counted twice. The theorem says this is the whole story.

Theorem 1.7.3 — Dimension Formula for Sums

Let U and W be finite-dimensional subspaces of a vector space V . Then $U + W$ is finite-dimensional, and

$$\dim(U + W) = \dim U + \dim W - \dim(U \cap W).$$

The picture behind the proof is the inclusion diagram. The smallest space, $U \cap W$, sits inside both U and W , and both sit inside $U + W$. We build bases from the bottom up.



Idea. This is a dimension formula, so we start from the **smallest** space and extend outward.

① Take a basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r)$ of $U \cap W$. ② Extend it to a basis of U by adding $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s$, and separately to a basis of W by adding $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t$. ③ **Big Claim:** the combined list of all $r + s + t$ vectors is a basis of $U + W$. Spanning is easy. For independence, move the $\mathbf{w}$ -part to the other side: the common vector lies in U and in W , hence in $U \cap W$, where the $\mathbf{v}$'s are a basis. ④ Count: $r + s + t = (r + s) + (r + t) - r$.

Proof. Step 1: bases. By [Theorem 1.2.2](#), $U \cap W$ is a subspace of V ; it lies inside U and uses the same operations, so it is also a subspace of U . Since U is finite-dimensional, so is $U \cap W$ ([Theorem 1.6.7](#)), and it has a basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r)$, where $r = \dim(U \cap W)$ ([Corollary 1.5.5](#)). This list is independent and lies in U , so by the Basis Extension Theorem ([Theorem 1.6.5](#)) there are vectors $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s \in U$ such that $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s)$ is a basis of U . In the same way, since the list also lies in W , there are $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t \in W$ such that $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t)$ is a basis of W . Thus $\dim U = r + s$ and $\dim W = r + t$.

Step 2: the Big Claim.

Claim. The list $\mathcal{B} = (\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t)$ is a basis of $U + W$.

Proof. Spanning. By [Proposition 1.7.2](#), $U + W = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s) + \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t)$ is the span of the concatenated list. That list contains each $\mathbf{v}_i$ twice; removing the second copies does not change the span, since every removed vector already lies in the span of what remains ([Theorem 1.3.5](#)). Hence $\mathcal{B}$ spans $U + W$.

Independence. Let $a_i, b_j, c_k \in F$ satisfy

$$a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_r\mathbf{v}_r + b_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + b_s\mathbf{u}_s + c_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + c_t\mathbf{w}_t = \mathbf{0}.$$

Move the $\mathbf{w}$ -part across and name the common vector:

$$\mathbf{x} := a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_r\mathbf{v}_r + b_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + b_s\mathbf{u}_s = -c_1\mathbf{w}_1 - \dots - c_t\mathbf{w}_t.$$

The middle expression lies in U , because all the $\mathbf{v}_i$ and $\mathbf{u}_j$ do. The right-hand expression lies in W , because all the $\mathbf{w}_k$ do. Hence $\mathbf{x} \in U \cap W$. Since $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r)$ spans $U \cap W$, there are $d_1, \dots, d_r \in F$ with $\mathbf{x} = d_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + d_r\mathbf{v}_r$. Comparing with the right-hand expression for $\mathbf{x}$,

$$d_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + d_r\mathbf{v}_r + c_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + c_t\mathbf{w}_t = \mathbf{0}.$$

This is a combination of the basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_t)$ of W , which is independent, so all $d_i = 0$ and all $c_k = 0$. Putting $c_1 = \dots = c_t = 0$ into the original equation leaves

$$a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + a_r\mathbf{v}_r + b_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + b_s\mathbf{u}_s = \mathbf{0},$$

a combination of the basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_r, \mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_s)$ of U . By its independence, all $a_i = 0$ and all $b_j = 0$. Hence $\mathcal{B}$ is linearly independent ([Definition 1.4.1](#)). ■

Step 3: count. By the claim, $U + W$ has a finite basis of length $r + s + t$, so it is finite-dimensional with $\dim(U + W) = r + s + t$ ([Definition 1.6.1](#)). Therefore

$$\dim(U + W) = r + s + t = (r + s) + (r + t) - r = \dim U + \dim W - \dim(U \cap W),$$

as claimed. ■

The proof also works when some of r, s, t are 0: an empty list is independent and spans $\{\mathbf{0}\}$, and every step reads correctly with empty sums. The move “basis of the smallest space, extend, Big Claim, count” is worth learning as a unit. It proves Rank–Nullity in Chapter 3 with the same four blocks.

The formula is often used to find one of the four numbers from the other three. Here are two uses, one by counting and one by computing.

Example. (Two planes in $\mathbb{R}^3$)

Let $U = \{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x + y + z = 0\}$ and $W = \{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x = z\}$. Show that $U + W = \mathbb{R}^3$, and find a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$ of the shape used in the proof.

Solution. Solving $x + y + z = 0$ for y , every vector of U is $(x, -x - z, z) = x(1, -1, 0) + z(0, -1, 1)$. The two vectors are independent (look at the first and third entries), so $\dim U = 2$. Similarly every vector of W is $(x, y, x) = x(1, 0, 1) + y(0, 1, 0)$, and $\dim W = 2$.

A vector lies in $U \cap W$ when $x = z$ and $x + y + z = 0$, that is, $y = -2x$. So $U \cap W = \{(x, -2x, x)\} = \text{span}((1, -2, 1))$, which has dimension 1. By the dimension formula,

$$\dim(U + W) = 2 + 2 - 1 = 3 = \dim \mathbb{R}^3.$$

Since $U + W \subseteq \mathbb{R}^3$ and the dimensions agree, $U + W = \mathbb{R}^3$ by [Theorem 1.6.8](#).

Following the proof: $(1, -2, 1)$ extends to a basis of U by $(1, -1, 0) \in U$. Indeed $(1, -1, 0)$ is not a multiple $(c, -2c, c)$ of $(1, -2, 1)$, since its first and third entries differ, so the list $((1, -2, 1), (1, -1, 0))$ is independent by [Lemma 1.5.3](#); it has length $2 = \dim U$, so it is a basis of U ([Theorem 1.6.4](#)). It extends to a basis of W by $(0, 1, 0) \in W$, for the same reason: a multiple of $(1, -2, 1)$ with first entry 0 is $\mathbf{0}$. The Big Claim says $((1, -2, 1), (1, -1, 0), (0, 1, 0))$ is a basis of $U + W = \mathbb{R}^3$.

Example. (Two planes in $\mathbb{R}^4$ from spanning lists)

Let $U = \text{span}((1, 1, 0, 0), (0, 0, 1, 1))$ and $W = \text{span}((1, 0, 1, 0), (0, 1, 0, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$. Find $\dim(U \cap W)$ and $\dim(U + W)$, and hence a basis of $U + W$.

Solution. Each spanning list is independent: in $a(1, 1, 0, 0) + b(0, 0, 1, 1) = (a, a, b, b) = \mathbf{0}$, both a and b are 0, and similarly $c(1, 0, 1, 0) + d(0, 1, 0, 1) = (c, d, c, d)$. So $\dim U = \dim W = 2$.

A vector lies in $U \cap W$ exactly when it can be written in both forms, $(a, a, b, b) = (c, d, c, d)$. Comparing entries gives $a = c$, $a = d$, $b = c$, $b = d$, so $a = b = c = d$. Hence $U \cap W = \text{span}((1, 1, 1, 1))$ and $\dim(U \cap W) = 1$. By the dimension formula, $\dim(U + W) = 2 + 2 - 1 = 3$.

For a basis, follow the proof. The vector $(1, 1, 1, 1)$ together with $(1, 1, 0, 0)$ is a list in U , and it is independent by [Lemma 1.5.3](#), because a multiple (c, c, c, c) of $(1, 1, 1, 1)$ never equals $(1, 1, 0, 0)$. It has length $2 = \dim U$, hence it is a basis of U ([Theorem 1.6.4](#)). Likewise $((1, 1, 1, 1), (1, 0, 1, 0))$ is a basis of W . By the Big Claim, $((1, 1, 1, 1), (1, 1, 0, 0), (1, 0, 1, 0))$ is a basis of $U + W$. In particular $U + W \neq \mathbb{R}^4$.

1.7.3 Direct sums

In a basis, every vector has **exactly one** expression as a combination (Theorem 1.5.1). Read that for F^n with the standard basis: $F^n = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1) + \cdots + \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_n)$, and each vector splits into pieces from these lines in exactly one way. We want the same property for subspaces that are not lines.

Sums do not always have it. In $\mathbb{R}^3 = P_{xy} + P_{yz}$,

$$(1, 1, 1) = (1, 1, 0) + (0, 0, 1) = (1, 0, 0) + (0, 1, 1),$$

two different splittings, because the planes share the y -axis and the y -component can be handed to either side. If we replace P_{yz} by the z -axis Z , then $(a, b, c) = (a, b, 0) + (0, 0, c)$ is the **only** splitting, since the Z -piece must have first two entries 0. We give this situation a name.

A sum is direct when every vector in it breaks into one piece from each subspace in exactly one way.

Definition 1.7.2 — Direct Sum

Let $U_1, \dots, U_k$ be subspaces of a vector space V over F . The sum $U_1 + \cdots + U_k$ is **direct** if **every** vector $\mathbf{v} \in U_1 + \cdots + U_k$ can be written in **exactly one** way as

$$\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k \quad \text{with } \mathbf{u}_i \in U_i \text{ for each } i.$$

In that case we write the sum as $U_1 \oplus \cdots \oplus U_k$. We write $V = U_1 \oplus \cdots \oplus U_k$ to mean that $V = U_1 + \cdots + U_k$ **and** the sum is direct.

In words: existence of a splitting is automatic, since that is what membership in the sum means. The content of “direct” is **uniqueness**: if $\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{u}'_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}'_k$ with $\mathbf{u}_i, \mathbf{u}'_i \in U_i$, then $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{u}'_i$ for **every** i . The symbol $\oplus$ does not build a new space. It is the same subspace $U_1 + \cdots + U_k$, with a property recorded in the notation. (Chapter 3 builds an “external” direct sum out of spaces that do not sit inside a common V .)

Examples.

- **Standard basis.** $F^n = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1) \oplus \cdots \oplus \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_n)$. More generally, if $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V , then $V = \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1) \oplus \cdots \oplus \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_n)$. A splitting $\mathbf{v} = a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_n\mathbf{v}_n$ is a choice of coefficients, and Theorem 1.5.1 says there is exactly one.
- **Two splittings of the plane.** Let X be the x -axis, Y the y -axis and $D = \{(t, t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}$ the line $y = x$. Then $\mathbb{R}^2 = X \oplus Y$, with $(a, b) = (a, 0) + (0, b)$ the only splitting. Also $\mathbb{R}^2 = X \oplus D$: if $(a, b) = (s, 0) + (t, t)$, the second entry forces $t = b$, and then the first forces $s = a - b$. So $(a, b) = (a - b, 0) + (b, b)$, and there is no other choice.
- **Polynomials.** $F[x]_{\leq 2} = \text{span}(1) \oplus \text{span}(x, x^2)$. If $a + bx + cx^2 = a' + (b'x + c'x^2)$, comparing coefficients gives $a = a'$, $b = b'$, $c = c'$.
- **Degenerate.** $U \oplus \{\mathbf{0}\} = U$ for every subspace U : the only possible $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ -piece is $\mathbf{0}$, so the U -piece of $\mathbf{v}$ must be $\mathbf{v}$.

Non-example by minimal change. Replace the z -axis in $\mathbb{R}^3 = P_{xy} \oplus Z$ by the plane P_{yz} . The sum is still all of $\mathbb{R}^3$, so existence still holds. What fails is uniqueness, as the two splittings of $(1, 1, 1)$ above show. So $\mathbb{R}^3 = P_{xy} + P_{yz}$, but the sum is **not** direct. Likewise upper plus lower triangular 2×2 matrices give $M_2(F)$, but a diagonal matrix can be put in either summand, so that sum is not direct.

Checking uniqueness for **every** vector looks like a lot of work. For two subspaces it reduces to one condition you can check in a line.

Theorem 1.7.4 — Direct Sum Criteria for Two Subspaces

Let U and W be subspaces of a vector space V . The following are equivalent:

- (a) the sum $U + W$ is direct;
- (b) $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$.

If moreover U and W are finite-dimensional, they are also equivalent to

- (c) $\dim(U + W) = \dim U + \dim W$.

Idea. Uniqueness questions go through differences. If $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{w}'$, then $\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{u}' = \mathbf{w}' - \mathbf{w}$ is a single vector lying in both U and W . So “no overlap” is exactly “no freedom in splitting”. For (c), the dimension formula says the overcount $\dim U + \dim W - \dim(U + W)$ is $\dim(U \cap W)$, which is 0 exactly when $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$.

Proof.

- (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b). Suppose the sum is direct and let $\mathbf{v} \in U \cap W$. Then $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{0}$ with $\mathbf{v} \in U$, $\mathbf{0} \in W$, and $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{v}$ with $\mathbf{0} \in U$, $\mathbf{v} \in W$. These are two splittings of $\mathbf{v} \in U + W$, so by uniqueness their U -pieces agree: $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Hence $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$.
- (b) $\Rightarrow$ (a). Suppose $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, and let $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{w}'$ with $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{u}' \in U$ and $\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{w}' \in W$. Then $\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{u}' = \mathbf{w}' - \mathbf{w}$. The left side lies in U and the right side in W , since both are subspaces. So this common vector lies in $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, which gives $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u}'$ and $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{w}'$. Hence every vector of $U + W$ has only one splitting.
- (c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c). Now let U and W be finite-dimensional. By the dimension formula (Theorem 1.7.3), (c) holds if and only if $\dim(U \cap W) = 0$. A space has dimension 0 exactly when the empty list is a basis of it, that is, when it equals the span of the empty list, which is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$. So (c) holds if and only if $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. ■

This is the everyday test: to show $V = U \oplus W$, show $V = U + W$ and $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. In finite dimension there is a shortcut that avoids checking $V = U + W$ at all: if $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ and $\dim U + \dim W = \dim V$, then $\dim(U + W) = \dim V$ by (c), so $U + W = V$ by Theorem 1.6.8. Count instead of check.

Example. (A plane and a line in $\mathbb{R}^3$)

Let $U = \{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x + y + z = 0\}$ and $L = \text{span}((1, 1, 1))$. Show that $\mathbb{R}^3 = U \oplus L$, and split (a, b, c) into its two pieces.

Solution. From Example (Two planes in $\mathbb{R}^3$), $\dim U = 2$, and $\dim L = 1$ since $(1, 1, 1) \neq \mathbf{0}$. If $t(1, 1, 1) \in U$, then $t + t + t = 3t = 0$, so $t = 0$. Hence $U \cap L = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. By Theorem 1.7.4, $\dim(U + L) = 2 + 1 = 3$, so $U + L = \mathbb{R}^3$ by Theorem 1.6.8. Therefore $\mathbb{R}^3 = U \oplus L$.

To split (a, b, c) , look for t with $(a, b, c) - t(1, 1, 1) \in U$, that is, $(a-t) + (b-t) + (c-t) = 0$. This gives $t = \frac{a+b+c}{3}$, and

$$(a, b, c) = \left(a - \frac{a+b+c}{3}, b - \frac{a+b+c}{3}, c - \frac{a+b+c}{3}\right) + \frac{a+b+c}{3}(1, 1, 1).$$

The L -piece is the average of the entries times $(1, 1, 1)$; the U -piece is what is left over.

The same splitting trick, “average with a reflected copy”, works for functions and matrices.

Example. (Even and odd functions)

Let $V = \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ be the space of all functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, with $E = \{f : f(-x) = f(x) \text{ for all } x\}$ and $O = \{f : f(-x) = -f(x) \text{ for all } x\}$. Then $V = E \oplus O$.

Solution. Both are subspaces by the Subspace Test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)): the zero function is even and odd, and the defining equations are preserved by sums and scalar multiples. For instance, if $f, g \in O$, then $(f+g)(-x) = -f(x) - g(x) = -(f+g)(x)$.

Sum. For any $f \in V$, put $f_E(x) = \frac{f(x)+f(-x)}{2}$ and $f_O(x) = \frac{f(x)-f(-x)}{2}$. Then $f = f_E + f_O$, and $f_E(-x) = \frac{f(-x)+f(x)}{2} = f_E(x)$, $f_O(-x) = \frac{f(-x)-f(x)}{2} = -f_O(x)$. So $V = E + O$.

Intersection. If $f \in E \cap O$, then $f(x) = f(-x) = -f(x)$ for every x , so $2f(x) = 0$ and $f(x) = 0$. Hence $E \cap O = \{0\}$, and $V = E \oplus O$ by [Theorem 1.7.4](#).

For example, $e^x = \cosh x + \sinh x$ is the splitting of the exponential function.

Example. (Symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices)

Let F be a field of characteristic not 2 (for instance $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$), and let $n \geq 1$. In $M_n(F)$, let $U_+ = \{A : A^T = A\}$ be the symmetric matrices and $U_- = \{A : A^T = -A\}$ the skew-symmetric ones ([Definition 0.9.11](#)). Then $M_n(F) = U_+ \oplus U_-$.

Solution. Both are subspaces: $0^T = 0 = -0$, and by [Theorem 0.9.5](#), $(A+B)^T = A^T + B^T$ and $(cA)^T = cA^T$, so the equations $A^T = \pm A$ survive sums and scalar multiples.

Since the characteristic is not 2, we have $2 = 1+1 \neq 0$ in F , so $\frac{1}{2}$ exists ([Definition 0.7.2](#)). For $A \in M_n(F)$,

$$A = \frac{1}{2}(A + A^T) + \frac{1}{2}(A - A^T).$$

By [Theorem 0.9.5](#), $(\frac{1}{2}(A + A^T))^T = \frac{1}{2}(A^T + A)$ and $(\frac{1}{2}(A - A^T))^T = \frac{1}{2}(A^T - A) = -\frac{1}{2}(A - A^T)$. So the first piece is in U_+ , the second in U_- , and $M_n(F) = U_+ + U_-$.

If $A \in U_+ \cap U_-$, then $A = A^T = -A$, so $2A = 0$. Multiplying by $\frac{1}{2}$ gives $A = 0$. Hence $U_+ \cap U_- = \{0\}$, and $M_n(F) = U_+ \oplus U_-$ by [Theorem 1.7.4](#). The pattern is the same as even plus odd: transpose plays the role of $x \mapsto -x$.

The hypothesis on the characteristic is used twice, both times to divide by 2. [Exercise \(C1: Symmetric Plus Skew over \$\mathbb{F}_2\$ \)](#) shows what goes wrong over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Quick check. Can two 2-dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^3$ form a direct sum?

Solution. No. If the sum $U + W$ were direct, [Theorem 1.7.4](#) (c) would give $\dim(U+W) = 2+2 = 4$. But $U+W \subseteq \mathbb{R}^3$, so $\dim(U+W) \leq 3$ by [Theorem 1.6.7](#). So two planes through $\mathbf{0}$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ always share a non-zero vector.

1.7.4 Direct sums of several subspaces

For $k \geq 3$ subspaces, the tidy condition $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ has no direct replacement by pairwise intersections; we will see why in a moment. What does carry over is the zero vector test, which looks just like linear independence, and a condition that compares each subspace with the sum of **all the others**.

Theorem 1.7.5 — Direct Sum Criteria for Several Subspaces

Let $U_1, \dots, U_k$ be subspaces of a vector space V , and write $S = U_1 + \dots + U_k$. The following are equivalent:

- (a) the sum S is direct;
- (b) the only way to write $\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k$ with $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$ is $\mathbf{u}_1 = \dots = \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$;
- (c) for **every** $j = 1, \dots, k$,

$$U_j \cap \sum_{i \neq j} U_i = \{\mathbf{0}\}.$$

If moreover each U_i is finite-dimensional with a basis $\mathcal{B}_i$, and $\mathcal{B}$ is the list obtained by writing $\mathcal{B}_1, \dots, \mathcal{B}_k$ one after another, then (a)–(c) are also equivalent to

- (d) $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis of S ;
- (e) $\dim S = \dim U_1 + \dots + \dim U_k$.

Here $\sum_{i \neq j} U_i$ is the sum of the $k - 1$ subspaces other than U_j (and $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ if $k = 1$).

Idea. Condition (b) is uniqueness for the single vector $\mathbf{0}$, and just as for independence, uniqueness for $\mathbf{0}$ gives uniqueness everywhere by taking differences. For (b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c), a non-trivial way of writing $\mathbf{0}$ is the same thing as a non-zero vector $\mathbf{u}_j$ that equals minus the sum of the other pieces. For (d), a combination of $\mathcal{B}$ groups into one piece per U_i ; independence of each $\mathcal{B}_i$ turns “piece is $\mathbf{0}$ ” into “coefficients are 0”. Finally (d) $\Leftrightarrow$ (e) is count instead of check: $\mathcal{B}$ always spans S , so it is a basis exactly when its length is right.

Proof.

- (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b). The vector $\mathbf{0} \in S$ has the splitting $\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} + \dots + \mathbf{0}$. If the sum is direct, it has no other, which is (b).
- (b) $\Rightarrow$ (a). Assume (b), and let $\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{u}'_1 + \dots + \mathbf{u}'_k$ with $\mathbf{u}_i, \mathbf{u}'_i \in U_i$. Subtracting and regrouping,

$$(\mathbf{u}_1 - \mathbf{u}'_1) + \dots + (\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}'_k) = \mathbf{0},$$

where $\mathbf{u}_i - \mathbf{u}'_i \in U_i$ because U_i is a subspace. By (b), $\mathbf{u}_i - \mathbf{u}'_i = \mathbf{0}$, that is, $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{u}'_i$,

for every i . Hence every vector of S has only one splitting.

- (c) $\Rightarrow$ (c). Assume (b), fix j , and let $\mathbf{v} \in U_j \cap \sum_{i \neq j} U_i$. Then $\mathbf{v} = \sum_{i \neq j} \mathbf{u}_i$ for some $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$, and so

$$\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_{j-1} + (-\mathbf{v}) + \mathbf{u}_{j+1} + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0},$$

with $-\mathbf{v} \in U_j$ in the j -th slot. By (b), every piece is $\mathbf{0}$; in particular $-\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$, so $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$.

- (d) $\Rightarrow$ (b). Assume (c), and let $\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$ with $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$. Fix j . Then

$$\mathbf{u}_j = -\sum_{i \neq j} \mathbf{u}_i = \sum_{i \neq j} (-\mathbf{u}_i).$$

The left side lies in U_j , and the right side lies in $\sum_{i \neq j} U_i$ since each $-\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$. By (c), $\mathbf{u}_j = \mathbf{0}$. As j was arbitrary, all pieces are $\mathbf{0}$.

For the rest, assume each U_i is finite-dimensional with basis $\mathcal{B}_i = (\mathbf{b}_{i1}, \dots, \mathbf{b}_{im_i})$, where $m_i = \dim U_i$. By [Proposition 1.7.2](#), $\mathcal{B}$ spans $S = \text{span}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \cdots + \text{span}(\mathcal{B}_k)$. In particular S is finite-dimensional.

- (b) $\Rightarrow$ (d). Since $\mathcal{B}$ spans S , it remains to prove independence. Let $\sum_{i=1}^k \sum_{r=1}^{m_i} a_{ir} \mathbf{b}_{ir} = \mathbf{0}$, and group the terms by subspace: put $\mathbf{u}_i = \sum_{r=1}^{m_i} a_{ir} \mathbf{b}_{ir} \in U_i$. Then $\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$, so each $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{0}$ by (b). Since $\mathcal{B}_i$ is independent, $a_{i1} = \cdots = a_{im_i} = 0$ for each i . Hence $\mathcal{B}$ is independent, and so a basis of S .
- (c) $\Rightarrow$ (b). Assume (d), and let $\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$ with $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$. Since $\mathcal{B}_i$ spans U_i , write $\mathbf{u}_i = \sum_{r=1}^{m_i} a_{ir} \mathbf{b}_{ir}$. Then $\sum_{i=1}^k \sum_{r=1}^{m_i} a_{ir} \mathbf{b}_{ir} = \mathbf{0}$ is a combination of the independent list $\mathcal{B}$, so every $a_{ir} = 0$, and therefore every $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{0}$.
- (d) $\Rightarrow$ (e). The list $\mathcal{B}$ has length $m_1 + \cdots + m_k$, so if it is a basis of S , then $\dim S = \dim U_1 + \cdots + \dim U_k$ by [Definition 1.6.1](#).
- (e) $\Rightarrow$ (d). The list $\mathcal{B}$ spans S and has length $m_1 + \cdots + m_k$, which equals $\dim S$ by (e). A spanning list whose length is the dimension is a basis ([Theorem 1.6.4](#)). This proves the theorem. ■

For $k = 2$, condition (c) reads $U_1 \cap U_2 = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ and $U_2 \cap U_1 = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, so we recover [Theorem 1.7.4](#). The criteria (d) and (e) say that **bases of the pieces assemble into a basis of a direct sum, and dimensions add**.

For $k \geq 3$, the tempting shortcut is to check only the intersections of the subspaces two at a time. It does not work.

Warning. Pairwise intersections $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ do not make a sum direct. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, take the three lines X (the x -axis), Y (the y -axis) and D (the line $y = x$). Any two of them meet only in $\mathbf{0}$. But

$$(1, 0) + (0, 1) + (-1, -1) = (0, 0)$$

writes $\mathbf{0}$ with non-zero pieces from X , Y , D , so (b) fails and $X + Y + D$ is **not** direct. Condition (c) sees the problem: $D \cap (X + Y) = D \cap \mathbb{R}^2 = D \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$.

The same example breaks another tempting generalization. For finite sets, $|A \cup B \cup C|$ is given by inclusion–exclusion, and the dimension formula looks like its two-set case. For three subspaces

the analogous formula would be

$$\dim(U_1 + U_2 + U_3) \stackrel{?}{=} \sum_i \dim U_i - \sum_{i < j} \dim(U_i \cap U_j) + \dim(U_1 \cap U_2 \cap U_3).$$

For X, Y, D the left side is $\dim \mathbb{R}^2 = 2$, and the right side is $1 + 1 + 1 - 0 - 0 - 0 + 0 = 3$. So the formula is **false**. The reason is that $U + W$ is not a union: the dimension of $(U_1 + U_2) \cap U_3$ is not determined by the pairwise intersections. [Exercise \(C3: Three Subspaces\)](#) gives the correct replacement and a second failure.

1.7.5 Complements

Given a subspace U of V , can we always find a subspace W with $V = U \oplus W$? Such a W is called a **complement** of U in V . In $\mathbb{R}^3$, the plane U of [Example \(A plane and a line in \$\mathbb{R}^3\$ \)](#) has the complement $\text{span}((1, 1, 1))$. In finite dimension, complements always exist, and the proof is again “basis of the smaller space, then extend”.

Theorem 1.7.6 — Existence of Complements

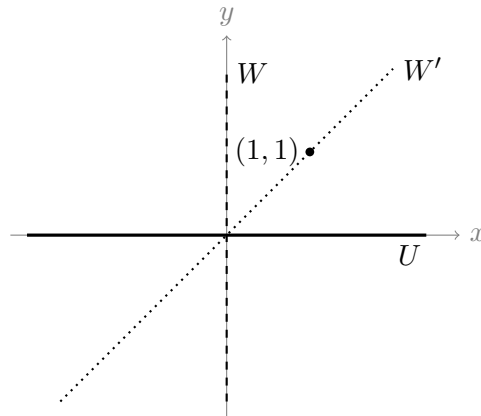
Let V be a finite-dimensional vector space and U a subspace of V . Then there is a subspace W of V with $V = U \oplus W$. Every such W satisfies $\dim W = \dim V - \dim U$.

Proof. By [Theorem 1.6.7](#), U is finite-dimensional; let $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m)$ be a basis of U ([Corollary 1.5.5](#)). This list is independent in V , so by the Basis Extension Theorem ([Theorem 1.6.5](#)) there are $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r \in V$ such that $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r)$ is a basis of V . Put $W = \text{span}(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r)$, a subspace by [Theorem 1.3.1](#).

By [Proposition 1.7.2](#), $U + W = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r) = V$. The list $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r)$ is independent, since a relation $c_1 \mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + c_r \mathbf{w}_r = \mathbf{0}$ is also a relation $0\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + 0\mathbf{u}_m + c_1 \mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + c_r \mathbf{w}_r = \mathbf{0}$ among the basis vectors of V , forcing all $c_k = 0$. So $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r)$ is a basis of W . The concatenation of the bases of U and W is a basis of $U + W = V$, so the sum is direct by [Theorem 1.7.5](#) ((d) $\Rightarrow$ (a)). Hence $V = U \oplus W$.

Finally, if W is any subspace with $V = U \oplus W$, then W is finite-dimensional ([Theorem 1.6.7](#)), and [Theorem 1.7.4](#) (c) gives $\dim V = \dim U + \dim W$, as claimed. ■

The proof made a choice: the vectors $\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_r$ that extend the basis. Different choices give different complements.



Warning. A complement is not unique. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, the x -axis U (solid) has the complement W , the y -axis (dashed), and also the complement W' , the line $y = x$ (dotted), as shown in the examples after Definition 1.7.2. So “the complement of U ” is meaningless, and $U \oplus W = U \oplus W'$ does **not** allow us to cancel U and conclude $W = W'$. What all complements share is their dimension. Also, a complement is not the set complement $V \setminus U$, which does not even contain $\mathbf{0}$.

Complements matter because a splitting $V = U \oplus W$ lets us study V one piece at a time. In Chapter 3 each such splitting gives a projection of V onto U along W , and the warning above becomes visible there: different complements give different projections. In Chapter 8 the eigenspaces of a diagonalizable operator split V as a direct sum, and that is what makes such operators easy to understand.

1.7.6 Exercises

1.7.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define the sum $U_1 + \cdots + U_k$ of subspaces of V , and what it means for the sum to be direct.
- State the dimension formula for $\dim(U + W)$, with its hypotheses.
- True or false: if $V = U + W$ and $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, then $V = U \oplus W$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: if U_1, U_2, U_3 are subspaces with $U_i \cap U_j = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ for all $i \neq j$, then the sum $U_1 + U_2 + U_3$ is direct. Justify your answer.
- True or false: if U is a subspace of V with $U \neq V$, then $V \setminus U$ is a complement of U . Justify your answer.
- Name the method used to prove the dimension formula, in four steps.

Solution.

- See Definition 1.7.1: $U_1 + \cdots + U_k = \{\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k : \mathbf{u}_i \in U_i\}$. By Definition 1.7.2, the sum is direct if every vector in it can be written as $\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + \mathbf{u}_k$ with $\mathbf{u}_i \in U_i$ in exactly one way.

- (b) If U and W are finite-dimensional subspaces of a vector space V , then $\dim(U + W) = \dim U + \dim W - \dim(U \cap W)$ ([Theorem 1.7.3](#)).
- (c) True. By [Theorem 1.7.4](#), $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ means the sum $U + W$ is direct, and it equals V .
- (d) False. The three lines X, Y, D in $\mathbb{R}^2$ (the axes and the line $y = x$) meet pairwise only in $\mathbf{0}$, but $(1, 0) + (0, 1) + (-1, -1) = \mathbf{0}$ is a non-trivial way to write $\mathbf{0}$, so the sum is not direct by [Theorem 1.7.5](#).
- (e) False. $V \setminus U$ does not contain $\mathbf{0}$, because $\mathbf{0} \in U$. So it is not a subspace, and cannot be a complement.
- (f) Take a basis of the smallest space $U \cap W$; extend it to bases of U and of W (Basis Extension); prove the Big Claim that all the vectors together form a basis of $U + W$ (spanning, then independence by moving one block across and noting the common vector lies in $U \cap W$); count.

1.7.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Two Planes in $\mathbb{R}^4$.

Let $U = \text{span}((1, 2, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1, 0))$ and $W = \text{span}((1, 3, 1, 1), (0, 0, 1, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$.

- (a) Show that $\dim U = \dim W = 2$.
- (b) Find $U \cap W$ and its dimension.
- (c) Hence find $\dim(U + W)$ and a basis of $U + W$.

Solution.

- (a) If $a(1, 2, 0, 1) + b(0, 1, 1, 0) = (a, 2a + b, b, a) = \mathbf{0}$, then $a = 0$ and $b = 0$ from the first and third entries. So the spanning list of U is independent, hence a basis, and $\dim U = 2$. Similarly $c(1, 3, 1, 1) + d(0, 0, 1, 1) = (c, 3c, c + d, c + d) = \mathbf{0}$ forces $c = 0$, then $d = 0$, so $\dim W = 2$.
- (b) A vector lies in $U \cap W$ exactly when $(a, 2a + b, b, a) = (c, 3c, c + d, c + d)$ for some $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$. The first entries give $a = c$. The second gives $2a + b = 3a$, so $b = a$. The third gives $a = a + d$, so $d = 0$; the fourth, $a = a + 0$, then holds. So the common vectors are $(a, 3a, a, a) = a(1, 3, 1, 1)$, and $U \cap W = \text{span}((1, 3, 1, 1))$, of dimension 1.
- (c) By the dimension formula ([Theorem 1.7.3](#)), $\dim(U + W) = 2 + 2 - 1 = 3$. Following its proof: $((1, 3, 1, 1), (0, 1, 1, 0))$ is a list in U (by (b), $(1, 3, 1, 1) \in U \cap W$). It is independent by [Lemma 1.5.3](#), since a multiple $c(1, 3, 1, 1)$ with first entry 0 is $\mathbf{0} \neq (0, 1, 1, 0)$. It has length $2 = \dim U$, hence it is a basis of U by [Theorem 1.6.4](#). Likewise $((1, 3, 1, 1), (0, 0, 1, 1))$ is a basis of W . By the Big Claim in the proof, $((1, 3, 1, 1), (0, 1, 1, 0), (0, 0, 1, 1))$ is a basis of $U + W$.

Exercise B2: A Plane and a Line.

Let $U = \{(x, y, z) \in \mathbb{R}^3 : x - 2y + z = 0\}$ and $L = \text{span}((1, 0, 1))$.

- (a) Prove that $\mathbb{R}^3 = U \oplus L$.
 (b) Write $(2, 0, 4)$ as $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ with $\mathbf{u} \in U$ and $\mathbf{w} \in L$.

Solution.

- (a) Solving for x , every vector of U is $(2y - z, y, z) = y(2, 1, 0) + z(-1, 0, 1)$. These two vectors are independent (look at the second and third entries), so $\dim U = 2$. Since $(1, 0, 1) \neq \mathbf{0}$, $\dim L = 1$. If $t(1, 0, 1) \in U$, then $t - 0 + t = 2t = 0$, so $t = 0$; hence $U \cap L = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. By [Theorem 1.7.4](#), $\dim(U + L) = 2 + 1 = 3$, so $U + L = \mathbb{R}^3$ by [Theorem 1.6.8](#). Therefore $\mathbb{R}^3 = U \oplus L$.
 (b) We need t with $(2, 0, 4) - t(1, 0, 1) = (2 - t, 0, 4 - t) \in U$, that is, $(2 - t) - 0 + (4 - t) = 0$. This gives $t = 3$. So

$$(2, 0, 4) = (-1, 0, 1) + 3(1, 0, 1),$$

and indeed $-1 - 0 + 1 = 0$, so $(-1, 0, 1) \in U$. By (a) this is the only such splitting.

Exercise B3: Direct or Not?.

Determine which of the following sums are direct. Justify your answer.

- (a) $\text{span}(1, x^2) + \text{span}(x, x^3)$ in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$.
 (b) $T_{\text{up}} + T_{\text{low}}$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$, where T_{up} and T_{low} are the upper and lower triangular matrices.
 (c) $\text{span}((1, 0, 0)) + \text{span}((0, 1, 0)) + \text{span}((1, 1, 1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
 (d) $\text{span}((1, 1, 0)) + \text{span}((0, 1, 1)) + \text{span}((1, 0, -1))$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution.

- (a) Direct. If $p \in \text{span}(1, x^2) \cap \text{span}(x, x^3)$, then $p = a + bx^2 = cx + dx^3$. Comparing coefficients of $1, x, x^2, x^3$ gives $a = c = b = d = 0$, so $p = 0$. By [Theorem 1.7.4](#) the sum is direct.
 (b) Not direct. The identity matrix I_2 is both upper and lower triangular, so $I_2 \in T_{\text{up}} \cap T_{\text{low}} \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$, and [Theorem 1.7.4](#) applies.
 (c) Direct. Each line has the basis given by its spanning vector, and we check that the concatenated list $((1, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0), (1, 1, 1))$ is independent. If $a(1, 0, 0) + b(0, 1, 0) + c(1, 1, 1) = (a + c, b + c, c) = \mathbf{0}$, then $c = 0$, hence $a = 0$ and $b = 0$. The list spans the sum by [Proposition 1.7.2](#), so it is a basis of the sum, and the sum is direct by [Theorem 1.7.5](#) ((d) $\Rightarrow$ (a)).
 (d) Not direct, although any two of the three lines meet only in $\mathbf{0}$ (no spanning vector is a multiple of another). Indeed

$$(1, 1, 0) + (-1)(0, 1, 1) + (-1)(1, 0, -1) = (0, 0, 0)$$

writes $\mathbf{0}$ as a sum of **non-zero** pieces from the three lines, so condition (b) of [Theorem 1.7.5](#) fails.

1.7.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Symmetric Plus Skew over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Let U_+ and U_- be the symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices in $M_2(\mathbb{F}_2)$.

- (a) Show that $U_+ = U_-$.
- (b) Deduce that $M_2(\mathbb{F}_2) \neq U_+ \oplus U_-$. Which step of [Example \(Symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices\)](#) fails, and why?

Solution.

- (a) In $\mathbb{F}_2$ we have $1 + 1 = 0$, so $-a = a$ for every $a \in \mathbb{F}_2$, and hence $-A = A$ for every $A \in M_2(\mathbb{F}_2)$. Therefore $A^T = -A$ holds if and only if $A^T = A$, which says $U_- = U_+$.
- (b) By (a), $U_+ \cap U_- = U_+$, which contains $I_2 \neq 0$. So the sum is not direct ([Theorem 1.7.4](#)). It is not even all of $M_2(\mathbb{F}_2)$: $U_+ + U_- = U_+ + U_+ = U_+$, and $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ is not symmetric. In [Example \(Symmetric and skew-symmetric matrices\)](#) both halves of the proof divide by 2: the splitting $A = \frac{1}{2}(A + A^T) + \frac{1}{2}(A - A^T)$ and the step from $2A = 0$ to $A = 0$. In $\mathbb{F}_2$, $2 = 1 + 1 = 0$ has no inverse, so neither step is available. This is exactly the case of characteristic 2 excluded by the hypothesis.

Exercise C2: Subspaces That Must Meet.

- (a) Let V be a vector space of dimension n , and let U, W be subspaces with $\dim U + \dim W > n$. Prove that $U \cap W \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$.
- (b) Deduce that any two 3-dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 4}$ contain a common non-zero polynomial.
- (c) Give an example showing that (a) fails if “ $>$ ” is replaced by “ $=$ ”.

Solution.

- (a) By [Theorem 1.6.7](#), U, W and $U + W$ are finite-dimensional, and $\dim(U + W) \leq \dim V = n$. By the dimension formula ([Theorem 1.7.3](#)),

$$\dim(U \cap W) = \dim U + \dim W - \dim(U + W) \geq \dim U + \dim W - n > 0.$$

A subspace of positive dimension has a basis with at least one vector, which is non-zero because a list containing $\mathbf{0}$ is dependent. Hence $U \cap W \neq \{\mathbf{0}\}$.

- (b) $\dim \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 4} = 5$ and $3 + 3 = 6 > 5$. By (a), the two subspaces meet in a non-zero polynomial.
- (c) In $\mathbb{R}^2$ (with $n = 2$), the x -axis and the y -axis have $1 + 1 = 2 = n$, but their intersection is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$.

Exercise C3: Three Subspaces.

- (a) Let U_1, U_2, U_3 be subspaces of a vector space V . Show that $(U_1 + U_2) + U_3 = U_1 + U_2 + U_3$.

(b) Now let U_1, U_2, U_3 be finite-dimensional. Prove that

$$\dim(U_1 + U_2 + U_3) = \dim U_1 + \dim U_2 + \dim U_3 - \dim(U_1 \cap U_2) - \dim((U_1 + U_2) \cap U_3).$$

(c) In $\mathbb{R}^3$, let $U_1 = \{z = 0\}$, $U_2 = \{y = 0\}$ and $U_3 = \{y = z\}$. Compute $\dim(U_1 + U_2 + U_3)$, every $\dim(U_i \cap U_j)$ and $\dim(U_1 \cap U_2 \cap U_3)$. Show that the inclusion–exclusion formula fails, and compare with (b).

Hint: for (b), apply the dimension formula twice.

Solution.

- (a) Both sides are subspaces by [Theorem 1.7.1](#). The right side contains U_1 and U_2 , hence $U_1 + U_2$ ([Theorem 1.7.1](#)), and it contains U_3 ; so it contains $(U_1 + U_2) + U_3$ by [Theorem 1.7.1](#). Conversely, an element $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 + \mathbf{u}_3$ of the right side is the sum of $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 \in U_1 + U_2$ and $\mathbf{u}_3 \in U_3$, so it lies in the left side.
- (b) By [Theorem 1.7.3](#), $U_1 + U_2$ is finite-dimensional with $\dim(U_1 + U_2) = \dim U_1 + \dim U_2 - \dim(U_1 \cap U_2)$. Applying the formula again to $U_1 + U_2$ and U_3 , and using (a),

$$\dim(U_1 + U_2 + U_3) = \dim(U_1 + U_2) + \dim U_3 - \dim((U_1 + U_2) \cap U_3).$$

Substituting the first equation into the second gives the formula.

(c) Each U_i is a plane, so $\dim U_i = 2$: $U_1 = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$, $U_2 = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_3)$, $U_3 = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2 + \mathbf{e}_3)$, each with an evidently independent spanning list. All three contain the x -axis $\text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.

- $U_1 \cap U_2 = \{y = z = 0\} = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.
- $U_1 \cap U_3 = \{z = 0, y = z\} = \{y = z = 0\} = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.
- $U_2 \cap U_3 = \{y = 0, y = z\} = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.
- $U_1 \cap U_2 \cap U_3 = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.

So each of these has dimension 1. Since $U_1 + U_2$ contains $\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_3$, it is $\mathbb{R}^3$, and so $U_1 + U_2 + U_3 = \mathbb{R}^3$ has dimension 3. The inclusion–exclusion formula would give

$$2 + 2 + 2 - 1 - 1 - 1 + 1 = 4 \neq 3,$$

so it fails. In (b), the last term is $(U_1 + U_2) \cap U_3 = \mathbb{R}^3 \cap U_3 = U_3$, of dimension 2, and indeed $2 + 2 + 2 - 1 - 2 = 3$. The inclusion–exclusion guess replaces this 2 by $\dim(U_1 \cap U_3) + \dim(U_2 \cap U_3) - \dim(U_1 \cap U_2 \cap U_3) = 1 + 1 - 1 = 1$, which is wrong because $(U_1 + U_2) \cap U_3$ is much bigger than $(U_1 \cap U_3) + (U_2 \cap U_3) = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1)$.

1.8 Infinite-Dimensional Spaces

Every theorem about bases so far has assumed a finite spanning list. Yet several of our running examples have none: $F[x]$ is not finite-dimensional ([Theorem 1.3.3](#)), and neither are the sequences or the functions $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Do such spaces have a basis at all? This section shows that they always do, using a principle from set theory called Zorn's Lemma, and then looks honestly at the price. The basis exists, but often nobody can write it down, and several finite-dimensional

facts stop being true.

1.8.1 Bases of infinite sets of vectors

An infinite-dimensional space cannot have a finite basis, so a basis now has to be an infinite collection of vectors. We recall the conventions for arbitrary subsets, set up with the span (Definition 1.3.2) and with independence (Definition 1.4.1). A linear combination always involves **finitely many** vectors, because the axioms only let us add two vectors at a time.

Let $S \subseteq V$ be any subset, finite or infinite.

- $\text{span}(S)$ is the set of all linear combinations $a_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{v}_k$ with $k \in \mathbb{N}$, $a_i \in F$ and $\mathbf{v}_i \in S$.
- S is **linearly independent** if **every finite list of distinct vectors** of S is linearly independent in the sense of Definition 1.4.1.
- S is a **basis** of V if S is linearly independent and $\text{span}(S) = V$.

For a finite set $S = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k\}$ of distinct vectors, these agree with the notions for the list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$, since a sub-list of an independent list is independent. The empty set is independent: its only finite list of distinct vectors is the empty list. In the infinite case we lose the ordering of a basis, and we will not need it.

Example. (A Basis of $F[x]$)

Show that $\{x^k : k \in \mathbb{N}\} = \{1, x, x^2, \dots\}$ **is a basis of** $F[x]$.

Solution. Spanning. By Definition 0.8.1, every polynomial can be written as $a_0 + a_1x + \cdots + a_Nx^N$ for some $N \in \mathbb{N}$. This is a finite linear combination of $1, x, \dots, x^N$.

Independence. Let $x^{k_1}, \dots, x^{k_m}$ be distinct monomials and suppose $a_1x^{k_1} + \cdots + a_mx^{k_m} = 0$. The left side is the polynomial whose coefficient of x^{k_j} is a_j , because the exponents k_j are distinct. The zero polynomial has every coefficient equal to 0, so by the definition of equality of polynomials, $a_j = 0$ for every j .

Hence $\{x^k : k \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is a basis of $F[x]$.

The sequence space behaves differently. Let $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ be the space of all sequences $(a_0, a_1, a_2, \dots)$ with entries in F , with entrywise addition and scaling. For $i \in \mathbb{N}$ let $\mathbf{e}_i$ be the sequence with 1 in position i and 0 everywhere else.

Example. (The Vectors $\mathbf{e}_i$ Do Not Span $F^{\mathbb{N}}$)

Show that $\{\mathbf{e}_i : i \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is linearly independent in $F^{\mathbb{N}}$, but is **not** a basis of $F^{\mathbb{N}}$.

Solution. Independence. Let $i_1, \dots, i_m$ be distinct and suppose $a_1\mathbf{e}_{i_1} + \cdots + a_m\mathbf{e}_{i_m} = \mathbf{0}$. Position i_j of the left side is a_j , since only $\mathbf{e}_{i_j}$ has a non-zero entry there. Position i_j of the zero sequence is 0, so $a_j = 0$ for every j .

Not spanning. A linear combination $a_1\mathbf{e}_{i_1} + \cdots + a_m\mathbf{e}_{i_m}$ has non-zero entries only in

the m positions $i_1, \dots, i_m$. So every vector in $\text{span}\{\mathbf{e}_i : i \in \mathbb{N}\}$ has only finitely many non-zero entries. The sequence $(1, 1, 1, \dots)$ has infinitely many, so it is not in the span.

The same example shows that $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ is infinite-dimensional. For each n , the list $(\mathbf{e}_0, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n)$ is independent of length $n + 1$. If a list of length m spanned $F^{\mathbb{N}}$, then $n + 1 \leq m$ for every n by [Theorem 1.6.1](#), which is impossible.

Warning. It is tempting to write $(1, 1, 1, \dots) = \mathbf{e}_0 + \mathbf{e}_1 + \mathbf{e}_2 + \dots$. In a vector space this sum **means nothing**: the axioms define sums of two vectors, hence of finitely many, and an infinite sum would need a notion of limit. So “the $\mathbf{e}_i$ span” is false, even though every sequence is “made of” its entries. Infinite sums return only in spaces with a notion of distance, much later.

Quick check. Let V be the space of formal power series $a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + \dots$ over F , that is, $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ with x^k standing for $\mathbf{e}_k$. Is $\{1, x, x^2, \dots\}$ a basis of V ?

Solution. No. It is independent, by the argument of [Example \(The Vectors \$\mathbf{e}_i\$ Do Not Span \$F^{\mathbb{N}}\$ \)](#). But its span consists of the series with only finitely many non-zero coefficients, which are the polynomials. The series $1 + x + x^2 + \dots$ is not among them, so the set does not span V .

So does $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ have a basis? In finite dimension we built bases by sifting ([Theorem 1.5.4](#)) or by extending one vector at a time ([Theorem 1.6.5](#)). Both constructions stop after finitely many steps. For $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ no step-by-step process can stop, and we need a different kind of existence argument.

1.8.2 Zorn’s Lemma

Look again at what a basis is in finite dimension: an independent list that cannot be enlarged ([Theorem 1.6.6](#)). “Cannot be enlarged” is a statement about the family of all independent sets, ordered by inclusion. Zorn’s Lemma is a general principle that produces objects which cannot be enlarged. To state it we need words for orderings.

A partial order is a way of comparing elements in which some pairs may be incomparable.

Definition 1.8.1 — Partial Order, Chain, Upper Bound, Maximal Element

Let P be a set. A **partial order** on P is a relation $\leq$ on P ([Definition 0.5.1](#)) such that, for all $p, q, r \in P$:

- (P1) $p \leq p$ (reflexive);
- (P2) if $p \leq q$ and $q \leq p$, then $p = q$ (antisymmetric);
- (P3) if $p \leq q$ and $q \leq r$, then $p \leq r$ (transitive).

Let $(P, \leq)$ be a partially ordered set.

- A **chain** in P is a subset $C \subseteq P$ such that for all $p, q \in C$, $p \leq q$ or $q \leq p$.
- An **upper bound** of a subset $C \subseteq P$ is an element $u \in P$ with $c \leq u$ for every

$c \in C$.

- A **maximal element** of P is an element $m \in P$ such that **no** $p \in P$ satisfies $m \leq p$ and $p \neq m$.

In words: a chain is a subset in which any two elements can be compared. An upper bound of C sits above everything in C , but it only has to lie in P , **not** in C . A maximal element has nothing strictly above it. It is **not** required to lie above everything else.

Example. (Inclusion as a Partial Order)

Let X be a set and P the power set of X (Definition 0.3.12), ordered by $\subseteq$. Check that this is a partial order, and describe chains, upper bounds and maximal elements when $X = \{1, 2\}$. Then do the same for the subsets of $\{1, 2\}$ with **at most one** element.

Solution. Every set satisfies $A \subseteq A$, which is (P1). If $A \subseteq B$ and $B \subseteq A$, then $A = B$ by Theorem 0.3.1, which is (P2). Inclusion is transitive, which is (P3).

For $X = \{1, 2\}$, the set $C = \{\emptyset, \{1\}, \{1, 2\}\}$ is a chain, while $\{1\}$ and $\{2\}$ are incomparable, so $\{\{1\}, \{2\}\}$ is not a chain. The set $\{1, 2\}$ is an upper bound of every subset of P , and it is the only maximal element.

Now let $Q = \{\emptyset, \{1\}, \{2\}\}$, still ordered by $\subseteq$. Both $\{1\}$ and $\{2\}$ are maximal: nothing in Q strictly contains either. Neither is above the other. The subset $\{\{1\}, \{2\}\}$ has no upper bound in Q .

Theorem 1.8.1 — Zorn's Lemma

Let $(P, \leq)$ be a **non-empty** partially ordered set in which **every non-empty chain** has an upper bound in P . Then P has a maximal element.

We do not prove Zorn's Lemma, and no proof is possible from the other everyday rules of set theory. It is equivalent to the **axiom of choice**, the principle already used to build right inverses of surjections in Theorem 0.4.6: from any family of non-empty sets one may choose one element from each. Mathematicians accept it as an axiom, and we do too. In this section we point out each place where it is used.

Warning. “Maximal” is not “largest”. The partially ordered set Q in Example (Inclusion as a Partial Order) has two maximal elements and no largest one. For bases this is the familiar fact that a space has many bases: in $\mathbb{R}^2$, both $\{\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2\}$ and $\{(1, 1), (1, -1)\}$ are maximal independent sets, and neither contains the other.

1.8.3 Every vector space has a basis

We prove the more general extension statement first, since the existence of a basis is the case $S = \emptyset$.

Theorem 1.8.2 — Basis Extension, General Form

Let V be a vector space over F , and let $S \subseteq V$ be a linearly independent subset. Then there is a basis B of V with $S \subseteq B$.

Idea. ① Let P be the family of independent sets containing S , ordered by $\subseteq$. ② A chain has the union as an upper bound, because an independence test uses only finitely many vectors, and finitely many members of a chain all fit inside one of them. ③ Zorn gives a maximal B . ④ If some $\mathbf{v}$ were outside $\text{span}(B)$, then $B \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$ would be a bigger independent set, so B spans.

Proof. Let P be the set of all linearly independent subsets $T \subseteq V$ with $S \subseteq T$, partially ordered by $\subseteq$ (see [Example \(Inclusion as a Partial Order\)](#)). Since S is independent, $S \in P$, so P is non-empty.

Step 1: every non-empty chain has an upper bound. Let $C \subseteq P$ be a non-empty chain and let $U = \bigcup_{T \in C} T$. Every $T \in C$ contains S and C is non-empty, so $S \subseteq U$, and $T \subseteq U$ for every $T \in C$.

Claim. If $T_1, \dots, T_k \in C$ with $k \geq 1$, then one of them contains all the others.

Proof. We use induction on k . For $k = 1$ there is nothing to prove. Suppose the claim holds for k , and let $T_1, \dots, T_{k+1} \in C$. By the induction hypothesis some T_j contains $T_1, \dots, T_k$. Since C is a chain, $T_j \subseteq T_{k+1}$ or $T_{k+1} \subseteq T_j$. In the first case T_{k+1} contains all of $T_1, \dots, T_{k+1}$, and in the second case T_j does. ■

Now let $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ be a list of distinct vectors of U . If $k = 0$, the empty list is independent. Otherwise, each $\mathbf{u}_i$ lies in some $T_i \in C$, and by the Claim one of $T_1, \dots, T_k$, say T_j , contains all the $\mathbf{u}_i$. Since T_j is independent, the list $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ is independent. Hence U is independent, so $U \in P$, and U is an upper bound of C .

Step 2: a maximal element. By Step 1 and [Theorem 1.8.1](#), P has a maximal element B . Thus B is independent and $S \subseteq B$.

Step 3: B spans V . Suppose not, and let $\mathbf{v} \in V$ with $\mathbf{v} \notin \text{span}(B)$. Then $\mathbf{v} \notin B$, since $B \subseteq \text{span}(B)$. We show $B \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$ is independent. Take a list of distinct vectors of $B \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$. If $\mathbf{v}$ is not in the list, the list lies in B and is independent. Otherwise, after reordering (which does not affect independence, as addition is commutative), the list is $(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_m)$ with distinct $\mathbf{w}_i \in B$. Let

$$a\mathbf{v} + b_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + b_m\mathbf{w}_m = \mathbf{0}.$$

If $a \neq 0$, then $\mathbf{v} = -a^{-1}(b_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \dots + b_m\mathbf{w}_m) \in \text{span}(B)$, a contradiction. So $a = 0$, and then $b_1 = \dots = b_m = 0$ because B is independent. Hence $B \cup \{\mathbf{v}\} \in P$, it contains B , and it is not equal to B . This contradicts the maximality of B . Therefore $\text{span}(B) = V$, and B is a basis of V containing S . ■

Notice where finiteness went. Steps 1 and 3 each look at only finitely many vectors at a time, which is all that linear algebra ever does. The one infinite step, “keep enlarging until you cannot”, is handed to Zorn’s Lemma.

Theorem 1.8.3 — Every Vector Space Has a Basis

Every vector space V over a field F has a basis.

Proof. The empty set is linearly independent. By Theorem 1.8.2 with $S = \emptyset$, V has a basis. For $V = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ that basis is $\emptyset$, since $\text{span}(\emptyset) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. ■

So $F^{\mathbb{N}}$ has a basis, and so do $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ and the continuous functions on $[0, 1]$. The theorem does not tell us what these bases are.

1.8.4 Existence without construction: $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$

The real numbers form a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$: add reals as usual, and multiply a real by a rational. By Theorem 1.8.3 this space has a basis, often called a **Hamel basis**. Nobody has ever written one down, and nobody will. It is known that the existence of such a basis cannot be proved without some form of the axiom of choice. What we **can** prove is that this basis is infinite. The tool is counting.

A countable set is one whose elements can be listed as a sequence, possibly with repeats.

Definition 1.8.2 — Countable Set

A set A is **countable** if $A = \emptyset$ or there is a **surjective** function $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$. Otherwise A is **uncountable**.

A surjection $\sigma: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$ lists A as $\sigma(0), \sigma(1), \sigma(2), \dots$, and every element of A appears somewhere. Repeats are allowed, so every finite non-empty set is countable. The next lemma collects what we need.

Lemma 1.8.4 — Countable Sets (a) If A is countable and $f: A \rightarrow A'$ is surjective, then A' is countable.

(b) $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ is countable.

(c) If A and A' are countable, then $A \times A'$ is countable.

(d) $\mathbb{Q}$ is countable, and $\mathbb{Q}^n$ is countable for every $n \geq 1$.

Proof.

- (a) If $A = \emptyset$, then $A' = f(A) = \emptyset$. Otherwise take a surjection $\sigma: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$. Then $f \circ \sigma: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A'$ is surjective by Theorem 0.4.3 (a composite of surjections is surjective).
- (b) For $n \in \mathbb{N}$, let 2^a be the largest power of 2 dividing $n+1$; it exists because $2^a \leq n+1$ bounds a . Then $(n+1)/2^a$ is odd, so it equals $2b+1$ for a unique $b \in \mathbb{N}$. Put $g(n) = (a, b)$. Given $(a, b) \in \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$, let $n = 2^a(2b+1) - 1$. The largest power of 2 dividing $2^a(2b+1)$ is 2^a , because $2^{a+1} \mid 2^a(2b+1)$ would force $2 \mid 2b+1$. Hence $g(n) = (a, b)$, and g is surjective.

- (c) If A or A' is empty, so is $A \times A'$. Otherwise take surjections $\sigma: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$ and $\tau: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A'$. The map $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A \times A'$, $(m, n) \mapsto (\sigma(m), \tau(n))$, is surjective. By (b) and (a), $A \times A'$ is countable.
- (d) The map $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ sending an even m to $m/2$ and an odd m to $-(m+1)/2$ is surjective, so $\mathbb{Z}$ is countable. The map $\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$, $(p, q) \mapsto p/(q+1)$, is surjective, so $\mathbb{Q}$ is countable by (c) and (a). Finally $\mathbb{Q}^{n+1}$ is $\mathbb{Q}^n \times \mathbb{Q}$ after identifying $(q_1, \dots, q_{n+1})$ with $((q_1, \dots, q_n), q_{n+1})$, so induction on n with (c) shows that $\mathbb{Q}^n$ is countable for every $n \geq 1$.

■

The real numbers are not countable. This is a fact about $\mathbb{R}$, not about linear algebra, and its proof needs one property of $\mathbb{R}$ that we take from analysis: the **nested interval property**. If $I_0 \supseteq I_1 \supseteq I_2 \supseteq \dots$ are closed bounded intervals $[a_n, b_n]$ with $a_n \leq b_n$, then some real number lies in every I_n .

Lemma 1.8.5 — $\mathbb{R}$ Is Uncountable

Assuming the nested interval property, there is no surjection $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$.

Proof. Let $r: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be any function. We build closed intervals $I_0 \supseteq I_1 \supseteq \dots$ of positive length with $r(n) \notin I_n$. Split $[0, 1]$ into the thirds $[0, \frac{1}{3}]$ and $[\frac{2}{3}, 1]$. They are disjoint, so $r(0)$ misses at least one of them; let I_0 be such a third. Given $I_n = [a, b]$ with $a < b$, the intervals $[a, a + \frac{b-a}{3}]$ and $[b - \frac{b-a}{3}, b]$ are disjoint and lie in I_n , so $r(n+1)$ misses one of them; let I_{n+1} be that one. By the nested interval property some x lies in every I_n . For each n , $x \in I_n$ and $r(n) \notin I_n$, so $x \neq r(n)$. Hence x is not a value of r , and r is not surjective.

■

Theorem 1.8.6 — $\mathbb{R}$ Is Infinite-Dimensional over $\mathbb{Q}$

The vector space $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ is not finite-dimensional.

Proof. Suppose a finite list spans $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. Appending 1 keeps it spanning, so we may take a spanning list $(b_1, \dots, b_n)$ with $n \geq 1$. Then the map

$$\mathbb{Q}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad (q_1, \dots, q_n) \mapsto q_1 b_1 + \dots + q_n b_n$$

is surjective, since every real number is a rational linear combination of $b_1, \dots, b_n$. By Lemma 1.8.4 (d) and (a), $\mathbb{R}$ is countable. This contradicts Lemma 1.8.5. Hence $\mathbb{R}$ is not finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{Q}$.

■

The proof really shows more: **every** finite-dimensional vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$ is countable. It is honest about its inputs. Linear algebra supplied only “a spanning list gives a surjection from $\mathbb{Q}^n$ ”; the rest is counting and one property of the real line.

Quick check. Is $\mathbb{C}$ finite-dimensional as a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$?

Solution. No. If $\mathbb{C}$ were countable, then $\mathbb{R} \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ would be countable too: pick any $y_0 \in \mathbb{R}$ and send $z \in \mathbb{C}$ to z if $z \in \mathbb{R}$ and to y_0 otherwise, a surjection $\mathbb{C} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, and apply [Lemma 1.8.4](#) (a). That contradicts [Lemma 1.8.5](#). So $\mathbb{C}$ is uncountable, and the proof of [Theorem 1.8.6](#), with $\mathbb{C}$ in place of $\mathbb{R}$, shows it is not finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{Q}$.

1.8.5 What changes in infinite dimension

Several finite-dimensional theorems use a count, and counting is exactly what fails here.

Warning. A proper subspace can be as big as the whole space. In finite dimension, $U \subseteq V$ with $\dim U = \dim V$ forces $U = V$ ([Theorem 1.6.8](#)). Now let $U = \{p \in F[x] : \text{the constant coefficient of } p \text{ is } 0\}$. By the argument of [Example \(A Basis of \$F\[x\]\$ \)](#), U has the basis $\{x, x^2, x^3, \dots\}$, and $x^k \leftrightarrow x^{k+1}$ matches it one-to-one with the basis $\{1, x, x^2, \dots\}$ of $F[x]$. Yet $1 \notin U$, so $U \neq F[x]$. The same happens in $F^{\mathbb{N}}$: the sequences with first entry 0 form a proper subspace, and deleting that first entry matches it one-to-one with all of $F^{\mathbb{N}}$, respecting addition and scaling. In Chapter 3 this becomes the shift map, which is injective but not surjective.

Remark. In an infinite-dimensional space, “ $\dim V = \infty$ ” hides real differences of size: $F[x]$ has a countable basis, while every basis of $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ is uncountable ([Exercise \(C2: Bases of \$\mathbb{R}\$ over \$\mathbb{Q}\$ Are Uncountable\)](#)), and set theory shows that all bases of one space have the same cardinality, a fact we will not develop.

Scope. From here on the book is mostly about finite-dimensional spaces, where bases are finite lists and counting works. Every theorem that needs finite dimension says so in its hypotheses. Infinite-dimensional spaces return with more structure, such as inner products and limits, where infinite sums can finally be given a meaning.

1.8.6 Exercises

1.8.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define what it means for an arbitrary subset S of a vector space V to be a basis of V .
- State Zorn’s Lemma, including the meaning of “chain” and “upper bound”.
- True or false: $\{\mathbf{e}_i : i \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is a basis of $F^{\mathbb{N}}$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: every linearly independent subset of an infinite-dimensional space is infinite. Justify your answer.
- True or false: in a partially ordered set, a maximal element m satisfies $p \leq m$ for every p . Justify your answer.

Solution.

- (a) S is a basis if every finite list of distinct vectors of S is linearly independent, and every vector of V is a linear combination of finitely many vectors of S .
- (b) See [Theorem 1.8.1](#) and [Definition 1.8.1](#): a non-empty partially ordered set in which every non-empty chain (a subset whose elements are pairwise comparable) has an upper bound (an element of P above every element of the chain) has a maximal element.
- (c) False. The set is independent, but $(1, 1, 1, \dots)$ is not a finite linear combination of the $\mathbf{e}_i$ ([Example \(The Vectors \$\mathbf{e}_i\$ Do Not Span \$F^{\mathbb{N}}\$ \)](#)).
- (d) False. The empty set and $\{x\} \subseteq F[x]$ are finite independent subsets of the infinite-dimensional space $F[x]$.
- (e) False. In $Q = \{\emptyset, \{1\}, \{2\}\}$ ordered by $\subseteq$, the element $\{1\}$ is maximal, but $\{2\} \not\subseteq \{1\}$ ([Example \(Inclusion as a Partial Order\)](#)).

1.8.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Finitely Supported Sequences.

Let $F^{(\mathbb{N})} \subseteq F^{\mathbb{N}}$ be the set of sequences with only finitely many non-zero entries.

- (a) Prove that $F^{(\mathbb{N})}$ is a subspace of $F^{\mathbb{N}}$.
- (b) Prove that $\{\mathbf{e}_i : i \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is a basis of $F^{(\mathbb{N})}$.

Solution.

- (a) We use [Theorem 1.2.1](#). (1) The zero sequence has no non-zero entries, so $\mathbf{0} \in F^{(\mathbb{N})}$. (2) Let $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in F^{(\mathbb{N})}$, with non-zero entries only in finite sets of positions A and A' . If $i \notin A \cup A'$, then $x_i + y_i = 0 + 0 = 0$. So $\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y}$ has non-zero entries only in the finite set $A \cup A'$, and $\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y} \in F^{(\mathbb{N})}$. (3) Let $c \in F$. If $i \notin A$, then $cx_i = c \cdot 0 = 0$, so $c\mathbf{x} \in F^{(\mathbb{N})}$. Hence $F^{(\mathbb{N})}$ is a subspace.
- (b) Each $\mathbf{e}_i$ lies in $F^{(\mathbb{N})}$, and the set is independent by [Example \(The Vectors \$\mathbf{e}_i\$ Do Not Span \$F^{\mathbb{N}}\$ \)](#). For spanning, let $\mathbf{x} \in F^{(\mathbb{N})}$ have non-zero entries only in positions $i_1, \dots, i_m$. Then $\mathbf{x}$ and $x_{i_1}\mathbf{e}_{i_1} + \dots + x_{i_m}\mathbf{e}_{i_m}$ agree in positions $i_1, \dots, i_m$ and are both 0 elsewhere, so they are equal. Hence $\{\mathbf{e}_i : i \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is a basis of $F^{(\mathbb{N})}$.

Exercise B2: Exponentials Are Independent.

For $k \in \mathbb{N}$ let $f_k \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ be $f_k(x) = e^{kx}$. Prove that $\{f_k : k \in \mathbb{N}\}$ is linearly independent. Hence deduce that $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is infinite-dimensional.

Hint: divide by the fastest-growing term.

Solution. Suppose not. Then there are distinct $k_1 < k_2 < \dots < k_m$ and scalars $a_1, \dots, a_m$, not all zero, with $a_1 e^{k_1 x} + \dots + a_m e^{k_m x} = 0$ for every $x \in \mathbb{R}$. Discarding terms with zero coefficient, we may assume $a_m \neq 0$. Dividing by $e^{k_m x} > 0$ gives, for

every $x \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$a_m = - \sum_{j=1}^{m-1} a_j e^{(k_j - k_m)x}.$$

Since $k_j - k_m < 0$ for $j < m$, each $e^{(k_j - k_m)x} \rightarrow 0$ as $x \rightarrow \infty$, so the right side tends to 0. The left side is the constant a_m , so $a_m = 0$, a contradiction. Hence the set is independent.

For each n , the list $(f_0, \dots, f_n)$ is independent of length $n + 1$. If a list of length m spanned $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$, [Theorem 1.6.1](#) would give $n + 1 \leq m$ for every n , which is impossible. Hence $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is infinite-dimensional.

Exercise B3: Continuous Functions.

Let $C[0, 1]$ be the space of continuous functions $[0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Prove that $C[0, 1]$ is infinite-dimensional.

Hint: use “tent” functions supported on disjoint intervals, and choose good points.

Solution. For $k \geq 1$, let $m_k = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{1}{k+1} + \frac{1}{k} \right)$ and $r_k = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{1}{k} - \frac{1}{k+1} \right) > 0$, the midpoint and half-length of $J_k = [\frac{1}{k+1}, \frac{1}{k}]$. Define

$$t_k(x) = \max(0, r_k - |x - m_k|).$$

This is continuous, as built from continuous functions by $|\cdot|$ and $\max$. Also $t_k(x) > 0$ exactly when $|x - m_k| < r_k$, that is, when x lies in the open interval $(\frac{1}{k+1}, \frac{1}{k})$. These open intervals are pairwise disjoint, and m_j lies in the j -th one. Hence $t_k(m_j) = 0$ for $j \neq k$, while $t_k(m_k) = r_k$.

Let $a_1 t_1 + \dots + a_n t_n = 0$. Evaluating at m_j gives $a_j r_j = 0$, so $a_j = 0$ since $r_j \neq 0$. Hence $(t_1, \dots, t_n)$ is independent for every n . As in [Exercise \(B2: Exponentials Are Independent\)](#), [Theorem 1.6.1](#) shows that no finite list spans $C[0, 1]$.

1.8.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Complements in Any Dimension.

Let U be a subspace of a vector space V , of any dimension. Prove that there is a subspace W of V with $V = U \oplus W$, that is, every $\mathbf{v} \in V$ can be written **uniquely** as $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w}$ with $\mathbf{u} \in U$, $\mathbf{w} \in W$.

Hint: [Theorem 1.8.2](#).

Solution. By [Theorem 1.8.3](#), U has a basis B_U . It is independent in V , so by [Theorem 1.8.2](#) there is a basis B of V with $B_U \subseteq B$. Let $W = \text{span}(B \setminus B_U)$, a subspace by [Theorem 1.3.1](#).

Existence. Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Since B spans, $\mathbf{v} = \sum_i a_i \mathbf{u}_i + \sum_j b_j \mathbf{w}_j$, a finite sum with $\mathbf{u}_i \in B_U$ and $\mathbf{w}_j \in B \setminus B_U$. The first sum lies in U and the second in W .

$U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. Let $\mathbf{v} \in U \cap W$. Since B_U spans U and $B \setminus B_U$ spans W , we have

$\mathbf{v} = \sum_i a_i \mathbf{u}_i = \sum_j b_j \mathbf{w}_j$ with distinct $\mathbf{u}_i \in B_U$ and distinct $\mathbf{w}_j \in B \setminus B_U$. Then $\sum_i a_i \mathbf{u}_i - \sum_j b_j \mathbf{w}_j = \mathbf{0}$ is a combination of a list of distinct vectors of B , because B_U and $B \setminus B_U$ are disjoint. Since B is independent, every a_i and b_j is 0, so $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$.

Uniqueness. If $\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u}' + \mathbf{w}'$ with $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{u}' \in U$ and $\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{w}' \in W$, then $\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{u}' = \mathbf{w}' - \mathbf{w}$ lies in $U \cap W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$. Hence $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{u}'$ and $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{w}'$. This proves $V = U \oplus W$.

Exercise C2: Bases of $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ Are Uncountable.

- (a) Let $A_0, A_1, A_2, \dots$ be countable sets. Prove that $\bigcup_{n \in \mathbb{N}} A_n$ is countable. (You may use the axiom of choice.)
- (b) Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{Q}$ with a countable basis. Prove that V is countable.
- (c) Deduce that every basis of $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ is uncountable.

Hint: for (b), write V as a union of spans of finite lists.

Solution.

- (a) Let $A = \bigcup_n A_n$. If $A = \emptyset$ there is nothing to prove; otherwise fix $a^* \in A$. For each n with $A_n \neq \emptyset$, choose a surjection $\sigma_n: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A_n$ (this is where choice is used). Define $h: \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$ by $h(n, m) = \sigma_n(m)$ if $A_n \neq \emptyset$, and $h(n, m) = a^*$ otherwise. Every $a \in A$ lies in some non-empty A_n and equals $\sigma_n(m)$ for some m , so h is surjective. By Lemma 1.8.4 (b) and (a), A is countable.
- (b) If the basis is empty, $V = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ is countable. Otherwise list the basis as $\sigma(0), \sigma(1), \dots$ for a surjection $\sigma: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow B$. Every $\mathbf{v} \in V$ is a combination of finitely many basis vectors, all among $\sigma(0), \dots, \sigma(n)$ for some n . Hence $V = \bigcup_n V_n$ with $V_n = \text{span}(\sigma(0), \dots, \sigma(n))$. The map $\mathbb{Q}^{n+1} \rightarrow V_n$, $(q_0, \dots, q_n) \mapsto \sum_i q_i \sigma(i)$, is surjective, so each V_n is countable by Lemma 1.8.4 (d) and (a). By (a), V is countable.
- (c) By Theorem 1.8.3, $\mathbb{R}$ has a basis over $\mathbb{Q}$. If some basis were countable, then $\mathbb{R}$ would be countable by (b), contradicting Lemma 1.8.5. Hence every basis is uncountable.

1.9 Changing the Field

Every vector space comes with its field, and we have already seen that the field matters: $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} \mathbb{C} = 1$ but $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C} = 2$ (Example (Dimensions of the Running Examples)). This section explains the pattern behind that example. Shrinking the field multiplies the dimension by a fixed factor, the **tower law**. Going the other way, every real vector space can be enlarged to a complex one, its **complexification**, without changing the dimension. Both moves are used later, most of all when real matrices need complex eigenvalues.

1.9.1 Restricting the scalars

Start with the standard example. The space $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{C}$ has the basis $(\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$, so its dimension is 2. But nothing stops us from multiplying vectors of $\mathbb{C}^2$ only by **real** numbers. The addition is the same, and the axioms still hold, because they hold for all complex scalars. So $\mathbb{C}^2$ is also

a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$. What is its dimension now?

Example. ($\mathbb{C}^2$ as a Real Vector Space)

Show that $(\mathbf{e}_1, i\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, i\mathbf{e}_2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{C}^2$ over $\mathbb{R}$, and write $(1 + 2i, 3 - i)$ in it.

Solution. Spanning. Let $(z_1, z_2) \in \mathbb{C}^2$ and write $z_k = a_k + b_k i$ with $a_k, b_k \in \mathbb{R}$. Then

$$(z_1, z_2) = a_1 \mathbf{e}_1 + b_1(i\mathbf{e}_1) + a_2 \mathbf{e}_2 + b_2(i\mathbf{e}_2),$$

a combination with **real** coefficients. For example, $(1 + 2i, 3 - i) = 1\mathbf{e}_1 + 2(i\mathbf{e}_1) + 3\mathbf{e}_2 + (-1)(i\mathbf{e}_2)$.

Independence. Let $a_1, b_1, a_2, b_2 \in \mathbb{R}$ with $a_1 \mathbf{e}_1 + b_1(i\mathbf{e}_1) + a_2 \mathbf{e}_2 + b_2(i\mathbf{e}_2) = \mathbf{0}$. The left side is $(a_1 + b_1 i, a_2 + b_2 i)$. Each entry is 0, and comparing real and imaginary parts (Definition 0.6.1) gives $a_1 = b_1 = a_2 = b_2 = 0$.

Hence $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}^2 = 4 = 2 \dim_{\mathbb{C}} \mathbb{C}^2$.

The general setting has a big field L , a smaller field K inside it, and a vector space over L .

Definition 1.9.1 — Subfield, Restriction of Scalars, Degree

Let L be a field. A **subfield** of L is a subset $K \subseteq L$ that contains 0 and 1 and is closed under addition, multiplication, negatives, and inverses of **non-zero** elements.

Let K be a subfield of L , and let V be a vector space over L . Keeping the addition of V and using scalar multiplication only for scalars in K makes V a vector space **over** K . We say V is obtained by **restriction of scalars**.

In particular L itself, a vector space over L , is a vector space over K . If it is finite-dimensional, its dimension is the **degree** $[L : K] := \dim_K L$.

In words: a subfield is a field sitting inside L with the same operations. Restriction of scalars forgets how to multiply by elements of L outside K .

There are two things to check. First, K with the operations of L is a field. Closure makes the operations land in K , the elements 0, 1, negatives and inverses are in K by assumption, and the remaining axioms are identities that hold for all elements of L , so in particular for those of K . Second, V over K is a vector space. Scalar multiplication $K \times V \rightarrow V$ lands in V , and each axiom of Definition 1.1.1 holds **for all** scalars in L , so in particular for all scalars in K .

We always write $\dim_K V$ or $\dim_L V$ when both fields are in play.

Example. (Degrees of Some Fields)

Find $[\mathbb{C} : \mathbb{R}]$, $[\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) : \mathbb{Q}]$ and $[K : K]$ for any field K . Is $[\mathbb{R} : \mathbb{Q}]$ defined?

Solution. $[\mathbb{C} : \mathbb{R}] = 2$. Every $z \in \mathbb{C}$ is $a \cdot 1 + b \cdot i$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, and $a + bi = 0$ forces $a = b = 0$ by Definition 0.6.1. So $(1, i)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$.

$[\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) : \mathbb{Q}] = 2$. The set $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) = \{a + b\sqrt{2} : a, b \in \mathbb{Q}\}$ is a subfield of $\mathbb{R}$ by Example

($\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ Is a Field). The list $(1, \sqrt{2})$ spans it over $\mathbb{Q}$ by definition. For independence, let $a + b\sqrt{2} = 0$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$. If $b \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{2} = -a/b \in \mathbb{Q}$, contradicting [Theorem 0.2.3](#). So $b = 0$, and then $a = 0$.

$[K : K] = 1$. The list (1) is a basis of K over K : every a equals $a \cdot 1$, and $a \cdot 1 = 0$ forces $a = 0$. This degenerate case says that restricting to the same field changes nothing.

$[\mathbb{R} : \mathbb{Q}]$ is not defined, because $\mathbb{R}$ is not finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{Q}$ ([Theorem 1.8.6](#)).

Restriction only goes **down**. The set $\mathbb{R}$ with the operations of $\mathbb{C}$ is **not** a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$: everything about addition works, but scalar multiplication leaves the set, since $i \cdot 1 = i \notin \mathbb{R}$. Enlarging the field needs a construction, which is the second half of this section.

1.9.2 The tower law

In [Example \(\$\mathbb{C}^2\$ as a Real Vector Space\)](#) we took a vector, wrote it in coordinates over $\mathbb{C}$, and then split each complex coordinate into real coordinates. The same two-stage process works for any fields.

Theorem 1.9.1 — Tower Law

Let K be a subfield of L , and let V be a vector space over L . Suppose $(a_1, \dots, a_m)$ is a basis of L over K and $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V over L . Then the list of the mn vectors

$$(a_1\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, a_m\mathbf{v}_1, a_1\mathbf{v}_2, \dots, a_m\mathbf{v}_2, \dots, a_1\mathbf{v}_n, \dots, a_m\mathbf{v}_n)$$

is a basis of V over K . In particular,

$$\dim_K V = [L : K] \cdot \dim_L V.$$

Idea. Coordinates in two stages. A vector is an L -combination of the $\mathbf{v}_j$; each L -coefficient is a K -combination of the a_i . Substituting gives a double sum $\sum_j \sum_i b_{ij} a_i \mathbf{v}_j$ with $b_{ij} \in K$. For independence, run the same two stages backwards: regroup the double sum by j , use independence over L , then independence over K .

Proof. Throughout we use two axioms of [Definition 1.1.1](#) for scalars in L : $(c + c')\mathbf{x} = c\mathbf{x} + c'\mathbf{x}$ and $c(c'\mathbf{x}) = (cc')\mathbf{x}$.

Spanning. Let $\mathbf{x} \in V$. Since $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ spans V over L , there are $c_1, \dots, c_n \in L$ with $\mathbf{x} = \sum_{j=1}^n c_j \mathbf{v}_j$. Since $(a_1, \dots, a_m)$ spans L over K , for each j there are $b_{1j}, \dots, b_{mj} \in K$ with $c_j = \sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} a_i$. Therefore

$$\mathbf{x} = \sum_{j=1}^n \left(\sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} a_i \right) \mathbf{v}_j = \sum_{j=1}^n \sum_{i=1}^m (b_{ij} a_i) \mathbf{v}_j = \sum_{j=1}^n \sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} (a_i \mathbf{v}_j),$$

where the second equality uses $(c + c')\mathbf{x} = c\mathbf{x} + c'\mathbf{x}$ and the third uses $c(c'\mathbf{x}) = (cc')\mathbf{x}$. This is a K -linear combination of the vectors $a_i \mathbf{v}_j$.

Independence. Let $b_{ij} \in K$ with $\sum_{j=1}^n \sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} (a_i \mathbf{v}_j) = \mathbf{0}$. Reading the display above

from right to left,

$$\sum_{j=1}^n \left(\sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} a_i \right) \mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{0}.$$

Each coefficient $\sum_i b_{ij} a_i$ lies in L , and $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is independent over L . Hence $\sum_{i=1}^m b_{ij} a_i = 0$ for every j . For each fixed j , this is a K -combination of $(a_1, \dots, a_m)$ equal to 0, and that list is independent over K . Hence $b_{ij} = 0$ for all i and j .

So the mn vectors $a_i \mathbf{v}_j$ form a basis of V over K , and $\dim_K V = mn = [L : K] \dim_L V$. ■

The name comes from the picture of fields stacked in a tower, $K \subseteq L$, with V on top: dimensions multiply as you go down. The most important case is $\mathbb{R} \subseteq \mathbb{C}$.

Theorem 1.9.2 — Complex Spaces as Real Spaces

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$ with basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$. Then $(\mathbf{v}_1, i\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, i\mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V over $\mathbb{R}$. In particular $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} V = 2 \dim_{\mathbb{C}} V$.

Proof. By [Example \(Degrees of Some Fields\)](#), $(1, i)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{C}$ over $\mathbb{R}$. By [Theorem 1.9.1](#) with $a_1 = 1$ and $a_2 = i$, the list $(1\mathbf{v}_1, i\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, 1\mathbf{v}_n, i\mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of V over $\mathbb{R}$, and $1\mathbf{v}_j = \mathbf{v}_j$ by [Definition 1.1.1](#). The dimension is $2n$. ■

This is the result of [Exercise \(C2: A complex space viewed over the reals\)](#), now as a case of the tower law. For example, $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}^n = 2n$, and $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}[x]_{\leq n} = 2(n+1)$, with basis $(1, i, x, ix, \dots, x^n, ix^n)$.

Warning. A subset of $\mathbb{C}^n$ can be a subspace over $\mathbb{R}$ without being a subspace over $\mathbb{C}$. The real vectors $\mathbb{R}^n \subseteq \mathbb{C}^n$ contain $\mathbf{0}$ and are closed under addition and under multiplication by **real** scalars, so they form an $\mathbb{R}$ -subspace of dimension n . But $\mathbf{e}_1 \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and $i\mathbf{e}_1 \notin \mathbb{R}^n$, so $\mathbb{R}^n$ is **not** a $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace. Always ask: a subspace over which field?

Quick check. What is $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{C})$? What is $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^2$?

Solution. $M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{C})$ has dimension 6 over $\mathbb{C}$ ([Example \(Dimensions of the Running Examples\)](#)), so $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} = 2 \cdot 6 = 12$ by [Theorem 1.9.2](#). The space $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^2$ has dimension 2 over the field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, and $[\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}) : \mathbb{Q}] = 2$ by [Example \(Degrees of Some Fields\)](#), so $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} = 2 \cdot 2 = 4$ by [Theorem 1.9.1](#).

1.9.3 Complexification

Now go up. A real matrix such as the rotation $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ moves every non-zero vector of $\mathbb{R}^2$ off its own line. In $\mathbb{C}^2$, however, it sends $(1, -i)$ to $(i, 1) = i(1, -i)$. To use such complex vectors for an arbitrary real space V , not just $\mathbb{R}^n$, we need a complex space that contains V the way $\mathbb{C}^n$ contains $\mathbb{R}^n$.

The model is $\mathbb{C}^n$ itself. Every $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{C}^n$ splits as $\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{x} + i\mathbf{y}$ with $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, its real and imaginary parts, taken entry by entry. Multiplying by $a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ gives

$$(a + bi)(\mathbf{x} + i\mathbf{y}) = (a\mathbf{x} - b\mathbf{y}) + i(a\mathbf{y} + b\mathbf{x}).$$

The right side only uses real scalars acting on real vectors. So we can copy it for any real space, exactly as $\mathbb{C}$ was built from pairs of real numbers in [Definition 0.6.1](#).

The complexification of V is the space of formal expressions $\mathbf{u} + i\mathbf{v}$ with $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in V$, multiplied by complex numbers the way the rules of algebra dictate.

Definition 1.9.2 — Complexification

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$. The **complexification** of V is the set $V_{\mathbb{C}} := V \times V$ with addition and scalar multiplication by $\mathbb{C}$ defined, for all $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}), (\mathbf{u}', \mathbf{v}') \in V_{\mathbb{C}}$ and $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, by

$$(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) + (\mathbf{u}', \mathbf{v}') := (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}', \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}'), \quad (a + bi)(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) := (a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v}, a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{u}).$$

We write $\mathbf{u} + i\mathbf{v}$ for $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$, and $\mathbf{u}$ for $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{0})$.

In words: addition is entry by entry. Multiplication by $a + bi$ is the formula forced by $i^2 = -1$. The notation is honest: $i(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{0}) = (0\mathbf{v} - 1\mathbf{0}, 0\mathbf{0} + 1\mathbf{v}) = (\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{v})$, by [Theorem 1.1.5](#) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#), so $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{0}) + i(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{0}) = (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$. Also a **real** scalar acts entrywise: $a(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) = (a\mathbf{u}, a\mathbf{v})$. So $V_{\mathbb{C}}$, restricted to real scalars, is just two copies of V .

Why $V_{\mathbb{C}}$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$. The operations land in $V \times V$. Addition is entrywise, so (commutativity, associativity, zero, negatives) follow from the same axioms in each entry of V , with zero $(\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{0})$ and negative $(-\mathbf{u}, -\mathbf{v})$. We check the scalar axioms that involve the multiplication of $\mathbb{C}$; below, $a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v}$ means $a\mathbf{u} + (-b)\mathbf{v}$, which is the same by [Theorem 1.1.8](#). Let $\alpha = a + bi$ and $\beta = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$, and $\mathbf{z} = (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$.

- $1\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{z}$: we get $(1\mathbf{u} - 0\mathbf{v}, 1\mathbf{v} + 0\mathbf{u}) = (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$, since $0\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ by [Theorem 1.1.5](#).
- $\alpha(\beta\mathbf{z}) = (\alpha\beta)\mathbf{z}$: since $\beta\mathbf{z} = (c\mathbf{u} - d\mathbf{v}, c\mathbf{v} + d\mathbf{u})$, the axioms of V give

$$\alpha(\beta\mathbf{z}) = (a(c\mathbf{u} - d\mathbf{v}) - b(c\mathbf{v} + d\mathbf{u}), a(c\mathbf{v} + d\mathbf{u}) + b(c\mathbf{u} - d\mathbf{v})) = ((ac - bd)\mathbf{u} - (ad + bc)\mathbf{v}, (ac - bd)\mathbf{v} + (ad + bc)\mathbf{u}).$$

Since $\alpha\beta = (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i$, this is $(\alpha\beta)\mathbf{z}$.

- $(\alpha + \beta)\mathbf{z} = \alpha\mathbf{z} + \beta\mathbf{z}$: with $\alpha + \beta = (a + c) + (b + d)i$,

$$(\alpha + \beta)\mathbf{z} = ((a + c)\mathbf{u} - (b + d)\mathbf{v}, (a + c)\mathbf{v} + (b + d)\mathbf{u}) = (a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v}, a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{u}) + (c\mathbf{u} - d\mathbf{v}, c\mathbf{v} + d\mathbf{u}) = \alpha\mathbf{z} + \beta\mathbf{z}.$$

The remaining axiom, $\alpha(\mathbf{z} + \mathbf{w}) = \alpha\mathbf{z} + \alpha\mathbf{w}$, is [Exercise \(B3: Working in a Complexification\)](#).

Here is the payoff: complexifying keeps the dimension, and even keeps the basis.

Theorem 1.9.3 — A Real Basis Is a Complex Basis of the Complexification

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ with basis $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$. Then $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$, that is, $((\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{0}), \dots, (\mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{0}))$, is a basis of $V_{\mathbb{C}}$ over $\mathbb{C}$. In particular $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} V_{\mathbb{C}} = \dim_{\mathbb{R}} V$.

Idea. A complex coefficient $a_j + b_j i$ on $\mathbf{v}_j$ puts $a_j \mathbf{v}_j$ into the real part and $b_j \mathbf{v}_j$ into the imaginary part. So one complex combination of the $\mathbf{v}_j$ is the same as two real combinations, one for each part, and both questions (spanning, independence) split into two real questions about $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$.

Proof. For $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbf{x} \in V$, [Definition 1.9.2](#) and [Theorem 1.1.6](#) give

$$(a + bi)(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{0}) = (a\mathbf{x} - b\mathbf{0}, a\mathbf{0} + b\mathbf{x}) = (a\mathbf{x}, b\mathbf{x}).$$

Call this identity $()$.

Spanning. Let $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) \in V_{\mathbb{C}}$. Since $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ spans V , there are $a_j, b_j \in \mathbb{R}$ with $\mathbf{u} = \sum_j a_j \mathbf{v}_j$ and $\mathbf{v} = \sum_j b_j \mathbf{v}_j$. By $()$ and entrywise addition,

$$\sum_{j=1}^n (a_j + b_j i)(\mathbf{v}_j, \mathbf{0}) = \sum_{j=1}^n (a_j \mathbf{v}_j, b_j \mathbf{v}_j) = \left(\sum_{j=1}^n a_j \mathbf{v}_j, \sum_{j=1}^n b_j \mathbf{v}_j \right) = (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}).$$

Independence. Let $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n \in \mathbb{C}$ with $\sum_j \alpha_j (\mathbf{v}_j, \mathbf{0}) = (\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{0})$, and write $\alpha_j = a_j + b_j i$ with $a_j, b_j \in \mathbb{R}$. By the same computation, $(\sum_j a_j \mathbf{v}_j, \sum_j b_j \mathbf{v}_j) = (\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{0})$. Since $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is independent over $\mathbb{R}$, all $a_j = 0$ and all $b_j = 0$. Hence every $\alpha_j = 0$.

Therefore $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n)$ is a basis of $V_{\mathbb{C}}$, and $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} V_{\mathbb{C}} = n$. ■

As a consistency check, restricting $V_{\mathbb{C}}$ back to $\mathbb{R}$ gives $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} V_{\mathbb{C}} = 2n$ by [Theorem 1.9.2](#), which matches the fact that $V_{\mathbb{C}}$ over $\mathbb{R}$ is two copies of V . The same proof works word for word for an infinite basis set, since every combination involves finitely many vectors.

Example. (The Complexification of $\mathbb{R}^n$ Is $\mathbb{C}^n$)

Show that the map $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) \mapsto \mathbf{x} + i\mathbf{y}$, from $(\mathbb{R}^n)_{\mathbb{C}}$ to $\mathbb{C}^n$, is a bijection that respects addition and multiplication by complex scalars.

Solution. Here $\mathbf{x} + i\mathbf{y}$ is computed in $\mathbb{C}^n$: its k -th entry is $x_k + y_k i$. Every $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{C}^n$ has unique real and imaginary parts entry by entry ([Definition 0.6.1](#)), so exactly one pair $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$ of real vectors maps to $\mathbf{z}$. Hence the map is a bijection.

Addition is entrywise on both sides, so it is respected. For scaling, let $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. In $(\mathbb{R}^n)_{\mathbb{C}}$, $(a + bi)(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) = (a\mathbf{x} - b\mathbf{y}, a\mathbf{y} + b\mathbf{x})$, which maps to the vector with entries $(ax_k - by_k) + (ay_k + bx_k)i$. In $\mathbb{C}^n$, the k -th entry of $(a + bi)(\mathbf{x} + i\mathbf{y})$ is

$$(a + bi)(x_k + y_k i) = (ax_k - by_k) + (ay_k + bx_k)i.$$

The two agree, so the map respects scalar multiplication. It sends the basis $(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n)$ of $(\mathbb{R}^n)_{\mathbb{C}}$ from [Theorem 1.9.3](#) to the standard basis of $\mathbb{C}^n$.

So $(\mathbb{R}^n)_{\mathbb{C}}$ is $\mathbb{C}^n$ in disguise; in Chapter 3 such a bijection will be called an isomorphism. In the same way $(M_n(\mathbb{R}))_{\mathbb{C}}$ is $M_n(\mathbb{C})$, and $(\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq n})_{\mathbb{C}}$ is $\mathbb{C}[x]_{\leq n}$. The construction earns its keep in Chapter 8, where real matrices without real eigenvalues, like the rotation above, get complex ones, and in Chapter 11, in the spectral theory of real operators.

1.9.4 Exercises

1.9.4.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define the degree $[L : K]$ of a subfield $K \subseteq L$.
- (b) State the Tower Law.
- (c) What is $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} \mathbb{C}^3$? Give a basis.
- (d) True or false: every $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace of $\mathbb{C}^n$ is an $\mathbb{R}$ -subspace. Justify your answer.
- (e) What is $\dim_{\mathbb{C}} (M_2(\mathbb{R}))_{\mathbb{C}}$?

Solution.

- (a) $[L : K] = \dim_K L$, where L is regarded as a vector space over K by restriction of scalars (Definition 1.9.1), when this dimension is finite.
- (b) See Theorem 1.9.1: if (a_i) is a basis of L over K and (v_j) is a basis of V over L , then $(a_i v_j)$ is a basis of V over K , so $\dim_K V = [L : K] \dim_L V$.
- (c) 6, with basis $(e_1, ie_1, e_2, ie_2, e_3, ie_3)$, by Theorem 1.9.2.
- (d) True. A $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace contains $\mathbf{0}$, is closed under addition, and is closed under multiplication by every complex number, in particular by every real number.
- (e) 4: $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} M_2(\mathbb{R}) = 4$ (Example (Dimensions of the Running Examples)), and Theorem 1.9.3 keeps the dimension.

1.9.4.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: A Tower over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Find $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^3$ and a basis of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^3$ over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Solution. By Example ($\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ Is a Field), $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a field, so $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^3$ is a vector space over it with basis (e_1, e_2, e_3) and dimension 3 (Example (Dimensions of the Running Examples)). By Example (Degrees of Some Fields), $(1, \sqrt{2})$ is a basis of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ over the subfield $\mathbb{Q}$. By Theorem 1.9.1,

$$(e_1, \sqrt{2}e_1, e_2, \sqrt{2}e_2, e_3, \sqrt{2}e_3)$$

is a basis of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^3$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. Hence $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})^3 = 2 \cdot 3 = 6$.

Exercise B2: Complex Matrices over $\mathbb{R}$.

Let $E_{11}, E_{12}, E_{21}, E_{22}$ be the matrix units of $M_2(\mathbb{C})$. Find a basis of $M_2(\mathbb{C})$ over $\mathbb{R}$, and write $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1+i & 2 \\ -i & 3i \end{pmatrix}$ in it.

Solution. The matrix units form a basis of $M_2(\mathbb{C})$ over $\mathbb{C}$ (Example (Standard Bases)).

By [Theorem 1.9.2](#),

$$(E_{11}, iE_{11}, E_{12}, iE_{12}, E_{21}, iE_{21}, E_{22}, iE_{22})$$

is a basis of $M_2(\mathbb{C})$ over $\mathbb{R}$, so $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} M_2(\mathbb{C}) = 8$. Splitting each entry of A into real and imaginary parts,

$$A = 1E_{11} + 1(iE_{11}) + 2E_{12} + 0(iE_{12}) + 0E_{21} + (-1)(iE_{21}) + 0E_{22} + 3(iE_{22}).$$

Exercise B3: Working in a Complexification.

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$.

- Verify that $\alpha(\mathbf{z} + \mathbf{w}) = \alpha\mathbf{z} + \alpha\mathbf{w}$ for all $\alpha \in \mathbb{C}$ and $\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{w} \in V_{\mathbb{C}}$.
- In $(\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 1})_{\mathbb{C}}$, compute $(2 - i)((1 + x) + ix)$ from [Definition 1.9.2](#), and compare with the product $(2 - i)(1 + x + ix)$ computed in $\mathbb{C}[x]$.

Solution.

- Let $\alpha = a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, $\mathbf{z} = (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$ and $\mathbf{w} = (\mathbf{u}', \mathbf{v}')$. Then $\mathbf{z} + \mathbf{w} = (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}', \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}')$, and by the distributive law in V and [Theorem 1.1.8](#),

$$\alpha(\mathbf{z} + \mathbf{w}) = (a(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}') - b(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}'), a(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}') + b(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u}')) = ((a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v}) + (a\mathbf{u}' - b\mathbf{v}'), (a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{u}) + (a\mathbf{v}' + b\mathbf{u}')),$$

where we also rearranged the sums using commutativity and associativity of addition in V . The right side is $(a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v}, a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{u}) + (a\mathbf{u}' - b\mathbf{v}', a\mathbf{v}' + b\mathbf{u}') = \alpha\mathbf{z} + \alpha\mathbf{w}$.

- Here $a = 2$, $b = -1$, $\mathbf{u} = 1 + x$ and $\mathbf{v} = x$. Then $a\mathbf{u} - b\mathbf{v} = 2 + 2x + x = 2 + 3x$ and $a\mathbf{v} + b\mathbf{u} = 2x - (1 + x) = -1 + x$. So the product is $(2 + 3x) + i(-1 + x)$. In $\mathbb{C}[x]$, $(2 - i)(1 + x + ix) = 2 + 2x + 2ix - i - ix - i^2x = (2 + 3x) + i(-1 + x)$, the same answer.

1.9.4.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: When Is a Real Subspace Complex?.

Let $W \subseteq \mathbb{C}^n$ be a subspace over $\mathbb{R}$.

- Prove that W is a subspace over $\mathbb{C}$ if and only if $i\mathbf{w} \in W$ for every $\mathbf{w} \in W$.
- Deduce that if W is a subspace over $\mathbb{C}$, then $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} W$ is even.
- Show that $W_0 = \{(z, \bar{z}) : z \in \mathbb{C}\} \subseteq \mathbb{C}^2$ is a subspace over $\mathbb{R}$ of even real dimension that is **not** a subspace over $\mathbb{C}$. So the converse of (b) fails.

Solution.

- ($\Rightarrow$) If W is a $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace, it is closed under multiplication by i .
($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $i\mathbf{w} \in W$ for every $\mathbf{w} \in W$. We use [Theorem 1.2.1](#) over $\mathbb{C}$. Since W is an $\mathbb{R}$ -subspace, $\mathbf{0} \in W$ and W is closed under addition. Let $\mathbf{w} \in W$ and $a + bi \in \mathbb{C}$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $a\mathbf{w} \in W$ and $b(i\mathbf{w}) \in W$, because W is closed under real scalars, and $(a + bi)\mathbf{w} = a\mathbf{w} + b(i\mathbf{w})$ by the axioms of $\mathbb{C}^n$. This lies in W by closure under addition. Hence W is a $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace.
- W is a subspace of the finite-dimensional $\mathbb{C}$ -space $\mathbb{C}^n$, so by [Theorem 1.6.7](#) it is

finite-dimensional over $\mathbb{C}$, and by [Corollary 1.5.5](#) it has a basis over $\mathbb{C}$, of some length k . Restricting the scalars of W to $\mathbb{R}$ gives the same real space as before, so $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} W = 2k$ by [Theorem 1.9.2](#).

- (c) Write $z = a + bi$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $(z, \bar{z}) = (a + bi, a - bi) = a(1, 1) + b(i, -i)$, so W_0 is the $\mathbb{R}$ -span of $((1, 1), (i, -i))$ and is an $\mathbb{R}$ -subspace by [Theorem 1.3.1](#). The list is independent over $\mathbb{R}$: $a(1, 1) + b(i, -i) = \mathbf{0}$ gives $a + bi = 0$, so $a = b = 0$. Hence $\dim_{\mathbb{R}} W_0 = 2$. But $(1, 1) \in W_0$ while $i(1, 1) = (i, i) \notin W_0$, because $\bar{i} = -i \neq i$. By (a), W_0 is not a $\mathbb{C}$ -subspace.

Exercise C2: A Tower of Degree Four.

Let $V = \{x + y\sqrt{3} : x, y \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}$.

- (a) Prove that $\sqrt{3} \notin \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.
 (b) Regard $\mathbb{R}$ as a vector space over its subfield $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$. Prove that V is a subspace with basis $(1, \sqrt{3})$.
 (c) Deduce that $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} V = 4$, with basis $(1, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{6})$.

Hint for (a): square both sides, and argue with remainders on division by 3.

Solution.

- (a) First, there are no integers p, q with $q \neq 0$, not both divisible by 3, and $cp^2 = 3q^2$ for $c \in \{1, 2\}$. Indeed, if $3 \nmid p$, then $p = 3t \pm 1$ and $cp^2 = c(9t^2 \pm 6t + 1)$ leaves remainder $c \in \{1, 2\}$ on division by 3, while $3q^2$ leaves remainder 0. So $3 \mid p$, say $p = 3s$. Then $9cs^2 = 3q^2$, so $q^2 = 3cs^2$, and the same remainder argument (a square not divisible by 3 leaves remainder 1) gives $3 \mid q$, a contradiction.

Now suppose $\sqrt{3} = a + b\sqrt{2}$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$. Squaring, $3 = a^2 + 2b^2 + 2ab\sqrt{2}$. If $ab \neq 0$, then $\sqrt{2} = (3 - a^2 - 2b^2)/(2ab) \in \mathbb{Q}$, contradicting [Theorem 0.2.3](#). If $b = 0$, then $a^2 = 3$; writing $a = p/q$ in lowest terms gives $p^2 = 3q^2$ with p, q not both divisible by 3, which is impossible. If $a = 0$, then $2b^2 = 3$, and $b = p/q$ in lowest terms gives $2p^2 = 3q^2$, also impossible. Hence $\sqrt{3} \notin \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$.

- (b) $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is a subfield of $\mathbb{R}$ by [Example \(\$\mathbb{Q}\(\sqrt{2}\)\$ Is a Field\)](#), so $\mathbb{R}$ is a vector space over it by restriction of scalars. We use [Theorem 1.2.1](#). (1) $0 = 0 + 0\sqrt{3} \in V$. (2) $(x + y\sqrt{3}) + (x' + y'\sqrt{3}) = (x + x') + (y + y')\sqrt{3} \in V$, since $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is closed under addition. (3) For $c \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, $c(x + y\sqrt{3}) = cx + (cy)\sqrt{3} \in V$, since $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ is closed under multiplication. So V is a subspace.

The list $(1, \sqrt{3})$ spans V by the definition of V . For independence, let $x + y\sqrt{3} = 0$ with $x, y \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$. If $y \neq 0$, then $y^{-1} \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and $\sqrt{3} = -xy^{-1} \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, contradicting (a). So $y = 0$, and then $x = 0$. Hence $(1, \sqrt{3})$ is a basis and $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})} V = 2$.

- (c) By [Example \(Degrees of Some Fields\)](#), $(1, \sqrt{2})$ is a basis of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. By [Theorem 1.9.1](#) applied to $\mathbb{Q} \subseteq \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ and the $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$ -space V , the list $(1 \cdot 1, \sqrt{2} \cdot 1, 1 \cdot \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{2} \cdot \sqrt{3}) = (1, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{6})$ is a basis of V over $\mathbb{Q}$. Hence $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} V = 2 \cdot 2 = 4$.

Chapter 2

Linear Systems and Matrices

Chapter 1 kept asking questions that end in a system of equations. Is this vector in the span of those? Is this list independent? Extend this list to a basis. Each time we solved a small system by hand and promised a systematic method. This chapter keeps that promise. Every question about finitely many vectors in F^n turns into a linear system, and linear systems have a complete algorithm: Gaussian elimination.

We do not treat the algorithm as a recipe. We prove that row operations never change the answer, that the fully reduced form of a matrix does not depend on the choices made along the way, and that the numbers it produces, pivots and free variables, measure exactly the dimensions of Chapter 1. Along the way the invertible matrices get their first full characterization, and we prove a fact Chapter 0 had to postpone: for square matrices, $AB = I$ already forces $BA = I$.

What you need. From Chapter 0, matrix multiplication read column by column ([Theorem 0.9.3](#)) and invertible matrices ([Definition 0.9.13](#)). From Chapter 1, span ([Definition 1.3.2](#)), linear independence ([Definition 1.4.1](#)), bases ([Definition 1.5.1](#)) and dimension ([Definition 1.6.1](#)).

2.0.1 Roadmap

- **Three views of a linear system.** Intersecting lines and planes, combinations of columns, and a single matrix equation; the shape of the solution set as a particular solution plus the homogeneous solutions.
- **Gaussian elimination.** Row operations, echelon and reduced echelon forms, and how to read the solutions off the reduced form.
- **Uniqueness of the reduced form.** Different sequences of row operations always reach the same reduced matrix, so pivot columns are well defined.
- **Elementary matrices and inverses.** Row operations as left multiplication, the invertible matrix theorem, and computing inverses by row reduction.
- **Rank.** Row space, column space and null space; row rank equals column rank; the Rouché–Capelli theorem; and a toolkit for the questions of Chapter 1.
- **LU factorization.** Storing elimination as a product of triangular matrices, with and without row swaps.
- **Applications.** Polynomial interpolation, balancing chemical equations, networks, and a puzzle over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

2.0.2 Named moves

- **Row operations do not change the solution set.** So simplify first, then read the answer.
- **Put it in reduced form, then read off.** Consistency, free variables, bases of the column, row and null spaces all come from the reduced row echelon form.
- **A question about vectors is a question about a matrix.** Put the vectors in as columns; independence, spanning and membership become statements about pivots.
- **Pivots count dimensions.** The number of pivots is the rank, and the free variables count the dimension of the null space.

2.1 Three Views of a Linear System

Chapter 1 kept running into the same kind of question. Is this vector in the span of those? Is this list independent? Every time, the question turned into a handful of equations in unknown coefficients, and we solved them by hand. This chapter gives those equations a name, looks at them from three sides, and turns solving them into an algorithm with a proof behind it. This first section sets up the language and answers a structural question before any computing: what can the set of all solutions look like?

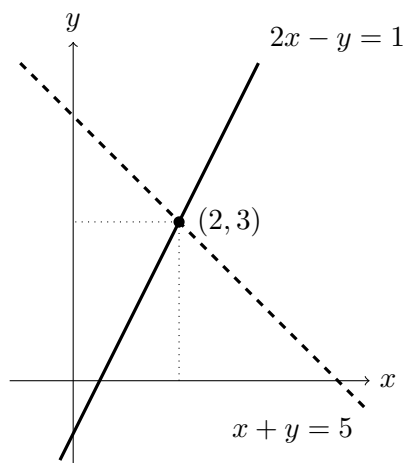
2.1.1 One system, three pictures

Here is a system of two equations in two unknowns, over $\mathbb{R}$:

$$\begin{aligned} 2x - y &= 1, \\ x + y &= 5. \end{aligned}$$

Adding the equations gives $3x = 6$, so $x = 2$, and then $y = 5 - x = 3$. We can read this one small system in three different ways, and each will be useful.

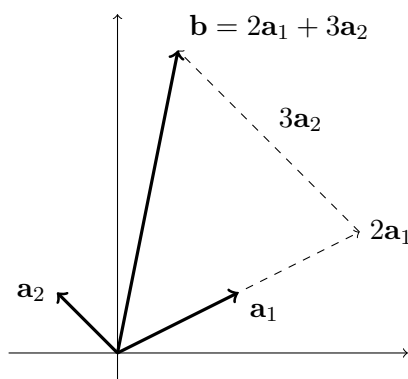
The row picture. Each equation describes a line in the plane: $y = 2x - 1$ and $y = 5 - x$. A solution is a point on **both** lines, so solving the system means intersecting them. The lines meet at $(2, 3)$.



The column picture. Stack the coefficients of x into one column and those of y into another. The system says

$$x \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} + y \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 5 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Now the unknowns are **weights**. We are asked how much of the vector $\mathbf{a}_1 = (2, 1)$ and how much of $\mathbf{a}_2 = (-1, 1)$ to combine to reach $\mathbf{b} = (1, 5)$. The answer $x = 2$, $y = 3$ says: walk twice along $\mathbf{a}_1$, then three times along $\mathbf{a}_2$.



The matrix picture. Collect the coefficients into a matrix and the unknowns into a column. By the definition of matrix multiplication ([Definition 0.9.9](#)), the system is the single equation

$$\begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} x \\ y \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 5 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \text{that is,} \quad A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}.$$

The three pictures say the same thing, and they are tied together by one fact from Chapter 0: $A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n$, a combination of the columns of A weighted by the entries of $\mathbf{x}$ ([Theorem 0.9.3](#)). The row picture is the one we draw. The column picture connects to Chapter 1, since it asks whether $\mathbf{b}$ lies in a span. The matrix picture is the one we compute and prove things with.

Remark. With more unknowns the pictures can no longer be drawn, but they do not change. An equation in three unknowns whose coefficients are not all zero describes a plane in $\mathbb{R}^3$, and a system asks where several planes meet. In the column picture, three unknowns mean three columns, and we ask whether a combination of them hits $\mathbf{b}$.

2.1.2 Linear systems

The example had two equations and two unknowns over $\mathbb{R}$. The general notion allows any numbers of each, and any field. Allowing any field is not generality for its own sake. Systems over $\mathbb{F}_2$ describe parity checks and switching puzzles, and systems over $\mathbb{Q}$ are what a computer can solve exactly.

A linear system is a finite list of equations, each saying that a fixed combination of the unknowns equals a fixed scalar.

Definition 2.1.1 — Linear system

Let F be a field and let $m, n \geq 1$. A **system of m linear equations in n unknowns** $x_1, \dots, x_n$ **over** F is a list of equations

$$\begin{aligned} a_{11}x_1 + a_{12}x_2 + \cdots + a_{1n}x_n &= b_1, \\ a_{21}x_1 + a_{22}x_2 + \cdots + a_{2n}x_n &= b_2, \\ &\vdots \\ a_{m1}x_1 + a_{m2}x_2 + \cdots + a_{mn}x_n &= b_m, \end{aligned}$$

where all a_{ij} and b_i lie in F .

- The **coefficient matrix** is $A = (a_{ij}) \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, the **right-hand side** is $\mathbf{b} = (b_1, \dots, b_m) \in F^m$, and the system is written $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$.
- The **augmented matrix** is the $m \times (n+1)$ matrix $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ obtained by appending $\mathbf{b}$ to A as a last column.
- A **solution** is a vector $\mathbf{s} = (s_1, \dots, s_n) \in F^n$ such that **every** equation holds when $x_j = s_j$ for all j ; equivalently, $A\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{b}$. The **solution set** is the set of all solutions, a subset of F^n .
- The system is **consistent** if it has **at least one** solution, and **inconsistent** if its solution set is empty.

In words: the coefficient matrix records the left-hand sides, row i for equation i and column j for unknown x_j . The augmented matrix records the whole system, and it is the object we will manipulate in the next section. A solution is a single vector of F^n , and it must satisfy all m equations at once, not just some of them. “Equivalently, $A\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{b}$ ” holds because the i -th entry of $A\mathbf{s}$ is $a_{i1}s_1 + \cdots + a_{in}s_n$ by [Definition 0.9.9](#), and two columns are equal exactly when all their entries agree.

Two small words deserve attention. A solution lives in F^n , with entries in **the field** F : the equation $2x = 1$ has the solution $\frac{1}{2}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$, but over $\mathbb{F}_2$ it reads $0 = 1$ and has none. And “consistent” means **at least one** solution, not exactly one.

Example. (None, one, or a whole line)

Find the solution set of each system over $\mathbb{R}$, and describe it in the row picture.

- $x + 2y = 1, 2x + 4y = 5.$
- $2x - y = 1, x + y = 5.$
- $x + 2y = 1, 2x + 4y = 2.$

Solution.

- Suppose (x, y) is a solution. Doubling the first equation gives $2x + 4y = 2$, while the second says $2x + 4y = 5$. Then $2 = 5$, which is false. So there is no solution, and the system is **inconsistent**. In the row picture, the lines $y = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{2}x$ and $y = \frac{5}{4} - \frac{1}{2}x$ have the same slope and different intercepts: they are parallel and never meet.
- As computed at the start of the section, any solution has $x = 2$ and $y = 3$;

conversely $2 \cdot 2 - 3 = 1$ and $2 + 3 = 5$. The solution set is $\{(2, 3)\}$, the single point where two non-parallel lines cross.

- (c) The second equation is twice the first, so a pair (x, y) satisfies both exactly when it satisfies $x + 2y = 1$, that is, when $x = 1 - 2y$. Writing t for y , the solution set is $\{(1 - 2t, t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}$. Both equations describe the **same** line, and every point on it is a solution.

The three answers are the three things two lines can do: miss, cross, or coincide. Over $\mathbb{R}$, and over any infinite field, no other sizes are possible: once we know the shape of the solution set (Theorem 2.1.3 below), this is a short argument, which you will give in Exercise (C1: How many solutions?). For instance, no system over $\mathbb{R}$ has exactly two solutions. Over a finite field the picture is different.

Example. (Exactly two solutions over $\mathbb{F}_2$)

Find all solutions of the system $x + y + z = 1$, $y + z = 0$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$. Then compare with the same system over $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution. In $\mathbb{F}_2$ we have $-1 = 1$, so the second equation says $y = -z = z$. Substituting into the first gives $x + 2z = 1$, and $2z = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$, so $x = 1$. Conversely, every $(1, z, z)$ satisfies both equations: $1 + z + z = 1 + 2z = 1$ and $z + z = 0$. Since z can only be 0 or 1, the solution set is

$$\{(1, 0, 0), (1, 1, 1)\},$$

with exactly two elements.

Over $\mathbb{R}$ the second equation gives $y = -z$, and then the first gives $x = 1$. The solution set is $\{(1, -t, t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}$, a line in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with infinitely many points. The equations are the same, but the field decides how many values the free unknown can take.

Now a non-example, by a minimal change. The equation $x + y^2 = 1$ looks like one of the equations above, and it still has a left side built from the unknowns and a constant on the right. But the unknown y appears squared, so the left side is not of the form $a_1x_1 + a_2x_2$ with **fixed scalars** a_1, a_2 . The clause that fails is “a fixed combination of the unknowns”. Its solution set in $\mathbb{R}^2$ is a parabola, not a line, and nothing in this chapter applies to it.

Warning. “**Consistent**” does not mean “has exactly one solution”. The system $x + 2y = 1$, $2x + 4y = 2$ of Example (None, one, or a whole line) (c) is consistent, and it has infinitely many solutions. Consistency only rules out the empty solution set. Whether the solution is unique is a separate question, answered by Corollary 2.1.4 below.

Why record the augmented matrix at all, when $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is shorter? Because solving a system never touches the names of the unknowns. Adding two equations adds their coefficients and their right-hand sides, and nothing else. The augmented matrix keeps exactly this data and throws away the symbols $x_1, \dots, x_n$ and the plus signs. In the next section every manipulation is performed on it.

One kind of system is always consistent, because it has an obvious solution.

Definition 2.1.2 — Homogeneous system

A linear system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ over F is **homogeneous** if $\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$. The vector $\mathbf{0} \in F^n$ is a solution of every homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, called the **trivial solution**. For any system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$, the system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, with the same coefficient matrix, is its **associated homogeneous system**.

The trivial solution exists by the zero rule of [Theorem 0.9.4](#): $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$. So for a homogeneous system the interesting question is never “is there a solution?” but “is there a **non-trivial** one?”. For example, $x + 2y = 0$, $2x + 4y = 0$ has the non-trivial solution $(-2, 1)$, while $2x - y = 0$, $x + y = 0$ has only the trivial one: adding the equations gives $3x = 0$, so $x = 0$, and then $y = -x = 0$.

Quick check. Over $\mathbb{R}$, write the system $x_1 - x_2 + 3x_3 = 4$, $2x_2 + x_3 = 0$ in the matrix picture and the column picture, and give its augmented matrix. Is $(4, 0, 0)$ a solution? Is $(1, 0, 1)$?

Solution. With $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\mathbf{b} = (4, 0)$, the system is $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$. In the column picture it reads $x_1(1, 0) + x_2(-1, 2) + x_3(3, 1) = (4, 0)$. The augmented matrix is

$$[A \mid \mathbf{b}] = \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & -1 & 3 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 \end{array} \right].$$

For $(4, 0, 0)$: $4 - 0 + 0 = 4$ and $0 + 0 = 0$, so it is a solution. For $(1, 0, 1)$: the first equation gives $1 - 0 + 3 = 4$, but the second gives $0 + 1 = 1 \neq 0$. One failing equation is enough, so it is not a solution.

2.1.3 Consistency is a question about span

The column picture turns “does this system have a solution?” into a question from Chapter 1.

Theorem 2.1.1 — Consistency and the span of the columns

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n \in F^m$, and let $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$. Then the system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent **if and only if** $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$. More precisely, $\mathbf{s} = (s_1, \dots, s_n)$ is a solution exactly when $\mathbf{b} = s_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + s_n\mathbf{a}_n$.

Proof. By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $A\mathbf{s} = s_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + s_n\mathbf{a}_n$ for every $\mathbf{s} \in F^n$. Hence $\mathbf{s}$ is a solution, that is $A\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{b}$, exactly when $\mathbf{b} = s_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + s_n\mathbf{a}_n$. This proves the second statement.

($\Rightarrow$) If the system is consistent, it has a solution $\mathbf{s}$, and then $\mathbf{b} = s_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + s_n\mathbf{a}_n$ is a linear combination of the columns. By [Definition 1.3.2](#), $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$.

($\Leftarrow$) If $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$, then $\mathbf{b} = s_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + s_n\mathbf{a}_n$ for some $s_1, \dots, s_n \in F$, and $\mathbf{s} = (s_1, \dots, s_n)$ is a solution by the first paragraph. Hence the system is consistent. ■

Read backwards, the theorem is a recipe for Chapter 1 questions: to decide whether $\mathbf{b}$ lies in the span of some vectors of F^m , put the vectors as the columns of a matrix and ask whether the system is consistent.

Example. (Span membership as a system)

In $\mathbb{R}^3$, let $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 2, 3)$ and $\mathbf{v}_2 = (0, 1, 2)$. Decide whether $(1, 4, 7)$ and $(1, 4, 8)$ lie in $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$.

Solution. Let A be the 3×2 matrix with columns $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2$. By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), $(1, 4, 7) \in \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$ if and only if the system

$$a = 1, \quad 2a + b = 4, \quad 3a + 2b = 7$$

in the unknowns a, b is consistent. The first equation gives $a = 1$, and then the second gives $b = 2$. The third equation must also hold, and it does: $3 + 4 = 7$. Hence $(1, 4, 7) = \mathbf{v}_1 + 2\mathbf{v}_2$ lies in the span.

For $(1, 4, 8)$, the first two equations are the same, so any solution has $a = 1$ and $b = 2$. The third equation now demands $3 + 4 = 8$, which is false. The system is inconsistent, so $(1, 4, 8) \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$.

Geometrically, $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$ is a plane through $\mathbf{0}$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$. The first right-hand side lies on that plane and the second does not.

2.1.4 The shape of the solution set

We now describe the solution set of an arbitrary system, starting with the homogeneous case. Chapter 1 already did the work there: in [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#) we checked, with the three conditions of the subspace test, that the solutions of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ form a subspace.

Theorem 2.1.2 — Homogeneous solutions form a subspace

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. The solution set $N = \{\mathbf{x} \in F^n : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}\}$ of the homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is a subspace of F^n .

Proof. This is [Example \(Solutions of a Homogeneous System\)](#): $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, and for $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in N$ and $c \in F$, the rules of [Theorem 0.9.4](#) give $A(\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{y}) = A\mathbf{x} + A\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$ and $A(c\mathbf{x}) = c(A\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{0}$. By the subspace test ([Theorem 1.2.1](#)), N is a subspace of F^n . ■

The solutions of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ with $\mathbf{b} \neq \mathbf{0}$ behave differently.

Warning. The solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ with $\mathbf{b} \neq \mathbf{0}$ is never a subspace. A subspace must contain $\mathbf{0}$, but $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} \neq \mathbf{b}$, so $\mathbf{0}$ is not a solution. For example, the solutions of $x - y = 1$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$ form a line that misses the origin. The sum of the solutions $(1, 0)$ and $(2, 1)$ is $(3, 1)$, and $3 - 1 = 2 \neq 1$: adding two solutions does not give a solution.

What does survive is this: the **difference** of two solutions of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ solves the homogeneous system, since $A(\mathbf{s} - \mathbf{s}') = \mathbf{b} - \mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$. So once one solution is known, every other one differs from it by a homogeneous solution. That is the whole structure.

Theorem 2.1.3 — Structure of the solution set

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$, let N be the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and suppose $\mathbf{p} \in F^n$ is **one** solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$. Then the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is

$$\mathbf{p} + N = \{\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h} : \mathbf{h} \in N\}.$$

Idea. The theorem is “particular plus homogeneous”. To prove equality of two sets, prove both inclusions. Going from a solution $\mathbf{s}$ to $\mathbf{p} + N$ uses the difference $\mathbf{s} - \mathbf{p}$, as observed above; going back uses the sum $A(\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}) = A\mathbf{p} + A\mathbf{h}$.

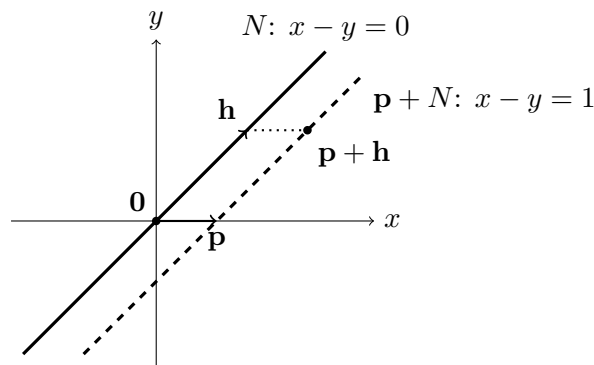
Proof. Let S be the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$. We use [Theorem 0.3.1](#).

($\subseteq$) Let $\mathbf{s} \in S$, and put $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{s} - \mathbf{p}$. By distributivity ([Theorem 0.9.4](#)), $A\mathbf{h} = A\mathbf{s} - A\mathbf{p} = \mathbf{b} - \mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$, so $\mathbf{h} \in N$. Hence $\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h} \in \mathbf{p} + N$.

($\supseteq$) Let $\mathbf{h} \in N$. Then $A(\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}) = A\mathbf{p} + A\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{b} + \mathbf{0} = \mathbf{b}$, again by distributivity, so $\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h} \in S$.

Therefore $S = \mathbf{p} + N$, as claimed. ■

The theorem splits solving $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ into two independent jobs: find **one** solution, and find **all** solutions of the homogeneous system. The set $\mathbf{p} + N$ is a translate of the subspace N by the vector $\mathbf{p}$, the kind of set that the picture in [Example \(A Line Missing the Origin\)](#) showed. For $x - y = 1$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$, the homogeneous solutions form the line $N = \text{span}((1, 1))$ through $\mathbf{0}$, one solution is $\mathbf{p} = (1, 0)$, and the solution set is the parallel line through $\mathbf{p}$.



A system solved by substitution fits the same pattern once we collect the free parameter.

Example. (Particular plus homogeneous)

Solve $x_1 + 2x_2 - x_3 = 4$, $x_2 + x_3 = 1$ over $\mathbb{R}$, and write the solution set in the form $\mathbf{p} + \text{span}(\mathbf{h})$.

Solution. The second equation gives $x_2 = 1 - x_3$. Substituting into the first, $x_1 = 4 - 2(1 - x_3) + x_3 = 2 + 3x_3$. The value of x_3 is not constrained, so write $x_3 = t$. Conversely, for every $t \in \mathbb{R}$ the vector $(2 + 3t, 1 - t, t)$ satisfies both equations, since

$(2 + 3t) + 2(1 - t) - t = 4$ and $(1 - t) + t = 1$. Hence the solution set is

$$\{(2 + 3t, 1 - t, t) : t \in \mathbb{R}\} = \{(2, 1, 0) + t(3, -1, 1) : t \in \mathbb{R}\} = \mathbf{p} + \text{span}(\mathbf{h}),$$

with $\mathbf{p} = (2, 1, 0)$ and $\mathbf{h} = (3, -1, 1)$. As [Theorem 2.1.3](#) predicts, $\mathbf{p}$ is a solution (take $t = 0$), and $\mathbf{h}$ solves the homogeneous system: $3 - 2 - 1 = 0$ and $-1 + 1 = 0$. In the row picture, two planes in $\mathbb{R}^3$ meet in a line, and this line does not pass through $\mathbf{0}$.

2.1.5 When is the solution unique?

A consistent system has a unique solution exactly when there is nothing to add to the particular solution. The theorem just proved turns this into a statement about the homogeneous system, and the column picture turns that into independence.

Corollary 2.1.4 — Uniqueness of solutions

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$, and let $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$ be such that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is **consistent**. The following are equivalent:

- (a) $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has exactly one solution;
- (b) $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution;
- (c) the list $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ is linearly independent.

Proof. Let N be the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Since the system is consistent, it has a solution $\mathbf{p}$, and by [Theorem 2.1.3](#) its solution set is $\mathbf{p} + N$.

(a $\Leftrightarrow$ b) The function $N \rightarrow \mathbf{p} + N$, $\mathbf{h} \mapsto \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}$, is surjective by definition of $\mathbf{p} + N$, and injective because $\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h} = \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}'$ implies $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{h}'$ by adding $-\mathbf{p}$ to both sides. So it is a bijection, and $\mathbf{p} + N$ has exactly one element if and only if N does. Since $\mathbf{0} \in N$ always, N has exactly one element if and only if $N = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, which is (b).

(b $\Leftrightarrow$ c) By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n$ for every $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$. So (b) says: for all $x_1, \dots, x_n \in F$, $x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$ implies $x_1 = \dots = x_n = 0$. This is word for word [Definition 1.4.1](#) for the list $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$. ■

Two remarks on the hypotheses. The equivalence of (b) and (c) does not need consistency; only (a) does. And consistency cannot be dropped from (a $\Leftrightarrow$ b): the system $x = 0$, $x = 1$ in one unknown has only the trivial solution in its homogeneous version ($x = 0$, $x = 0$), but it has no solution at all, so it certainly does not have exactly one.

So the three pictures answer the two basic questions about $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ in the language of Chapter 1: a solution **exists** when $\mathbf{b}$ is in the span of the columns, and it is **unique** when the columns are independent. What we still lack is a reliable way to decide either question for a given matrix. That is the job of Gaussian elimination, in the next section.

2.1.6 Exercises

2.1.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define what it means for a linear system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ over F to be consistent, and what its augmented matrix is. What is the size of the augmented matrix of a system of m equations in n unknowns?
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is a subspace of F^n .” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has two different solutions, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has a non-trivial solution.” Justify your answer.
- Let $A \in M_{3 \times 5}(\mathbb{R})$. In which spaces do the unknown vector $\mathbf{x}$ and the right-hand side $\mathbf{b}$ of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ live?
- Name the theorem that turns “is $\mathbf{b}$ in the span of $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$?” into a question about a linear system, and state which system.

Solution.

- It is consistent if it has at least one solution $\mathbf{s} \in F^n$, that is, some $\mathbf{s}$ with $A\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{b}$. The augmented matrix is $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$, the matrix A with $\mathbf{b}$ appended as an extra last column. It has size $m \times (n + 1)$.
- False in general. If $\mathbf{b} \neq \mathbf{0}$, then $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} \neq \mathbf{b}$, so $\mathbf{0}$ is not a solution and the solution set is not a subspace. (If $\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$, it is a subspace, by [Theorem 2.1.2](#).)
- True. If $\mathbf{s} \neq \mathbf{s}'$ are solutions, then $A(\mathbf{s} - \mathbf{s}') = \mathbf{b} - \mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$ by distributivity, and $\mathbf{s} - \mathbf{s}' \neq \mathbf{0}$.
- $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^5$, one entry per column of A , and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^3$, one entry per row.
- [Theorem 2.1.1](#): $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ if and only if $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent, where A is the matrix with columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$.

2.1.6.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Three views.

- Write the system $x_1 - x_2 + 2x_3 = 3$, $2x_1 + x_3 = 1$ over $\mathbb{R}$ in the matrix picture and in the column picture, and give its augmented matrix.
- Write out, as a list of equations, the system with augmented matrix
$$\left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & 4 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 3 & -1 & 5 \end{array} \right]$$
 over $\mathbb{R}$. How many equations and unknowns does it have? Hence decide whether it is consistent.

Solution.

- (a) The matrix picture is

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ x_3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 3 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The column picture is $x_1(1, 2) + x_2(-1, 0) + x_3(2, 1) = (3, 1)$. The augmented matrix is $\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & -1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right]$.

- (b) The system is $x_1 + 4x_2 = 0$, $x_2 = 2$, $3x_1 - x_2 = 5$: three equations in two unknowns. The second equation gives $x_2 = 2$, and then the first gives $x_1 = -8$. The third equation would require $-24 - 2 = 5$, which is false. Hence no vector satisfies all three equations, and the system is inconsistent.

Exercise B2: In the span or not?

Determine whether the vector $\mathbf{b}$ lies in the span of the given vectors. Justify your answer, and when it does, write $\mathbf{b}$ as a linear combination of them.

- (a) $\mathbf{b} = (2, 1, 4)$ and $(1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 2)$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
 (b) $\mathbf{b} = (1, 1, 1)$ and $(1, 2, 0), (2, 4, 1)$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.
 (c) $\mathbf{b} = (1, 1, 0)$ and $(1, 0, 1), (0, 1, 1)$ in $\mathbb{F}_2^3$. Is the answer the same in $\mathbb{R}^3$?

Solution. By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), in each case we decide whether the system $a\mathbf{v}_1 + b\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{b}$ in the unknowns a, b is consistent.

- (a) The system is $a = 2$, $b = 1$, $a + 2b = 4$. The first two equations force $a = 2$, $b = 1$, and then $a + 2b = 4$ holds. Hence $(2, 1, 4) = 2(1, 0, 1) + (0, 1, 2)$ is in the span.
 (b) The system is $a + 2b = 1$, $2a + 4b = 1$, $b = 1$. Doubling the first equation gives $2a + 4b = 2$, contradicting the second, since $2 \neq 1$. Hence the system is inconsistent and $(1, 1, 1)$ is not in the span.
 (c) The system is $a = 1$, $b = 1$, $a + b = 0$. The first two force $a = b = 1$, and then $a + b = 1 + 1 = 0$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$. Hence $(1, 1, 0) = (1, 0, 1) + (0, 1, 1)$ is in the span over $\mathbb{F}_2$. In $\mathbb{R}^3$ the same first two equations force $a = b = 1$, but $1 + 1 = 2 \neq 0$, so the system is inconsistent and $\mathbf{b}$ is **not** in the span. The answer depends on the field.

Exercise B3: Solve and describe.

Solve each system over $\mathbb{R}$ by substitution, and write its solution set in the form $\mathbf{p} + \text{span}(\dots)$. Check that your $\mathbf{p}$ is a solution and that your spanning vectors solve the associated homogeneous system.

- (a) $x_1 + x_2 + x_3 = 2$, $x_2 - x_3 = 1$.
 (b) $x_1 - 2x_2 + x_3 - x_4 = 1$, $x_3 + 2x_4 = 3$.

Solution.

- (a) The second equation gives $x_2 = 1 + x_3$, and then the first gives $x_1 = 2 - (1 + x_3) - x_3 = 1 - 2x_3$. With $x_3 = t$ free, every solution is $(1 - 2t, 1 + t, t)$, and conversely each such vector satisfies both equations. So the solution set is $(1, 1, 0) + \text{span}((-2, 1, 1))$.

Check: $1 + 1 + 0 = 2$ and $1 - 0 = 1$; and $-2 + 1 + 1 = 0$, $1 - 1 = 0$.

- (b) The second equation gives $x_3 = 3 - 2x_4$. The first then gives $x_1 = 1 + 2x_2 - (3 - 2x_4) + x_4 = -2 + 2x_2 + 3x_4$. The unknowns $x_2 = s$ and $x_4 = t$ are free, and every solution is

$$(-2 + 2s + 3t, s, 3 - 2t, t) = (-2, 0, 3, 0) + s(2, 1, 0, 0) + t(3, 0, -2, 1),$$

and conversely each such vector is a solution. So the solution set is $(-2, 0, 3, 0) + \text{span}((2, 1, 0, 0), (3, 0, -2, 1))$. Check: $-2 - 0 + 3 - 0 = 1$ and $3 + 0 = 3$; for $(2, 1, 0, 0)$: $2 - 2 + 0 - 0 = 0$ and $0 + 0 = 0$; for $(3, 0, -2, 1)$: $3 - 0 - 2 - 1 = 0$ and $-2 + 2 = 0$.

2.1.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: How many solutions?

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$, and let N be the solution set of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.

- Suppose F is **infinite**. Prove that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has either no solution, exactly one solution, or infinitely many solutions.
- Suppose F is **finite**. Prove that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has either no solution or exactly $|N|$ solutions.
- Give a system over $\mathbb{F}_3$ with exactly three solutions.

Hint: for (a), if N contains a non-zero vector $\mathbf{h}$, look at its multiples.

Solution.

- Suppose the system is consistent, with a solution $\mathbf{p}$. By Theorem 2.1.3 its solution set is $\mathbf{p} + N$, and as in the proof of Corollary 2.1.4 the map $\mathbf{h} \mapsto \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}$ is a bijection $N \rightarrow \mathbf{p} + N$. If $N = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, there is exactly one solution. Otherwise, let $\mathbf{h} \in N$ with $\mathbf{h} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Since N is a subspace (Theorem 2.1.2), $c\mathbf{h} \in N$ for every $c \in F$. If $c\mathbf{h} = c'\mathbf{h}$, then $(c - c')\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{0}$, and since $\mathbf{h} \neq \mathbf{0}$, Theorem 1.1.9 gives $c = c'$. So $c \mapsto c\mathbf{h}$ is injective, and N contains infinitely many vectors because F is infinite. Hence $\mathbf{p} + N$ is infinite.
- If the system is consistent with solution $\mathbf{p}$, the bijection $N \rightarrow \mathbf{p} + N$ from (a) shows that the solution set has exactly $|N|$ elements. Otherwise it has none.
- The single equation $x + y = 1$ over $\mathbb{F}_3$ (a system with $m = 1$, $n = 2$). For each of the three values of $y \in \mathbb{F}_3$ there is exactly one $x = 1 - y$, so the solutions are $(1, 0), (0, 1), (2, 2)$. Consistently with (b), the homogeneous equation $x + y = 0$ has the three solutions $(0, 0), (2, 1), (1, 2)$.

Exercise C2: The right-hand sides that work.

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$.

- Prove that the set $C = \{\mathbf{b} \in F^m : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b} \text{ is consistent}\}$ is a subspace of F^m .
- Deduce that if $n < m$, then there is some $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$ for which $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is inconsistent.

- (c) For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$, find one such $\mathbf{b}$.

Solution.

- (a) By Theorem 2.1.1, $\mathbf{b} \in C$ if and only if $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$. So $C = \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$, which is a subspace of F^m by Theorem 1.3.1.
- (b) By (a), C is spanned by the n vectors $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$. Since $\dim F^m = m$ (Example (Dimensions of the Running Examples)), Theorem 1.6.3 says no list of fewer than m vectors spans F^m . As $n < m$, $C \neq F^m$, so some $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$ is not in C , and for that $\mathbf{b}$ the system is inconsistent.
- (c) Take $\mathbf{b} = (1, 0, 0)$. A solution would satisfy $x + 2y = 1$ and $2x + 4y = 0$. Doubling the first gives $2x + 4y = 2 \neq 0$, a contradiction. So $A\mathbf{x} = (1, 0, 0)$ is inconsistent.

2.2 Gaussian Elimination

Every reader of this book has solved a system of equations by eliminating unknowns: subtract a multiple of one equation from another, and a variable disappears. Done by hand on small systems, this feels like common sense. Done on a system of 50 equations, or over $\mathbb{F}_2$, or in a proof about all systems at once, it needs to be an algorithm, and we need to know that it never changes the answer. This section makes elimination precise, proves that it always reaches a standard shape, and shows how to read every solution from that shape.

2.2.1 Three moves that do not change the answer

Here is a system over $\mathbb{R}$, solved the way one would solve it on paper:

$$\begin{aligned} x + 2y + z &= 4, \\ 2x + 4y + 3z &= 9, \\ x + 3y + z &= 5. \end{aligned}$$

Subtract twice the first equation from the second: $z = 1$. Subtract the first from the third: $y = 1$. Then the first equation gives $x = 4 - 2 - 1 = 1$.

Only three kinds of move were used, or could reasonably be used: **reorder** the equations, **multiply** an equation by a non-zero number, and **add a multiple** of one equation to another. None of them looks at the names x, y, z . Each acts on the coefficients and the right-hand side of whole equations, that is, on the rows of the augmented matrix. The first step above, for instance, replaces row 2, $(2, 4, 3 \mid 9)$, by row 2 minus twice row 1, $(0, 0, 1 \mid 1)$.

Not every move that looks harmless is safe. Multiplying an equation by 0 turns it into $0 = 0$, and a constraint silently disappears. So we list the allowed moves carefully.

An elementary row operation is a reversible move on the rows of a matrix: swap two rows, rescale one row by a non-zero scalar, or add a multiple of one row to a different row.

Definition 2.2.1 — Elementary row operations

Let F be a field and let $M \in M_{m \times k}(F)$ have rows $\mathbf{r}_1, \dots, \mathbf{r}_m$. An **elementary row operation** on M is one of the following.

- (1) **Swap** two rows: for $i \neq j$, exchange $\mathbf{r}_i$ and $\mathbf{r}_j$. Notation: $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$.
- (2) **Scale** a row: for an index i and a scalar $c \in F$ with $c \neq 0$, replace $\mathbf{r}_i$ by $c\mathbf{r}_i$. Notation: $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$.
- (3) **Replace** a row by adding a multiple of **another** row: for indices $i \neq j$ and any $c \in F$, replace $\mathbf{r}_i$ by $\mathbf{r}_i + c\mathbf{r}_j$. Notation: $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$.

In each case the rows not mentioned are left unchanged.

In words: (1) reorders, (2) rescales one row by a **non-zero** scalar, and (3) changes **one** row, row i , using a **different** row j , which itself stays as it was. We write $R_i \rightarrow R_i - cR_j$ for $R_i \rightarrow R_i + (-c)R_j$. The notation R_i refers to the current row i at the moment the operation is performed.

Take $M = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$. Then $R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2$ gives $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $R_1 \rightarrow -2R_1$ gives $\begin{pmatrix} -2 & -4 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, and $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 3R_1$ gives $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & -5 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. The degenerate case $m = 1$ is worth a glance: a one-row matrix admits no swap and no replacement, since both need two different rows, so its only elementary row operations are the scalings.

The minimal change that breaks the definition is to drop “ $c \neq 0$ ”. The move $R_2 \rightarrow 0R_2$ still replaces one row by a multiple of itself, but it sends $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ to $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, and no move of any kind can recover the lost row $(3, 1, 1)$ from that matrix. The failing clause is $c \neq 0$, and the damage is exactly irreversibility.

Warning. Perform operations one at a time. It is tempting to write “ $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2$ and $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1$ ” as one step, using the old rows in both. That is not a sequence of elementary row operations, and it can destroy information. On the system $x = 1$, $x = 1$ it produces $0 = 0$, $0 = 0$, whose solution set is all of F , not $\{1\}$. Done in order, the second operation uses the **new** row 1, $(0 \mid 0)$, and leaves row 2 unchanged, so no information is lost.

Why these three and no others? They are exactly the moves of hand elimination, and each can be undone by a move of the same kind, which is what the theorem below needs. The condition $i \neq j$ in (3) is not fussiness: “add c times row i to row i ” would be scaling by $1 + c$, which is illegal when $c = -1$ (Exercise C1).

An elementary row operation acts on the rows, but it treats each column separately: the new entry in position (i, l) is computed only from entries of column l . We record this, because it will be used again and again.

Lemma 2.2.1 — Row operations act column by column

Let $M = [M_1 \mid M_2] \in M_{m \times k}(F)$ be split into its first k_1 columns M_1 and its remaining columns M_2 . If an elementary row operation turns M into $M' = [M'_1 \mid M'_2]$ (split in the

same place), then the same operation turns M_1 into M'_1 and M_2 into M'_2 . In particular, an elementary row operation turns a zero column into a zero column.

Proof. Let m_{hl} be the entries of M and m'_{hl} those of M' . For a swap $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$: $m'_{il} = m_{jl}$, $m'_{jl} = m_{il}$, and $m'_{hl} = m_{hl}$ for $h \neq i, j$. For a scaling $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$: $m'_{il} = cm_{il}$, and other rows are unchanged. For a replacement $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$: $m'_{il} = m_{il} + cm_{jl}$, and other rows are unchanged. In each case, every entry of column l of M' is computed from column l of M alone, by the same rule for every l . Hence applying the operation to M_1 or to M_2 separately gives M'_1 and M'_2 . If column l of M is zero, each formula gives 0, since $c \cdot 0 = 0$ and $0 + c \cdot 0 = 0$ (Theorem 0.7.1). ■

For an augmented matrix, the lemma says: operating on $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ is the same as operating on A and on $\mathbf{b}$ with the same moves. Now we name what sequences of moves produce.

Definition 2.2.2 — Row equivalence

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times k}(F)$. We say A is **row equivalent** to B if B can be obtained from A by a **finite** sequence of elementary row operations. The empty sequence is allowed, so every matrix is row equivalent to itself.

In Example (Row equivalence) of Chapter 0 we met a definition that looks different: $B = EA$ for an **invertible** matrix E . In section 4 of this chapter we prove that the two definitions agree (Theorem 2.4.7), by writing each elementary row operation as multiplication by an invertible matrix. Until then, “row equivalent” means the definition above.

2.2.2 Row operations preserve solutions

Here is the promise from the start of the section, now as a theorem.

Theorem 2.2.2 — Row operations preserve solutions

Let F be a field.

- (a) (**Reversibility**) If an elementary row operation turns M into M' , then an elementary row operation **of the same type** turns M' back into M .
- (b) Row equivalence is an equivalence relation on $M_{m \times k}(F)$.
- (c) If $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ and $[A' \mid \mathbf{b}']$ in $M_{m \times (n+1)}(F)$ are row equivalent, then the systems $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ and $A'\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}'$ have the **same** solution set.

Idea. Reversibility is checked type by type, and the check for scaling is the only place where $c \neq 0$ is used. For (c), every equation of the new system is a combination of equations of the old one, so an old solution satisfies the new system. That gives one inclusion. Instead of repeating the argument backwards, reversibility gives the other inclusion for free.

Proof.

- (a) A swap $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ is undone by the same swap. A scaling $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$ is undone by $R_i \rightarrow c^{-1}R_i$, which is a legal scaling because $c \neq 0$ has an inverse $c^{-1} \neq 0$ in F (Definition 0.7.1): the row becomes $c^{-1}(c\mathbf{r}_i) = \mathbf{r}_i$. A replacement $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$ is undone by $R_i \rightarrow R_i - cR_j$. Here we use $i \neq j$: row j was not changed by the first operation, so the second one gives $(\mathbf{r}_i + c\mathbf{r}_j) - c\mathbf{r}_j = \mathbf{r}_i$.
- (b) Reflexivity holds via the empty sequence. For symmetry, suppose operations $O_1, \dots, O_s$, in this order, turn A into B . By (a), each O_t has an undoing operation O'_t . Then $O'_s, O'_{s-1}, \dots, O'_1$, in this order, turn B back into A . For transitivity, if a sequence turns A into B and another turns B into C , performing the first and then the second turns A into C , and this is still a finite sequence.
- (c) First suppose a **single** operation turns $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ into $[A' \mid \mathbf{b}']$. Let S and S' be the two solution sets. Write $\mathbf{r}_h$ for row h of A , so that equation h says $\mathbf{r}_h \mathbf{x} = b_h$, where $\mathbf{r}_h \mathbf{x}$ is a 1×1 product. Let $\mathbf{s} \in S$, so $\mathbf{r}_h \mathbf{s} = b_h$ for every h . Each equation of the new system holds at $\mathbf{s}$:
- after $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$, the new equations are the old ones in another order;
 - after $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$, the new equation i is $(c\mathbf{r}_i)\mathbf{x} = cb_i$, and $(c\mathbf{r}_i)\mathbf{s} = c(\mathbf{r}_i\mathbf{s}) = cb_i$;
 - after $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$, the new equation i is $(\mathbf{r}_i + c\mathbf{r}_j)\mathbf{x} = b_i + cb_j$, and $(\mathbf{r}_i + c\mathbf{r}_j)\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{r}_i\mathbf{s} + c(\mathbf{r}_j\mathbf{s}) = b_i + cb_j$, by Theorem 0.9.4.

The other equations are unchanged. Hence $\mathbf{s} \in S'$, and $S \subseteq S'$. By (a), a single operation turns $[A' \mid \mathbf{b}']$ back into $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$, so the same argument gives $S' \subseteq S$. Therefore $S = S'$.

For a sequence of s operations, the intermediate augmented matrices all have the same solution set, by the single-operation case applied s times (formally, by induction on s). This proves (c). ■

This theorem is the license for everything that follows: we may transform a system as much as we like by row operations, and the solutions of the final system are the solutions of the original one. What it does **not** license is just as important.

Warning. Scaling by 0 is not a row operation, and it changes the solution set. Over $\mathbb{R}$, the system $x + y = 2$, $x - y = 0$ has exactly one solution, $(1, 1)$. Applying the illegal move $R_2 \rightarrow 0R_2$ gives $x + y = 2$, $0 = 0$, whose solutions $(2 - t, t)$ form a whole line. The inclusion $S \subseteq S'$ in the proof above still holds; what fails is reversibility, and with it $S' \subseteq S$.

Warning. Column operations are not allowed. Operations on the columns of $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ mix up the unknowns. The system $x + y = 3$, $x - y = 1$ has the unique solution $(2, 1)$. Adding column 1 to column 2 of its augmented matrix gives $\left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$, the system $x + 2y = 3$, $x = 1$, whose only solution is $(1, 1)$. Even swapping two columns of A swaps the corresponding entries of every solution.

2.2.3 Echelon forms

Row operations can change a system a great deal. We now choose a target: a shape of matrix from which the solutions can be read off with no further work. Look at the finished computation from the start of the section. After eliminating, the augmented matrix could be brought to

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right],$$

which says $x = 1$, $y = 1$, $z = 1$ outright. Not every system can be brought to this shape, since not every system has exactly one solution. The general target is a staircase.

For a non-zero row of a matrix, its **leading entry** is its first non-zero entry, reading from the left.

A matrix is in row echelon form when its non-zero rows come first and their leading entries step strictly to the right as we go down.

Definition 2.2.3 — Row echelon form

A matrix $R \in M_{m \times k}(F)$ is in **row echelon form** if:

- (E1) there is an integer r with $0 \leq r \leq m$ such that rows $1, \dots, r$ are non-zero and rows $r+1, \dots, m$ are zero; and
- (E2) if the leading entry of row i lies in column j_i , for $i = 1, \dots, r$, then $j_1 < j_2 < \dots < j_r$, **strictly**.

The leading entries of rows $1, \dots, r$ are the **pivots** of R , and the columns $j_1, \dots, j_r$ are its **pivot columns**.

In words: (E1) says zero rows sit at the bottom, and (E2) says each pivot lies strictly to the right of the pivot above it. Two consequences are used constantly. Each row contains at most one pivot, so there are at most m pivots. And **every entry below a pivot is zero**: if $h > i$, then row h is zero or has its leading entry in column $j_h > j_i$, so its entry in column j_i is 0.

Definition 2.2.4 — Reduced row echelon form

A matrix $R \in M_{m \times k}(F)$ is in **reduced row echelon form (RREF)** if it is in row echelon form, with pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r$, and moreover:

- (E3) every pivot equals 1: $r_{ij_i} = 1$ for $i = 1, \dots, r$; and
- (E4) every pivot is the **only** non-zero entry in its column: $r_{hj_i} = 0$ for all $h \neq i$.

In words: (E3) normalizes the pivots, and (E4) clears the entries **above** each pivot as well as below. Together they say that the pivot column j_i is the standard basis vector $\mathbf{e}_i \in F^m$.

Example. (Echelon or not?)

Decide which of the following real matrices are in row echelon form, and which are in

reduced row echelon form. Give the pivot columns where they exist.

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Q = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 5 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad T = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Z = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Solution. P is in row echelon form: rows 1 and 2 are non-zero, row 3 is zero, and the leading entries lie in columns $1 < 3$. The pivot columns are 1 and 3. It is **not** reduced: the pivot 2 is not 1, failing (E3), and column 3 has the non-zero entry 3 above the pivot -1 , failing (E4).

Q is in reduced row echelon form, with pivot columns 1 and 3. Both pivots are 1, and columns 1 and 3 are $\mathbf{e}_1$ and $\mathbf{e}_2$. The entries 5, 2, 3 in the non-pivot columns 2 and 4 are allowed to be anything.

T is **not** in row echelon form. Its leading entries lie in columns 1, 3, 2, and $3 < 2$ fails, so (E2) fails. Swapping rows 2 and 3 would repair it.

Z is in reduced row echelon form, with $r = 0$: there are no pivots, and (E2)–(E4) hold vacuously. This degenerate case matters, because the zero matrix must have an RREF too, and it is itself.

For Q , a minimal change gives a non-example: replacing the 0 in position $(1, 3)$ by 4 keeps (E1)–(E3), but column 3 now has the non-zero entry 4 above its pivot, so (E4) fails.

Why insist on the reduced form, when row echelon form already allows back substitution? Because a system in reduced form needs **no** substitution: each pivot variable appears in exactly one equation. More importantly, the reduced form turns out to be **unique**: a matrix is row equivalent to exactly one matrix in RREF, however the operations are chosen. That is proved in the next section, and it is what makes later definitions, such as the rank, independent of choices. Row echelon form is not unique, as the warning after the worked example shows.

Quick check. Is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ in reduced row echelon form? If it is the coefficient matrix of a homogeneous system in x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4 , which unknowns correspond to pivot columns?

Solution. Yes. Row 3 is the only zero row and it is last; the leading entries lie in columns $1 < 3$; both are 1; and columns 1 and 3 are $\mathbf{e}_1$ and $\mathbf{e}_2$. The pivot columns are 1 and 3, so the unknowns x_1 and x_3 correspond to pivots, and x_2, x_4 do not.

2.2.4 Gauss–Jordan elimination

We now show that every matrix can be brought to reduced row echelon form. The procedure works through the columns from left to right, keeping a count r of the pivots found so far.

Gauss–Jordan elimination. Input: $M \in M_{m \times k}(F)$. Set $r = 0$. For $l = 1, 2, \dots, k$ in turn:

1. Look for a row h with $h > r$ whose entry in column l is non-zero. If there is none, column l gets no pivot; go on to the next l .

2. Otherwise choose such an h . If $h \neq r + 1$, perform $R_{r+1} \leftrightarrow R_h$.
3. Let $a \neq 0$ be the entry now in position $(r + 1, l)$. Perform $R_{r+1} \rightarrow a^{-1}R_{r+1}$, so that this entry becomes 1.
4. For every row $g \neq r + 1$ whose entry c in column l is non-zero, perform $R_g \rightarrow R_g - cR_{r+1}$.
5. Increase r by 1.

Output: the final matrix, which is in reduced row echelon form, with r pivots.

Step 2 involves a choice: any non-zero entry will do. By hand, we choose one that avoids fractions. If we skip the scaling in step 3 and clear only the entries **below** the pivot a , by $R_g \rightarrow R_g - ca^{-1}R_{r+1}$ for the rows $g > r + 1$, the output is a row echelon form instead; this cheaper variant is **Gaussian elimination**, and it is followed by back substitution.

Theorem 2.2.3 — Existence of the reduced row echelon form

Let F be a field. Every matrix $M \in M_{m \times k}(F)$ is row equivalent to a matrix in reduced row echelon form.

Idea. We prove that the algorithm works, by induction on the number l of columns processed. The invariant is: the first l columns of the current matrix form a matrix in RREF. When a new column is processed, all the operations involve only rows below the pivots found so far, or add multiples of the new pivot row, which is zero in the first l columns. So the part already built is never disturbed. After all k columns, the whole matrix is in RREF.

Proof. For $0 \leq l \leq k$, let $P(l)$ be the statement: there is a matrix M_l row equivalent to M and an integer $r \geq 0$ such that the $m \times l$ matrix L formed by the first l columns of M_l is in reduced row echelon form with exactly r non-zero rows. We prove $P(l)$ for all l by induction (Theorem 0.2.7). For $l = 0$ take $M_0 = M$ and $r = 0$; there are no columns, so there is nothing to check.

Suppose $P(l)$ holds for some $l < k$, with M_l , L and r as described, and let $j_1 < \dots < j_r \leq l$ be the pivot columns of L . By (E1) for L , rows $r + 1, \dots, m$ of M_l are zero in columns $1, \dots, l$. Let L' denote the first $l + 1$ columns of the matrix we are about to construct.

Case 1: every entry of column $l + 1$ of M_l in rows $h > r$ is zero (this includes the case $r = m$). Put $M_{l+1} = M_l$. Rows $r + 1, \dots, m$ of L' are zero, and rows $1, \dots, r$ are non-zero with the same leading entries as in L , which lie in columns $\leq l$. So (E1)–(E3) hold for L' with the same r and pivot columns, and so does (E4), since the pivot columns of L' are those of L and are unchanged. Hence L' is in RREF and $P(l + 1)$ holds.

Case 2: some row $h > r$ has a non-zero entry in column $l + 1$. Then $r + 1 \leq h \leq m$. Perform steps 2, 3 and 4 of the algorithm with this h and with column $l + 1$; call the result M_{l+1} . It is row equivalent to M_l , hence to M , by Theorem 2.2.2 (b).

These operations do not change columns $1, \dots, l$. Indeed, the swap in step 2 and the scaling in step 3 only move or rescale rows h and $r + 1$, which are both zero in those columns. Each replacement $R_g \rightarrow R_g - cR_{r+1}$ in step 4 adds a multiple of row $r + 1$, which is still zero in columns $1, \dots, l$. So the first l columns of M_{l+1} form the matrix L . In column $l + 1$, step 3 makes the entry in row $r + 1$ equal to 1, and each replacement in step 4 makes the entry of row g equal to $c - c \cdot 1 = 0$ without changing any other row. So column $l + 1$ of M_{l+1} is $\mathbf{e}_{r+1}$.

We check that L' is in RREF with $r + 1$ non-zero rows. Rows $1, \dots, r$ of L' have the same leading entries as in L , in columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r \leq l$. Row $r + 1$ is zero in columns $1, \dots, l$ and has a 1 in column $l + 1$, so its leading entry is in column $j_{r+1} := l + 1 > j_r$. Rows $r + 2, \dots, m$ are zero in columns $1, \dots, l$ and in column $l + 1$, so they are zero. This gives (E1) and (E2). The pivots are 1, by (E3) for L and the construction, so (E3) holds. For (E4), the columns $j_1, \dots, j_r$ are unchanged from L , and column $l + 1$ is $\mathbf{e}_{r+1}$. Hence $P(l + 1)$ holds.

By induction $P(k)$ holds: M_k is row equivalent to M , and its first k columns, which are all of M_k , form a matrix in reduced row echelon form. This proves the theorem. ■

The proof is also the correctness proof of the algorithm: the matrix M_l is the state of the computation after column l . Note where the field axioms were used. Step 3 divides by $a \neq 0$, which needs (F8), and nothing else in the argument depends on which field we work over.

Example. (Gauss–Jordan on a 3×4 system)

Solve the following system over $\mathbb{R}$ by Gauss–Jordan elimination, naming each operation:

$$\begin{aligned} 2x_2 - 2x_3 + x_4 &= 3, \\ x_1 + x_2 + x_3 &= 3, \\ 2x_1 + x_2 + 3x_3 + x_4 &= 3. \end{aligned}$$

Solution. We work on the augmented matrix. **Column 1.** Row 1 has a 0 there, so we bring up row 2, whose entry is already 1. Then we clear the rest of column 1.

$$\left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 & 1 & 3 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 & 1 & 3 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 1 & -3 \end{array} \right]$$

Column 2. The candidates below row 1 are 2 and -1 . Choosing -1 avoids fractions, so we swap it up and scale.

$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 1 & -3 \\ 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow -R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \end{array} \right]$$

Now clear column 2 above and below the pivot.

$$\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & -2 & 1 & 3 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 3 & -3 \end{array} \right]$$

Column 3. The only entry below row 2 is 0, so column 3 gets no pivot. **Column 4.** The entry 3 in row 3 becomes the pivot.

$$\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow \frac{1}{3}R_3} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_3} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \end{array} \right]$$

Column 5. No rows remain below row 3, so we stop. The final matrix is in RREF, with pivot columns 1, 2 and 4. It is the system

$$x_1 + 2x_3 = 1, \quad x_2 - x_3 = 2, \quad x_4 = -1,$$

which by [Theorem 2.2.2](#) has the same solutions as the original. The unknown x_3 is unconstrained; writing $x_3 = t$, the solutions are

$$(1 - 2t, 2 + t, t, -1) = (1, 2, 0, -1) + t(-2, 1, 1, 0), \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Check: $(1, 2, 0, -1)$ gives $4 + 0 - 1 = 3$, $1 + 2 + 0 = 3$ and $2 + 2 + 0 - 1 = 3$; and $(-2, 1, 1, 0)$ gives $2 - 2 + 0 = 0$, $-2 + 1 + 1 = 0$ and $-4 + 1 + 3 + 0 = 0$. This is the “particular plus homogeneous” form of [Theorem 2.1.3](#).

A computer algebra system does the same computation exactly. In the online version the cell below can be edited and run, which is a good way to check a hand computation.

```
from sympy import Matrix

M = Matrix([
    [0, 2, -2, 1, 3],
    [1, 1, 1, 0, 3],
    [2, 1, 3, 1, 3],
])
R, pivots = M.rref() # the RREF and the (0-based) pivot columns
print(R)
print("pivot columns:", [j + 1 for j in pivots])
```

Warning. Echelon forms are not unique; only the reduced form is. Different choices in step 2 give different intermediate matrices. For $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$, the operation $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 3R_1$ gives the row echelon form $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & -2 \end{pmatrix}$. Starting instead with $R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2$ and then $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - \frac{1}{3}R_1$ gives the row echelon form $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 0 & \frac{2}{3} \end{pmatrix}$. Both continue to the same RREF, I_2 . That this always happens is the theorem of the next section; until it is proved, “the” RREF of a matrix is not yet justified.

2.2.5 Reading off the solutions

Once $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ is in reduced row echelon form, the example shows what to do: a pivot in the last column signals a contradiction, and otherwise the unknowns without pivots can be chosen freely. We name the two kinds of unknowns.

Suppose $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$, with $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, is row equivalent to a matrix $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ in reduced row echelon form, where R is $m \times n$. For $l \leq n$, the unknown x_l is a **pivot variable** if l is a pivot column of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$, and a **free variable** otherwise. (By the uniqueness theorem of the next section, this does not depend on which sequence of operations was used.)

Theorem 2.2.4 — Reading solutions from the RREF

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$, and suppose $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ is row equivalent to a matrix $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ in reduced row echelon form. Let r_{il} be the entries of R and $\mathbf{c} = (c_1, \dots, c_m)$.

- (a) $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is inconsistent **if and only if** the last column, column $n + 1$, is a pivot column of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$, that is, some row of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ is $(0 \cdots 0 \mid 1)$.
- (b) Suppose there is no pivot in the last column. Let $j_1 < \cdots < j_r$ be the pivot columns. Then for **every** choice of scalars $t_l \in F$, one for each free variable x_l , there is **exactly one** solution with $x_l = t_l$ for all free l , namely the one with

$$x_{j_i} = c_i - \sum_{l \text{ free}} r_{il} t_l \quad (i = 1, \dots, r).$$

In particular, setting every free variable to 0 gives the solution $\mathbf{p}$ with $p_{j_i} = c_i$ and all other entries 0.

- (c) A consistent system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has exactly one solution **if and only if** it has no free variables, that is, each of the columns $1, \dots, n$ is a pivot column.

Proof. By Theorem 2.2.2 (c), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has the same solution set as $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{c}$, so we work with the latter.

(a, $\Leftarrow$) If row i of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ has its pivot in column $n + 1$, then its first n entries are 0 and $c_i = 1$ by (E3). Equation i reads $0 = 1$, which is false in any field (Definition 0.7.1). So there is no solution.

- (b) Suppose no pivot lies in column $n + 1$. Then all pivots of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ lie in columns $j_1, \dots, j_r \leq n$. By (E1), rows $r + 1, \dots, m$ of $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ are zero, so the corresponding equations read $0 = 0$ and hold for every $\mathbf{x}$. For $i \leq r$, row i of R has $r_{ij_i} = 1$ by (E3) and $r_{ij_h} = 0$ for $h \neq i$ by (E4). So equation i reads

$$x_{j_i} + \sum_{l \text{ free}} r_{il} x_l = c_i.$$

Hence $\mathbf{x}$ is a solution if and only if $x_{j_i} = c_i - \sum_{l \text{ free}} r_{il} x_l$ for $i = 1, \dots, r$. Each unknown is either a pivot variable or a free variable, not both. So once the free variables are given the values t_l , these equations determine every pivot variable uniquely, and the resulting vector is a solution. This proves (b).

(a, $\Rightarrow$) This is the contrapositive of what (b) just showed: if there is no pivot in the last column, then choosing all $t_l = 0$ produces a solution, so the system is consistent.

- (c) By (a), a consistent system has no pivot in the last column, so (b) applies. If there are no free variables, (b) gives exactly one solution. If x_l is free, the choices $t_l = 0$ and $t_l = 1$, with all other free variables 0, give two solutions whose l -th entries differ, since $0 \neq 1$. This proves (c).

■

In Example (Gauss–Jordan on a 3×4 system) the pivot columns were 1, 2, 4, the free variable was x_3 , and (b) gave $x_1 = 1 - 2t$, $x_2 = 2 + t$, $x_4 = -1$, with $\mathbf{p} = (1, 2, 0, -1)$. The same recipe works over any field, and over a finite field the free variables can take only finitely many values.

Example. (Elimination over $\mathbb{F}_2$)

Solve the following system over $\mathbb{F}_2$:

$$x_1 + x_2 + x_4 = 1, \quad x_2 + x_3 + x_4 = 0, \quad x_1 + x_3 + x_4 = 1.$$

How many solutions are there? What changes if the same equations are read over $\mathbb{R}$?

Solution. In $\mathbb{F}_2$, $-1 = 1$, so $R_i \rightarrow R_i - R_j$ is the same operation as $R_i \rightarrow R_i + R_j$, and every non-zero pivot is already 1. **Column 1** has its pivot in row 1; clear row 3. **Column 2** has its pivot in row 2; clear rows 3 and 1.

$$\begin{aligned} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right] &\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_1} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right] &\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \end{array} \right] \\ &\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \end{array} \right] \end{aligned}$$

In the row $R_3 + R_1$, the entries $1 + 1$ became 0, and in $R_3 + R_2$ the entry in column 3 is $1 + 1 = 0$. **Column 3** has only a 0 below row 2, so no pivot. **Column 4** has its pivot in row 3; row 1 already has a 0 there, so only row 2 needs clearing.

$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_3} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \end{array} \right]$$

This is in RREF, with pivot columns 1, 2, 4 and no pivot in the last column, so the system is consistent by [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (a). The free variable is $x_3 = t$, and part (b) gives $x_1 = 1 - t = 1 + t$, $x_2 = -t = t$, $x_4 = 0$. Since $t \in \mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$, there are exactly two solutions:

$$(1, 0, 0, 0) \quad \text{and} \quad (0, 1, 1, 0).$$

Check the second: $0 + 1 + 0 = 1$, $1 + 1 + 0 = 0$, $0 + 1 + 0 = 1$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$.

Over $\mathbb{R}$ the first step is $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1$, giving row 3 = $(0, -1, 1, 0 \mid 0)$, and adding row 2 then gives $(0, 0, 2, 1 \mid 0)$. The entry 2 is non-zero in $\mathbb{R}$, so column 3 now gets a pivot. Completing the reduction gives pivot columns 1, 2, 3, free variable x_4 , and infinitely many real solutions. The same equations lead to different pivot patterns over different fields, because $1 + 1 = 0$ in one and not in the other.

When a coefficient depends on a parameter, whether a column gets a pivot can depend on the parameter too. Then the reduction splits into cases, one for each answer to “is this entry zero?”.

Example. (A system with a parameter)

For which $k \in \mathbb{R}$ does the system $x + ky = 1$, $kx + y = 1$ have no solution, exactly one solution, or infinitely many? Find the solutions when they exist.

Solution. The entry in position $(1, 1)$ is 1 for every k , so it is a pivot with no case

distinction:

$$\left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & k & 1 \\ k & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - kR_1} \left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & k & 1 \\ 0 & 1 - k^2 & 1 - k \end{array} \right].$$

(For $k = 0$ this operation changes nothing, which is allowed.) Column 2 gets a pivot in row 2 exactly when $1 - k^2 = (1 - k)(1 + k)$ is non-zero, and only then may we scale by its inverse. So we split into cases.

Case $k \neq \pm 1$. Then $1 - k^2 \neq 0$, and $R_2 \rightarrow (1 - k^2)^{-1}R_2$ turns row 2 into $(0, 1 \mid \frac{1}{1+k})$, since $\frac{1-k}{(1-k)(1+k)} = \frac{1}{1+k}$. Then $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - kR_2$ turns row 1 into $(1, 0 \mid 1 - \frac{k}{1+k}) = (1, 0 \mid \frac{1}{1+k})$. The RREF is $[I_2 \mid \mathbf{c}]$ with $\mathbf{c} = (\frac{1}{1+k}, \frac{1}{1+k})$, and by [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (c) this is the only solution. Check: $\frac{1}{1+k} + \frac{k}{1+k} = 1$ for both equations.

Case $k = 1$. Row 2 is $(0, 0 \mid 0)$, and $\left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right]$ is in RREF with pivot column 1. The free variable is $y = t$, and [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (b) gives the solutions $(1 - t, t)$, $t \in \mathbb{R}$: infinitely many.

Case $k = -1$. Row 2 is $(0, 0 \mid 2)$, and $R_2 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_2$ makes it $(0, 0 \mid 1)$. The last column is a pivot column, so the system is inconsistent by [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (a). Directly: $x - y = 1$ and $-x + y = 1$ add up to $0 = 2$.

Hence there is no solution for $k = -1$, there are infinitely many for $k = 1$, and there is exactly one otherwise. The trap is to scale by $(1 - k^2)^{-1}$ before asking whether $1 - k^2$ is zero: that step silently assumes $k \neq \pm 1$, and loses exactly the two interesting cases.

2.2.6 More unknowns than equations

Counting pivots gives a first general theorem. A matrix with m rows has at most m pivots, one per non-zero row. If there are more unknowns than that, some unknown must be free.

Corollary 2.2.5 — More unknowns than equations

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ with $n > m$.

- (a) The homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has a **non-trivial** solution.
- (b) Consequently, every list of n vectors in F^m with $n > m$ is linearly dependent.

Proof.

- (a) By [Theorem 2.2.3](#), $[A \mid \mathbf{0}]$ is row equivalent to a matrix $[R \mid \mathbf{c}]$ in RREF. By [Lemma 2.2.1](#), each operation keeps the last column zero, so $\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$, and the last column is not a pivot column. Each pivot is the leading entry of a different row, so there are at most m pivots, hence at most $m < n$ pivot columns among the first n columns. So some x_l is a free variable. By [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (b), with $t_l = 1$ and every other free variable 0, there is a solution whose l -th entry is $1 \neq 0$. This solution is non-trivial.
- (b) Let $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n \in F^m$ and let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have these columns. By (a) there is $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$ with $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and by [Theorem 0.9.3](#) this says $x_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{v}_n = \mathbf{0}$ with $x_1, \dots, x_n$ not all zero. So the list is linearly dependent.

Part (b) is not new: since $\dim F^m = m$, it is also a case of [Theorem 1.6.3](#), which rests on the Steinitz Exchange Theorem ([Theorem 1.6.1](#)). The proof here is independent of that one. It uses nothing from Chapter 1 beyond the definition of independence, only elimination and a count of pivots. Two proofs by different routes give some confidence that the dimension theory of Chapter 1 and the computations of this chapter will fit together, and the rest of the chapter makes that fit exact. ■

2.2.7 Exercises

2.2.7.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- List the three types of elementary row operation, including the conditions on the scalar and on the indices.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “every matrix in row echelon form is in reduced row echelon form.” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if the RREF of $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ has a zero row, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is inconsistent.” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “a homogeneous system of 3 equations in 5 unknowns over $\mathbb{R}$ has infinitely many solutions.” Justify your answer.
- Explain why swapping two columns of A in $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ is **not** a safe step when solving $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$.

Solution.

- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ with $i \neq j$; $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$ with $c \neq 0$; $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$ with $i \neq j$ and any $c \in F$.
- False. $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ is in row echelon form, but its first pivot is $2 \neq 1$, so (E3) fails; its second column also has a non-zero entry above the pivot, so (E4) fails.
- False. A zero row is the equation $0 = 0$, which every vector satisfies. Inconsistency means a row $(0 \cdots 0 \mid 1)$ ([Theorem 2.2.4](#) (a)). For example $\left[\begin{array}{c|c} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{array} \right]$ is the consistent system $x = 1, 0 = 0$.
- True. By [Corollary 2.2.5](#) ($5 > 3$) there is a non-trivial solution $\mathbf{h}$, and since $\mathbb{R}$ is infinite, the multiples $c\mathbf{h}$ ($c \in \mathbb{R}$) are infinitely many distinct solutions, as in [Exercise \(C1: How many solutions?\)](#).
- It swaps the roles of two unknowns: $\mathbf{s}$ solves the new system exactly when the vector obtained from $\mathbf{s}$ by swapping those two entries solves the old one. So the solution set changes, unless the swap happens to fix it. For instance $x = 1, y = 2$ becomes $y = 1, x = 2$.

2.2.7.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Reduce and solve.

Reduce the augmented matrix of each system over $\mathbb{R}$ to reduced row echelon form, naming each operation. Hence decide whether the system is consistent, and if so, describe all solutions.

- (a) $x_1 + 2x_2 - x_3 = 1$, $2x_1 + 5x_2 + x_3 = 4$, $x_1 + 3x_2 + 2x_3 = 4$.
 (b) $x_1 + x_2 + 2x_3 = 3$, $2x_1 + 3x_2 + 5x_3 = 7$, $x_1 + 2x_2 + 4x_3 = 5$.
 (c) $x_1 - x_2 + 2x_3 + x_4 = 2$, $2x_1 - 2x_2 + 5x_3 + 4x_4 = 5$, $-x_1 + x_2 - x_3 + x_4 = -1$.

Solution.

(a)

$$\begin{aligned} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 \\ 2 & 5 & 1 & 4 \\ 1 & 3 & 2 & 4 \end{array} \right] &\xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 2 \\ 1 & 3 & 2 & 4 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 3 \end{array} \right] \\ &\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & -7 & -3 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 3 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & -7 & -3 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \end{aligned}$$

Column 3 gets no pivot. Column 4 has its pivot in row 3:

$$\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + 3R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & -7 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & -7 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right].$$

The last column is a pivot column, so by [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (a) the system is inconsistent. (Row 3 already said $0 = 1$ before the last two operations.)

(b)

$$\begin{aligned} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 3 & 5 & 7 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 & 5 \end{array} \right] &\xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 & 5 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 2 \end{array} \right] \\ &\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \end{aligned}$$

Columns 1, 2, 3 are pivot columns and the last column is not, so by [Theorem 2.2.4](#)

(c) there is exactly one solution, $(1, 0, 1)$. Check: $1 + 0 + 2 = 3$, $2 + 0 + 5 = 7$, $1 + 0 + 4 = 5$.

(c)

$$\left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 2 & 1 & 2 \\ 2 & -2 & 5 & 4 & 5 \\ -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 & -1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 2 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 & -1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_1} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 2 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Column 2 has only zeros below row 1, so no pivot. Column 3 has its pivot in row 2:

$$\xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 0 & -3 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 0 & -3 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right].$$

Columns 4 and 5 have only a 0 in row 3, so this is the RREF. The pivot columns are 1 and 3; the free variables are $x_2 = s$ and $x_4 = t$. By [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (b), $x_1 = s + 3t$ and $x_3 = 1 - 2t$. Hence the solution set is

$$\{(0, 0, 1, 0) + s(1, 1, 0, 0) + t(3, 0, -2, 1) : s, t \in \mathbb{R}\}.$$

Exercise B2: A parameter.

For which $k \in \mathbb{R}$ is the system

$$x + y - z = 2, \quad x + 2y + z = 3, \quad x + y + (k^2 - 5)z = k$$

inconsistent, which give exactly one solution, and which give infinitely many? Justify your answer, and find the solutions when they exist.

Solution.

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 1 & 1 & k^2 - 5 & k \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & k^2 - 5 & k \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & k^2 - 4 & k - 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & -3 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & k^2 - 4 & k - 2 \end{array} \right]$$

Whether column 3 gets a pivot depends on whether $k^2 - 4 = (k - 2)(k + 2)$ is zero.

Case $k \neq \pm 2$. Then $k^2 - 4 \neq 0$, and $R_3 \rightarrow (k^2 - 4)^{-1}R_3$ turns row 3 into $(0, 0, 1 \mid \frac{1}{k+2})$, since $\frac{k-2}{(k-2)(k+2)} = \frac{1}{k+2}$. Then $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + 3R_3$ and $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_3$ give the RREF $[I_3 \mid \mathbf{c}]$ with

$$\mathbf{c} = \left(\frac{k+5}{k+2}, \frac{k}{k+2}, \frac{1}{k+2} \right),$$

using $1 + \frac{3}{k+2} = \frac{k+5}{k+2}$ and $1 - \frac{2}{k+2} = \frac{k}{k+2}$. By [Theorem 2.2.4](#) (c) there is exactly one solution, $\mathbf{c}$.

Case $k = 2$. Row 3 is zero, and the matrix is in RREF with pivot columns 1, 2 and free variable $z = t$. The solutions are $(1 + 3t, 1 - 2t, t)$, $t \in \mathbb{R}$: infinitely many.

Case $k = -2$. Row 3 is $(0, 0, 0 \mid -4)$, and $R_3 \rightarrow -\frac{1}{4}R_3$ makes it $(0, 0, 0 \mid 1)$. The last column is a pivot column, so the system is inconsistent.

Hence: inconsistent for $k = -2$, infinitely many solutions for $k = 2$, and exactly one solution otherwise.

Exercise B3: Over $\mathbb{F}_3$.

Solve each system over $\mathbb{F}_3$ by reducing to RREF, naming each operation, and list all solutions.

- (a) $x + 2y + z = 1$, $2x + y + z = 0$, $x + z = 2$.
 (b) $x + y + 2z = 1$, $2x + z = 2$.

Solution. In $\mathbb{F}_3$ the inverses are $1^{-1} = 1$ and $2^{-1} = 2$, since $2 \cdot 2 = 4 = 1$, and $-1 = 2$, $-2 = 1$.

(a)

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Here $1 - 4 = -3 = 0$, $1 - 2 = -1 = 2$, $0 - 2 = 1$, and $0 - 2 = 1$, $2 - 1 = 1$. Column 2 has entries 0, 1 below row 1, so we swap:

$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow 2R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array} \right]$$

There are no free variables, so the unique solution is $(0, 1, 2)$. Check: $0 + 2 + 2 = 4 = 1$, $0 + 1 + 2 = 3 = 0$, $0 + 2 = 2$.

(b)

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right],$$

using $0 - 2 = 1$, $1 - 4 = 0$, $2 - 2 = 0$. The free variable is $z = t$, and $x = 1 - 2t = 1 + t$, $y = 0$. As t runs through 0, 1, 2, the solutions are $(1, 0, 0)$, $(2, 0, 1)$, $(0, 0, 2)$: exactly three.

2.2.7.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Why $i \neq j$?

Consider the move “ $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_i$ ”, which the definition does **not** allow.

- (a) Show that for $c = -1$ this move is not reversible: give a matrix on which its effect cannot be undone by any sequence of elementary row operations and moves of this kind, and a system whose solution set it changes.
 (b) Show that for $c \neq -1$ the move is an elementary row operation of another type. Explain why the condition $i \neq j$ in type (3) therefore loses nothing.

Solution.

- (a) The move replaces $\mathbf{r}_i$ by $\mathbf{r}_i + (-1)\mathbf{r}_i = \mathbf{0}$. Apply it to the 1×2 augmented matrix $[1 \mid 1]$ of the equation $x = 1$ over any field F : the result is $[0 \mid 0]$, the equation $0 = 0$. The solution set changes from $\{1\}$ to all of F . No sequence of moves can return to $[1 \mid 1]$: every elementary row operation, and every move “ $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_i$ ”, sends a zero matrix to a zero matrix, by the formulas in the proof of [Lemma 2.2.1](#) and $c \cdot 0 = 0$.
 (b) The move replaces $\mathbf{r}_i$ by $(1 + c)\mathbf{r}_i$. If $c \neq -1$, then $1 + c \neq 0$, and this is the scaling

$R_i \rightarrow (1+c)R_i$, an operation of type (2). So allowing $i = j$ in type (3) would add only moves that are already available (when $c \neq -1$) and one move that destroys information ($c = -1$). Requiring $i \neq j$ excludes exactly the bad case.

Exercise C2: The cost of elimination.

Let $A \in M_n(F)$ and $\mathbf{b} \in F^n$, and suppose that Gauss–Jordan elimination on $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ finds, for each $l = 1, \dots, n$, a non-zero entry in position (l, l) and so never swaps. Count as one **operation** each multiplication or division of two scalars, under these conventions: scaling row l costs one division for each entry in columns $l+1, \dots, n+1$ (the pivot is simply set to 1), and each replacement $R_g \rightarrow R_g - cR_l$ costs one multiplication for each entry in columns $l+1, \dots, n+1$ (the entry in column l is simply set to 0).

- Show that processing column l costs at most $n(n+1-l)$ operations.
- Hence show that the whole elimination costs at most $\frac{1}{2}(n^3 + n^2)$ operations.
- Roughly how many times more work is a system of $2n$ equations than one of n equations, for large n ?

Solution.

- Scaling row l costs $n+1-l$ divisions. At most $n-1$ other rows need a replacement, each costing $n+1-l$ multiplications. The total is at most $(n+1-l) + (n-1)(n+1-l) = n(n+1-l)$.
- Summing (a) over $l = 1, \dots, n$, and substituting $q = n+1-l$, which runs through $1, \dots, n$,

$$\sum_{l=1}^n n(n+1-l) = n \sum_{q=1}^n q = n \cdot \frac{n(n+1)}{2} = \frac{n^3 + n^2}{2},$$

using the formula for $1 + \dots + n$ (Proposition 0.2.8).

- The bound is dominated by $\frac{1}{2}n^3$ for large n , since $\frac{1}{2}n^2$ is small compared with it. Replacing n by $2n$ multiplies n^3 by 8, so doubling the size of the system costs roughly eight times as much.

Exercise C3: Solvable for every right-hand side.

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, and suppose that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent for **every** $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$. Prove that $m \leq n$.

Hint: suppose $m > n$, reduce A to its RREF R , and run the operations backwards on $[R \mid \mathbf{e}_m]$.

Solution. Suppose, for a contradiction, that $m > n$. By Theorem 2.2.3, some sequence of operations $O_1, \dots, O_s$ turns A into a matrix R in RREF. By (E2), R has at most n pivots, one in each pivot column, so at most $n < m$ non-zero rows, and by (E1) its last row is zero. Therefore the last row of $[R \mid \mathbf{e}_m]$ is $(0 \cdots 0 \mid 1)$, so the system $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_m$ has no solution.

By Theorem 2.2.2 (a), each O_t is undone by an operation O'_t , and $O'_s, \dots, O'_1$ turn R back into A . Apply them to $[R \mid \mathbf{e}_m]$. By Lemma 2.2.1 they act on the two blocks

separately, so the result is $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ for some $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$. By [Theorem 2.2.2](#) (c), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has the same solutions as $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_m$, namely none. This contradicts the hypothesis, so $m \leq n$.

2.3 Uniqueness of the Reduced Form

Gauss–Jordan elimination involves choices: which non-zero entry to use as a pivot, and in what order to perform the operations. Different choices give different intermediate matrices, and different row echelon forms. The previous section claimed that they always end at the **same** reduced row echelon form. This matters more than it seems. Pivot columns, free variables, and later the rank of a matrix are all read off from the reduced form; if two people could reduce the same matrix to two different answers, none of these would be well defined. This section proves the claim.

2.3.1 What row operations remember

Row operations change the columns of a matrix. What do they keep? Take

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 3 & 6 & 2 & 7 \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{and its RREF} \quad R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

over $\mathbb{R}$ (the computation is carried out in an example later in this section). The columns of R look nothing like those of A . But look at how the columns depend on each other. In R , column 2 is twice column 1, and column 4 is column 1 plus twice column 3. In A , with columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_4$,

$$\mathbf{a}_2 = (2, 4, 6) = 2\mathbf{a}_1, \quad \mathbf{a}_4 = (3, 2, 7) = (1, 2, 3) + 2(1, 0, 2) = \mathbf{a}_1 + 2\mathbf{a}_3.$$

The same relations, with the same coefficients. This is no accident. A relation $x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$ among the columns says $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ ([Theorem 0.9.3](#)), and row operations do not change the solutions of a homogeneous system.

Lemma 2.3.1 — Row equivalent matrices have the same homogeneous solutions

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ be row equivalent. Then for every $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$, $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if $B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.

Proof. Let a sequence of elementary row operations turn A into B . By [Lemma 2.2.1](#), the same sequence turns $[A \mid \mathbf{0}]$ into $[B \mid \mathbf{0}']$, where $\mathbf{0}'$ is obtained from the zero column by row operations and so is again the zero column. Hence $[A \mid \mathbf{0}]$ and $[B \mid \mathbf{0}']$ are row equivalent, and by [Theorem 2.2.2](#) (c) the systems $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ and $B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ have the same solution set. ■

Rewriting $A\mathbf{x}$ as a combination of columns turns the lemma into the statement we observed.

Lemma 2.3.2 — Row operations preserve column relations

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$ and $\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_n$, and suppose that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Leftrightarrow B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$. This holds, for instance, if A and B are row equivalent (Lemma 2.3.1). Then:

- (a) for all $x_1, \dots, x_n \in F$: $x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if $x_1\mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{b}_n = \mathbf{0}$;
- (b) for every index l and all scalars $d_1, \dots, d_{l-1}$: $\mathbf{a}_l = d_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + d_{l-1}\mathbf{a}_{l-1}$ if and only if $\mathbf{b}_l = d_1\mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + d_{l-1}\mathbf{b}_{l-1}$;
- (c) for every index l : $\mathbf{a}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{l-1})$ if and only if $\mathbf{b}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_{l-1})$.

Proof.

- (a) By Theorem 0.9.3, $x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n = A\mathbf{x}$ and $x_1\mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{b}_n = B\mathbf{x}$, where $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$. The hypothesis says $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Leftrightarrow B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.
- (b) The equation $\mathbf{a}_l = d_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + d_{l-1}\mathbf{a}_{l-1}$ holds if and only if $d_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + d_{l-1}\mathbf{a}_{l-1} + (-1)\mathbf{a}_l + 0\mathbf{a}_{l+1} + \dots + 0\mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$. By (a), with these coefficients, this holds if and only if the same combination of the $\mathbf{b}_j$ is $\mathbf{0}$, that is, $\mathbf{b}_l = d_1\mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + d_{l-1}\mathbf{b}_{l-1}$.
- (c) By Definition 1.3.2, $\mathbf{a}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{l-1})$ means that the left side of (b) holds for **some** scalars $d_1, \dots, d_{l-1}$. By (b) this happens if and only if the right side holds for some scalars, which means $\mathbf{b}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_{l-1})$.

■

Warning. Row operations preserve column relations, not columns or their span. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$, the operation $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1$ gives $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. The relation “column 2 = 2 · column 1” holds in both. But every column of A lies on the line $\text{span}((1, 1))$, and every column of the new matrix lies on the different line $\text{span}((1, 0))$. So the span of the columns changed. To answer a question about the columns of A themselves, find the relations from the reduced form, and then use them on the columns of A .

2.3.2 The columns of a reduced matrix

In a matrix in RREF, the column relations can be read off at a glance: pivot columns are standard basis vectors, and a non-pivot column **displays its own coefficients**. We record this precisely, together with a description of the pivot columns that does not mention pivots at all.

Lemma 2.3.3 — Columns of a matrix in RREF

Let $R \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ be in reduced row echelon form, with entries r_{il} , columns $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n$, and pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r$.

- (a) For each $i = 1, \dots, r$, the pivot column $\mathbf{u}_{j_i}$ is $\mathbf{e}_i$.

(b) If l is **not** a pivot column, then

$$\mathbf{u}_l = \sum_{i: j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{e}_i = \sum_{i: j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{u}_{j_i}.$$

(c) Column l is a pivot column **if and only if** $\mathbf{u}_l \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$.

Proof.

- (a) By (E3) the entry of $\mathbf{u}_{j_i}$ in row i is 1, and by (E4) its other entries are 0.
- (b) Let l be a non-pivot column, and look at the entry r_{il} in each row i . If $i > r$, row i is zero by (E1), so $r_{il} = 0$. If $i \leq r$ and $j_i > l$, then r_{il} lies strictly before the leading entry of row i , so $r_{il} = 0$. The case $j_i = l$ does not occur, since l is not a pivot column. So the only possibly non-zero entries of $\mathbf{u}_l$ are the r_{il} with $j_i < l$, which gives the first expression; the second follows from (a).
- (c) If l is not a pivot column, (b) writes $\mathbf{u}_l$ as a combination of the columns $\mathbf{u}_{j_i}$ with $j_i < l$, so $\mathbf{u}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$. Conversely, let $l = j_i$ be a pivot column. For each $l' < j_i$, the entry $r_{il'}$ lies before the leading entry of row i , so it is 0. Hence every vector of $\text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$, being a combination of vectors with i -th entry 0, has i -th entry 0. But $\mathbf{u}_l = \mathbf{e}_i$ has i -th entry 1 $\neq 0$, so $\mathbf{u}_l \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$. ■

Part (c) says: reading the columns from left to right, a column gets a pivot exactly when it is **new**, not a combination of the columns before it. That condition is about column relations only, and column relations survive row operations. This is the whole idea of the uniqueness proof.

2.3.3 The uniqueness theorem

We can now prove that the reduced form depends only on the homogeneous solutions, and hence not on the operations used to reach it.

Theorem 2.3.4 — Uniqueness of the reduced row echelon form

Let $R, R' \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ be in reduced row echelon form, and suppose that $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Leftrightarrow R'\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$. Then $R = R'$.

Consequently, every matrix $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is row equivalent to **exactly one** matrix in reduced row echelon form, called **the RREF of A** .

Idea. A column dependence $\sum_j x_j \mathbf{u}_j = \mathbf{0}$ is exactly a null vector $\mathbf{x}$, so R and R' have the same column relations. The pivot columns are exactly the columns that are not combinations of earlier columns (Lemma 2.3.3 (c)), so R and R' have the same pivot columns. A pivot column is a standard basis vector in both. A non-pivot column of an RREF matrix is determined by how it is built from the pivot columns before it (Lemma 2.3.3 (b)), and that recipe is a column relation, so it is the same in both. Hence every column agrees.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n$ and $\mathbf{u}'_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}'_n$ be the columns of R and R' , and r_{il} the entries of R . By hypothesis, [Lemma 2.3.2](#) applies to R and R' .

Same pivot columns. For each l , by [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (c), $\mathbf{u}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$ if and only if $\mathbf{u}'_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}'_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}'_{l-1})$. By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (c) applied to R and to R' , column l is a pivot column of R if and only if it is a pivot column of R' . So both matrices have the same pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r$.

Pivot columns agree. By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (a), $\mathbf{u}_{j_i} = \mathbf{e}_i = \mathbf{u}'_{j_i}$ for $i = 1, \dots, r$.

Same non-pivot columns. Let l be a non-pivot column. By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (b) for R ,

$$\mathbf{u}_l = \sum_{i: j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{u}_{j_i}.$$

This is an equation of the form in [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (b), with coefficient r_{il} on column j_i and 0 on the other earlier columns. By that lemma, the same equation holds for R' :

$$\mathbf{u}'_l = \sum_{i: j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{u}'_{j_i} = \sum_{i: j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{e}_i = \mathbf{u}_l,$$

where the middle equality uses [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (a) for R' , and the last uses [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (b) for R .

Hence $\mathbf{u}_l = \mathbf{u}'_l$ for every l , and $R = R'$.

For the consequence, let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. By [Theorem 2.2.3](#), A is row equivalent to at least one matrix in RREF. Suppose A is row equivalent to R and to R' , both in RREF. Row equivalence is an equivalence relation ([Theorem 2.2.2](#) (b)), so R is row equivalent to R' . By [Lemma 2.3.1](#), $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Leftrightarrow R'\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ for every $\mathbf{x}$, and by the first part $R = R'$. This proves the theorem. ■

Notice what the proof did **not** do: it never compared the two sequences of operations. A direct comparison of two runs of the algorithm would have to track every choice, and quickly becomes unmanageable. The proof instead found a description of the RREF, “pivots where a new column appears, and coefficients of the old columns elsewhere”, that refers only to the null space, which the operations cannot change.

The theorem also gives a practical test: two matrices of the same size are row equivalent exactly when their RREFs are equal (you will write out the two-line proof in [Exercise \(B2: Row equivalence via the RREF\)](#)). For example, over $\mathbb{R}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ both reduce to $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, by $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1$ and by $R_1 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_1$ respectively, so they are row equivalent. But $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$ reduces to $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \neq \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, so it is row equivalent to neither, even though all three matrices have the same pivot columns.

Example. (Two echelon forms, one reduced form)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 3 & 6 & 2 & 7 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$.

- Reduce A to a row echelon form in two ways: first using row 1 as the first pivot row, then starting with $R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2$.
- Continue both to reduced row echelon form.
- Read the column relations of A off the RREF.

Solution.

- First route:

$$A \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & -4 \\ 3 & 6 & 2 & 7 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & -4 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & -2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - \frac{1}{2}R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & -4 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} =$$

Second route:

$$A \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 3 & 6 & 2 & 7 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - \frac{1}{2}R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 6 & 2 & 7 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - \frac{3}{2}R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Both E_1 and E_2 are in row echelon form, and $E_1 \neq E_2$. Both have pivot columns 1 and 3.

- From E_1 :

$$E_1 \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow -\frac{1}{2}R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

From E_2 :

$$E_2 \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The two routes end at the same matrix R , as [Theorem 2.3.4](#) guarantees.

- By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (b), the non-pivot columns of R are $\mathbf{u}_2 = 2\mathbf{u}_1$ and $\mathbf{u}_4 = 1 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1 + 2\mathbf{u}_3$, reading the coefficients from the entries of each column. By [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (b), the same relations hold for the columns of A : $\mathbf{a}_2 = 2\mathbf{a}_1$ and $\mathbf{a}_4 = \mathbf{a}_1 + 2\mathbf{a}_3$. Check: $2(1, 2, 3) = (2, 4, 6)$ and $(1, 2, 3) + 2(1, 0, 2) = (3, 2, 7)$.

Both echelon forms in the example had the same pivot columns, although they were different matrices. That is also true in general, and it is the practical version of the theorem.

2.3.4 Pivot columns are well defined

Corollary 2.3.5 — Pivot columns are well defined

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n$. Define the **pivot columns** of A to be the

pivot columns of the RREF of A .

- (a) Column l is a pivot column of A **if and only if** $\mathbf{a}_l \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{l-1})$.
- (b) If E is **any** matrix in row echelon form that is row equivalent to A , then the pivot columns of E are the pivot columns of A . In particular, every row echelon form of A has the same number of non-zero rows.

Idea. Part (a) combines [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (c) with the fact that column relations pass from the RREF back to A . For (b), finish the reduction of E : scale each pivot to 1 and clear the entries above the pivots. These operations never move a leading entry, so they produce a matrix in RREF with the same pivot columns as E , and by uniqueness it is the RREF of A .

Proof. The RREF of A is well defined by [Theorem 2.3.4](#); let $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n$ be its columns.

- (a) A and its RREF are row equivalent, so by [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (c), $\mathbf{a}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{l-1})$ if and only if $\mathbf{u}_l \in \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{l-1})$. By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (c), the latter fails exactly when l is a pivot column.
- (b) Let E have entries e_{hl} and pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_s$. First perform $R_i \rightarrow e_{ij_i}^{-1} R_i$ for $i = 1, \dots, s$, which is legal since each pivot e_{ij_i} is non-zero. Scaling a row by a non-zero scalar does not change which of its entries are zero ([Theorem 0.7.1](#) (d), (f)), so the result is still in row echelon form with the same pivot columns, and now every pivot is 1. Next, for $i = 1, 2, \dots, s$ in turn, and for each $h < i$, perform $R_h \rightarrow R_h - cR_i$, where c is the current entry of row h in column j_i . Row i is zero in all columns before j_i , so this changes row h only in columns $\geq j_i > j_h$. Hence the leading entry of row h is still a 1 in column j_h , no zero row is touched, and the entries below every pivot stay 0. The operation makes the entry in position (h, j_i) equal to 0, and it does not spoil the entries $(h, j_{i'})$ with $i' < i$ cleared earlier, because row i has a 0 in column $j_{i'} < j_i$. At the end, every pivot column is a standard basis vector, so the matrix is in RREF, with pivot columns $j_1, \dots, j_s$.

This matrix is row equivalent to E , hence to A ([Theorem 2.2.2](#) (b)). By [Theorem 2.3.4](#) it is the RREF of A . Therefore the pivot columns of E are those of A . Since the non-zero rows of E correspond one-to-one to its pivots, their number s is the number of pivot columns of A , whichever E we chose. ■

In practice, (b) means we may stop at any row echelon form to find the pivot columns, and (a) means we can sometimes find them with no elimination at all. Part (a) also says that the pivot columns of A are exactly the columns kept when the list $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ is sifted as in [Theorem 1.5.4](#): a column is kept exactly when it is not in the span of the columns before it. The number of pivot columns is the first candidate for a measure of “how much a matrix contains”; later in this chapter it becomes the rank.

Quick check. Without computing any row operations, find the pivot columns of $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 2 & 4 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution. Use [Corollary 2.3.5](#) (a) column by column. $\mathbf{a}_1 = (1, 2) \neq \mathbf{0}$, so it is not in $\text{span}(\emptyset) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$: pivot. $\mathbf{a}_2 = (2, 4) = 2\mathbf{a}_1$: not a pivot. $\mathbf{a}_3 = (0, 1)$ is not a multiple of $(1, 2)$, and $\text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \mathbf{a}_2) = \text{span}((1, 2))$: pivot. $\mathbf{a}_4 = (1, 3) = \mathbf{a}_1 + \mathbf{a}_3$: not a pivot. The pivot columns are 1 and 3.

Warning. Uniqueness is a property of the reduced form only. A matrix has many row echelon forms ([Example \(Two echelon forms, one reduced form\)](#) gave two), and it is only their pivot positions that agree. Also, two different matrices in RREF with the **same** pivot columns need not be row equivalent: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ are both in RREF with pivot column 1, but they are different RREF matrices, so by [Theorem 2.3.4](#) neither is row equivalent to the other.

2.3.5 Exercises

2.3.5.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- State the uniqueness theorem for the reduced row echelon form.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if A and B are row equivalent, then the columns of A and the columns of B span the same subspace.” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “if A and B are row equivalent and $\mathbf{a}_3 = \mathbf{a}_1 - \mathbf{a}_2$ for the columns of A , then $\mathbf{b}_3 = \mathbf{b}_1 - \mathbf{b}_2$ for the columns of B .” Justify your answer.
- Determine whether the following statement is true: “any two row echelon forms of the same matrix have the same number of zero rows.” Justify your answer.
- In the RREF of a matrix, what do the entries of a non-pivot column tell you about the original matrix?

Solution.

- If $R, R' \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ are in RREF and $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Leftrightarrow R'\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$, then $R = R'$. Hence every matrix is row equivalent to exactly one matrix in RREF.
- False. $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ are row equivalent, but their columns span $\text{span}((1, 1))$ and $\text{span}((1, 0))$, which are different lines in $\mathbb{R}^2$.
- True, by [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (b) with $l = 3$, $d_1 = 1$, $d_2 = -1$.
- True. By [Corollary 2.3.5](#) (b), every row echelon form of an $m \times n$ matrix A has exactly as many non-zero rows as A has pivot columns, so the number of zero rows is m minus that number.
- If column l is not a pivot column, its entries r_{il} (for the pivot rows i with $j_i < l$) are the coefficients expressing column l of the original matrix as a combination of its pivot columns: $\mathbf{a}_l = \sum_{j_i < l} r_{il} \mathbf{a}_{j_i}$.

2.3.5.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: Column relations.

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & -2 & 1 & 7 & 0 \\ 1 & -1 & 1 & 5 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$. Find the RREF of A , naming each operation.

Hence find the pivot columns of A , and express each non-pivot column of A as a linear combination of the pivot columns before it. Check your answer on the columns of A .

Solution.

$$\begin{aligned} A &\xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 1 & -1 & 1 & 5 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \\ &\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + 2R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 3 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \end{aligned}$$

The pivot columns are 1, 3 and 5. By [Lemma 2.3.3](#) (b), in the RREF column 2 is -1 times column 1, and column 4 is 2 times column 1 plus 3 times column 3. By [Lemma 2.3.2](#) (b), the columns of A satisfy

$$\mathbf{a}_2 = -\mathbf{a}_1, \quad \mathbf{a}_4 = 2\mathbf{a}_1 + 3\mathbf{a}_3.$$

Check: $-(1, 2, 1) = (-1, -2, -1) = \mathbf{a}_2$, and $2(1, 2, 1) + 3(0, 1, 1) = (2, 7, 5) = \mathbf{a}_4$.

Exercise B2: Row equivalence via the RREF.

Prove that two matrices $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ are row equivalent if and only if they have the same RREF.

Solution. ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose A and B are row equivalent, and let R be the RREF of B . Then A is row equivalent to B , and B to R , so A is row equivalent to R by transitivity ([Theorem 2.2.2](#) (b)). By the uniqueness in [Theorem 2.3.4](#), R is the RREF of A .

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose both have the RREF R . Then A is row equivalent to R , and by symmetry R is row equivalent to B ([Theorem 2.2.2](#) (b)). By transitivity A is row equivalent to B .

Exercise B3: Row equivalent or not?

Determine whether the matrices in each pair are row equivalent over $\mathbb{R}$. Justify your answer.

- (a) $P = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 5 & 7 \end{pmatrix}$ and $Q = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 & 7 \end{pmatrix}$.
- (b) $P = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ and $Q = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$.

Solution. By [Exercise \(B2: Row equivalence via the RREF\)](#), two matrices of the same size are row equivalent exactly when their RREFs are equal. So we compute both RREFs.

$$(a) \quad P \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \text{ and } Q \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 3R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \text{ The RREFs are equal, so } P \text{ and } Q \text{ are row equivalent.}$$

$$(b) \quad P \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

$$Q \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_3} I_3.$$

I_3 .

The RREFs differ (one has a zero row, the other is I_3), so P and Q are **not** row equivalent. Consistently with [Corollary 2.3.5](#), P has pivot columns 1, 2 while Q has 1, 2, 3.

2.3.5.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Counting reduced forms.

- List, by pivot columns, all 2×3 matrices over $\mathbb{F}_2$ in reduced row echelon form, and show that there are exactly 15 of them.
- Deduce that $M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{F}_2)$, which has 64 elements, splits into exactly 15 classes of row equivalent matrices.
- Show that over a field with q elements there are exactly $2q^2 + 2q + 3$ such matrices.

Solution. We count over a field F with q elements, sorting by the list of pivot columns. In a matrix in RREF, a pivot column is forced (it is $\mathbf{e}_i$), an entry before a leading entry or in a zero row is forced to be 0, and every other entry, one lying in a non-pivot column to the right of its row's pivot, is free.

- With $q = 2$, writing $*$ for a free entry:
 - no pivots: $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, 1 matrix;
 - pivot column 1 only: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & * & * \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, 4 matrices;
 - pivot column 2 only: $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & * \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, 2 matrices;
 - pivot column 3 only: $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, 1 matrix;
 - pivot columns 1, 2: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & * \\ 0 & 1 & * \end{pmatrix}$, 4 matrices;
 - pivot columns 1, 3: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & * & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, 2 matrices;
 - pivot columns 2, 3: $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, 1 matrix.

A 2×3 matrix has at most two pivots, so these are all the cases. The total is $1 + 4 + 2 + 1 + 4 + 2 + 1 = 15$.

- (b) Row equivalence is an equivalence relation (Theorem 2.2.2 (b)), so $M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{F}_2)$ is partitioned into equivalence classes (Theorem 0.5.2). By Theorem 2.3.4, each class contains exactly one matrix in RREF: at least one by Theorem 2.2.3, and at most one since two RREF matrices in the same class would be row equivalent, hence equal. So the classes correspond one-to-one to the 15 matrices of (a).
- (c) The same list, with each free entry taking q values, gives $1 + q^2 + q + 1 + q^2 + q + 1 = 2q^2 + 2q + 3$. For $q = 2$ this is $8 + 4 + 3 = 15$, as in (a).

Exercise C2: Deleting a column.

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ with $n \geq 2$, and let R be its RREF.

- (a) Let A' and R' be obtained from A and R by deleting the **last** column. Prove that R' is the RREF of A' .
- (b) Show by an example that the corresponding statement for deleting the **first** column is false.

Solution.

- (a) Let a sequence of row operations turn A into R . By Lemma 2.2.1, the same sequence turns A' into R' , so A' is row equivalent to R' . By Theorem 2.3.4 it suffices to show that R' is in RREF. Let $j_1 < \dots < j_r$ be the pivot columns of R . If $j_r < n$, then deleting column n does not change any leading entry or any pivot column, and the zero rows of R stay zero, so (E1)–(E4) still hold. If $j_r = n$, then row r of R is zero except for its pivot in column n , so in R' rows $r, \dots, m$ are zero and rows $1, \dots, r-1$ keep their leading entries in columns $j_1 < \dots < j_{r-1}$ and their pivot columns. Again (E1)–(E4) hold, with $r-1$ pivots. Hence R' is in RREF, and it is the RREF of A' .
- (b) Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{R}$. Then $A \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} I_2$, so its RREF is I_2 , and deleting the first column of I_2 gives $\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$. But deleting the first column of A gives $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$, whose RREF is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$, via $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1$. These differ. The pivot of a later column depends on the columns before it, so removing an early column can move pivots.

2.4 Elementary Matrices and Inverses

Gaussian elimination is a list of instructions: swap these rows, scale that one, add a multiple of one row to another. So far it lives outside algebra, as something we do to a matrix. This section turns every row operation into a matrix, so that “apply an operation” becomes “multiply on the left”. With that one observation the algorithm becomes a tool for proofs. We use it to prove the main theorem about invertible matrices, to show that a one-sided inverse of a square matrix is automatically two-sided, which Chapter 0 stated after Definition 0.9.13 but could not prove, and to compute inverses.

Throughout, F is a field, and we use the three elementary row operations of [Definition 2.2.1](#) with their notation: the swap $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ ($i \neq j$), the scaling $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$ (c **non-zero**), and the replacement $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$ ($i \neq j$, any $c \in F$).

2.4.1 Row operations are matrix multiplications

We have already seen one row operation disguised as a product. In [Example \(Row equivalence\)](#) of Chapter 0, multiplying $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 5 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ on the left by $E = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ replaced row 2 by row 2 minus twice row 1, that is, it performed $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1$. Look at E itself: it is what that same operation does to the identity matrix I_2 . This is no accident, and it deserves a name.

An elementary matrix is the identity matrix after one row operation.

Definition 2.4.1 — Elementary matrix

Let $m \geq 1$. A matrix $E \in M_m(F)$ is an **elementary matrix** if it is obtained from I_m by performing **exactly one** elementary row operation. Writing E_{ij} for the matrix unit (1 in entry (i, j) , 0 elsewhere; see [Example \(Standard Bases\)](#)), the three kinds are:

1. P_{ij} , obtained by $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ with $i \neq j$: the identity with rows i and j swapped;
2. $D_i(c) = \text{diag}(1, \dots, 1, c, 1, \dots, 1)$, with c in position i , obtained by $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$ with $c \neq 0$;
3. $I_m + cE_{ij}$, obtained by $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$ with $i \neq j$ and $c \in F$: the identity with an extra c in entry (i, j) .

In words: start from I_m , do **one** operation, and record the result. The size m is the number of **rows** of the matrices we plan to operate on. Type 3 puts c in row i , column j : the row that changes is i , and the row that gets copied is j .

Examples. In $M_3(F)$,

$$P_{13} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad D_2(5) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 5 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad I_3 - 3E_{31} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ -3 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

come from $R_1 \leftrightarrow R_3$, $R_2 \rightarrow 5R_2$ (over a field where $5 \neq 0$), and $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_1$. The degenerate case is worth a look: $D_1(1) = I_m$ is elementary, since “multiply row 1 by 1” is a legal operation, and so is $I_m + 0E_{12}$. The identity is an elementary matrix. For $m = 1$ the elementary matrices are exactly the 1×1 matrices (c) with $c \neq 0$, since there are no two distinct rows to swap or combine.

Non-example by minimal change. Change $c = 5$ in $D_2(5)$ to $c = 0$. The matrix $\text{diag}(1, 0, 1)$ is still diagonal and still differs from I_3 in one entry, but “multiply row 2 by 0” is not an elementary row operation: the clause $c \neq 0$ fails. Likewise $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ is a rearrangement of the rows of I_3 , but every one of its rows has moved, and a single swap moves only two rows. So it is not elementary. It is, however, the **product** $P_{12}P_{23}$ of two elementary matrices, as Exercise A1 at the end of this section checks.

The whole point of the definition is the next theorem. To perform a row operation on **any**

matrix, multiply on the left by what that operation does to the identity.

Theorem 2.4.1 — Row operations are left multiplications

Let ρ be an elementary row operation on matrices with m rows, and let $E = \rho(I_m)$ be the corresponding elementary matrix. Then for **every** $n \geq 1$ and every $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$,

$$\rho(A) = EA.$$

Idea. Each operation builds every new row as a combination of the old rows, with coefficients that do not depend on the matrix: for $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$, new row i is $1 \cdot (\text{row } i) + c \cdot (\text{row } j)$, and every other row is copied. Feed in I_m , whose rows are the standard row vectors, and the coefficients appear as the entries of E . Then the row view of a product says EA forms exactly those combinations of the rows of A .

Proof. Let $\mathbf{r}_1, \dots, \mathbf{r}_m$ be the rows of A , and write $\mathbf{e}_l^\top$ for the l -th row of I_m . By Definition 2.2.1, for each k there are scalars $c_{k1}, \dots, c_{km}$, depending on ρ but **not** on A , such that row k of $\rho(A)$ is $c_{k1}\mathbf{r}_1 + \dots + c_{km}\mathbf{r}_m$. Explicitly, every row that the operation does not touch has $c_{kk} = 1$ and all other $c_{kl} = 0$, and the touched rows are:

- for $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$: row i is $\mathbf{r}_j$ and row j is $\mathbf{r}_i$;
- for $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$: row i is $c\mathbf{r}_i$;
- for $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$: row i is $\mathbf{r}_i + c\mathbf{r}_j$.

Applying ρ to I_m , row k of E is $c_{k1}\mathbf{e}_1^\top + \dots + c_{km}\mathbf{e}_m^\top = (c_{k1} \ \dots \ c_{km})$. So the (k, l) -entry of E is c_{kl} . By Theorem 0.9.2 (rows), row k of EA is (row k of E) A , and by Theorem 0.9.3 (rows version) this equals $c_{k1}\mathbf{r}_1 + \dots + c_{km}\mathbf{r}_m$, which is row k of $\rho(A)$. Since every row agrees, $\rho(A) = EA$. This proves the theorem. ■

So a sequence of operations $\rho_1, \rho_2, \dots, \rho_k$, performed in that order, turns A into

$$\rho_k(\dots \rho_2(\rho_1(A)) \dots) = E_k \dots E_2 E_1 A, \quad E_i = \rho_i(I_m),$$

by applying the theorem k times and using associativity. The whole of Gaussian elimination is a single matrix $E_k \dots E_1$ standing on the left.

Warning. The **first** operation stands **rightmost**. Doing $R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2$ and then $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + R_2$ on I_2 gives $(I_2 + E_{12})P_{12} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, while the product in the other order is $P_{12}(I_2 + E_{12}) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Also, multiplying by E on the **right** performs a **column** operation: $A(I_2 + E_{12})$ adds column 1 to column 2, and column operations change solution sets.

Example. (Three operations, three products)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$. Compute $P_{13}A$, $D_2(5)A$ and $(I_3 - 3E_{31})A$, and check that each is the result of the corresponding row operation.

Solution. By the row view, row k of EA is the combination of the rows of A whose weights are row k of E .

- Rows of P_{13} are $\mathbf{e}_3^\top, \mathbf{e}_2^\top, \mathbf{e}_1^\top$, so $P_{13}A = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$: rows 1 and 3 are swapped.
- Row 2 of $D_2(5)$ is $5\mathbf{e}_2^\top$, so $D_2(5)A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$: row 2 is multiplied by 5.
- Row 3 of $I_3 - 3E_{31}$ is $(-3 \ 0 \ 1)$, so row 3 of the product is $-3(1, 2) + (3, 4) = (0, -2)$, and $(I_3 - 3E_{31})A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -2 \end{pmatrix}$: this is $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_1$.

In each case the product agrees with the operation, as [Theorem 2.4.1](#) predicts.

Quick check. Which 3×3 elementary matrix performs $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + 4R_3$? Which operation undoes it, and what is its matrix?

Solution. Apply the operation to I_3 : row 2 becomes $\mathbf{e}_2^\top + 4\mathbf{e}_3^\top$, so the matrix is $I_3 + 4E_{23}$, with 4 in entry $(2, 3)$. The operation $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 4R_3$ undoes it, since row 3 is unchanged by both; its matrix is $I_3 - 4E_{23}$.

Every row operation can be undone by another row operation, and the matching statement for matrices is:

Theorem 2.4.2 — Elementary matrices are invertible

Every elementary matrix is invertible, and its inverse is an elementary matrix of the same kind:

$$P_{ij}^{-1} = P_{ij}, \quad D_i(c)^{-1} = D_i(c^{-1}), \quad (I_m + cE_{ij})^{-1} = I_m - cE_{ij} \quad (i \neq j).$$

Proof. Let $E = \rho(I_m)$, and let ρ' be the operation on the same line of the display: $\rho' = \rho$ for a swap, $R_i \rightarrow c^{-1}R_i$ for $R_i \rightarrow cR_i$ (legal, since $c \neq 0$ gives $c^{-1} \neq 0$), and $R_i \rightarrow R_i - cR_j$ for $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_j$. In each case $\rho'(\rho(A)) = A$ and $\rho(\rho'(A)) = A$ for every A , as in [Theorem 2.2.2](#) (a): swapping twice restores the order; scaling by c and c^{-1} multiplies row i by $cc^{-1} = 1$; and adding cR_j and then $-cR_j$ to row i restores row i , because $i \neq j$ means row j is not changed in between. Let $E' = \rho'(I_m)$. By [Theorem 2.4.1](#),

$$E'E = \rho'(E) = \rho'(\rho(I_m)) = I_m \quad \text{and} \quad EE' = \rho(E') = \rho(\rho'(I_m)) = I_m.$$

Hence E is invertible with $E^{-1} = E'$, which is the matrix in the display. This proves the theorem.

The hypothesis $i \neq j$ did real work: “add c times row i to row j ” is scaling by $1 + c$, which destroys row i when $c = -1$ and cannot be undone. That is why [Definition 2.2.1](#) excludes it. ■

2.4.2 The invertible matrix theorem

Chapter 0 defined an invertible matrix by the existence of a two-sided inverse, and gave only one practical test, $ad - bc \neq 0$, for 2×2 matrices ([Theorem 0.9.8](#)). For larger matrices, searching for B with $AB = BA = I_n$ directly is hopeless. What we want is a list of conditions, each of which we can check by a method we already have, that are all equivalent to invertibility. Then we may test whichever is cheapest.

We need one small fact about square matrices in reduced form.

Lemma 2.4.3 — Square reduced matrices

Let $R \in M_n(F)$ be in reduced row echelon form. Then either $R = I_n$, or the last row of R is zero.

Proof. Suppose the last row of R is not zero. Since zero rows of a matrix in echelon form come after all non-zero rows ([Definition 2.2.3](#)), no row of R is zero, so each of the n rows has a pivot. Let the pivot of row k be in column c_k . Pivots move strictly to the right as we go down, so $1 \leq c_1 < c_2 < \dots < c_n \leq n$. A strictly increasing list of n integers in $\{1, \dots, n\}$ must be $1, 2, \dots, n$, so $c_k = k$. By [Definition 2.2.4](#), each pivot equals 1 and is the only non-zero entry of its column, so column k of R is $\mathbf{e}_k$ for every k . Hence $R = I_n$. ■

Here is the theorem. It collects, for a square matrix, facts about solving systems, about row reduction, and about the columns as vectors in the sense of Chapter 1.

Theorem 2.4.4 — Invertible Matrix Theorem

Let $A \in M_n(F)$, with columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n \in F^n$. The following are equivalent.

- (a) A is invertible.
- (b) The homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.
- (c) The reduced row echelon form of A is I_n .
- (d) A is a product of elementary matrices.
- (e) For **every** $\mathbf{b} \in F^n$, the system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a solution.
- (f) The columns $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ are linearly independent.
- (g) The columns $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ span F^n .
- (h) The columns $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ form a basis of F^n .

Idea. Eight conditions would need 56 implications if proved pairwise; a cycle through them needs far fewer. The plan:

- ① the core cycle $(a) \Rightarrow (b) \Rightarrow (c) \Rightarrow (d) \Rightarrow (a)$, where each arrow uses one earlier tool (cancel by A^{-1} ; row reduction; elementary matrices; products of invertible matrices);
- ② $(b) \Leftrightarrow (f)$, which is the column view $A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n$;
- ③ $(f) \Leftrightarrow (h) \Leftrightarrow (g)$, which is “count instead of check” in the n -dimensional space F^n ;
- ④ $(g) \Leftrightarrow (e)$, which is “consistent means $\mathbf{b}$ is in the column span”.

The only arrow that needs a new argument is $(b) \Rightarrow (c)$; the others quote a result we already have. An RREF that is not I_n has a zero row, so it really has fewer equations than unknowns, and such a homogeneous system has a non-trivial solution.

Proof. **(a) $\Rightarrow$ (b).** Suppose A is invertible and $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Multiplying on the left by A^{-1} and using [Theorem 0.9.4](#), $\mathbf{x} = (A^{-1}A)\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}(A\mathbf{x}) = A^{-1}\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$.

(b) $\Rightarrow$ (c). Suppose (b) holds. By [Theorem 2.2.3](#), A is row equivalent to a matrix R in reduced row echelon form, and R is the RREF of A by [Theorem 2.3.4](#). By [Lemma 2.3.1](#), $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has the same solutions as $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, so it too has only the trivial solution. Suppose, for a contradiction, that $R \neq I_n$. By [Lemma 2.4.3](#), the last row of R is zero. If $n = 1$, then $R = (0)$ and $\mathbf{x} = (1)$ is a non-trivial solution. If $n \geq 2$, the last equation of $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ reads $0 = 0$, so $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has the same solutions as the homogeneous system $R'\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ formed by the first $n - 1$ rows. That system has $n - 1$ equations in $n > n - 1$ unknowns, so by [Corollary 2.2.5](#) it has a non-trivial solution. Either way we contradict (b). Hence $R = I_n$.

(c) $\Rightarrow$ (d). Suppose the RREF of A is I_n . By [Definition 2.2.2](#) there are row operations $\rho_1, \dots, \rho_k$ taking A to I_n . If $k = 0$, then $A = I_n = D_1(1)$ is elementary. Otherwise, with $E_i = \rho_i(I_n)$, [Theorem 2.4.1](#) gives $E_k \cdots E_1 A = I_n$. Each E_i is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.2](#), so multiplying on the left by E_k^{-1} , then E_{k-1}^{-1} , and so on, gives

$$A = E_1^{-1}E_2^{-1} \cdots E_k^{-1},$$

and each E_i^{-1} is elementary by [Theorem 2.4.2](#).

(d) $\Rightarrow$ (a). Suppose $A = E_1 \cdots E_k$ with each E_i elementary and $k \geq 1$. Each E_i is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.2](#), and a product of two invertible matrices is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3). By induction on k , A is invertible.

So far (a), (b), (c), (d) are equivalent.

(b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (f). By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n$. So “ $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ only for $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ ” says exactly that $x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$ forces $x_1 = \cdots = x_n = 0$, which is [Definition 1.4.1](#) for the columns.

(f) $\Leftrightarrow$ (h) $\Leftrightarrow$ (g). The columns form a list of exactly n vectors in F^n , and $\dim F^n = n$ ([Example \(Dimensions of the Running Examples\)](#)). By [Theorem 1.6.4](#), such a list is a basis if it is linearly independent, and also if it spans. Conversely a basis is independent and spanning by [Definition 1.5.1](#). Hence $(f) \Rightarrow (h) \Rightarrow (g) \Rightarrow (h) \Rightarrow (f)$.

(g) $\Leftrightarrow$ (e). By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a solution if and only if $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$. So (e) says every $\mathbf{b} \in F^n$ lies in this span, that is, $F^n \subseteq \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$. The reverse

inclusion always holds, so (e) is equivalent to (g).

Combining the four parts, all eight conditions are equivalent. This proves the theorem. ■

In practice the theorem is a menu. To show a matrix **is** invertible, pick the most convenient item, very often (b): take a solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ and show it is $\mathbf{0}$. To show a matrix is **not** invertible, exhibit one non-zero solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, or one linear relation among the columns. In later chapters the list grows: kernels and images of linear maps in Chapter 3, determinants in Chapter 6, eigenvalues in Chapter 8, and singular values in Chapter 12.

Quick check. Is $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R})$ invertible? Use whichever item of [Theorem 2.4.4](#) is quickest.

Solution. No. The third column is the sum of the first two: $(1, 0, 1) + (2, 1, 3) = (3, 1, 4)$. So $\mathbf{a}_1 + \mathbf{a}_2 - \mathbf{a}_3 = \mathbf{0}$ is a linear relation with coefficients not all zero, item (f) fails, and hence (a) fails. Equivalently, $\mathbf{x} = (1, 1, -1)$ is a non-trivial solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.

Warning. The theorem is about **square** matrices. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$, the columns span $\mathbb{R}^2$ (the first two are $\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2$), so (g) holds, but $\mathbf{x} = (1, 1, -1)$ solves $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, so (b) fails. The proof of (f) $\Leftrightarrow$ (g) used that the number of columns equals $\dim F^n$, and that is exactly what breaks.

2.4.3 One-sided inverses are two-sided

Chapter 0 left a gap on purpose. The definition of invertibility ([Definition 0.9.13](#)) asks for **both** $AB = I_n$ and $BA = I_n$. Chapter 0 then stated that, for square matrices, the first equation already implies the second, but that nothing there could prove it: the entries of AB and BA are different sums. Now we can prove it, and the proof uses the menu above instead of entries.

Theorem 2.4.5 — One-sided inverses of square matrices

Let $A, B \in M_n(F)$. If $AB = I_n$, then $BA = I_n$. Hence A and B are both invertible, $B = A^{-1}$ and $A = B^{-1}$.

Idea. We cannot touch BA directly, so we aim at invertibility of one factor instead. Which one? From $AB = I_n$, a vector killed by B is killed by $AB = I_n$, so it is $\mathbf{0}$. That is item (b) for B . Once B^{-1} exists, we may cancel it: $A = (AB)B^{-1} = B^{-1}$.

Proof. Suppose $AB = I_n$, and let $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$ with $B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Then, by [Theorem 0.9.4](#),

$$\mathbf{x} = I_n \mathbf{x} = (AB)\mathbf{x} = A(B\mathbf{x}) = A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}.$$

So $B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution, and B is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.4](#) ((b) $\Rightarrow$

(a)). Multiplying $AB = I_n$ on the right by B^{-1} and using associativity,

$$A = A(BB^{-1}) = (AB)B^{-1} = I_n B^{-1} = B^{-1}.$$

Therefore $BA = BB^{-1} = I_n$. Since $A = B^{-1}$ is invertible with inverse B by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 2), we get $A^{-1} = B$. This proves the theorem. ■

By symmetry, $BA = I_n$ also implies $AB = I_n$: apply the theorem with the roles of A and B swapped. So from now on, **to verify that B is the inverse of a square matrix A , one product suffices**. We also get a useful consequence of the same kind: if $A, B \in M_n(F)$ and AB is invertible, then A and B are invertible (Exercise B3 at the end of this section).

Warning. For **non-square** matrices a one-sided inverse need not be two-sided. Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then $AB = I_2$, but $BA = \text{diag}(1, 1, 0) \neq I_3$. In fact no $C \in M_{3 \times 2}(F)$ has $CA = I_3$: $A\mathbf{e}_3 = \mathbf{0}$, so $CA\mathbf{e}_3 = \mathbf{0} \neq \mathbf{e}_3 = I_3\mathbf{e}_3$. The proof above breaks because $B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0} \Rightarrow \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ no longer gives invertibility: B is not square, so [Theorem 2.4.4](#) does not apply.

2.4.4 Computing the inverse

[Theorem 2.4.4](#) (c) says A is invertible exactly when it row reduces to I_n . The proof of (c) $\Rightarrow$ (d) even produced a matrix: if $E_k \cdots E_1 A = I_n$, then $E_k \cdots E_1$ is a left inverse, hence **the** inverse by [Theorem 2.4.5](#). We do not want to multiply out the E_i by hand. The trick is to let the operations act on I_n at the same time as on A : since $E_k \cdots E_1 I_n = E_k \cdots E_1$, the operations that turn A into I_n turn I_n into A^{-1} . We write $[A \mid I_n]$ for the $n \times 2n$ matrix whose first n columns are those of A and whose last n columns are those of I_n .

Input: $A \in M_n(F)$.

1. Form the $n \times 2n$ matrix $[A \mid I_n]$.
2. Row reduce it to reduced row echelon form $[R \mid C]$, with $R, C \in M_n(F)$.
3. If $R = I_n$, output $A^{-1} = C$. Otherwise, output “ A is not invertible”.

In practice, stop as soon as a zero row appears in the left half: A is then not invertible (see the remark after the theorem).

Theorem 2.4.6 — Inverse by row reduction

Let $A \in M_n(F)$, and let $[R \mid C]$ be the reduced row echelon form of $[A \mid I_n]$, with $R, C \in M_n(F)$. Then R is the reduced row echelon form of A . Consequently, A is invertible if and only if $R = I_n$, and in that case $A^{-1} = C$.

Idea. Two things need checking. First, the operations act on the two halves independently, so the left half is transformed exactly as A alone would be. Second, the left half of a reduced matrix is itself reduced, so it really is the RREF of A . The first is the

column view of a product; the second is a small check on the staircase shape. After that, $R = EA$ and $C = EI_n = E$, and [Theorem 2.4.5](#) finishes.

Proof. Let $\rho_1, \dots, \rho_k$ be row operations taking $[A \mid I_n]$ to $[R \mid C]$, and put $E = E_k \cdots E_1$ with $E_i = \rho_i(I_n)$ (and $E = I_n$ if $k = 0$). By [Theorem 2.4.1](#), $[R \mid C] = E[A \mid I_n]$. By [Theorem 0.9.2](#) (columns), each column of $E[A \mid I_n]$ is E times the corresponding column, so

$$R = EA \quad \text{and} \quad C = EI_n = E.$$

Claim. R is in reduced row echelon form.

Proof. If row k of R is non-zero, its first non-zero entry is also the first non-zero entry of row k of $[R \mid C]$, so the pivots of the non-zero rows of R are pivots of $[R \mid C]$, in the same positions. Suppose row k of R is zero but some later row $l > k$ of R is non-zero. Row k of $[R \mid C]$ cannot be zero, since zero rows of $[R \mid C]$ come after its non-zero rows and row l is non-zero. So its pivot lies in a column $> n$, while the pivot of row l lies in a column $\leq n$, to the left: this contradicts the staircase condition of [Definition 2.2.3](#). Hence the zero rows of R come last, the pivots of R move strictly right, and each pivot of R is 1 and the only non-zero entry in its column, because this holds in $[R \mid C]$. So R satisfies [Definition 2.2.4](#). ■

Now $R = E_k \cdots E_1 A$ is obtained from A by the operations $\rho_1, \dots, \rho_k$ ([Theorem 2.4.1](#)), so A is row equivalent to R , and R is in reduced form. By [Theorem 2.3.4](#), R is the RREF of A . By [Theorem 2.4.4](#) ((a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c)), A is invertible if and only if $R = I_n$. If $R = I_n$, then $EA = I_n$, and [Theorem 2.4.5](#) gives $A^{-1} = E = C$. This proves the theorem. ■

Remark. The early stop is justified the same way. If, after some operations, $[A \mid I_n]$ has become $[A' \mid E']$ with a zero row in A' , then, exactly as in the proof, E' is the product of the elementary matrices of the operations used so far and $A' = E'A$. So E' is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.2](#) and [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3). A matrix with a zero row k is not invertible, since row k of $A'X$ is zero for every X , so $A'X \neq I_n$. If A were invertible, $A' = E'A$ would be invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3). Hence A is not invertible.

Example. (A 3×3 inverse)

Find the inverse of $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 5 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R})$, or show that it does not exist.

Solution. Row reduce $[A \mid I_3]$, naming each operation.

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 5 & 3 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 3 & 3 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow[\substack{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1}]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & -1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

The left half now has three pivots, so no zero row will appear. Clear above the pivots, from the bottom up:

$$\begin{array}{l} R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_3 \\ R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3 \end{array} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -3 & 2 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 6 & -3 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -3 & 2 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right].$$

The left half is I_3 , so by [Theorem 2.4.6](#) A is invertible and

$$A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 6 & -3 & 1 \\ -3 & 2 & -1 \\ 1 & -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Check one product: row 1 of A times the columns of A^{-1} gives $6-6+1=1$, $-3+4-1=0$, $1-2+1=0$; rows 2 and 3 give $(0,1,0)$ and $(0,0,1)$ in the same way. So $AA^{-1}=I_3$, and by [Theorem 2.4.5](#) this single product is enough.

Example. (When the algorithm stops)

Decide whether $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 5 & 7 \\ 1 & 3 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R})$ is invertible.

Solution. Row reduce $[A \mid I_3]$:

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 3 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 5 & 7 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 3 & 4 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 3 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & 3 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right].$$

A zero row has appeared in the left half, so by the remark after [Theorem 2.4.6](#), A is not invertible. The right half of that row is not wasted: it records the combination of rows that produced zero. Row 3 of the left half is $1 \cdot (\text{row } 1) - 1 \cdot (\text{row } 2) + 1 \cdot (\text{row } 3)$ of A , and indeed $(1, 2, 3) - (2, 5, 7) + (1, 3, 4) = (0, 0, 0)$.

Finally, the method writes an invertible matrix as a product of elementary matrices, as in [Theorem 2.4.4](#) (d).

Example. (Factoring into elementary matrices)

Write $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 5 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ as a product of elementary matrices, and read off A^{-1} .

Solution. Reduce A to I_2 , keeping integers:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 5 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The elementary matrices of these operations are $E_1 = I_2 - 2E_{21}$, $E_2 = I_2 - E_{12}$, $E_3 = I_2 - E_{21}$, and by [Theorem 2.4.1](#), $E_3E_2E_1A = I_2$. Multiplying on the left by E_3^{-1} , then

E_2^{-1} , then E_1^{-1} , and using [Theorem 2.4.2](#),

$$A = E_1^{-1}E_2^{-1}E_3^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Multiplying out confirms it: the last two factors give $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, and then the first factor adds twice row 1 to row 2, giving $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 5 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$. Also $E_3E_2E_1$ is a left inverse of A , hence A^{-1} by [Theorem 2.4.5](#):

$$A^{-1} = E_3E_2E_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & -1 \\ -5 & 2 \end{pmatrix},$$

which agrees with [Theorem 0.9.8](#), since $ad - bc = 1$. The factorization is not unique: a different sequence of operations gives different factors.

2.4.5 Row equivalence, revisited

Two descriptions of “row equivalent” are now on the table. [Example \(Row equivalence\)](#) of Chapter 0 said $B = EA$ for some invertible E . [Definition 2.2.2](#) says B is reachable from A by finitely many row operations. Chapter 0 promised that they agree, and now it is one line each way.

Theorem 2.4.7 — Row equivalence is left multiplication by an invertible matrix

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. Then A is row equivalent to B (that is, B can be reached from A by row operations) if and only if $B = EA$ for some invertible $E \in M_m(F)$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose row operations $\rho_1, \dots, \rho_k$ take A to B . By [Theorem 2.4.1](#), $B = E_k \cdots E_1 A$ with $E_i = \rho_i(I_m)$, and $E = E_k \cdots E_1$ is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.2](#) and [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (part 3). (If $k = 0$, take $E = I_m$.)

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $B = EA$ with E invertible. By [Theorem 2.4.4](#) ((a) $\Rightarrow$ (d)), $E = E_k \cdots E_1$ for some elementary matrices E_i . Let ρ_i be the operation with $\rho_i(I_m) = E_i$. By [Theorem 2.4.1](#), performing ρ_1 , then $\rho_2, \dots$, then ρ_k on A produces $E_k \cdots E_1 A = B$. Hence A is row equivalent to B . ■

So the equivalence relation of [Example \(Row equivalence\)](#) is the one Gaussian elimination moves along, and “two matrices have the same RREF” is the same as “each is an invertible matrix times the other”. In the next section this form, $B = EA$, is what makes row spaces and ranks easy to compare.

2.4.6 Exercises

2.4.6.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define an elementary matrix, and write down the 3×3 elementary matrix that performs $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 7R_1$.
- (b) State four of the conditions in [Theorem 2.4.4](#).
- (c) True or false: the product of two elementary matrices is always an elementary matrix. Justify your answer.
- (d) True or false: if $A \in M_{2 \times 3}(F)$, $B \in M_{3 \times 2}(F)$ and $AB = I_2$, then $BA = I_3$. Justify your answer.
- (e) True or false: if $A \in M_n(F)$ and $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_j$ has a solution for each $j = 1, \dots, n$, then A is invertible. Justify your answer.
- (f) Describe the method for computing the inverse of a square matrix, and how it detects a matrix that is not invertible.

Solution.

- (a) An elementary matrix in $M_m(F)$ is one obtained from I_m by exactly one elementary row operation ([Definition 2.4.1](#)). Applying $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 7R_1$ to I_3 gives $I_3 + 7E_{31} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 7 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$.
- (b) For $A \in M_n(F)$, each of the following is equivalent to A being invertible: $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution; the RREF of A is I_n ; A is a product of elementary matrices; the columns of A form a basis of F^n .
- (c) False. A single row operation changes at most two rows of I_3 (a swap changes two, a scaling or an addition changes one), so every elementary 3×3 matrix has at least one row equal to the corresponding row of I_3 . But $P_{12}P_{23} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ (by the row view, its rows are rows 2, 1, 3 of P_{23}) differs from I_3 in every row. Hence it is a product of two elementary matrices that is not elementary.
- (d) False. With $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $AB = I_2$ but $BA = \text{diag}(1, 1, 0) \neq I_3$. [Theorem 2.4.5](#) needs square matrices.
- (e) True. Let $\mathbf{x}_j$ solve $A\mathbf{x}_j = \mathbf{e}_j$, and let B have columns $\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_n$. By [Theorem 0.9.2](#), AB has columns $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n$, so $AB = I_n$, and A is invertible by [Theorem 2.4.5](#).
- (f) Row reduce $[A \mid I_n]$ to reduced form $[R \mid C]$. If $R = I_n$, then $A^{-1} = C$; if $R \neq I_n$, in particular if a zero row appears in the left half at any stage, A is not invertible ([Theorem 2.4.6](#)).

2.4.6.2 B. Practice**Exercise B1: Inverses by row reduction.**

For each matrix, find the inverse or show that it is not invertible.

$$(a) \ A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \\ 4 & 1 & 8 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R}).$$

$$(b) \ B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 2 & 5 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R}).$$

$$(c) \ C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{F}_2).$$

Solution.

(a) Row reduce $[A \mid I_3]$:

$$\begin{aligned} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 4 & 1 & 8 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] &\xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 4R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -4 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -2 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right] \\ &\xrightarrow[R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_3]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 5 & 2 & -2 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -4 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -2 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right]. \end{aligned}$$

The left half is I_3 , so by [Theorem 2.4.6](#), $A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 5 & 2 & -2 \\ -4 & 0 & 1 \\ -2 & -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Check: row 1 of

A against the columns of A^{-1} gives $5 - 4 = 1$, $2 - 2 = 0$, $-2 + 2 = 0$, and rows 2 and 3 give $(0, 1, 0)$ and $(0, 0, 1)$, so $AA^{-1} = I_3$, which suffices by [Theorem 2.4.5](#).

(b) Row reduce $[B \mid I_3]$:

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 5 & -1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 2 & -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -2 & -1 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

A zero row appears in the left half, so B is not invertible (remark after [Theorem 2.4.6](#)). The right half of that row says $-2(\text{row } 1) - (\text{row } 2) + (\text{row } 3) = \mathbf{0}$, that is, row 3 of B is $2(\text{row } 1) + (\text{row } 2)$.

(c) Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ we have $-1 = 1$, so subtracting a row is adding it. Row reduce $[C \mid I_3]$:

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_1} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_3} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + R_2} \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Hence $C^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Check in $\mathbb{F}_2$: row 1 of C is $(1, 1, 0)$, and against the columns of C^{-1} it gives $0 + 1 = 1$, $1 + 1 = 0$, $1 + 1 = 0$; rows 2 and 3 give $(0, 1, 0)$ and $(0, 0, 1)$ similarly.

Exercise B2: A product of elementary matrices.

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 5 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$.

- (a) Write A as a product of elementary matrices.
- (b) Hence write A^{-1} as a product of elementary matrices, and compute it.

Solution.

- (a) Reduce A to I_2 :

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 5 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow -R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 3R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

With $E_1 = I_2 - 2E_{21}$, $E_2 = D_2(-1)$, $E_3 = I_2 - 3E_{12}$, [Theorem 2.4.1](#) gives $E_3E_2E_1A = I_2$. Multiplying on the left by $E_3^{-1}, E_2^{-1}, E_1^{-1}$ in turn and using [Theorem 2.4.2](#),

$$A = E_1^{-1}E_2^{-1}E_3^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Check: the last two factors give $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$, and adding twice row 1 to row 2 gives $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 2 & 5 \end{pmatrix}$.

- (b) Since $E_3E_2E_1A = I_2$, [Theorem 2.4.5](#) gives

$$A^{-1} = E_3E_2E_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -3 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -5 & 3 \\ 2 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

(The last two factors give $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 2 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$, and $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 3R_2$ then gives the answer.)

This agrees with [Theorem 0.9.8](#), since $ad - bc = -1$.

Exercise B3: Invertible products.

Let $A, B \in M_n(F)$, and suppose AB is invertible. Prove that A and B are both invertible.

Solution. Let $C = (AB)^{-1}$. Then $A(BC) = (AB)C = I_n$ by associativity, so A has the right inverse BC , and by [Theorem 2.4.5](#) A is invertible. Similarly $(CA)B = C(AB) = I_n$, so B has the left inverse CA . By [Theorem 2.4.5](#) with the roles of the two matrices swapped (CA times B is I_n), B is invertible. This proves the claim.

2.4.6.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Triangular matrices.

Let $U = (u_{ij}) \in M_n(F)$ be upper triangular ([Definition 0.9.5](#)).

- (a) Prove that U is invertible if and only if $u_{ii} \neq 0$ for every i .
- (b) Prove that if U is invertible, then U^{-1} is upper triangular.

Hint: for (a), use item (b) or item (f) of Theorem 2.4.4; for (b), consider the systems $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_k$.

Solution.

- (a) ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose every $u_{ii} \neq 0$, and let $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Row i of this system reads $u_{ii}x_i + u_{i,i+1}x_{i+1} + \cdots + u_{in}x_n = 0$, since $u_{ij} = 0$ for $j < i$. We show $x_n = x_{n-1} = \cdots = x_1 = 0$ by downward induction. Row n is $u_{nn}x_n = 0$, and $u_{nn} \neq 0$, so $x_n = 0$. If $x_{i+1} = \cdots = x_n = 0$, row i becomes $u_{ii}x_i = 0$, so $x_i = 0$ since $u_{ii} \neq 0$. Hence $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and U is invertible by Theorem 2.4.4 ((b) $\Rightarrow$ (a)).
- ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $u_{kk} = 0$ for some k . Every column $j \leq k$ of U has zero entries in rows $k, k+1, \dots, n$: below the diagonal by triangularity, and in row k of column k by assumption. So the k columns $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k$ all lie in $\text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_{k-1})$, a subspace of dimension $k-1$ (its spanning list is a sub-list of the standard basis, hence independent). By Theorem 1.6.3 (a), a list of $k > k-1$ vectors there is linearly dependent. A non-trivial relation among $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k$, extended by zero coefficients on $\mathbf{u}_{k+1}, \dots, \mathbf{u}_n$, is a non-trivial relation among all the columns. So the columns of U are dependent, and U is not invertible by Theorem 2.4.4 ((a) $\Rightarrow$ (f)). (For $k = 1$, the span is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$ and $\mathbf{u}_1 = \mathbf{0}$, so the same conclusion holds.)
- (b) Suppose U is invertible, so every $u_{ii} \neq 0$ by (a). Fix k , and let $\mathbf{x}$ be the k -th column of U^{-1} . By Theorem 0.9.2, $U\mathbf{x}$ is the k -th column of $UU^{-1} = I_n$, so $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_k$. For $i > k$, row i of this system reads $u_{ii}x_i + \cdots + u_{in}x_n = 0$. By the same downward induction as in (a), running only over $i = n, n-1, \dots, k+1$, we get $x_n = \cdots = x_{k+1} = 0$. So the k -th column of U^{-1} has zeros below position k . As k was arbitrary, U^{-1} is upper triangular.

Exercise C2: All right inverses.

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{2 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$.

- (a) Find all $B \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$ with $AB = I_2$.
 (b) Show that there is no $C \in M_{3 \times 2}(\mathbb{R})$ with $CA = I_3$.

Solution.

- (a) By Theorem 0.9.2, $AB = I_2$ means that the columns $\mathbf{b}_1, \mathbf{b}_2$ of B satisfy $A\mathbf{b}_1 = \mathbf{e}_1$ and $A\mathbf{b}_2 = \mathbf{e}_2$. The matrix A is already in reduced form with pivots in columns 1 and 2 and x_3 free, so $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ means $x_1 = -x_3$, $x_2 = -x_3$, and its solutions are the multiples of $(-1, -1, 1)$. One solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_1$ is $(1, 0, 0)$, and one solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{e}_2$ is $(0, 1, 0)$. By Theorem 2.1.3,

$$\mathbf{b}_1 = (1, 0, 0) + s(-1, -1, 1), \quad \mathbf{b}_2 = (0, 1, 0) + t(-1, -1, 1) \quad (s, t \in \mathbb{R}).$$

Hence the right inverses of A are exactly

$$B = \begin{pmatrix} 1-s & -t \\ -s & 1-t \\ s & t \end{pmatrix}, \quad s, t \in \mathbb{R},$$

infinitely many of them.

- (b) Suppose $CA = I_3$, and let $\mathbf{x} = (-1, -1, 1)$, so $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Then $\mathbf{x} = I_3\mathbf{x} = C(A\mathbf{x}) = C\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0}$, a contradiction since $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Hence A has no left inverse.

Exercise C3: Nilpotent perturbations of the identity.

Let $A \in M_n(F)$ and suppose $A^k = 0$ for some integer $k \geq 1$.

- (a) Prove that $I_n + A$ is invertible, by using item (b) of [Theorem 2.4.4](#).
 (b) Verify that $(I_n + A)(I_n - A + A^2 - \cdots + (-1)^{k-1}A^{k-1}) = I_n$, and deduce a formula for $(I_n + A)^{-1}$.

Solution.

- (a) Let $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$ with $(I_n + A)\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. Then $A\mathbf{x} = -\mathbf{x}$. Multiplying on the left by A and using this again, $A^2\mathbf{x} = A(-\mathbf{x}) = -A\mathbf{x} = (-1)^2\mathbf{x}$, and inductively $A^j\mathbf{x} = (-1)^j\mathbf{x}$ for every $j \geq 1$. Taking $j = k$, $\mathbf{0} = A^k\mathbf{x} = (-1)^k\mathbf{x}$, so $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ (multiply by $(-1)^k$). By [Theorem 2.4.4](#) ((b) $\Rightarrow$ (a)), $I_n + A$ is invertible.
 (b) Expanding with [Theorem 0.9.4](#),

$$(I_n + A) \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} (-1)^j A^j = \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} (-1)^j A^j + \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} (-1)^j A^{j+1} = I_n + (-1)^{k-1} A^k = I_n,$$

since the terms $(-1)^j A^j$ for $1 \leq j \leq k-1$ in the first sum cancel against the terms $(-1)^{j-1} A^j$ of the second, and $A^k = 0$. By [Theorem 2.4.5](#), $(I_n + A)^{-1} = I_n - A + A^2 - \cdots + (-1)^{k-1} A^{k-1}$.

2.5 Row Space, Column Space, Null Space and Rank

We can now reduce any matrix and read off the solutions of any linear system. This section asks a coarser question: how much information does a matrix carry? Three subspaces come attached to every matrix A : the vectors $A\mathbf{x}$ it can produce, the combinations of its rows, and the vectors it sends to zero. Their dimensions are governed by a single number, the rank, which is the number of pivots. With it we settle when a system is solvable and how many solutions it has, and we turn the questions of Chapter 1 about vectors in F^m (independent? spanning? a basis of a sum or an intersection?) into a routine computation, which is the “systematic method” that Chapter 1 promised.

Throughout, F is a field and $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ has columns $\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n \in F^m$.

2.5.1 Three subspaces of a matrix

Here is the matrix we will follow through the section:

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 2 & 4 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{4 \times 5}(\mathbb{R}).$$

Three questions about it have come up in this chapter, and each answer is a set. For which $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^4$ can we solve $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$? By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), exactly for $\mathbf{b}$ in the span of the columns. Which $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^5$ solve $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$? By [Theorem 2.1.2](#), a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^5$. And which new equations can we derive from the four by adding multiples of them? Their left-hand sides are exactly the combinations of the rows. These three sets recur so often that they get names.

The column space is everything A can produce, the null space is everything A kills, and the row space is every left-hand side we can build from the equations of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$.

Definition 2.5.1 — Column space

The **column space** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is the span of its columns,

$$\text{col}(A) := \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n) = \{A\mathbf{x} : \mathbf{x} \in F^n\} \subseteq F^m.$$

Definition 2.5.2 — Row space

The **row space** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is the span of its rows,

$$\text{row}(A) := \text{span}(\text{row } 1, \dots, \text{row } m) \subseteq M_{1 \times n}(F).$$

Definition 2.5.3 — Null space

The **null space** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is the solution set of the homogeneous system,

$$\text{nul}(A) := \{\mathbf{x} \in F^n : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}\} \subseteq F^n.$$

In words: $\text{col}(A)$ lives among the **outputs**, in F^m (one entry per row); $\text{nul}(A)$ lives among the **inputs**, in F^n (one entry per column); and $\text{row}(A)$ consists of row vectors of length n . The two descriptions of $\text{col}(A)$ agree by [Theorem 0.9.3](#): $A\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{a}_n$, and as $\mathbf{x}$ runs over F^n these are all the combinations of the columns.

Well-definedness. All three are subspaces. $\text{col}(A)$ and $\text{row}(A)$ are spans, hence subspaces by [Theorem 1.3.1](#), of F^m and of $M_{1 \times n}(F)$ respectively. $\text{nul}(A)$ is a subspace of F^n by [Theorem 2.1.2](#). The row vectors $M_{1 \times n}(F)$ form an n -dimensional space, with the standard basis $\mathbf{e}_1^T, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n^T$ ([Example \(Dimensions of the Running Examples\)](#)). Transposing turns row vectors into columns and respects sums and scalar multiples ([Theorem 0.9.5](#)), so it sends a combination of rows to the same combination of their transposes, and only the zero row transposes to $\mathbf{0}$. The transposes of the rows of A are the columns of A^T . Hence transposing sends $\text{row}(A)$ onto $\text{col}(A^T)$, a list of rows is independent exactly when the list of their transposes is, and transposing a basis of

$\text{row}(A)$ gives a basis of $\text{col}(A^\top)$. Therefore

$$\dim \text{row}(A) = \dim \text{col}(A^\top). \quad (*)$$

Examples.

- **The identity.** $\text{col}(I_n) = F^n$, since the columns $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_n$ span; $\text{row}(I_n) = M_{1 \times n}(F)$; and $\text{nul}(I_n) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, since $I_n \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}$.
- **The zero matrix** is the degenerate case. For $0 = 0_{m \times n}$, $\text{col}(0) = \text{span}(\mathbf{0}, \dots, \mathbf{0}) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, $\text{row}(0) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, and $\text{nul}(0) = F^n$, since every $\mathbf{x}$ is killed. It carries no information, and its column space is as small as possible while its null space is as large as possible. We will see that this trade-off is exact.
- **A single row.** For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{1 \times 3}(\mathbb{R})$, the columns are the scalars $1, 1, -1 \in \mathbb{R}^1$, so $\text{col}(A) = \mathbb{R}^1$, $\text{row}(A) = \text{span}(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix})$ is a line of row vectors, and $\text{nul}(A)$ is the plane $x + y - z = 0$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Non-example by minimal change. Replace $\mathbf{0}$ by a non-zero right-hand side: the solution set $\{\mathbf{x} \in F^n : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}\}$ with $\mathbf{b} \neq \mathbf{0}$. It is described by the same equations, and it is still of the form $\mathbf{p} + \text{nul}(A)$ when non-empty (Theorem 2.1.3). But it does not contain $\mathbf{0}$, since $A\mathbf{0} = \mathbf{0} \neq \mathbf{b}$, so it fails the first condition of Theorem 1.2.1.

Warning. The three spaces live in **different places**. For $A \in M_{4 \times 5}(\mathbb{R})$ above, $\text{col}(A) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^4$ but $\text{nul}(A) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^5$, so a statement such as “ $\text{nul}(A) \subseteq \text{col}(A)$ ” does not even make sense. Keep track by size: $A\mathbf{x}$ needs $\mathbf{x}$ with n entries and returns a vector with m entries.

2.5.2 Rank and nullity

The column space measures how much A can reach, and the null space how much it collapses. We measure each by its dimension. Both are subspaces of finite-dimensional spaces, so both have a dimension by Theorem 1.6.7.

The rank counts the independent directions that A can produce.

Definition 2.5.4 — Rank of a matrix

The **rank** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is $\text{rank } A := \dim \text{col}(A)$.

Definition 2.5.5 — Nullity of a matrix

The **nullity** of $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ is $\text{nullity } A := \dim \text{nul}(A)$.

From the examples above: $\text{rank } I_n = n$ and $\text{nullity } I_n = 0$; $\text{rank } 0_{m \times n} = 0$ and $\text{nullity } 0_{m \times n} = n$; and $\text{rank} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} = 1$, with nullity 2. In each case rank plus nullity equals the number of columns. Two simple bounds hold at once: $\text{rank } A \leq m$, because $\text{col}(A) \subseteq F^m$, and $\text{rank } A \leq n$, because $\text{col}(A)$ is spanned by n vectors (Theorem 1.6.3). Why define rank through columns and not rows? We could have, and one of the main theorems of this section says the answer would be the same.

2.5.3 What row operations preserve

To compute these spaces we will row reduce. So we first ask what a row operation does to each of them. Recall from [Theorem 2.4.7](#) that A is row equivalent to B exactly when $B = EA$ with $E \in M_m(F)$ invertible; since row equivalence is symmetric ([Theorem 2.2.2](#) (b)), we may simply say that A and B are row equivalent.

Theorem 2.5.1 — Row operations and the three spaces

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ be row equivalent. Then:

- (a) $\text{row}(B) = \text{row}(A)$;
- (b) $\text{nul}(B) = \text{nul}(A)$. Equivalently, writing $\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_n$ for the columns of B : for all $c_1, \dots, c_n \in F$, the columns of A satisfy $c_1 \mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if the columns of B satisfy $c_1 \mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{b}_n = \mathbf{0}$;
- (c) but $\text{col}(B)$ and $\text{col}(A)$ **need not** be equal.

Proof.

- (a) Write $B = EA$ with E invertible, by [Theorem 2.4.7](#). By [Theorem 0.9.2](#), row i of EA is (row i of E) A , which by [Theorem 0.9.3](#) (rows version) is a combination of the rows of A . So every row of B lies in $\text{row}(A)$, and $\text{row}(B) \subseteq \text{row}(A)$ by [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (1). Since $A = E^{-1}B$ with E^{-1} invertible, the same argument gives $\text{row}(A) \subseteq \text{row}(B)$.
- (b) The equality $\text{nul}(B) = \text{nul}(A)$ is [Lemma 2.3.1](#). By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $c_1 \mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{a}_n = A\mathbf{c}$ and $c_1 \mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{b}_n = B\mathbf{c}$ with $\mathbf{c} = (c_1, \dots, c_n)$, so the second statement is the first one written out (this is [Lemma 2.3.2](#)).
- (c) Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, obtained by $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1$. Then $\text{col}(A) = \text{span}((1, 1))$ and $\text{col}(B) = \text{span}((1, 0))$. These lines differ, since $(1, 0)$ is not a multiple of $(1, 1)$.

■

So row reduction keeps the row space and the **relations among the columns**, but it moves the columns themselves.

Warning. Do not read $\text{col}(A)$ off the reduced form. In (c) above, the RREF of A is B , whose column space is the x -axis, while $\text{col}(A)$ is the line $y = x$. What survives row reduction is the *pattern* of dependence: in both matrices column 2 equals column 1. So we use the RREF to decide **which** columns to take, and then take those columns **from** A .

2.5.4 Bases from the reduced form

Fix the notation for the rest of the section. Let $R = (r_{kj})$ be the reduced row echelon form of A ([Theorem 2.2.3](#), [Theorem 2.3.4](#)), with columns $\mathbf{r}_1, \dots, \mathbf{r}_n \in F^m$. Let R have r non-zero rows, and let the pivot of row k lie in column j_k , so that $j_1 < j_2 < \dots < j_r$. These are the **pivot**

columns of A , well defined by [Corollary 2.3.5](#). The remaining columns are the **free columns**. We use three facts from [Definition 2.2.4](#):

- rows $r + 1, \dots, m$ of R are zero;
- column j_k of R is $\mathbf{e}_k$ (the pivot is 1 and the only non-zero entry of its column);
- in row k , every entry to the left of the pivot is 0.

From the last two, if column j of R has exactly t pivot columns to its left, then **every entry of $\mathbf{r}_j$ in rows $t + 1, \dots, m$ is zero, except the pivot entry of row $t + 1$ when $j = j_{t+1}$** . Indeed, for $k \geq t + 1$, row k is either zero or has its pivot in column $j_k \geq j$, and entries to the left of a pivot vanish. In the running example,

$$R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

with $r = 3$, pivot columns 1, 3, 4 and free columns 2, 5 (the reduction is carried out in [Example \(Bases for the running example\)](#) below).

The column space comes first. In R the answer is visible: the pivot columns are $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_r$, and every column has zeros below row r . Row reduction does not preserve columns, but by [Theorem 2.5.1](#) (b) it preserves every linear relation among them, and “is a basis” and “equals this combination” are statements about relations.

Theorem 2.5.2 — Pivot columns form a basis of the column space

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r$, and let $R = (r_{kj})$ be its RREF. Then:

- the pivot columns of A , $(\mathbf{a}_{j_1}, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j_r})$, form a basis of $\text{col}(A)$;
- if column j is free and t pivot columns lie to its left, then $\mathbf{a}_j = r_{1j}\mathbf{a}_{j_1} + \dots + r_{tj}\mathbf{a}_{j_t}$;
- the pivot columns of A are exactly the vectors kept when $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$ is sifted as in [Theorem 1.5.4](#).

Idea. Both claims are statements about linear relations among columns, so by [Theorem 2.5.1](#) (b) it suffices to prove them for R , where they can be seen by inspection. The pivot columns of R are $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_r$, which are independent. A free column of R is $\sum_k r_{kj}\mathbf{e}_k$, a combination of the pivot columns to its left with its own entries as coefficients. So we transfer two relations back to A : “ $\sum c_k \mathbf{a}_{j_k} = \mathbf{0}$ forces $c_1 = \dots = c_r = 0$ ” and “ $\mathbf{a}_j - \sum_k r_{kj}\mathbf{a}_{j_k} = \mathbf{0}$ ”. Part (c) is a rereading of [Corollary 2.3.5](#).

Proof. Throughout, we use [Theorem 2.5.1](#) (b) in the form: for scalars $c_1, \dots, c_n$,

$$c_1 \mathbf{a}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{a}_n = \mathbf{0} \iff c_1 \mathbf{r}_1 + \dots + c_n \mathbf{r}_n = \mathbf{0}. \quad (\dagger)$$

- Let column j be free, with t pivot columns $j_1, \dots, j_t$ to its left. By the fact in bold before the theorem, the entries of $\mathbf{r}_j$ in rows $t + 1, \dots, m$ are zero, so $\mathbf{r}_j = r_{1j}\mathbf{e}_1 + \dots + r_{tj}\mathbf{e}_t = r_{1j}\mathbf{r}_{j_1} + \dots + r_{tj}\mathbf{r}_{j_t}$, since $\mathbf{r}_{j_k} = \mathbf{e}_k$. This is a linear relation among the columns of R with coefficient 1 on $\mathbf{r}_j$, $-r_{kj}$ on $\mathbf{r}_{j_k}$, and 0 elsewhere. By $(\dagger)$, the columns of A satisfy the same relation, which is (b).
- Spanning.* Each pivot column $\mathbf{a}_{j_k}$ lies in $\text{span}(\mathbf{a}_{j_1}, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j_r})$, and each free column

does by (b). Hence $\text{col}(A) = \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n) \subseteq \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_{j_1}, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j_r})$ by [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (1). The reverse inclusion holds by [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (2), since the pivot columns are among the columns.

Independence. Let $c_1\mathbf{a}_{j_1} + \dots + c_r\mathbf{a}_{j_r} = \mathbf{0}$. This is a relation among all the columns of A with coefficient 0 on the free columns. By $(\dagger)$, $c_1\mathbf{r}_{j_1} + \dots + c_r\mathbf{r}_{j_r} = c_1\mathbf{e}_1 + \dots + c_r\mathbf{e}_r = \mathbf{0}$. The k -th entry of the left side is c_k , so $c_1 = \dots = c_r = 0$. Hence the pivot columns of A are linearly independent, and with spanning they form a basis of $\text{col}(A)$ by [Definition 1.5.1](#).

- (c) By [Corollary 2.3.5](#) (a), column j is a pivot column if and only if $\mathbf{a}_j \notin \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j-1})$. Sifting keeps $\mathbf{a}_j$ exactly when $\mathbf{a}_j$ is not in the span of the vectors kept before it, and by [Theorem 1.5.4](#) (applied to $(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j-1})$) that span is $\text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_{j-1})$. Hence the kept vectors are exactly the pivot columns. This proves the theorem. ■

This is sifting ([Theorem 1.5.4](#)) done by elimination. In Chapter 1, each step “is $\mathbf{v}_j$ in the span of the vectors kept so far?” was a separate small system. One row reduction answers all of them at once, and part (b) even gives the coefficients.

The row space and the null space are read off R directly.

Theorem 2.5.3 — Basis of the row space

The non-zero rows of the RREF R of A form a basis of $\text{row}(A)$.

Proof. By [Theorem 2.5.1](#) (a), $\text{row}(A) = \text{row}(R)$. The zero rows of R contribute nothing to a combination, so the r non-zero rows span $\text{row}(R)$. For independence, let $c_1(\text{row } 1) + \dots + c_r(\text{row } r) = 0$. Look at the entry in column j_k : since column j_k of R is $\mathbf{e}_k$, only row k has a non-zero entry there, equal to 1. So that entry of the combination is c_k , and $c_k = 0$ for each k . Hence the non-zero rows are a basis of $\text{row}(A)$. ■

For the null space, each free variable gets one basis vector: set that free variable to 1, the other free variables to 0, and solve for the pivot variables.

Theorem 2.5.4 — Basis of the null space

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have RREF $R = (r_{kj})$ with pivot columns $j_1 < \dots < j_r$. For each free column f , define $\mathbf{s}_f \in F^n$ by

$$(\mathbf{s}_f)_f = 1, \quad (\mathbf{s}_f)_{f'} = 0 \text{ for every other free } f', \quad (\mathbf{s}_f)_{j_k} = -r_{kf} \text{ for } k = 1, \dots, r.$$

Then the vectors $\mathbf{s}_f$, one for each free column f , form a basis of $\text{nul}(A)$. In particular $\text{nullity } A = n - r$, the number of free columns.

Proof. By [Theorem 2.5.1](#) (b), $\text{nul}(A) = \text{nul}(R)$. For $k \leq r$, row k of R has entry 1 in column j_k , entry 0 in every other pivot column (since column $j_{k'}$ is $\mathbf{e}_{k'}$), and entries r_{kf}

in the free columns. Rows $k > r$ are zero. Hence $R\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is equivalent to the r equations

$$x_{j_k} = - \sum_{f \text{ free}} r_{kf} x_f \quad (k = 1, \dots, r). \quad (\ddagger)$$

Spanning. Let $\mathbf{x} \in \text{nul}(A)$, and put $\mathbf{y} = \sum_{f \text{ free}} x_f \mathbf{s}_f$. For a free column f , the f -th entry of $\mathbf{y}$ is x_f , since $\mathbf{s}_f$ has a 1 there and the other $\mathbf{s}_{f'}$ have 0. For a pivot column, the j_k -th entry of $\mathbf{y}$ is $\sum_f x_f (-r_{kf})$, which equals x_{j_k} by $(\ddagger)$. So $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$ lies in the span of the $\mathbf{s}_f$. Each $\mathbf{s}_f$ itself satisfies $(\ddagger)$, so it lies in $\text{nul}(A)$.

Independence. If $\sum_f c_f \mathbf{s}_f = \mathbf{0}$, then the f -th entry of the left side is c_f , so every $c_f = 0$.

Hence the $\mathbf{s}_f$ form a basis of $\text{nul}(A)$, and there are $n - r$ of them. ■

Example. (Bases for the running example)

Find bases of $\text{col}(A)$, $\text{row}(A)$ and $\text{nul}(A)$, and the rank and nullity, for

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 2 & 4 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{4 \times 5}(\mathbb{R}).$$

Solution. Row reduce:

$$A \xrightarrow[\substack{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1}]{\substack{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\substack{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_2}]{\substack{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_3} R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The pivot columns are 1, 3, 4, and the free columns are 2, 5.

Column space. By Theorem 2.5.2 (a), the pivot columns of A ,

$$\mathbf{a}_1 = (1, 2, 1, 0), \quad \mathbf{a}_3 = (0, 1, 1, 1), \quad \mathbf{a}_4 = (0, 0, 1, 1),$$

form a basis of $\text{col}(A)$, so $\text{rank } A = 3$. By part (b), the free columns are $\mathbf{a}_2 = 2\mathbf{a}_1$ (from column 2 of R) and $\mathbf{a}_5 = -\mathbf{a}_1 + 2\mathbf{a}_3 + \mathbf{a}_4$ (from column 5). Check: $-(1, 2, 1, 0) + 2(0, 1, 1, 1) + (0, 0, 1, 1) = (-1, 0, 2, 3) = \mathbf{a}_5$. Note that $\text{col}(A) \neq \text{col}(R)$: every column of R has last entry 0, but $\mathbf{a}_3$ does not.

Row space. By Theorem 2.5.3, a basis is

$$(1 \ 2 \ 0 \ 0 \ -1), \quad (0 \ 0 \ 1 \ 0 \ 2), \quad (0 \ 0 \ 0 \ 1 \ 1),$$

so $\dim \text{row}(A) = 3$.

Null space. The equations $(\ddagger)$ read $x_1 = -2x_2 + x_5$, $x_3 = -2x_5$, $x_4 = -x_5$. By Theorem 2.5.4, a basis is

$$\mathbf{s}_2 = (-2, 1, 0, 0, 0), \quad \mathbf{s}_5 = (1, 0, -2, -1, 1),$$

so nullity $A = 2$. Check: $As_2 = -2\mathbf{a}_1 + \mathbf{a}_2 = \mathbf{0}$ and $As_5 = \mathbf{a}_1 - 2\mathbf{a}_3 - \mathbf{a}_4 + \mathbf{a}_5 = \mathbf{0}$, which are the two relations found above.

So $\text{rank } A = \dim \text{row}(A) = 3$ and $\text{rank } A + \text{nullity } A = 5$, the number of columns.

Quick check. Without computing anything, what is the largest possible rank of a 3×5 matrix, and the smallest possible nullity?

Solution. $\text{rank } A = \dim \text{col}(A) \leq 3$, since $\text{col}(A) \subseteq F^3$. By Theorem 2.5.4, the nullity is the number of free columns, $5 - r$, where $r \leq 3$ is the number of pivots (one per non-zero row). So the nullity is at least 2. For example $(I_3 \ 0_{3 \times 2})$ attains rank 3 and nullity 2.

2.5.5 Row rank equals column rank

The example came out with $\dim \text{row}(A) = \dim \text{col}(A)$. This is not luck, and it is surprising: the row space and the column space live in different spaces, and the rows and columns of a 4×5 matrix have nothing obvious in common. Counting pivots explains it.

Theorem 2.5.5 — Row rank equals column rank

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, and let r be the number of pivots of its RREF. Then

$$\dim \text{row}(A) = \dim \text{col}(A) = r.$$

Consequently $\text{rank } A = \text{rank } A^T$.

Proof. By Theorem 2.5.2 (a), $\text{col}(A)$ has a basis consisting of the r pivot columns, so $\dim \text{col}(A) = r$. By Theorem 2.5.3, $\text{row}(A)$ has a basis consisting of the non-zero rows of the RREF. Each non-zero row contains exactly one pivot and each pivot lies in a non-zero row, so there are r of them, and $\dim \text{row}(A) = r$. Finally, by (*) at the start of this section, $\text{rank } A^T = \dim \text{col}(A^T) = \dim \text{row}(A) = r = \text{rank } A$. ■

The theorem makes the rank independent of **which** echelon form we compute. Gaussian elimination without the final clearing-up phase produces an echelon form that is not reduced, and different sequences of operations produce different echelon forms. They all give the same count.

Corollary 2.5.6 — Rank from any echelon form

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, and let G be a matrix in row echelon form that is row equivalent to A . Then the number of non-zero rows of G is $\text{rank } A$, and the columns of G containing its pivots are exactly the pivot columns of A .

Proof. By Corollary 2.3.5 (b), the pivot columns of G are the pivot columns of A . Each non-zero row of G has exactly one pivot, in a different column (Definition 2.2.3), so the number of non-zero rows of G equals the number of pivot columns of A , which is $\text{rank } A$.

by [Theorem 2.5.5](#). ■

Warning. Rank is a property of A , not of a computation, but it must be counted from a row echelon form. The number of non-zero rows of A itself is not the rank: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$ has two non-zero rows and rank 1. Count non-zero rows only after reaching an echelon form. And the rank depends on the field when the entries are read in different fields: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$ has rank 2 over $\mathbb{R}$, but over $\mathbb{F}_2$, where $-1 = 1$, both rows are $(1 \ 1)$ and the rank is 1.

2.5.6 Rank–nullity and the Rouché–Capelli theorem

The trade-off between the zero matrix and the identity was exact, and now we can say why.

Theorem 2.5.7 — Rank–Nullity for Matrices

For every $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$,

$$\text{rank } A + \text{nullity } A = n,$$

the number of **columns** of A .

Proof. Let r be the number of pivot columns of A . By [Theorem 2.5.5](#), $\text{rank } A = r$. By [Theorem 2.5.4](#), $\text{nullity } A = n - r$. Adding gives n . ■

Each column of A is either a pivot column, contributing a direction to $\text{col}(A)$, or a free column, contributing a direction to $\text{nul}(A)$. Nothing is lost and nothing is counted twice. In Chapter 3 the same equation becomes the Rank–Nullity Theorem for linear maps, with a proof that uses no matrices at all.

Now the question this chapter started with. When does $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ have a solution, and how many solutions are there? The first answer was $\mathbf{b} \in \text{col}(A)$ ([Theorem 2.1.1](#)); here is a version that is a pure count.

Theorem 2.5.8 — Rouché–Capelli Theorem

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$, and let $[A \mid \mathbf{b}] \in M_{m \times (n+1)}(F)$ be the augmented matrix.

- (a) The system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent if and only if $\text{rank } A = \text{rank } [A \mid \mathbf{b}]$.
- (b) Suppose it is consistent, let $\mathbf{p}$ be one solution, let $r = \text{rank } A$, and let $\mathbf{s}_1, \dots, \mathbf{s}_{n-r}$ be a basis of $\text{nul}(A)$. Then every solution can be written as

$$\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{p} + t_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \cdots + t_{n-r}\mathbf{s}_{n-r}$$

for **exactly one** choice of $(t_1, \dots, t_{n-r}) \in F^{n-r}$. In words: the solutions form an $(n-r)$ -parameter family.

- (c) If moreover F is a finite field with q elements (for instance $\mathbb{F}_p$, with $q = p$), a consistent system has exactly $q^{n-\text{rank } A}$ solutions.

Idea. For (a), adding the column $\mathbf{b}$ can only enlarge the column space, and the dimension goes up exactly when $\mathbf{b}$ is new, that is, when $\mathbf{b} \notin \text{col}(A)$. For (b), the structure theorem says solutions are $\mathbf{p}$ plus null vectors, and null vectors have unique coordinates in a basis. For (c), unique coordinates mean the solutions are in bijection with F^{n-r} , which has q^{n-r} elements.

Proof.

- (a) By [Definition 2.5.1](#), $\text{col}([A \mid \mathbf{b}]) = \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n, \mathbf{b})$, which contains $\text{col}(A)$ by [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (2).
 $(\Rightarrow)$ Suppose the system is consistent. By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), $\mathbf{b} \in \text{span}(\mathbf{a}_1, \dots, \mathbf{a}_n)$, so by [Theorem 1.3.5](#) $\text{col}([A \mid \mathbf{b}]) = \text{col}(A)$, and the ranks are equal.
 $(\Leftarrow)$ Suppose $\text{rank } A = \text{rank } [A \mid \mathbf{b}]$. Then $\text{col}(A)$ is a subspace of $\text{col}([A \mid \mathbf{b}])$ of the same dimension, so $\text{col}(A) = \text{col}([A \mid \mathbf{b}])$ by [Theorem 1.6.8](#). In particular $\mathbf{b} \in \text{col}(A)$, and the system is consistent by [Theorem 2.1.1](#).
- (b) By [Theorem 2.5.7](#), nullity $A = n - r$, so a basis $\mathbf{s}_1, \dots, \mathbf{s}_{n-r}$ of $\text{nul}(A)$ exists ([Theorem 2.5.4](#)). By [Theorem 2.1.3](#), $\mathbf{x}$ is a solution if and only if $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p} \in \text{nul}(A)$. By [Theorem 1.5.1](#), applied in the vector space $\text{nul}(A)$ with this basis, each $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p} \in \text{nul}(A)$ equals $t_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \dots + t_{n-r}\mathbf{s}_{n-r}$ for exactly one $(t_1, \dots, t_{n-r})$. Conversely every such expression is in $\text{nul}(A)$, so $\mathbf{p}$ plus it is a solution. This proves (b).
- (c) By (b), the rule $(t_1, \dots, t_{n-r}) \mapsto \mathbf{p} + t_1\mathbf{s}_1 + \dots + t_{n-r}\mathbf{s}_{n-r}$ is a bijection from F^{n-r} onto the solution set: every solution is hit, and by exactly one tuple. A tuple in F^{n-r} is a choice of $n-r$ entries, each one of q elements, so F^{n-r} has q^{n-r} elements. (When $r = n$ there is exactly one tuple, the empty one, and the basis of $\text{nul}(A)$ is empty, so $\mathbf{p}$ is the only solution and $q^0 = 1$.) Hence the solution set has q^{n-r} elements. ■

Over an infinite field such as $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$, part (b) gives the familiar trichotomy: no solution, exactly one solution (when $\text{rank } A = n$), or infinitely many (when $\text{rank } A < n$, since distinct values of t_1 give distinct solutions). Over a finite field “infinitely many” is replaced by an exact power of q . For example, over $\mathbb{F}_2$ a system can never have exactly 3 or 6 solutions.

Example. (Counting solutions over $\mathbb{F}_3$)

Over $\mathbb{F}_3$, consider

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b}' = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Decide whether $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ and $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}'$ are consistent, and count their solutions.

Solution. We reduce both augmented matrices at once, carrying two right-hand columns; arithmetic is modulo 3, so $-1 = 2$ and $-2 = 1$.

$$\left[\begin{array}{cccc|c|c} 1 & 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c|c} 1 & 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 & 1 \end{array} \right] \xrightarrow[R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \left[\begin{array}{cccc|c|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 2 \end{array} \right].$$

Row operations act on each column separately, so deleting either right-hand column gives a reduction of the corresponding augmented matrix. For instance, in row 2, $(1, 2, 1, 0) - (1, 1, 0, 2) = (0, 1, 1, -2) = (0, 1, 1, 1)$, and in row 3, $(2, 0, 1, 2) - 2(1, 1, 0, 2) = (0, -2, 1, -2) = (0, 1, 1, 1)$.

The left block is an echelon form of A with two non-zero rows, so $\text{rank } A = 2$ by [Corollary 2.5.6](#). With $\mathbf{b}$, the augmented matrix $[A \mid \mathbf{b}]$ has the same two non-zero rows (the last is zero), so $\text{rank } [A \mid \mathbf{b}] = 2 = \text{rank } A$, and by [Theorem 2.5.8](#) (a) the system is consistent. By part (c) it has exactly $3^{4-2} = 9$ solutions. Explicitly, the reduced system is $x_1 = 2 - 2x_3 - x_4 = 2 + x_3 + 2x_4$ and $x_2 = 2 - x_3 - x_4 = 2 + 2x_3 + 2x_4$, with $x_3, x_4 \in \mathbb{F}_3$ free: nine choices.

With $\mathbf{b}'$, the last row $(0, 0, 0, 0 \mid 2)$ is a non-zero row with its pivot in the last column, so $[A \mid \mathbf{b}']$ has three non-zero rows in echelon form and $\text{rank } [A \mid \mathbf{b}'] = 3 \neq 2$. By [Theorem 2.5.8](#) (a), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}'$ has no solution. Indeed, row 3 of A is the sum of rows 1 and 2, so any solution would need $b'_3 = b'_1 + b'_2 = 1$, but $b'_3 = 0$.

2.5.7 Rank of a product

Multiplying matrices cannot create information: every column of AB is a combination of the columns of A , and every row is a combination of the rows of B . The rank records this.

Theorem 2.5.9 — Rank of a product

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ and $B \in M_{n \times p}(F)$. Then

$$\text{rank}(AB) \leq \min(\text{rank } A, \text{rank } B).$$

Moreover, if $P \in M_m(F)$ and $Q \in M_n(F)$ are invertible, then $\text{rank}(PA) = \text{rank } A = \text{rank}(AQ)$.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_p \in F^n$ be the columns of B . By [Theorem 0.9.2](#), the columns of AB are $A\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, A\mathbf{b}_p$, which lie in $\text{col}(A)$ by [Definition 2.5.1](#). By [Proposition 1.3.4](#) (1), $\text{col}(AB) \subseteq \text{col}(A)$, so $\text{rank}(AB) \leq \text{rank } A$ by [Theorem 1.6.7](#). Similarly, row i of AB is $(\text{row } i \text{ of } A)B$, a combination of the rows of B by [Theorem 0.9.3](#) (rows version), so $\text{row}(AB) \subseteq \text{row}(B)$. By [Theorem 2.5.5](#), $\text{rank}(AB) = \dim \text{row}(AB) \leq \dim \text{row}(B) = \text{rank } B$.

For the second statement, apply the inequality twice: $\text{rank } A = \text{rank}(P^{-1}(PA)) \leq \text{rank}(PA) \leq \text{rank } A$, so equality holds throughout. The same sandwich with $A = (AQ)Q^{-1}$ gives $\text{rank}(AQ) = \text{rank } A$. ■

The equality case recovers something we already knew in a new form: row operations (left multiplication by an invertible P) do not change the rank. The inequality is often strict. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, both factors of $A \cdot A$ have rank 1, but $A^2 = 0$ has rank 0.

2.5.8 A toolkit for questions from Chapter 1

In Chapter 1 we asked, again and again, whether some vectors in F^m are independent, whether they span, how to extend them to a basis, and what the sum and intersection of two subspaces are. Each was answered by solving a small system by hand. Everything now reduces to one move: **put the vectors as columns of a matrix, row reduce, and read off pivots.**

Theorem 2.5.10 — Independence and spanning by rank

Let $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k \in F^m$, and let $A = (\mathbf{v}_1 \ \cdots \ \mathbf{v}_k) \in M_{m \times k}(F)$. Then:

- (a) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is linearly independent if and only if $\text{rank } A = k$, that is, every column is a pivot column;
- (b) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ spans F^m if and only if $\text{rank } A = m$, that is, every row of the RREF has a pivot;
- (c) $(\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k)$ is a basis of F^m if and only if $k = m = \text{rank } A$.

Proof.

- (a) By [Theorem 0.9.3](#), $c_1\mathbf{v}_1 + \cdots + c_k\mathbf{v}_k = A\mathbf{c}$ with $\mathbf{c} = (c_1, \dots, c_k)$, so the list is independent if and only if $\text{nul}(A) = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, that is, nullity $A = 0$. By [Theorem 2.5.7](#) this means $\text{rank } A = k$.
- (b) The list spans F^m if and only if $\text{col}(A) = F^m$. Since $\text{col}(A) \subseteq F^m$ and $\dim F^m = m$, this holds if and only if $\text{rank } A = m$, by [Theorem 1.6.8](#) for one direction and because equal spaces have equal dimension for the other. The number of pivots is $\text{rank } A$ by [Theorem 2.5.5](#), and the RREF has m rows, each with at most one pivot.
- (c) Combine (a) and (b) with [Definition 1.5.1](#).

■

Example. (Testing independence)

Decide whether $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 2, 0, 1)$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = (2, 4, 1, 1)$, $\mathbf{v}_3 = (0, 0, 1, -1)$ are linearly independent in $\mathbb{R}^4$. If not, find a linear relation.

Solution. Row reduce the matrix with these columns:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 2 & 4 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\substack{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1}]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\substack{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2}]{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Only columns 1 and 2 are pivot columns, so the rank is $2 < 3$, and the vectors are

dependent by [Theorem 2.5.10](#) (a). Column 3 of the RREF gives the relation, by [Theorem 2.5.2](#) (b): $\mathbf{v}_3 = -2\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2$. Check: $-2(1, 2, 0, 1) + (2, 4, 1, 1) = (0, 0, 1, -1)$. Moreover $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$ is a basis of $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$ by [Theorem 2.5.2](#) (a).

To **extend** an independent list to a basis of F^m , append the standard basis and keep the pivot columns. The appended vectors guarantee that the columns span F^m . The original vectors all survive, because by [Theorem 2.5.2](#) (c) a column is discarded only if it lies in the span of the columns before it, and an independent list has no such vector ([Lemma 1.5.3](#)).

Example. (Extending to a basis by elimination)

Extend the independent list $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2) = ((1, 2, 0, 1), (2, 4, 1, 1))$ from [Example \(Testing independence\)](#) to a basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$.

Solution. Form $M = (\mathbf{v}_1 \ \mathbf{v}_2 \ \mathbf{e}_1 \ \mathbf{e}_2 \ \mathbf{e}_3 \ \mathbf{e}_4)$ and row reduce:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 4 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\text{then } R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + R_2]{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{then } R_3 \rightarrow -R_3]{R_3 \leftrightarrow R_4} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + 2R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -2 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

This is an echelon form with pivots in columns 1, 2, 3, 4. By [Corollary 2.5.6](#) these are the pivot columns of M , so by [Theorem 2.5.2](#) (a) the corresponding columns of M form a basis of $\text{col}(M) = \mathbb{R}^4$:

$$(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2).$$

(Clearing above the pivots gives the RREF, whose column 5 says $\mathbf{e}_3 = -\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2 - \mathbf{e}_1 - 2\mathbf{e}_2$; check: $-(1, 2, 0, 1) + (2, 4, 1, 1) - (1, 0, 0, 0) - 2(0, 1, 0, 0) = (0, 0, 1, 0)$.)

For sums and intersections, one reduction does both jobs.

Proposition 2.5.11 — Sum and intersection by elimination

Let $U, W \subseteq F^m$ be subspaces with bases $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k)$ and $(\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_l)$, and let $M = (\mathbf{u}_1 \ \dots \ \mathbf{u}_k \ \mathbf{w}_1 \ \dots \ \mathbf{w}_l) \in M_{m \times (k+l)}(F)$. Then:

- (a) the pivot columns of M form a basis of $U + W$;
- (b) for $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \dots, x_{k+l}) \in F^{k+l}$ write $\mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{x}} := x_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + x_k\mathbf{u}_k$, the combination of the $\mathbf{u}$'s with the first k entries of $\mathbf{x}$ as coefficients. If $(\mathbf{n}_1, \dots, \mathbf{n}_d)$ is a basis of $\text{nul}(M)$, then $(\mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{n}_1}, \dots, \mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{n}_d})$ is a basis of $U \cap W$.

In particular $\dim(U + W) = \text{rank } M$ and $\dim(U \cap W) = \text{nullity } M$.

Proof.

- (a) By [Proposition 1.7.2](#), $U + W = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, \mathbf{w}_1, \dots, \mathbf{w}_l) = \text{col}(M)$, and Theo-

rem 2.5.2 (a) applies.

- (b) By Theorem 0.9.3, $\mathbf{x} \in \text{nul}(M)$ means $x_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + x_k\mathbf{u}_k = -(x_{k+1}\mathbf{w}_1 + \cdots + x_{k+l}\mathbf{w}_l)$, so $\mathbf{u}_\mathbf{x}$ lies in U and in W . Also $\mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{x}+\mathbf{y}} = \mathbf{u}_\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{u}_\mathbf{y}$ and $\mathbf{u}_{c\mathbf{x}} = c\mathbf{u}_\mathbf{x}$, by the vector space axioms in F^m .

Spanning. Let $\mathbf{v} \in U \cap W$. Since the $\mathbf{u}$'s span U and the $\mathbf{w}$'s span W , $\mathbf{v} = a_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + a_k\mathbf{u}_k = b_1\mathbf{w}_1 + \cdots + b_l\mathbf{w}_l$. Then $\mathbf{x} = (a_1, \dots, a_k, -b_1, \dots, -b_l) \in \text{nul}(M)$ and $\mathbf{u}_\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{v}$. Writing $\mathbf{x} = \sum_i t_i \mathbf{n}_i$ gives $\mathbf{v} = \sum_i t_i \mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{n}_i}$.

Independence. Let $\sum_i t_i \mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{n}_i} = \mathbf{0}$, and put $\mathbf{x} = \sum_i t_i \mathbf{n}_i \in \text{nul}(M)$. Then $\mathbf{u}_\mathbf{x} = x_1\mathbf{u}_1 + \cdots + x_k\mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{0}$, so $x_1 = \cdots = x_k = 0$ because the $\mathbf{u}$'s are independent. Since $M\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, also $x_{k+1}\mathbf{w}_1 + \cdots + x_{k+l}\mathbf{w}_l = \mathbf{0}$, so the remaining entries vanish because the $\mathbf{w}$'s are independent. Hence $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and $t_1 = \cdots = t_d = 0$ because the $\mathbf{n}_i$ are independent.

The dimension statements follow by counting the two bases, using Theorem 2.5.5 for rank M .

■

Adding the two counts and using Theorem 2.5.7 gives $\dim(U + W) + \dim(U \cap W) = \text{rank } M + \text{nullity } M = k + l = \dim U + \dim W$. This is the Dimension Formula for Sums (Theorem 1.7.3) again, now with a second, computational proof for subspaces of F^m . (Some texts use the matrix with columns $\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_k, -\mathbf{w}_1, \dots, -\mathbf{w}_l$ instead of M , so that a null vector gives equal combinations $\sum a_i \mathbf{u}_i = \sum b_j \mathbf{w}_j$ with no sign change. The two null spaces differ only by the signs of the last l entries.)

Example. (A basis of a sum)

Let $U = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2)$ and $W = \text{span}(\mathbf{w}_1, \mathbf{w}_2)$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$, where

$$\mathbf{u}_1 = (1, 0, 1, 2), \quad \mathbf{u}_2 = (0, 1, 1, 1), \quad \mathbf{w}_1 = (1, 1, 0, 1), \quad \mathbf{w}_2 = (1, 3, 0, 1).$$

Find a basis and the dimension of $U + W$.

Solution. Each pair is independent, since neither vector is a multiple of the other (compare the first two entries), so $\dim U = \dim W = 2$. Row reduce $M = (\mathbf{u}_1 \quad \mathbf{u}_2 \quad \mathbf{w}_1 \quad \mathbf{w}_2)$:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - 2R_1]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & -4 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & -4 \end{pmatrix}$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{then } R_3 \rightarrow -\frac{1}{2}R_3]{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_3]{R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3} R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The pivot columns are 1, 2, 3. By Proposition 2.5.11 (a), $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{w}_1)$ is a basis of $U + W$, and $\dim(U + W) = 3$. Column 4 of R says $\mathbf{w}_2 = -\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 + 2\mathbf{w}_1$; check: $-(1, 0, 1, 2) + (0, 1, 1, 1) + 2(1, 1, 0, 1) = (1, 3, 0, 1)$.

Example. (A basis of an intersection)

For U and W as in [Example \(A basis of a sum\)](#), find a basis of $U \cap W$, and check the Dimension Formula for Sums.

Solution. We reuse the RREF R of M . Its only free column is column 4, so by [Theorem 2.5.4](#) $\text{nul}(M)$ has the basis $\mathbf{n} = (1, -1, -2, 1)$ (set $x_4 = 1$; then $x_1 = 1$, $x_2 = -1$, $x_3 = -2$). The relation $M\mathbf{n} = \mathbf{0}$ reads $\mathbf{u}_1 - \mathbf{u}_2 - 2\mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2 = \mathbf{0}$, that is,

$$\mathbf{u}_1 - \mathbf{u}_2 = 2\mathbf{w}_1 - \mathbf{w}_2.$$

By [Proposition 2.5.11](#) (b), $\mathbf{u}_{\mathbf{n}} = \mathbf{u}_1 - \mathbf{u}_2 = (1, -1, 0, 1)$ is a basis of $U \cap W$. Check that it lies in W : $2(1, 1, 0, 1) - (1, 3, 0, 1) = (1, -1, 0, 1)$. So $\dim(U \cap W) = 1$, and

$$\dim U + \dim W - \dim(U \cap W) = 2 + 2 - 1 = 3 = \dim(U + W),$$

in agreement with [Theorem 1.7.3](#).

2.5.9 Exercises

2.5.9.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- Define $\text{col}(A)$, $\text{row}(A)$, $\text{nul}(A)$ and $\text{rank } A$ for $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, and say which space each subspace lives in.
- State the Rank–Nullity Theorem for matrices and the Rouché–Capelli Theorem.
- True or false: if R is the RREF of A , then $\text{col}(R) = \text{col}(A)$. Justify your answer.
- True or false: there is a 4×6 real matrix with nullity 1. Justify your answer.
- True or false: for every $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, $\text{rank } A = \text{rank } A^T$. Justify your answer.
- Describe how to find a basis of $U \cap W$ for subspaces $U, W \subseteq F^m$ given by bases.

Solution.

- $\text{col}(A)$ is the span of the columns, a subspace of F^m ; $\text{row}(A)$ is the span of the rows, a subspace of $M_{1 \times n}(F)$; $\text{nul}(A) = \{\mathbf{x} \in F^n : A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}\}$, a subspace of F^n ; and $\text{rank } A = \dim \text{col}(A)$ ([Definition 2.5.1](#), [Definition 2.5.2](#), [Definition 2.5.3](#), [Definition 2.5.4](#)).
- For $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$, $\text{rank } A + \text{nullity } A = n$ ([Theorem 2.5.7](#)). For $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$, $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent if and only if $\text{rank } A = \text{rank } [A \mid \mathbf{b}]$; then the solutions are $\mathbf{p} + \text{nul}(A)$, an $(n - \text{rank } A)$ -parameter family, with exactly $q^{n - \text{rank } A}$ solutions over a field with q elements ([Theorem 2.5.8](#)).
- False. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, and $(1, 1) \in \text{col}(A)$ but $(1, 1) \notin \text{col}(R) = \text{span}((1, 0))$. Row operations preserve the row space and the column relations, not the column space ([Theorem 2.5.1](#)).
- False. Its rank is at most 4, since the column space lies in $\mathbb{R}^4$, so by [Theorem 2.5.7](#) its nullity is $6 - \text{rank } A \geq 2$.

- (e) True. This is [Theorem 2.5.5](#).
 (f) Put the basis vectors of U and then of W as the columns of M , find a basis of $\text{nul}(M)$ from the RREF, and for each basis vector $\mathbf{n}$ take the combination of the $\mathbf{u}$'s with the first k entries of $\mathbf{n}$ as coefficients ([Proposition 2.5.11](#)).

2.5.9.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: The three subspaces of a 3×5 matrix.

Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 2 & 0 & 3 \\ 2 & -2 & 5 & 1 & 4 \\ -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 & -5 \end{pmatrix} \in M_{3 \times 5}(\mathbb{R}).$$

Find bases of $\text{col}(A)$, $\text{row}(A)$ and $\text{nul}(A)$. Hence verify $\text{rank } A + \text{nullity } A = 5$.

Solution. Row reduce:

$$A \xrightarrow[\substack{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1 \\ R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_1}]{\substack{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2 \\ R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 2 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & -2 & 7 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The pivot columns are 1 and 3; the free columns are 2, 4, 5.

By [Theorem 2.5.2](#), the pivot columns of A , $(1, 2, -1)$ and $(2, 5, -1)$, form a basis of $\text{col}(A)$. By [Theorem 2.5.3](#), $(1 \ -1 \ 0 \ -2 \ 7)$ and $(0 \ 0 \ 1 \ 1 \ -2)$ form a basis of $\text{row}(A)$. The reduced equations are $x_1 = x_2 + 2x_4 - 7x_5$ and $x_3 = -x_4 + 2x_5$, so by [Theorem 2.5.4](#) a basis of $\text{nul}(A)$ is

$$\mathbf{s}_2 = (1, 1, 0, 0, 0), \quad \mathbf{s}_4 = (2, 0, -1, 1, 0), \quad \mathbf{s}_5 = (-7, 0, 2, 0, 1).$$

For example $A\mathbf{s}_4 = 2\mathbf{a}_1 - \mathbf{a}_3 + \mathbf{a}_4 = (2, 4, -2) - (2, 5, -1) + (0, 1, 1) = \mathbf{0}$. Hence $\text{rank } A = 2$ and $\text{nullity } A = 3$, and $2 + 3 = 5$, as [Theorem 2.5.7](#) requires.

Exercise B2: Independence and extension in $\mathbb{R}^4$.

Let $\mathbf{v}_1 = (1, 0, 2, 1)$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = (2, 1, 3, 1)$, $\mathbf{v}_3 = (0, 1, -1, -1)$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$.

- (a) Determine whether $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$ is linearly independent. Justify your answer.
 (b) Find a basis of $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$, and extend it to a basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$ using standard basis vectors.

Solution.

- (a) Row reduce the matrix with columns $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3$:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 2 & 3 & -1 \\ 1 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\substack{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1 \\ R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1}]{\substack{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2 \\ R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + R_2, \ R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 2R_2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The rank is $2 < 3$, so the list is dependent by [Theorem 2.5.10](#) (a). Column 3

gives $\mathbf{v}_3 = -2\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2$ (Theorem 2.5.2 (b)); check: $(-2, 0, -4, -2) + (2, 1, 3, 1) = (0, 1, -1, -1)$.

- (b) By Theorem 2.5.2 (a), $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$ is a basis of $\text{span}(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3)$. To extend it, row reduce $(\mathbf{v}_1 \ \mathbf{v}_2 \ \mathbf{e}_1 \ \mathbf{e}_2 \ \mathbf{e}_3 \ \mathbf{e}_4)$:

$$\begin{aligned} & \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 3 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & -2 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \\ & \xrightarrow[\text{then } R_3 \rightarrow -R_3]{R_3 \leftrightarrow R_4} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + 2R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & -2 \end{pmatrix}. \end{aligned}$$

This echelon form has pivots in columns 1, 2, 3, 4, which are the pivot columns by Corollary 2.5.6. By Theorem 2.5.2 (a) the corresponding columns form a basis of the column space, which is $\mathbb{R}^4$ since it contains $\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_4$. Hence $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ is a basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$ extending $(\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2)$.

Exercise B3: Sum and intersection in $\mathbb{R}^5$.

Let $U = \text{span}(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{u}_3)$ and $W = \text{span}(\mathbf{w}_1, \mathbf{w}_2)$ in $\mathbb{R}^5$, where

$$\mathbf{u}_1 = (1, 1, 0, 0, 1), \quad \mathbf{u}_2 = (0, 1, 1, 0, 0), \quad \mathbf{u}_3 = (1, 0, 0, 1, 0), \quad \mathbf{w}_1 = (1, 2, 2, 1, 2), \quad \mathbf{w}_2 = (0, 0, 1, 1, 1).$$

Find $\dim U$, $\dim W$, a basis of $U + W$ and a basis of $U \cap W$. Hence verify Theorem 1.7.3.

Solution. Row reduce $M = (\mathbf{u}_1 \ \mathbf{u}_2 \ \mathbf{u}_3 \ \mathbf{w}_1 \ \mathbf{w}_2)$:

$$\begin{aligned} & \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_5 \rightarrow R_5 - R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \\ & \xrightarrow[R_5 \rightarrow R_5 + R_3]{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[\text{then } R_4 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_4]{R_4 \leftrightarrow R_5} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \end{aligned}$$

Clearing above the pivots ($R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_4$, $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_4$, $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_4$, then $R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_3$, $R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_3$) gives

$$R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The pivot columns are 1, 2, 3, 4, so $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{u}_3, \mathbf{w}_1)$ is independent by [Theorem 2.5.2 \(a\)](#), and so are its sub-lists $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{u}_3)$ and $(\mathbf{w}_1)$; also $\mathbf{w}_2$ is not a multiple of $\mathbf{w}_1$ (compare first entries). Hence $\dim U = 3$ and $\dim W = 2$, with the given spanning lists as bases. By [Proposition 2.5.11 \(a\)](#), $(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \mathbf{u}_3, \mathbf{w}_1)$ is a basis of $U + W$, so $\dim(U + W) = 4$.

The only free column is column 5. Setting $x_5 = 1$ gives $\mathbf{n} = (1, 1, 0, -1, 1)$, a basis of $\text{nul}(M)$ by [Theorem 2.5.4](#). So $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 - \mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2 = \mathbf{0}$, and by [Proposition 2.5.11 \(b\)](#), $\mathbf{u}_1 + \mathbf{u}_2 = (1, 2, 1, 0, 1)$ is a basis of $U \cap W$. Check: $\mathbf{w}_1 - \mathbf{w}_2 = (1, 2, 1, 0, 1)$. Hence $\dim(U \cap W) = 1$, and

$$\dim U + \dim W - \dim(U \cap W) = 3 + 2 - 1 = 4 = \dim(U + W).$$

2.5.9.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Rank of a sum.

Let $A, B \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. Prove that $\text{rank}(A + B) \leq \text{rank } A + \text{rank } B$. Give an example where the inequality is strict.

Solution. The j -th column of $A + B$ is $\mathbf{a}_j + \mathbf{b}_j$, which lies in $\text{col}(A) + \text{col}(B)$ ([Definition 1.7.1](#)). This sum is a subspace ([Theorem 1.7.1](#)), so by [Theorem 1.3.1](#), $\text{col}(A + B) \subseteq \text{col}(A) + \text{col}(B)$. By [Theorem 1.6.7](#) and [Theorem 1.7.3](#),

$$\text{rank}(A+B) \leq \dim(\text{col}(A) + \text{col}(B)) = \text{rank } A + \text{rank } B - \dim(\text{col}(A) \cap \text{col}(B)) \leq \text{rank } A + \text{rank } B.$$

For strictness, take $A = I_2$ and $B = -I_2$ over $\mathbb{R}$: $\text{rank}(A + B) = \text{rank } 0 = 0 < 2 + 2$.

Exercise C2: Matrices of rank one.

Let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$. Prove that $\text{rank } A = 1$ if and only if $A = \mathbf{xy}^T$ for some **non-zero** $\mathbf{x} \in F^m$ and $\mathbf{y} \in F^n$.

Solution. ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $A = \mathbf{xy}^T$ with $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \neq \mathbf{0}$, and write $\mathbf{y} = (y_1, \dots, y_n)$. By [Theorem 0.9.2](#), the j -th column of $\mathbf{xy}^T$ is $\mathbf{x}$ times the j -th column of $\mathbf{y}^T$, the 1×1 matrix (y_j) ; that is, $y_j \mathbf{x}$. So every column lies in $\text{span}(\mathbf{x})$, and $\text{col}(A) \subseteq \text{span}(\mathbf{x})$. Since $\mathbf{y} \neq \mathbf{0}$, some $y_j \neq 0$, and then $y_j \mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$ because $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$ ([Theorem 1.1.9](#)). The list $(\mathbf{x})$ is independent, since $a\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ forces $a = 0$ ([Theorem 1.1.9](#)), so $\text{span}(\mathbf{x})$ has dimension 1, and $\text{rank } A \leq 1$ by [Theorem 1.6.7](#). On the other hand $\text{rank } A \neq 0$: a space of dimension 0 has the empty list as a basis, so it equals $\text{span}() = \{\mathbf{0}\}$, but $\text{col}(A)$ contains the non-zero vector $y_j \mathbf{x}$. Hence $\text{rank } A = 1$.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $\text{rank } A = 1$, and let $(\mathbf{x})$ be a basis of $\text{col}(A)$; then $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Each column $\mathbf{a}_j \in \text{col}(A)$ equals $y_j \mathbf{x}$ for some $y_j \in F$. Put $\mathbf{y} = (y_1, \dots, y_n)$. By the computation in ($\Leftarrow$), the j -th column of $\mathbf{xy}^T$ is $y_j \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{a}_j$, so $A = \mathbf{xy}^T$. If $\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$, then $A = 0$ would have $\text{rank } 0$, so $\mathbf{y} \neq \mathbf{0}$. This proves the claim.

Exercise C3: The matrix $i + j$.

For $n \geq 1$, let $A_n \in M_n(\mathbb{R})$ have entries $a_{ij} = i + j$. Prove that $\text{rank } A_1 = 1$ and $\text{rank } A_n = 2$ for every $n \geq 2$. Hence find nullity A_n .

Hint: write each row as a combination of two fixed row vectors.

Solution. For $n = 1$, $A_1 = (2) \neq 0$, so $\text{rank } A_1 = 1$. Let $n \geq 2$, and put $\mathbf{1} = (1 \ 1 \ \cdots \ 1)$ and $\mathbf{d} = (1 \ 2 \ \cdots \ n)$ in $M_{1 \times n}(\mathbb{R})$. Row i of A_n is $(i+1 \ \cdots \ i+n) = i\mathbf{1} + \mathbf{d}$. So $\text{row}(A_n) \subseteq \text{span}(\mathbf{1}, \mathbf{d})$, and $\dim \text{row}(A_n) \leq 2$ by [Theorem 1.6.3](#).

Rows 1 and 2 are $(2 \ 3 \ \cdots)$ and $(3 \ 4 \ \cdots)$. If $c_1(\text{row } 1) + c_2(\text{row } 2) = 0$, the first two entries give $2c_1 + 3c_2 = 0$ and $3c_1 + 4c_2 = 0$. Subtracting the first from the second gives $c_1 + c_2 = 0$, so $c_1 = -c_2$, and then $-2c_2 + 3c_2 = c_2 = 0$, so $c_1 = 0$. Hence $\text{row}(A_n)$ contains two independent vectors, and $\dim \text{row}(A_n) \geq 2$ by [Theorem 1.6.3](#).

So $\dim \text{row}(A_n) = 2$, and $\text{rank } A_n = 2$ by [Theorem 2.5.5](#). By [Theorem 2.5.7](#), nullity $A_n = n - 2$ for $n \geq 2$, and nullity $A_1 = 0$.

Exercise C4: Counting right-hand sides over a finite field.

Let F be a finite field with q elements, and let $A \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ have rank r .

- Prove that exactly q^r vectors $\mathbf{b} \in F^m$ make $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ consistent.
- By counting the pairs $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{b}) \in F^n \times F^m$ with $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ in two ways, and using [Theorem 2.1.3](#) but **not** [Theorem 2.5.7](#), prove that $\text{nul}(A)$ has exactly q^{n-r} elements. Deduce nullity $A = n - r$: a counting proof of Rank–Nullity over a finite field.
- Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. How many $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{F}_2^3$ give a consistent system, and how many solutions does each such system have?

Solution.

- By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent exactly when $\mathbf{b} \in \text{col}(A)$. Let $(\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_r)$ be a basis of $\text{col}(A)$. By [Theorem 1.5.1](#), $(t_1, \dots, t_r) \mapsto t_1\mathbf{c}_1 + \cdots + t_r\mathbf{c}_r$ is a bijection $F^r \rightarrow \text{col}(A)$: every vector of $\text{col}(A)$ is hit by exactly one tuple. Since F^r has q^r elements, so does $\text{col}(A)$.
- Let $N = |\text{nul}(A)|$. Each $\mathbf{x} \in F^n$ determines exactly one $\mathbf{b} = A\mathbf{x}$, so there are q^n pairs. Now group the pairs by $\mathbf{b}$. If $\mathbf{b} \notin \text{col}(A)$, there are none, by [Theorem 2.1.1](#). If $\mathbf{b} \in \text{col}(A)$, pick one solution $\mathbf{p}$; by [Theorem 2.1.3](#) the solutions are $\mathbf{p} + \text{nul}(A)$, and $\mathbf{h} \mapsto \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}$ is a bijection from $\text{nul}(A)$ onto this set (it is onto by definition, and $\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h} = \mathbf{p} + \mathbf{h}'$ gives $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{h}'$). So each of the q^r vectors $\mathbf{b}$ of (a) accounts for exactly N pairs, and there are $q^r N$ pairs in total. Hence $q^r N = q^n$, and $N = q^{n-r}$.
Let $d = \text{nullity } A$. The argument of (a), applied to a basis of $\text{nul}(A)$ of length d , gives $N = q^d$. So $q^d = q^{n-r}$. Since $q \geq 2$, distinct exponents give distinct powers of q , so $d = n - r$. This is [Theorem 2.5.7](#), proved here by counting alone.
- Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_1$ gives row 3 equal to $(0, 1, 1)$, and then $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2$ makes it zero. So an echelon form is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, and $\text{rank } A = 2$ by [Corollary 2.5.6](#). By (a), exactly $2^2 = 4$ of the 8 vectors $\mathbf{b}$ give a consistent system, and by [Theorem 2.5.8](#) (c) each has $2^{3-2} = 2$ solutions. (The consistent $\mathbf{b}$ are those with $b_1 + b_2 + b_3 = 0$. The rows of A add up to zero, so every consistent $\mathbf{b}$ satisfies this equation; exactly 4 vectors of $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ satisfy it, and 4 are consistent, so the two sets coincide.)

2.6 LU and PLU Factorizations

Gaussian elimination solves one system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$. In practice the matrix often stays fixed while the right-hand side changes: the same network under different loads, the same model fed different data. The row operations depend only on A , so repeating them for every $\mathbf{b}$ wastes almost all of the work. This section stores the elimination as a factorization $A = LU$, a lower triangular matrix that remembers the operations times an upper triangular matrix that is their result. We prove when it exists and when it is unique, and we repair its failures with row swaps.

Throughout, F is a field and all matrices are square, in $M_n(F)$.

2.6.1 Triangular systems are cheap

Some systems need no elimination at all. Take

$$U = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad U\mathbf{x} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ -1 \\ -4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The last equation mentions only x_3 : $-2x_3 = -4$, so $x_3 = 2$. The second mentions x_2 and the known x_3 : $3x_2 + 2 = -1$, so $x_2 = -1$. The first then gives $2x_1 - 1 - 2 = -1$, so $x_1 = 1$. This is **back substitution**: in an upper triangular system with non-zero diagonal entries, each equation introduces exactly one new unknown, read from the bottom up. A lower triangular system is solved the same way from the top down, by **forward substitution**.

Now suppose a matrix A factors as $A = LU$ with L lower triangular and U upper triangular. Then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ reads $L(U\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{b}$. Naming the inner vector $\mathbf{y} = U\mathbf{x}$ splits the problem in two:

first solve $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$ for $\mathbf{y}$, then solve $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$ for $\mathbf{x}$.

Both are triangular, so both are cheap. The expensive part, finding L and U , is done once for all right-hand sides.

An LU factorization is Gaussian elimination written down once, so that it never has to be done again.

2.6.2 LU factorizations

Definition 2.6.1 — LU factorization

A matrix $L \in M_n(F)$ is **unit lower triangular** if it is lower triangular and **every** diagonal entry equals 1. Let $A \in M_n(F)$. An **LU factorization** of A is a pair (L, U) of matrices in $M_n(F)$ such that

$$A = LU, \quad L \text{ is **unit** lower triangular,} \quad U \text{ is upper triangular.}$$

In words: L has 1's on the diagonal and zeros above it, and the entries below the diagonal are unrestricted. U has zeros strictly below the diagonal, and its diagonal entries are unrestricted; some of them may be 0. The definition says **an** factorization: whether there is only one is a theorem, and it needs a hypothesis.

Example. (An LU factorization from elimination)

Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 4 & 5 & -1 \\ -2 & 8 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{Q}).$$

Reduce A to upper triangular form using only operations “subtract a multiple of a higher row from a lower row”, and record each multiplier. Compare the result with the matrix U of the previous subsection.

Solution. The first pivot is 2. To clear column 1 below it we subtract $\ell_{21} = 4/2 = 2$ times row 1 from row 2, and $\ell_{31} = -2/2 = -1$ times row 1 from row 3:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 4 & 5 & -1 \\ -2 & 8 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - (-1)R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 9 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The second pivot is 3. We subtract $\ell_{32} = 9/3 = 3$ times row 2 from row 3:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 9 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 \end{pmatrix} = U.$$

Put the multipliers below the diagonal of a unit lower triangular matrix, each in the position of the entry it cleared:

$$L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ \ell_{21} & 1 & 0 \\ \ell_{31} & \ell_{32} & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 0 \\ -1 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Multiplying out, row by row,

$$LU = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 2 \cdot 2 & 2 \cdot 1 + 3 & 2 \cdot (-1) + 1 \\ -2 & -1 + 9 & 1 + 3 - 2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 4 & 5 & -1 \\ -2 & 8 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = A.$$

So (L, U) is an LU factorization of A , and U is exactly the triangular matrix of the back substitution above.

The example suggests the general statement: elimination produces U , and the multipliers, **with their signs as subtracted**, fill in L . We prove this below. First, the smallest cases.

- **Upper triangular A .** $A = I \cdot A$, and I is unit lower triangular. So every upper triangular matrix, including 0 and I , has the LU factorization (I, A) .
- 1×1 . Every $(a) \in M_1(F)$ is upper triangular, so $(a) = (1)(a)$. Nothing can go wrong here, and that is exactly why the 2×2 failure below is instructive.

Non-example by minimal change. The matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has the LU factorization

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Change the top-left entry from 1 to 0, and everything collapses.

Example. (An invertible matrix with no LU factorization)

Show that $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(F)$ has **no** LU factorization, over any field F , although A is invertible.

Solution. A is invertible, since $AA = I_2$. Suppose, for a contradiction, that $A = LU$ with

$$L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ \ell & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad U = \begin{pmatrix} u & v \\ 0 & w \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then

$$LU = \begin{pmatrix} u & v \\ \ell u & \ell v + w \end{pmatrix}.$$

Comparing $(1, 1)$ -entries with A gives $u = 0$. Comparing $(2, 1)$ -entries gives $\ell u = 1$. But $\ell u = \ell \cdot 0 = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#), and $0 \neq 1$ in a field. This contradiction shows that no LU factorization exists.

What failed is visible: the $(1, 1)$ -entry of any product LU is u_{11} alone, so a zero there forces the whole first column of LU to vanish. In elimination terms, the first pivot is 0 while the entry below it is not, and the only cure is to **swap** rows, which “subtract a multiple of a higher row from a lower row” cannot do. We return to this with permutation matrices.

Why “unit”. Without the 1’s on the diagonal of L , uniqueness would fail even for invertible matrices. If $A = LU$ and D is any invertible diagonal matrix, then also $A = (LD)(D^{-1}U)$, where LD is still lower triangular and $D^{-1}U$ still upper triangular. When L is invertible and $D \neq I$, this is a different pair, and over any field with more than two elements such a D exists. For instance $(2) = (1) (2) = (2) (1) = (4) (1/2)$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. Fixing the diagonal of L removes this freedom and matches what elimination does: it never rescales a row.

Warning. **Invertible does not mean “has an LU factorization”.** The matrix of [Example \(An invertible matrix with no LU factorization\)](#) is invertible and has none. Conversely, a singular matrix can have one: $0 = I \cdot 0$. Existence of an LU factorization is a property of the **order of the rows**, not of invertibility.

2.6.3 Unit lower triangular matrices

Elimination builds L out of elementary matrices, and the uniqueness proof below divides one factorization by another. Both need the same facts: products and inverses of unit lower triangular matrices stay unit lower triangular. We also need to know exactly when a triangular matrix is invertible.

The key observation is a statement about where the non-zero entries of a product can sit.

Lemma 2.6.1 — Unit lower triangular matrices are closed

Let $L, L' \in M_n(F)$ be unit lower triangular. Then:

- (a) LL' is unit lower triangular;
- (b) L is invertible, and L^{-1} is unit lower triangular.

Idea. Write $L = I + N$, where N has non-zero entries only strictly below the diagonal. Multiplying two such matrices pushes the non-zero entries **further** below the diagonal, so $N^n = 0$. Then the geometric series $1/(1+t) = 1 - t + t^2 - \cdots$ stops after n terms and gives the inverse exactly.

Proof. Say that $X \in M_n(F)$ is **p -low** if $x_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i < j + p$. So 0-low means lower triangular, and 1-low means zero on and above the diagonal.

Claim. If X is p -low and Y is q -low, then XY is $(p+q)$ -low. A matrix that is n -low is the zero matrix.

Proof. By Definition 0.9.9, $(XY)_{ij} = \sum_{l=1}^n x_{il}y_{lj}$. A term can be non-zero only if $i \geq l + p$ and $l \geq j + q$, which together give $i \geq j + p + q$. So if $i < j + p + q$, every term is 0 and $(XY)_{ij} = 0$. For the second statement, every pair of indices satisfies $i \leq n < 1 + n \leq j + n$, so every entry of an n -low matrix is 0. ■

Write $L = I + N$ and $L' = I + N'$. Since L and L' are unit lower triangular, N and N' are 1-low.

For (a), $LL' = I + N + N' + NN'$ by Theorem 0.9.4. Here $N + N'$ is 1-low, since a sum of entries that are both 0 is 0, and NN' is 2-low, hence 1-low, by the Claim. So $LL' - I$ is 1-low, which says that LL' is unit lower triangular.

For (b), let $K = I - N + N^2 - \cdots + (-1)^{n-1}N^{n-1}$. Multiplying out, the sum telescopes:

$$(I + N)K = I + (-1)^{n-1}N^n = I,$$

where $N^n = 0$ because N^n is n -low by the Claim applied $n - 1$ times. The same computation gives $K(I + N) = I$, since N commutes with its own powers. Hence L is invertible with $L^{-1} = K$. Finally $K - I = \sum_{p=1}^{n-1} (-1)^p N^p$ is a sum of 1-low matrices, by the Claim, so K is unit lower triangular. This proves the lemma. ■

Transposing everything, the same statements hold for **unit upper triangular** matrices (upper triangular with 1's on the diagonal).

The next lemma decides invertibility of a triangular matrix from its diagonal, without any computation beyond back substitution.

Lemma 2.6.2 — Invertibility of a triangular matrix

An upper triangular matrix $U \in M_n(F)$ is invertible if and only if **every** diagonal entry $u_{11}, \dots, u_{nn}$ is non-zero.

Proof. ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose every $u_{kk} \neq 0$, and let $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$. We show $x_k = 0$ for $k = n, n-1, \dots, 1$ in turn. Suppose $x_{k+1} = \cdots = x_n = 0$ (nothing is assumed when $k = n$). Row k of $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ reads $u_{kk}x_k + \sum_{j>k} u_{kj}x_j = 0$, because $u_{kj} = 0$ for $j < k$. The sum vanishes, so $u_{kk}x_k = 0$, and $x_k = 0$ since $u_{kk} \neq 0$. Hence $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is the only solution of $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and U is invertible by Theorem 2.4.4.

($\Rightarrow$) We prove the contrapositive. Suppose $u_{kk} = 0$ for some k . For each $j \leq k$, the entries of column j in rows $i \geq k$ are zero: if $i > j$ this is upper triangularity, and the only remaining case $i = j = k$ is $u_{kk} = 0$. So the first k columns of U lie in $W = \text{span}(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_{k-1})$. The list $(\mathbf{e}_1, \dots, \mathbf{e}_{k-1})$ is independent and spans W , so $\dim W = k - 1$ (for $k = 1$, $W = \{\mathbf{0}\}$ has dimension 0). By [Theorem 1.6.3](#) (a), these k columns are linearly dependent, so the columns of U are dependent, and U is not invertible by [Theorem 2.4.4](#). This proves the lemma. ■

2.6.4 Elimination without row swaps

To prove that elimination always produces an LU factorization, we first need to say exactly which elimination we mean. It is Gaussian elimination restricted to one kind of operation: subtracting a multiple of a row from a row **below** it.

Elimination without row swaps. Input: $A \in M_n(F)$. Put $A^{(0)} = A$. For $k = 1, 2, \dots, n-1$, write $A^{(k-1)} = (a_{ij})$ and do the following.

- If $a_{kk} \neq 0$, set $\ell_{ik} = a_{ik}/a_{kk}$ for $i = k+1, \dots, n$.
- If $a_{kk} = 0$ and $a_{ik} = 0$ for **every** $i > k$, set $\ell_{ik} = 0$ for $i = k+1, \dots, n$.
- If $a_{kk} = 0$ but $a_{ik} \neq 0$ for **some** $i > k$, **stop**: a row swap is needed.

If we did not stop, obtain $A^{(k)}$ from $A^{(k-1)}$ by replacing row i with (row i) $-\ell_{ik}$ (row k), for each $i = k+1, \dots, n$.

If the loop finishes without stopping, we say **elimination without row swaps succeeds** on A . The numbers ℓ_{ik} ($i > k$) are its **multipliers**, and $U = A^{(n-1)}$ is its **result**.

In both non-stopping cases the new (i, k) -entry is $a_{ik} - \ell_{ik}a_{kk} = 0$: in the first case by the choice of ℓ_{ik} , in the second because both terms are already 0. The multipliers are well defined: row k is not changed during step k , so it does not matter in which order the rows $i > k$ are updated.

The proof will write each step as a matrix. By [Definition 2.4.1](#), the elementary matrix of the operation $R_i \rightarrow R_i + cR_k$ ($i \neq k$) is $I + cE_{ik}$, where E_{ik} is the matrix unit with 1 in entry (i, k) . We will write the matrix unit as a product of a column and a row,

$$E_{ik} = \mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^T,$$

which holds because $\mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^T$ has (p, q) -entry $(\mathbf{e}_i)_p (\mathbf{e}_k)_q$, equal to 1 if $p = i$ and $q = k$, and 0 otherwise. We will use one more rule constantly: for a vector $\mathbf{v} \in F^n$, the 1×1 matrix $\mathbf{e}_k^T \mathbf{v}$ is the k -th entry v_k , which we treat as a scalar. In particular $\mathbf{e}_k^T \mathbf{e}_j = 0$ for $j \neq k$.

For $1 \leq k \leq n$ and a vector $\mathbf{v} \in F^n$ whose first k entries are zero, put

$$G_k(\mathbf{v}) = I + \mathbf{v} \mathbf{e}_k^T.$$

Its only non-identity entries are v_i in position (i, k) , for $i > k$: it is the identity with the column vector $\mathbf{v}$ written into column k below the diagonal. So $G_k(\mathbf{v})$ is unit lower triangular.

Lemma 2.6.3 — Multiplier matrices

Let $1 \leq k \leq n$, and let $\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_m \in F^n$ be vectors such that the first k entries of $\mathbf{v}$ are zero and, for each j , the first j entries of $\mathbf{v}_j$ are zero ($m \leq n$). Then:

- (a) $G_k(\mathbf{v})$ is the product, in any order, of the elementary matrices $I + v_i E_{ik}$ for $i = k+1, \dots, n$;
- (b) $G_k(\mathbf{v})G_k(-\mathbf{v}) = G_k(-\mathbf{v})G_k(\mathbf{v}) = I$;
- (c) $G_1(\mathbf{v}_1)G_2(\mathbf{v}_2) \cdots G_m(\mathbf{v}_m) = I + \mathbf{v}_1 \mathbf{e}_1^\top + \mathbf{v}_2 \mathbf{e}_2^\top + \cdots + \mathbf{v}_m \mathbf{e}_m^\top$.

Proof. For (a), let $i, j > k$. By [Theorem 0.9.4](#),

$$(I + a \mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^\top)(I + b \mathbf{e}_j \mathbf{e}_k^\top) = I + a \mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^\top + b \mathbf{e}_j \mathbf{e}_k^\top + ab \mathbf{e}_i (\mathbf{e}_k^\top \mathbf{e}_j) \mathbf{e}_k^\top,$$

and the last term is zero because $\mathbf{e}_k^\top \mathbf{e}_j = 0$ for $j \neq k$. Repeating this, one factor at a time, the product of the $I + v_i E_{ik} = I + v_i \mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^\top$ in any order is $I + \sum_{i>k} v_i \mathbf{e}_i \mathbf{e}_k^\top = I + \mathbf{v} \mathbf{e}_k^\top$, since $\mathbf{v} = \sum_{i>k} v_i \mathbf{e}_i$.

For (b), $(I + \mathbf{v} \mathbf{e}_k^\top)(I - \mathbf{v} \mathbf{e}_k^\top) = I - \mathbf{v}(\mathbf{e}_k^\top \mathbf{v}) \mathbf{e}_k^\top = I$, because $\mathbf{e}_k^\top \mathbf{v} = v_k = 0$. Swapping the signs gives the other order.

For (c), we use induction on m ; the case $m = 1$ is the definition. Suppose the formula holds for $m - 1$. Then

$$\left(I + \sum_{j<m} \mathbf{v}_j \mathbf{e}_j^\top\right)(I + \mathbf{v}_m \mathbf{e}_m^\top) = I + \sum_{j<m} \mathbf{v}_j \mathbf{e}_j^\top + \mathbf{v}_m \mathbf{e}_m^\top + \sum_{j<m} \mathbf{v}_j (\mathbf{e}_j^\top \mathbf{v}_m) \mathbf{e}_m^\top.$$

For $j < m$, $\mathbf{e}_j^\top \mathbf{v}_m$ is entry j of $\mathbf{v}_m$, which is zero because the first m entries of $\mathbf{v}_m$ are zero. So the last sum vanishes, and the formula holds for m . This proves the lemma. ■

Part (c) is the heart of the matter: when the factors come in the order $G_1, G_2, \dots$, they **do not interfere**, and each vector $\mathbf{v}_j$ lands untouched in column j .

Theorem 2.6.4 — LU from elimination

Let $A \in M_n(F)$, and suppose elimination without row swaps succeeds on A , with multipliers ℓ_{ik} and result U . Let L be the unit lower triangular matrix whose (i, k) -entry is ℓ_{ik} for every $i > k$. Then U is upper triangular and

$$A = LU.$$

In particular A has an LU factorization.

Idea. Each step of elimination is left multiplication by a product of elementary matrices, which collapses to one matrix $G_k(-\ell_k)$. So $U = G_{n-1}(-\ell_{n-1}) \cdots G_1(-\ell_1)A$. To get A back, undo the steps in reverse order. Their inverses $G_k(\ell_k)$ then appear in the order $G_1, G_2, \dots$, which is exactly the order in which, by [Lemma 2.6.3](#) (c), the multipliers drop into place.

Proof. Let $A^{(0)}, \dots, A^{(n-1)} = U$ be the matrices produced by the algorithm. For each k , let $\ell_k = \sum_{i>k} \ell_{ik} \mathbf{e}_i \in F^n$, a vector whose first k entries are zero.

Step 1: U is upper triangular. We show by induction on k that in $A^{(k)}$ every entry below the diagonal in columns $1, \dots, k$ is zero. For $k = 0$ there is nothing to prove. Suppose it holds for $A^{(k-1)}$. Step k changes only rows $i > k$, replacing row i by row i minus a multiple of row k . In columns $j < k$, the entry of row k lies below the diagonal ($k > j$), so it is 0 by the induction hypothesis, and the entries of row i in these columns stay 0. In column k , the new entries below the diagonal are 0, as noted after the algorithm. This completes the induction, and for $k = n - 1$ it says that U is upper triangular.

Step 2: each step is a matrix. Step k performs the operations “add $-\ell_{ik}$ times row k to row i ” for $i = k + 1, \dots, n$. By [Theorem 2.4.1](#), applying them one after another multiplies $A^{(k-1)}$ on the left by the corresponding elementary matrices $I - \ell_{ik} E_{ik}$. By [Lemma 2.6.3](#) (a), their product is $G_k(-\ell_k)$. Hence $A^{(k)} = G_k(-\ell_k) A^{(k-1)}$, and therefore

$$U = G_{n-1}(-\ell_{n-1}) \cdots G_2(-\ell_2) G_1(-\ell_1) A.$$

Step 3: undo the steps. Multiply both sides on the left by $G_{n-1}(\ell_{n-1})$, then by $G_{n-2}(\ell_{n-2})$, and so on down to $G_1(\ell_1)$. By [Lemma 2.6.3](#) (b), each one cancels the factor next to it, and we get

$$G_1(\ell_1) G_2(\ell_2) \cdots G_{n-1}(\ell_{n-1}) U = A.$$

By [Lemma 2.6.3](#) (c), the product on the left of U is $I + \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \ell_k \mathbf{e}_k^T$. Its (i, k) -entry for $i > k$ is ℓ_{ik} ; its diagonal entries are 1; its entries above the diagonal are 0. That is, it is L . Hence $A = LU$ with L unit lower triangular and U upper triangular, as claimed. ■

So the multipliers are not something to be remembered separately: they **are** the lower triangular factor. When a computer performs elimination it stores each ℓ_{ik} in the slot (i, k) that it has just cleared, and at the end the one array holds L below the diagonal and U on and above it.

Warning. The matrix that performs elimination, L^{-1} , is not L with its multipliers negated. In [Example \(An LU factorization from elimination\)](#) the operations multiply A on the left by

$$G_2(-\ell_2) G_1(-\ell_1) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 7 & -3 & 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

and the entry $7 = 1 + (-3)(-2)$ mixes two multipliers. This matrix is L^{-1} , by Step 3 of the proof. It is L , whose factors come in the order G_1, G_2 , that has the multipliers cleanly in place.

Quick check. Find the LU factorization of $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 6 & 5 \end{pmatrix}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$ by elimination, and check it by multiplying.

Solution. The pivot is 2 and the multiplier is $\ell_{21} = 6/2 = 3$. Subtracting 3 times row 1 from row 2 gives $U = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 0 & 5-12 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 0 & -7 \end{pmatrix}$, and $L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Check:
 $LU = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 6 & 12-7 \end{pmatrix} = A$.

2.6.5 Solving with an LU factorization

Once $A = LU$ is known, each system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ costs two substitutions.

Example. (Two right-hand sides, one factorization)

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & -1 \\ 4 & 5 & -1 \\ -2 & 8 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ with the factorization $A = LU$ of [Example \(An LU factorization from elimination\)](#). Solve $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ for

$$\mathbf{b} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ -3 \\ -6 \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad \mathbf{b}' = \begin{pmatrix} 3 \\ 7 \\ -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Solution. First right-hand side. Forward substitution in $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$:

$$y_1 = -1, \quad 2y_1 + y_2 = -3 \Rightarrow y_2 = -1, \quad -y_1 + 3y_2 + y_3 = -6 \Rightarrow y_3 = -6 - 1 + 3 = -4.$$

Back substitution in $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$:

$$-2x_3 = -4 \Rightarrow x_3 = 2, \quad 3x_2 + x_3 = -1 \Rightarrow x_2 = -1, \quad 2x_1 + x_2 - x_3 = -1 \Rightarrow x_1 = 1.$$

So $\mathbf{x} = (1, -1, 2)$. Check: $A\mathbf{x} = (2 - 1 - 2, 4 - 5 - 2, -2 - 8 + 4) = (-1, -3, -6) = \mathbf{b}$.

Second right-hand side. $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}'$: $y_1 = 3$, $y_2 = 7 - 2 \cdot 3 = 1$, $y_3 = -2 + y_1 - 3y_2 = -2 + 3 - 3 = -2$. Then $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$: $-2x_3 = -2$, so $x_3 = 1$; $3x_2 + 1 = 1$, so $x_2 = 0$; $2x_1 + 0 - 1 = 3$, so $x_1 = 2$. So $\mathbf{x}' = (2, 0, 1)$, and indeed $A\mathbf{x}' = (4 + 0 - 1, 8 + 0 - 1, -4 + 0 + 2) = (3, 7, -2)$.

Since the diagonal of U is $2, 3, -2$, all non-zero, U is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.2](#), L is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.1](#), and so $A = LU$ is invertible. Each solution found is therefore the only one.

How much is saved? Count the arithmetic operations $(+, -, \times, \div)$ for an $n \times n$ matrix. At step k of elimination there are $n - k$ rows below the pivot. Each needs one division for its multiplier, then $n - k$ multiplications and $n - k$ subtractions in the columns to the right of column k . With $j = n - k$, the total is

$$\sum_{j=1}^{n-1} j(2j+1) = \frac{n(n-1)(4n+1)}{6} \approx \frac{2}{3}n^3.$$

Forward substitution with a unit lower triangular L uses $n(n-1)$ operations, and back substitution n^2 , so a pair of triangular solves costs $2n^2 - n$. For $n = 1000$ that is about 6.7×10^8 operations for the factorization, done once, against about 2×10^6 for each new right-hand side.

2.6.6 Uniqueness

The factorization of [Example \(An LU factorization from elimination\)](#) came from one particular procedure. Could another procedure give a different pair (L, U) ? For invertible matrices, no.

Theorem 2.6.5 — Uniqueness of the LU factorization

Let $A \in M_n(F)$ be **invertible**. If $A = L_1U_1$ and $A = L_2U_2$ are LU factorizations, then $L_1 = L_2$ and $U_1 = U_2$.

Idea. Take the difference in multiplicative form: from $L_1U_1 = L_2U_2$ we get $(L_2^{-1}L_1)U_1 = U_2$. The matrix $M = L_2^{-1}L_1$ is unit lower triangular, and multiplying U_1 by it must leave an upper triangular matrix. Clearing below the diagonal column by column, the non-zero pivots of U_1 force M to have nothing below its diagonal. Invertibility of A is what provides those non-zero pivots.

Proof. By [Lemma 2.6.1](#) (b), L_1 and L_2 are invertible. Hence $U_1 = L_1^{-1}A$ is a product of invertible matrices, so it is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#), and by [Lemma 2.6.2](#) its diagonal entries $u_{11}, \dots, u_{nn}$ are all non-zero.

Let $M = L_2^{-1}L_1$. By [Lemma 2.6.1](#), $M = (m_{ij})$ is unit lower triangular. Multiplying $L_1U_1 = L_2U_2$ on the left by L_2^{-1} gives $MU_1 = U_2$, so MU_1 is upper triangular. We show $m_{ij} = 0$ for all $i > j$, by induction on the column j .

Fix j , and suppose $m_{ik} = 0$ whenever $k < j$ and $i > k$. Let $i > j$. Since MU_1 is upper triangular and $i > j$,

$$0 = (MU_1)_{ij} = \sum_{k=1}^n m_{ik}u_{kj} = \sum_{k \leq j} m_{ik}u_{kj} = m_{ij}u_{jj},$$

where the third equality uses $u_{kj} = 0$ for $k > j$, and the last uses $m_{ik} = 0$ for $k < j$ (here $i > j > k$). Since $u_{jj} \neq 0$, we get $m_{ij} = 0$. This completes the induction, so M is lower triangular with 1's on the diagonal and nothing below it: $M = I$.

Hence $L_2^{-1}L_1 = I$, and multiplying by L_2 gives $L_1 = L_2$. Then $U_1 = L_1^{-1}A = L_2^{-1}A = U_2$. This proves the theorem. ■

Two consequences are worth saying. The LU factorization of an invertible matrix does not depend on how it was found, so it is legitimate to speak of **the** factors L and U . And if elimination without row swaps succeeds on an invertible A , then every pivot is non-zero: row k is not changed after step k , so the pivot of step k is u_{kk} , which is non-zero by the first paragraph of the proof. So the second case of the algorithm (a zero pivot over a zero column) never occurs.

Remark. The hypothesis “invertible” cannot be dropped. For every $c \in F$,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ c & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

since the first column of the right factor is zero. Taking $c = 0$ and $c = 1$ gives two

different LU factorizations. The proof breaks exactly at “ $u_{jj} \neq 0$ ”, here for $j = 1$.

2.6.7 Row swaps and the PLU factorization

Example (An invertible matrix with no LU factorization) showed that some matrices, even invertible ones, have no LU factorization, because elimination meets a zero pivot with a non-zero entry below it. The cure in Gaussian elimination is to swap rows. We now show that the swaps can all be collected in front, as a single matrix that rearranges the rows of A **before** elimination starts. After that rearrangement, no swaps are needed.

Matrices that rearrange rows have a name.

Definition 2.6.2 — Permutation matrix

Let $\sigma \in S_n$ be a permutation of $\{1, \dots, n\}$. The **permutation matrix** of σ is

$$P_\sigma = (\mathbf{e}_{\sigma(1)} \quad \mathbf{e}_{\sigma(2)} \quad \cdots \quad \mathbf{e}_{\sigma(n)}) \in M_n(F),$$

the matrix whose j -th column is $\mathbf{e}_{\sigma(j)}$. A matrix is a **permutation matrix** if it equals P_σ for some $\sigma \in S_n$.

Equivalently, a permutation matrix has exactly one 1 in each row and in each column, and zeros elsewhere. The identity is P_{id} . The matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ of **Example (An invertible matrix with no LU factorization)** is P_τ for the transposition $\tau = (1 \ 2)$. By contrast $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ is **not** a permutation matrix: each column is still non-zero, but its first row contains two 1's, and its second column $(1, 1)$ is not a standard basis vector.

Lemma 2.6.6 — Permutation matrices

Let $\sigma, \tau \in S_n$.

- (a) $P_\sigma P_\tau = P_{\sigma \circ \tau}$. In particular a product of permutation matrices is a permutation matrix.
- (b) P_σ is invertible and $P_\sigma^{-1} = P_\sigma^\top$.
- (c) If $\tau = (r \ s)$ is a transposition, then P_τ is the elementary matrix P_{rs} that swaps rows r and s , and $P_\tau^2 = I$.
- (d) Let $1 \leq k < r < s \leq n$, let $\tau = (r \ s)$, and let $\mathbf{v} \in F^n$ have its first k entries zero. Then $P_\tau \mathbf{v}$ has its first k entries zero, and

$$P_\tau G_k(\mathbf{v}) P_\tau = G_k(P_\tau \mathbf{v}).$$

Proof.

- (a) By **Theorem 0.9.3**, $P_\tau \mathbf{e}_j = \mathbf{e}_{\tau(j)}$ and so $P_\sigma P_\tau \mathbf{e}_j = P_\sigma \mathbf{e}_{\tau(j)} = \mathbf{e}_{\sigma(\tau(j))}$. So the j -th column of $P_\sigma P_\tau$ is $\mathbf{e}_{(\sigma \circ \tau)(j)}$, for every j , which is the claim.
- (b) By **Theorem 0.9.2**, $(P_\sigma^\top P_\sigma)_{ij} = \mathbf{e}_{\sigma(i)}^\top \mathbf{e}_{\sigma(j)}$, which is 1 if $\sigma(i) = \sigma(j)$ and 0 otherwise.

Since σ is injective, $\sigma(i) = \sigma(j)$ exactly when $i = j$. Hence $P_\sigma^\top P_\sigma = I$, and by [Theorem 2.4.5](#), P_σ is invertible with inverse $P_\sigma^\top$.

- (c) Swapping rows r and s of I produces a matrix whose column r is $\mathbf{e}_s$, whose column s is $\mathbf{e}_r$, and whose other columns j are $\mathbf{e}_j$. These are the columns $\mathbf{e}_{\tau(j)}$, so the swap matrix is P_τ . Since $\tau \circ \tau = \text{id}$, part (a) gives $P_\tau^2 = P_{\text{id}} = I$.
- (d) Write $P = P_\tau$. Its effect on a vector is to exchange entries r and s , which are both beyond position k , so $P\mathbf{v}$ still has its first k entries zero. Since $k \neq r, s$, we have $P\mathbf{e}_k = \mathbf{e}_{\tau(k)} = \mathbf{e}_k$. By (b) and (c), $P^\top = P^{-1} = P$, so $\mathbf{e}_k^\top P = \mathbf{e}_k^\top P^\top = (P\mathbf{e}_k)^\top = \mathbf{e}_k^\top$ by [Theorem 0.9.5](#). Therefore

$$P(I + \mathbf{v}\mathbf{e}_k^\top)P = P^2 + (P\mathbf{v})(\mathbf{e}_k^\top P) = I + (P\mathbf{v})\mathbf{e}_k^\top = G_k(P\mathbf{v}),$$

using $P^2 = I$ from (c). This proves the lemma. ■

By (c) and [Theorem 2.4.1](#), $P_\tau A$ is A with rows r and s swapped, and by (a) every permutation matrix is a product of such swaps applied in turn, since for $n \geq 2$ every permutation is a product of transpositions ([Theorem 0.10.4](#)). So PA is always A with its rows rearranged.

Definition 2.6.3 — PLU factorization

Let $A \in M_n(F)$. A **PLU factorization** of A is a triple (P, L, U) of matrices in $M_n(F)$ such that

$$PA = LU, \quad P \text{ is a permutation matrix,} \quad L \text{ is unit lower triangular,} \quad U \text{ is upper triangular.}$$

In words: after rearranging the rows of A by P , the matrix has an LU factorization. By [Lemma 2.6.6](#) (b) this can also be written $A = P^\top LU$, which is why some books write the factorization as $A = PLU$ with their P our $P^\top$. For example, $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has the PLU factorization (A, I, I) , since $AA = I = I \cdot I$. An LU factorization is the special case $P = I$.

To produce P , run elimination and allow a swap whenever a zero pivot has a non-zero entry below it.

Elimination with row swaps. Input: $A \in M_n(F)$. Put $A^{(0)} = A$. For $k = 1, 2, \dots, n-1$, with $A^{(k-1)} = (a_{ij})$:

- If $a_{ik} = 0$ for **every** $i \geq k$, set $P_k = I$ and all $\ell_{ik} = 0$, and let $A^{(k)} = A^{(k-1)}$.
- Otherwise choose some $r_k \geq k$ with $a_{r_k k} \neq 0$. Let P_k be the matrix swapping rows k and r_k (so $P_k = I$ if $r_k = k$), and let $B = P_k A^{(k-1)}$. Set $\ell_{ik} = b_{ik}/b_{kk}$ for $i > k$, and obtain $A^{(k)}$ from B by replacing row i with (row i) $-\ell_{ik} \cdot$ (row k) for each $i > k$.

This version never stops. Here is the result it delivers.

Theorem 2.6.7 — Existence of a PLU factorization

Every $A \in M_n(F)$ has a PLU factorization.

Idea. Step roadmap. ① As before, each step is a matrix: $A^{(k)} = G_k(-\ell_k)P_k A^{(k-1)}$, and the final matrix U is upper triangular. ② The swaps are tangled with the multiplier matrices. A swap of two rows below row k can be pushed to the right past G_k at the price of swapping the entries of the multiplier vector: this is Lemma 2.6.6 (d). ③ Once all swaps sit next to A , the rest is the LU proof word for word. In practice, ② says: when you swap two rows, also swap the multipliers already stored in those rows.

Proof. Run elimination with row swaps on A , producing $A^{(0)}, \dots, A^{(n-1)} = U$, swap matrices $P_1, \dots, P_{n-1}$ and multipliers ℓ_{ik} . Let $\ell_k = \sum_{i>k} \ell_{ik} \mathbf{e}_i$, whose first k entries are zero.

Step 1. Exactly as in Step 1 of the proof of Theorem 2.6.4, every entry of $A^{(k)}$ below the diagonal in columns $1, \dots, k$ is zero. The only new point is the swap in step k : it exchanges rows k and $r_k \geq k$, whose entries in columns $j < k$ are below the diagonal and hence zero, so the swap does not disturb these columns. After the swap the pivot b_{kk} is non-zero, and the new entries below it are $b_{ik} - \ell_{ik}b_{kk} = 0$. Hence U is upper triangular. By Lemma 2.6.6 (c), Theorem 2.4.1 and Lemma 2.6.3 (a), as in Step 2 of that proof,

$$A^{(k)} = G_k(-\ell_k) P_k A^{(k-1)} \quad (k = 1, \dots, n-1).$$

This also holds in the first case of the algorithm, where $P_k = I$ and $G_k(\mathbf{0}) = I$.

Step 2. For $1 \leq k \leq m \leq n-1$ put $\ell_k^{(m)} = P_m P_{m-1} \cdots P_{k+1} \ell_k$, with $\ell_m^{(m)} = \ell_m$. We claim that the first k entries of $\ell_k^{(m)}$ are zero and that

$$G_m(-\ell_m) P_m \cdots G_1(-\ell_1) P_1 = G_m(-\ell_m^{(m)}) \cdots G_1(-\ell_1^{(m)}) P_m \cdots P_1.$$

For $m = 1$ both sides are $G_1(-\ell_1) P_1$. Suppose the claim holds for m , and multiply it on the left by $G_{m+1}(-\ell_{m+1}) P_{m+1}$. The matrix P_{m+1} is I or swaps rows $m+1$ and $r_{m+1} > m+1$, both beyond every $k \leq m$. So by Lemma 2.6.6 (c) and (d), for each $k \leq m$ and each vector $\mathbf{v}$ with its first k entries zero,

$$P_{m+1} G_k(\mathbf{v}) = P_{m+1} G_k(\mathbf{v}) P_{m+1} P_{m+1} = G_k(P_{m+1} \mathbf{v}) P_{m+1},$$

and $P_{m+1} \mathbf{v}$ again has its first k entries zero. Applying this for $k = m, m-1, \dots, 1$ moves P_{m+1} to the right past every factor G_k , replacing $\ell_k^{(m)}$ by $P_{m+1} \ell_k^{(m)} = \ell_k^{(m+1)}$ (note $P_{m+1}(-\mathbf{v}) = -P_{m+1} \mathbf{v}$). This is the claim for $m+1$.

Step 3. By Step 1, $U = G_{n-1}(-\ell_{n-1}) P_{n-1} \cdots G_1(-\ell_1) P_1 A$. Write $\ell'_k = \ell_k^{(n-1)}$ and $P = P_{n-1} \cdots P_1$. By Step 2,

$$U = G_{n-1}(-\ell'_{n-1}) \cdots G_1(-\ell'_1) P A.$$

P is a permutation matrix by Lemma 2.6.6 (a) and (c). Multiplying on the left by $G_{n-1}(\ell'_{n-1})$, then $G_{n-2}(\ell'_{n-2})$, and so on, and using Lemma 2.6.3 (b) and (c) as in Step 3 of the proof of Theorem 2.6.4,

$$PA = LU, \quad L = I + \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \ell'_k \mathbf{e}_k^T,$$

where L is unit lower triangular because the first k entries of each ℓ'_k are zero. So (P, L, U) is a PLU factorization of A . This proves the theorem. ■

Example. (A swap in the middle)

Find a PLU factorization of

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 7 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{Q}).$$

Solution. Step 1. The pivot 1 is non-zero, so no swap. The multipliers are $\ell_{21} = 2$ and $\ell_{31} = 3$:

$$A \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \ell_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 2 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Step 2. The pivot position $(2, 2)$ holds 0, but the entry below it is 1. Elimination without row swaps would stop here. We swap rows 2 and 3, so $P_2 = P_{23}$:

$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = U.$$

The entry below the new pivot is already 0, so $\ell_{32} = 0$, and U is upper triangular.

By Step 2 of the proof, the stored multipliers of step 1 are swapped too: $\ell'_1 = P_2 \ell_1 = (0, 3, 2)$. Hence

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Check: PA is A with rows 2 and 3 swapped, and

$$LU = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 3 & 6+1 & 3-1 \\ 2 & 4 & 2+1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 3 & 7 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = PA.$$

Notice where the multipliers ended up: 3 in row 2 and 2 in row 3, traveling with the rows they belong to. To solve $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$, multiply by P and solve $LU\mathbf{x} = P\mathbf{b}$ by two substitutions; since P is invertible, this changes no solutions. For $\mathbf{b} = (2, 3, 8)$, $P\mathbf{b} = (2, 8, 3)$. Forward substitution in $L\mathbf{y} = P\mathbf{b}$ gives $y_1 = 2$, $y_2 = 8 - 3 \cdot 2 = 2$, $y_3 = 3 - 2 \cdot 2 = -1$. Back substitution in $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$ gives $x_3 = -1$, $x_2 = 2 + x_3 = 1$, $x_1 = 2 - 2x_2 - x_3 = 1$. Check: $A(1, 1, -1) = (1 + 2 - 1, 2 + 4 - 3, 3 + 7 - 2) = (2, 3, 8)$.

Remark. Over $\mathbb{R}$, computers do not choose just any non-zero pivot. They choose the entry of **largest absolute value** in the column, which is called **partial pivoting**. The reason is rounding. For $A = \begin{pmatrix} \varepsilon & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ with $\varepsilon = 10^{-20}$, elimination without swaps gives the multiplier 10^{20} and $u_{22} = 1 - 10^{20}$, which in standard double-precision arithmetic is stored as -10^{20} . Multiplying back, the computed LU has $(2, 2)$ -entry $10^{20} - 10^{20} = 0$

instead of 1. Swapping the rows first gives the harmless multiplier ε . Chapter 23 makes this precise.

2.6.8 Symmetric matrices: the LDL factorization

When A is symmetric, the two factors of $A = LU$ are secretly related: up to a diagonal matrix, U is the transpose of L . In [Example \(An LU factorization from elimination\)](#) the factors look unrelated, but that matrix is not symmetric. Try a symmetric one:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 3 & 7 & -8 \\ -2 & -8 & 5 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 2R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 3R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & -2 & -2 \\ 0 & -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & -2 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = U,$$

with multipliers $\ell_{21} = 3$, $\ell_{31} = -2$, $\ell_{32} = 1$. Divide each row of U by its diagonal entry: the rows become $(1, 3, -2)$, $(0, 1, 1)$, $(0, 0, 1)$. These are the columns of $L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 3 & 1 & 0 \\ -2 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, read as rows. So $U = DL^T$ with $D = \text{diag}(1, -2, 3)$, and $A = LDL^T$.

Theorem 2.6.8 — LDL factorization

Let $A \in M_n(F)$ be **symmetric** and **invertible**, and suppose $A = LU$ is an LU factorization. Then the diagonal entries $u_{11}, \dots, u_{nn}$ of U are non-zero, and with $D = \text{diag}(u_{11}, \dots, u_{nn})$,

$$U = DL^T \quad \text{and} \quad A = LDL^T.$$

Idea. Pull the diagonal out of U , writing $U = DV$ with V unit upper triangular, so $A = LDV$. Transposing, $A = A^T = V^T(DL^T)$, which is a second LU factorization of the same invertible matrix. Uniqueness forces the two to agree, so $L = V^T$.

Proof. As in the proof of [Theorem 2.6.5](#), $U = L^{-1}A$ is invertible, so its diagonal entries are non-zero by [Lemma 2.6.2](#). Hence D is invertible, with $D^{-1} = \text{diag}(u_{11}^{-1}, \dots, u_{nn}^{-1})$. Let $V = D^{-1}U$. Row i of V is u_{ii}^{-1} times row i of U , so V is upper triangular with $v_{ii} = u_{ii}^{-1}u_{ii} = 1$, and $A = LDV$.

Since A is symmetric and $D^T = D$, [Theorem 0.9.5](#) gives

$$A = A^T = (LDV)^T = V^T DL^T = V^T(DL^T).$$

Here V^T is unit lower triangular, because V is unit upper triangular. And DL^T is upper triangular: its (i, j) -entry is $u_{ii}\ell_{ji}$, and $\ell_{ji} = 0$ when $j < i$, since L is lower triangular. So (V^T, DL^T) is an LU factorization of the invertible matrix A . By [Theorem 2.6.5](#), $V^T = L$ and $DL^T = U$. Therefore $A = LU = LDL^T$, as claimed. ■

The factorization stores about half as much: L and the diagonal D determine everything. Over $\mathbb{R}$, when every entry of D is positive, one can split $D = D^{1/2}D^{1/2}$ and write $A = (LD^{1/2})(LD^{1/2})^T$; this is the **Cholesky factorization**, which Chapter 12 connects with positive definite matrices.

Remark. Symmetry alone does not give an LU factorization: $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ is symmetric and invertible, and has none by [Example \(An invertible matrix with no LU factorization\)](#). The theorem assumes the factorization exists and then improves it.

2.6.9 Exercises

2.6.9.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) Define an LU factorization of a matrix $A \in M_n(F)$, and a PLU factorization.
- (b) True or false: every invertible matrix has an LU factorization. Justify your answer.
- (c) Suppose $A = LU$. In which order are the two triangular systems solved to find a solution of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$, and what is each one?
- (d) True or false: the product of two unit lower triangular $n \times n$ matrices is unit lower triangular. Justify your answer.
- (e) True or false: the zero matrix in $M_2(F)$ has more than one LU factorization. Justify your answer.
- (f) What is the inverse of a permutation matrix P ?

Solution.

- (a) See [Definition 2.6.1](#): $A = LU$ with L unit lower triangular and U upper triangular. See [Definition 2.6.3](#): $PA = LU$ with P a permutation matrix, L unit lower triangular and U upper triangular.
- (b) False. $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ is invertible but has no LU factorization, by [Example \(An invertible matrix with no LU factorization\)](#).
- (c) First $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$, by forward substitution; then $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$, by back substitution. Then $A\mathbf{x} = L(U\mathbf{x}) = L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$.
- (d) True, by [Lemma 2.6.1](#) (a).
- (e) True. For every $c \in F$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ c & 1 \end{pmatrix} 0 = 0$, so $\left(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ c & 1 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right)$ is an LU factorization; $c = 0$ and $c = 1$ give two different ones. This does not contradict [Theorem 2.6.5](#), because 0 is not invertible.
- (f) $P^{-1} = P^T$, by [Lemma 2.6.6](#) (b).

2.6.9.2 B. Practice

Exercise B1: An LU factorization.

Find the LU factorization of

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ -3 & -7 & 4 \\ 2 & 6 & -3 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{Q})$$

by elimination without row swaps. Hence show that A is invertible.

Solution. Step 1. The pivot is 1, with multipliers $\ell_{21} = -3$ and $\ell_{31} = 2$:

$$A \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - (-3)R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 & -3 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Step 2. The pivot is -1 , with multiplier $\ell_{32} = 2/(-1) = -2$:

$$\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - (-2)R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 4 \\ 0 & 0 & 5 \end{pmatrix} = U.$$

By [Theorem 2.6.4](#),

$$L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -3 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & -2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A = LU.$$

$$\text{Check: } LU = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 0 \\ -3 & -6-1 & 4 \\ 2 & 4+2 & -8+5 \end{pmatrix} = A.$$

The diagonal entries $1, -1, 5$ of U are non-zero, so U is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.2](#), and L is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.1](#). Hence $A = LU$ is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#).

Exercise B2: Two systems, one factorization.

With $A = LU$ as in [Exercise \(B1: An LU factorization\)](#), solve $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ for $\mathbf{b} = (3, -6, 5)$ and for $\mathbf{b} = (0, 1, -2)$, using only forward and back substitution.

Solution. For $\mathbf{b} = (3, -6, 5)$. $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$: $y_1 = 3$; $-3y_1 + y_2 = -6$, so $y_2 = 3$; $2y_1 - 2y_2 + y_3 = 5$, so $y_3 = 5 - 6 + 6 = 5$. Then $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$: $5x_3 = 5$, so $x_3 = 1$; $-x_2 + 4x_3 = 3$, so $x_2 = 1$; $x_1 + 2x_2 = 3$, so $x_1 = 1$. Hence $\mathbf{x} = (1, 1, 1)$. Check: $A\mathbf{x} = (1+2, -3-7+4, 2+6-3) = (3, -6, 5)$.

For $\mathbf{b} = (0, 1, -2)$. $L\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{b}$: $y_1 = 0$; $y_2 = 1 + 3y_1 = 1$; $y_3 = -2 - 2y_1 + 2y_2 = 0$. Then $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$: $5x_3 = 0$, so $x_3 = 0$; $-x_2 + 0 = 1$, so $x_2 = -1$; $x_1 + 2(-1) = 0$, so $x_1 = 2$. Hence $\mathbf{x} = (2, -1, 0)$. Check: $A\mathbf{x} = (2-2, -6+7, 4-6) = (0, 1, -2)$.

Since A is invertible ([Exercise \(B1: An LU factorization\)](#)), each solution is the only one, by [Theorem 0.9.7](#).

Exercise B3: A PLU factorization.

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 2 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{Q})$.

- (a) Explain why A has no LU factorization.
- (b) Find a PLU factorization of A .
- (c) Hence solve $A\mathbf{x} = (0, 2, 7)$.

Solution.

- (a) If $A = LU$, then the $(1, 1)$ -entry gives $u_{11} = a_{11} = 0$, and the $(2, 1)$ -entry gives $a_{21} = \ell_{21}u_{11} = 0$. But $a_{21} = 1 \neq 0$, a contradiction, exactly as in [Example \(An invertible matrix with no LU factorization\)](#).
- (b) The first pivot position holds 0 and the entry below is 1, so swap rows 1 and 2, $P_1 = P_{12}$:

$$A \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 0R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 1R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & -3 \end{pmatrix} = U.$$

The multipliers are $\ell_{21} = 0$, $\ell_{31} = 2$, $\ell_{32} = 1$, and no swap happens after step 1, so they need no rearranging. Hence

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

$$\text{Check: } PA = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \text{ and } LU = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 2+1 & 2+2-3 \end{pmatrix} = PA.$$

- (c) $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ holds if and only if $PA\mathbf{x} = P\mathbf{b}$, since P is invertible ([Lemma 2.6.6 \(b\)](#)). Swapping the first two entries of $\mathbf{b} = (0, 2, 7)$, we solve $LU\mathbf{x} = P\mathbf{b} = (2, 0, 7)$. $L\mathbf{y} = (2, 0, 7)$: $y_1 = 2$, $y_2 = 0$, $y_3 = 7 - 2 \cdot 2 - 0 = 3$. $U\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}$: $-3x_3 = 3$, so $x_3 = -1$; $x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$, so $x_2 = 2$; $x_1 + x_2 + x_3 = 2$, so $x_1 = 1$. Hence $\mathbf{x} = (1, 2, -1)$. Check: $A\mathbf{x} = (0 + 2 - 2, 1 + 2 - 1, 2 + 6 - 1) = (0, 2, 7)$.

2.6.9.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: Leading principal submatrices.

For $A \in M_n(F)$ and $1 \leq k \leq n$, the **leading principal submatrix** $A_k \in M_k(F)$ is the top-left $k \times k$ corner of A , with entries a_{ij} for $i, j \leq k$.

- (a) Let L be lower triangular and U upper triangular in $M_n(F)$. Show that $(LU)_k = L_k U_k$ for every k .
- (b) Deduce that if A has an LU factorization $A = LU$ with U invertible, then every leading principal submatrix $A_1, \dots, A_n$ is invertible.
- (c) Prove the converse: if $A_1, \dots, A_n$ are all invertible, then A has an LU factorization with U invertible.

Hint for (c): induction on n . Write A with A_{n-1} in its top-left corner, a column $\mathbf{b}$, a row $\mathbf{c}^\top$ and a corner entry d , and look for L and U of the same shape.

Solution.

- (a) Let $i, j \leq k$. By [Definition 0.9.9](#), $(LU)_{ij} = \sum_{l=1}^n \ell_{il} u_{lj}$. If $l > k$, then $l > i$, so $\ell_{il} = 0$ because L is lower triangular. Hence $(LU)_{ij} = \sum_{l=1}^k \ell_{il} u_{lj} = (L_k U_k)_{ij}$, as claimed.
- (b) Suppose $A = LU$ with U invertible. By (a), $A_k = L_k U_k$. The matrix L_k is unit lower triangular, so it is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.1](#). By [Lemma 2.6.2](#), $u_{11}, \dots, u_{nn}$ are non-zero; U_k is upper triangular with diagonal $u_{11}, \dots, u_{kk}$, so U_k is invertible by the same lemma. Hence A_k is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#).
- (c) We prove by induction on n that every $A \in M_n(F)$ whose leading principal submatrices are all invertible has an LU factorization with U invertible. For $n = 1$, $A = (a_{11})$ with $a_{11} \neq 0$, and $A = (1)(a_{11})$ works. Let $n \geq 2$ and suppose the statement holds for $n - 1$. Write

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} A_{n-1} & \mathbf{b} \\ \mathbf{c}^\top & d \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{c} \in F^{n-1}, d \in F.$$

The leading principal submatrices of A_{n-1} are $A_1, \dots, A_{n-1}$, all invertible, so by the induction hypothesis $A_{n-1} = L'U'$ with L' unit lower triangular and U' upper triangular and invertible. Put $\mathbf{y} = L'^{-1}\mathbf{b}$, $\mathbf{x}^\top = \mathbf{c}^\top U'^{-1}$ and $z = d - \mathbf{x}^\top \mathbf{y}$, and let

$$L = \begin{pmatrix} L' & \mathbf{0} \\ \mathbf{x}^\top & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad U = \begin{pmatrix} U' & \mathbf{y} \\ \mathbf{0}^\top & z \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then L is unit lower triangular and U is upper triangular. Computing LU entry by entry, splitting each sum $\sum_{l=1}^n$ into $l \leq n-1$ and $l = n$: the top-left block is $L'U' + \mathbf{0}\mathbf{0}^\top = A_{n-1}$; the top-right column is $L'\mathbf{y} + \mathbf{0}z = \mathbf{b}$; the bottom-left row is $\mathbf{x}^\top U' + 1 \cdot \mathbf{0}^\top = \mathbf{c}^\top$; the corner is $\mathbf{x}^\top \mathbf{y} + z = d$. Hence $A = LU$.

Finally $A = A_n$ is invertible by hypothesis, and L is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.1](#), so $U = L^{-1}A$ is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#). This completes the induction.

In the language of elimination: z is the n -th pivot, and (c) shows that invertible leading corners are exactly what keeps every pivot non-zero.

Exercise C2: An LDL factorization.

Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -4 & 8 \\ -4 & 5 & -11 \\ 8 & -11 & 27 \end{pmatrix} \in M_3(\mathbb{R})$.

- (a) Find the LU factorization of A , show that A is invertible, and write $A = LDL^\top$.
 (b) Deduce that $\mathbf{x}^\top A \mathbf{x} > 0$ for every non-zero $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution.

- (a) Step 1: pivot 4, multipliers $\ell_{21} = -1$, $\ell_{31} = 2$. Row 2 becomes $(-4, 5, -11) + (4, -4, 8) = (0, 1, -3)$, row 3 becomes $(8, -11, 27) - 2(4, -4, 8) = (0, -3, 11)$. Step 2: pivot 1, multiplier $\ell_{32} = -3$; row 3 becomes $(0, -3, 11) + 3(0, 1, -3) = (0, 0, 2)$.

Hence

$$L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & -3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad U = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -4 & 8 \\ 0 & 1 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix},$$

and $A = LU$ by [Theorem 2.6.4](#). The diagonal $4, 1, 2$ of U is non-zero, so U is invertible ([Lemma 2.6.2](#)), L is invertible ([Lemma 2.6.1](#)), and $A = LU$ is invertible. A is symmetric, so by [Theorem 2.6.8](#), with $D = \text{diag}(4, 1, 2)$,

$$A = LDL^T, \quad DL^T = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -4 & 8 \\ 0 & 1 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = U,$$

which confirms the theorem directly.

- (b) Let $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$ and put $\mathbf{y} = L^T \mathbf{x}$. By [Lemma 2.6.1](#), L is invertible, so L^T is invertible by [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (4), so $\mathbf{y} \neq \mathbf{0}$ (otherwise $\mathbf{x} = (L^T)^{-1} \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$). By [Theorem 0.9.5](#), $\mathbf{y}^T = \mathbf{x}^T L$, so

$$\mathbf{x}^T A \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}^T L D L^T \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}^T D \mathbf{y} = 4y_1^2 + y_2^2 + 2y_3^2,$$

reading the 1×1 matrix as a real number. Each term is ≥ 0 , and at least one $y_i \neq 0$, which makes its term strictly positive. Hence $\mathbf{x}^T A \mathbf{x} > 0$.

Exercise C3: Counting matrices without an LU factorization.

- (a) Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} \in M_2(F)$. Prove that A has an LU factorization if and only if $a \neq 0$ or $c = 0$.
- (b) Let q be a prime. How many matrices in $M_2(\mathbb{F}_q)$ have **no** LU factorization? List them for $q = 2$.

Solution.

- (a) ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $A = LU$ with $L = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ \ell & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $U = \begin{pmatrix} u & v \\ 0 & w \end{pmatrix}$. As in [Example \(An invertible matrix with no LU factorization\)](#), $LU = \begin{pmatrix} u & v \\ \ell u & \ell v + w \end{pmatrix}$, so $a = u$ and $c = \ell u = \ell a$. If $a = 0$, then $c = 0$. Hence $a \neq 0$ or $c = 0$.
- ($\Leftarrow$) If $a \neq 0$, elimination without row swaps succeeds with multiplier $\ell = c/a$, and indeed

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ c/a & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & d - cb/a \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & cb/a + d - cb/a \end{pmatrix} = A.$$

If $c = 0$, then A is upper triangular and $A = IA$.

- (b) By (a), A has no LU factorization exactly when $a = 0$ and $c \neq 0$. There are $q - 1$ choices of c , and q choices each of b and d , so there are $(q - 1)q^2$ such matrices. For $q = 2$ this gives 4 of the 16 matrices: $a = 0$, $c = 1$, and $b, d \in \{0, 1\}$, that is,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

2.7 Applications of Linear Systems

We now have a complete engine: elimination decides whether $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is consistent, rank–nullity counts the free parameters, and the null space describes the freedom. This section runs the engine on four problems from outside linear algebra. In each one the modeling step is where the thinking happens: which quantities are unknown, why the constraints are linear, and over which field. Each model is also honest about what it leaves out.

2.7.1 Polynomial interpolation

Suppose we know the values of an unknown polynomial at a few points, and want the polynomial. Through two points with different x -values there is exactly one line. Through three there is exactly one parabola, possibly degenerate. The general question: given points $(x_0, y_0), \dots, (x_n, y_n)$ in F^2 , is there a polynomial $p \in F[x]_{\leq n}$ with

$$p(x_0) = y_0, \quad p(x_1) = y_1, \quad \dots, \quad p(x_n) = y_n,$$

and is it unique?

The unknowns are the coefficients. Writing $p = c_0 + c_1x + \dots + c_nx^n$, the condition $p(x_i) = y_i$ reads $c_0 + c_1x_i + \dots + c_nx_i^n = y_i$, by [Definition 0.8.6](#). The x_i and y_i are known numbers, so this is a **linear** equation in $c_0, \dots, c_n$, even though p itself is not linear. The $n + 1$ conditions form a square system

$$V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{y}, \quad V = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & x_0 & x_0^2 & \cdots & x_0^n \\ 1 & x_1 & x_1^2 & \cdots & x_1^n \\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & & \vdots \\ 1 & x_n & x_n^2 & \cdots & x_n^n \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{pmatrix} c_0 \\ \vdots \\ c_n \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{y} = \begin{pmatrix} y_0 \\ \vdots \\ y_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

By [Theorem 2.4.4](#), this has exactly one solution for **every** $\mathbf{y}$ as soon as $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution. And $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$ says that the polynomial with coefficients $\mathbf{c}$ has the $n + 1$ roots $x_0, \dots, x_n$. So everything hinges on a fact about polynomials: a non-zero polynomial of degree at most n cannot have $n + 1$ distinct roots. Chapter 0 proved this only for degree at most 2, in [Exercise \(C1: Roots of a quadratic\)](#), so we prove it now in general. It takes two lemmas.

The first is long division by $x - c$, carried out one leading term at a time.

Lemma 2.7.1 — Factor Theorem for a Linear Divisor

Let $p \in F[x]$ and $c \in F$. Then there is $q \in F[x]$ such that

$$p = (x - c)q + p(c).$$

In particular, if c is a root of p , then $p = (x - c)q$.

Idea. Divide as at school. If p has leading term a_dx^d , subtract $a_dx^{d-1}(x - c)$, which kills the leading term and leaves a polynomial of smaller degree. Repeat until only a constant remains. To turn “repeat” into a proof, use induction on the degree. The constant left over is found by evaluating at c , where the factor $x - c$ vanishes.

Proof. We first show that $p = (x - c)q + r$ for some $q \in F[x]$ and some constant $r \in F$, by strong induction on $\deg p$ ([Theorem 0.2.10](#)), treating $p = 0$ together with the constants. If $p = 0$ or $\deg p = 0$, then p is a constant, and $q = 0$, $r = p$ work.

Let $d \geq 1$, and suppose the statement holds for every polynomial of degree less than d , and for 0. Let $\deg p = d$ with leading coefficient a_d , and put

$$p_1 = p - a_d x^{d-1}(x - c) = p - a_d x^d + c a_d x^{d-1}.$$

The coefficient of x^d in p_1 is $a_d - a_d = 0$, and all higher coefficients are 0, so $p_1 = 0$ or $\deg p_1 < d$. By the induction hypothesis, $p_1 = (x - c)q_1 + r$ with $r \in F$. Hence

$$p = (x - c)(a_d x^{d-1} + q_1) + r,$$

which is the statement for p , with $q = a_d x^{d-1} + q_1$.

Now evaluate at c . By [Theorem 0.8.5](#), $p(c) = (c - c)q(c) + r = 0 \cdot q(c) + r = r$. So $r = p(c)$, and if $p(c) = 0$, then $p = (x - c)q$. This proves the lemma. ■

Lemma 2.7.2 — Root bound

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$, and let $p \in F[x]$ be **non-zero** with $\deg p \leq n$. Then p has **at most** n distinct roots in F .

Proof. We use induction on n . If $n = 0$, then $p = a$ is a non-zero constant, and $p(c) = a \neq 0$ for every $c \in F$, so p has no roots.

Let $n \geq 1$, suppose the statement holds for $n - 1$, and let $p \neq 0$ with $\deg p \leq n$. If p has no root, we are done. Otherwise let c be a root. By [Lemma 2.7.1](#), $p = (x - c)q$ for some $q \in F[x]$. Then $q \neq 0$, since otherwise $p = 0$, and by [Theorem 0.8.3](#), $\deg p = 1 + \deg q$, so $\deg q \leq n - 1$. By the induction hypothesis, q has at most $n - 1$ distinct roots.

Let $s \in F$ be any root of p . By [Theorem 0.8.5](#), $0 = p(s) = (s - c)q(s)$, so $s - c = 0$ or $q(s) = 0$ by [Theorem 0.7.1](#). Hence every root of p is c or a root of q , and p has at most $1 + (n - 1) = n$ distinct roots. This completes the induction. ■

The field axioms did real work in the last step: a product of two non-zero elements is non-zero. Over $\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z}$, which is not a field, $x^2 - 1$ has the four roots 1, 3, 5, 7, as [Exercise \(C1: Roots of a quadratic\)](#) showed. And the lemma is sharp: over $\mathbb{F}_2$, the polynomial $x^2 + x$ of [Example \(Different polynomials, same function\)](#) has degree 2 and the two roots 0 and 1.

The lemma also settles a question left open in Chapter 0. If F is **infinite** and the polynomial function of p is zero, then every element of F is a root of p . If p were non-zero, this would be more than $\deg p$ roots, so $p = 0$. Over an infinite field, a polynomial is therefore determined by its values: if $p(c) = q(c)$ for every $c \in F$, then $p - q$ has zero polynomial function by [Theorem 0.8.5](#), so $p - q = 0$.

Theorem 2.7.3 — Polynomial interpolation

Let $x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n \in F$ be **distinct**, and let $y_0, y_1, \dots, y_n \in F$ be arbitrary. Then there is **exactly one** polynomial $p \in F[x]_{\leq n}$ with $p(x_i) = y_i$ for $i = 0, 1, \dots, n$.

Proof. A polynomial $p \in F[x]_{\leq n}$ is the same thing as its coefficient vector $\mathbf{c} = (c_0, \dots, c_n) \in F^{n+1}$, since two polynomials are equal exactly when their coefficients agree (Definition 0.8.1). As computed above, $p(x_i) = y_i$ for all i if and only if $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{y}$, where $V \in M_{n+1}(F)$ has (i, j) -entry x_i^j (rows and columns numbered from 0 to n).

Let $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$, and let $q = c_0 + c_1x + \dots + c_nx^n$. Then $q(x_i) = 0$ for every i , so q has the $n+1$ distinct roots $x_0, \dots, x_n$, while $\deg q \leq n$. By Lemma 2.7.2, q cannot be non-zero, so $q = 0$ and $\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$. Hence $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution, and V is invertible by Theorem 2.4.4. By Theorem 0.9.7 (7), $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{y}$ has exactly one solution $\mathbf{c} = V^{-1}\mathbf{y}$. The polynomial with these coefficients is the unique p required. This proves the theorem. ■

The proof is a model of how this chapter turns questions into systems. Existence for every right-hand side and uniqueness are both properties of the square matrix V , and for a square matrix they come together. So we only had to prove uniqueness for the zero data, and that was a statement about roots. Chapter 5 gives an explicit formula for p , the Lagrange interpolation formula. Here is the computation by elimination.

Example. (A cubic through four points)

Find the polynomial $p \in \mathbb{Q}[x]_{\leq 3}$ whose graph passes through $(-1, 2)$, $(0, 1)$, $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 11)$.

Solution. The x -values $-1, 0, 1, 2$ are distinct, so by Theorem 2.7.3 there is exactly one such $p = c_0 + c_1x + c_2x^2 + c_3x^3$. The conditions $p(x_i) = y_i$ give the augmented matrix below. We first swap the rows for $x = -1$ and $x = 0$, so that the simplest row leads:

$$\left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -1 & 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 & 8 & 11 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 & 1 & -1 & 2 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 & 8 & 11 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1, R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 2 & 4 & 8 & 10 \end{array} \right)$$

Next clear column 2 below the pivot -1 :

$$\xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + 2R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 6 & 6 & 12 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - 3R_3} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & -1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 6 & 6 \end{array} \right).$$

Back substitution: $6c_3 = 6$, so $c_3 = 1$; $2c_2 = 2$, so $c_2 = 1$; $-c_1 + c_2 - c_3 = 1$, so $c_1 = -1$; and $c_0 = 1$. Hence

$$p = 1 - x + x^2 + x^3.$$

Check: $p(-1) = 1+1+1-1 = 2$, $p(0) = 1$, $p(1) = 1-1+1+1 = 2$, $p(2) = 1-2+4+8 = 11$.

Warning. The x -values must be distinct as elements of F . If $x_0 = x_1$, the first two equations of $V\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{y}$ have the same left-hand side, so the system is inconsistent for any data with $y_0 \neq y_1$. This depends on the field: over $\mathbb{F}_3$ the numbers -1 and 2 are the **same** element, so the four points of [Example \(A cubic through four points\)](#) do not have distinct x -values there. Note also that the theorem promises degree **at most** n : the three points $(0, 0), (1, 1), (2, 2)$ are interpolated by $p = x$, of degree 1.

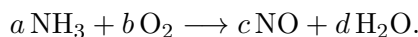
Quick check. Find the polynomial $p \in \mathbb{F}_3[x]_{\leq 2}$ with $p(0) = 1$, $p(1) = 0$ and $p(2) = 0$.

Solution. The x -values $0, 1, 2$ are distinct in $\mathbb{F}_3$, so there is exactly one such p . Since 1 and 2 are roots, try $p = a(x - 1)(x - 2)$, which has degree at most 2 and vanishes at 1 and 2 . Then $p(0) = a \cdot (-1)(-2) = 2a$, and $2a = 1$ gives $a = 2$, since $2 \cdot 2 = 4 = 1$ in $\mathbb{F}_3$. Expanding, $p = 2(x^2 - 3x + 2) = 2(x^2 + 2) = 2x^2 + 1$. Check: $p(0) = 1$, $p(1) = 3 = 0$, $p(2) = 9 = 0$. By uniqueness, this is the answer.

What the model leaves out. Interpolation fits the data **exactly**. When the y_i are measurements with errors, an exact fit of high degree follows the noise and can swing wildly between the data points. The honest tool there is a low-degree polynomial that fits approximately, found by least squares in Chapter 10.

2.7.2 Balancing chemical equations

When ammonia burns in oxygen over a catalyst, it produces nitric oxide and water:



The coefficients a, b, c, d count molecules. The model rests on one physical law: **atoms are neither created nor destroyed**, so each element appears equally often on both sides. For each element this gives one linear equation:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{N: } & a = c, \\ \text{H: } & 3a = 2d, \\ \text{O: } & 2b = c + d. \end{aligned}$$

Moving everything to the left gives a homogeneous system, so the balanced coefficient vectors form the null space of its coefficient matrix. We want positive integers, but we compute over $\mathbb{Q}$. Elimination uses only the four field operations on integer data, so it never leaves $\mathbb{Q}$, and a rational solution can be scaled to an integer one at the end.

Example. (Burning ammonia)

Find all solutions of the system above over $\mathbb{Q}$, and hence the balanced equation with the smallest positive integer coefficients.

Solution. In the order (a, b, c, d) , with rows N, H, O, the coefficient matrix is reduced as follows:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 3 & 0 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 2 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 3R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 3 & -2 \\ 0 & 2 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 2 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 3 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

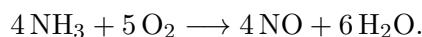
Scale rows 2 and 3 by $\frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{1}{3}$, then clear column 3 above its pivot:

$$\begin{array}{l} R_2 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}R_2 \\ R_3 \rightarrow \frac{1}{3}R_3 \end{array} \rightarrow \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -\frac{1}{2} & -\frac{1}{2} \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -\frac{2}{3} \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{\begin{array}{l} R_1 \rightarrow R_1 + R_3 \\ R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + \frac{1}{2}R_3 \end{array}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & -\frac{2}{3} \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -\frac{5}{6} \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -\frac{2}{3} \end{pmatrix}.$$

This is the RREF. The pivot columns are 1, 2, 3, and d is the only free variable. By [Theorem 2.2.4](#), with $d = t$, the solutions are

$$(a, b, c, d) = t \left(\frac{2}{3}, \frac{5}{6}, \frac{2}{3}, 1 \right), \quad t \in \mathbb{Q}.$$

So the null space is a line: rank 3 and nullity $4 - 3 = 1$, as [Theorem 2.5.7](#) predicts. The coefficients are integers exactly when $\frac{2}{3}t$, $\frac{5}{6}t$ and t are integers, which forces t to be a multiple of 6. The smallest positive choice $t = 6$ gives $(4, 5, 4, 6)$:



Check: N: $4 = 4$. H: $12 = 12$. O: $10 = 4 + 6$.

Nullity 1 is what makes “the balanced equation” meaningful: every balancing is a multiple of one. Positivity was luck of the data here. Nothing in the algebra guarantees that the null space contains a vector with all entries positive, and when it does not, the proposed reaction cannot be balanced at all.

Warning. A null space of dimension 2 or more does not give one balanced equation. For $a\text{H}_2 + b\text{O}_2 \rightarrow c\text{H}_2\text{O} + d\text{H}_2\text{O}_2$, the equations $2a = 2c + 2d$ (hydrogen) and $2b = c + 2d$ (oxygen) have rank 2 and nullity 2. Both $(2, 1, 2, 0)$ and $(1, 1, 0, 1)$ balance, and so does every positive combination of them. The “reaction” is really two reactions, $2\text{H}_2 + \text{O}_2 \rightarrow 2\text{H}_2\text{O}$ and $\text{H}_2 + \text{O}_2 \rightarrow \text{H}_2\text{O}_2$, and the proportions depend on chemistry, not on algebra.

What the model leaves out. Conservation of atoms is necessary, not sufficient. The equations cannot tell whether a reaction actually happens, and reactions involving ions also conserve electric charge, which adds one more linear equation.

2.7.3 Flows in a network

A small town center has four intersections and five one-way streets. Cars enter and leave the center at some intersections. We measure the external traffic and want to know the traffic on each street.

The model has one assumption: at every intersection, as many cars leave per minute as arrive, since cars do not pile up or vanish. In electrical circuits the same rule for currents is **Kirchhoff’s current law**. To write it down, number the intersections (**vertices**) $1, \dots, m$ and the streets (**edges**) $1, \dots, k$. Each edge e runs from a vertex $\text{tail}(e)$ to a **different** vertex $\text{head}(e)$. The unknown f_e is the flow along edge e . The data s_v is the net external supply at v : cars entering the network there per minute, with a negative sign for cars leaving. Conservation at v says

$$(\text{flow out of } v) - (\text{flow into } v) = s_v.$$

Definition 2.7.1 — Incidence matrix

The **incidence matrix** of a network with vertices $1, \dots, m$ and edges $1, \dots, k$, where $k \geq 1$, is $N \in M_{m \times k}(\mathbb{R})$ with

$$N_{ve} = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } v = \text{tail}(e), \\ -1 & \text{if } v = \text{head}(e), \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Row v of $N\mathbf{f}$ is $\sum_e N_{ve}f_e$, the flow out of v minus the flow into v . So conservation at every vertex is the single matrix equation $N\mathbf{f} = \mathbf{s}$. Column e of N has exactly one 1 and one -1 , so its entries sum to 0. Adding up all the conservation equations therefore gives $0 = s_1 + \dots + s_m$: **total inflow equals total outflow**. This is necessary for a solution. The next result shows that, for a network in one piece, it is also sufficient.

A network is **connected** if for any two vertices v, w there is a sequence of vertices $v = w_0, w_1, \dots, w_t = w$ in which each consecutive pair is joined by an edge, in either direction.

Proposition 2.7.4 — Rank of an incidence matrix

Let $N \in M_{m \times k}(\mathbb{R})$ be the incidence matrix of a **connected** network with m vertices. Then $\text{rank } N = m - 1$.

Idea. Rank is easier to see through the transpose. A vector $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ assigns a number to each vertex, and $N^T\mathbf{y}$ records, for each edge, the difference of the numbers at its two ends. So $N^T\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$ says that the numbers agree across every edge. Along a chain of edges they then agree everywhere, so the null space of N^T is the line of constant vectors. Rank-nullity and “row rank equals column rank” finish.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$. For each edge e , entry e of $N^T\mathbf{y}$ is $\sum_v N_{ve}y_v = y_{\text{tail}(e)} - y_{\text{head}(e)}$, by Definition 0.9.10 and Definition 2.7.1. Hence $N^T\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if $y_u = y_w$ whenever u and w are joined by an edge.

Suppose $N^T\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$. Given any vertex w , connectedness gives a sequence $1 = w_0, w_1, \dots, w_t = w$ with consecutive vertices joined by edges, so $y_1 = y_{w_1} = \dots = y_w$. Hence $\mathbf{y} = y_1\mathbf{1}$, where $\mathbf{1} = (1, \dots, 1) \in \mathbb{R}^m$. Conversely $N^T\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{0}$, since all differences vanish. So $\text{nul}(N^T) = \text{span}(\mathbf{1})$, and since $\mathbf{1} \neq \mathbf{0}$, its dimension is 1.

The matrix N^T has m columns, so Theorem 2.5.7 gives $\text{rank } N^T = m - 1$. By Theorem 2.5.5, $\text{rank } N = \text{rank } N^T = m - 1$. This proves the proposition. ■

Corollary 2.7.5 — Solvable flow problems

Let $N \in M_{m \times k}(\mathbb{R})$ be the incidence matrix of a connected network, and let $\mathbf{s} \in \mathbb{R}^m$. Then $N\mathbf{f} = \mathbf{s}$ has a solution if and only if $s_1 + \dots + s_m = 0$. In that case the solutions form $\mathbf{f}_0 + \text{nul}(N)$ for any one solution $\mathbf{f}_0$, and $\dim \text{nul}(N) = k - m + 1$.

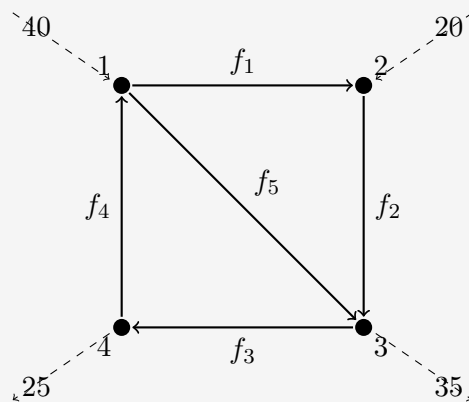
Proof. Let $W = \{\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^m : z_1 + \cdots + z_m = 0\}$. It is the solution set of the homogeneous system with the $1 \times m$ coefficient matrix $(1 \ \cdots \ 1)$, so it is a subspace by [Theorem 2.1.2](#). That matrix has rank 1, since its column space is spanned by the non-zero column (1) and so equals $\mathbb{R}^1$. By [Theorem 2.5.7](#), $\dim W = m - 1$.

Each column of N has entries summing to 0, so it lies in W , and since W is a subspace, $\text{col}(N) \subseteq W$ by [Theorem 1.3.1](#). Also $\dim \text{col}(N) = \text{rank } N = m - 1 = \dim W$, by [Definition 2.5.4](#) and [Proposition 2.7.4](#). Hence $\text{col}(N) = W$ by [Theorem 1.6.8](#). By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), $N\mathbf{f} = \mathbf{s}$ is consistent if and only if $\mathbf{s} \in \text{col}(N) = W$, which is the first claim. The description of all solutions is [Theorem 2.1.3](#), and $\dim \text{nul}(N) = k - (m - 1)$ by [Theorem 2.5.7](#), since N has k columns. ■

The $k - m + 1$ free parameters have a clear meaning: they are flows around **loops**. Adding the same amount of traffic all the way around a closed circuit of streets changes no intersection's balance.

Example. (Traffic in a town center)

Four intersections are joined by one-way streets $1 \rightarrow 2$, $2 \rightarrow 3$, $3 \rightarrow 4$, $4 \rightarrow 1$ and $1 \rightarrow 3$, carrying unknown flows $f_1, \dots, f_5$ (cars per minute) in that order. From outside, 40 cars per minute enter at intersection 1 and 20 at intersection 2, while 35 leave at intersection 3 and 25 at intersection 4.



Find all flows that satisfy conservation. If street $4 \rightarrow 1$ is closed for repairs and flows cannot be negative, what is the largest flow the diagonal street $1 \rightarrow 3$ may have to carry?

Solution. The network is connected, and $\mathbf{s} = (40, 20, -35, -25)$ sums to 0, so by [Corollary 2.7.5](#) a solution exists and the solutions have $5 - 4 + 1 = 2$ free parameters. We row reduce $[N \mid \mathbf{s}]$, with rows for vertices 1, 2, 3, 4 and columns for $f_1, \dots, f_5$:

$$\left(\begin{array}{ccccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 40 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 20 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & -1 & -35 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & -25 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_1} \left(\begin{array}{ccccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 40 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 60 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & -1 & -35 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & -25 \end{array} \right)$$

$$\xrightarrow{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + R_2} \left(\begin{array}{ccccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 40 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 60 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 & 25 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 & -25 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 + R_3} \left(\begin{array}{ccccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 40 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & 1 & 60 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 & 25 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{array} \right).$$

This is the RREF, with pivots in columns 1, 2, 3, so $\text{rank } N = 3 = m - 1$, as [Proposition 2.7.4](#) predicts. The free variables are $f_4 = \alpha$ and $f_5 = \beta$, and by [Theorem 2.2.4](#),

$$\mathbf{f} = \begin{pmatrix} 40 \\ 60 \\ 25 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} + \alpha \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} + \beta \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ -1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{R}.$$

The two null space vectors are the loops: α sends extra cars around $1 \rightarrow 2 \rightarrow 3 \rightarrow 4 \rightarrow 1$, and β moves cars from the route $1 \rightarrow 2 \rightarrow 3$ onto the diagonal $1 \rightarrow 3$.

With street $4 \rightarrow 1$ closed, $\alpha = f_4 = 0$ and $\mathbf{f} = (40 - \beta, 60 - \beta, 25, 0, \beta)$. Non-negativity requires $\beta \geq 0$, $40 - \beta \geq 0$ and $60 - \beta \geq 0$, that is, $0 \leq \beta \leq 40$. So the diagonal may carry up to 40 cars per minute, which happens when street $1 \rightarrow 2$ is empty. Check, for $\mathbf{f} = (0, 20, 25, 0, 40)$: at vertex 1, out $0 + 40$ minus in 0 is 40; at 2, out 20 minus in 0 is 20; at 3, out 25 minus in $20 + 40$ is -35 ; at 4, out 0 minus in 25 is -25 .

What the model leaves out. Linear algebra finds every flow that conserves cars, including physically meaningless ones with negative entries, and it cannot say which of the many valid flows drivers actually choose. Non-negativity and street capacities turn the problem into one about inequalities, which is the subject of linear programming. The matrix NN^T of this model, the graph Laplacian, returns in Chapter 23.

2.7.4 Lights out over $\mathbb{F}_2$

A puzzle has a 3×3 grid of lights, each on or off. Pressing a light **toggles** it and its horizontal and vertical neighbors (a corner has two neighbors, an edge light three, the center four). Starting from some pattern, the goal is to switch every light off. Can every starting pattern be solved?

The model rests on two observations about the puzzle, and together they say that the right field is $\mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\}$.

1. Encode “on” as 1 and “off” as 0. Toggling a light is adding 1 in $\mathbb{F}_2$, because $0 + 1 = 1$ and $1 + 1 = 0$. The effect of several presses on a light is the sum of their effects, and since addition is commutative, **the order of presses does not matter**.
2. Pressing a button twice toggles each affected light twice, which is $1 + 1 = 0$: nothing. So a strategy is just the **set** of buttons pressed once, a vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{F}_2^9$.

Number the cells (i, j) , row i , column j , and list them row by row. Pressing button (i, j) adds to the pattern a fixed vector $\mathbf{a}_{ij} \in \mathbb{F}_2^9$, with 1’s at (i, j) and its neighbors. Let $A \in M_9(\mathbb{F}_2)$ be the matrix with these columns. Starting from pattern $\mathbf{b}$ and pressing the buttons in $\mathbf{x}$, the final pattern is $\mathbf{b} + A\mathbf{x}$ by [Theorem 0.9.3](#), and we want it to be $\mathbf{0}$. Since $-\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{b}$ in $\mathbb{F}_2^9$, the puzzle is

the linear system

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b} \quad \text{over } \mathbb{F}_2, \quad A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

By [Theorem 2.1.1](#), pattern $\mathbf{b}$ is solvable exactly when $\mathbf{b} \in \text{col}(A)$. So “is every pattern solvable?” asks whether $\text{rank } A = 9$.

Example. (Every pattern of the 3×3 puzzle is solvable)

Show that $\text{rank } A = 9$. Deduce that every one of the $2^9 = 512$ starting patterns can be switched off, by exactly one set of presses.

Solution. We show that $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution. Write the presses as a grid x_{ij} , and suppose $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$: the presses change no light. The equation for light (i, j) says that the presses at (i, j) and its neighbors add up to 0. We solve these equations row by row, remembering that $-u = u$ in $\mathbb{F}_2$. Name the top row $x_{11} = p$, $x_{12} = q$, $x_{13} = r$.

Lights of row 1 determine the presses of row 2. Light $(1, 1)$ gives $x_{11} + x_{12} + x_{21} = 0$, so $x_{21} = p + q$. Likewise lights $(1, 2)$ and $(1, 3)$ give

$$x_{22} = x_{11} + x_{12} + x_{13} = p + q + r, \quad x_{23} = x_{12} + x_{13} = q + r.$$

Lights of row 2 determine the presses of row 3. Light $(2, 1)$ gives $x_{31} = x_{11} + x_{21} + x_{22} = p + (p + q) + (p + q + r) = p + r$, using $3p = p$ and $2q = 0$. Light $(2, 2)$ gives $x_{32} = x_{12} + x_{21} + x_{22} + x_{23} = q + (p + q) + (p + q + r) + (q + r) = 0$. Light $(2, 3)$ gives $x_{33} = x_{13} + x_{22} + x_{23} = r + (p + q + r) + (q + r) = p + r$.

Lights of row 3 give three conditions on p, q, r .

$$\begin{aligned} (3, 1) : \quad & x_{21} + x_{31} + x_{32} = (p + q) + (p + r) + 0 = q + r = 0, \\ (3, 2) : \quad & x_{22} + x_{31} + x_{32} + x_{33} = (p + q + r) + (p + r) + 0 + (p + r) = p + q + r = 0, \\ (3, 3) : \quad & x_{23} + x_{32} + x_{33} = (q + r) + 0 + (p + r) = p + q = 0. \end{aligned}$$

The first and third give $r = q$ and $p = q$, and then the second gives $3q = q = 0$. So $p = q = r = 0$, and the formulas above make every $x_{ij} = 0$.

Hence the null space of A is $\{\mathbf{0}\}$, and $\text{rank } A = 9 - 0 = 9$ by [Theorem 2.5.7](#). So $\text{col}(A)$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{F}_2^9$ of dimension 9, and $\text{col}(A) = \mathbb{F}_2^9$ by [Theorem 1.6.8](#). Every pattern $\mathbf{b}$ lies in $\text{col}(A)$, so every pattern is solvable. The solution is unique by [Corollary 2.1.4](#), since $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution. In particular exactly one of the 512 press sets solves each of the 512 patterns.

The same chase finds an actual solution: the constants from $\mathbf{b}$ simply ride along.

Example. (Switching off the center)

Only the center light is on. Which buttons should be pressed?

Solution. Now $\mathbf{b}$ has a 1 at $(2, 2)$ only, so the equation for light $(2, 2)$ has right-hand side 1 and all others 0. Rows 1 and 2 of lights give, as before, $x_{21} = p + q$, $x_{22} = p + q + r$, $x_{23} = q + r$, $x_{31} = p + r$, $x_{33} = p + r$, and now

$$x_{32} = 1 + x_{12} + x_{21} + x_{22} + x_{23} = 1.$$

The lights of row 3 give $(p + q) + (p + r) + 1 = 0$, $(p + q + r) + (p + r) + 1 + (p + r) = 0$ and $(q + r) + 1 + (p + r) = 0$, that is,

$$q + r = 1, \quad p + q + r = 1, \quad p + q = 1.$$

Adding the first two gives $p = 0$; then $q = 1$ and $r = 0$. Substituting, $x_{21} = x_{22} = x_{23} = 1$, $x_{31} = x_{33} = 0$ and $x_{32} = 1$. So we press the center and its four neighbors, a plus sign:

	×	
×	×	×
	×	

Check, counting how often each light is toggled. The center is toggled by all five presses: odd, so it goes from on to off. A corner, say $(1, 1)$, is toggled by presses at $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 1)$: even, so it stays off. An edge light, say $(1, 2)$, is toggled by presses at $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 2)$: even, so it stays off. By the symmetry of the plus sign the other corners and edges behave the same way.

Quick check. Starting from all lights **off**, which set of presses produces the pattern with only the center light **on**?

Solution. The same plus sign. Starting from $\mathbf{0}$, presses $\mathbf{x}$ produce the pattern $A\mathbf{x}$, so we need $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ with $\mathbf{b}$ the center pattern, which is exactly the system just solved. Over $\mathbb{F}_2$, turning a pattern on and turning it off are the same problem.

Remark. Larger boards behave differently. A computation over $\mathbb{F}_2$, by the same elimination, gives rank $A = 12$ for the 4×4 board and rank $A = 23$ for the 5×5 board. On the 5×5 board, $\text{col}(A)$ has dimension 23, so it contains 2^{23} patterns (coordinates in a basis match its elements with $\mathbb{F}_2^{23}$), and only one pattern in four can be switched off.

What the model leaves out. Nothing, which is rare. The puzzle is linear over $\mathbb{F}_2$ by its rules, so the model is exact. It even predicts features that are not obvious when playing, such as the irrelevance of the order of presses.

2.7.5 Exercises

2.7.5.1 A. Check your understanding

Exercise A1.

- (a) State the polynomial interpolation theorem, including its hypotheses.
- (b) True or false: there is a polynomial $p \in \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 1}$ with $p(1) = 2$ and $p(1) = 3$. Which hypothesis of the theorem fails?
- (c) In balancing a chemical equation, what does it mean if the null space of the coefficient matrix has dimension 1? Dimension 2?
- (d) Why is lights out modeled over $\mathbb{F}_2$ and not over $\mathbb{R}$?
- (e) A connected network has 6 vertices and 9 edges. What is the rank of its incidence matrix, and how many free parameters does the solution set of a consistent flow problem have?

Solution.

- (a) See [Theorem 2.7.3](#): for **distinct** $x_0, \dots, x_n \in F$ and any $y_0, \dots, y_n \in F$, there is exactly one $p \in F[x]_{\leq n}$ with $p(x_i) = y_i$ for all i .
- (b) False: $p(1)$ is one number, and $2 \neq 3$. The theorem needs distinct x -values, and here $x_0 = x_1 = 1$.
- (c) Dimension 1: all balancings are multiples of one vector, so there is one balanced equation up to scaling (provided a positive multiple exists). Dimension 2 or more: there are independent balancings, and the equation is a mixture of several reactions whose proportions algebra cannot decide.
- (d) A light has two states, and toggling twice restores it, so toggling is adding 1 with $1 + 1 = 0$, which is arithmetic in $\mathbb{F}_2$. Over $\mathbb{R}$, pressing a button twice would count as 2, not 0.
- (e) By [Proposition 2.7.4](#) the rank is $6 - 1 = 5$. By [Corollary 2.7.5](#) a consistent problem has $9 - 6 + 1 = 4$ free parameters.

2.7.5.2 B. Practice**Exercise B1: Interpolating four points.**

Find the polynomial $p \in \mathbb{Q}[x]_{\leq 3}$ with $p(0) = -1$, $p(1) = 1$, $p(2) = 3$ and $p(3) = 11$. Justify that there is only one.

Solution. The x -values 0, 1, 2, 3 are distinct, so there is exactly one such $p = c_0 + c_1x + c_2x^2 + c_3x^3$, by [Theorem 2.7.3](#). Its coefficients solve

$$\left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 & 8 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 9 & 27 & 11 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_1]{R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - R_1, R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 2 & 4 & 8 & 4 \\ 0 & 3 & 9 & 27 & 12 \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - 3R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 2R_2} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 6 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 6 & 24 & 6 \end{array} \right)$$

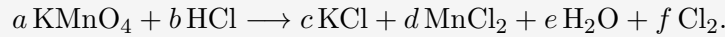
and then $R_4 - 3R_3$ turns the last row into $(0, 0, 0, 6 \mid 6)$. Back substitution: $c_3 = 1$; $2c_2 + 6 = 0$, so $c_2 = -3$; $c_1 - 3 + 1 = 2$, so $c_1 = 4$; $c_0 = -1$. Hence

$$p = -1 + 4x - 3x^2 + x^3.$$

Check: $p(0) = -1$, $p(1) = -1 + 4 - 3 + 1 = 1$, $p(2) = -1 + 8 - 12 + 8 = 3$, $p(3) = -1 + 12 - 27 + 27 = 11$.

Exercise B2: Balancing a redox reaction.

Potassium permanganate reacts with hydrochloric acid:



Write the conservation equations for K, Mn, O, H and Cl, find all rational solutions, and hence the balanced equation with the smallest positive integer coefficients.

Solution. Counting atoms of each element on both sides:

$$\text{K: } a = c, \quad \text{Mn: } a = d, \quad \text{O: } 4a = e, \quad \text{H: } b = 2e, \quad \text{Cl: } b = c + 2d + 2f.$$

In the order (a, b, c, d, e, f) , the coefficient matrix has rows $(1, 0, -1, 0, 0, 0)$, $(1, 0, 0, -1, 0, 0)$, $(4, 0, 0, 0, -1, 0)$, $(0, 1, 0, 0, -2, 0)$ and $(0, 1, -1, -2, 0, -2)$. The equations are nearly solved already, so we eliminate by substitution, which is row reduction written in words. The K, Mn and O equations give $c = a$, $d = a$, $e = 4a$. The H equation gives $b = 2e = 8a$. The Cl equation gives $2f = b - c - 2d = 8a - a - 2a = 5a$, so $a = \frac{2}{5}f$. Taking $f = t$ as the free variable, the RREF of the coefficient matrix is

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -\frac{2}{5} \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & -\frac{16}{5} \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & -\frac{1}{5} \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & -\frac{1}{5} \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & -\frac{1}{5} \end{pmatrix},$$

and the solutions are $(a, b, c, d, e, f) = t(\frac{2}{5}, \frac{16}{5}, \frac{2}{5}, \frac{2}{5}, \frac{8}{5}, 1)$, $t \in \mathbb{Q}$. The rank is 5 and the nullity $6 - 5 = 1$, so the balancing is unique up to scaling. All entries are integers exactly when t is a multiple of 5, and $t = 5$ gives



Check: K $2 = 2$; Mn $2 = 2$; O $8 = 8$; H $16 = 16$; Cl $16 = 2 + 4 + 10$.

Exercise B3: A ring road.

Four intersections lie on a ring of one-way streets $1 \rightarrow 2$, $2 \rightarrow 3$, $3 \rightarrow 4$, $4 \rightarrow 1$, with flows f_1, f_2, f_3, f_4 in that order. From outside, 30 cars per minute enter at intersection 1 and 10 at intersection 3, while 15 leave at intersection 2 and 25 at intersection 4.

- Write down the incidence matrix N and the supply vector $\mathbf{s}$, and explain without computation why the system $N\mathbf{f} = \mathbf{s}$ is consistent.
- Find all solutions.
- If all flows must be non-negative, what is the smallest possible flow on each street?

Solution.

- (a) With rows for the vertices and columns for the edges,

$$N = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{s} = \begin{pmatrix} 30 \\ -15 \\ 10 \\ -25 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The ring is connected, and $30 - 15 + 10 - 25 = 0$, so the system is consistent by [Corollary 2.7.5](#).

- (b) Row reducing $[N \mid \mathbf{s}]$: $R_2 + R_1$ gives $(0, 1, 0, -1 \mid 15)$; then $R_3 + R_2$ gives $(0, 0, 1, -1 \mid 25)$; then $R_4 + R_3$ gives the zero row. The pivots are in columns 1, 2, 3, and $f_4 = t$ is free, so

$$\mathbf{f} = (30 + t, 15 + t, 25 + t, t), \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

There is $4 - 4 + 1 = 1$ parameter, the flow around the ring. Check at $t = 0$: vertex 1, $30 - 0 = 30$; vertex 2, $15 - 30 = -15$; vertex 3, $25 - 15 = 10$; vertex 4, $0 - 25 = -25$.

- (c) All flows are non-negative exactly when $t \geq 0$, since then $30 + t, 15 + t, 25 + t \geq 0$ too. Each flow increases with t , so all are smallest at $t = 0$: $f = (30, 15, 25, 0)$. No car needs to use street $4 \rightarrow 1$.

2.7.5.3 C. Going deeper

Exercise C1: The 2×2 puzzle.

Consider lights out on a 2×2 grid, where pressing a light toggles it and its two horizontal and vertical neighbors. Number the cells $1 = (1, 1)$, $2 = (1, 2)$, $3 = (2, 1)$, $4 = (2, 2)$.

- (a) Write down the matrix $A \in M_4(\mathbb{F}_2)$ of the puzzle.
 (b) Show that $A^2 = I$.
 (c) Deduce that every pattern is solvable by exactly one set of presses, and find the presses that switch off the pattern with only light 1 on.

Solution.

- (a) Button j toggles every light except the one diagonally opposite. So

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

- (b) Let J be the 4×4 all-ones matrix and Q the permutation matrix exchanging $1 \leftrightarrow 4$ and $2 \leftrightarrow 3$, which has 1's on the anti-diagonal. Then $A = J - Q = J + Q$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$. Every entry of J^2 is $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 0$, so $J^2 = 0$. Each row and each column of Q has a single 1, so $JQ = J$ and $QJ = J$. And $Q = P_\sigma$ for $\sigma = (1\ 4)(2\ 3)$, with $\sigma \circ \sigma = \text{id}$, so $Q^2 = P_{\text{id}} = I$ by [Lemma 2.6.6](#) (a). By [Theorem 0.9.4](#),

$$A^2 = J^2 + JQ + QJ + Q^2 = 0 + J + J + I = I,$$

because $J + J = 2J = 0$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$.

- (c) By (b), A is invertible with $A^{-1} = A$. By [Theorem 0.9.7](#) (7), $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has exactly one solution $\mathbf{x} = A\mathbf{b}$ for every $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{F}_2^4$. For $\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{e}_1$, $\mathbf{x} = A\mathbf{e}_1 = (1, 1, 1, 0)$: press lights 1, 2, 3. Check: light 1 is toggled by presses 1, 2, 3, three times, so it goes off; light 2 by presses 1 and 2; light 3 by presses 1 and 3; light 4 by presses 2 and 3; each of these is toggled twice and stays off.

Exercise C2: Interpolating values and slopes.

For $p = c_0 + c_1x + c_2x^2 + c_3x^3 \in F[x]_{\leq 3}$, define its (formal) derivative $p' = c_1 + 2c_2x + 3c_3x^2$.

- (a) Prove that for **every** field F and all $a, b, c, d \in F$ there is exactly one $p \in F[x]_{\leq 3}$ with

$$p(0) = a, \quad p'(0) = b, \quad p(1) = c, \quad p'(1) = d.$$

- (b) Find this p over $\mathbb{Q}$ for $(a, b, c, d) = (0, 1, 1, 0)$.

Hint: in (a), check that elimination never divides by an element that could be zero in some field.

Solution.

- (a) The four conditions are linear in $c_0, \dots, c_3$: $p(0) = c_0$, $p'(0) = c_1$, $p(1) = c_0 + c_1 + c_2 + c_3$, $p'(1) = c_1 + 2c_2 + 3c_3$. Row reducing the augmented matrix, using only additions of multiples of rows,

$$\left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & a \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & b \\ 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 & c \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 3 & d \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow[R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - R_2]{R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - R_1 - R_2} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & a \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & b \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & c - a - b \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 3 & d - b \end{array} \right) \xrightarrow{R_4 \rightarrow R_4 - 2R_3} \left(\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & a \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & b \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & c - a - b \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 2a + b - c \end{array} \right)$$

Here $3 - 2 = 1$ holds in every field. The coefficient matrix is now upper triangular with every diagonal entry equal to 1, so it is invertible by [Lemma 2.6.2](#), and back substitution gives the unique solution without any division:

$$c_3 = 2a + b - 2c + d, \quad c_2 = (c - a - b) - c_3 = -3a - 2b + 3c - d, \quad c_1 = b, \quad c_0 = a.$$

Row operations preserve the solution set ([Theorem 2.2.2](#)), so the original system also has exactly this one solution, for every field F .

- (b) With $(a, b, c, d) = (0, 1, 1, 0)$: $c_3 = 0 + 1 - 2 + 0 = -1$, $c_2 = 0 - 2 + 3 - 0 = 1$, $c_1 = 1$, $c_0 = 0$. So $p = x + x^2 - x^3$. Check: $p(0) = 0$; $p' = 1 + 2x - 3x^2$, so $p'(0) = 1$; $p(1) = 1 + 1 - 1 = 1$; $p'(1) = 1 + 2 - 3 = 0$.

Exercise C3: Networks in several pieces.

Let $N \in M_{m \times k}(\mathbb{R})$ be the incidence matrix of a network with m vertices. Say that vertices v and w are **linked** if they are joined by a sequence of vertices in which consecutive ones share an edge, in either direction (every vertex is linked to itself by the sequence of length zero).

- (a) Show that “linked” is an equivalence relation. Its equivalence classes are called

the **components** of the network; let c be their number.

- (b) Prove that $\text{rank } N = m - c$.

Solution.

- (a) *Reflexive*: by the sequence of length zero. *Symmetric*: reversing a sequence from v to w gives one from w to v , and consecutive vertices still share an edge. *Transitive*: following a sequence from u to v by one from v to w gives a sequence from u to w . So “linked” is an equivalence relation ([Definition 0.5.2](#)).
- (b) Let $C_1, \dots, C_c$ be the components, and let $\mathbf{1}_{C_r} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ have entry 1 at the vertices of C_r and 0 elsewhere. As in the proof of [Proposition 2.7.4](#), $N^T \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{0}$ if and only if $y_u = y_w$ for every edge joining u and w . Following sequences of edges, this holds if and only if $\mathbf{y}$ is constant on each component, that is, $\mathbf{y} = \sum_r \lambda_r \mathbf{1}_{C_r}$ with λ_r the common value on C_r . (Conversely each $\mathbf{1}_{C_r}$ is in the null space, since both ends of an edge lie in the same component.) So $(\mathbf{1}_{C_1}, \dots, \mathbf{1}_{C_c})$ spans $\text{nul}(N^T)$. It is independent: if $\sum_r \lambda_r \mathbf{1}_{C_r} = \mathbf{0}$, then reading the entry at any vertex of C_r , where only the r -th vector is non-zero because the components are disjoint ([Theorem 0.5.2](#)), gives $\lambda_r = 0$. Hence $\dim \text{nul}(N^T) = c$. Since N^T has m columns, [Theorem 2.5.7](#) gives $\text{rank } N^T = m - c$, and [Theorem 2.5.5](#) gives $\text{rank } N = m - c$, as claimed.

Chapter 3

Linear Transformations

Vector spaces are only half of the story; the other half is the maps between them that respect addition and scalar multiplication. This chapter studies these *linear transformations*.

3.0.1 Overview

In this part, we will explore:

- **Linear transformations:** the definition and basic properties, examples and non-examples, and the fact that a linear transformation is determined by its values on a basis.
- **Kernel and image:** the two subspaces attached to every linear transformation, with examples and their basic theorems.
- **The rank–nullity theorem:** nullity and rank, and the identity $\text{nullity}(f) + \text{rank}(f) = \dim(V)$ for a finite-dimensional V .

3.1 Linear Transformations

In Chapter 1, we studied vector spaces as static objects—sets equipped with addition and scalar multiplication. Now we turn to the study of **structure-preserving maps** between vector spaces. Just as group theory studies homomorphisms and topology studies continuous functions, linear algebra studies **linear transformations**.

A linear transformation is a function that “respects” the vector space structure: it preserves addition and scalar multiplication. This simple requirement has profound consequences. Linear transformations are the morphisms in the category of vector spaces, and understanding them is central to all of linear algebra.

3.1.1 Definition and Basic Properties

Definition 3.1.1 — Linear Transformation

Let V, W be vector spaces over F . A function $T : V \rightarrow W$ is called a **linear transfor-**

mation (or **linear map**), if

(LT1) $T(\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2) = T(\mathbf{v}_1) + T(\mathbf{v}_2)$, for all $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$;

(LT2) $T(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = \lambda T(\mathbf{v})$, for all $\lambda \in F$ and $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

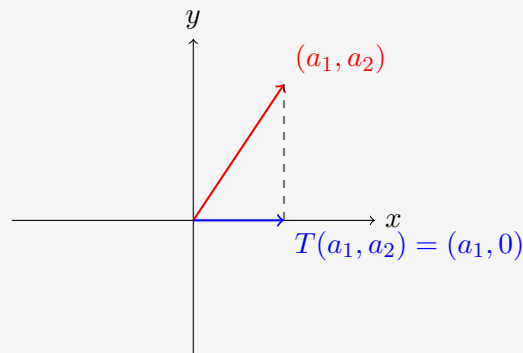
3.1.2 Examples of Linear Transformations

We now present a rich collection of examples. For each, we determine whether the given function is a linear transformation by verifying the two axioms (LT1) and (LT2).

3.1.2.1 Geometric Transformations

Example. (Projection onto a Coordinate Axis)

Determine whether $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by $T(a_1, a_2) = (a_1, 0)$ is a linear transformation.



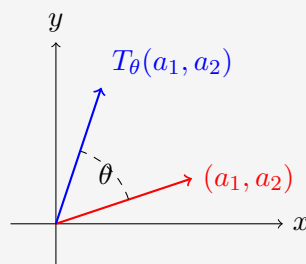
Solution. Let $\mathbf{v} = (a_1, a_2)$ and $\mathbf{w} = (b_1, b_2)$ be vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$, and let $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$.

- **Additivity:** $T(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) = T(a_1 + b_1, a_2 + b_2) = (a_1 + b_1, 0) = (a_1, 0) + (b_1, 0) = T(\mathbf{v}) + T(\mathbf{w})$.
- **Homogeneity:** $T(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = T(\lambda a_1, \lambda a_2) = (\lambda a_1, 0) = \lambda(a_1, 0) = \lambda T(\mathbf{v})$.

Thus T is a linear transformation.

Example. (Rotation in the Plane)

Determine whether rotation by angle θ (counterclockwise) in the plane is a linear transformation. That is, let $T_\theta : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ be the rotation map.



Solution. Write (a_1, a_2) in polar coordinates: $a_1 = r \cos \phi$ and $a_2 = r \sin \phi$. Then:

$$\begin{aligned} T_\theta(a_1, a_2) &= (r \cos(\theta + \phi), r \sin(\theta + \phi)) \\ &= (r \cos \theta \cos \phi - r \sin \theta \sin \phi, r \sin \theta \cos \phi + r \cos \theta \sin \phi) \\ &= \cos \theta (r \cos \phi, r \sin \phi) + \sin \theta (-r \sin \phi, r \cos \phi) \\ &= \cos \theta (a_1, a_2) + \sin \theta (-a_2, a_1). \end{aligned}$$

Thus $T_\theta(a_1, a_2) = (a_1 \cos \theta - a_2 \sin \theta, a_1 \sin \theta + a_2 \cos \theta)$.

Linearity follows from this explicit formula: for $\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^2$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\begin{aligned} T_\theta(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) &= \cos \theta (\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) + \sin \theta \cdot J(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) = T_\theta(\mathbf{v}) + T_\theta(\mathbf{w}), \\ T_\theta(\lambda \mathbf{v}) &= \cos \theta (\lambda \mathbf{v}) + \sin \theta \cdot J(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = \lambda T_\theta(\mathbf{v}), \end{aligned}$$

where $J(a_1, a_2) = (-a_2, a_1)$ is itself linear.

3.1.2.2 Matrix-Induced Transformations

Example. (Left Multiplication by a Matrix)

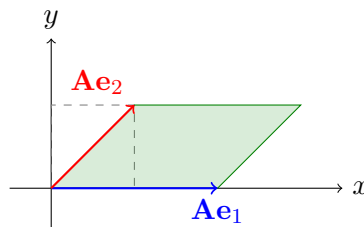
Let $\mathbf{A} \in M_{m \times n}(F)$ be an $m \times n$ matrix. Determine whether $f_{\mathbf{A}} : F^n \rightarrow F^m$ defined by $f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{A}\mathbf{v}$ (where $\mathbf{v}$ is viewed as a column vector) is a linear transformation.

Solution. For $\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in F^n$ and $\lambda \in F$:

- **Additivity:** $f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{A}\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{A}\mathbf{w} = f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{v}) + f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{w})$.
- **Homogeneity:** $f_{\mathbf{A}}(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{A}(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = \lambda(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{v}) = \lambda f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{v})$.

These follow from the distributive and scalar properties of matrix multiplication ([Theorem 0.9.4](#)).

For $F = \mathbb{R}$ and $m = n = 2$, the map $f_{\mathbf{A}}$ sends the unit square to the parallelogram spanned by $\mathbf{A}\mathbf{e}_1$ and $\mathbf{A}\mathbf{e}_2$, the columns of $\mathbf{A}$.



The unit square (dashed) and its image under $\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$.

Example. (A Specific Matrix Transformation)

Determine whether $T : F^3 \rightarrow F^2$ defined by $T(a_1, a_2, a_3) = (2a_1 + a_3, a_2 - a_1)$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. This is the matrix transformation induced by $\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$, since

$$\begin{bmatrix} 2 & 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \\ a_3 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 2a_1 + a_3 \\ a_2 - a_1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

By the previous example, T is linear.

Example. (Trace)

Determine whether the **trace** function $\text{tr} : M_n(F) \rightarrow F$ defined by $\text{tr}(\mathbf{A}) = \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ii}$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. For matrices $\mathbf{A}, \mathbf{B} \in M_n(F)$ and $\lambda \in F$:

- **Additivity:** $\text{tr}(\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{B}) = \sum_{i=1}^n (a_{ii} + b_{ii}) = \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ii} + \sum_{i=1}^n b_{ii} = \text{tr}(\mathbf{A}) + \text{tr}(\mathbf{B})$.
- **Homogeneity:** $\text{tr}(\lambda \mathbf{A}) = \sum_{i=1}^n \lambda a_{ii} = \lambda \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ii} = \lambda \text{tr}(\mathbf{A})$.

Thus trace is a linear transformation from the vector space of matrices to the scalar field.

3.1.2.3 Polynomial and Function Space Transformations

Example. (Multiplication by x)

Determine whether $T : F[x] \rightarrow F[x]$ defined by $T(f(x)) = x \cdot f(x)$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. For polynomials $f, g \in F[x]$ and $\lambda \in F$:

- **Additivity:** $T(f + g) = x(f + g) = xf + xg = T(f) + T(g)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $T(\lambda f) = x(\lambda f) = \lambda(xf) = \lambda T(f)$.

Thus multiplication by x is a linear transformation.

Example. (Differentiation)

Determine whether $D : \mathbb{R}[x] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]$ defined by $D(f(x)) = f'(x)$ (the derivative) is a linear transformation.

Solution. For polynomials $f, g \in \mathbb{R}[x]$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$:

- **Additivity:** $D(f + g) = (f + g)' = f' + g' = D(f) + D(g)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $D(\lambda f) = (\lambda f)' = \lambda f' = \lambda D(f)$.

These are the standard sum rule and constant multiple rule from calculus.

Remark. More precisely, $D : \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq n} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq n-1}$ maps polynomials of degree at most n to polynomials of degree at most $n - 1$.

Example. (Integration)

Determine whether $T : \mathbb{R}[x] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]$ defined by $T(f(x)) = \int_0^x f(t) dt$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. For polynomials $f, g \in \mathbb{R}[x]$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$:

- **Additivity:** $T(f+g) = \int_0^x (f(t) + g(t)) dt = \int_0^x f(t) dt + \int_0^x g(t) dt = T(f) + T(g)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $T(\lambda f) = \int_0^x \lambda f(t) dt = \lambda \int_0^x f(t) dt = \lambda T(f)$.

These follow from the linearity of the integral.

Example. (Shift Operator)

Fix $\theta \in \mathbb{R}$. Determine whether the **shift operator** $S_\theta : C(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow C(\mathbb{R})$ defined by $S_\theta(f)(x) = f(x - \theta)$ is a linear transformation. (This operator translates the graph of f by θ units to the right.)

Solution. For $f, g \in C(\mathbb{R})$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$:

- **Additivity:** $S_\theta(f+g)(x) = (f+g)(x-\theta) = f(x-\theta) + g(x-\theta) = S_\theta(f)(x) + S_\theta(g)(x)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $S_\theta(\lambda f)(x) = (\lambda f)(x-\theta) = \lambda f(x-\theta) = \lambda S_\theta(f)(x)$.

Thus the shift operator is linear.

Example. (Composition Operator)

Fix a continuous function $g : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Determine whether the **composition operator** $C_g : C(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow C(\mathbb{R})$ defined by $C_g(f) = f \circ g$, i.e., $C_g(f)(x) = f(g(x))$, is a linear transformation.

Solution. For $f, h \in C(\mathbb{R})$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$:

- **Additivity:** $C_g(f+h)(x) = (f+h)(g(x)) = f(g(x)) + h(g(x)) = C_g(f)(x) + C_g(h)(x)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $C_g(\lambda f)(x) = (\lambda f)(g(x)) = \lambda f(g(x)) = \lambda C_g(f)(x)$.

The shift operator is the special case where $g(x) = x - \theta$.

3.1.2.4 Identity and Inclusion Maps**Example. (Identity Map)**

Let V be a vector space. Determine whether the **identity map** $\text{id}_V : V \rightarrow V$ defined by $\text{id}_V(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{v}$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. For $\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{w} \in V$ and $\lambda \in F$:

- **Additivity:** $\text{id}_V(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{w} = \text{id}_V(\mathbf{v}) + \text{id}_V(\mathbf{w})$.
- **Homogeneity:** $\text{id}_V(\lambda\mathbf{v}) = \lambda\mathbf{v} = \lambda\text{id}_V(\mathbf{v})$.

The identity map is trivially linear.

Example. (Inclusion Map)

Let $W \subseteq V$ be a subspace. Determine whether the **inclusion map** $\iota : W \hookrightarrow V$ defined by $\iota(\mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{w}$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. The inclusion map is simply the identity map restricted to W , viewed as a map into V . The verification is identical to the identity map.

Example. (Zero Map)

For any vector spaces V and W , determine whether the **zero map** $0 : V \rightarrow W$ defined by $0(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{0}_W$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. For $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$ and $\lambda \in F$:

- **Additivity:** $0(\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2) = \mathbf{0}_W = \mathbf{0}_W + \mathbf{0}_W = 0(\mathbf{v}_1) + 0(\mathbf{v}_2)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $0(\lambda\mathbf{v}_1) = \mathbf{0}_W = \lambda\mathbf{0}_W = \lambda \cdot 0(\mathbf{v}_1)$.

The zero map is linear.

3.1.2.5 Field-Dependent Examples

Example. (Complex Conjugation)

Determine whether complex conjugation $T : \mathbb{C} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ defined by $T(z) = \bar{z}$, where $\overline{a + bi} = a - bi$, is a linear transformation.

Solution. **As a map of $\mathbb{C}$ -vector spaces:** T is **not** linear over $\mathbb{C}$.

Consider $z = 1$ and $\alpha = i$. Then:

$$T(\alpha z) = T(i) = -i, \quad \text{but} \quad \alpha T(z) = i \cdot \bar{1} = i.$$

Since $T(i \cdot 1) = -i \neq i = i \cdot T(1)$, the homogeneity condition fails.

As a map of $\mathbb{R}$ -vector spaces: T is linear over $\mathbb{R}$.

For $z = a + bi$ and $w = c + di$ with $a, b, c, d \in \mathbb{R}$, and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$:

- **Additivity:** $T(z + w) = \overline{(a + c) + (b + d)i} = (a + c) - (b + d)i = (a - bi) + (c - di) = T(z) + T(w)$.
- **Homogeneity:** $T(\lambda z) = \overline{\lambda a + \lambda bi} = \lambda a - \lambda bi = \lambda(a - bi) = \lambda T(z)$.

This example illustrates that **linearity depends on the choice of scalar field**.

3.1.3 Non-Examples of Linear Transformations

It is equally important to recognize functions that are **not** linear transformations. We verify non-linearity by finding a counterexample to either (LT1) or (LT2).

Example. (Squaring)

Determine whether $T : F^2 \rightarrow F^2$ defined by $T(a_1, a_2) = (a_1^2, 0)$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. We show that T fails additivity. Consider $\mathbf{v} = (1, 0)$:

$$T(\mathbf{v}) + T(\mathbf{v}) = (1, 0) + (1, 0) = (2, 0),$$

but

$$T(\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v}) = T(2, 0) = (4, 0).$$

Since $(2, 0) \neq (4, 0)$, additivity fails and T is not linear.

Alternatively, homogeneity fails: $T(2\mathbf{v}) = T(2, 0) = (4, 0) \neq 2 \cdot (1, 0) = (2, 0) = 2T(\mathbf{v})$.

Example. (Norm)

Determine whether $T : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ defined by $T(\mathbf{v}) = \|\mathbf{v}\|$ (the Euclidean norm) is a linear transformation.

Solution. Homogeneity fails for negative scalars. Consider $\mathbf{v} = (1, 0, \dots, 0)$ and $\lambda = -1$:

$$T(\lambda\mathbf{v}) = T(-1, 0, \dots, 0) = \|(-1, 0, \dots, 0)\| = 1,$$

but

$$\lambda T(\mathbf{v}) = (-1) \cdot \|(1, 0, \dots, 0)\| = -1.$$

Since $1 \neq -1$, homogeneity fails and T is not a linear transformation.

(The norm does satisfy $\|c\mathbf{v}\| = |c|\|\mathbf{v}\|$, but this is not the same as $c\|\mathbf{v}\|$ when $c < 0$.)

3.1.4 Basic Theorems

Theorem 3.1.1 — Zero Maps to Zero

Let $T : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then $T(\mathbf{0}_V) = \mathbf{0}_W$.

Proof. Using additivity with $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}_V$:

$$T(\mathbf{0}_V) = T(\mathbf{0}_V + \mathbf{0}_V) = T(\mathbf{0}_V) + T(\mathbf{0}_V).$$

Adding $-T(\mathbf{0}_V)$ to both sides gives $\mathbf{0}_W = T(\mathbf{0}_V)$. ■

Remark. This theorem provides a quick test for non-linearity: if $T(\mathbf{0}) \neq \mathbf{0}$, then T is not linear.

Example. (Constant Function)

Determine whether $T : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ defined by $T(x) = 5$ for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. We use [Theorem 3.1.1](#): any linear transformation must map zero to zero.

Here, $T(0) = 5 \neq 0$.

Therefore, T is not a linear transformation.

Example. (Translation)

Determine whether $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by $T(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{c}$ for some fixed nonzero $\mathbf{c} \in \mathbb{R}^2$ is a linear transformation.

Solution. Using [Theorem 3.1.1](#): $T(\mathbf{0}) = \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{c} = \mathbf{c} \neq \mathbf{0}$.

Therefore, translation by a nonzero vector is not linear.

Maps of the form $\mathbf{v} \mapsto \mathbf{A}\mathbf{v} + \mathbf{c}$ are called **affine transformations**. They are linear if and only if $\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}$.

Theorem 3.1.2 — Linear Maps Preserve Negation

Let $T : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then $T(-\mathbf{v}) = -T(\mathbf{v})$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Proof. Using homogeneity with $\lambda = -1$:

$$T(-\mathbf{v}) = T((-1)\mathbf{v}) = (-1)T(\mathbf{v}) = -T(\mathbf{v}).$$

■

Theorem 3.1.3 — Equivalent Characterization of Linearity

Let V, W be vector spaces over F and $T : V \rightarrow W$ be a function. Then T is a linear transformation if and only if

$$T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1 + \beta\mathbf{v}_2) = \alpha T(\mathbf{v}_1) + \beta T(\mathbf{v}_2)$$

for all $\alpha, \beta \in F$ and $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose T is linear. Then for any $\alpha, \beta \in F$ and $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$:

$$\begin{aligned} T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1 + \beta\mathbf{v}_2) &= T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1) + T(\beta\mathbf{v}_2) && \text{(by LT1)} \\ &= \alpha T(\mathbf{v}_1) + \beta T(\mathbf{v}_2) && \text{(by LT2)} \end{aligned}$$

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1 + \beta\mathbf{v}_2) = \alpha T(\mathbf{v}_1) + \beta T(\mathbf{v}_2)$ for all $\alpha, \beta \in F$ and $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$.

- **Additivity (LT1):** Setting $\alpha = \beta = 1$, we get $T(\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2) = T(\mathbf{v}_1) + T(\mathbf{v}_2)$.
- **Homogeneity (LT2):** Setting $\beta = 0$, we get $T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{0}) = \alpha T(\mathbf{v}_1) + 0 \cdot T(\mathbf{v}_2)$, i.e., $T(\alpha\mathbf{v}_1) = \alpha T(\mathbf{v}_1)$.

Thus T satisfies both (LT1) and (LT2), so T is linear. ■

Theorem 3.1.4 — Linear Maps Preserve Linear Combinations

Let $T : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then for any vectors $\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n \in V$ and scalars $a_1, \dots, a_n \in F$:

$$T\left(\sum_{i=1}^n a_i \mathbf{v}_i\right) = \sum_{i=1}^n a_i T(\mathbf{v}_i).$$

Proof. By induction on n . The base case $n = 1$ is homogeneity. For the inductive step:

$$\begin{aligned} T\left(\sum_{i=1}^{n+1} a_i \mathbf{v}_i\right) &= T\left(\sum_{i=1}^n a_i \mathbf{v}_i + a_{n+1} \mathbf{v}_{n+1}\right) \\ &= T\left(\sum_{i=1}^n a_i \mathbf{v}_i\right) + T(a_{n+1} \mathbf{v}_{n+1}) && \text{(additivity)} \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^n a_i T(\mathbf{v}_i) + a_{n+1} T(\mathbf{v}_{n+1}) && \text{(induction + homogeneity)} \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^{n+1} a_i T(\mathbf{v}_i). \end{aligned}$$
■

3.1.5 Linear Transformation Determined by Basis

Another useful fact of a linear transformation is that once we know how it acts on a basis, then we know how it acts on every vector in the domain.

Theorem 3.1.5 — Linear Transformations are Determined by Their Action on a Basis

Let $T : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation and V is finite dimensional, and $B = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n\}$ be a basis for V . Then we have:

1. For every $\mathbf{v} \in V$, $f(\mathbf{v})$ is a linear combination of $f(\mathbf{v}_1), f(\mathbf{v}_2), \dots, f(\mathbf{v}_n)$.
2. Suppose the linear transformation $g : V \rightarrow W$ satisfies $g(\mathbf{v}_i) = f(\mathbf{v}_i)$ for all i . Then $g = f$.

We say ‘ f is determined by $f(\mathbf{v}_1), \dots, f(\mathbf{v}_n)$ ’ in this case.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Since B is a basis of V , we can write $\mathbf{v} = \alpha_1 \mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + \alpha_n \mathbf{v}_n$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} f(\mathbf{v}) &= f(\alpha_1 \mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + \alpha_n \mathbf{v}_n) \\ &= \alpha_1 f(\mathbf{v}_1) + \dots + \alpha_n f(\mathbf{v}_n). \end{aligned}$$

This proves the first condition.

Moreover, if $g : V \rightarrow W$ satisfies $g(\mathbf{v}_i) = f(\mathbf{v}_i)$, then:

$$\begin{aligned} g(\mathbf{v}) &= g(\alpha_1 \mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + \alpha_n \mathbf{v}_n) \\ &= \alpha_1 g(\mathbf{v}_1) + \dots + \alpha_n g(\mathbf{v}_n) \\ &= \alpha_1 f(\mathbf{v}_1) + \dots + \alpha_n f(\mathbf{v}_n) \\ &= f(\alpha_1 \mathbf{v}_1 + \dots + \alpha_n \mathbf{v}_n) \\ &= f(\mathbf{v}). \end{aligned}$$

Since $g(\mathbf{v}) = f(\mathbf{v})$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$, we have $f = g$. This finishes the second condition. ■

Example.

Is it possible to have a linear map $f : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$ such that

$$f(1, 0) = (2, 3, 4), \quad f(1, 1) = (3, 4, 5), \quad f(2, 3) = (4, 56)?$$

Solution. Idea: Since $\{(1, 0), (1, 1)\}$ forms a basis of $\mathbb{R}^2$, these two function value would determine f completely.

Suppose such a linear transformation f exists. Observe that

$$(2, 3) = -1(1, 0) + 3(1, 1).$$

Apply f then we have:

$$\begin{aligned} f(2, 3) &= f(-1(1, 0) + 3(1, 1)) \\ &= -1f(1, 0) + 3f(1, 1) \\ &= -1(2, 3, 4) + 3(3, 4, 5) \\ &= (7, 8, 11) \\ &\neq (4, 56). \end{aligned}$$

Which is inconsistent with the third equation, therefore no such transformation exists.

Example.

Suppose we are given a linear transformation $f : \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$. And it is also known that

$$f(x^3) = 3x^2, \quad f(x^2) = 2x, \quad f(x) = 1, \quad f(1) = 0.$$

Solution. As $\{1, x, x^2, x^3\}$ forms a basis of $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$. And $D(x^k) = f(x^k)$, for $k = 0, 1, 2, 3$, as D is differentiation. We have that $D \equiv f$ is the same linear transformation.

3.2 Kernel and Image

3.2.1 Definition

Definition 3.2.1 — Kernel

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Define the **kernel** of f by

$$\ker(f) := \{\mathbf{v} \in V : f(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{0}_W\}.$$

i.e. The kernel contains everything in the domain that becomes the zero vector under f .

Definition 3.2.2 — Image

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Define the **image** of f by

$$\text{im}(f) := \{\mathbf{w} \in W : \mathbf{w} = f(\mathbf{v}) \text{ for some } \mathbf{v} \in V\}.$$

i.e. The image contains all the possible outputs of the function f .

Remark. The kernel is also known as the nullspace, which you might be familiar from Gilbert Strang's book. And the image is also called the range. Also, we sometimes denote the image as $f(V)$.

3.2.2 Examples

Example. (Differentiation)

Let $D : \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ be defined by $D(f(x)) = f'(x)$. Find the kernel and image of D .

Solution. Kernel: We seek all polynomials $f(x) \in \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$ such that $D(f(x)) = f'(x) = 0$.

A polynomial has derivative zero if and only if it is a constant. Thus:

$$\ker(D) = \{c : c \in \mathbb{R}\} = \text{span}\{1\}.$$

So $\dim(\ker(D)) = 1$.

Image: We need to determine which polynomials in $\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ can be obtained as derivatives.

Let $f(x) = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + a_3x^3 \in \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3}$. Then:

$$D(f(x)) = f'(x) = a_1 + 2a_2x + 3a_3x^2.$$

As a_1, a_2, a_3 range over all real numbers, we can obtain any polynomial of degree at most 2. Therefore:

$$\text{im}(D) = \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}.$$

So $\dim(\text{im}(D)) = 3$.

Note that $\dim(\ker(D)) + \dim(\text{im}(D)) = 1 + 3 = 4 = \dim(\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3})$.

Example. (Trace)

Let $\text{tr} : M_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be defined by $\text{tr}(\mathbf{A}) = a_{11} + a_{22}$. Find the kernel and image of tr .

Solution. Kernel: We seek all matrices $\mathbf{A} \in M_2(\mathbb{R})$ such that $\text{tr}(\mathbf{A}) = 0$.

Let $\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$. Then $\text{tr}(\mathbf{A}) = a + d = 0$, which means $d = -a$.

So the kernel consists of all matrices of the form:

$$\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & -a \end{bmatrix} = a \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix} + b \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix} + c \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Therefore:

$$\ker(\text{tr}) = \text{span} \left\{ \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}, \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \right\}.$$

So $\dim(\ker(\text{tr})) = 3$.

Image: For any $r \in \mathbb{R}$, we can find a matrix with trace r , for example $\begin{bmatrix} r & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$.

Therefore:

$$\text{im}(\text{tr}) = \mathbb{R}.$$

So $\dim(\text{im}(\text{tr})) = 1$.

Note that $\dim(\ker(\text{tr})) + \dim(\text{im}(\text{tr})) = 3 + 1 = 4 = \dim(M_2(\mathbb{R}))$.

3.2.3 Basic Theorems

Theorem 3.2.1 — Properties of Kernel

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then:

1. $\ker(f)$ is a subspace of V ;
2. f is injective iff $\ker(f) = \{\mathbf{0}_V\}$.

Proof.

1.
 - Non-emptiness: As f is linear, $f(\mathbf{0}_V) = \mathbf{0}_W$, therefore $\mathbf{0}_V \in \ker(f)$.
 - Closure under addition: Let $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in \ker(f)$, it implies that $f(\mathbf{v}_1) = \mathbf{0}_W$ and $f(\mathbf{v}_2) = \mathbf{0}_W$. We have

$$f(\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2) = f(\mathbf{v}_1) + f(\mathbf{v}_2) = \mathbf{0}_W + \mathbf{0}_W = \mathbf{0}_W.$$

Therefore $\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2 \in \ker(f)$.

- Closure under scalar multiplication: Let $\mathbf{v} \in \ker(f)$, it implies that $f(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{0}_W$. We have

$$f(\lambda \mathbf{v}) = \lambda f(\mathbf{v}) = \lambda \mathbf{0}_W = \mathbf{0}_W.$$

Therefore $\lambda \mathbf{v} \in \ker(f)$.

2.
 - ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose f is injective. Let $\mathbf{v} \in \ker(f)$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} f(\mathbf{v}) &= \mathbf{0}_W \\ &= f(\mathbf{0}_V) \end{aligned} \quad (\text{linearity})$$

By having $f(\mathbf{v}) = f(\mathbf{0}_V)$ and f is injective, it implies that $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}_V$, so $\ker(f) = \{\mathbf{0}_V\}$.

- ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\ker(f) = \{\mathbf{0}_V\}$, and we consider $f(\mathbf{v}) = f(\mathbf{w})$. Reordering the terms we get $f(\mathbf{v}) - f(\mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{0}_W$, and since f is linear we have $f(\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w}) = \mathbf{0}_W$. Therefore $\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w} \in \ker(f) = \{\mathbf{0}_V\}$, implying that $\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}_V$, hence $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{w}$. So f is injective.

■

Theorem 3.2.2 — Properties of Image

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then:

1. $\text{im}(f)$ is a subspace of W ;
2. f is surjective iff $\text{im}(f) = W$.

Proof.

1.
 - Non-emptiness: Since f is linear, $\mathbf{0}_W = f(\mathbf{0}_V)$, therefore $\mathbf{0}_W \in \text{im}(f)$.
 - Closure under addition: Let $\mathbf{w}_1, \mathbf{w}_2 \in \text{im}(f)$. So $\mathbf{w}_1 = f(\mathbf{v}_1)$, and $\mathbf{w}_2 = f(\mathbf{v}_2)$

for some $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \in V$. Notice that

$$\mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2 = f(\mathbf{v}_1) + f(\mathbf{v}_2) = f(\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2).$$

Therefore $\mathbf{w}_1 + \mathbf{w}_2 \in \text{im}(f)$.

- Closure under scalar multiplication: Let $\mathbf{w} \in \text{im}(f)$. So $\mathbf{w} = f(\mathbf{v})$ for some $\mathbf{v} \in V$. Notice that

$$\lambda \mathbf{w} = \lambda f(\mathbf{v}) = f(\lambda \mathbf{v}).$$

Therefore $\lambda \mathbf{w} \in \text{im}(f)$.

2. f is surjective $\Leftrightarrow \forall \mathbf{w} \in W$, we have $\mathbf{w} \in f(\mathbf{v})$ for some $\mathbf{v} \in V$, that is equivalent to say $W \subseteq \text{im}(f)$, and by the first condition we know that $\text{im}(f) \subseteq W$ is always true. Hence we have f is surjective $\Leftrightarrow W = \text{im}(f)$.

■

3.3 Rank-Nullity Theorem

3.3.1 Nullity and Rank

Definition 3.3.1 — Nullity

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. The **nullity** of f is defined by

$$\text{nullity}(f) := \dim(\ker(f)).$$

Definition 3.3.2 — Rank

Let $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. The **rank** of f is defined by

$$\text{rank}(f) := \dim(\text{im}(f)).$$

Example.

Recall that for $D : \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 3} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$ defined by

$$D(f(x)) = f'(x),$$

we have $\ker(D) = \mathbb{R}$ and $\text{im}(D) = \mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}$. Compute the nullity and rank of D .

Solution. $\text{nullity}(D) := \dim_{\mathbb{R}}(\ker(D)) = \dim_{\mathbb{R}}(\mathbb{R}) = 1.$

$\text{rank}(D) := \dim_{\mathbb{R}}(\text{im}(D)) = \dim_{\mathbb{R}}(\mathbb{R}[x]_{\leq 2}) = 3.$

Remark. For other examples of nullity and rank, review the examples in the last section, which we have it covered.

3.3.2 The Theorem

Theorem 3.3.1 — Rank-Nullity Theorem

Let V be a finite dimensional vector space and $f : V \rightarrow W$ be a linear transformation. Then we have

$$\text{nullity}(f) + \text{rank}(f) = \dim(V).$$

Proof. Let $S = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n\}$ be a basis of $\ker(f)$, having $\text{nullity}(f) = \dim(\ker f) = n$. Since $\ker(f) \subseteq V$, by the Basis Extension Theorem (Theorem 1.6.5), we can extend S to $S' = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_n, \mathbf{s}_1, \dots, \mathbf{s}_k\}$, a basis of V , having $\dim(V) = n + k$.

Claim. $S'' = \{f(\mathbf{s}_1), f(\mathbf{s}_2), \dots, f(\mathbf{s}_k)\}$ is a basis of $\text{im}(f)$.

Proof. We verify two properties.

Spanning. Let $\mathbf{w} \in \text{im}(f)$, we have $\mathbf{w} = f(\mathbf{v})$ for some $\mathbf{v} \in V$ by definition. As S' is a basis of V , we can write $\mathbf{v} = \sum_{i=1}^n \alpha_i \mathbf{v}_i + \sum_{i=1}^k \beta_i \mathbf{s}_i$. Then we apply f to both sides:

$$\mathbf{w} = f(\mathbf{v}) = f\left(\sum \alpha_i \mathbf{v}_i + \sum \beta_i \mathbf{s}_i\right) = \sum \alpha_i f(\mathbf{v}_i) + \sum \beta_i f(\mathbf{s}_i) = \sum \beta_i f(\mathbf{s}_i),$$

where the last equality holds since $\mathbf{v}_i \in \ker(f)$. Since $\mathbf{w}$ can be expressed by $f(\mathbf{s}_i)$'s, therefore S'' spans $\text{im}(f)$.

Linear independence. Suppose that $\alpha_1 f(\mathbf{s}_1) + \dots + \alpha_k f(\mathbf{s}_k) = \mathbf{0}$. By linearity of f , it becomes $f(\alpha_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \dots + \alpha_k \mathbf{s}_k) = \mathbf{0}$. Therefore we have $\alpha_1 \mathbf{s}_1 + \dots + \alpha_k \mathbf{s}_k \in \ker(f)$. Moreover, as S is a basis of $\ker(f)$, we know that $\sum \alpha_i \mathbf{s}_i = \sum \beta_i \mathbf{v}_i$ for some $\beta_i \in F$. Reordering gives $\sum \alpha_i \mathbf{s}_i - \sum \beta_i \mathbf{v}_i = \mathbf{0}$. As S' is linearly independent, this forces all α_i 's and β_i 's to be 0. This completes the proof of the claim. ■

Hence, we have

$$\text{rank}(f) = \dim(\text{im}(f)) = k = (n + k) - n = \dim(V) - \text{nullity}(f). \quad \blacksquare$$

For the map $f_{\mathbf{A}} : \mathbb{R}^4 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$, $f_{\mathbf{A}}(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{A}\mathbf{v}$, the rank and nullity can be computed exactly with SymPy. In the online version the code can be edited and run; for any matrix, the sum is the number of columns, $\dim(\mathbb{R}^4) = 4$.

```
from sympy import Matrix

A = Matrix([
    [1, 2, 3, 4],
    [2, 4, 6, 8],
    [1, 0, 1, 0],
])
rank = A.rank() # dim(im f_A)
nullity = len(A.nullspace()) # dim(ker f_A): size of a basis of the kernel
```

```
print("rank =", rank, " nullity =", nullity, " columns =", A.cols)
rank + nullity == A.cols
```